

Text ONLY - TBS & BTNH Complete Collected Drafts

John Roapes

T H E B A S T A R D S O N O F T H E G R E A T A M E R I C A N N O V E L I S T

Variant: All The Collected Words

John L. Roapes

T A B L E O F C O N T E N T S

E P I G R A P H O R I S M (S) © [\[1\]](#)

B R I A N D I L L O N

“Only poets come close.”

- “How How How What What What How—When” *Suppose a Sentence* (2020)

E D W A R D D A H L B E R G

“Only those who know the ocean ponder death as they behold it, whereas those bound closely to the ground are more sensual.”

- *Because I Was Flesh* (19XX)

H E N R Y M I L L E R

“Nothing, on deep analysis, proves to be what it seems or purports to be. Man continues to hunger.”

- *The Books in my Life* (1969)

“Never was the fear of life so rampant. The fear of life has replaced the fear of death.”

- *The Books in my Life* (1969)

J O R G E L U I S B O R G E S

“We could not deceive one another, and that makes conversation hard.”

- “The Other” from *The Book of Sand* (1975)

KENNETH K OCH

“Isn’t this history, and aren’t we a couple of ruins”

- “In Love with You” (First published in Apr. 1955, Poetry Magazine)

MARIANNE M OORE

“Dürer would have seen a reason for living

in a town like this, with eight stranded whales

to look at; with the sweet sea air coming into your house”

- “The Steeple-Jack” from *Selected Poems* (1935)

NATSUME S ŌSEKI

“However you look at it, the human world is not an easy place to live.”

- *Kusamakura* (1906) [\[2\]](#)

“The early Zen priest Daie is said to have suffered greatly from the fact that even the enlightened mind, which has mastered the illusion of reality, is still troubled by dreams of the vulgar world.”

- *Kusamakura* (1906)

“The main path has become indistinguishable among the numerous tracks that meet and part and intersect. All are a path of some sort, and none is the path itself.”

- *Kusamakura* (1906)

ROLAND B ARTHES

“Better the illusions of subjectivity than the impostures of objectivity. Better the Imaginary of the subject than its censorship.”

- *The Preparation of the Novel* (Session of December 2, 1978)

“...despite the fact that they keep happening, these ‘catastrophes’ are never planned for: the *weather* only exists after the event, as a discourse of irresponsibility.”

- *The Preparation of the Novel* (Session of January 20, 1979)

SUSAN S ONTAG

“I took a trip to see the beautiful things.”

- “Unguided Tour” *The New Yorker* (Oct. 1977)
 - By way of Brian Dillon’s “Suppose a Sentence”

OSCAR M ILOSZ

“You, sad, sad sound of rain on the rain”

- “Les Terrains vagues” *Andramandoni* (1918)

WITOLD G OMBROWICZ

“He intended nothing at all because he wrote the way a child pees against a tree, in order to relieve himself.”

- *Diary: Volume One* (1953)

Preface (Yours, Truly Yours)

My fear as I set out to write this novel, if that is what it is or shall become – for the lines between novel, memoir and biography will be frequently blurred and trespassed and should, for the reader’s sake, be set aside for the time being – until that is, the reader has completed the *novel* – which is how I, as the scribe of this particular tale, have conceived of it for a number of reasons, not the least of which is the need to answer certain unanswerable questions, and not the greatest of which is the need to keep private some of the personal details of the deceased, given the lack of agency necessitated by their current state – my fear is that I will find myself unable to adequately capture the brilliance of my late friend, about whom this novel is centrally based, if only because my own intellect is sufficiently lacking in ways that even my friend, W. T. Grayson, would concede, though never without stating some sort of mitigating platitude about the various types of intelligence and rattling off a list of his own deficiencies, as he was perceptive and well aware of the sizeable chasm between himself and others with regard to his ability to retain, comprehend, conceptualize and practically apply the outputs of nearly any type and quantity of data with a machine like capacity, speed and consistency.

Still, I am confident that there is no man better suited to tell this story than myself, because the rest of the world still believes W. T. Grayson went to his grave a schizophrenic, hearing voices and muttering to himself, utterly convinced of a conspiracy theory that had long since been disproven by a stoic quartet of lawyers representing the estate of The Great American Novelist, and there is no one left but myself to tell the story, even with the knowledge of the Great Risk this act presents, and the current state of the few other individuals who have attempted to set straight the facts around the life and death of my best friend, W. T. Grayson.

When one starts to think about William Theodore Grayson and the story of his life, which is to say the story of what occurred to him between birth (November 1984, Wagner, Iowa) and final breath (November 2019, Atlantic Ocean, Coastal South Carolina, Precise Coordinates Unknown), there is a natural tendency to open the story with his entry into the world, one of very few certain commonalities we all share– which is to say we were all born; none of us has died; and we are all stuck between the two great poles of existence, stuck here needing to eat, drink, piss and shit. Beyond that, there are no guarantees.

So it seems natural, logical even, to begin with the beginning. The chaos of the delivery room, the white robes smeared with various depths and shades of blood– but not from T.’s perspective, of course, not that he would have seen anything much more than blurry dark vagaries moving about in some absolute new brightness, a brightness never previously experienced, the very definition of “brand new”– and with the brightness, still, the novelty of contrast, a *new* type of darkness in its own right. His own cries, a sound foreign to him as of yet, wails without origin, though perhaps he notices some correlation, perhaps, but there is nothing, not a single iota of concrete, objective data, that can even skim the surface of really, truly, telling us if he notices anything like that. The newborn’s experience of the world is as foreign to us as the experience of death, actual death, not those near-death-experiences that end up as best-selling books but really when you come down to it are more or less descriptions of something like a hallucinogenic trip initiated by the body in the microseconds prior to death, the sort that generate best selling books and interview tours and the occasional made-for-tv movie preaching some form of *carpe-diem-but-in-moderation-of course* . I mean we know as much about being, say, 60-seconds into a lifetime, as we know about really dying for good– what it feels like to become dirt. [\[3\]](#)

Even then, though, I make the leap to assume, or to play it safe, imagine, that the anxiety of the room (that swirling conflagration of brand new light and reconstituted darkness) would have permeated his consciousness, from Day One he was the locus around which revolved the tendencies of chaos and fear

and guilt and worry. Born solipsists we all must be, for in reality, objectively, the world does revolve around us, in a way.

One is naturally compelled to start with the umbilical noose around his neck. The unspoken but palpable concern that had begun mounting in the room after the first utterance of the word “breach”, or slightly before that even as the medical staff knowingly observed the sonogram but maintained the necessary poise and professionalism until the surgeon came into the room to discuss options. The feeling that a countdown clock had been initiated but had not been made visible to Izzy, the very recognition of which seemed to correlate with the pain she felt. This was a time, still, when the routine c-section was not routine, and fatalities related to childbirth were significantly more common than they would become in the decade to come and the fear of which was not something that Izzy had even considered until surgery became a necessity rather than an option. *Nowhere near ready for this*, she thought - this is where a story begins.

Or later could work, after the child, on the verge of asphyxiation, was pulled from the womb and rescued but not out of the woods yet, not quite, blue, almost purple skin but somewhat translucent too - the sort of questions that you’d think we can answer but can only assume: did the child feel the presence of death nearby? They learn to breathe in that first moment, and this is the moment that it began, the child pulls for air only to find the passage blocked. How simple birth seems to an earth brimming with billions of us and yet for each life a small miracle unfolds. He made it to the beginning, it would seem, and then it becomes apparent, as the mother, numb from the chest down, hears his screams to her unimaginable relief, looks about the room and thinks of how she got here. How *they* got here, rather, as if she somehow has now become both herself and another. And the story must begin, one imagines, with an answer to that question at least - because there was a whole life required just as preface, seventeen years of one at any rate, and so it can’t be that we begin here. No, no - it can’t be so simple.

There’s no beginning. *Nowhere near ready*. Screams against the shady chaos of the delivery room, kind hands clean the body of blood and viscera and the hair so much hair, the first thing Izzy has heard clearly in hours. So much hair. And nowhere is a father to be found.

History Lessons

The Great American Novelist was, as is the case with all Great American things, the product of an amalgamation of sources, none of which were American in the slightest. His father had immigrated to the United States in the last great wave prior to the onset of WWII and while on paper, at Ellis Island, he entered the country as an Italian, the truth that the Great American Novelist would discover late in life, as a byproduct of the meticulous research he put into each of his novels (one of which was a thinly veiled retelling of his father’s story, perhaps the most poorly reviewed novel of his career, and still the subject of several books by literary critics and excerpted in many academic anthologies of American Literature, Italian-American Literature, Post-WWII Fiction and so on and so forth – which is to say the worst of his novels received greater praise than most writers dream of, let alone conceive of realistically achieving) that his father had forged his Italian citizenship with a diligence that far exceeded the requirements to pass through Ellis Island, going as far as to create an entirely false and intricately detailed family tree diagram, which he had gone lengths to age and spent weeks at a time creating unique penmanship techniques to create individual signatures that he could replicate with stamp like consistency, and backstories for each of the members of his family tree that were all filled with

extraordinary detail, and if they had been true would have made the Great American Novelist's extended family among the most incredible collection of individual backstories ever comprised.

To provide a few examples [\[4\]](#) :

- Carlo Torta (b.1845): one of his mother's six uncles, who ran a hat shop in Naples and was scratched blind in his left eye by a feral cat he had attempted to rescue when he was only seven years old. He had two daughters and a son, who were also provided backstories, one of which involved a romantic relationship between one of the daughters and a provincial aristocrat who had proven soon thereafter to be a violent drunk and was sentenced to death when found guilty of murdering poor Carlo's eldest daughter. But Carlo, begged that the court grant mercy upon the young, passionate boy, making a speech to the judge that convinced him to let the boy go, mandating that he repay the father with labor in exchange for a small ration of food and water until the father deemed his debt repaid - this sort of indefinite sentence was not altogether uncommon in those times, although mankind proves quickly why we should not be allowed nice things. The young man was so happy and so grateful to Carlo for his kindness that he didn't even notice when, after two weeks of hard labor, one night, Carlo locked the door to the room where he'd been given lodgings, which was an underground room devoid of any windows or methods of escape apart from the door, and Carlo listened on with a sick glee, providing the young man small amounts of water and food every few days so that he slowly lost his mind and was always sick with hunger and thirst but did not die for months. As the weeks wore on and the boy grew increasingly despondent, Carlo himself grew increasingly manic in his behavior, and was known in the surrounding areas as "The Mad Hatter of Villagio" (which, Villagio, just means "village" in Italian) - this all prior to the publication of Lewis Carroll's masterpiece.
- Giovanni Biscotti (b. 1811) - A relation by marriage, not blood (for even the GAN's father knew that putting Biscotti in his own bloodline would be one step too many), who was five generations removed from Leonardo DaVinci himself, through a purely matriarchal bloodline that reached all the way to DaVinci's second daughter, Chiara [\[5\]](#) . Giovanni Biscotti, in his father's backstory, was an inventor with a penchant for creating things that would later become some of the most commonly used products in the world, but having invented them "ahead of his time" as it were, often scrapped the idea altogether due to a lack of patronage or investment. Among his inventions, the greatest was the steam engine, of which he had built a working model set on wheels, approximately the size of a modern skateboard. However, when showing it to a prominent member of society from their small town of "Villagio" (for all his father's originality, the GAN was stupified by "Villagio", that chosen town name, and the complete lack of creativity it displayed), the man stood atop the machine and held onto the T-shaped bar Biscotti had fashioned as a handle, but when it began to move beneath his feet, requiring a minimal degree of balance and focus, the man short, stout man become so frightened he went completely rigid, losing any athletic ability he'd ever displayed. The steam-engine-skateboard shot out from under his feet, spraying pressurized steam all over his calves and feet, leaving him with third degree burns that would become infected and nearly kill him, though, in the end it would not kill him, leaving Biscotti, motorless and on the losing side of a trial that cost him most of his life savings and permanently altering the class status of his children, and children's children and so on, ultimately necessitating the trip to Ellis Island in search of the American Dream.

- Michela Pietá - A literal virgin mother. Her son, Carmine, was a brawler - known across the whole of southern Italy for the size of his hands. And because everyone knows the size of a man's hands directly correlates to the size of his manhood, Carmine was also a notorious Casanova of his era. Said to have fathered such a significant percentage of the children in their small town that down the road there was a statistically relevant increase in genetic birth defects in the village and the government officially sanctioned the relocation of a number of indigent prostitutes from Rome in order to return balance to the local gene pool.

-

B O O K O N E

P A R T X

I

Though it may be true that life ends only once: with death—there are other times in one's life, many in fact, in which we (willfully or not) part ways with our consciousness under the assumption that it will be back in due time. This occurs each night when we go to sleep, of course. But there are also concussions and substance benders (vacations of the self), fainting spells seizures and any moment in which we have a true and honest interaction with the sublime, and of course, medical procedures, prior to which we are perhaps made more aware than in any other previously mentioned opportunity, exactly the gravity of the choice we are making as we go through the horrifying mundanity of signing documents meant to account for what should happen in the event your consciousness wanders off somewhere and finds itself lost, permanently.

The preceding sentence needs no qualifications and no caveats. If it were an entrance exam to some sort of club, the acceptance rate would be inordinately high—it would be a club for nearly everyone. It would be a club for all conscious members of the human race. In some sense the club exists, we all

meet everyday, we don't talk about the entrance exam, and some of us are more anxiety-ridden about the whole thing than others. There are all sorts of factions within the community; largely these are based on our response to the cascade of questions that follows the knowledge shared above.

Lower order beings (even the smartest ones like dolphins and chimpanzees) do not seem to understand this fact in the same way we do—and accordingly, they are considered primitive.

Symbolically, in the Old Testament, this was the fruit that came from the tree of knowledge. The one fundamental truth. Everything then that follows, the entire tome of the Old Testament, is an attempt to respond to the recognition of this one pure fact. Religion's main job, in this way, has always been to hide the truth from us—or to sugarcoat it, to dress it up, to make it palatable, as they say, meaning something that we can swallow without offending our taste buds or health.

These simple truths are not nearly as common as one might think. The sky is not blue, nor in reality is the ocean, yet they are vibrant reflections of one another, a cacophony of the prismatic refraction of (some)light, seen by the typical human eye as an elegant shade we know only in relation to the other colors that append it in the highly ordered spectrum of our vision; the color of one is entirely contingent on the color of the other—no, the sky is not blue. That much is certain.

II

The island of XX is, depending on who you ask, an idyll or an abyss. Very rarely the accidental visitor arrives, and being unprepared—which is to say without preconceived notions—it can happen that they see both iterations of the place, one layered on top of the other (though the order is not apparent upon even the closest inspection). They see nothing but confusion, paradox, inconsistency and entropy.

They see natural beauty long since marred by European colonists and their forebears; but blink and the same visage is one of nature's inherent strength, the wealth and abundance of color and character amongst the fauna. *The Heart Tree*, the oldest of its variety in the world, it's massive cephalopodic family of limbs signifying something infinite—surrounded, as it were, on all sides, by well intentioned, ten foot high wire fencing, barbed across the top, all to keep out the violence of our own nature. *The Heart Tree*: glorious arboreal realization of the complexity of life all around us. *The Heart Tree*: caged monstrosity of deregulated growth—or—the fence (humanity) as an extension of the tree, all of us bastardized and ungainly.

Here sits the isle, taut on a limn
Oasis imprison'd by a wolf in lambskin

III

T and John had yet to walk the whole island on the night that Pappy set a curse on them. One of them, both of them. Neither was sure. But John had been, of late, getting jealous of his friend, and it had caused a rift of the sort that is not uncommon between young men in want of approval from the world of manhood.

However, while it is true that John felt the desire for approval with a sort of desperate desire that can only be said to reflect poorly on his upbringing, and furthermore displayed a lack of self awareness that, while completely normal for a child still in the throes of adolescence, nonetheless seemed out of place on an island such as Noer, where childhood was something that took place in privacy and one's induction into manhood was a semi communal event that took place at *Gram's Pen: Tavern and Social Club* ; and during which certain rituals took place that ensured no one exited the event with any remaining notions of innocence.

The things that took place at Gram's were the sorts of things that have a way of getting into the water supply and poisoning the soil so that the burden had a way of displacing itself, and people had a reason to stay right in place.

For most of the boys on the island nothing was more appealing, or anticipated, than The Initiation, which took place on the 6th night following the young man's sixteenth birthday. But John, who was not one of the islanders at heart, did not think that the initiation was the sort of event that he would participate in. The way certain young males choose not to participate in the ritualistic barbarism of the inaccurately titled "Greek Life".

What John wished for was a matter of confusion, significant confusion - and for that reason he went to speak with Pappy on the night of his sixteenth birthday. What sort of intuition it was that caused T to follow, and to follow him quietly at that, aware of every creaking board in the house, and listen in, later, when things began to get out of control; and finally to enter at that critical moment, that apex of (what could it be but magic?) - that remains to be answered - though an attempt will be made in the pages that follow.

IV

Percival Roapes, who would later come to be known as Pappy to his four grandchildren, spent most of his life navigating the terrain of XX Island and attempting to capture, by way of map-making, the intricacies of its ever shifting shorelines, tidal creeks and inlets. With the eye of an unrealized artist he did persist in attempting to make permanent the micro-cartographies of fiddler crab thoroughfares, and approached his task bravely without fear of the imagination when he envisioned the underground enclaves of a clan of blind and batty moles, some thirty thousand in number, even going as far as to append a history of the clan, including its leaders, structure, customs, factions and rivalries—crossing over yet another threshold from cartographer/artist to biologist/cultural historian/sociologist—all maintained within his collection of some three hundred twenty three or three hundred twenty four green canvas notebooks bought from the military surplus store, the whole lot of them immaculately cataloged, annotated, bookmarked and sorted into a classification scheme that was enough to make a librarian blush. Everything accomplished with no formal training in cartography, or even the art of sketching—and yet not a page that could be described as amateurish or lacking in polish.

He was an artisan, one might be inclined to conclude, and this was his life's work. And when it was discovered by John, and in turn shared with his best and only true friend, T. The detail T commented on, after poring over hundreds of pages of lore, images, charts and graphs, after reviewing so many pages in silence while a bright yellow sun crossed the skylight, illuminating a pillar of fine particles of dust wherever it so chose to travel, shocked the then seventeen-year-old John so much so that he was nearly felled like a young pine. He was shocked by the thing his friend had noticed, which came with such an air of mystery that the two now knew they were obligated to investigate on their own.

It was a bridge T had asked about, lightly penciled in on certain maps, altogether absent on others, jutting out from the point of a small outcropping of land where a shack once stood that had caught fire in a storm when John was young. Labeled on a particular map as “B. T. N. (Bridge to Nowhere)”, that the young boy John, who had grown up on the property for the entirety of his life, had only heard spoken of from his Pappy—and on the topic had been sworn to secrecy with a notably dark foreboding and a stern warning such that a boy does not forget. But the warning had been followed by heavy gales of laughter, the variety intended to wipe a conversational slate clean, and had accordingly been forgotten for the most part—though in truth, as he would learn later on, it is a difficult thing to truly forget something, and a process which cannot be done intentionally because the very attempt to forget causes the inverse effect, etching a memory into one's mind with some degree of permanence. When one thinks they have forgotten something of great importance it is almost always the case that they have not, in fact, forgotten the thing itself, but managed only to forget the location where they stored it—and should be aware that any number of events could cause it to reappear incidentally, under completely unpredictable circumstance.

It was on their first visit, when they were still quite young, that T named it *Exedra Isle* .

The Place on the Far Side of the Bridge to Nowhere was too long and in any case it wasn't a proper name as much as a description. For his part, John had no idea what an Exedra, though he trusted T's instincts to a fault. He made the vague connection to Excedrin, etymologically questionable at best, and assumed the name had something to do with the brain or the head, as Excedrin was a medicine used most frequently in the treatment of headaches.

T was an enthusiast for all things Ancient Greek and Roman—though he admitted on several occasions to having a small preference towards the Greek philosophical style, if only because it arrived first, and thus was monumental in its scope, laying the groundwork for the next several millennia of critical thought and humanities . In the interviews John gave, following his best friend's disappearance, he never failed to mention T's love for the great minds and ideas of classical antiquity—as if he had a list of things that he needed people to know about T, and his passion for Euripedes, Pythagoras, Socrates, Boethius, Plato (but less than one might expect), Sisyphus (far more than one might guess) —and this specific passion, among the hundreds of obsessions that, as though they were his children, constantly waged battle over his time and attention, was of significant importance in what he needed the world to understand about his friend.

An exedra in ancient Greece was a semi-circular or rectangular bench with a high back, often found in public spaces, used for social gatherings, discussions, and philosophical debates. These structures were integral parts of Greek architecture, particularly in places where public life and intellectual activity flourished.

The name made far more sense to John once he'd done a little research on the subject matter. They'd gone back only once more, over a decade had elapsed in the interim during which John had convinced himself it was a dream and T had gone mad and recovered on two separate occasions - both times as a result of having gone too deep into theoretical physics and quantum theory without a proper plan for extrication. Still, he had recovered twice from the depths of his own madness, and, the ungrateful bastard he was, he still decided to take that second voyage to *L'Esedra* - "Looking for something," John would repeat almost every time he was interviewed, "that he promised me he'd never go looking for again." He had the soundbite perfected—you could playback any one of the myriad interviews given during the long Winter of 2015, which seemed to stretch well into the Spring of 2016—and it would be nearly impossible to notice any difference in tone, cadence, or meaning. It had become nothing but a soundbite to him. Signifying nothing. Because his father had taught him at a young age that the key to lying is consistency and an unwavering commitment to the lie—ironically one of the few things he'd told him that ended up being true.

On November 27th, 1996, T and his mother, Isabelle Grayson, who has gone by Izzy since grade school and does not even turn her head at the sound of her legal name to this very day, arrived on XX Island via Southwood Highway and made their way directly to Roapes Drive, which was, to Izzy's surprise, closed to public access by a large and ominous bronze gate. It was a great relief to her when, having pulled up to the gate in their eggshell colored Ford Taurus, the gates began moving on their own almost instantaneously, sweeping inward to reveal an oak lined drive that curved slightly to the right, eventually disappearing into the foliage. It wasn't until she had crossed the precipice onto the property that she noticed the ghastly pale man with long bone-white hair, who logic dictated had been the one to press the button that opened the gate—and when she rolled down her window to speak to him, failed to suppress a gasp at the sight of his deeply foggy corneas before asking as politely as she could muster (she momentarily despaired that she would not know how to speak to anyone here) if he might please direct her to the residence of Beatrice and Henry Roapes—only thinking after the fact that maybe she should have said it the other way around, Henry and Beatrice Roapes—but it didn't matter because the man had been pointing on down the drive since before she'd even begun her sentence and his hand continued to hang there like a scarecrow's lifeless arm, a white gloved hand pointing in the only direction there was to go by way of a long, thin, index finger that T imagined would be exposed as literally nothing but bone if the white glove were to be removed. His mother hushed him, which struck him as odd, considering he hadn't spoken a word aloud. But certain mothers, Izzy being one of them, truly did have that uncanny ability to display genuine signs of telepathy with their offspring. ^[6] Izzy, for example, would often feel physical pain without explanation, in one such instance she began to shout out about her arm, *Oh God! It hurts!* —- but even she knew that she was hamming it up a bit, the pain was inexplicable. T was off at college at the time and it was only two hours later he called to let her know that he had just gotten out of the hospital, a freak accident, he'd caught his arm that was hanging out the window of his friends truck, on an oversized mailbox. Snapped the forearm right in half. He was worried that his mother was going to have fit over the hospital bill, *It really had been his own dumb fault* .

Mr. Iscariot chuckled to himself as the car drove off. Nothing thrilled him more than getting a chance to do the pointing routine, as though there were somewhere else for the visitors to go, other than further down the drive. And he particularly liked it when he could recognize the scent of a young female who had yet to go through menopause. What benefits the olfactory system received when his sight had been taken from him—at moments like this he was actually grateful for it. No one in the whole of the Southeast had a more keen nose for pussy than Mr. Iscariot. He laughed again before returning to his shack where he pressed the other button, the one that shut the gate, and then turned the radio on once more, delighted to catch the tail end of Toni Braxton's "Unbreak My Heart".

The storm arrived no more than fifteen minutes after T and Izzy had pulled over to the side of the driveway at 8 Roapes Drive and started with introductions. It pulled up fast and screeched to a halt right beneath a sizable magnolia. Ten minutes later the sky would blacken and whether ominous or comical, no one but Henry Roapes had thought it right to decide so quickly.

Henry Roapes, standing beside his wife, his hand gripped tight about her waist so that John, who stood on his mother's left, could see his father's fingertips whiten as they pressed against her hip. Henry whispered grittily, out the side of his mouth, loud enough so that both his wife and son could hear: "Did y'know she was bringing a john in tow with her?" at which Bea pinched tight at the back of his neck where her other hand had been placed and made a shushing sound at him.

Bea couldn't tell if Henry was trying to be funny, or just rude, but either way she called him *crass* and looked down at her son, John, who kept his eyes trained elsewhere, pretending not to have heard.

He was in the first semester of his sixth grade year and particularly voracious when it came to language arts and reading. He knew that a *john*, along with being a toilet, was also the name of a man who had something to do with prostitutes.

Izzy waved a long, slender hand in their direction and smiled. She had a wide smile, with large bright teeth, and cheekbones that sat high up on her face. T, who was still barely visible, turned off the car and removed the keys from the ignition. He was not much more than a shadow at that point, but one could see his broad shoulder and muscular build. No one, standing where Henry, Bea and John were standing, would have guessed he was thirteen as well—particularly because he had been the one driving the car—but when he walked around the front of the truck and his face became visible, it was clear that he was still a boy. He wore a beard but it was sparse, particularly in the cheeks, and poorly maintained so that his neck appeared to be the hairiest part about him. He wore a Wagner College baseball cap which was well worn and dirty and he made an effort to spit in the manliest way possible once he was in full view. Izzy could be heard reprimanding him, but not clearly, just in tone and manner—and his confidence fluttered away just that quickly. As they approached John heard her saying, Just because I let you drive doesn't make you into some kind of cowboy. Don't let me see you do that nastiness again—especially in front of Mrs. Bea and her family.

—Yes ma'am, came the boy's response. His voice sought an octave too low for its own good, and eked out just enough no to cause a full sprint out.

Something about the scene made Henry Roapes chuckle, and John felt a brief lightness in his chest, standing beside his parents—it was the most "family-like" they'd been in some time. It was a feeling he would remember for decades, in part because it was one of the last times he could remember the

three of them together without one of his parents at the other's throat, but also because the entire tone of the moment shifted abruptly as a simple, but determined gust of wind whipped through the air, turning the remaining leaves in the trees onto their backsides.

A massive, dark black cumulus cloud appeared in the sky like the fo'c'sle of a massive celestial warship, that towered over the island—a thorough darkness that extended across the whole of the Roapes property (which was several miles in its own right), and that shadow kept right on expanding in his mind's eye on to the Wrathburn property, which had been nothing but wild indigo until they endeavored to start farming it; seeing as its value was extraordinary and it grew plentiful as dandelion on a little league baseball field— *Lucky pricks ever since **they** settled beside **us*** , Pappy could not help but to emphasize that it was they that chose to settle beside us, two lovers quarreling over who first asked the other to dance—that it was the Roapes who'd settled and the Wrathburns who followed behind, Pappy maintained. Though like all else, the primacy of ownership was bickered over, even though it mattered for naught, it always had been a topic of barroom debate, whether it was the Wrathburns who settled beside the Roapes' land or the Roapes who built our Great Estate next to the Wrathburns. And Pappy bore a particular grudge as he'd gone and married one, Miss Deborah Wrathburn that is, later Mee-Maw to her grandson, John—anyways, they found the plant and it was from then on called *domestic indigo* as Pappy liked to joke. *Hard work domesticating that wild weed that so happened to make a royal powder internationally traded which could only be grown under such specific conditions as occurred right there. Lucky is all it was.*

That was how far the darkness from that storm cloud went, all the way out to where the banks turned into nothing but oyster rich pluff mud, and thin strands of marsh grass, each blade with its own fingernail sized snail who, like sisyphus, was fated to climb the reed when the tide came in (in turn cleaning it off, free from destructive bacteria—I assume and should verify) and as the tide goes back out again the snail travels to the base of the giant blade of grass where it gathers its necessities and prepares for the ascent once again— but also dangerous, the pluff mud I mean, where one wrong step will catch you a laceration so deep a man can bleed out, right to death that is, and it had happened before.

IIX

Enigmatic is the sort of word that is a compliment when used about an abstraction, a fiction, a personality, something that is already being objectified, and as such, when the term is used as a compliment it can only be done so by turning the subject into an object, dehumanizing (because even a human is stripped of their humanity when they take on the weight of *enigma*), and it necessitates a sort of tacit voyeurism in all those who nod their head in agreement.

Bob Dylan is an enigma.

But T was an enigma in the truest sense of the word and the connotations in a local context, in a human context, are quite cold and unkind. They almost always indicate a distrust, if not an outright dislike of the person who bears the title. We do not love celebrities. A hometown enigma is a celebrity who is trying to pass off as human. They belong in a cage, under analysis, at a remove. They should not have parents. Not even one. And it is nearly offensive that the local enigma should seek compassion under any conditions. The need for love is beneath them and whether they know it or not, they know it.

T was an enigma and he could not find the words to describe the horror of it to anyone, so he spent most of his life in hiding.

An enigma almost inherently cannot be understood. By OED Reference, “[figuratively,] an enigma is a person or thing that is mysterious, puzzling, or difficult to understand.” The definition itself leaves plenty of room for gray area, in part because an enigma is actually “A riddle, usually one involving metaphor,” and as such when a person is considered an enigma it is always in a figurative sense. They are like a riddle, and “usually” a riddle that “[involves a] metaphor.” The qualifiers run deep, just as riddles can be solved, the human enigma is “difficult to understand.”

Doesn’t it seem that there may be some gap in our vocabulary? Or are we so confident in the human capacity for comprehension?

Were I to take this definition of enigma as stated I would go so far as to say I’ve known many an enigma in my life. Perhaps everyone I’ve ever known has been an enigma—to me at least—because I struggle with the idea that something so complex and completely isolated as another human being’s mind could ever *not* be “difficult to understand.” And even allowing for modest leeway in the definition of “difficult” and “understand” – anyone I’ve ever met who has read and grappled with titans of literature is dealing in enough complexity that it would be, more or less, a lie, to claim that they were not meeting the minimal criteria to be figuratively called an enigma.

We are a cocky lot; and hubris may yet prove to be the downfall, not just of “the hero” (as most mildly attentive college Freshman learn in ENG 101 - alongside vague associations with Robert Cambell and Odysseus), but of humanity itself—because there is still one more definition of enigma, or more accurately Enigma, the capital E indicating that it is a proper noun, a name, in this case of a thing.

More specifically it is the name that was given to a Nazi cipher machine as well as the nearly unbreakable (and enigmatic) code that it created. Perhaps it is telling that the Naval Enigma Machine had its code ultimately broken by Alan Turing’s Bombe given the critical distinction, a gulf of possibility, that lies between something that is difficult to do versus something that is impossible to do. The very nature of a cipher demands that it can be translated by someone or something. And a code that can be translated can be broken, one would assume—at a minimum it proved to be true in this case. That is the distinction between genuine randomness and the randomize button on a musical playlist. True randomness cannot be recreated outside of physical processes. Put otherwise, randomness cannot

be purely manmade. Humankind can approximate it using algorithm-driven pseudo random number generators (PRNGs) but cannot replicate the divine totality of true randomness found in things like radioactive decay, thermal noise - flying in the face of determinism - and ultimately allowing Alan Turing the capacity to build the machine that broke Enigma for good, cracked the Nazi code that had been appropriately named after that which is nearly beyond comprehension, but not.

What is the word for someone who is impossible to understand? There is the objectively accurate, but unsatisfyingly direct, “incomprehensible”. And then there is “inscrutable”, which is used lightly in common practice, as if it meant something other than what it did. The *inscrutable* is impossible to understand. This category would, almost by rule, include all beings more sophisticated than the subject who is asking the question. It would also almost certainly include children below a certain age, at which it is impossible to remember or understand what it was like to have been unaware of certain feelings, experiences, emotions. Once one has fallen in love, it is impossible to understand what the world is like without the knowledge of the sensation. One can sympathize, even perhaps empathize, but understand? Better to have loved and lost than never to have loved at all? No one knows if this is the case! The two experiences are mutually exclusive. The person who has *loved and lost* cannot remember what it was like *never to have loved at all* —this is obvious in the fact that they find it so easy to say one is preferable to the other [\[7\]](#) . Really, what this person means is to say, “I would do anything to get rid of this condition I face.” At least that’s the way I understand it.

Some synonyms for enigma: mystery, puzzle, riddle, paradox, quandary.

But if an inscrutable enigma is a paradox we should start being more careful around words. Someone is bound to get hurt, or worse, be misunderstood. What a nightmare it would be.

T was an *inscrutable enigma* .

—only that as an enigma one has to develop an inherent distrust of anyone who claims to understand them, meaning what they believe is real in life and what it is they mean to say when they speak. This is part of their nature, this distrust (and distrust breeds first resentment, then contempt) —one excellent way to identify a true and veritable enigma is to identify that person who is most happy with you, most at peace, when you respond to their attempt at genuine communication of what they see and feel while they move through the world, not by nodding your head pensively in agreement, but by stating clearly and without shame that you cannot entirely grasp what they are saying, but that you wish you could, and then (This is critical!) when they explain again, less patiently, but more efficiently to communicate the same concept or sensation, not to simply appease them with agreement, but to inform them of the truth—that is, that you still cannot grasp it in, not entirely, but you are certain that you are closer now than you were the time before.

Missa Solemnis . Mee-Maw died after a short, violent battle with melanoma. John remembered her death as a series of snapshots, the way one tends to remember their youth in singular, crystalline moments from which they extrapolate the rest.

November 30th, 1994: His tenth birthday party. Mee-Maw sat at the head of the long table in the Great House, Pappy at her side, smiling with her entire face as John stuffed himself on the gluttonous cake she'd made—crumbles of brittle, homemade toffee and fudge covered thick whipped cream, graham crackers and pie filling and caramel in every crack and crevice. She had an indulgent streak in her too, that had turned her into a fat and jolly old woman, and she loved nothing more than watching the pure enjoyment of excess.

Miss Dolores cleared the table and then announced it was time for presents.

From his parents a new bicycle.

From Uncle James, a leather bound notebook and a fountain pen. Uncle James told him he would be an artist one day. He sniffed the leather and wondered if it was a journal, or a sketchbook, or if it was meant to be something else altogether.

From Pappy, he received an atlas, which excited him a great deal, but he could see in his periphery, his father's laugh, as though it were ridiculous. John remembered how confused he was in that moment, recognizing a gulf that existed between father and son—How was that man his father? Why did it feel so unnatural?—he was unsure how to express his excitement anymore. He knew it was still there, but it had gone into hiding, on the run from the part of himself that he knew must exist, the part his father built.

He was grateful when a letter fell out from between the pages of the atlas, in Pappy's script it was written *Read In Private* , so he tucked it back in the book and looked over to his grandfather, who winked at him in a way that let him know he'd seen everything, and understood.

John watched Mee-Maw sneak another large spoonful of peach cobbler—her underarm swung in fleshy waves. Like rest of her body it was covered in brown and black moles, age spots and skin tags of varying shapes and sizes - each of them having started as nothing more than a freckle and then bloomed, in time, into the galaxy of speckled skin that John associated with something reptilian.

Rough terrain across every inch of her forearms, her back, her legs (though she rarely exposed them anymore), even her face looked like it had been splashed with speckles of hardened mud. Apart from photographs from her wedding day—in which she was tall, thin, fair skinned, and exuded a sort of royalty in the way that she held her hand up, but allowed it to dangle at the wrist for anyone who might want to inspect the ring finger, which of course sparkled incandescently—apart from those photographs

which covered so much of the available wall space on main floor that they forced the question from anyone who spent more than five minutes inside:

Was that Deborah?

When visitors first attended an event at the Great House (for a time there were many events, many visitors, but that time passed with Mee-Maw), it was not uncommon to find them, later in the evening, having returned to the main hall, standing with hands intertwined behind their backs, gazing intently into one or another photograph as if it were an exhibit at an art museum—the look was always the same blend of perplexed and awestruck—because it was quite impossible to miss once you saw it, but it was something like one of those optical illusions that require you to relax your gaze and allow the eyes to do the work.

The visitor could observe, quite clearly, how the heavysset matron of the house, Mrs. Deborah Roapes, who was now completely covered in mostly benign growths (growths anywhere from the size of a pin prick to a half dollar, with a comprehensive spectrum of shades of brown), had once been voted the “Treasure of the Island”

If this person was not seen directly staring at the pictures, they could be identified later in the evening, staring at Mee-Maw as if questioning reality itself.

It was in such a small box and weighed nearly nothing.

Mee-Maw excused herself quickly but only got as far as the main hallway before she started coughing, violently. There she is, doubled over, Pappy at her side.

Pappy had a record of Beethoven that he would play over and over again on gray days. He could tell by the smell, he said, if the weather would clear—and invariably, when he put on Beethoven, it would be an all day affair and the sun would not show through the clouds and yet the clouds would not rain and the air would stand still, so wet and warm that one had to wade through it to get from place to place.

He called it sun cancer, and though he had always been more comfortable indoors, once he decided it was the sun that had killed Mee-Maw it became a sort of resentment of the outdoors altogether, and his proclivity for indoor activities became more of a compulsion than a simple preference. Eventually it got so that simple things like taking a trip to the store became the subject of long monologues about radiation and how, in the end, the sun would be the end of everything, how one day it would suddenly expand, swallowing everything in its path, and the earth would be swallowed whole and then condensed into the infinite gravity of a black hole. There would be nothing that remained as it proceeded to consume all that was within reach.

See: George Bataille; *The Solar Anus* . An object of excrement, Pappy declared it. And by then he was old enough and well off in such a way that he could live his life out with such disdain for the source of all life—though he faced significant criticism from his sons.

Then he would begin to list the planets. He had an incredible memory, so with each planet he would list the major moons (at least those that had names worth reciting). From there he might begin to list off comets, unexplained phenomena—it became a formless act of rote memorization and recitation, something like the child of religious zealots who could ramble off entire passages from any book in the Old Testament.

He could provide a thousand reasons why he despised that giant ball of gas around which all of the known celestial bodies in the solar system revolve, upon which all life relies. For example, a person who wore glasses, like myself or Pappy, every time they stepped outside because the very world around them became obscured and no matter how you wiped at your glasses you could not rid them of the condensation, you simply had to wait until they adapted.

X

[Treasure of the Island]

—paraded through the street for her beauty, on some fourth in July

back when young men with parted hair kept shirts tucked

morality ordained by God and all the wars,

—all the wars they ran towards—so eager, so righteous and
chaste

—oh yes! in the name of the Holy Lord, America

the righteous land. Where any man could work his

right into prosperity! —oh yes! —oh yes! When Deborah

was the supple vessel, where no man's hearth was borne;

—seventeen. hauled so to float cross the whole of the

Island

on parade. She in a one piece swimsuit a wide brimmed hat

to cast a sloping shadow, contrast cross the skin so pure—

sun-kissed, golden,

—white and flawless, so Percival had seen:

She was a Great American Beauty.

[The Island of Perseus]

Where, stranded, we combed

each grain of sand blown

west for sheer want of rain

and found a shore anew

a home amid idle tides

but never a way home

never life so vague

covered in sugar

still but for the insects

thick as a new surface

all across the hide

Arrived , but yet unsettled, Izzy and William Theodore Grayson were kept from accessing their new house by Mother Nature herself, as if to warn them about the new world they would be asked to contend with—there was a ferocious storm that exploded at precisely the moment the rubber tire of the eggshell Ford Taurus crossed over onto Roapes Lane. These were noticeably thick, voluminous drops. It came from a soot black thundercloud that had itself appeared quickly and without warning, as if pulled from the island itself in some kind of ecological leaching process. At 1732 hours it should have been a pink dappled horizon, instead the cloud made it appear to be late into the night.

Moreover, the frequency with which lightning struck horrified Izzy, who could only remember one other rainstorm as loud and immense—only one—a disastrous cruise vacation she'd gone on with a former romantic interest, one might call him. Though, looking back on it, he had never truly interested her, nor had she felt the slightest hint of romance. He was overweight, in his forties, and did inconceivable well on a few incredibly well timed investments which was as much as he would say about the source of his money. And for Izzy's part it was as much as she wanted to ask.

In retrospect, she had been gold digging. In fact, at the time she had known exactly what she was doing, and had been willing to go much, much further.

It was only during the intervening years, when telling others about it, that she had invented certain qualities about the man that might have made her truly interested in him, had they been true. For example, she told many people that he'd spent two years living in a buddhist temple, and had been on the path to becoming a monk when he had a vision that he had to experience unselfish love before he could go any further on his journey towards *the universal singularity* . He'd even written a book about it, under a pen name of course, and he had promised to himself never to give away his identity to combat the specter of ego. Unbelievable as it was, she was a natural born storyteller, which is more than just a euphemism for a liar, it's something else. Liars, great liars, know the key is in saying only what is necessary, and keeping as close to the truth as their lie will allow, so as not to get snared in their own net. The storyteller is expansive and creative and sees villas where there are only shacks, gently flowing canals where there are only drainage ditches and sewage pipes. Storytellers own the world and shape it at their behest. Liars see the world and manipulate perspectives to achieve their ends.

Izzy was a storyteller. And her son, her William, had inherited her gift. As they pulled to a halt in front of the great house Izzy felt an overwhelming desire to throw the car in drive and peel out of there as fast as the tormented old vehicle would allow, but William surprised her; he put his hand over hers on the vibrating handle of the clutch. He gently squeezed it in such a way that brought about a wave of reassurance. She felt his hand, looked up to see him smiling, and when he spoke she felt as though something that had been chasing her for years and years and years had finally, at last, given up in its

pursuit. “We made it,” he said - as behind him, atop a long flight of wide stairs, the massive doors to the Great House cracked open, and Izzy made eye contact with John for the first time.

XII

During the nearly twenty four hour drive from Wagner to XX William ^[8] expressed his frustration in as many ways as he could invent.

There were stages, both of the trip (which was broken up into three days, deviating from the initial plan), and of his response to the changes (or as he called it, the “suppression of the proletariat desire by the fascist regime of Isabelle Grayson”). He was, as has been established, prodigiously intelligent, though he’d never stayed out of trouble at school for long enough for any teacher to do anything about it, even if some of them did care. He was brilliant academically, likely had what was then called “a photographic memory” but is now generally recognized as the markings of a high functioning savant. His problems in school likely came from his early introduction to Marx, Nietzsche, Cioran and many other, more obscure thinkers who ranged (politically) from *far left* to *absolute anarchists*, some of whom would go on to do great and terrible things with their lives. Some of whom would be labeled anarcho-terrorists—some who truly were anarcho-terrorists, but many who were just young artists keen to anything with a revolutionary spirit and an excuse to fight back against the onslaught of boredom and hypocrisy they saw everywhere they looked.

These were the sort of men Izzy often brought home and dated for a while, and then for one reason or another ultimately banished from the house by changing the locks while they were out at a party meeting ^[9], any meeting for that matter that had some sort of an affiliated acronym and was on a CIA watchlist, or else when they were out at the bar with their friends (which, depending on the man, was often the same thing as a party meeting). She was pragmatic in that she kicked them out exclusively on weekdays that coincided with her days off from work. This allowed her time (with William at school, and the men, often, off doing the same mischievous things they did while she worked) to sort through their meager belongings for anything of value that could be taken without fear of having the cops called—mostly drugs, though she also took goods she knew to be stolen in the first place. Once she took a gun and regretted it afterwards. The man who she’d taken it from would not go quietly. Once he realized what had happened he called and called non-stop for two days; the next day he showed up at her small apartment complex riding an obscenely large motorcycle, the handle of a baseball bat protruding from the backpack he wore.

He shouted *Get out here you fucking cunt!* over and over until someone called the police and he was arrested on the spot. He had a warrant for attempted homicide in New Jersey. He’d gotten into a fight at a Russian Bar in Hoboken. The newspaper said he’d pulled a gun and fired, accidentally striking the

bartender rather than his intended target. The bartender, a burly mustachioed man, had nearly bled out, but had not. Izzy turned the gun in to the police (and in fact received \$1500 in reward money from the DA's office in New Jersey).

After that she became much more cautious, but not necessarily in the ways one might expect—she still opened her home to all sorts of terrible men with a certain degree of wanton abandon—but when she sent them packing she never again took a weapon; lesson learned.

What she didn't keep she left in neatly organized boxes with a thoughtful, but cold note. She always came up with a plan that involved her and William staying with one of her friends from work, as to avoid any unnecessary commotion, or emotion, for that matter.

By and by William came to resent not just the men his mother brought home, but his mother for bringing them home—though he tried, and frequently failed, to remember that she was likely lonely. And whatsmore she believed that William wanted a father more than anything in the world. Though the latter fact was true, it was not apparent to William yet just how true it was, and so it remained an open wound in their relationship that remained open for so long it eventually scarred and became permanent.

This, perhaps, explains why William began the long, long journey by detailing the list of men that they had “lived with” in Wagner; —and a much longer list than Izzy recalled, she realized very early on, as he'd chosen to go in alphabetical order by first name or nickname (for those who seemed not even to have a real name, as if they were merely characters that had been invented so as to be a part of this list, a part of his mother's narrative) and it took nearly ten minutes to get to Nathan Harsh—the only one William had ever truly liked, and after he said Nathan's name he had to stop because his voice began to quiver.

This was torture for Izzy, but William had framed it in such a way that it was supposed to be a ritual of sorts—they were cleansing themselves—he told her, as he went on to speak in detail about his most terrible, painful and sad memories. There seemed to be a bottomless well of these short monologues, which occasionally turned into debate-like dialogues, in moments of weakness when Izzy could not bear it any longer and felt the need to interject and correct him or disagree with one point or another—though of course she knew he did not make mistakes of memory; and compounding the issue: she knew that he knew this too, so each time she interjected to question him it was an act of futility that only brought about a more painful lashing than before because he would pick out and describe increasingly specific details to help *jog her memory* until eventually she would say *Enough! You're right. You're right* , —never once thinking to tell him she couldn't take it any more, so much of her failure beneath a spotlight, listed out like items in an estate sale; she never even imagined that it was her right to put a stop to it, unfathomable, whether due to a subconscious form of martyrdom (certainly, she couldn't have really believed it was redemptive?), or perhaps a vile fetish, a sado-masochistic tendency that she

had retained from her days as a teenage “cutter”; either way she never even considered that she could stop it, stop him.

She was utterly powerless as she passed the southbound exit, maintaining a cool 65 mph because anything more and the Taurus began to wobble—the car took on a reckless life of its own.

At the end of each monologue William made a mimetic production of ripping up the invisible pages of their orally recounted history and then tossing the pieces out the window. Once (though she knew it was a trick of the road) in the rear view mirror she could have sworn she saw the tiny flecks of paper, rippling, glistening, then spreading out and consolidating again.

What *was that* called again? It was William who loved to see them so much, the starlings—but she couldn’t ask him, of course, she didn’t even know what she would say.

By then he’d physically outgrown his mother, and the trip was the first time in her memory she recognized the new dynamic. Izzy had missed their southbound exit at some point, completely oblivious, thinking about the vision she’d had in the rearview mirror, her mother’s madness, how strange it had been to reconnect with Beatrice the way she had, and how insane it was—both what they were doing, and the fact that it had been offered in the first place. Part of her was wondering if they wouldn’t show up to streamers and balloons and a whole party of people gathered to look at the idiots who’d packed their entire lives and driven from Wagner to XX all to be the butt of some lame joke—some kind of sick trick that wealthy families like to play just to remind themselves they can. Maybe they wrote you a giant check at the end if you were a good sport about it. Maybe they hunted you like in that story by Upton Sinclair, “The Greatest Game”? She was so lost in thought it wasn’t until she saw the third or fourth sign for Chicago that it registered: she’d overshot her mark substantially.

William slapped the front dash of the old car so hard she thought the air bag might deploy, “Chicago? Chi-CAGO?” He said it a few times and then trained his gaze out the window and pouted as if he had a strict schedule to keep or plans of some sort upon arriving in XX. She was never frightened of him, it should be made clear, because objectively he had grown large and strong enough that his outburst surely would be frightening to someone else, someone *who was not Izzy*. But even after she felt the violence of his blow quiver across the frail frame of the struggling Taurus there was not a moment that passed in which saw or felt anything impure—anything more frightening than fear; and not fear for himself, but fear for something altogether incomprehensible. A *murmuration* she thought, a murmuration.

She was worried, always worried—but never scared in the least. no, but she was concerned about the choices she’d made and realized that she knew nothing about the ways that a boy becomes a man.

He put Bruce Springsteen’s *Nebraska* tape in, rewound it to a precise point. He pressed play and looked out the window, humming or singing to himself quietly.

Crepuscularity.

The mistake he made was in making eye contact with her. He looked his Mee-Maw in the eyes, dark almost black olive pits against the faded yellow whites of her eyes. The knowledge was immediate and difficult to bear. She had... *spoken to him* . He was certain of it. Though it was in the manner that one speaks to one's own self—the speaking never occurs, and the hearing never occurs, but nonetheless words pass, concrete ideas pass, in what must be their most true and actual form. And after it happened, because there was no evidence that it or anything had happened at all, John refused to believe it.

It is close .

Semantic Relativity .

After all that has occurred, been written about, litigated, forgotten or remembered, one might be surprised to learn that it was John who first introduced T to the work of Grant Allen Norton—which was, at the time, making waves as they say, in the literary circles. The Post-Maximalism, or Omnirealism, or Comprehensive Fractalism—the names only got more and more obscure as time went on. When John gave it to T it was a *book* . A damn big book, but a book nonetheless.

Really it was Uncle James first, though, who had left a well worn copy of Norton's thousand page tome, *Broken Horizon* , in the small cubby just inside the side entrance to the Great House (where he'd been leaving him books with small notes of recommendation since introducing him to Holden Caulfield for Christmas a few years prior). This time the note was on an index card, folded atop a stack of index cards that sat beside the book, in which John was instructed to use a card as a bookmark and fill with his thoughts as he read. Of all the books John had received from his uncle, this was the first that was a shared discovery and not some sort of sentimental education—in that way it was the first book John received that did not seem to come with an implicit lesson or goal in mind, except for the clear hope that he would find something in it that justified the recommendation. Something that his Uncle could not tell him, and perhaps was still looking for himself.

The folded index read was nearly full with James' miniature print— *a literary correspondence* , as John thought of it:

Big things in the works. Off to Puerto Rico — with Kelly and The Idiot [\[10\]](#). Wish me luck! Read the Norton book while I'm away. I think it's the greatest book I've ever read. You'll appreciate it, I think—had to share with someone. Feel free to pass it on to "T-Bone" when you finish up, he might dig it too. As for the index cards: Use one at a time - it will serve as your bookmark and a place to make notes. Once a card is full, start a new one. Always take notes! 'The world is so vast, young friend—now go on and keep it that way.' Not sure when I'll be back, but I hope not long. In the meantime, feed Crowley and take care of the house for me (see pg. 1000).

Crowley was a cat. John was fairly certain it caught its own food having found entrails in unexpected places more than once, but he had always been willing to oblige his Uncle's requests to *cat sit* as it was basically an unspoken excuse for him to move out of his own house every so often, where the residual energy from his parents' mutually miserable lives lingered in the corners, always watching for some unexpectedly pleasant thing to occur, it seemed. Sometimes he'd walk through a doorway and know they'd been in there earlier, a sensation that leapt out and stayed on you as if secreted from the glands of a particularly resentful skunk.

The book was a thick, squat paperback of unorthodox dimensions. It had a soft cover that was roughly (if not precisely) square—the bottom half was a dark cerulean above which a gold stripe ran horizontally across the page, dividing the blue from the gray and white upper half. A horizon line, only slightly abstracted.

The first thing John thought was how frustrating it was to come across a book that did not align properly on a bookshelf. Square books are an inconvenience and stand out amidst a collection of other books printed in roughly standard dimensions. When he picked it up, he could see a spot towards the end of the book where the pages were misaligned, where something slightly larger than could be accommodated had been placed between two of the pages. The key of course, but what else was on page 1000? He found the thousandth page—noticed the tiny font, the paragraphs that started sans-indentation, and he found an envelope with his name on it. The pages were thin in a way that greatly pleased John's aesthetic sense, the thin wispy *crinkle* they made when a page was turned, like a bible was made of, almost, but dense with language.

Perhaps there was even something to that, he thought: the tiny words—and so many of them. They constituted significant physical weight, one could feel the amount of ink used on a given page—the paper itself a fragile verrel, thin as a ripple of wind skittering through dry fallen leaves. But the language itself, the truth, that was something.

With regard to the envelope, he realized right away that there was a stack of U. S. tender inside but rather than open the envelope right there in the Great House where anyone could walk in at any time—John decided to take the book and envelope over to James' house right away and open it there.

As he made his way towards #6 Roapes Drive, which was over a slight elevation and then back down the otherside, he thought about his mother and father and wondered, briefly, where they were and what they were doing? Neither of them had been home since morning and it was nearing on 'cocktail' hour, possibly the only happy hour of the day for them, but he hadn't heard either of their cars come down the road - they were both easily distinguished vehicles for different reasons and John was certain neither of them would be in the garage if he's gone home.

James was in love with Kelly and desperately so. Though John was too young at the time to notice the obvious signs, even as severe as they were. He did know that there was something altogether odd about the way James acted around the twins. The pursuit of this "business venture" for example, seemed a wild deviation in just about every possible way. He understood that it was often emotional, and not logical consideration that led to that sort of decision.

John only vaguely understood that the business plan had to do with regulatory loopholes, had required the consultation of several scientists (who could almost always be identified by their forest green, wagon-bodied Subaru w/roof rack), and had required the services of Mitch, who John only understood to be a professional consultant, whatever that meant, and who was involved in everything and anything that required signatures. Mitch was always kind but very formal, and when occasionally he made a joke, it usually only made a portion of the people around him laugh. He had a heavy accent and often referred to his home country with a feminine pronoun but never explicitly said if he was Irish or Welsh or perhaps Scottish.

Jared Oakstone had been out of town and something had occurred that required James and Kelly to wait at the boathouse until one of the ships came in. This was a week or so prior to his departure. They'd sat there and drank until late in the day and told each other things about themselves. On the way back to his house he'd been so overjoyed he woke John, and John obliged, curious. They went and sat on his porch and James tried to tell John about it but he was drunk beyond comprehension, and his brain kept jumping from thought to thought, and John never fully understood more than a few details.

When he woke up the next morning he seemed genuinely concerned that he'd told John something he shouldn't have.

The whole thing made John nervous. But James, who was always nervous, seemed completely at ease. The answer must be in the book, John thought, and so he sat down to read *Broken Horizon* on a Saturday morning. By evening even his father had noticed his absence. He skipped dinner that night and read onward.

The book was constructed in such a way that there were many small, tiny even, concrete sections of paragraph or sentence length. These were part of a smallish unit, sometimes only a page in length, but a parent unit nonetheless, built of three or more of the subordinate elements in each. The parent/child

relationship of the elements at this level maintained a cadence at the micro-level that very rarely vacillated.

The parent elements as described here, can be thought of as the raw materials of which the structure is made: the lumber, steel, bricks or stones —not necessarily identical in size or shape, but all sharing the same purpose, all singular components—and as the axiom has it, they aim to create a whole that is greater than the sum of its parts.

These micro chapters, then, created a tempo of sorts as they were compiled into larger configurations, some paratactically organized, sequenced to create feeling and sensation that emulated or enhanced the story being told. Other bricks were built into hypotactic structures, with unique patterns and textures that made up the poetry of the overall work. The texture of the text, in a way.

From a certain remove it gave one the impression of the titularly absent *horizon*, which was both a flat line, and an ever present, constantly changing subjectivity [\[11\]](#). From this established understanding—and *only* once this is genuinely accepted—the contextually objective *truth* of *Broken Horizon* is revealed: that the deconstruction of this discourse is self sufficient. The infinite canvas provided by the very act of allowing consciousness to become something so simple and essential, so human yet so divine, not opened to the reader so much as brought to bloom in such a way that it is recognized as a part of the reader and the reading—that all is art. To understand this, to have made that leap into the abyss without fear is to have recognized oneself as the creator; formed into a whole that provided context and form for the line itself, the horizon that divided the heavens from earth. At its core *Broken Horizon* offered this to the thoughtful reader, and all through the subtlety of time and repetition, dissonance and its resolution, and again, and again, and aga...

XV

Fifteen.

But Norton breaks all of that too. He offers up the poisoned fruit only to retract his offer, bowing repeatedly as he backs away in shame.

Consider the story in which Norton is interviewed by a prominent and well respected literary critic.

The critic was writing for the sort of intellectual culture magazine that now seems quaint and pretentious but was once the *voice* of *culture*. And at the time of the writing, the late nineties, nearing the turn of the millennium, seemingly always on the precipice of something indescribable and horrifying.

The critic is writing the sort of piece that is written every so often, intended to make a bold prediction about the coming, say, decade—who will be the dominant voice? Who will shape America? How? And though Norton is the obvious selection, having written the only truly innovative, monumental, stimulating book in the last fifteen years give or take [\[12\]](#); Somehow, it seems a bit *easy*.

Likewise the piece would look backwards to try to position Norton in the canon, or rather atop the canon, as it seemed so clear to be the case that he had become *The American Voice* if not the *Voice of Literature* – a craft that, by the time of this interview, was in the doldrums. Apart from the naturally vampiric lifeblood draining, corporate pressure of capitalism on the publishing industry—there was the issue of audiobooks, and digital books; shrinking attention spans; a generation of children who were slowly becoming desensitized to the images and language of international terrorism [\[13\]](#), at the same time hardly allowed to roam their neighborhoods for fear of domestic terrorism—the decade of *the man in the white van*.

Art in America had lost its foothold, its funding, and was in desperate need of someone who could clearly articulate its purpose. Someone who was writing out of desperation, but did not need the money. That paradoxical, unidentified individual, it seemed possible, was the author of *Broken Horizon*.

To put it lightly, the interview did not go well. It was partially the fault of the critic, who in an effort to stroke the author's ego did not treat him as he would any other subject—and rather spent days and weeks considering what forms of psychological cunning he might use to bring forth the mind that seemed beyond mortal comprehension. He was known to be an astute reader, who picked up on things that average or even above average readers often failed to notice. He read around the work, the unknown pieces, the miscellany.

He liked to say he would read a book a minimum of two times: “The first time to read what the author has written; The second time to read what the author has not.” This was exactly the sort of axiomatic rhetoric that made him the darling of the major pseudoliterary publications. Though it is true, he was an acute reader, a retrospective glance at his literary output shows that he was a critic of his times, rather than a critic of all time, and it can be coherently argued that his body of work is representative of a deep comprehension of the psychology of narcissism, turning time and again to lines of questioning that lead his subjects into exclamations of their own deeply imbued grandiosity followed by short, punctuated questions meant to open a small valve from which their insecurities would begin to escape.

The critic knew all of this.

It is what made him not only great, but consistently great. He'd taken down literary giants in his day. Only on three occasions did he come across an artist for whom his primary assumption proved false. In each case the story had turned out a complete failure (in one case, early in his career, costing him his job). These three articles are conspicuously missing from his *Collected Works*. They don't appear

referenced in his bibliography. Today they are routinely removed from his Wikipedia page by a mysterious contributor whose only amendments to the site have been the six or seven times he has removed the articles from the page.

The degree to which he was aware of this particular aspect of his own writing is unclear. It is possible that the critic simply wrote the best way he knew how - and this was the way he saw the world.

Perhaps, being a narcissist himself, it was only natural for him to think in this vein. Perhaps a statistical evaluation of prose writers and narcissism would display a nasty, horrifying correlation that no one wants to be aware of but everyone already secretly knows and he exploited a well known correlation that everyone else willingly avoided out of—fear? —loneliness?

In any case, the day came. The critic flew to meet Norton at his house in Iowa with plans to hold two sessions: an afternoon interview on Day One (with the introduction of a fine Rye Whiskey right around the midpoint of the conversation), and a morning interview on Day Two, which he had scheduled at eight AM, fully anticipating the need to push the interview back to a more reasonable hour if all went well), this time starting straight away with the whiskey, as literary comrades and semi-closetted alcoholics, the both of them.

XVI

The only part of the interview that went as planned was the start time of the interview on Day One. He arrived promptly at 2 p.m. at Norton's home address. It was a small, isolated house located so far from the downtown area of Wagner, Iowa that it was technically in a different county altogether. The house was white-ish, but yellowed by years and years of accrued pollen dust, such that it was almost more yellow than white. Like in the house of a serious and compulsive smoker, the yellow was made more obvious when the critic saw a patch of wall that had been protected until recently, it seemed, by a large square object. The contrast immediately made the rest of the house look yellow.

He stood on the front stoop making a note about the contrast, and had not yet rung the doorbell, when he was surprised to hear a tinny, radio-garbled voice coming from a speaker shaped like a tiny megaphone mounted above the left corner of the front door. The voice was deep and ominous, as though filtered through a modulator of some sort for effect. This made it incredibly hard to understand. Beside the speaker there was also a tiny camera, approximately the size and shape of a twinkie, that made quick, short movements while it looked at him—it gave off the distinct likeness of a small, suspicious house finch.

With Norton he brought out some of his most provoking questions early into the interview, as if to say *I'm not like the rest of them, I'm a rival—I'm worthy* and they were responded to flippantly, without any desire to spar, with disinterest even. So much so that the critic suddenly felt more than a bit

insecure. In hindsight the critic would recognize that it was a mistake trying to *impress* Norton the way he had—he would not make the same mistake with a woman, skipping straight to lovemaking without a hint of foreplay, so why had he done it with Norton? Perhaps it had been his subliminal desire to incur the wrath of the man, rather than the genius. Perhaps it had been his hope to display Norton at his worst, to disappoint him in a sense. These at least were the best answers he could come up with in the restless nights that followed the interview. These were the thoughts that haunted him as he failed to string together two sentences that belonged in print, particularly in a magazine of such repute.

Things had been wrong from the start. The critic had been startled by his subject, or at least his subject's voice. Intentionally or not, he had been required to play along, indulge him. He understood narcissists at their core, though, and decided to go along with the song and dance routine. He looked into the camera and held up his unfolded wallet to display an ID, of course all for show, there was no way the man could read the ID. It merely signified his tacit agreement to the order of things here. He put his wallet away as he repeated his name in a professional manner and then stated the purpose of his visit, "...as we agreed during our most recent conversation...on..." he hastily rifled through a tiny notebook pulled from his breast pocket, "the sixteenth. Yes, the sixteenth at 3:30 p.m. my time...so, 2:30 or thereabouts for you. Ring any bells Mr. Norton?"

Just then the critic heard a voice shouting something or other inside the house. The speaker remained silent. Perhaps he's mad, the critic thought for a brief moment—but it couldn't be, he was a professor; a tenured professor at Wagner for that matter. Even IF he'd managed to somehow hide his madness long enough to get the job, there wasn't a chance in the world that he could have navigated the politics and sheer bureaucracy necessary to advance to a tenured position. *As a novelist, he could be completely out of his gourd, but as a tenured professor there was simply too much paperwork.*

Finally the door opened and the critic was somewhat taken aback by the short, middle-aged man with a graying beard and receding hairline that stood in the entranceway. He would later remark that he felt as though he was standing face to face with the saddest man he'd ever met and his immediate response was an intense guilt because he knew, as a writer, he would have to describe the feeling he had as he stood there and the man across from him sputtered out an apology for his roommate, something nonsensical, and he could literally feel loneliness exuding from his sad pores. But in the moment he did not say a word. He held out his hand and met sadness with formality.

Norton had somehow broken the critic. And the editors at the magazine began to sense that something was very wrong as the days went by and nothing, no drafts, no updates, no responses even to their emails.

Both John and T were bright students and both shared a reputation for being irreverent towards their teachers (though never outright rude, it should be said—they just seemed as if they didn't belong among their peers).

They isolated themselves from others so much that rumors spread amongst the student body as they are wont to do on small islands. Neither of them had participated in so much as a single extracurricular activity. Both had been removed from the Honor Society as they had failed to meet the required eight hours of community service. As such neither would be able to include 'Honor Society' on their college applications when the time came—and the time was right around the corner.

It was spring break of their junior year and life was offering one of those rare seasons that seemed to deliver serenity en masse to anyone smart enough to ease off a bit and let things run their course. It was a moment in time that often is captured in one's memory as a distinct event. A particular song resonates. Each night seems to share the same bright dying hues of a lowcountry sunset. In one's memory it was always a perfect seventy degrees.

For T it aligned with the unprecedented feeling of comfort—the absence of the overriding anxiety that seemed to permeate his entire life until then. There were times, of course, when things had been *good* before that—but as he would recall in his journals, "It was the first time that I could remember the distinct absence of worry—as though everything were not on the precipice of collapse. I was young enough, then, not to be frightened by that sort of feeling—and that was one of the first times I recognized *youth as a sort of wisdom* ." This would become a recurring theme in his writings, growing more and more nuanced and complex as he found himself aged and by extension spending more time in the direct contact of the dark and disturbing.

This is what happens as we age: as if it were the natural course of things. Or at least one reading of William Theodore Grayson might suggest so.

For John, the experience was similar, but there were elements of his life at home that he could not shake, no matter how he tried. Senior year was both right around the corner and so far off it wasn't worth thinking about. When he did think about it though, it seemed less burdensome than school had ever seemed before—there was an end in sight.

And with all of the accelerated learning courses they'd taken, they'd each have half day schedules. T intended to get a job, a thought that John had never really even considered. He had been dreaming of pursuing ' *a life of the mind* ' , as Izzy had called it one particularly memorable night a few weeks prior.

John had taken her and T out on *The Lady Jane* , a nineteen foot skiff he'd been given by his mother for no apparent reason (not apparent, that is, until he saw the look on his father's face when he found out what she'd done; the excess make-up that made no apologies). It was a center console with a T top parasol and a thin, Carolina blue border that was tasteful. Every few minutes he'd throttle down the

engine and point out a house owned by a basketball player or actress or senator, once he pointed to a small islet that was nothing more than a mound of sand with some grass in the middle, just as he pointed there was a big proliferation of movement in the water and suddenly a school of small fish were being herded up onto the sand by a pack of porpoises that would follow behind and scoop up the salty, flailing treats greedily. *It's called strand feeding*, he said. *No where else in the world but here.*

Stopping every so often in spots John knew to be particularly plentiful with sea life.

T was impressed by John's knowledge of the waterways.

T was naturally gifted at just about anything he did. He picked up new skills with jealousy-inducing ease. He mastered them quickly, grew bored, then cast them aside while John was still trying to get a hold of the fundamentals. John's father had once noticed this and as a result came to like T, to encourage him, and whenever he had the chance to praise him in front of John he did so in a way that came out as if he were asking a question, but no one was sure what the question was, or why he was trying to ask it in such an obtuse way.

John, who had been a decent, but lazy pianist since he was six or seven, watched in horror as T sat down beside him one day at the baby grand piano in the great house and asked him two or three questions about how sheet music worked, and what the point of the pedals were, and then fumbled around with the keys a bit before knocking out a chunk of Chopin that John had been practicing for years. Only someone who had been watching their entire lives unfold would have noticed the way John's face grew pale as he looked around the house to see who might have been there and heard what had occurred.

The fallout from the event was psychologically devastating: No one had been there to see John's reaction, no one except for T, who looked to his friend for a response—though he was well aware that what he'd just done was the byproduct of the unique capacity he had for pattern recognition and memorization (and as such it followed that it was not so much amazing as it was uncommon...though, he supposed he could claim *extraordinary*, he confirmed with himself—yes it exceeded the ordinary but failed to be anything more than that). He found John's face displayed nothing but a thin smile that seemed to sink into his face, distaste even. John's internal response had somehow tried to hide behind his own dark blue eyes (if eyes are the gateway to the soul, as it is often enough stated to be it must be because they are one of only two body parts that act almost as if they operated semi autonomously, and at best took took guidance) —the result was that the whole of his face looked uninhabited, while his eyes alone seemed crowded with a multiplicity of selves and doubles and somehow they all seemed to cancel one another out.

It was a face that made no sense.

Fishing and boating, though, turned out to be an altogether different experience. T questioned him about how he knew when to turn, what certain signs and buoys meant, why he waved at every person they passed, how a depth finder worked, the way motors worked and what was the point of the long yellow construction tunnels. John explained all this and more.

He brought them to an area where an old shipwreck had been repurposed by the transformative brackish marsh, with its powerful tides and ceaseless process of moving and changing and forcing adaptation among its inhabitants. Adaptation that the sunken ship (rumored to have been a pirate vessel, John had been told once by an uninformed friend, learned it to be false, and continued to tell people that it was *rumored to* be so, because that much was true, the rumor, I mean. It was now a diverse ecosystem where you could catch everything from sea trout to bonnethead sharks—it was not yet well known by the inshore charters, somehow it had been kept a secret of the island. When they showed up on the island that day it did not disappoint.

T was amazed at the grace with which his friend could feel the tide and adjust accordingly, allowing the boat to drift into a certain position before setting it to idle there and casting one of two or three poles he kept at the ready, pulling up flounder the size of a serving dish one after another. He was feeling good. He was like a basketball player on a streak. He handed the pole off to T, lit a cigarette, and then said “Y’see that, over there?” knowing, of course, that they hadn’t; he’d barely seen it, but he was certain of what he’d seen: the cresting dorsal fin of a massive redfish had shown itself above the surface for a second, before making a small splash as it darted at some shrimp or mud minnow. “This is how it’s done,” he said, as if it were an every night occurrence for him, because he knew somehow that this really *was* how it was done, before he even flicked his wrist he knew the fish was his. The bat hit the water and not two seconds passed before his line started running so fast he wondered for a moment if it hadn’t been a small bonnet head, but he quickly tugged and set and knew what he was dealing with right away.

He called Izzy over and told her to grab his rod. When she giggled he felt heat run through his entire body. He couldn’t have recreated the exchange given another thousand opportunities. Guilt ran rampant in such a way a man can learn to enjoy. It had been nothing, the shared recognition of a freudian slip. If anything, he felt encouraged.

He couldn’t miss. He was in the mythical *zone* of which one does not act so much as they embody themselves. If he’d been playing golf it would have been the moment he hit his first hole in one. He wondered about T, for a moment, but couldn’t bring himself to look up. Besides, the red was still running and they needed to stop him before he managed to get the line tangled on an oyster bed. “Pull on it,” he demanded. “Keep the tip pointed up.” He reached around her waist and tightened the slack, just slightly. This was a big damn red, no question. It continued to jet out into the water with line until finally it gave a momentary pause. “Now!” He said, “start reeling that sonofabitch in.” She stared at him blankly, momentarily overwhelmed, perhaps she had some desire to see him act. Again he moved

behind her and put his hand over hers, it was small in his grip and he had to position his fingers delicately so as not to press against one of her digits in a way that hurt. He found just the right spot and took control, allowing her only to hold on. He heard her heavy breath in his ear and felt himself getting an erection. *Fuck. Fuck fuck fuck.*

So many potential futures were playing out in his mind that he didn't even hear T behind him, calling out that *he had one too ! Was he doing it right?* John focused on getting the red back to safe water, which he was able to do, and then said in the manliest voice he could conjure that he was going to let go now. "You take control from here. If he wants to run, let him. But keep the line taut and if he gives an inch you take as much as you can."

He saw now, what his mother had spoken about, half in awe, half jealous: her frightening beauty. The cut of her distinct, yet gentle features, against the pinks and purples of an endless sky just beyond the reeds, beyond the untouched natural preservatory across the water, beyond the year that would follow and the year after that, the horizon went on forever, it seemed, so long as there was always something to abstract it, to remind you that it wasn't real. *And when T went off to college? What then?*

[MORE TO GO—T: Thinks he has it caught something big, snaps the line pulling it from the water, ends up accidentally hitting John in the back....]

XVIII

This would become a recurring theme in his writings, growing more and more nuanced and complex as he found himself aged and by extension spending more time in the direct contact of the dark and disturbing .

This is what happens as we age: as if it were the natural course of things.

Or at least one reading of William Theodore Grayson might suggest so.

T said *Broken Horizon* was the Great American Novel. Norton, the Great American Novelist. But he never seemed to notice the ways in which he and Norton fundamentally differed. Whereas Norton was all head, and therefore saw the awakening to a new horizon of consciousness as a beautiful, if broken, path; T. Grayson, who was a representative of the consciousness of the heart in a way, saw the advancement through life not as an awakening, but a slow pruning of all the unnecessary growth that is forced upon us. Beauty was in the simplicity of refinement and sweeping away.

It is hard to describe the distinction without falling back to false dichotomies of Eastern and Western thought. The inherent flaw in doing so, confined as one must be by the very language at hand, is that the vocabulary of the West (the language, the schools of thought) does not contain the words or

concepts to explain away what has been learned. It is precisely this impossibility that is captured in the work of T. Grayson, and perhaps, one might posit the possibility of unlearning, a potential source from which the heart of his work springs—and taken seriously this would make W. T. Grayson the antithesis of Norton. And yet, they also seem to be two pieces of the same whole.

But there is much more to get to before we get to that.

XIX

Permanent by Fracture.

T was cut from a hard, dense rock—built to resist change in all its capacities, unable to accommodate even the slightest need for concession. He would always be, always: what he was and only that.

His way was to make demands of life—a collection of interrogative strategies, playing all roles: cross examiner and witness; the judge, the jury, the victim and always the accused, the innocent, the guilty; the sentenced and the pardoned.

This is, at least, what John saw in him as he began taking inventory of his new situation, and slowly, over time, found that he was beginning to spend his days in the presence of a new kind of individual. Someone who saw the world in a different way than anyone John had ever met before. Apart from Pappy, who was always tired since MeeMaw died, T was the only person who wanted to talk to John about the books he'd read. And with T, it turned out, John was something of a lightweight. T had read all of the books John had, and he'd read volumes of critiques and essays about them. He could draw comparisons between Dostoyevsky and Nietzsche and William Blake, elaborate on them in detail, and provide similes and metaphors, representations of ideas that John could not grasp, and present them in such a way that they not only became comprehensible, but beautiful and unique. His monologues (for John didn't dare venture into the realm of dialogue, not yet) were things that needed to be written down, John thought. And so, one day, John began keeping an account of the events going on around him, in real time, as it were—and it so happened that he chose an altogether critical time to begin writing these things down, because he soon realized that he was capturing much more than his own thoughts on his new friend—a story was unfolding before his very eyes that even he, as the author, could not shape or refine. He was merely a Watson, who was nothing to be scoffed at as far as John was concerned.

Watson was much more than a ledger, though Holmes often failed to realize the critical role Watson played. There was no Holmes without a Watson, though such a thing could never be said in front of either of them—both would deny it fervently.

John Roapes

12.1.2002

Last night I turned eighteen and when I woke this morning, for a moment, I wondered if it hadn't all been a dream. Then I opened my eyes, which was a mistake, and found the sunlight pouring into my room unbearable—I remembered, then, the events of the night prior with more specificity and clarity and looked around to find the remnants of my wanton destruction scattered about on the floor. It looked like a crime scene, as if someone had broken into my room and tossed it upside down looking for something of immense value. In a way, this was true - but I hadn't needed to break into my own house, and in a more sober state I would have been able to search the room without causing the destruction that lay before me.

I was embarrassed by what I saw and I scolded myself aloud, which was something I never did, I don't particularly like the sound of my own voice. But perhaps I needed to hear that my own voice was still there. I don't know, for some reason I cursed at myself, felt around and found a bent pack of Camel Lights in my breast pocket, cigarettes still functional. I lit one and asked myself, aloud, what the fuck was wrong with me.

A voice replied, for a moment I thought I'd lost it completely. This voice was also worse for the wear, glottal and scratchy, beat up. It responded, "Get over yourself, Roapes," and finally I saw T's feet, one sock on, one sock off, on the floor at the bottom of my bed, where the rest of him was hidden behind the footboard. He'd taken Rufus's bed. Rufus was a Basset and particularly fond of his bed – I saw him then, chest held high and regal if a bit stuffy (English Bassets, like Rufus, tend to carry themselves a bit more formally than their American counterparts). He was glaring at T, completely still, giving off the impression that he'd been sitting there and staring at him for hours, possibly the whole night.

I saw the empty bottle of Jim Beam resting horizontal and uncapped beside the no-longer-bedside table, also resting on its "x-axis" beneath the crown glass window that looks out over the property.

Many people believe crown glass looks the way it does because glass is a "superfluid" and over time it moves and swirls and causes the wavy texture that morphs the view outdoors. By and large this is not the reason why crown glass looks as though it has been slowly melting. While the waves generally do indicate that the glass is older than most glass windows you see today - the reason is that it came out looking that way as a result of a glass blowing process that we no longer use. We want our windows to be invisible today — Crown glass never looked like modern glass. It was born like that.

Personally I prefer the imperfection of the old windows in the Talking House. They turn the view of the southeastern part of our property, which the windows of my bedroom, and adjacent office look out on, into something like an impressionist painting, a small patch of wild indigo might be stretched and melded into the surrounding tall grass so that it becomes a representation of the land less than a concrete, static vista. Of course, either view still bests 99% percent of the office views I've ever seen - so I should count myself lucky and leave it at that.

Looking through that glass I sometimes forget what century it is, the vista it contains: still unmarred by anything man made as far as the eye can see. A kaleidoscopic blend of pastels and the bright colors of life, the indulgent blue of a Carolina sky meets the darker hues, whites and blues where sky becomes water, but through this glass one cannot tell.

The horizon is always changing. It is a matter of one's relative altitude, the curvature of the earth and some relatively simple *trigonometry*, at least I believe that's the term for it. Math never was my strong suit. But what this means to someone like myself— who depends on words to make sense of things that are born of the mathematical realm— is that the *location of the horizon* is a result of one's perspective.

I thought about this a moment, and in my bedraggled, nearly hallucinatory state I thought I was half brilliant. "T," I called out.

He responded sounding worse for the wear but T all the same—you could hear the thoughts rattling around in his head even as he spoke directly to you. T was always in two different places, psychologically speaking. Only one of them was open to public access. "What's on your mind?"

"The horizon," I said, "I'm sure this is a dumb question but ...well, okay the horizon is relative to my point of view or perspective. For example if I sit up I will see a different horizon than I see from here. And you and I will never see the horizon in the exact same way because it would require us to occupy the same exact space at the same exact time. In this sense it is *subjective*, no?"

"Or is the horizon *objective* because if I had the tools on hand, or could imagine having the tools on hand at a minimum, I know I could calculate the distance of the horizon to an almost perfect degree of accuracy?"

T didn't respond for almost thirty seconds, and I was excited because I couldn't think of a time I'd rendered T speechless before. Then another thirty seconds passed with still no answer and I became much less certain. I sat up and stretched as far forward as possible, and was able to see just over the edge of the footboard, T's head hung in an uncomfortable-looking position, and a bit of drool had started to collect in a slow growing unit only staying in place due to surface tension, from the edge of his bottom lip. It was certain to spill over soon by the looks of things. In other words, he'd woken up

briefly, or at least sat up and responded with outstanding somnambulistic vocal projection and fallen back asleep.

From high aloft in this grand old manor, I can see clear to the ocean, just a thin strip visible beyond the canopy of oaks, pines and occasional willow. It too contracts and expands

FORM: ENTROPY

John was chiseled from a soft stone, built to withstand a constant, low-grade pressure—but always retained the concern that he could be completely reshaped (or created in a new likeness) or destroyed in the event of true disaster. His was an asking sort of life, an unceasing wait for answers.

...and on the island there was a woman who was known for her age. The oldest woman on all of XX it was said, and likely all of the state, just as well if it were the whole country there was likely none older; once it was said she was the oldest woman in the entire world but she revolted at the idea and spat on the man who said it (he was a doctor and a man of faith) —her green phlegm dripped down the front of his white coat and he looked down at her and maintained composure despite wanting nothing more than to strangle her on the spot. *What makes you so certain you are not, in fact, the oldest living woman in the entirety of the world?* the doctor asked her, not impolitely but not without a trace of disgust in his voice. At first the old woman would not answer—she simply shook her head the way one does in response to the irreverence of the arrogant—and the doctor, who had traveled some distance to meet the old woman and had planned to write a study about his findings, realized with certainty that he would not get what he had come for, a vial of her blood, decided that his visit was over. He retrieved a small cloth from his breast pocket and wiped the woman's mucosa off the stomach of his doctor's coat, folding it up in such a way that the phlegm was in the middle of the cloth where it would remain until he could get it to his lab, and he put the cloth in a plastic bag he retrieved from his leather doctor's case (for he too seemed timeless— *a doctor who made house visits?* —not in the 90s); and perhaps it was something about the case that captured the old woman's attention, for she cleared her throat loudly and this time spat into the spittoon she kept beside her chair and then she said: *Young man, I awaited your visit for some time. When I realized the aim of your studies, your intentions, I should say—I knew then that I was not the oldest woman in the world. I was upset to discover such a thing and so I spat—*

please forgive my impertinence—it is tiring waiting so long. Now everyone in the room looked at her in anticipation—what did she mean? Though the doctor seemed to understand, because soon after he smiled, finished packing her bag, and told her not to worry, it would not be long. And as he walked out of the room, his leather doctor’s case trembling in his right hand, which itself was trembling quite terribly, the old woman called out to him: *I’m sorry. I’m sorry* —at which the doctor began to cry, increased the tempo of his gait, and disappeared through the doorway.

-

When John inquired as to the meaning of the story about the doctor and the old lady, T said it was not his story. There was not a hint of insincerity in his voice when he said, “It was the old lady who told it to me herself. And if I knew what it meant I wouldn’t have had to write it down. But I think it has something to do with where we are headed,” he said, and we continued to wait on the old widow’s walk. The clouds had begun to congregate in the distance like a far off herd of sheep. *It is tiring waiting so long.*

-

Today the duty is clear. How can it be so clear on days such as these and opaque on all of the others?

-

To look so long means to miss the sudden : from David Baker’s poem, “The Blue”, which opens (n.b. the title serves as its first line and thus is repeated here): *The blue// heron is gray, not blue, but great enough* — “How does one answer a question about time at all?” John asked so often that T took it upon himself to comprehend special relativity. He read all of the primary texts on the subject, then found the most frequently cited contemporary papers, cross-referenced bibliographies, and developed what could only be called a compendium of the complete readings in Theoretical Physics. He enrolled in a course at Wagner but had already read the entire syllabus, and finding himself still in want of an answer he dropped that course and enrolled in a Philosophy of Time course—taught by a member of the McTaggart bloodline. It sometimes seemed that every professor was a descendent of a well known academic—unfortunately it was also often the case the most interesting part of their course was when they told obscure anecdotes about their famous progenitors and the same could be said of his professor, the McTaggart descendant, who had discovered nothing that his Great-Great-Uncle had not conceived of some hundred years prior, at least so far as T could tell.

This was the state of things when he came home for summer break between his Junior and Senior year at Wagner and announced that Time was the fundamental question of existence. Or, no, rather—it was the fundamental question of conscious existence, the distinguishing feature, as it were, between what we can propose it means think and what we propose it means to act. And perhaps, he further stipulated, the semantics were wrong—because the proposition of meaning, of what something *really means* is an unnecessary complexity when trying to distill something to its fundamental truth value by way of language—which, he yielded, was already a shaky position from which to build a theory of the world: language as a foundation—but a necessary position, nonetheless, because the written word is the source of light by which we are able to see, however dimly, into the soul of another being. In other words:

without words we would have to be either exponentially more advanced or many magnitudes simpler to event attempt alternative communication methods ^[14] —so we must accept language as our core principles must stay— *this is where I say, he said, if you take issue with this position we unfortunately can go no further; I apologize for having wasted your time.*

Or in any event it was the gateway to the fundamental question - it was the question that, once answered, would open the door to fields of inquiry that were currently out of the realm of human comprehension.

You've stumped me , he said—and that was a bleak day.

-

[from *The Journals of William Theodore Grayson: Book 4* → '07 - '11]

I've learned of the 'Great Dispute' which pitted brother against brother and have been unable to forget the matter since. Henry was a veteran of the US Army, not by choice but by necessity. His father, Pappy, out of fear or concern or resentment I do not know, executed an amendment to the trust that would remove either son, should they fail to maintain a standard of behavior befitting the Roapes family name. The vague language served its purpose when Henry Roapes was determined to have struck his mother in violence, at the shy age of seventeen, for a purpose that remains undisclosed to this day. There was a clause to this amendment, because Pappy was a man with a deep belief in redemption as well as a man who felt immeasurable pride in his country (he also, notably, bore a guilt at having been too old to enlist during Vietnam—and this guilt was magnified by the death of his brother at the hands of the Viet Cong, after spending ten months as a POW in unimaginable conditions) —the clause stated that either son would be 'forgiven their trespasses' by enlisting in any branch of the US Military and serving no less than five years. Henry kissed his son on his forehead when he left for Desert Storm in early 1990. When he returned half-deaf, with two purple hearts and a violent tilt in the way he held his head, his father promptly added him to the trust, despite the fact that he was medically discharged before meeting the five years of mandated service.

Pappy had successfully absorbed his son's guilt - and now knew, at least, that he would have to carry the guilt as well. A masochistic form of solidarity that fostered resentment rather than enabling forgiveness. The backwards language spoken between a father and his firstborn son. Each digging a hole for the other until one day they look up and realize they won't be free again.

When his time came James took steps to avoid the draft. He did not dodge so much as he keenly evaded. He went to Vanderbilt, where the Roapes had a legacy of honored graduates. He was in all ways a man of the intellect, but he also felt a deep seated certainty that war, for him, might as well be a guarantee of death or imprisonment.

To Henry he was a traitor, a turncoat, a threat. He disowned him in a way that only an older sibling can.

With Pappy it was more complex. He had, as is common practice, made every mistake possible in raising his first son, but perhaps he never felt so comprehensively a failure until the time came to provide words of guidance for his second son and he found himself devoid of ideas. He stood nowhere on the subject — or perhaps more accurately, he wanted to have a little bit of everything and so he ended up providing nothing.

Whereas Henry had to work so hard to destroy his father, James had to do nothing more than ask for advice and watch as the man shrunk in fear. There was no true North, he felt at the time—he was ill-suited for the task that had been set before him. He could never love James the way he loved Henry—that was the truth—and there was nothing that he could do about it.

It was Deborah, then, who sat at the head of that table. Pappy knew, when all was said and done, he'd become a weak man.

That was then.

One night, Sunday dinner brought all of them round the table. John, who was by then nine years old, remembers watching his father and his uncle become ravenous and bloodthirsty. He remembers finding a tooth on the floor, where he had hidden himself beneath the table when the fireworks began. He remembered thinking that, for a pacifist, his uncle had shown a clear aptitude for violence.

Anyone who goes to war for the US Government , he'd said, *returns a war criminal* .

And that was all it took. In sequence, he heard his father grunt with exertion, a rapid clatter of footsteps as the brothers went one way and MeeMaw made for the garage, the sound of old wood splintering, old wood clattered, at least two glasses shattered, his mother's instinctual gasp, a rushed reprimand shouted from a covered position, pathetic; his father's grunt followed immediately by a similar, but undeniably distinct *humph* —this, he recognized as traded blows, an uneven exchange—then a few moments of deliberation or perhaps preparatory movements... *fuckingillyou* his father's voice muttered between labored breaths, a scuffle, then a misstep or mistake made by Uncle James after which a quick howl preceded an extended *A-A-A-RHH -OW* and the surprisingly loud *POP* of a shoulder, later discovered to have been over extended in its duties and released from the socket forthwith. My father repeated the word *bitch* several times with colorful variations. James moaned in pain, hollered once more as my father kicked his ass, quite literally, with a steel toed work boot before spitting with intention and audible velocity; the same three or four profanities. His younger brother whimpered and cried.

John and his mother were huddled in the kitchen, hidden behind the island bar. Meemaw came running in from the garage with a Louisville slugger just in time to hear my father close the front door behind him—soon gravel would fly as his tires fought for traction.

John's mother stopped him from reentering the dining area until she had seen the damage—and having seen it, she turned and decided they would exit through the garage door. They heard Pappy stand and walk to his youngest son, asking him diagnostic questions about his injuries—MeeMaw began to say something to him, but the look that Pappy gave somehow provided the only response she needed (though much later he would realize that she had stopped in shock, not satisfaction; she'd never seen her husband's tears before).

Epistolary

Dear *****,

You do not know who I am, though were you to see my face, and perhaps as you read through this letter and pick up on certain stylistic tools, recurring motifs, my *abuse of punctuation*, as I believe you once called it—I am confident you will quickly deduce who I am (if you have not been preparing for this letter to arrive for a long time already—this remains a mystery to me). I can only assume this particular turn of phrase—“abuse of punctuation”—was a stock phrase of yours, given the number of students you had under your tutelage, the number of aspiring writers you broke and broke again like wild stangs so that they might follow the same rules as the rest of the herd. The masses of modern, domesticated *Lemus Lemus*.

I cannot say I fully fault you for the decision you made to quit teaching, though it was mid-semester—*my semester*, and I was certain that had you seen more than that one, anxiously composed, short story—certainly if you had seen something else you would have noticed that there was something unique going on. Initially, I was too nervous to write the first piece, admittedly, for some reasons that are obvious and for others that you will come to better understand by reading this letter.

I don't consider that piece to be one of my better stories. Frankly, the content of the piece is only saved by the sheer necessity from which it was born, which is to say, what is of quality in that story is not the writing, but the very heart of the text which beats in the same way my own heart did as I sat down to write it (of course this is only in my humble opinion—I should append this to every sentence I write but to spare time and paper will only add it as a parenthetical here and let you infer the rest).

My heart beat furiously as I wrote that story. Twenty six and a half single-spaced pages, in a Palatino font I found acceptable and size-11 font, because I share your proclivity for the oddity of life and that extends to numerology as you once mentioned it does in your own life as well. I will not settle for an

even number no matter what the circumstance: the volume of the television, the amount of gas I put in my car - I go up to the attendant and I say, “Nine dollars on pump three,” for example, and hand them a ten dollar bill and without fail the attendant replies with a voice that sounds as though it has to travel through thicket and bramble just to exit the body, the attendant always replies by asking me what I’d like to do with the extra dollar, already on the move towards the scratch-offs, as though it were insane that I should only want to put nine dollars of gas in my vehicle when I’m in possession of a ten dollar bill.

If you could only see their face when I tell them, “I’d like to put it back in my wallet.” A look of revulsion unlike anything you’ve ever seen, unlike anything you can imagine. Though, on second thought, I bet you CAN imagine it. I bet you’ve been in my exact same position given what I’ve heard about your own compulsive behavior. At least it wouldn’t surprise me in the least if you did. I believe we may share more in common you might think at the moment, Mr. Norton, a good deal more. And that’s why I’m writing to you — furthermore, I hope you will forgive the length of my initial letter, as there is a good deal to tell and I have no interest in doing it in installments. Though of course, you will only be able to read it as your time allows—and I will try to break the letter that follows into bite-sized subsections for a busy man like yourself—miniature chapters, if you will, so that the following does not seem such a daunting task.

All that being said, part of me is very excited to tell you what I have come to believe with the utmost certainty to be true—but there is another voice in my head (of course, for every point there must be a counterpoint—there can be no donut without the donut *hole* [\[15\]](#) [\[16\]](#)) that speaks to me in a tone of patriarchal condescension, not that I would know what that sounds like, but I suppose it speaks to me in the tone I would imagine represents patriarchal condescension and it tells me, condescendingly, that I am an idiot for writing this—and furthermore, that if I send it to you, I am an even bigger idiot, and that in all likelihood you won’t make it far enough into what I’ve written, because I tend to meander when I write (though I am mostly silent when given the option to speak), and you are a busy man and I haven’t put the point of the letter right up front.

That was one of your lessons. *People should give a book fifty pages before they quit, most of them give a book about fifty words, at a time, so your first fifty need to be good and your next fifty need to be better and if you do that, in a row, for long enough, eventually they might trust you enough that you can take a breather and write something that takes more than fifty words to say.* Then you said: *If you are writing so that people will read your books, do not become a writer at all.*

Well here I am, and I’m hoping you’ve read this far and you’re willing to keep going. But that’s the end of my introduction. No big reveal yet. Skip ahead if you’d like, but you’ll need to come back and read it all anyways, and I’ve structured it the way I have intentionally, so my hope is that you’ll trust me and keep on moving forward, paragraph by paragraph, and I promise we will get there.

[Interlude]

There is something sadistic about the practice of forcing an artist to put their least refined writing on display. It is like asking a man who is ashamed of the size or shape of his genitals to display them, fresh out of a cold shower, and then ask the most beautiful woman he can imagine to point out some positive qualities, but mostly just to pick it apart for flaws. I could imagine in either scenario the same thing being said, “It’s like there is nothing there.”

I can feel the gut churning nausea even today to this day; It was horrifying. Though there remains a part of me that would like to write the story again, well this time, and see what would happen if I gave the story what it deserved—because, like you said, there is very little that does not demand our close attention and consideration. Almost know bad art is due to the topic or plot; this is something I tend to believe

It was the one about the boy with divorced parents who is told by the courts that he will have to “split time” as they call it, between mom and dad

Part ∞

←

When asked about his childhood, John would never respond with the truth.

This ran counter to his nature, which was to be honest in all capacities. To lie was to stray from his nature, except in this case, in this scenario— when he was asked about his childhood it came preternaturally to him to tell stories that he did not remember.

In his journals he tried long and hard to articulate the reasons why he would deviate from his nature in this way, from that which was natural. It was his firm belief that deception was the mortal wound from which mankind suffered and would one day perish. And his lies made him complicit.

His grandfather had taught him of the Liar’s Paradox when he was young.

The Cretan philosopher Epimenedes (6th Century BCE): “All Cretans are liars.”

Nearly three millenia went by before John was served the paradox by his grandfather. Admittedly symbolic logic was not his strong suit, but he reflexively understood what was off with this particular problem.

It broke down somewhere in the land of semiotics, intention and perspective.

In John’s opinion one did not need a postgraduate degree in set theory to understand that the issue at the core of the paradox was in how the terms were defined; how those terms, however they might be defined, would be used to formulate a statement, or utterance, that was considered logically and syntactically aligned with the rules of the language—English, in his case—and was then, if logically and syntactically sound, assigned a truth value (there are more truth values than right and wrong—this is apparent when comic book levels of critical thought are applied to ethics, vis-a-vis Batman) when its very foundations were rooted in the subjective realm of language. The way to break this paradox was simply to respond with further questions regarding the meaning of a word (really any word works) and continue to ask, *But why?*, like an insolent child, to responses that will grow increasingly vague and subjective until the answer is “Because...that’s how language works,” at which point, any response to the question: *But why?*, is pure theory, and the machine stops churning altogether.

John was humble and intelligent enough to understand that an academic philosopher would have a number of responses to this line of thinking, but he also understood that a truly sufficient response to this concern would eliminate the paradox in the first place—he imagined it as the self sustaining energy source at the core of philosophy, built of infinitely smaller and more intricate parts like an image that you can continue to zoom in on, finding another image that you can zoom in on in which another painting sits, and so on and so on. For some time afterwards he decided he would become a philosopher if only because he wanted to take part in that discussion.

In a way this revelation (if it could be called such a thing) became a weight he had to bear. The cross one carries without the crutch of religion to sublimate the shortcomings of our own humanity. Sitting on a wobbly barstool in the corner of every room, listening in to every conversation, there was a little Cretan, much more diabolical in his imagination than Epimenedes deserved. *But why?* he muttered again and again .

As it turns out the truth is a devious thing—John did not *remember* this conversation with his grandfather, not really. He did not remember his childhood at all prior to the torrential storm that arrived in near-simultaneity with T and Izzy, Izzy and T, on November 27th, 1996—and as of late the absence of real, concrete memories had begun to disturb him. But that was all moments from changing.

1996: The year after Mee-Maw; The Year of the Great Cloud; The Year the Graysons arrived on XX.

The Year in which, for all intents and purposes, John Roapes life was reified and given to him as a gift, “Here, you now own your life. No refunds, returns or exchanges. No one cares if you don’t want it anymore. You’ve got it now. It’s illegal, in fact, to try to get rid of it. Yeah. As a matter of fact you have to try to keep it alive a real long time. Make sure it’s clean, by the by. Lucky for you, says here you’re decent looking. Should make things easier for you so long as you’ve got a...” **turns imaginary sheet in imaginary imaginary dossier** “...welp, anyways you’re decent looking and smart. Two out of three aint bad...not bad at all.” **imaginarily fades away. nothing is imaginary anymore. life is a thing he owns. it’s like being born, he thinks. He thinks some more, and a bit more. He’s here now. And there’s a whole life in his hands.

Were he an artificial being, it would be like the year he was turned on—what preceded November 27th no more than a backstory. He remembered, suddenly, and without explanation. November 27th, a storm chiseled into the very stone of his existence.

He had not a single recollection of *anything* prior to the arrival of Izzy and T, which might have made sense if he’d been four or five when they arrived, but at the age of twelve it was puzzling.

In fact, it was their arrival and the occasionally imprinted memories that began to collect like fallen leaves in the days and weeks and months that followed, those small but clear insights into the past that allowed him to understand that fundamental function had been *broken* inside him for so long. Until then, his mind had somehow created its own form of an oral tradition, in which he would tell the story of an event that happened, remembering not the actual feelings, sights and sounds of a given event; only remembering the way he had described the event to himself, almost as a fiction. He remembers stories of his childhood with the consistency of a written document, that he then retells, passing on to himself the details and feelings that one would expect of a genuine memory. Lacking something—something quite essential but without a name.

Of course, none of this was obvious to him, how memory worked (or didn’t work) until the days and weeks that followed the arrival of the Graysons.

At least that’s how he remembered it.

✧

It had not struck Izzy, that she was restarting her entire life, until she began to see the signs of life around her, completely foreign but for her William, who was foreign too in his own way, and then realized that there was some expectation of her to participate in the world that she had chosen as the place for her rebirth.

Beatrice had lived in her mind as a young maternal presence, that was the memory she had sculpted from their time together in Wagner. Beatrice had neither been aware of the pseudo-imprinting she'd committed by saving Izzy one night, escorting her out of a party where she didn't belong only to find she had nowhere to go, and bringing her back to her own apartment—a penthouse in the newest residential apartment building in the whole of Wagner. Structurally absurd, the building looked as if it might fall over at any minute; it was as though each floor had been added on independently, facing a slightly different direction, a thirteen-story, scoliosis-ridden spine that popped out of the ground, writhing around like some sort of land-dwelling sea beast—an apartment that wouldn't have been remotely affordable on a professor's salary, Bea was aware. It was the third tallest building in the area, which gave the penthouse unrestricted views in almost every direction. That night Izzy had indulged in the drug of choice at Wagner parties, cocaine, and she could not keep herself from telling Bea every thought that crossed her mind.

Initially, Bea found it infuriating, this child so thoroughly attempting to be one of the students, particularly when she wore no bra (not as a political statement, but because she never had before) and her breasts were larger, and almost perfectly round, compared to Bea who had skipped that stage, somehow. Bea's breasts had arrived small, like they had been taped down, and already at twenty one she was being shown up by youth with perkier breasts. Women were busy burning bras while Bea was utilizing bras to emphasize what little there was for her to work with in the first place.

Despite that though, Bea couldn't help but note that Izzy's intelligence was astonishing, and eventually it started to make her sad, or perhaps angry, at Izzy's parents or guardians. And the more she asked about her past the more and more moved she became by the child's story.

Izzy had been devastated beyond comprehension when Bea had left, to “go home” she'd said. Izzy couldn't understand how her home could not be in Wagner, after having spent so much time there, having built friendships and planted seeds that were only now beginning to flower, bear fruit. And she had promised to stay another year. Bea had yet to graduate, but she came back from Summer break nervous, and it was a matter of a month and a half before she had met Izzy privately to tell her she would be “going home”. Izzy was far too mad to notice her genuine tears, or to notice the small protrusion near her bellybutton that would become John's stillborn older brother, Henry Jr., who was buried less than a year later in a pine box beside The Heart Tree.

For Izzy none of this was real or known, one day she was there and the next she was not.



Christmas Eve, 1996 - The Grayson's had been living in the small house that had been *loaned* to them, free of charge, for reasons that were never discussed in public, and rarely in private, for almost a month.

Still, apart from the first night, which had been so full of promise—the massive storm, the excitement and novelty of companionship, the long discursive conversations about what life had been like in Iowa and what might be expected of XX—the boys had not yet spent enough time with each other to feel comfortable in the other’s company. There was a vague sense of suspicion on John’s behalf, he saw none of the grateful gestures that someone who had received something for nothing was expected to display. He was not suspicious of the lack of decorum, in fact that, if anything, made him envious. But he was suspicious of himself—his every move seemed to be driven by a desire to build this new relationship.

John was also suspicious of Izzy, who had been the sole character in his increasingly frequent fantasies and marathon masturbation sessions. She was too young to be his mother’s friend but she was T’s mother, which made her old enough to be his own mother. She was sexually desirable in a way that filled him with images and ideas that were completely out of the realm of possibility, but did not feel entirely true either. He felt at once as though he were a child and an adult. On both the top and the bottom of the world, respectively.



Large swaths of XX are nothing but swampland. Trees of all varieties as well as large bushes are scattered about the swampland in an economic way. Each tree and bush seems to have the necessary amount of surrounding space to grow to full size unimpeded—one gets the impression they had the area plotted out and carefully measured before deciding where to grow. And though at face value this idea sounds absurd - and in reality, of course, it is impossible, the fact of the matter is it is no coincidence the way they grow as though in collaboration with one another.

Trees, apparently can communicate—not in the same way as you or I intend when we communicate (at least, not knowingly, because we do communicate in so many non-verbal, unintentional ways, that we fail to recognise them explicitly— usually this is because it is something that pervades our everyday (like the greenery in the swamps, or how fascinating it is that the human race drives around in tiny fuel filled bombs at speeds our body cannot travel on it’s high speeds without second thought, despite the fact that only heart disease and cancer are the only two more common causes of death in the United States [\[17\]](#) ”)).

Trees release something like a pheromone through a kind of fungus—particularly old forests have been able to share this information, cross-species, a fact that sounds as unbelievable as it is true.

Evolutionarily this has allowed trees to optimize their territory where available, growing root structures that occupy what is necessary and passing critical enzymes through the soil, because they have “received” a message via the enzymes of other trees that are in need of “support”. Entire forests that operate with a sort of hive mind, distributing resources in a selfless and utilitarian fashion in a way that the virus of consciousness, or the human A.S.S. (Anti-Selflessness Syndrome), simply does not allow. There are myriad books dedicated to the topic of trees and the epigean conversations that we are

witnessing when we walk through Yellowstone or hike the Appalachian Trail. Recently, scientists have found substantial evidence to support the idea that there is even a “Mother Tree”.

Does this not conjure the image of a forest of trees bowing at once while the singular reification of *Mother Nature* stands tall, humbly accepting their gratitude, thinking—no, not thinking, but exuding the sentiment...

Oh my, how I and You and We have grown!

...While in the background the reverent trees hum in a tone inaccessible to the human ear. The mother tree delegates, redistributes, oversees the network.

This is the way the world works.

On XX it seemed obvious that everything green was somehow unified. This was before any of the science explaining the subterranean fungal communication and yet it was known, and had been known, since long before T arrived.

T, though, seemed to hear it. Of course he couldn't have heard it—there are limits to what even the most free-spirited, open-minded reader is willing to believe. But if you were there, if you knew him, it would be hard to deny that he *seemed* to hear it. That he reacted to it as if he were a part of the system himself.



Henry Roapes was a vile man. When he was a child, even, Percival remembered the way he was always ill at ease if the boy had been gone too long, and the number of times his concern had been justified by the heavy knock at the door of one or another of the men on the island, Henry held by the arm, red faced with clenched teeth, a raw riverbed of dried tears in the crevasses where they ran. He liked knives—by the time he was seven Percival caught him exsanguinating a squirrel he'd managed to knock unconscious, but failed to kill, with a beebee gun. Percival entered the empty shed at exactly the moment the arterial spray hissed from the little rodent's severed neck, covering his son's face in a single violent spurt that made him cackle with laughter. His father remembered the red blood against the whiteness of his front tooth, the first one to have grown in, a permanent tooth. It bothered him that it had coincided with the arrival of his tooth in such a way. Some sort of a bad omen. Some sort of a sign.

Until that day he'd raised Henry with a switch just the same as he'd been raised himself—but he got no enjoyment out of it the way his own father had and he lacked the constitution to hit a child with the force required to make it hurt. He'd never understood where it came from in his own father. But as he looked down upon his blood drenched son, smiling like a lunatic as the squirrel's body convulsed once

more, causing it to fall from the counter to the floor, he briefly saw his fathers small, pellet-like eyes, and he knew then that the child was no good. A switch wasn't any use, that was for certain.

Then it was the Fulcher's chicken a year or so later. And his girlfriend's dog in high school, though they didn't catch him for that.

Percival Roapes knew his son was sick when he was still in his mother's womb, he would later admit only after she had passed away. He dared not say a word to his wife, knowing, with certainty, that it would kill her to know what he felt when he put his hand upon her swollen stomach. Or perhaps, that she would kill him.

As a result, when John first came into the world Percival worried a great deal for his grandson. He worried for Beatrice too—who had seen what she had done by marrying the elder son, but not until it was too late. By then she was too deep into motherhood, and too isolated from the world outside of XX, beyond the limits of the XX connector the world had moved on and she would never again gain the speed required to merge into all of that traffic, all of that chaos. And when things were okay she didn't want to, there were days when she saw him smile and it was genuine and things seemed possible (even if she knew, and you always know somewhere deep inside, that her husband wasn't living right—and some part of him had it out for their son, but how do you say something like that?).

She'd evaluated her choices at some point and realized that she'd better play with the hand she was dealt if she wanted to stay in the game. Henry, once, when voicing one of his many spousal complaints, told her it was like *she folded her hand before she got to see the flop, life-wise, that was* — which unbeknownst to him was a more apt reference than he might have imagined.

She spoke to Percival one night, after Sunday dinner.

She cleared the table, while Percival, Pappy by then, was the only person who remained. Henry had left to go down to the pub, like Henry, or smoke cigarettes, like James, or run off to the library to pick a book to leaf through, as William was wont to do. Mee-maw was taking a bath - she took one every night. Pappy was waiting for Bea to tell him what he knew she needed to say.



Henry Roapes was a vile man. When he was a child, even, Percival remembered the way he was always ill at ease if the boy had been gone too long, and the number of times his concern had been justified by the heavy knock at the door of one or another of the men on the island, Henry held by the arm, red faced with clenched teeth, a raw riverbed of dried tears in the crevasses where they ran. He liked knives—by the time he was seven Percival caught him exsanguinating a squirrel he'd managed to knock unconscious, but failed to kill, with a beebee gun. Percival entered the empty shed at exactly the

moment the arterial spray hissed from the little rodent's severed neck, covering his son's face in a single violent spurt that made him cackle with laughter. His father remembered the red blood against the whiteness of his front tooth, the first one to have grown in, a permanent tooth. It bothered him that it had coincided with the arrival of his tooth in such a way. Some sort of a bad omen. Some sort of a sign.

Until that day he'd raised Henry with a switch just the same as he'd been raised himself—but he got no enjoyment out of it the way his own father had and he lacked the constitution to hit a child with the force required to make it hurt. He'd never understood where it came from in his own father. But as he looked down upon his blood drenched son, smiling like a lunatic as the squirrel's body convulsed once more, causing it to fall from the counter to the floor, he briefly saw his father's small, pellet-like eyes, and he knew then that the child was no good. A switch wasn't any use, that was for certain.

Then it was the Fulcher's chicken a year or so later. And his girlfriend's dog in high school, though they didn't catch him for that.

Percival Roapes knew his son was sick when he was still in his mother's womb, he would later admit only after she had passed away. He dared not say a word to his wife, knowing, with certainty, that it would kill her to know what he felt when he put his hand upon her swollen stomach. Or perhaps, that she would kill him.

As a result, when John first came into the world Percival worried a great deal for his grandson. He worried for Beatrice too—who had seen what she had done by marrying the elder son, but not until it was too late. By then she was too deep into motherhood, and too isolated from the world outside of XX, beyond the limits of the XX connector the world had moved on and she would never again gain the speed required to merge into all of that traffic, all of that chaos. And when things were okay she didn't want to, there were days when she saw him smile and it was genuine and things seemed possible (even if she knew, and you always know somewhere deep inside, that her husband wasn't living right—and some part of him had it out for their son, but how do you say something like that?).

She'd evaluated her choices at some point and realized that she'd better play with the hand she was dealt if she wanted to stay in the game. Henry, once, when voicing one of his many spousal complaints, told her it was like *she folded her hand before she got to see the flop, life-wise, that was* — which unbeknownst to him was a more apt reference than he might have imagined.

She spoke to Percival one night, after Sunday dinner.

She cleared the table, while Percival, Pappy by then, was the only person who remained. Henry had left to go down to the pub, like Henry, or smoke cigarettes, like James, or run off to the library to pick a book to leaf through, as William was wont to do. Mee-maw was taking a bath - she took one every night. Pappy was waiting for Bea to tell him what he knew she needed to say.

INTERLUDE

Of William

(or, Life as a Close Reading: An Assorted History of William Theodore Tipnam the Third, Grayson Island and Its Inhabitants, The Bridge to Nowhere, and Some Thoughts and Remarks on the Nature of Reality, Humanity, Existence and Consciousness with regard to the Concepts of the Absurd, Sublime and Transcendental)

Selected Epigraphs (From “The Collected Notebooks Vols. 4-7: The Words of Others”)

“How many horrible and beautiful things!”

- Honoré de Balzac, *Facino Cane*

“Living life falsely and in dreams is still living life.”

- Fernando Pessoa, *The Book of Disquiet* , Entry 49

“He intended nothing at all because he wrote the way a child pees against a tree, in order to relieve himself.”

- Witold Gombrowicz, *Diary: Volume 1* , pg. 70

A Thinkpiece

In a *thinkpiece* about William, published just last week, aptly titled “Thinking Of William”, the well-intentioned but misguided author wrote that I was his *best friend* . I had been interviewed on the anniversary of his death by a young woman from a literary magazine out of New York with a name like *Paper* , or *Slant* , or *Breaks* , that I had, unsurprisingly, never heard of, but that nonetheless is apparently of some renown in *those circles* , circles of literary merit where young authors publish their early works before breaking onto the scene with a book that is immediately crowned the new *Great American Novel* , despite the same claim having been made just weeks prior about some other young author’s fresh anti-postmodern critique of late-stage capitalism, small circles where the idea of literary fame still exists in the mind of some, circles which have come to revere the late William Theodore Tipnam the Third since his death, but, I presume, would most certainly have eviscerated him in those very same magazines and *journals* had his work found a following while he was still alive, complicating the mystery of his posthumous fame. This may, of course, to the critical reader imply that I am suggesting his work is revered in these circles (but in many others too) *because* he died, which is not my intention, I should clarify, rather I mean to posit that the reception of his work among *literary circles* has been given an appropriate amount of consideration and thought (and in turn appreciation) which it might not have been given if discovered while he was still around to be looked at – spoken to. It does not bother me much, but still I have found myself thinking about it since my copy of the journal

arrived – no it doesn't bother me much, but it must bother me some, I presume, that when she, the writer of the *thinkpiece*, asked me for my thoughts, via a hastily written email that was chock full of typos, which I imagine was sent after the piece was already in its final form, despite her telling me it was in the final round of edits prior to publication – when I told her it was a silly thing to say, that I was his *best friend*, because William could not have a best friend anymore than a man can domesticate a rattlesnake, which is to say the idea itself is foolish and displays a fundamental misunderstanding of the very subject of its conjecture.

I knew a man who tried to keep a pet rattler. William knew him too. And when we learned of his death neither of us were surprised, of course, because in a rattler's world there is no such concept as *domestication*, regardless of whatever thoughts there were to the contrary in the mind of the man who kept the rattler (he named it *Morricone*), and the same could be said for William, who had been labeled as *autistic* after he died, by a bunch of clinicians and psychiatrists who'd never so much as spent a moment in the man's presence, because of his preference for the company of non-human animals to those of the human variety, and his obsession with lists of things (he even kept lists of lists and had an entire bookshelf full of notebooks titled "Lists - #[X]" that went as high as "Lists - #33" and were written in a script that was so patient, perfect and legible that his estate is currently in talks with a large and well known Creative Agency about creating a WTT3 font) – he has been filed away as an autistic genius because of these and many, many other traits that at a minimum one would describe as unconventional, and in some cases mad, and would not be outright wrong.

But I suppose this is all why I felt compelled to sit down and write this all out. Not to catch a ride on his death-induced glorification train, but because the man deserves more than the caricature that has been drawn of him, lovingly as it has been, because WTT3, was much more than a font, much too unreal to have a simple man like me as his *best friend*, and much too complex to be diagnosed by a term like autism (or even genius, or enigma). So I aim to do what I've done for most of my adult life, explain him to you – though without a doubt I will fail as I have so many times already – it would be a disservice not to try yet again. And again, and again if needed. Because while I may not have been his best friend, I remain nourished by the fact that he was mine.

The Great Continuum

I have also chosen to put this all down for a simple reason – to cleanse the past, put truth to paper – as William so often said he planned to do with his next book, but always seemed to find a way to avoid. As obscure, and unappreciated his work was while he was alive, it always seemed as if William, himself, was aware of the path that his career would take, which is to say he took great pains to prepare his manuscripts as though they would, one day, be critiqued by as cold, particularly harsh and omniscient judge; word by word, by critics of the ilk that only praised genius that came pre-approved by a Federal Administration of one sort or another. But it is hard to recall a time gone by, without the

stain of what has happened since obscuring the original beneath. It is in the nature or of *The Great Mind* that its modern appeal (of the now) is inversely proportional to its universal value (of the forever) - which is to say it is universally true that greatness is better understood from a distance, a remove, and the immediate observations of greatness are *always* defined by a certain lack of perspective, because, as it were, most find it is neither *now*, nor *forever*, at any given moment. *Now* has just passed, *forever* runs from us at the speed of life, and so we exist in the liminal state of *waiting* for what is about to happen, no matter how many books on mindfulness one consumes - the present state is always at a remove of at least one heartbeat, or in some cases, of its absence. Metaphysical debates rage about the nature of time as it were. Presentism - the idea that there is nothing but the present - is perhaps the most innately sensible position, but far from being the most common position held by the physicists and quantum theorists - *Presentism* sits so low on the totem pole as to be considered laughable as a position. It is one of many instances in which those ideas derived from human perception, those ideas deemed commonsensical, are more or less considered hogwash by the academics and experts who study and report on their findings. In this case, however, one has to wonder if it is not, to some degree, that most of mankind simply doesn't want to know, and when they end up finding themselves with evidence that contradicts the relative safety of their platitude rich lives, said evidence can usually be found hidden deep in their personal sanatorium of ideas, veagrants, and other things better left forgotten.

William was not a physicist, but had the brain of a polymath and was able to understand that something was afoot, without knowing precisely what, almost intrinsically. He was obsessed, from an early age, before I knew him - with taking apart watches—[UF]

From the “Unpublished Notebooks of William Theodore Tipnam III” (November 14, 2000):

There is a great continuum on which every story ever uttered, thought, whispered, imagined or reviled exists. From ‘Moby Dick’ to ‘Declaration of Independence’, from the fib you told your mother about your father’s whereabouts that evening years ago, to the truth you told her later, with both relief and regret, which still rang false to a mother’s ears - the way you bit on your lower lip as you spoke it, how the natural topography of your face drained the tears from the corner of your eyes to the corners of your lips as though the path had been engineered to recycle your own sadness. No story is absolute in one direction or the other, no utterance, no theory, no so-called fact. No. Not one.

There is, on one side, full and infinite truth (which must include all of its dependencies and assumptions, evidence and corroboration, and even must be composed of its multitudinous lies), and on the other side there is the negation of truth, which is not a lie but something more sinister: the conscious and intentional dissolution of truth; not just its absence, but the guttural, vile oblivion which fills that space. Another form of dark matter, as it were, all around us. We never escape its reach, the invisible language of everything that isn't, never shall be, and yet, is the foundational building block of everything that is. The Antithesis of Borges' imagined Library of Babel. Or, paradoxically, a redacted Library of Babel where everything ever said has been removed.

What then, is left?

This is the answer I'm looking for.

A New Gold Standard

It is said, in some circles, that William detested people. This is not the truth by any means, but it certainly isn't a claim drawn from nowhere. He had his hermitage and his generally unpleasant manner when asked to uphold any sort of formal or informal tradition in the name of courtesy (a position he departed from, later in life, but by then there wasn't enough time left to finish his final work, let alone change his reputation). No, William cared for other people, his bigger concern, I believe, was that they didn't care for themselves. *The GOLDEN RULE*, he would say, *is not so golden if you ask me - unless it is the gold of Midas. Really, now, think about it - treat everyone the way you would like to be treated*—then he would pick one of the poor souls who had chosen to come sit with him that afternoon, one of a small group of young aspiring artists who had invented their own movement (but of course) and inducted William into it (as their leader) without so much as running the idea past him — they called themselves *Post-Illusionists*, I want to say, and though William despised the naive idealism of the name, he loved the adoration, I could tell— *If everyone followed the Golden Rule, which, it seems to me, they might, they'd all be hurting one another, which it seems to me they are, because at the bottom of a man's soul isn't the wish to be treated kindly, with love and respect - but to be spat upon, the inherent masochist, the martyr, and still, then, come out on top. That is why the Golden Rule is a broken rule, and needs a new revision.*

It likely need not be stated that the *Post-Illusionists* subsequently took this as their mission statement, and driving pursuit, the creation of a functional replacement for the Golden Rule that starts from tabula rasa - which is to say, fundamental rule from which all other rules might flow - derivative of nothing, ideologically isolate, unquestionable, outside of logic - something so innate it, once discovered, would cause all of humanity to forget that there was a time in which it did not exist, as if humankind collectively woke from a bad dream with no beginning and no end, a new and final state of

enlightenment. “ *A noble pursuit, best left to Sancho Panza and Don Quixote* ,” William was once quoted to have said - though, as always, the author left out the critical qualification: that it would be best left to DQ and SP would be a nobler and truer one than what he have been whittled down to. But, no, no, I don’t know that William ever really meant that to be a philosophy he became associated with, I think it more or less grew on him, just a small piece, like one barnacle of hundreds that lined the underside of the great Whale’s belly. And I can state irrefutably that he thought no more or less of any of the barnacles that spackled his great mammalian body. Take it or leave it, you could say, was his perspective on just about everything in life. Everything, that is, except for his art - which William once said, was a truer representation of the individual than the individual himself.

A load of shit, I told him later.

He laughed gently and said, “Course you’re right about that. But I meant it all the same.”

The Post-Illusionists

“When the Illusion becomes the Reality, Reality no longer is an Illusion.

Meetings held at Charlie’s **P**arty **U**nification **B**ackoffice on Tuesdays, Wednesdays, and Thursdays (and occasionally Fridays and Saturdays, by will of Bacchus). Consult your local somnambulist for directions. Invitation required, available by request at the door.”

- From The Post Illusionist Spring ‘95

Among William’s collected belongings were original prints of the first fifteen issues of “ *The Post Illusionist* ” While the earlier issues, the first year and a half or so of the quarterly ‘Zine , have all the tell tale signs of the underground, quasi-punk, intellectual aesthetic that the group so desperately identified with while it was young, as the publication began to gain some local attention, there is a maturation process that occurs that William writes about in one of his books, “ *and only then one begins to see the tell-tale signs of decay in the ‘progression toward professionalism’, can even catch a whiff of its manicured output (rank as cockroach bile and more diseased),,INVESTORS, the bacterium of profit falls from between the pages when grasped lightly and shaken, these little marketing cutouts and advertisements for chain restaurants with false Irish roots that are defended by THE EDITORS as necessary to maintain the QUALITY PUBLICATION that readers have come to expect—but I ask them and get no reply, Do you mean to say you’ve made it two-ply?*”

Pappy’s Manor

The summer I first met William was a hot one, which can be said of most summers, this summer was hot with a particular sort of body penetrating humidity that made one sonorous, while simultaneously.

My father and I were new to the island - having recently bought a dilapidated old southern estate adjacent to the Tipnam property, adjacent because, William would later remind me, it had once belonged to their family and in some ways it always would. He was very blunt like that, even as a child, and it is quite difficult to explain the way in which such a statement could be made without sounding condescending or arrogant or just flat out spiteful. But it wasn't, it was historical fact the way it came from his mouth. Yes, we now owned the papers to the house, they had been required to unload some of their land for practical reasons (reasons that both William and I would come to learn in the following years, but then only understood to be *reasons*) – yes, it was ours but, he said his family had built it and lived in it for more generations than a house could be lived in without becoming a piece of the family history, and as such, forever a part of the Tipnam lineage, no matter where paperwork sat.

It was mid July when we moved in and the first thing I noticed as we pulled down the drive to our new home, it was somehow obvious, though without any signifiers or sound logic to justify the intuition, I knew I was surrounded on all sides by other Tipnam residences (or, as I had not yet met William or heard the Tipnam name, it might be more accurate to say that I felt surrounded by a cohesive unit, in the middle of something or someone that had grown into the land; large baroque houses or estates – some populated, others abandoned and worse for the wear). The first concrete thing I noticed was that the *main house*, which was barely visible from the gravel drive we traveled, was still decorated brightly in Christmas ornamentation – strings of red and white lights hung from the massive oaks that lined either side of the immensely long driveway that lead to the manor, and surprisingly large wire reindeer were frozen in place throughout the uncultivated property that made up the surrounding environment. Even from that distance, as we pulled up that first evening, I could see the manor itself, sparkling with white lights and atop the widow's walk a single, massive, explosively bright "Christmas Star", as it peeked between the swaying, broad-leafed oak branches, beaming with that good-old-fashioned Christian humility, something calling out to be worshiped. It was out of place, which made it somehow fit right in.

But again, there is no good explanation as to why these feelings were so clear, so obvious, especially to a boy like myself, who might have been *smart*, in some ways, but was not anything like the observant, keen, enigmatic boy who was to be my new neighbor, and only other male child within a radius of several miles - within, that is to say, the limited range of my freedom, which like so much else in my life was shaped by the Tipnam property lines, which was a boundary set half by County Road 523, and half by the rough waters of the Atlantic and her tributaries – WTT3, who would throughout the course of our lives continue to astound me with the things that he picked up on, identified, recalled and so on.

A Brief Aside #1

The expectation of genius is that it provides us with answers. The reality of genius is that it expands the questions we ask. William felt this burden most heavily, I think, because his was a family of

uncommon simplicity, and so they came to him for answers in the most trivial of matters, only to find that he confused rather than aided them. Apart from his Pappy, who understood, his family came to resent William for his brilliance - and as soon as they realized it for what it was they called it *slowness* in order to keep it subdued, and perhaps in a halfwitted attempt to keep William from realizing it himself. By the time I met him he was in the midst of a full on crisis, having realized that his family despised him, and that apart from Pappy (who had begun to lose his own wits) not a single one of them understood him when he spoke. It seemed as if, he confessed at a young age, this family was not his family at all. It is difficult to imagine a more frightening possibility, for a child of our age - but to William, rather, it seemed a source of interest, a cause for investigation, and outwardly he showed no signs of the existential fear that one would imagine should spring naturally from that well, as if he had known it all along.

A Different View of Pappy's Manor

My understanding as to why we moved to Grayson Island, South Carolina has changed shape over the years - though I believe it has finally solidified into something close to the truth. My father had served with William's father in Vietnam - which, I suppose, in those days, was something like becoming kin.

My mother, who had been my father's *high school sweetheart*, took twenty years to decide she couldn't bear the man he became when he returned from that war. So she went off and found a happy man, rich off trusts and eager to share, and when she left my father she offered me room and board wherever the wind took them - but I'd already made my mind up that I couldn't tolerate a cheater, and so it was my father and I, struggling to get by on his disability checks and his under the table work as a private bodyguard, which had found us constantly looking for other means of income, new places to live, and more adequate means for financial stability. All of which was solved when my father and William's reunited one night, while we were on a brief road trip through the area for reasons that had not been disclosed to me.

The Secret to Success

What I am about to disclose is no more a secret than it is a bit of information that was never made public for reasons both practical and legal. But now that my friend (perhaps he was my best friend, who am I to say) - now that my best friend is dead, I believe that the communication of certain omissions may serve a greater good inasmuch as I believe the truth is unequivocally superior to any falsehood (even if I understand that it sometimes must be kept hidden for reasons both practical and legal).

The truth? I suppose I'll come right out and say it. The books written by my best friend, those books that are now owned partially by a trust held in my name, which were never defined as a serious literature until after his death and are now the catalyst at the center of a large bidding war between the avant garde and mainstream publishing houses - these novels, as they are categorized, shelved and sold, novels about a running set of characters that are interwoven between two separate worlds (one which is our world and a second which is the root system of our world, the raw material one might say, of which it is made up).

These novels are not novels, if one takes the author at his word. They are something else - not quite autobiography or memoir, not journals, no, they are certainly stories in the common sense of the word - but they happen to have happened. They are real in some sense of the word. A Pentad; The Five Tomes ; From *Illusion* to *Reality* , where the truly absurd finally offers its respite. William created a cycle of works, novels he said, which in any case laid bare the truth of one's isolation - "One need not accept the rules and terms dictated by life. I never signed anything agreeing to the terminal condition that comes with the rest of it."

The truth is that these books are more fact than fiction. And if you asked William he would tell you that they are ***all fact , no fiction*** . And I can't help but think, now, in retrospect, that there is a greater mystery about the reality *behind* the books, than that which is contained without the knowledge of their origin. Which is to say I felt an imperative that struck me on the day of his death, to set the truth free, understanding that there may be repercussions, which there have been, some of which have been minor and easy to brush aside, others which have altered the course of my remaining life).

The great works of William's life - which all blend together into one great magnum opus when read correctly - they are all, according to William *with his hand pressed against a copy of Darwin's Origins of Species* , "the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth, so help him Aristotle," (or however he put it on that day of his confession). The secret of these great works of the imagination is that, according to the author himself, they were less imagined than the public was led to believe - as they were no more than the retelling of his life when stripped to their bare bones. This was problematic for a number of reasons, perhaps the foremost being that to say such a thing aloud would have unquestionably raised concerns about his mental capacities and likely would have led to an alternate world where William died not as a moderately well known, hermetic author, but rather as a somewhat archetypal version of the schizophrenia artist - and it is impossible to know if, in this world, his genius would have still resonated or if it would have been drowned out by the more romantic story of his mental illness.

Now I will state this once, and only once, because if I do not clarify this now, with some degree of finality, the question would hover over the rest of the book like a giant lens, distorting both the facts and the manner in which they are told. Only once - so please store this in your mind so as to avoid any questions of the like that should occur as the story gets rolling.

This is what I need to say: My friend William did not suffer from schizophrenia, and the works he published, forever referred to as fiction (until, I hope, this book sheds some light on the truth, some of which I observed), are the most true in their most unbelievable capacities. Because while William

said he always struggled to capture the loneliness of the abandoned lover, child, or friend - he did not struggle in the slightest to tell the true story of his life, even where the story deviated from logic, common sense, reality. He described the ochre of a demon's eyes in full clarity, but (first) fumbled his way around a description of his own mother's voice, at one moment calling it *nasal and tinny* and then, soon after, describing the same woman's voice a *low-key, smoky blend of vowels and consonants*.

Now, throat sufficiently cleared, perhaps we can set forth on this voyage properly, beginning where all good stories begin, at a bar.

William Jr. arrived at Charlie's Pub for the fourth consecutive morning, stepping in behind Trista, who was also on her fourth consecutive day shift, eight hours to go, eleven to seven, and then it was two days off to be with her daughter, visit her mother (it had been two weeks since she'd been to the care facility and her mother had already started with the short responses to her phone calls), two days off, she remembered as she turned on the window signs and started putting the clean pour-tops on the liquor bottles, one by one, that she also had to bring her car into the shop the next day, because the helpful man who'd changed her tire had also told her not to drive on the spare any more than necessary, it wasn't meant to bear that kind of pressure, and yet a week and a half later she still hadn't had the time (or if she had the time then not the money, and if she had the time and the money then the shop was surely closed), so there was the car, which reminded her of the registration, that needed to get taken care of too, but not during the two days she got with Carla, it just wasn't fair, dragging the poor child from place to place just to wait in lines to get paperwork filled out and money paid, so that by the time everything was said and done she'd have the car fixed up just in time to drive Carla back to her ex-in-laws, where she had a giant bedroom and a new TV with a remote and no antennas and a walkman and the only place she was willing to bring her friends so that Trista never got to meet any of them apart from picking them up and dropping them off at their little get togethers down by the Old Sheepshead Dock, where she hoped they didn't do the things Trista had done at that age after getting dropped off by her mom, *but surely they don't, we were bad and she's not a bad kid* - Trista in a sort of reverie, cutting lemons and limes and brushing them into small containers for later when it got busy, and then finally she remembered Billy had come in behind her and she looked down the long end of the bar and saw him in his regular corner stool with his paperboy cap pulled forward and his head leaned back as though it weren't dark enough in the one-windowed Pub already, and he needed the extra layer to block out the gray misty fluorescence that floated about the place smelling of piss and vomit a little extra that morning.

She decided not to wake him and went back to cutting fruits, placing them into little plastic containers, and thinking through her next two days, worrying; when she would find time to take her daughter to see the horses, like she had promised last week and the week before that.

The Works of William Theodore Tipnam III

- The Pentad (Books I - IV)
 - Book I: The Illusion (2000)
 - Book II: Maps of the Labyrinth (2001)
 - Book III: Post-Illusion (2002)
 - Book IV: A Certain Passage (2008)
- Other Works
 - Ghosts of the Cassique (Fiction) (2001)
 - Indigo: Poems (Poetry) (2002)
 - The Confessions of a Dying and Forgotten Pirate (Fiction) (2003)
 - Disbelief (Essays) (2008)
 - The Illusion: Other Verities (Fiction) (2009)
- Posthumous Releases
 - *No Horizon* (2016)
 - Book V of The Pentad
 - Published posthumously, “No Horizon” was an unfinished work. The general public and scholars alike debate the amount of work that remained, upon the event of his death, for the work to be “fit for publication” according to William Tipnam’s own, notoriously specific and frustratingly neurotic standards. Notably, the *unfinished* “No Horizon” is almost unanimously regarded as the pinnacle of his achievements - and yet research shows that up until at least three months prior to his death, he communicated to both his agent (Karina Lontano) and Editor (Michael Thrash) that the book was progressing at a fine pace, but had turned out to be significantly larger in scope than he imagined at the outset, and he felt as though he had only just reached the halfway point, the fulcrum on which the entire book was intended to turn. Making things all the more difficult to untangle, as a rule, he would allow no access (none, whatsoever) to the manuscript of *No Horizon* , until a full first draft was complete, and as such, it came as a surprise to both Karina and Michael, who conspired to come into possession of William’s laptop quite illegally (but were not held accountable until after the publication of “No Horizon” had already occurred), that the manuscript they found was over seven hundred pages long, and read for all intents and purposes as a complete novel.
 - In her review for the New York Times, Alena Xenochristos, wrote that “Reading the novel one gets the impression that another dash of salt might have overseasoned it, and yet not a single ingredient could be removed without altering the composition of a perfect dish altogether. Stunningly, this

unfinished draft reads as one of the most complete works of literature in the history of American letters.” She then goes on to ask the question William left unanswered, “What could he have possibly had in mind for the *second half* of this 750 page novel? One feels a total sense of completeness upon turning the final page - the literary equivalent of post-Thanksgiving belly-patting satisfaction, ready for nothing more than the tryptophan induced nap to allow the body to digest, recover, and appreciate its complete and utter gluttony of satisfaction.”

- Close Proximities (Fiction) (2016)
- First We Were Sad, Then Came the Fear (Fiction) (2016)
- No Illusions (Poetry) (2016)
- Paradox and Parabola: A Manifesto (Book-Length Essay) (2018)
- The Collected Notebooks Vols. 1-14
 - Limited Print Edition – Ninety nine copies of fourteen notebooks/journals fully transcribed and unedited.

A Rebirth of Sorts: The Arrival

A critical admission must be made at this point by the author - for should I expect you to trust a single word of what I am to tell you, it can only be because I have told it with complete and unabridged transparency. Incredible as the story is, even a mildly contemplative reader will find themselves asking the means by which I came to know the details of the events that took place in the Tipnam household to initiate everything that followed, and the extent to which my retelling of a story which has already been told (in five volumes, nonetheless) is flavored with dashes of fabrication and invention - as it is true, I also turned to writing as a profession – though only a bit later in life, after I had established myself as a man of industry and by luck secured a small fortune which allowed me time (the most critical nutrient in any decent writer’s diet) - as did this reassuring prosperity relieve my diseased brain of its greatest source of anxiety: the need to make an income sufficient to provide for a family, should one ever fall into my unworthy hands. In the latter case it seems Fate was wise enough to leave me childless, though she was certainly aided by my appearances and demeanor over time. But I’m not yet on the far side of forty, and I’ve seen enough in this lifetime already to understand that it is never safe to assume that Fate is done with you. There are always further depths; greater heights. My knowledge of the events is informed by three primary resources - each of which I will speak to in greater detail in the coming pages. First, there were the events as told to me by William himself, over the course of years, as he had decided to choose me as his confidant in this matter (why me, only William could answer that – but it was in me that he harbored his greatest secrets). Two, there was the physical evidence, that has long since been destroyed, ravaged or otherwise washed away by time - though some of it I kept; items that

corroborate certain elements of the story, locked away in a fire retardant safebox along with two or three other personal effects. And third, there was my own experience, which borders on the inconceivable, itself - but as I am the only one of us who remains, I feel duty-bound to finish the story that William started so long ago. And though I may not be even half the writer he was - I will do, with my limited gifts, the best I can to allow my friend William to rest easy where he lies.

I was two months William's elder, but because his facial hair appeared (in a nearly full state) at an unnaturally early age, and because of both his appearance and consistent facial expression there was an oft-remarked sense that he had been born with pre-existing anxiety, something that had accrued genealogically until finally, unable to support its own weight any longer, it was absorbed by the boy in utero, something that clung to him, resting heavily on his shoulders like the rucksacks our father's carried in the war. Even at the age of thirteen, William was more likely to be identified as college student who was constantly on the verge of a nervous breakdown than a young teen, pulsating with newfound sexual urges, and barely aware of the muscles that rippled across his shoulders and lower back like a new, thick, sub-layer of power. And this trend continued for the rest of our lives as it were, as if he was aging faster than one should age, years carving into him over the course of months. And I suppose one might come to the conclusion that it is not so unnatural that his death came early as a result.

So it was when we first met; I was pig-faced and still wore the fresh, virginal, unshaven skin of a child, while William, who I'd been aching to meet since our arrival three days prior, sported facial hair that grew from his sideburns to his prevalent adam's apple. It was unkempt, and certainly was not the full beard that would become one of his distinguishing features, thick and coarse, the only element of his appearance that he maintained with some sort of regularity, trimming and shaping it as a landscape artist creates a figure from a holly bush, over time, in a sort of symbiotic relationship with the bush itself - not cutting a shape into existence, but convincing the beard itself to grow in a particular way so that it ultimately grew into a straight dark extension of his chin (underneath, he despised the way his chin, like his father's, was somewhat small and undistinguished, which I ultimately understood to be the reason he felt so strongly attached to his beard - it was used to infer a bold, 'masculine' jawline) - the perfect contours of a stone that has been shaped over time, by the rolling waters of some great river. He also spoke with the deep, leathery voice of a smoker, though it would be another year or two before he'd pick the habit up in full.

But let me not lose track of our time and place - it was the fall of 1995, my father and I were living in a house that was far too large for us in general, but because half of the house had been decreed as off-limits by our (for lack of a more suitable word) benefactors we were constrained to the first floor, which still was more space than we could fill. The house, for the most part, was built from the earth that surrounded it - thick oak beams, brick made from red river clay, and that was what I liked most about it.

We were living out of boxes, eating saltines with butter and microwaveable chicken pot pies. We drank nothing but well water, except at cocktail hour when my father would fix himself a cup full of some plastic bottled scotch whiskey that never ran out. *Rotgut*, William's father said when he

stopped by for an early drink one evening. *Want some real hooch just say the word*, his father winked. But my own father felt, I suppose, that he had already taken enough - paying a pittance in rent for a house with twelve-foot coffered ceilings, windows with individual panes of glass large enough to fit a truck through. He never took the hooch from William's father, nor any other gift offered, unless he was able to pay for what he took right then and there on the spot. But disability pay wasn't ever going to be the same thing as a salary, he knew, and I suppose that was what got him thinking about committing the acts he would come to commit, whether out of pride or self-pity I'll never be certain.

One morning, after a week or two of pure boredom (I had yet to learn the value of imagination, creativity) my father sent me to William's house on an errand (or rather, I'd been sent to William's Aunt Harriet's house, where he was temporarily staying, he later explained, until his father got himself together, by which he meant sober, and William's mother would come back home). Harriet, and by extension, William, were staying in the cottage house, where only a few generations prior, the house slaves had lived. The house slaves were treated differently than the other slaves they'd owned. They lived in relative luxury compared to the plantation slaves who slept five or six heads to a room, in small shacks built hastily, without running water or electricity, some of which still stood around the perimeter of the property, worse for the wear having never been attended to in the century since they'd been abandoned. Most had been reclaimed by nature, tall grasses growing thick through the floorboards where holes in the roofs allowed a patch of sun to nourish slow and steady growth.

Some hundred and fifty years have passed since slavery was officially abolished, of course, but the inhumanity and indecency it had imbued into the fabric of our country (*Our economy! Our bloodline, tainted from inception*, I hear William now. Lecturing me as he paced in front of those broad window panes, cigarette dangling from the tip of his lips, almost never smoking it, as though its primary purpose was to serve as a smoke machine obscuring his gaze so that one couldn't be certain of the object of his attention. How many of life's questions did I turn to William to answer, having failed to come up with a reasonable explanation on my own? How many of his anecdotes, axioms, hypotheses and theories can I still recite by memory? How many have I forgotten?! – back to the story at once) the vile memory and lingering remnants of slavery had proven much harder to eradicate than the *Emancipation Proclamation* had been able to abolish by decree, that much was for certain. And much of it was still found on the Tipnam property, having nowhere else to go.

Whether metaphorically or metaphysically, it is not hard to understand what haunted the Tipnam Estate. The land was land that had once been, farmed, harvested and tended to by a substantial number of slaves, largely African, but there is the story of the two *lost* Indians who were *discovered and taken in*, to become members of the Tipnam workforce. Both being female, it surprised everyone when the younger and more beautiful of the two began showing signs of pregnancy after her first year as a slave.

Supposedly, that was when the two were separated - the pregnant daughter (as she later would explain in clear English, she and her mother had barely escaped from a skirmish between two tribes, her clan had been overtaken by a larger tribe of Indians that had been forced to the north by the Spanish, and as far as she knew, they were all that remained of her clan, the rest killed or absorbed by the larger

tribe that had invaded from somewhere to the south) was taken into the Great House no sooner than her condition was discovered - she was taught to speak English and was fluent within a year. She became quite well read over the next few years and then the unimaginable occurred, she began to dream and think in English first. Her mother had by then died, and there was no one left to speak to in her native tongue. Grief stricken and further burdened by guilt, she became a spiteful mother to her light skinned daughter - first in private, and then, as the grief grew bolder, she would publicly shun her own child, and run off to her room in a crying fit. She was diagnosed with *hysterical melancholia*, and no longer suitable as a house guest, she was given a small parcel of property and a regular stipend, both of which would disappear should she ever set foot on the property again.

It's not a story told around the Tipnam dinner table. Rather it was the sort of story that William and I would discover only by way of obstinance and untamed curiosity. One of the many stories that would put us in danger, as it were, but that is all to be addressed in due time.

Right - so I'd been sent off by my dad with an envelope full of money to deliver to William's grandfather. My father recognized my boredom and had already grown tired of my insistent requests to go fishing together, play card games (cable television did not reach the property, and rabbit ears provided only three stations that were decipherable, each one seemingly playing an endless loop of a different baptist minister shouting incantations or preaching the book of Revelations while a phone number blinked beside giant gold letters: *DONATE NOW!*, or *WHERE WILL YOU BE??*).

My father told me first to go find the youngest Tipnam, my soon to be friend William, and ask him to assist me in delivering the money to his grandfather, who was the owner of *just about everything as far as the eye could see*, my father told me, a hint of his own southern roots beginning to soften the consonants in his sentences.

The envelope I carried was meant to secure our lodgings for the next several months, I gathered.

I did not dare count the money in front of my father - I still retained some of the *social etiquette* that had been so important to my mother (despite the fact that they seemed absurd to me - these small diplomatic gestures that were apparently the only way to show the world that your mother had provided some element of *class* in your cultural diet) - and I did not know then that I carried in my hands the major share of what we had to our name, but this comes as no surprise, as I didn't know much about anything that was going on during those first few weeks.

All the while, one event after another led me further down the rabbit hole that was the Tipnam family lineage, each interaction begging more questions than providing answers. It was a labyrinth of history, half-truths, legends, lore and, ultimately, a darkness from which things had emerged, events had occurred, and still much more was to come, wave after wave of inexplicable events that ravaged a bloodline the same irreversible way a storm reshapes a coastline.

But again I am jumping ahead of myself.

I knew *nothing* in those days and trusted my intuition to guide me (which is as good a method as any when attempting to make sense of things - despite what some philosophers may have you

believe). I wondered what sort of boy I was on my way to meet. I was eager. The idea of a friend was so full of promise that I began to worry. I wondered if I should extend my hand when I met him, as if I were the type of thirteen year old boy who casually shook hands with other thirteen year old boys when we met (I decided I'd better not). I contemplated what I should say by way of introduction - surely anything I could tell him about us he'd already have known from his own father, I thought - though that assumption, like so many others, proved to be founded on a false premise.

I was eager as I navigated the gravel drive uphill. The Great House had been built on the highest part of the island. I felt I was on my way to begin anew, in a sense - which was an intuition that turned out to be more accurate than I ever would have presumed.

So I trudged forth in the direction of the Great House, where (given my father had not steered me wrong) I would find the smaller house that stood nearby, and what's more I would find the boy who was temporarily living there, with his aunt, while his father *got well* (I realized I didn't know what this meant) so that his mother would come back home (at least, I thought, I knew this feeling all too well).

The envelope was gripped tight in my right hand and I had maybe a quarter-mile to go when I felt the first drop of rain. One drop, that was all, I thought nothing of it until, twenty seconds later I heard a loud BOOM behind me, and turning to look I saw a flat gray curtain of rain through the semi-bare branches of massive live oaks, skinny, orange tinted carolina pines, and balding magnolias. I thought I'd better make a run for it so I turned and made a mad dash toward the general vicinity where I knew the place to be.

A Relative Paradox

From An Overwhelming Sense of Need: The Collected Journals of W. Tipnam III

[March 2000]

- *capture the reverie...breathlessness*
- *a manifesto of sorts*
- *monologue received (heard?) upon reaching the far side of the bridge - ~~cannot remember~~ who said this?*
- *augustine of hippo - philosophical presentism (anti-eternalism?), but this is somehow diff. (reread a.h.)*

“In a sense, because the future is eternally out of reach, infinitely ungraspable – because a goal is an illusion, something you look forward to only inasmuch as you aspire to look back upon it – as such, we have no choice in the matter: we shape our lives with stories. In fact, one might say it is the stories that

are reality, and our lives are but the fine tipped pen scribbling hastily across the page that it might miss now the detail of the osprey flying by as the herring hangs limp in the talons of a mother's tender grasp.

We live in an age of *mindfulness*, the *western Buddhists* freshly returned from their pilgrimage to some holy site in Nepal or Tibet, studious practitioners of *being in the moment*, each CEO perfecting their *tree pose* from the respite of their corner office only to fire their slim waisted secretary for interrupting with a 'phone call from the missus', vague notions of universality, oneness, who swore they heard the Ohm amidst the din of the sweaty subway car, yes, who felt for a moment the absence of the self, the dissolution of self into a state of how shall they put it...oh, nevermind.

But then if one is to accept the merit, to give the self away as illusory. By seeking the moment we assign ourselves the idiots' task - we ask ourselves to solve the riddle of the hare who can only gain on the tortoise in increments, and as such, never arrives - we tease ourselves with the impossibility of infinitude as a state which we might achieve. We wish to vomit for all our wisdom.

for fuck's sake.

Live for the illusion, for the fiction that is inherent in every memory, which is to say in everything we've ever known, will ever know. There is no state but the past in existence. And what is past is already at a remove from the truth – should one refuse to revel in it? The space between what has passed and what is passing, located precisely on the other side of the bridge to nowhere. What fine print would one sign to press pause for just a moment. To just say...stop. And have it be. There are few finer reasons to live than to imagine that there exists a place where one can stop with all the humdrum rabble rousing teetotaling drunkards, wishful-thinking free-association life beyond the spectrum in the infinite present...one might say.

It is to take one's life to be the artwork, to acknowledge the abyss, capture it in song, and then dance along the precipice, to feel the vibration of existence itself before diving into the abyss. There is nothing but the fall. The long, long fall," said the man on the far side of the bridge when I arrived. Then finally, he stuck his hand out to shake mine and introduced himself.

- *too MUCH, language cannot be transcribed, re-work entirely*
- *load of shit - sounds like i'm stuck INSIDE the box*
- *put yourself on the G. Island*
- *expel yourself from the work*
- *ego is inevitable, just run from it*
- *tell, some things can't be shown, but tell it correctly*

Looking and Seeing

There was a look of incredulity on William's face when we first met. It took some time, me seated beside him, both facing the same direction, at the splintering old picnic bench where we'd been set up to meet, halfway between the marsh and his Aunt Harriet's house, which was halfway to the Great House. A low-graded hill that had been partially filled by his ancestors in order to expand their land and was now, slowly but surely being consumed by the sea.

He strung a fishing rod in silence, patiently dealing with the instrument and the tangled mess of threaded line he had to first untangle. I intermittently interrupted the quietude with an occasional question, and to each he deflected, natural as a feather repels a raindrop, a full twenty minutes if not more, before I realized the incredulity, or was it pure amazement, was not a momentary thing brought on by his forced interaction with a new person (a peer, one would say, but we were no peers then, if ever), but it had nothing to do with me, this look that he wore without acknowledgement – it was more of a built in temperament, it wasn't something that left him. *Lord* knows how long he'd been that way, I thought then, it seemed to be a look he would maintain long after I left, and would be there waiting for me should we meet again, I thought then, in the direct sun - the slack jawed absence one sees when an actor plays mental patient – those big eyes, shining with the memory of their own luminescence, the faint glow of a flashlight recently switched off, but as if the light was somehow permanently in that liminal state - *being* , but not being *there* .

As luck would have it I have always been patient in my ways, perhaps as a result of my unpredictable youth, I learned early not to expect much of those around you. And I learned, too, that those who spoke too much were often compensating for a lack of genuine ideas, complex thought. I'd been raised with the understanding that still waters run deep, as they say, and by then it was something I'd tried on for myself - the pensive, silent observational quality of *great men* - but even then I knew that it was not the sort of thing you cultivate intentionally, and though I tried to cultivate it despite myself - despite the feeling that I'd forever fall short.

How old are you? I asked. He did not look up from his task when he responded that 'he supposed' he was thirteen. An odd response, but one I accepted nonetheless. *Me too* , I told him.

Do you like it here? merited a simple nod for a response, initially, until I opened my mouth to speak again and he answered more concretely:

I had better . Another short, obscure response. By all means he seemed intentionally dense, but then there was that look that seemed to be nothing but pure amazement - almost infantile in its silent enraptured state. He pulled and picked at the knotted fishing line some more and then suddenly I saw a hint of a smile cross his mouth as he pinched one section of line between his thumb and forefinger and pulled slowly, the entire knot decomposing little by little. He'd pull, set the line between his teeth, grab a section closer to the knot and pull again - there was not an instance of tension then, as he pulled until not a trace of the knot remained.

Just then a gigantic white bird took flight out of the marsh grass, effortlessly. It banked sideways with the light breeze and turned towards the empty beach island, just visible from where we sat.

Did you see that bird?

Finally, here he responded, looking directly at me for the first time, *Which one?*

I had only seen the one, I told him, a white one with a gray stripe down the back of its thin neck. He returned to his focused state - now tying small lead weights to the line, knotting them with precision but still watching all the time. Taking it all in at once somehow. Apparently he'd already had his eye on any number of creatures.

The way he saw the world seemed to me as though he were not entirely human - there was something more primal in his gaze, there seemed to be a way in which he was a part of the world, whereas I, and everyone else I'd ever known, were mere observers of the living, breathing fabric of the world - in that state of hyper-sensitivity that makes mankind look slow and dull in comparison. The world was, for me, a set of all objects I'd ever seen - and I imagined that was how the world was constituted for the rest of us too. But with William, it was as if he were the subject of a greater vision - and things seemed to happen around him as though he were of no more consequence than a strong breeze; the sound of a blue heron wading through marsh as a light rain sets in - hardly there but for the ripples in its wake. Where I had seen one bird amidst a backdrop like a still-life, he had seen something else entirely - a full prism of life moving, flying, swimming, gliding, skimming the surface of things. He was looking at something that, as far as I could tell, wasn't even there. Certainly there had only been one bird?

Are there more of them somewhere? I asked, now looking around with a fake sort of ambition. As though I were looking closer, seeing what (or rather how) he saw, but there was nothing more to be seen. A patch of tall grass extended out towards the water's edge where thick green and yellowing reeds grew from pluff mud and the tide was so far out that near to us the surface of the mud had begun to bake and crack in little plate sized sheets that curled up around the edges - light then filtered in through the marsh grass, landing on the dappled floor where it was further deconstructed by the micro-valleys and rifts of the bed. The dimpled topography of the pluff mud which was so porous that it filled up and dried out with every tide.

I realized that by faking it I had actually begun to see things differently. This was perhaps the first thing I learned from William - *no matter where you look, there is something to be seen*.

Looking in this way I saw more than I had initially, even from thirty, forty feet away - I saw the effervescent, bubbling, wet mud, made alive by the movement of fiddler crabs scurrying between small holes into which they would disappear and behind them a bubble would occasionally rise to the surface where it sat until popped by any number of invisible forces that were omnipresent at that level - surface pressure, evaporation, tiny vibrations from the far off movement of a spooked red drum - Minor, imperceptible things that seemed to dictate the way everything worked, from the pluff mud to the tiny snails that climbed the height of the marsh grass with the tides only to slide back down again as it receded, keeping it clean as a part of their symbiotic relationship..

It is hard to describe how vivid it all became, suddenly - to a boy who'd spent the majority of his childhood, so far, moving from house to house in the crowded suburban sprawl from Ohio to northern Virginia.

I couldn't even remember a time I'd been to the beach. I thought about it for some while and then remembered I'd been to the Pacific Ocean once, on the last family trip I could remember: *85 South to Nashville, take a right on 40 and ride it all the way to Barstow*. That was back when my mother and father were still fighting, which in my memory meant they were still talking, at least.

More what? He asked, puzzled. And there it was again, that look of sheer shock and bewilderment at what he saw around him. Not just the trees, and the slow tiding water, the lonely beach across the way, the far off houses - but even when he looked at me to speak, I suddenly felt the intensity of his gaze and it was me now - I, somehow, was sublime, an abyss, the sort of thing that strikes silence in a man. I struggled to get the words out of my mouth, *More birds* I reminded him - *were there more birds I could not see?* And he nodded his square, sun darkened face, turned back to the scene in front of us, and said *More than you could ever imagine*.

Some Notes on Time: I

Excerpt from *An Overwhelming Sense of Need: The Collected Journals of W. Tipnam* *III*

[December 1995]

...doing some reading on einsteins theory of *special* relativity and wow does that sure as shit blow the door off the hinges, thinking about all the harriets of the world, all the johnny sellers, carson bellevues, toms, dicks, and harrys out there walking around like they own the place, man they dont even own the time. did you know if you are at the top of a mountain you age a little faster than you do down at the bottom of a well? means time aint shit except what we call it. a second is only a second if its my second and i'm talking to me about it - your second and my second arent the same. but practically they are the same, to the naked eye the same (now whos ever seen a clothed eye? theres a riddle for you - why did the eye undress itself? or something like that) but this is what makes it so ridiculous to jt when i tried explaining this to him the first time (and hes about the smartest person ive ever met even if i havent met all that many people, hes at the top and even he said to me, the way he does whenever he thinks things are getting too theoretical, will theres some things that arent meant to be explained - but i could still tell i got to him a bit because he sat there and considered it for a while

after that and we didnt speak for the rest of the day the way we do when one of us is on to something) but anyways they arent the same, one second and another - its all -winkwink- 'relative'. they werent kidding when they said that einstein was a genius, walking around with THAT in his head and not ripple in the pond of the ever-more-primitive *homosapiens*' watercooler conversations, searching for the proof – same thing in math as in court, you need proof if youre to be believed. meanwhile, the whole world doesnt much give a shit (except for the scientists, but they cant convey it correctly, i guess, cant tell it so it makes sense) that time as we know it isn't anything more than a homemade measuring stick we threw some notches on - about as real as bigfoot...

Prophet

My father's first name was Gerald and that's a fine name but it wasn't the right one for him. Gerald's are good natured, if unambitious. And that would have been fine and well, being named Gerald, if it weren't for the fact that he was no Jerry either. Jerry might have been worse. Jerry's talk more than most. They play second base, they like to be in proximity to danger, but only so long as they are closest to the exit. They are fast. My father was not fast.

As it were, the point I was hoping to make was that my father broke the mold when it came to Gerald's. He spent a significant portion of his childhood in one of those schools where they send children who kick cats and use their first magnifying glass to burn anything slow enough to catch, kids who loaded up their peashooters with rocks instead of peas, and kids who never left the Five and Dime without a new pocket knife. He got in trouble most of his childhood the way he tells it, *Weren't much else to do in Chester, Ohio but go to church or run from it - so I ran from it, straight into Conway Academy, and Conway Academy is just about a one-way-ticket to the military if it keeps you outta jail.*

At Conway he took on his middle name, Prophet, or rather it was chosen for him by his peers, and he was more than happy to leave Gerald behind. Prophet was a family name on my Nana's side, but also happened to suit him well (despite his aversion to organized religion of any denomination).

His intelligence was no secret to anyone who spent more than a few minutes in his presence. For two years before the war broke out in Vietnam he would amaze his fellow *inmates*, as they referred to themselves, by predicting events that would occur days, sometimes weeks and months in advance. He taught them about global politics, as he understood them in those days, which is to say, haphazardly and with a healthy dose of pure fiction. But he had some sort of inherent awareness of the world and its structures, the way things worked to put it simply, that he was correct more often than the rest of his peers on intuition and a memory that one of his classmates once described as, "a giant filing cabinet with no formal organization." Whenever he was about to share a theory, they alleged, his eyes would almost roll back in his head and you could practically see him shuffling through the filing cabinet, in an fashion no more organized than the cabinet itself, and then there would be a moment of build-up, a tightening key, and then (most of the time) there would be a visible release of tension when he found it, that little pebble of an idea that would grow into the truth in months or weeks or years.

It don't take a genius , was his response.

No, they agreed, *it takes a prophet* . Thereafter followed a long silence in which certain of his classmates considered the idea with sincerity - the volume and accuracy of his predictions was astounding, undoubtedly. But, sensing their unease, he reanimated the group of young, male derelicts by speaking in his (now well practiced and intoned) slow, clear reply, “The only thing I *prophesize* is someone is getting their ass whooped the next time the banana pudding doesn't last until the end of the lunch-line,” and then to the small, uncomfortable chuckle that returned, he replied, “and, of course, that I'm going to fuck Nurse Ellen by the time I graduate from *Gone-away Academy* ,” at which everyone laughed full throatedly until the RA for their floor, a senior without any friends to speak of, stepped in and told them to quiet down for inspection, ensure their working areas were clean and properly stocked [UNFINISHED/CUT?]

One Version of the Beginning

On the morning of his thirteenth birthday he rose early with the concern that this may be the last time his birthday held such excitement for him - if pushed to express why, he would have struggled to answer, rubbing lightly at the sparse facial hair that had started to show, first as an extension of his sideburns, but now even in small patches on his chin, cheeks, and on the underside of his jawline (most offensively, he thought - this was the only component of his beard he took measures to shave), why this underlying concern that he was aging out of excitement for events like birthdays, Christmas, those special gift giving days that acted primarily as an excuse to remove oneself from the day-in day-out consistency of the daily ritual.

Perhaps it was that he'd observed this phenomenon, in the graceless way all adults he knew spoke about their birthdays as if they were better off forgotten - the almost requisite joke about it being the fourth or fourteenth time so and so was turning twenty nine, this accompanied by the painful forced laughter that followed, as though *aging* was this thing that, slowly (or did it occur overnight - surely not)... this thing that slowly, over the course of one's life, transitioned from intoxicating, exciting, entering a new world, a new phase so to speak, filled with the new possibilities brought about by having gained such a critical year of experience - how it transforms from what is ostensibly a blindly positive surge of joy to the existential horror that he saw, when he looked closely at his mother's ambivalent smile, and became all the more clear, when she, having seen him looking, forced herself to turn the dial up, *for his sake* - *don't take that from him* .

Perhaps William thought, this was the real version of learning about Santa Claus - and the whole fraudulence of Christmas was a test run, meant to prepare the preadolescent for the onslaught of disillusionment destined to come in waves for the next five to seven decades; if one is *lucky* , that is.

The Tipnam property was vast, even if they had parceled and sold off more than half of it since the property lines were first drawn up. Back then there had been five families: the Wrathburnes, the Penroses, the Graysons, the Renfields and the Tipnams. There were feuds and love affairs between these families enough to fill a bookshelf - and I have long thought of undertaking the project myself, but to do so would require a degree of objectivity I would likely struggle to maintain - having had my own interactions with the vestiges of the families that remain. Only the Penroses are no longer represented among the island's inhabitants - the result of a curse, I've come to believe, as it was following an event of great infamy among all of the families, that the Penrose kin bore but one single male heir in a generation of twenty six opportunities to do so - Charlton Penrose - and he ran away at the age of twenty two, having fallen in love with a French aristocrat named Pierre (of course) that he met down at the market, leaving not so much as a note when he departed, so the story goes.

Three of them were farming families, the Renfields, the Penroses, and the Graysons. Each tried their hand at a number of crops before settling on their respective products of commerce. Indigo, Cabbage and Rice were at the heart of the farming community on this island. The Tipnams were not considered a farming family, though they did farm as well - depending on the year a visitor might find okra, cotton, tobacco in it's large leafy tufts - for a period of time it was livestock, though this period was short lived and one of great deficit and one might suggest embarrassment for the great family. I've been told the story enough times to recite it from memory, but it's not the same when Pappy isn't the one telling it so I like to skip straight to the punchline - hogs and hurricanes make for the foulest smelling low-country boil one could imagine, *smell of death still aint washed itself outta the ground where the barn once stood, dead hogs piled high as the stormline. They say hogs is smart creatures, well these hogs aint figure to swim their way out the barn before the water crested the doors and there werent nowhere left to go but heaven.*

That old barn came down and the land, which was some of the lowest on the island, was soon thereafter leased to the Renfields and populated with small little huts where their recently acquired slaves were made to live.

The Tipnams had gone back to their small farming operation as well, at least as far as the tax man was concerned. If you weren't the tax man then you'd know that the cotton they grew was nothing more than a facade, a manner of evasion, so to speak, and the real source of their continued profit came to them through the water in a manner of speaking - though they weren't pirates proper either. They were something unique as far as I've been able to ascertain through my studies. But we'll get to that in due time...in due time...I set out here to tell you about Jonelle and if I get into the history of the Tipnams and the Atlantic Ocean it will be another hundred pages before I get back to the topic at hand.

Those huts were destroyed and rebuilt so many times it became a sort of rite of passage for the family that has inhabited them since the land was leased to the Renfields once so long ago - but it was a

matter of great confusion and some bloodshed when the Confederacy, having lost the war, found itself populated with an entirely brand new population of individuals that now held rights, whether those rights were upheld being another matter entirely. By then the lease with the Renfields had paid out the value of the land many times over but the deed to the land itself still sat in the same secret location as the multitudinous other records that the Tipnams kept - a location which was a matter of family legacy, known only to the *Triad* (which was the lineage of the three eldest, living, first-born males in the Tipnam family at any given time). As you might guess, when one member died the next in line of the appropriate generation was properly initiated and so forth, such that there are at least two supposed stories of fratricide that William disclosed to me - both of them despicable in their own ways. Well the issue was that the Renfields then, having been forced to free the family of house slaves that had been under their ownership for upwards of five generations decided they no longer wished to lease the land upon which those huts sat, and the family who lived there had no intentions of leaving. As the Tipnam patriarch at the time, Jeremiah Joseph 'JJ' Tipnam (a name it would serve the reader to remember) made the decision to gift the land to the family of freed slaves who called the boggy, mosquito plagued, and waterlogged plot of swamp home. No paperwork was involved, nor were words exchanged, one day just followed the next as they had done before and though the land by deed belonged to JJ Tipnam, by all other accounts it was owned by the Fields family (who had, by law, been forced to take a surname upon emancipation - and in an effort to distance themselves from their former owners, had decided to cut the head right off the Renfield family name and make the rest their own).

A strange, silent friendship emerged between JJ Tipnam and Ernest Fields, and when a great storm came through that September, JJ offered to rebuild their homes in exchange for support and assistance with his newest business venture. And with a handshake a new partnership was enacted that would last until this very day, though not without many, many changes and alterations and at least two full blown catastrophes, one of which was just about to occur when my father and I took up residence with the Tipnam family during the off-colored Fall of 1994.

Jonelle Fields was, physically, a massive human being. He was only sixteen years old when I first met him, but looked to be at least thirty five. He was exiting the outhouse, trailed by a trio of flies like some sort of naturally formed ellipses...the fumes that followed in his wake were nearly visible, a sort of wavering shimmer like hot heat off freshly laid asphalt. The outhouse seemed to expand when he walked out - released from the vacuum-like gravity of his weight, which threatened to collapse, or rather implode the tiny shack - moaning beneath the weight of his gargantuan feet when he stepped in the door, creaking as if actively warning its visitor when he sat his giant, inconceivably sweaty ass down to defecate.

None of this seemed to bother Jonelle in the slightest, who could be heard whistling (interrupted by thick, extended grunts of effort) from the treeline, where William and I stood momentarily still as he pulled out a sack of Red Man chew tobacco, tore open the package and then dug around for a minute before chucking a palmful into his mouth, and without a word extending the bag in my direction, as though I had the first idea what it was, my only thought that is smelled of prunes or raisins or something sweet and fruity. Due to our proximity, and not wanting to give away our position, I quietly took the

bag and mimicked his actions - taking a large pinch of the oddly wet, sticky substance and I threw it in my mouth just like he had, failing to realize that he had then compacted the substance by using his teeth and tongue in order to hold it in his cheek, that is, failing to realize he had not swallowed it. No sooner had I thrown a substantial amount of *chaw* , as William called it, than I felt the juices filling my mouth with a thick and tingling sensation and I, not wanting to appear somehow inferior or less aware than my new friend, did what seemed natural, swallowing the viscous solution with immediate regret when I saw William expectorating his own, dark, congealed ball of saliva, dark and thick as mud, a string of it hanging from his lip, at the same time I felt an acidic fire roaring down my esophagus (or was it upwards?) and tried rapidly to spit up as much as I could, though I had not worked the tobacco into a ball, allowing the strands to disperse throughout my mouth so I was spitting out not only the juice but little bits of dark brown leaves - the acidic fire traveling down my throat like so many razor wielding riders on a roller coaster that paused for a moment to do a loop around my chest before descending into my stomach where all hell broke loose. I convulsed with the need to vomit. *Oh no...keep it down!* I heard William shouting in whispers. *He'll hear us!* The half shouted whisper went on, but my stomach gurgled, spouted and the picture of a great geyser that I'd seen on our one and only family vacation came to mind as my head, half-cocked, erupted - mouth, nose and eyes each expelling their own substances, burning more than it had going down as it came back out. And with it a dizziness, not altogether unpleasant, separate but still related to the *chaw* . My breakfast, little yellow bits of egg and fried Spam still in bite sized pieces as though I'd altogether forgotten to chew painted the low hanging interior of the ancient live oak we'd staked out as our hiding spot. And then, before I'd completed the first bodily evacuation the second came right behind. I couldn't remember having eaten as much as I expelled, my body must have been calling on hidden reservoirs of food it kept locked away for a hungry moment.

I was amazed by the complete lack of control I felt, terrified and dizzy, and all the while getting a whispered tongue lashing from William. I should've told him I didn't know what I was doing. What the hell was I thinking throwing in a mouthful of tobacco like I was Chipper Jones?

I wiped my face and mouth and cringed at the burning feeling in my stomach - surely this was how ulcers formed. William looked at me, then the outhouse, then back to me, back to the outhouse.

Only he knew, at that time, the size of the man inside. If I'd known I'd have been running, but there was something inherent in William's judgment that I trusted, more than I trusted my own instincts.

While he was prone to changing his position on things - and always reserved the right to contradict himself - as he believed contradiction to be an inherent quality of the macro-structure of the universe - whatever William spoke was **true** , if only for the moment in which he spoke it, he could not speak something false. So if he were to say at some moment, "It is raining," and I, looking around, would see nothing but empty blue celestial cover from one end of the sky to the other - it would suddenly become apparent to me that he was speaking of some other part of the world, where the sky had suddenly exploded with precipitation. When he believed the world to be driven by the tenets of postmodernism, as he did during a short spell in 1999, all one had to do was look around to see the overwhelming fragmentation and meta, self-referential quality of the world wherever one walked. It was everywhere

we went - true as the evening star was the evening star, and the morning star the same. But when, soon thereafter, he disavowed postmodernism, having finally reached its rotten core, and tossed it aside in favor of a pure essentialist view of the things that composed our universe, the whole world would shift with him and in all things one would see only that they could be composed of fundamental essences, basic building blocks making up the world from galaxy to atom - and all of the meta concepts that had been chasing us down like haggard, but determined tax collectors, in an instant vanished and could no longer be found without some other essential truth beneath them (that most certainly hadn't been there before).

You see we all think we are the center of our own universe, it is said, but I am rather confident that it was not me, but William that the universe looked to for its rules, and as such I was merely a satellite, always off center but completely absorbed by its gravity - at no risk of losing course - constantly circling the truth even as it, itself, moved (expanded, heaved, contracted, heated, cooled, settled and breathed life into things). To know William, was to connect the evening star with the morning - and from there name it *Venus*, as if the name had never been uttered before.

Truisms For Idiots

"They say," he said to the disinterested crowd, "that doing the same thing and expecting different results is one definition of insanity - but once again here *they* are wrong, this is called entropy if you believe in science, and it sits at the intersection of evolutionary biology and the concept of time itself." He leaned forward and spoke slowly into the small microphone. "They have an opinion on everything. They are not to be trusted." He got a small chuckle from the class, one of the laughs hung in the air a moment too long and caused him to scan the faces row by row one more time.

How many more days could he go on like this, he wondered, scanning the crowd for *her* face?

But his thought was interrupted by the appearance of another, unexpected face, that must have appeared while he had his back turned, blowing his nose into his monogrammed handkerchief, or when he'd been busy scribbling loudly on the chalkboard, a series of words for the students to consider. It was a very specific and unexpected face, standing out amid the sea of students as if they were a two dimensional plane, and this figure protruded from the plane, bringing in a new field of depth to the eyes - or was it, rather, that this face had rendered the world around him two dimensional, though it had not been before, and only now had the homogeneity of the class become a true characteristic of its existence. That face! perhaps even more surprising than it would have been to find *her*.

This meant something extraordinary had occurred, but he could not very well stop his lecture, so on he went.

Finally I'd finished heaving and just felt ashamed. More than anything I wanted to turn and bolt, risking the damage that my legs would suffer from the thorny, serpentine undergrowth which was everywhere but seemed to have no place of origin, a giant carpet of calf and shin slicing vines. But I was embarrassed and was not prepared to quit.

William quietly laughed at intervals, stopping to glance through his binoculars towards the outhouse, which I only then noticed was making noises of its own. I wiped at my face and attempted to clear my nose by pressing one nostril shut and blowing with all my might through the other - a large chunk of something half-digested shot out sideways and I was able to breathe through both nostrils again, finally. The acid had managed to do its own damage by then and each inhale and exhale stung in almost exactly the same way it stung when one inhales ocean water unexpectedly - a burning sensation that was all the more pathetic for having been self induced.

We were forty feet or so from the outhouse and the tree cover was minimal. But Jonelle, William had warned me, was essentially blind if he was not wearing his glasses - this in itself was not the warning, rather, William had told me that his vision issues had turned out to be a gift to his other senses, calling the human body *The Great Network* he noted that where one element of perception lagged behind, the other often compensated. So Jonelle was particularly well known for his sense of smell and hearing; among his cousins and siblings he was often used to report on the weather (where he outscored the meteorologist on his worst day.)

INTERLUDE 2

Part X: Section 1.0.0

0130 EST – December 1st, 2001 – XX Island

The oversized moon caused extreme tides and the low-lying section of Oakstone Road where the two young men currently walked was the only way to get to their destination that had not been flooded.

Even the road, for this particular stretch, was hardly there—water risen well above the shoulder of the road had forced the young men to walk the center of the road where it was at its highest, following the faintly visible strips of white paint that served as the median. From above one would see the patch of road as a sort of hourglass through which they passed, the only walkable passage to the southern tip of the island, where they were headed. *If the water fully crested, as it had before, did that make the southern tip of the island an island of its own?* The smaller one, John, led the way while the other one, who was broader but perhaps no taller than the other, and whose name was W. T. followed close behind,

frequently looking back to ensure no cars were approaching. Though he knew no one was coming — no one had really been concerned for their whereabouts since they turned thirteen or so—it seemed that was the age of manhood on XX, which I suppose is a way of saying if someone came looking for them that night it meant something had gone wrong, it would mean something had upset the balance in some way, and that would be more concerning than anything else. Consistency and predictability were staples of life on XX; their life at The Talking House, as unconventional as it was, was nothing if not consistent; it was consistently unconventional. Two young men, roommates, living on their own terms and bothering no one. *It was a peaceful existence*, W. T. thought, looking back towards the Talking House and the Great House and his mother's house, which was really a well maintained doublewide that had been given to them by John's family—they'd gone as far as to lay a foundation and raise the house six and a half feet so that it was a good eighteen inches above the hundred year floodplain. A threshold they'd come close to crossing that night, but hadn't—at least not when they'd walked past the house an hour or two prior, and there hadn't been a drop of rain since then, though the tide had still been on the rise. W. T. didn't know how that sort of thing worked, but John hadn't said anything. John had been here all his life and knew intrinsically when and when not to be worried about things like that. John hadn't been worried, not about his Mother and the house at least—and John was always worrying about Izzy (which is what everyone, including W. T., called his Mother).

They passed through the thinnest part of the hourglass at 0132 AM EST precisely. The sound of the whipping wind was growing louder while at the same time the silence of being completely alone out there (together, but alone, that is) was impossible to mistake. In that sense it was both incredibly loud, and eerily silent in a paradoxical way that struck W. T. as being conditions that should only exist when one is indoors—as though they were breaking some sort of fundamental rule by making this trip in the first place—which, indeed, they were. In fact they were breaking a number of very important rules—ground rules, rules of engagement expectations (quasi-rules), unwritten rules, and at least one of the rules they were breaking was a law.

Depending on who you asked, the number of broken rules could be anywhere from 2 to 16— though this didn't seem to concern John in the least, and by extension W. T. felt comfortable with it as well.

The roadway was expanding as they made their way up the other side. All the tiny inclines and declines in a relatively flat stretch of land became much more noticeable after a significant amount of rainfall has created a single flat surface for perspective. Little undulations that would otherwise be invisible were clearly brought forth like small hills and valleys by the shimmering glint of moonlight refracted off the flat plane of the risen tide, which had so much more meaning to the two boys that night. The storm, the high water, the hourglass, the intervals of white paint on the wet black pavement all leading them towards their destination—that place that John knew because his Pappy had spoken to him; a place that W. T. could only guess at, and felt no inclination to do so, knowing it would make no difference in the end.

John would take them there, and then they would know.

How bright the moon had been, unbelievably bright, and so large in the sky it seemed strange that people couldn't go vacation there. So large that the man in the moon was hard to construct, visually, because the craters and peaks and the whole topography of the place seemed to be close enough to run a hand across it. W. T. saw it as a fossilized sea sponge, hanging from a celestial mobile for a planet that was an infant. And if earth is the infant, he thought, then the Sun must be the parent. And he felt some sort of satisfaction in the world he had imagined and its simplicity.

"We are getting close," John said. "Last mile." And as he spoke the words a large cumulus cloud blew in out of nowhere—though neither of them could see the full scope of the cloud, only the edge which was illuminated by the moonlight for a few moments until the moon was consumed entirely, the size of the cloud was truly massive, sky-swallowing, and just like that the moonlight had been revoked. The night turned a complete and utter black. Not even a halo of the moon, not even a specter of its bright beacon could be seen through the deep, dark and swollen cloud which had arrived so rapidly as to catch them off guard entirely.

A boom of thunder rang out and W. T. was struck with a vision, or perhaps a feeling or sensation more accurately put: it was as if the opening bell had been rung for a heavyweight prize fight to begin, except only the official stood center ring; both fighters were still seated in their respective corners and when the bell rang they first looked around in surprise, but quickly regained composure and made eye contact with one another (like pavlov's dogs, once the bell sounded they instinctively responded); but with neither side willing to make the decisive first step (perhaps giving the advantage to the opponent, who might have been plotting based on the assumption that the other fighter would move first), the first round of the fight took place entirely in the psychic realm between the fighters minds, sweat dripping in torrents down each fighters face and body, their coaches astounded, first yelling at them, and then struck by fear at the intensity of these two top-tier machines of violence.

He pulled a small flashlight from his pocket, not much larger than a marker or a tube of acrylic paint and clicked it on to see John's back, up ahead, moving with a patient, constant ambulation, carrying on as though he hadn't even noticed the lights had gone out, paying no heed to the sudden shift in wind speed and direction, the palpable drop in barometric pressure that made W. T.'s ears feel slightly odd, though he could not say precisely what the feeling was. The slender light spread in a small conical shape that was at its largest only slightly wider than his friend's back; and because it was a dim light that did not extend far beyond the twenty feet between the two of them it did almost no good whatsoever in W. T.'s hands. He was prepared to hand it over to John, as soon as he asked. He cast the light to the right and saw high water stretching out into the vast emptiness that was to the west. To the east it was the same, the drainage ditches were completely underwater along with everything else except for this one, elevated stretch of Oakstone Road on which they were currently traveling towards

an unknown end—all at the behest of a senile and possibly demented man’s confused ramblings at the tail end of John’s 18th birthday..

They were on a peninsula of sorts, though it was hardly large enough to earn the name and was only referred to as the South Point as far as W. T. knew.

A few seconds after the thunder had sounded, which is to say in the moments that W.T. had been imagining the bell for a boxing match had been rung and so on and so forth, John had an oddly connected thought occur to him—a memory struck him that seemed somehow related to the thunder and dark black skies, but he could not for the life of himself explain how.

It was a memory of Pappy in his armchair in the smoking room where the two boys liked to come and sit a look through his library while Pappy told them the truth about things that had long been kept hidden from them. It was also Pappy’s only remaining pulpit where he wasn’t interrupted by his children or children-in-laws, or well meaning visitors, or doctors (who were the worst). On that day Pappy had gone on a spree of rants about how much he despised Mike Tyson and Muhammed Ali alike—However, at the same time he spoke of Rocky Marciano as if he had been handed down to man by God himself; and mostly John thought about how once, W. T. had told Pappy that the preference of Marciano to Ali, in terms of who was the better fighter, was hardly comparable—and it was Ali’s race and politics that made him feel this way, in other words, nothing about his preference of Marciano to Ali (Tyson was a different matter) could really be justified. John thought about how, had it been anyone else, Pappy would have thrown them from the house without so much as a moment’s hesitation, but because it was W. T., who Pappy respected as if they had been life-long friends, as if W. T. had once done something very honorable that Pappy would never forget—because of that unique dynamic—Pappy thought about what W. T. had said and reconsidered his opinions about the boxers altogether.

John had expected Pappy to talk about Indians, which was his go to when it came to discussing his thoughts on skin color and race. How he essentially was under the impression that the greatest race on earth was the Indians (by which he meant Native Americans, and in particular the local tribes that had once lived in the same area, which were actually numerous and varied but were broadly spoken about as a single group, as the ‘Creek Indians’ because they lived along the creeks, rivers and related bodies of water that spread out from the XX River). But this was not his response.

Ultimately, he came to the conclusion that Marciano, too, was not worth the stool he sat on—and he decided that it was Sugar Ray Leonard who was the greatest fighter of all time. Neither John, nor W. T. had known what to make of that. He’d switched divisions all together! And anyways, Pappy didn’t watch boxing as far as John knew – he supposed it was just one of those things that older people run off at the mouth about.

Part X: Section 1.0.1

John woke to the sound of W. T.'s voice though it seemed like they were already in the middle of a conversation. He thought, perhaps, W. T. had started talking, and John, in his sleep, had uttered responses that were sensible enough for W. T. to continue talking—W. T. had the capacity to talk to himself, at any rate, John sometimes heard him through the walls at the Talking House, going on and on telling stories that were just on the verge of impossible, but not quite impossible enough to be written off completely. Maybe this quality led to his success as a writer, later in life, or maybe it was the byproduct of some other quality that had led him down that path. In any case, he was in that sort of fugue state when John woke that day—with only a vague recollection of their arrival on the strange island, pitching a tent in the clattering rain under the protection of a Live Oak that was larger than any he'd ever seen before. Larger than the Forever Oak, which was the pride of XX Island, larger by magnitudes. He didn't understand how a tree like this that he sat beneath could so much as exist without his having at least heard of it—but sure enough it was there, and they'd found it.

"You know how she is," W. T. spoke in a sort of directionless manner. If it wasn't for the circumstances of their current predicament John would have likely assumed there was some third individual that was the assumed listener. But they'd found an island in the dark, at the end of the bridge to nowhere, just as Pappy had insinuated, however vaguely, in his rambling monologue (that John seemed to think had been a curse. "She tells a story six times, she tells six different stories. To her, they are all real stories about her life, about my life too. But they can't all be true. We can't have done half the things she's said. You know? And it genuinely hurts my head to start trying to figure out where we went or what we did before we came here."

John, who had been turned away, lying on his side with his arm beneath his head, and beneath that the springy tarpaulin surface of the tent floor, now turned and looked up at the tangle of shadows and juxtaposition of light that took up his whole field of vision. It seemed that the sun had not been up for very long. For one thing the angle of the shadows, which were long and thin and driving across the top of the tent, suggested the sun was low on the horizon. For another, the morning orchestra of native bird calls was almost impossible to confuse with other times of day. Once the sun was higher in the sky, at say, 10 A. M. - the birds all chatted independently of one another during other parts of the day, but in earlier morning time, as it was now predicted to be, they sang a song that seemed to play off of one another, with a specific sequence and cadence.

Only the mockingbird, that bastard, disrupted the accord. On good days, John thought of its independence as something like dissonance—listening intently for the moments when it seemed to fall into rhythm with the world around it. On other mornings he could think only of the stupidity of its song, and how mankind had only made them worse and worse. A mockingbird in an urban environment was like a broken childrens toy, non-stop shrieks and wails that don't change in sequence or meaning (because they are meaningless their meaning cannot change) until it's run through in its entirety.

The only redeeming quality of a mockingbird is its dedication as a parent. One needs only to have a mockingbird decide to build a nest outside the front door to find out how much they are driven to protect their offspring against any threat, real or perceived, regardless of size.

“Do you know—have I ever told you, I mean—or has she...do you know about my childhood at all?” he asked.

John thought about it briefly; it did not take him long to realize he knew almost nothing about W. T.’s life before XX. That part of W. T.’s life was a non-grata subject. John could vaguely recall some terse interactions they’d had when they were younger that might have, possibly, had to do with questions about his past, as such it made sense that the conversation had been put to rest and forgotten completely. It had eventually been ignored into non-existence—as though W. T.’s life had started in media res, age thirteen, with an amorphous and irrelevant backstory. “Not really. No,” John said, “I mean I figured you were some kind of undercover agent or something, don’t think you pulled the wool over my eyes. I just didn’t want to out you.”

John laughed half heartedly and then turned to look at W. T. He was seated, with his legs crossed *Indian Style* as it had been called in grade school. His posture was near perfectly erect - a straight back, shoulders pulled back. He had, somehow, lifted his toes over his calf on both sides, which John could hardly make sense of - it seemed either impossible, or incredibly painful. While he did not rule out the former (impossible things happen all the time) John wondered how much pain his friend was in at that exact moment. He watched as W.T. leaned forward and nearly touched his forehead to his toes, bouncing back and forth, each time getting his forehead slightly closer to his toes. Then he stopped and sat up, his face was red with exertion. “Do you know where I grew up? It’s a different place than where I was born—though I guess I did some growing up there too.” John was more than a little confused and started to think he was in a dream, that perhaps he’d been struck by some flying piece of debris in the storm and knocked unconscious. Then he began to think of the events of the night prior, and in his exhausted and groggy state wondered if that had been a dream, and maybe this was a dream within a dream, or a second dream of sorts. He looked at W. T. as though he were not real, with genuine confusion and a sort of placeless dread, and he remembered that W. T. had once told him to look at his hands if he ever thought he was dreaming, that for some reason it was nearly impossible to look at your hands, or was it that they didn’t look quite right if you were dreaming—if you were dreaming you would have the wrong number of fingers or your right and left would be reversed or something like that?

In any event he looked down at his hands. *Nothing special*.

“You aren’t dreaming, *Roap-a-Dope*.” W. T. said, and laughed a genuine laugh.

“I don’t know,” John said. His mouth tasted like dirt or sweat or as if he’d eaten a worm, he thought.

“What don’t you know?”

“Where you grew up,” he said, wanting to regain his wits. “Where were you—I mean, where did you grow up? Aren’t you from Wagner?”

“I was born there,” he said. Then sharply snapped, “No! Not yet!,” as John was reaching out towards the zipper opening of the tent, preparing to let in the sun. John retracted his hand and then shook it.

There was a lingering numbness in it from having slept in a certain position and it felt as if it had been slapped out of the air by W. T.’s command. “I was born there but my Mom and I left when I was just one,” he said. “I don’t know if she ever even told your mom this. She probably didn’t. And stop looking at your hands—I don’t even know if that’s true.”

John realized then he’d been looking for a nail long enough to bite. He put his hands back behind him, palms downward, propping his body up. “I’m sorry. About the tent I mean. What time is it?”

“We went to South America, to Argentina—but I don’t remember it at all. Too young. On my mom’s mom’s side we have a bunch of family there. When *paisans* immigrated back then, they did it in droves, and they either went to Ellis Island or Argentina. Why Argentina? I mean thousands upon thousands of dark skinned southern Italian *paisanos* went to Argentina. Sometimes one sister went to Ellis Island and one sister went to Argentina. My mom went down there to find them, and I was her carry-on...some guy brought her, paid our way and everything, said he was her uncle by which he meant like—third cousin, twice removed or some nonsense like that. When we got to Argentina he tried to fuck her while they were staying in some shithole motel, waiting on a phone call. I was like two, sitting in some crib, watching some guy try to rape my mother. I guess...you know...I don’t remember—like I said—but I guess that’s what happened—at least that’s what she told me. He tried to do it and she tried to stop him but I don’t really know what that means, I guess.”

At this point John made the decision to stay encouragingly quiet, the same way his head shrinker liked to do, only nodding or providing answers if absolutely necessary. He thought, *the only questions I will ask will be those that are absolutely necessary to display interest*. He decided to act under the foundational principle that every question W. T. asked rhetorically, and as a rule he did not respond to rhetorical questions unless he felt there was no way to proceed without an answer. He had never seen W. T. like this, ever. Communicating with him had always been a sort of exercise of the wits, so that at the end of a night of long discussion one felt as though they’d participated in a moderately strenuous workout, more cardiovascular than muscular, a training of mental stamina and endurance. It was obvious that this was something that W. T. had been thinking about saying for a long while, maybe the whole night—*Maybe he’d been sitting up all night listening to the rain and thinking about what he was going to say when I woke up*, John thought—*Maybe it had been even longer than that - days, weeks. It could have been something he’s been wanting to talk about since he was a child but hadn’t ever been able—Maybe I should have asked more.*

But in truth he knew that wouldn't have made a difference. It's possible that it would have made him even more withdrawn regarding his past. Small patches of light flickered on the semi-transparent green tent. Octagons and hexagons, and elongated triangles—all the effect of sunlight passing through tree branches and the still fairly thick foliage—one shape in particular looked like the business end of a trident with sharp pointed tines and somehow it was a bit threatening though I couldn't say how, precisely.

W.T. had been given the tent for Christmas two years prior. For a while he set it up in the room over the garage, the FROG, as it was commonly referred to in the Southeast, an acronym for “Finished Room Over Garage” that John found abundantly stupid as far as names go. Initially it had seemed like he was trying to show how much he appreciated the gift, but the more adamantly John pressed him to use one of the four other beds in the house, even if he wanted it moved into the Frog, John said he'd be more than happy to help him move it. But W. T. was happy where he was, and did not want to change his sleeping arrangements, not for all the pillows and sheets that make grown men discuss thread counts and the relative difference between Egyptian cotton and other variants and blends of fabrics until eventually John gave in and told him: *Fine, but if my Mom decides she wants to stop over you have to take it down before she gets here. She'll take the house away over a lack of hospitality.*

Abruptly, he started speaking again, “What was it Pappy said last night? Family don't mean nothin', except when it means everything. Well it turned out one thing was true—that fat bastard was family—we had a whole family of leather skinned Argentinian assholes down there. They all hated each other. They lived in a tiny village a few hundred miles from nowhere and fucked each other's wives or each other's goats, and they drank wine with their breakfast cereal. My mom knew she'd fucked up pretty bad, I imagine, but what are you gonna do?” He looked at John—John processed the question and reminded himself not to respond—he nodded instead, which he figured was the right decision because W. T. went on with his monologue. “She started tending bar for that same creepy guy who'd brought her down there, Pierro? Pablo? Pavarotti? Whatever his name was—she tended bar at a shithole establishment, with actual shitholes for bathrooms, *Turkish style* as they say in the architecture magazines. I was only two. She kept me locked in the back office, I don't have any memories but I have images, you know?” (John nodded.) “I used to stand on this little desk and I could see through a little square window at the top of the door that was sorta shaded green, the window, like it was made from a melted down wine bottle. In Argentina, man, they wake up at like 5 PM—it's too fucking hot all day long—they wake up at 5 and they don't get moving til 10 and the party really starts at 2 or 3 in the morning. I got green pictures of big titted Argentinian whores doing shit that we can't legally watch online here in the states. Uncle Paparazzi used to come in the back office shirtless and sweaty, say *Hola Pendito*, and I got these mental images of him opening up a giant jar of cocaine he kept back there, dipping this like mechanical pencil type thing in that filled up like a fucking syringe, and sniffing so much powder it would look like his eyes were going to explode when he finally looked up. These images man. They've been coming back to me. You know why?”

This one had John perplexed.

"Do you know why I've started remembering things...Roap-a-Dope? Do you remember how we got here? What do you remember?"

John realized he couldn't remember anything about getting there, or where they were, or why. The storm, vaguely. Something to do with Pappy, he thought. But he was almost certain, for a moment, that he was dreaming. Except he looked at his hands and saw all ten digits. And he was sure he could remember what had happened a few nights ago. "I need you to hit me," he said to W. T. And W. T. seemed more than happy to oblige.

"Do you remember now?" he asked, after he had hit John squarely in the shoulder with enough strength to knock him on his side and force him to prop himself back up on his hands.

John was astounded at the strength of his punch, from a seated, cross-legged, toes over calves position that seemed like something he'd seen on the cover of an anthology of Hindu texts, or more likely, on a commercial or pamphlet for some local yoga instructor who was a young, white woman and couldn't even pronounce the Bhagavad Gita, let alone recognize the difference between Buddhism and Hinduism. John suddenly found the pose dubious along with the story - but what had happened the night prior? He didn't remember anything new, nothing had changed except now there was a dull pain in his shoulder that hadn't been there previously. "Nope, didn't work," he said. "But I'm not dreaming, you're right." Then he made a move to open the tent again, watching W. T. as he did it, but this time W. T. did not stop him. "My birthday party is all I remember. I must have gotten drunk. Did I do the sad-drunk thing? Is that why we're here?" He unzipped the door panel just slightly and the bright, bright morning dashed through the opening, painting light on little specks of dust and dirt that floated in the air. It made a barrier between the two young men that seemed appropriate and let in a bit of cool, fresh morning air. He unzipped it no further.

All W. T. gave as a response was a brief shake of the head, as if to say, *Nope, still not there*. And then, he moved on from the topic of the previous night altogether and returned to his story. John didn't dare stop him. "I don't know, really if these are memories of images, or a single image and stories I've pasted on top of them like some sort of filter. But they are fucking vivid man, I can see that green glass clear as day—tiny square panel at the top of a old wooden door that grew tight in the humidity and shrank at night. Always making noises one way or another, expanding or shrinking.

"The point is, obviously I'm not in Argentina, and it wasn't the straightest line from there to here either. One picture I have is one night, I'm standing on the chair pulled up in front of the door, and I'm thinking by now I might be three or four—but fuck if I know, y'know—anyways the picture in the green glass isn't big titted Argentinian women, but Izzy, laying flat on the top of the bar, motionless, wearing her same dress with the denim top and the long white bottom. She still has the dress, except she has about 3 or 4 of them and I don't know if one is the original or if she always was wearing a

different one? In any event, she's wearing THAT dress laying on the bar, and I think she looks almost like Snow White, asleep on that table, basically dead looking. And on the far side of the bar, sort of halfway climbing up to get on top of her, but not quite there yet—and as far as I can tell this guy is about to do some bad shit to my Mom; you can imagine. So once I heard her shouting I must have started banging on that door as hard as I possibly could.” He paused for a moment and looked at the sheath of light that cut through the tent—John's face was hard to make out on the other side, as the light cut directly across his face, obscuring it, but he was grateful for it because he had a feeling that if he had seen John's face clearly he might not have been able to go on talking the way he was. “I've dreamed it so many times and each time there has been a different outcome and so I don't know if I banged enough so that she— they—stopped and came to the door and let me out and she said to him that they would meet again...because I've dreamed that it happened that way—or that they did not hear me because she was too loud, or worse that she did not but HE did hear me and went on screwing like that right in front of me, knowing I was watching...because I've dreamed that too, maybe more than the other—or finally, only once, I had a dream that my fat, sweaty uncle was behind me in the room, sniffing his mechanical pencil-like contraption, and I looked back at him and he looked at me and he said, *You'd have been better off with me, Pendito. Now you're really going to get fucked.* Which, crazy as it sounds, feels the most like the truth of all the dreams I've had, but what do I know—the whole thing might have been a dream. My mother did meet a man, though, who was a friend of the family, but not family proper. He had moved to Argentina from Italy only recently, and had decided it was not for him, but right before he was set to go back to Italy, he met my mother, and one night...maybe it was that night...he told her he wouldn't leave Argentina without her. Italians are really romantic like that—it's not just something made up—they are the craziest of all. At least Calabrians. He was tall and skinny with long hair and always kept a very clean shave and my first actual memory, not like a picture that I remember and draw conclusions from, but like real and proper memory, is of this Italian guy, Giuseppe, with long hair and dark skin and a guitar and a shitty, taped-up suitcase, walking up ahead of my mom and I, and he's walking way too fast for us to keep up but he keeps on shouting back for us to keep up, keep up...and we're running into a tiny airport, like really it's just one building with an airstrip outback, and I trip over something, some big old rock and my mom is trying so hard to keep up that she just drags me along for like a foot or two, scraping my knees to bloody hell, before she realizes I've become dead weight, and I'm crying and Giuseppe is yelling at my Mom in Italian, which neither of us understand, and he ushers us on to this tiny airplane that looks like it's taped together more than his suitcase is, and he throws his luggage in and my mom and I only have one bag, that's it, nothing else, and he throws that in too, and then he points at the door to the plane, and there is blood running down my legs but it doesn't matter we have to go, and he hops on up into the cockpit and sits right beside the pilot and then suddenly were flying over a quilted stretch of land that's greener than anything I'd seen the whole time I'd been in Argentina, and Giuseppe and the other pilot flew that goddamned plane all the way to the international airport and I couldn't believe it.

“My mom was fucking a pilot. At three or four years old—maybe even five by then—that was about the coolest thing in the whole damn world. Giuseppe could do no wrong.”

The beam of light was slowly traveling downward across the back of the tent, like a doctor’s slow moving scalpel, relieving the tension of whatever it had sliced through. It was also moving slightly from left to right, so that at present it’s diagonal column passed directly over W. T.’s shoulder, where a seatbelt strap sits, and John realized that if nothing was done, in very short order, it would slice right through his upper torso, and just underneath W. T.’s left arm—and even though he understood it to be harmless, he also felt a shameful amount of anxiety about the imagined decapitation that would take place.

Although he was certain that this was his real life—in other words, that his physical presence was the same one he’d been consciously inhabiting since birth, and that an action here would have permanent ramifications —meaning although he was certain it was not a dream, the world also had a surreal quality about it that he had felt before once when he was very, very tired, having been unable to sleep for three days straight—that had been a kind of insanity, he remembered. He’d also experienced a similar sensation the first time (and only time) he had ingested acid, which had been the greatest experience of his life until it became the most terrifying experience of his entire life—and he’d decided then that the greatest joy in life was not equal in value to the greatest terror in life, because he would never pay the cost of enduring what he had in order to enjoy what he had given another thousand opportunities. He had not yet figured out what to make of that equation.

In any case, the surreality of the moment was much more like the bout of exhaustion related insanity than the hall of mirrors that was LSD. Whatever it was—he felt a deep concern about the light that would soon be cutting through W. T. and decided to fully open the door now, so that the light would pour in on both of them, and whatever would happen, would happen.

When he moved to do so he didn’t ask W. T.’s opinion this time. Instead he was quick, unzipping the entire semi-circular flap so that it settled into a pile of ruffles at the foot of the tent. John was able to see and hear a more complete vision of their surroundings and found it to be paradoxically a new and intoxicating place while sharing many of the same features and elements that made up XX. It was like a version of XX that had been enhanced somehow—somewhere magical, hidden behind a wall of trees that no one had ever laid eyes on. The vibrancy had been dialed up so that the greens were greener, fuller, more lush—and through the leaves: a sky blue and bright as sundrenched ocean water on a remote pacific island never before explored. A blue you could see through—straight into the heavens in the middle of the day. Though he could not see any, he could feel the presence of perfect white clouds, popped kernels of corn that hung there, perhaps going in circles for all John knew. He could feel them as with the rest of the ecosystem, the trees alive with small, chipper birds; long, green-legged frogs; the nearly imperceptible background rustle of leaves crunching underfoot a doe, a young calf sniffing for the life-giving nourishment of her breast.

W. T. looked out, astonished. He saw and sensed different things than John. Each live oak seemed the largest he'd ever seen, they expanded out into the distance as far as the eye could see, each with a substantial circumference of free terrain around it so that its branches could dive into the soil and leap back out again like terrestrial sea snakes on ancient medieval maps. The tree they'd parked under was a broad hemisphere in which they were safe and protected. Each primary branch like a trunk in itself. He wondered on its age. He felt the warm December sun and how it seemed to fill him with energy, spilling in through the open doorway onto the three quarters of his body that was now exposed.

Pappy had described the island as an incredibly frightening place though. And the appearance was, no doubt, edenic—but there was a veneer-like quality to the crispness of it all as if stepping out of the tent and into the world would cause everything to begin to crumble—there was an element of foreboding somewhere far off in the back of his head (*was that perhaps the sensation that had made him start telling John the story, a story he thought he'd successfully forgotten? a memory he'd dedicated himself to exorcizing*). Pappy's notions did not match the appearances of the island, but then again his message, as cryptic as it had been, (half the murmurings of a senile *dementiatus* , as Pappy liked to call himself in moments of lucidity, the other half seemed pure *mystic folklore* as W. T. would later call it) his message had been clear—Not to be deceived, always wary of overconfidence, that the world of surfaces is a world of obscurity, twenty thousand miles wide and one inch deep.

At least, this was what W. T. had interpreted, he thought, closing his eyes as he thought so that he would be able to hear his own mind at work more clearly. Though, truth be told, W. T. didn't remember nearly as much of the previous evening as he'd insinuated when talking to John. That had come from somewhere else too.

He looked over at John, who appeared to be actively trying to restrain himself from speaking. “What is it man,” he said, “spit it out.”

John looked at W. T. in a sort of amazement, feeling a bit frightened now, but placelessly (he only knew for certain that W. T. was by no means the source of the fear, and if he were not there, the fear would be substantially more deep and concerning.

Oddly enough—it struck him that it was the fear one feels when they believe themselves to have been alone for a not insignificant duration, and then, suddenly, discovers that someone is nearby, maybe they've been nearby for some substantial amount of time, perhaps they've always been there and you have never ever looked—the kind of fear that is both present and retroactive in nature, so that one is experiencing both the fear of their current state, and a vast array of past fears all at once—as if the past was a sequence frames on a film reel, and upon finally recognizing the presence of another in the corner of the shot, one is left with the unfulfillable desire to rewind time and see how long the *other thing* has been there. The well earned jumpscare that slowly mutates into a full blown component of the shot. How well they know their role.

It was also a kind of fear he'd felt before when they used to attend parties at the Agrippa Lodge, where the Five had been holding parties since it had been erected in the year 1800 [18], and meetings disguised as parties (but never meetings that were simply meetings, it would be improper). Logan Wrathburn was always at the Agrippa parties. He was a boy who was exactly John's age and who the two families had, since they were young, assumed was a friend of John's because when they were infants, on a couple of occasions, they'd played with blocks together and cried when they were separated.

John hadn't ever mentioned the truth to his parents, that Logan Wrathburn was a deeply, deeply disturbed child who did things to animals in front of John that he still had nightmares about, mostly because John felt uncomfortable discussing the things that Logan had done in general, let alone to his parents, and also because he had found a way to keep Logan away from him at the parties and he no longer had to deal with him in any capacity. But there was a fear that he felt any time Logan was in the room—incredibly, he didn't even have to have seen him enter to feel his presence. If John walked into a room where Logan was, or had been recently, he instinctively shuddered, and this single pulse of fear ran through his body. And he was for some reason reminded of that feeling of fear, sitting in the tent with W. T. Though it had nothing to do with W. T. whatsoever.

It was as if Logan had been there, John thought—but he could not describe precisely in what capacity, or why.

Finally, John responded to W. T. "Did you make it to Italy?"

Part X: Section 1.1.0

Izzy was just shy of twenty years old when she left Argentina with the man named Giuseppe and her almost four year old son, William Theodore Grayson. She was in love, she thought, though she was aware enough to recognize she had fallen in love many times for someone who was only nineteen.

Most people seemed to talk about having two or three great loves throughout the course of their lives—all the rest of them sort of faded into a patchwork memory of *relationships* in general—but Izzy thought this was at least the fourth time she'd fallen head over heels in love and this time was very reminiscent of the others. She knew what people talked about when they talked about having butterflies in your stomach, and literally dreaming of someone's touch, someone's voice. Moreover, Giuseppe was far from wealthy, in fact he was quite poor from what she could tell, so she knew that this had not influenced her. And it was not purely sexual, she thought, it couldn't be purely sexual because she had enjoyed spending evenings with him doing nothing. She was in love, she convinced herself, and self-deception was a skill she had mastered. For the two months before they left for Italy their relationship consisted mostly of doing nothing (or rather of Izzy serving drinks while Giusé watched and occasionally picked at his guitar) because of Uncle Tete and his threats to take William and sell him if

she ever left the boy unattended to go “make fuck with that *gitarista*”. Uncle had gone crazy, real crazy, from the moment he realized she wasn’t flush with American money — *Argentina had been a mistake but she needed to forgive herself and move on*, she thought as the lights of Naples appeared, having been obscured by a cloud, in the dark black of night, through the airplane’s tiny window; Giuseppe tapped on the glass with his long, thin finger and said, “Napoli. Sento l’odore di figa già,” he said and laughed at a joke she couldn’t understand. Italian was such a beautiful language, and though she understood little of what he said when he spoke Italian, she enjoyed hearing it all the same. It was a musical language. Her grandmother had spoken Italian, she remembered, but she had been so young then that she really couldn’t recall anything specific. And her grandfather had made it a matter of law that none of his children spoke anything but English—her mother told a story about the time her brother had been caught with an Italian Bible, of all things, because he could easily translate the passages. Her mother said she had not known her father to be a violent man until that day, and after it was over something irreparable had been done between the two men in her life. They no longer spoke to one another, and that had lasted until her father’s death. He’d gone to the grave without ever broaching the topic with his only son. Those were Grayson qualities, she thought, but perhaps they were DiBosco too.

Giuseppe spoke English well enough that it didn’t matter. And she would learn to speak Italian in no time. She’d already picked up a few things here and there. “Ti amo,” was the most common phrase she spoke, which was so similar to the Spanish for the same, and had been uttered thousands of times over the past month and a half. Sometimes she felt like it was all they had to say to each other. They were truly living on love, sometimes she thought. Though, again, self-deception and daftness are not the same things. While Izzy was a pro at the former, it would be a mistake to call her daft. Stubborn, more like it, and in love with love.

He’d told her that they would stay with his friends when they arrived. They were musicians too, and there was an apartment in the city where they all lived when they needed to, from what he had said. His English, it seemed, only became a barrier in certain conversations—the specifics of their living arrangements being one of them. But his reassurance was sufficient, they would have a bed, a roof over their head, a shower to themselves, and even a giant tub, he said, that was made of mosaic tiles—*the most beautiful bathtub in the entire world*, he told her, and if she began to ask more he would kiss her passionately while William, out of embarrassment, looked as far away as was possible, occasionally pinching her if she was in reach to let her know he didn’t like it.

One of the friends was very wealthy, and it was his family’s house (or apartment) and they let them use it for free for the most part. It was where he had been living before he left for Argentina. He spoke about his friends hesitantly, and Izzy had a premonition that the apartment would be nothing like the image she’d constructed based on his reports. When she asked him if they knew about William he pretended not to understand the question despite the clearly indicative hand gestures she made. At the International Airport she found a pocket dictionary for sale - a fairly standard English to Italian. She

gave it to William to play with in the stroller (which she'd also stolen from Uncle Tete before they left that warm and foggy night), then she and William walked out of the store together, his studious eyes gazed over the pages and Izzy wondered if he might actually be reading. By the looks of it he was reading intently. But she knew it certainly couldn't be the case.

She still couldn't figure out the reasons for Giuseppe's trip to Argentina, and that had been a concern—but one that she'd had to overlook. The choice was between the good looking, dark haired musician (who on the one hand wasn't a relative, but on the other hadn't tried to force himself on her, physically), and the overweight, disconcertingly sweaty and hairy relative who kept telling her that her son (who was barely three at the time) was gay. It hadn't been too difficult to decide.

When she asked Giuseppe about his reasons for coming, she always sensed the deception. She was not dumb. At first he'd said he'd come to work, but he hadn't worked for a single day since she'd met him. Every day he came to the bar and watched soccer and drank beer to pass the time until she got off and, if William was asleep they would make love right there in the bar and fall asleep on the hardwood and wake up and make love again, continuously, until they heard the rooster crow. He was a fast lover, but passionate in his own way, and they always got plenty of sleep between the five minute sessions. He was passionate in his own way, by which she meant he liked to choke her, passionately, and she found she enjoyed it—there was something *death-defying* about it—and it also was this action, the move to begin choking her, that made him come so quickly. So it never lasted long, ten or fifteen seconds tops. Though of course she had wondered what would happen if he didn't come so quickly.

The rooster seemed to always be fifteen minutes ahead of the sun. Then Giusé would go back to his apartment (another friend's place) and she would carry William to the small room upstairs, in Uncle's house, where she would sleep a bit more, until William woke her up; then she would spend the day following William around the town, looking at all the local animals and luxuriously slow pace of the Argentinian town that seemed to be solely composed of her male family members and their spouses or mistresses. Where were all of the women? When they talked about their sisters and mothers it was always in a nostalgic way, as if one day they'd all decided to up and abandon the men together, in unison. When she thought about it, it was a very simple and dreary life they lived. There was a shop and a bar where they served themselves, trading the same bills back and forth between one another day after day and complaining about the government. Every so often there would be someone new who came to the town for one reason or another, and they would stay for a week or two at the most; by the end they would be drunk all the time, doing nothing, and then one day they would just be gone, that was it. It was an odd lifestyle, but there was something to be admired about it all the same. They were farmers, if you asked them, but it was very rare she saw anyone tending to the orchard. The chickens ran about the town like they owned the village, walking in and out of the bar as they pleased. There had been three large pigs that lived in a pen on the outer edge of the town. They seemed to belong to an old man with three teeth, who always sat beside them smiling and ushering Izzy and William over, but they were mean bastards, and the old man would motion for William to go play with the pigs, giving

him a piece of stale bread or a rotten apple and then he would try to pinch Izzy's nipple and laugh. She and William stayed away from them when they walked around town for the most part - especially once the smallest of the three pigs bit William on the arm and left him with a scar that seemed like it might be around for a while.

She was glad to be out of that place. Glad to be rid of Uncle. She'd never heard a man joke about rape so much.

Giuseppe had been a breath of fresh air. He had a beautiful voice, and was strikingly good looking, and he kept himself clean-shaven - which was what had at first made him stand out. Being clean-shaven had the additional effect of making one seem recently bathed, which was a quality that many of the bar patrons did not particularly exude.

When she had asked him why he had come to such a small town outside of Buenos Aires, Giuseppe answered casually that one night in Naples he had been at a bar with his friends, who had been his friends all his life, and as they sat around drinking they'd begun rattling off their dreams and places they wanted to go and visit, every one seemed to have a dream of a place that they wanted to see but you could hear when they spoke about it that they knew, each and every one of them knew, that they would never actually leave Naples and do the things that they dreamed of—this was why their dreams were so vivid. They allowed their imagination to dwell in the realm of the impossible so that they could have the safety and comfort of the possible, which was a prison, Giuseppe said, he had realized that night that they were living in a happy, satisfactory prison of their own design. Eventually a girl who he had known since *Asilo*, who had lived a very difficult life according to the stories Giuseppe had heard, but who nonetheless remained an unfettered dreamer, called out to Giuseppe and asked him to share his passion. He was caught off guard, because the girl had always been very quiet, but on this topic had become emboldened and even exuberant, exclamatory — *he was the one who was the 'artist' of the group*, she'd said, *surely he had aspirations to pursue his art in some beautiful foreign place, where had he dreamed of going his whole life? Why hadn't he chimed in yet?*

In that group he was considered the artist, because he wrote songs and carried around a guitar, but he'd never really embraced the moniker, and felt a bit phony when people called him the artist. If he were a famous musician he would have been a pop-star, a sell-out, no Bob Dylan.

In any case, Giuseppe realized that he'd never gone so far as to let himself dream in that free and unrestrained way, because he believed happiness was right there, where they were, and certainly it would be hard to find a more wonderful place, besides perhaps Milan or Florence, than sitting right there on that stool where he sat, considering the absurdity of talking about dreams without any intention of committing to them. The bar happened to have a large map of Buenos Aires on its wall, because the owner's brother had moved there, to live with a distant relative.

“I didn’t know that everyone had dreams like that,” Giuseppe told Izzy. It was the third or fourth day he’d come to the bar, sat in the same stool, and drank the cheap local ale until he’d gotten drunk enough to start calling her *Beautiful*, not as an adjective, but as though it was her name. “You understand Beautiful. Of course you do. I suddenly felt like I’d been missing out on something critical, some piece of me was empty that shouldn’t have been. Though as I’ve explained, this trip has taught me I was wrong about that. I asked the girl to give me a dart, because I’d seen someone do it once before in a movie; I took the dart and flung it at the map, aiming generally for Buenos Aires, you see—and this town is where I landed, a good distance from the bullseye, which was Buenos Aires, because I was drunk.”

He decided that night at the bar, after a long conversation with the girl who had provoked him and a good deal of cocaine, and under the impression that they would have sex later that night if he kept up with the devil-may-care façade, that he was a man of action. He told her that the difference between him and the rest of the men in the bar was that he did not talk so much nonsense. He made up his mind, and he acted.

“And it was really like that,” he concluded, looking deep into Izzy’s almost green eyes. “I saved up money for a plane ticket; travel arrangements. I told my boss I was going on holiday, and I left. He said he would not save me a job. I said, what for? And then I came here.”

Something didn’t make sense with the whole story, but Izzy didn’t want to see it. Or if she did see it she didn’t want to deal with it. She needed to believe him in order to keep her own regret, about her own decisions, from haunting her when she slept, as had been the case for weeks. “Did you sleep with the girl?” Izzy asked, caring less about the answer than she did about the need to keep the conversation moving along, keeping it from turning to her story—avoiding any discussion of who she had been, why she was there.

“No,” he replied. “Her boyfriend came to pick her up on a Vespa an hour later. But she was not for me. I was so drunk and in a state of total bliss—I tried to go to a swingers club but they didn’t even let me in the door.”

Izzy laughed with uncertainty, and then went to the other end of the bar where a tiny, old man in a green sweater that was made more of holes than it was of cloth, held out an empty mug of beer and repeated her name in a moderately loud, but monotone voice. The way he pronounced it, it sounded like he was calling her *Easy*. “Eeasyy ...” he swayed a bit in his seat and then again, “Eeasyy.” He smiled in the way that only long gone drunks can smile, as if what he saw in front of him was a different world altogether than the dingy dive bar, something gorgeous that only he could see. His name was Ernesto Quaricci and he looked to be one hundred and ten years old, give or take.

When she took his mug from his hand it was as if he didn’t notice, he left his hand hanging there in the air, holding nothing, grasping at nothing, until she returned with a full mug and set it down in front of

him. The sound of the glass hitting the solid wooden countertop roused him and he looked at her for the first time, first breasts, then face. “No money,” he said after he’d guzzled half the mug. He proceeded to pull his pockets inside out as if to prove he was not lying.

When finally she gave up on trying to throw him out (he was impenetrable in his semi catatonic state, and Izzy did not really care about Uncle’s profits) she walked back to Giuseppe and found him sleeping, his head propped against the wall, a bit of drool forming in the corner of his mouth. She decided to leave him be, but after he did not move even slightly for nearly forty five minutes, she put her finger beneath his nose to check that he was still breathing and this woke him.

Part X: Section 1.1.1

Giuseppe was a man who could fall asleep almost anywhere, immediately, and enjoy the still, sound sleep reserved for saints and psychopaths. One should always be skeptical of anyone who can sleep so easily, for a subconsciousness without guilt is necessarily deficient.

In the same way that one need not be religious to understand the inherent value of certain moral codes, particularly that one code that has been deemed primary, treat others as you, yourself, wish to be treated [\[19\]](#) —just as one can be an atheist, agnostic, satanist, or worshiper of the ancient Norse gods and comprehend the value of the precept, one need not be anything whatsoever to understand that we are born with original sin. In fact, it is the Catholics who pretend that this fundamental fault can be washed away in infancy, a soul redeemed before it has even fully taken shape, it is they who have the poorest understanding of the truth of the matter.

Consciousness itself needs no metaphor, no apple and no tree, to make its basic amoral composition clear as swamp water. Consciousness is not good or bad, rather it seems to be quite clearly *good* AND *bad*, and any number of other adjectives that describe the infinitely complex and (like it or not) instinctually selfish core of human nature. In this way, original sin is an apt metaphor for that which we must actively strive to counteract, to battle, to wage war against if necessary.

Primary Documents: The Principles of W. T. Grayson

- 1) Never, under any circumstance, tell yourself a lie.
 - a) This presents a paradox, of course, as your’s is the only mind that can determine, with any degree of accuracy, whether you are telling yourself a lie. To some extent it seems like an impossibility.

- b) In order to overcome this obstacle one must imagine they are writing a letter themselves from a future state (as all states of being already in existence, the truth is available to you). In the letter, tell yourself what you already know, but have not yet learned. This is a form of freely available time travel.
- 2) View others in this simple way: Either, one is an extension of yourself - treated commensurately without exception; or one is nothing to yourself.
- 3) Something once came from nothing. Thus nothing must be treated with the caution one adopts in approaching an abyss, from which entire worlds may emerge at any time.
- 4) You can always change your mind. You are never pot committed to any incorrect position.
- 5) Reject dogma and ideology as if they are born from Satan's wretched, widened maw. All who do not reject dogma and ideology out right...

Primary Documents: Notebook #214

The great works (of literary Art) share a common denominator→ they read as though born out of an urgent necessity.

{simple q: can this be faked??}

Since stories have existed and been consumed, which is to say since before the recorded oral tradition → {arguably there is a need to travel back thirty to forty thousand years ago, consider the cave paintings of Lascaux-[demands deconstruction of story→separate lecture]} and completely independent of geography or culture, as we stretch the metaphorical canvas so wide we must speak of the most ancient human acts of artistic creation known by human kind, these in conjunction with abstraction and representation, everything that was Great

++here we must agree that it is not true that { *everything is great* }, in fact quite importantly, this is where I seek to differentiate that which is *Great Art* with that which is merely content, even that which is good content, entertaining content, content that satiates a fundamental need for story but is. not. ART.—a line that seems to have been blurred for some , but can be clearly distinguished by the degree to which it [*ART*] was born of pure need.

[REFERENCE: Roberto Bolaño→prolific author, undoubtedly one of the finest writers of Latin American prose ever published, remained in relative obscurity, jotting down fragments and putting together the occasional short story, living life so that he may understand it, as it were. *How vain to sit down and write without having first stood up to live* , something along those lines, truly in his blood a writer's writer. Boom, his liver is failing, and he is not of the class that gets to skip the line for a liver transplant, of

course. Now he is on the run from death, the hot breath of its fiery maw nipping at his very heels. 1) Los Detectives Salvajes 2) 2666 → [ART] {literary} now and forever elements of the landscape where great writers go to remind themselves what can be done.

This is where we aim to land. Nowhere but here.

-

The necessities of our nature have evolved, mutated, stagnated, digressed, been misinterpreted and in adequately nurtured, but with regard to *art* they contain the universal definition within themselves. “I think therefore I am” is more accurately stated “I need, therefore I am.” {Perhaps, then, it is necessity which is art, and not that true art is by nature necessary: or perhaps this is a redundancy.}

→ The fundamental paradox remains the same. Great Art is made because it must exist. In another mode of articulation: it did exist; it will exist; it cannot fail to exist. {Abusing the metaphor → Great Art is in the DNA of humanity. How it presents itself, is diagnosed, treated and ultimately preserved is a matter of the subject’s will. The artist → The subject}

→NB: The artist as conduit is both irrelevant and imperative. Like all things from which life springs forth, the vehicle of creation is necessary, but relevant only to the extent that it impacts its creation. The titular Dr. Frankenstein has little bearing on the actions and decisions of his creation—though one can imagine a world in which his role extends far beyond that of the creator. So too does the author of a novel have a choice in the matter.

How should one make this decision?

→HERE, Finally we learn the meaning of art

***If you can see how that can be, and in fact must be the case: then, and only then, will you find yourself riding alongside

The components of an epic poem, for example, remembered and passed forward, was the vital essence of what needed to be said. Even the flourishes are enlivened by the desperate beauty comparable to the mating rituals of male birds of paradise (and not only them, there are many species that share this instinct for the beautiful) — beauty bound by necessity is the realization of impermanence, the destruction of self, the definition of the sublime. And it is fundamental to true writing, by which I mean art. It is what we shall pursue in this very hall.

Primary Documents: Take Home Quiz #1

Answer the following questions as honestly as you can. Avoid all abstraction, respond with clear sentences. Use proper grammar unless the response requires you to use a particular vernacular - if you are speaking with a particular vernacular make it known.

1. Invent one word that does not exist but should.
 - a. Provide the word, the part of speech, and the definition.
 - b. Use the word to create one sentence.
 - c. Use the word in the title of a poem.
 - i. Do not write the poem, but write the first line of the poem, and give any pertinent details about the structure and expectations of the poem so that if you were to die someone could write the rest of the poem based on your explanation.
2. Choose a bookshelf in your house—write the first and last sentence of seven books (selected at your discretion).
 - a. If you do not have seven books in your house but you DO have a video game console—drop this course immediately.
 - b. If you do not have seven books in your house for legitimate reasons (financial, disability related, etc.), respond here with your school P.O. box to receive a seven book, “Bookshelf Starter Kit” from me
3. Schopenhauer, Cioran, and Camus get into a fight. Who wins, and how?
4. Write five hundred words about the average working day of a professional welder living in Portland, Maine. Remember, this is NOT an extraordinary day.
 - a. Describe the process of researching for this piece.

Part X: Section 1.0.2

It would much later be revealed that W. T. *had* been reading that Italian dictionary that Izzy had stolen; or rather, that Izzy had lifted from the airport convenience shop, using W. T. as an unknowing accomplice and shield. He had been reading a great many things, and though it is hard to know exactly how young he was when he began to read, as he didn’t speak a word aloud until he was seven, from time to time in his adult life he would, for no reason at all, write out a word that came to his mind without knowing why or what it meant. The majority of them, his psychiatrists were very quick to note (he saw a number of them), were Spanish, and not just Spanish, but Argentine-Spanish [\[20\]](#), with only a small number of Italian words popping up here and there. *Bulín. Quilombo. Lupanar. Atrenzo*.

When he looked up the words, though, it was a mystery to him as to where they had come from—why he was expelling them later in life, like the playground legend of the splinter that spends years passing through your body, and if pitched on the wrong trajectory, may very well pierce your heart when least expected, but with any luck the splinter usually finds its way out via some painful and inexplicable pustule that will only arrive when one has long since forgotten the splinter or the playground legend altogether. Though W. T. never did forget that particular legend. Secretly, until it was dispelled by a somewhat inappropriately hysterical medical doctor, when W. T. was in his early twenties he had deep anxieties about several particularly large splinters he remembered having pierced him as a child—and

though none of them were even remotely pointed in the direction of his heart, his real fear was that it would be the large artery that runs down one's forearm, the one people use to kill themselves, that would be severed. He had nightmares of it—and he'd memorized a quick and succinct explanation that he would deliver to John in the event that it did happen, if he knew he was bleeding out and there was nothing to be done. He wanted to make sure people knew it was the god damned splinter, and not some act of martyrdom.

Though objectively he should have known quite obviously that such a thing was ridiculous and impossible, and that his worries were foolish, it is incredible to realize the weight of assumptions we carry forward from childhood into adulthood. All of it locked in like law—the same reason people who were abused or molested as children can never truly rid themselves of the scars—a child's brain is a powerful instrument, and W. T. was of the opinion that the human race, in general, was far too flippant with their youth in this regard.

It's true, he had many odd ideas, but then again - he had an unbelievably odd childhood. You see?

The speaking thing, for example. When they were in Italy his mother had convinced herself that she could homeschool him, despite the conditions of their life being absolutely uncondusive to anything remotely close to an education. Izzy's intuition about their new place of residence had been correct, in that it wasn't the grand palace of freedom and endless opportunity that Giuseppe had sold to her night after night, whispering in her ear as they fell asleep half-nude on the beer and liquor soaked floor behind the bar. It was truly a large, magnificent estate, that much was true. It was owned by the family of his friend, Tino, whose father worked for the Italian government in a vague way—though they also made it clear that his money was private money. He seemed to be, as far as Izzy could tell, a sort of contract negotiator for the government. In their permanent employ, but as a contractor himself. There were frequent insinuations that he was a very violent man. But Izzy had met him three times at least and she'd never gotten that impression. He had been kind and inquisitive. He loved to talk about America, and repeated the same few American catch phrases whenever given the opportunity [\[21\]](#), and he complimented Izzy for finding a way through her difficult life with a growing boy. The main surprise, which Giuseppe swore had not been the case when he'd left for Argentina, was that the house was occupied by his friend's family again. They had moved back from Monaco for reasons that were also unclear. There was Tino's father and mother, plus his two younger siblings, and a pet cat that was the size of a pit bull who became quite fond (and even protective) of William.

This meant that everyone else was relegated to the pool house, which was where Tino was living. It was not meant to house five adults and a quickly growing child. It had a single bedroom, which Tino did not give up, forcing Izzy to take her showers and get dressed in the semi public bathroom in the living area/converted game room. This didn't bother her, but it did bother her when Giuseppe called her a *porca putana*, for walking around wearing nothing but a towel, as though there were some other option that she was not considering.

They were illegal immigrants, W. T. and Izzy—this was the reason she gave herself for not coming up with something better for W. T. (educationally speaking)—but thinking about it only made her feel more guilty. She'd known as much when she took in hand the fake passports that Giuseppe had acquired for her and W. T. before leaving Argentina. And she especially knew it when she felt the scrutinous glare of the cold, calculated customs officials, waiting for what seemed like several minutes (but was in fact no more than twelve or thirteen seconds) at the kiosk before the stern officer let her into the country.

She couldn't bear the guilt about the school situation. She'd kept her child basically imprisoned when they lived in Argentina - he'd gotten older now, though, and it had become less tenable to put him somewhere safe and let him run wild. After only two months of *homeschooling* she began plotting to get him into a proper school of some sort—she didn't much care how, though in large part this indifference was because she didn't even have options yet; there wasn't a clear path forward. And still he wasn't talking.

“We'll teach him to be a musician,” said Giuseppe's mohawked friend in clear English (including a slight Humphrey Bogart accent, that could be attributed to the source of his language education). His nickname was *Tre-Cento* or ‘Three Hundred’, which was supposedly a reference to the number of women he'd slept with.

“How will you teach him anything?!” Izzy spit back, “He can't speak a single word. Non parla niente!”

As more time went by and he remained silent, the pressure began to mount and at some point during his fifth year of life, after a full year and some living in the tight quarters of the pool house, Izzy made the decision to move back to the United States—the reasons for which are both incredibly obvious and almost impossible to state clearly. Among them was the fact that young W. T. was not yet speaking in any language, not English or Italian. He was incredibly adept at sign language, something he'd picked up while looking through a book: “Which really should have made them wonder,” W. T. said. “How was I reading the book on sign language if I couldn't speak ANY language? But there are so many questions from that period of time that I can't begin to answer. This one is low on the list.” What he was really stuck on was the fact that there were a large number of adults around him at this time.

“Yeah, adults, sure, in their early twenties - but being in your early twenties in the late-eighties was like being in your early thirties since like the late aughts, practically speaking. Economically, emotionally, psychologically—this generation was raised by people who remembered World War II, and then were too late for the hippie movement, squares of the rightest angles—at least in America. In Italy, it's hard to say what they were—they were Italian I guess—life in the shadow of Mussolini, either playing dumb or still in hiding, the days of young Berlusconi, what that must have been like? Though I suppose, to be honest, the defining factor with this particular group was that their parents had money, these were Italians who'd somehow profited from the war—and it turned out that those were not honest

dollars, and the men who made them were not the most honest men. I can still see the grand bookshelves in the big house, we were allowed inside for a late lunch, from two until four, daily.

People think of Italians and their wine, and that's not a joke, they drink red wine like water and no one much notices. But nobody really mentions the grappa, which is a natural byproduct of the wine, and needs to be consumed in a ration that is fairly consistent with regard to the amount of wine being produced; no one wants a surplus economy, right? That's how the Casadoro family saw it, at least—so by the end of lunch time, most days, the whole world just needs to take thirty or forty minutes just to digest and drink some water, by which I mean red wine, and sober up a bit. My mother never really picked up Italian. She knew enough to get around, but that was about it. Everyone wanted to speak English to her—and they almost all spoke English, even if they varied in their degrees of mastery. It might as well be a second national language among the wealthier Italians. Giuseppe, who only played the part, but was in fact a poor southern Italian, who'd been mistakenly brought into the group when they were too young to know better, and besides, these were leftists when their father was out of the house. As soon as he closed the doors, headed to some nefarious business meeting, usually something having to do with building things or tearing things down, his son would start screaming in the general direction of the front of the house: *Menaggia, 'sta fascista! Tutti FASCISTI!!* The doors were very thick, and even if his father had stood on the other side of the door and pressed his ear against it, the wood was thick and double paned—yes, double paned wooden doors...I don't know the answer to that one. Insulation, I would guess. Eventually someone would calm him down and then they'd meander back to the pool area. There were four of them, plus my mother and I, who lived in the pool house together (though there was not a day that did not also include at least a guest—sometimes several).

Also strange was that two of them, Mirco and Marco, had their own pool houses respectively, that we would sometimes visit, but never when their parents were home—and as soon as it got close to time for their parent to return home, they always decided to come back to *Il Castello Casadoro* and chose to sleep on one of the couches in the pool house, or on the plush, thick green carpet that was the most American thing I saw the whole time I was there. Every day, like some kind of joke, they would think of a new reason they could not be at the house that afternoon. Someone they didn't want to see was coming over. The cleaning lady was going to show up early the next morning. They'd left their hash at *Castello Casadoro* and needed to come and get it anyway. Every. Single. Day. It was amazing, Mirco and Marco could have pulled it off for the rest of their lives. It didn't matter how ridiculous or meaningless the excuse was, they would say anything and that would be sufficient to stop anyone from questioning it.

“Tino had a giant VW van, I didn't know they made them big like that, and so long as you fit in the van you were *staying at Casadoro for the night or finding your own ride home—I mean...*

“I don't understand why it matters that I was five. It's like my memory turned on with that fucking dictionary—I remember those days better than any of them, I'm sure—the ones who are still alive. That's what I was getting to before I was interrupted, but yeah it turns out I understood Italian,

could read it and comprehend it, at a level that was likely higher than most of the inhabitants of the house. They all thought I was mentally deficient, I just didn't particularly want to speak...

"I don't know why. But anyways listen because this shit gets weirder before we get out of there.

"No.

"Not quite so directly, but I suppose you could say so. Sure. But still that's not really what I was getting at by—

"Yes, that is the whole point. And really, when it comes right down to the ugly truth, my mom had become a sort of distorted version of a housewife for all intents and purposes. For all of the boys-slash-men there. Tino was the worst, because it was at least theoretically, his house—and it wasn't as though his parents were, you know, the type of people who wanted to make sure their kid didn't turn out to be a spoiled, rich, asshole. It was somehow as though the opposite were the case. One day, for example, there was a girl hanging around named Sara Gattina. I later found out she was fifteen years old, which makes the whole thing that much worse. Walking beside the pool she crossed paths with Tino, who managed to simultaneously push her into the pool while untying the string to the bottom half of her bikini.

"His laugh was nasal and obnoxious—a jackal, a scavenger's laugh—but even worse was his father's laugh, which was predatory and angry—like a prehistoric wolf is the best I can imagine—it boomed down from above, where he stood gazing down from his veranda, drinking something dark, smoking a cigar, his arm around a woman who was not his wife and she was laughing too. Terrible beasts of men, they were.

"I believe *Gattina* was in fact a nickname, not her real last name, because people often called her just by *Gattina* [\[22\]](#), and *gattina* translates to kitten, or little cat. The resemblance was only in the eyes, but it was there - her eyes were quite stunning, large green irises with dark black almonds at their center. All of the men, including Giuseppe, would speak loudly about her large breasts—all in Italian, of course—the slow, slurred *dialetto Napolitano*—which may as well have been a different language from the standard Italian, which is what you'd hear in Florence or Bologna where the language is spoken in a near textbook fashion—so that Izzy, Mom...so she wouldn't be able to understand them. They were oblivious to the fact that I could understand though, just as oblivious as my mom. All of them, I mean every single one of them—they didn't...It was as if I didn't—exist—at all. It was as if I was translucent, meaningless. As if there weren't an action I could take or a thing I could do...besides the ultimate step of becoming human—shifting from the wooden toy into Pinocchio—speaking, that is...there was nothing besides language that could make me real. It was both a superpower and a curse. It was also horrifying...to be nothing, you know? To know so much and be so little. Like I was a

book. Agency, I had none. And Izzy, Ma, was this shitty Italian musician's s-s-S-SEX SLAVE. And I was nothing. Mute. Broken.

"Inside, I was quite resentful. But still I did not speak. I don't know if it was by choice or not, I assume the latter. I assume that I could not speak for some reason, despite comprehending more than most adults around me. Some barrier existed between my mind and my mouth, something that needed only to be formally ruptured, in a ceremony of sorts, which would soon occur."

Finally, W. T. stopped talking.

He reached to his left and found a small brownish green bag that John had not yet noticed. He opened the top of the bag which was cinched tight with a cord and a latch, above which a rectangular flap with a strip of velcro could be pulled over to protect water from entering through the cinched opening. The interior opening, to put it bluntly, looked like a puckered anus when it was closed so tight like it had been—when it was loosened though, one thought of a pouch of gold coins, a fat aristocrat who tosses the bag, slightly open, to a table of hard working peasants, so that some of the coins scatter and roll off the table onto the dirty floor to be picked up by their silently astounded children, in a tavern somewhere with swinging doors...long, long ago, and an unimaginable distance from where John Roapes stared, dumbstruck by the story being told by his best and only friend, who he now felt he barely knew, his W. T., who had reached into the bag and withdrawn four bright orange clementines, tossing one, underhand, over to John.

Just like a leather pouch of gold.

And just like gold, John noticed, staring down at the small, round object in his hand—the clementine had a distinct luminescence to it. It shone on the skin of his palm—a shade of orange far too bright to be attributed to a reflection. There was a source.

Part X: Section 1.1.2

Some ten or eleven odd years later, by which time the doublewide on XX Island had come to represent, for Izzy Grayson, her '*new life*' and perhaps more importantly it was the embodiment of her and her son's restabilization—far from perfect, but sufficient; it was well maintained and disguised as a home with raised supports, the addition of a pitched and shingled roof, even an extension off the back that served as a deck. James had even offered to put in a hot tub, which was ridiculous in the semi-tropical humidity of XX, where nine months out of the year she was able to wear short sleeves and cut off jean shorts, where she'd had to finally give in and learn to wear contact lenses, because it was commonly so muggy that her glasses would fog up as soon as she stepped outdoors. She'd graciously turned down the hottub, and pretended not to notice the inappropriate placement of his hand as he stepped past her to point at the back deck, indicating where a hot tub might go. She knew it wasn't right, and that another

woman would have slapped him or threatened to tell his wife—but coming from where she’d been, James’ futile attempt to disguise his intentions was borderline noble. Not that it justified anything, no.

“Blue House” which is what she called it, (not “the double-wide”) and which was a name that stuck even after she repainted the exterior the current light—or more accurately *pale* —yellow of sweet corn picked from the stalk, was initially painted a bright, sky blue that seemed almost inappropriate at night. A pure daytime blue that was enough to drive Izzy to begin painting landscapes shortly after they’d moved in.

Painting had been one of Izzy’s favorite activities as a child, and she’d shown genuine talent, which she had pursued until her mother was remanded to the mental institution at Wagner, and her life began to take a new, unanticipated path.

Wagner’s Psychiatric Ward was legendary. The medical school was renowned for its School of Psychiatry, under which there was a well-funded academic practice that dealt in Psychoanalysis—and Wagner was known specifically for the interesting research that came out of the synthesis and collaboration between the two programs, which were traditionally considered to be not-so-secretly at odds with one another, but had (particularly in the mid to late 70s) pioneered some radical treatments for what was then called manic depression (and now called bi-polar disorder) that did not segregate the biological from the psychological as explicitly as common practice dictates.

Unfortunately, scandal overwhelmed Wagner, particularly The Adelaide Renfield School of Psychiatry and in an effort, it is presumed, to save the reputation of his lover who was the Dean of the ARSoP, a young medical student in the midst of a complete psychotic breakdown, attempted to burn up the entire archive of patient records (which is, in and of itself, a unique and multifaceted mystery because no one—no group, that is—not the FBI or CIA, not the NSA, not the KGB, not even the Wagner Police Department had any active cases in which they were investigating the Renfield School of Psychiatry—though theories are not in short supply [\[23\]](#)), which was in the basement of the building, and either failing to understand basic thermodynamics, or with completely sadistic disregard for life, the young student, rumored to have looked like a smooth skinned version of the older Willem Dafoe, ended up burning the entire facility to the ground - in an event now unoriginally referred to as The Massacre at Renfield.

Most of the medical staff and students survived. Though the student himself is said to have lit the fire, and then entered some sort of psycho-paralysis, in which (on the tapes of the incident that could be recovered - the video feed actually piped into a security room that was located off premises) the man stood in place, as though his feet were glued to the ground. It is said that he attempted to move, looking like one might imagine a rat looks after finding themselves caught in a glue trap. Realizing his legs would not budge he slipped into a state of complete catatonia and as the fire consumed the room around him he didn’t move so much as a muscle, it is said the tape shows, until at some point he collapses in

the smoke and poof, his body ignites in flame—some sort of internal combustion. Needless to say, that story has grown more and more gruesome over the years, but it is suspicious that of the tapes of the events that exist (and they do exist) the basement tapes have never been made visible to the media, let alone the public. It gave W. T. the shivers just to speak about it, the once or twice he did.

What is known is that the fire alarm had gone off as expected and allowed adequate time to exit the building and watch as the red vines of fire chase black clouds of smoke out the windows of the first floor, then second, and finally once it had reached the third story, the whole building was a giant red bush of flickering flame. Many of the patients were able to survive too - those who were not left behind in their restraints by cowardly attendants, or so sedated that they did not wake from the asphyxiation until at the very last moment before their heart stopped beating they opened their eyes, and in the moment before they lost consciousness for the final time, surely assumed they had died and gone to hell.

Very little is known about the life of Darla Grayson (née DiBosco) following her placement among the patients at Renfield Psychiatric—but it is certain that was present during the fire—both footage from the scene and first hand accounts indicate that she'd spent almost the entire day on the third floor in "The Quiet Area" which was mostly filled with depressive patients who had no energy to talk, or patients who had lost the ability to speak for a variety of reasons—some psychological in nature, meaning they physically had the capacity to speak, maybe they even had spoken previously, but simply wouldn't allow it. One very old man had skin that seemed translucent, no matter where you looked on his body you could see dark highways of veins just beneath the skin. The skin was not blotchy, or liver spotted—it was a sort of flat, milky-white that seemed to let light pass through it. His eyes were always bloodshot, and his skin seemed to hang from his body like something he could take on and off if he wanted to. He'd been a criminal of some sort, you could almost sense it by the way he sat in his wheelchair—head tilted slightly backwards, one hand on top of the other resting in his lap. You got the feeling he was looking at something intently, but something that wasn't actually there. What made him particularly unique among the patients, though, was that he was essentially vegetative—so the gangster vibe he gave off by sitting a certain way, that panache of sorts, was completely unaffected. It was physically burned into him as "the way to sit," —no part of him was consciously trying to put on airs. Still he sat there, stoically—except for every so often—every once in a blue moon his chin would drop and remain there with no explanation. And if one were to look inside that toothless maw at those terrifying moments, they would see the stump of a tongue, wagging about half-heartedly, like the tail end of a severed worm, writhing about on the hot pavement, looking fruitlessly for its other half.

But there were others too. There was also Eric Niemann, who suffered from paranoid delusions and had stopped speaking entirely because he believed someone or something had taken over his brain, so he stayed in "The Quiet Room", because if he could not speak then the spirit that was in his mind surely was not allowed to speak either, the way he imagined it. Occasionally he muttered to himself, but always very quietly, and never bothered the other patients. Lastly, in the quiet room, which was about

as large as a decent sized cafeteria, There was an older woman named Lorette, who was so frightened of human interaction that she spent her day intentionally hiding in the corner of “The Quiet Room”, where there was a large bookshelf that sat catty corner on the far side of the room. Lorette was among the smallest inhabitants at Renfield and she was able to slip between the bookshelf and the wall, an opening that seemed smaller than her head was wide, which she managed nonetheless, and she would just go back there and sit down, wrapping her hands around her knees with her head pitched back against the wall, staring through the six inch gap out into “The Quiet Room”.

Most reports indicate that Darla spent almost all of her time in The Quiet Room and that day was no different. The video evidence shows Darla to be a thin woman who arrives in the frame quietly, one moment she is not there and the next she is a part of the environment. She stands beside the window with her hands together, fingers interlaced, hanging approximately where her bellybutton would be.

Almost monastic in her stillness, staring out that third story window until exactly [\[24\]](#) thirty minutes before the arsonist lit his first match, Darla Grayson turned away from the window, walked briskly to her room where she packed her belongings. Her roommate, who slept twenty hours a day, was predictably asleep (and was notably one of the few who did not escape on that day).

Darla packed a small duffel bag with two floral patterned dresses, a pair of tight, black, elastic shorts, a pair of sweatpants with “WAGNER” in purple and black clock letters down the left leg, and two simple white shirts. She threw her diary in the bag along with a blank notebook. She pulled a box from inside the top drawer of her desk and put it gently in the bag. Other items she packed, in no specific order: two very small stones she extracted from her pillowcase (these were crystals with supposed healing power—one was a light blue), two pens, something long and thin that had been kept on the windowsill, behind the same plain green curtain that could be found in every other patient room at Renfield. The color of the curtain had bothered Darla a great deal—she frequently complained to her counselor that the curtain was a sort of “vomit green” that made her nauseous by association.

She packed a toothbrush, hairbrush and a book of poems by an Italian poet who had been recommended to her by her thesis advisor, many years prior - before she’d finished her PhD in Comparative Literature, before she’d begun teaching classes of her own, before her Izzy had been born, and before she’d been locked away, as it were. It was the sole vestige of her past that she kept.

Packing took fifteen minutes. There was no deliberation, no second guessing and one is compelled to believe that there was no question in Darla’s mind as she left her room that day that she would not be going back to Renfield for a very long time. But how she knew such a thing is anyone’s guess.

Part X: Section 1.1.3

Looking back on her life, Izzy Grayson would point to the year 1989 as a year of fundamental and consequential change— “a Robert Frost Year” she called it, by which she meant a year in which two roads diverged— “But neither road seemed to be particularly traveled by. That would have been too easy.”

W. T. had disappeared almost a year prior, and his case had long since been ruled inconclusive, relegated to the cold cases, somewhere in both the State and Local police’s archives. Izzy had pleaded to keep the case open, calling the police station daily, reaching out to anyone in her address book who might have even the vaguest connections to the FBI or any sort of Federal Agency. She organized petitions, tried going to church for a few months, held a vigil, hired a private eye. She’d gone to the edge of her sanity and looked out into the vast realm of *letting go* that lay before her.

For a long time the only person that Izzy would speak to was John. For his part, John knew that W. T. was gone. At first he allowed Izzy her fantasy, but any time he insinuated that there was even a remote possibility he might not return, she would go raving mad. Her eyes would tighten, her pupils would shrink, her carotid artery would begin to pulse against her neck visibly.

She’d slapped him, kicked him, kissed him and bitten him. She’d drawn blood. She’d cried and cried and cried.

Unbeknownst to anyone but John (by request), W. T. had been working on a memoir of sorts, leading up to the day of his disappearance, January 2nd, 2017. As was his practice, the first draft had been written on an Olivetti (which is to say, there was not a digital copy that existed anywhere in the world), so when he went missing the very first thing John did was gather all of the manuscript papers he could find and put them in the small fireproof safe that had been built into the wall of the study behind a framed print of Dürer’s *Rhinoceros*, a wood block print no larger than the standard loose leaf paper used today, a veritable original according to Pappy, that had hung in the office of the Great House since its acquisition by questionable means, which had taken place during the heyday of the pirates some three centuries prior.

He said nothing to Izzy about the unfinished manuscript for some time. Finally he said, “There was a book. There was a false bottom in the desk drawer. He wrote about his life.” She did not speak for several minutes. He had been wondering how she would respond since he’d known about the book, almost a year if his memory served him correctly.

They were sitting in the room that had been a formal dining room when John first moved in. It had, John realized looking around, slowly evolved into a study over time. Piece by piece. Whereas other “trust fund kids” spent their money on drugs, alcohol, and extravagant trips where they stayed at five star hotels and took day trips to remote areas and desolate slums so that they could return home and write blog posts about how eye opening it all had been, John had spent his money on valuable books and expensive artworks.

Early on in his collecting career he purchased with abandon, and the dining room had become something of a workshop, where his inventory of rare books, paintings and intellectual paraphernalia (for example, he had a silver spoon that had been owned by Sigmund Freud, and had a specific insignia that proved it was the spoon he had used to stir cocaine into his coffee based on verified accounts from accredited sources—the spoon sat in a plain old coffee mug on the dining room table for almost two years before he found it one day, fresh out of lean silverware, and used it to stir half and half into his own instant coffee before he remembered what it was). Over time the dining room accrued stack and stacks of books, they grew out of the surface of the table like rectangular stalagmites, until eventually the table was full. The literary stalagmites then began to grow from the tops of every cupboard and cabinet in the room—stacks of books subdivided by ornately framed paintings he'd not gotten around to hanging—and when the cupboards and cabinets were full, including the drawers and every little nook and cranny possible, the rest of the room was taken over piece by piece. Chairs, end tables, the broad windowsills. John emptied the china from the china cabinet, wrapping each piece in several layers of tissue paper before boxing them and moving them into one of several empty rooms upstairs. It seemed he would never run out of space, there was always room for one more painting, one more stack of books.

Though finally the day came—he returned from a rare books auction with a set of obscure occult encyclopedias from the early enlightenment, which were interesting because they showed an early example of pre-enlightenment thought confronted with the objectivity of scientific rigor. John, having read some excerpts prior to the auction, had known at once he needed the set for his collection, because, as he wrote to W. T., he'd “never seen an encyclopedia or reference work that seemed so pervasively melancholic. What a sad time it must have been! Having your spirits taken from you like that!” But while he waited for the books to be delivered he searched the dining room for a space for the set of twelve leather bound books, each approximately the size of a postcard and as thick as an issue of Reader's Digest. There was just no place for them to go.

The obvious question one might ask is: Why not simply use a different room? There were rooms upstairs that were completely barren, just begging to be given a purpose.

But John, who rarely questioned his instincts, knew that there was a reason the books needed to stay where they were. It didn't take him long to figure out why - he brought the books with him into the living room, temporarily, and when he sat in his reading chair, struck by a pang of anxiety, his eyes moved on their own back towards the dining room, which, through the large, open doorway, could be seen in its entirety. He needed their presence, visually, and as such came to the sensible decision that the dining room must be turned into a library of sorts - a project he took to with the frenzied mania of a man trying to outrun his own shadow. He worked through the night and well into the next day, fell asleep for an hour or two on the floor beside his collection of mid-century American Noir Raymond

Chandler and Dashell Hammett of course, but there was also Horace McCoy, William Lindsay Gresham, Goodis, Woolrich, and of course there was Cain.

On his chest was a book by Massimo Carlotto, a modern Italian noir novelist, titled *The Fugitive*. It was the only book in his *noir* collection that had been written in John's lifetime and it was a favorite of his, though he suspected sentimentality was at play. It was a fictional autobiography of the author's life while on the run and had been given to him by W. T. as a gift when John had started writing his own brand of detective fiction. Carlotto had Argentinian ties, suggested ties to organized crime, and his writing was both gritty and stylish, even in translation, in a way that none of the American writers could even mildly compare.

John could recall the lecture he'd been given upon receiving the book,

W. T. telling him, "If you want to write something good, stick with Dashell Hammett. Spare, sparse sentences will never go out of style—it's a beat you can ride like a journalist." He then snatched the Carlotto book that he'd just given as a gift, he lifted the book to his nose and ran his thumb over the corner of the pages so that it made the sound of someone shuffling a deck of cards. He inhaled deeply and seemed briefly to disappear into the back of his mind—as if to retrieve something left behind. He then spoke again, "But if you want to make *art* —and I *know* you want to make *fucking art* — we couldn't be friends if you wanted to write Clive Cussler novels. If you want to *make art* you have to leave the Americans behind, frankly, when it comes to genre."

Though John wasn't confused, one could be forgiven for thinking they need to repeat themselves—something to do with the way his eyebrows were set when he was refraining from asking a question—this usually led to more exposition from W. T. — John didn't mind so much, frankly. "Americans are too boring to imagine good crime fiction. They see the whole world as white or black, good or bad—Christ, look at their comic book heroes. Batman is their take on psychological complexity; nuance. The US Government doesn't need to create propaganda with friends like these. We have the national identity of a corporation; the American soul is corporate. We're genuine fucking RANDIANS! It's our aesthetic. Moralists who are great at mapping plots, and delivering the goods if you're looking for fun twists and a nice clean summary at the end of your stories. Just right for airports, no doubt. But you know as well as I do that three hundred years of repressed, entitled Puritans, don't have the capacity for the kind of ambiguity that art requires." He stopped, briefly, and then finally said, "Only in America do we even discuss ' *Genre Fiction* ' —we're so busy obsessing over categories and boundaries—Fuck Man! The {GAN} was the closest we've come since Poe; I fuckin' mean it. And just our luck, he turns out to be a pussy." He sort of gasped when he was done speaking, as if he'd forgotten to breathe.

And that was the last thing he said before he opened his first pint of Jack Daniels for the day. He'd made it nearly to three PM.

It was an improvement.

John thought his point about Americans and genre fiction had some genuine merit—about puritans and rules—the national obsession with boundaries—the earnest belief in freedom—it was all sort of dishearteningly naive when you thought about it. But try as he might, and he tried for days and weeks and months, John couldn't conceive of a plot, let alone a novel, that wasn't composed of the same bricks and mortar that Hammet and Chandler and the rest of them had used. W. T., for his part, had forgotten the entire conversation by the time he woke up the next day; for which John was both grateful and ashamed.

Finally, she tried to speak, her lips quivered—the shadow of a large cloud crossed the sky and when it's shadow covered her face and John saw her as a young woman for a moment that lingered. He saw her in the streets of Argentina, with W. T. running around at her feet, chasing chickens through the street. He thought of the mean pigs and the old man—it was the first time he'd remembered the story in a long, long time.

Then, eventually, she left XX island without a word.

Part X: Section 1.2.0

She was gone from XX Island for a few months and then one day she showed up at the Talking House. She knew it was never locked, so she let herself in and called out to John. When he did not respond she knew where to go. She ascended the broad staircase to the second floor. At the top of the stairs she took a right and walked to the end of the long hallway where there was a small wooden door, with an ornate bronze handle that seemed as if it would fall off every time someone opened or closed the door. It never did though, the handle had been there as long as the house. It led to the Widow's Walk, where John had spent almost all his time—either reading, napping, or writing—since the day William had disappeared.

She found him there, sitting on the small couch that he and W. T. had carried upstairs when the two of them were eighteen or nineteen. He did not seem to be deep in thought, but then again, he did not appear to be doing much else besides thinking, either. It was a pull-out couch, and since W. T. had gone missing, John had essentially moved into the small, isolated tower. He slept on the couch, though he rarely pulled it out — and he spent his days writing, as if he was trying to fill the void that W. T. had left behind. There was a small desk in the corner of the room where the Olivetti sat. Apart from the typewriter, the desk itself was covered with disorganized piles of paper, typed and cast aside in the manner of the mad artist, compelled by the need to write every sentence that might occur to them so

that they might stumble upon the singular line they'd been seeking. Each page filled to the brim with words. She wondered what he had been working on. Then she went and sat beside him without speaking a word.

The couch faced eastward, where darkness climbed the sky, pushing the last hints of daylight over the horizon at their backs. The widow's walk (which was not a widow's walk, technically speaking, since John's father had it enclosed) had massive glass windows that made up most of the eastern and western facing walls. The northern and southern sides of the room were just drywall, which had been that bright sky blue, but had been repainted a dark gray since she'd last been upstairs.

Finally it was dark outside. And in the room the only light came from the surprisingly bright flame of two old lamps that hung on either side of the room, perhaps kerosene, artifacts that had been present in the room for generations and still performed their task with great dignity. Though there was an overhead fan that was fit for electric light bulbs, the sockets themselves were empty.

Occasionally John would set the book down, tap a Lucky Strike out of the soft pack that sat on the small table in front of the couch, and lit it up with the matchbook he kept tucked in the cellophane wrapping. Eventually, on his third or fourth smoke, Izzy reached for the pack herself. She showed off by extracting the cigarette with a single tap on the bottom of the pack. It made John smile, she didn't know that W. T. liked to do the same. Then he waited and was unsurprised to see her strike the match in the same smooth, efficient way that W. T. had done it, as though the match were an extension of his finger. The only difference was that she blew the match out when she was done before putting it in the ashtray, whereas W. T. had liked to leave it alight in the ashtray and watch as it burned out on its own.

Then he asked her where she had been and she told him.

She told him a good deal about her life that night. Not the stuff he knew about their lives as vagabonds, making ends meet when W. T. was young—but of her life before that—which were stories she'd only ever mentioned when she'd been drinking, and was always quick to stop herself and go to sleep as soon as she caught herself.

On the day her mother was taken to Renfield, Izzy had been called to the school office midway through art class. She had just turned nine years old and had, earlier in the day, found out by way of handwritten note, that her crush on George Mann was reciprocated. There were fifteen minutes, give or take, until the lunch bell would ring and George had agreed to sit beside her and said that he would hold her hand if she would like that (all via this same note, passed back and forth, requiring not one or two, but three willing accomplices, who each time the note came their way did their civic duty and passed it to the next individual in the daisy chain, until it arrived at one terminal point or the other).

The note had just arrived on its final trip back to Izzy when the male and female duo from the Department of Social Services knocked on the door to their classroom. Somehow aware that the

intrusion had something to do with her or her mother—because any time something odd or out of the ordinary occurred in Izzy’s life it turned out to be the result of something related to her mother.

The woman was short and uncomfortably overweight with a broad smile across her face that seemed, to Izzy, like the result of some sort of curse. At nine years old, having grown up under the care of her mother, who had progressively grown more and more isolated from her family (and had no friends to speak of) —the idea of a curse was well within the realm of possibility. In fact, curses had been the cause of many of their misfortunes, as far as she’d known at the time—and what was particularly frightening to young Izzy Grayson was that the people who were cursing them seemed to be everywhere.

Trips to the grocery store had become incredibly frightening. There was a man in his mid thirties who had short brown hair, parted either to the left or right (which seemed to indicate something to Izzy’s mother, but it was something she could not articulate). He wore khaki slacks, and a button down shirt that was always a single color, never any patterns whatsoever. Sometimes he wore glasses, but other times he did not. This was a way of trying to *confuse Mama*, Darla whispered to Izzy the second or third time it had occurred. Izzy had asked her why he looked different this time, noting the different way his hair was parted, the absence of the wire-rimmed glasses worn the previous time. Izzy could no longer remember, truth be told, when she had realized that something was wrong with her mother—or even if she had realized it at all before they took her away—what she remembered was the desperation in her mother’s eyes as she parked their cart, which was oddly (*this* she remembered) full of cans and cans of cat food despite the fact that they had no pets at home whatsoever. She remembers how roughly her mother yanked her arm as they left the cart behind and dashed between aisles, stopping at each end cap to peer around the corner—the pure panic visible in not only her eyes, but palpable via the cold sweat of her grip. She remembers her mother’s shrill scream when, turning down the aisle that led to the exit, she came face to face with *the man* (except now he had red hair and a mustache) and the way he stared at both mother and daughter in complete shock, and as her mother ducked and yanked Izzy along, now at nearly a full sprint, the sound of the man’s voice, confused and concerned, “Dr. Grayson? Excuse me! Dr. Grayson, is everything alright?” his voice trailing off and the sound of hushed whispers as Darla nearly collides with an elderly woman carrying a shopping basket full of apples and cake mix as she remembered it, someone calling out *Ma’am! Ma’am!* until finally they are crashing through the doorway and out into the cold, gray February morning and Izzy looks up at her mother’s bulging, crazed eyes and deathly gray pallor and feels, she realized so many years later, feels *not afraid*, no it’s not that really, looking up at the empty black disease that was her mother’s gaze she feels completely and utterly alone in the world because her mother is not there, not with her, she’s vanished somehow—swallowed up by the woman whose grasp now feels as though it might break her fingers and Izzy pulls her hand away from her with all her might and only then does she begin to cry the insatiable tears of a realization she cannot describe, not even decades later as she told her story to John, the two of them

slowly drawing nearer to one another on the small couch in the Widow's Walk, and she asked him to make her a promise he would never break.

And he did.

Part X: Section 1.0.3

John pushed his finger against the thin skin until he felt the pleasant pop and release of tension— he'd ruptured the skein and penetrated the wet pulpy interior up to the first knuckle of his index finger. He had half expected the thing to shatter, shards of orange light spreading across the tent like fireworks, but it felt no different to the touch than any other clementine he'd ever had before.

It felt no different at all—this much was true—but when he extracted his finger to begin to peel back the skin he saw a bright beam of light shining back at him. So bright, at first, he dared not even look at it—worried he might blind himself. He turned his head to avoid the light and looked at the spot where it landed on the dappled green canvas of the tent's interior.

What was going on?

He looked at W. T. for an answer, but his gaze was met by a broad smile, as if W. T. had known just what would happen when he'd opened the fruit. If that was even what it was, John thought. Certainly one didn't need to be a botanist to recognize the taste of a clementine, his line of reasoning continued, and then he licked the juice that was running down the interior of the finger he'd used to pop the fruit—there was no question.

He wondered if he'd gone mad—but he didn't think it was the case despite the substantial evidence to the contrary. He felt, rather, as if he'd stepped into a new reality of sorts—one that was much more fluid and considerably less...confined...than the one from which he'd come. He'd begun to have images of the night prior pop up here and there. Nothing like a concrete, temporal memory—cause and effect, one thing leading to the next (though he sensed such a thing could be recalled with enough time and focus, but he had no desire to dedicate himself to such tedious tasks) —no, these were snapshots fully equipped with the sensory details that were present in the moment.

For example, the light that shot from the clementine brought to mind the bright beam of the Maglite that he had used to lead the way through the house once the power had gone out. A smell of something foreign, burning, nothing he had smelled before in his life—it was pleasant and he led the way as W. T. followed up the staircase in the Great House, down the hallway, past the outcove where the Grand Piano that had supposedly belonged to the great composer Niccolò Paganini sat with its lid raised, keys exposed (they were never exposed), and when he shined the Maglight in that direction he half-expected to see the ghost of the composer himself sitting there—though that had not been the case.

Then from behind him the voice of W. T.: *You hear that? Ropeadope? You hear that noise?*

At first he had not, but then faintly he heard the quiet, but consistent sound of *tick, tick, tick*. the sharp, pleasant, almost citrusy smell still fresh in his nostrils, how he heard the sound of the metronome ticking

Quickly though the light, bright and orange as it had been, began to fade into a sort of butterscotch, a soft twilight shade, and soon thereafter there was only a faint trace of whatever had been there left, little specks floating in the air like the heavy pollen that continuously accumulated in spring, and summer, and even midway into fall. Yellow powder that covered everything with a fine coat. It made him think of Pappy, everything reminded him of Pappy for some reason, but this memory was particularly vivid, Pappy in his Cadillac, long and regal, as a child he thought it was a limousine. And for a good half of the year Pappy would take his car through the carwash, every day, first thing in the morning, to ensure the pollen didn't set into the paint—if you left it too long it would set into the clear coat—and once it was set, that was that, he'd be driving around in a yellow-tinted Cadillac until he traded it in or had her repainted. Every so often John would be there, staying at the Great House because his Dad had been in a mood, or his parents had gone out the night before when he was too young to be left alone. Those mornings he rode with Pappy to the car wash, Bill Stetson's car wash, and Pappy told him stories about his own childhood that were too incredible to be true, but in any event were incredible enough to make John wake with the sun and look outside to see how much pollen had collected on the windowsill, running downstairs to report on it like some kind of weatherman. Pappy's laugh, high pitched and bright eyed no matter the circumstance—most of all John remembered how Pappy had explained pollen to him once, when he was very young, and that he'd believed it until he was far too old to go on believing it, and then he tried to believe it a bit more. Pollen, he'd said, was food for the earth. He said he wasn't sure if it was Mother Nature or Father Time, but it was one of the two, and they sprinkled it down from the sky in the summertime, like fish food and the earth were one giant fishbowl, and that's why the world turned green in the spring. So that's why he made sure to wash it off his car every day, you see, because if it got caught there, stuck in the clear coat as it were, well that would be like stealing from the earth. And he didn't know for certain, he'd remind John, but it didn't much matter if it was Mother Nature or Father Time, because if you made one of them mad they told the other one, and they'd be mad too. So that was why he never got mad or upset about the pollen that sometimes fell so heavy it would look like the whole earth had been dusted over. That was just the way things were.

With that in mind, John stood. He found the tent much larger than it had been when he'd first woken up—though theoretically impossible; *The tent could not have grown*. But he stood in front of what seemed to be a full-sized entry way, taller than John by any measure, and then stuck his hand (the one that held the now completely non-illuminated clementine) through the doorway, into the fresh breeze. Part of him expected to hear the slick twang of an imaginary guillotine. Part of him reminded himself that he didn't actually know what a guillotine would sound like if one had begun to fall. But of course he felt nothing but the cool humidity of a winter day in the low country. He thought the world outside was moving to

the pulse of the metronome—though he convinced himself that this, certainly, was in his head. He looked back at his friend and a deep well of concern splashed around inside of him.

As they set off on their walk, John felt the story of the prior evening coming to life inside him—it had been there, awaiting something, perhaps the increased circulation of blood brought about by the movement of his body had stirred it to life; perhaps, like some sort of reptilian creature it had been the sun that drew him to life, warming his blood and clearing blockages that allowed it free. Whatever it was, he had the feeling that it had been stored away in his body, not in his mind, and he could not have brought the memories forth by will—they required something more primitive (though he didn't think that was the right word), it was really something more *direct*, he thought. And it struck him that what he was imagining was primitive, or instinctual, or at a minimum was outside of the realm of the psychological, was in fact infinitely more complex than anything he could ever conjure in his own mind.

This was a revelation, though he did not know what to make of it—he was only certain that it made life larger by magnitudes.

He was reminded of Yukio Mishima's *Sun and Steel*, a book he had absolutely despised the first and second times he read it. But W. T. had recommended it. And as a rule, when it came to W. T.'s recommendations, John would read a book cover to cover twice - regardless of his impression on the first read. Even if he hated it, which had been the case with *Sun and Steel*, he found the whole thing pedantic and preachy and lacking those fundamental qualities that are necessary for a preachy, pedantic book to be ascribed any value in the John Roapes "Literary Canon".

Doors that had once been sealed shut by language, which was the singular tool of the mind, were now open. He had felt them release. But what precisely had been opened, and how this new... *sense*?...yes, sense—how this new sense might be put to use was hardly even a question worth posing given how little he understood.

Still, at the same time he understood nothing, he was notably not surprised (in fact he had almost anticipated it, the way one can smell an imminent rainshower) when W. T. spoke the first words that had been spoken since they'd left the tent, "It's a breakthrough. Don't you think? Indescribable, really."

John only nodded in response, speechless. Ahead of them was a long, straight drive that stretched all the way to the horizon and further then still. It was a similar tunnel of live oaks, though these oaks were strewn with obscene amounts of Spanish moss, all of it grew into a tangle that moved from tree to tree in one continuous blanket, a singular organism. Where it hung from the lowest branches some of it grew into thick, rope-like knots that brought to mind Amazonian vines, Kipling and *The Jungle Book*.

In fact, the tunnel of live oaks *looked like* the same roads John had traveled all his life, but upon closer inspection there were small differences everywhere that made the long, straight, empty road quite different from any other he'd ever seen.

But still they kept walking, with no destination in mind save the horizon, neither of them speaking aloud, until at some point (it's almost impossible to say when), John realized they'd been involved in a long and detailed conversation about the events of the night prior and the way they related to everything, past and future, though neither had even once spoken a word.

Feng Zhaolin - Observe the Flying Waterfall on the Ridge

Part X: Section 1.2.1

Izzy remembered portions of her life with an unbelievable amount of clarity. Particularly amazing was how far back into her childhood her memory extended. For example, she swore she remembered what her father looked like, even though she knew for a fact that he'd left when she was not yet three. She said she remembered the sound of his voice and the heavy noise his boots made on the hardwood floor when he came to visit. He usually visited for a week or two at a time before leaving to be with his real family again, the ones whose picture he carried in his wallet. She remembers him as a departing figure,

always halfway out the door, and that gaze, which she remembered so distinctly, looked back at once resentfully and with a deep sense of tragedy, as his daughter, his Izzy-Bee, hugged her tiny arms around her mother's sad, slobbering face once again. That was how she remembered it, in any event, him perpetually leaving them; he always left, no matter how much Darla begged and begged him to stay.

Though perhaps it was the case that he only came once, only left once; and that it was that single scene, playing over and over again in her head that made her think of it as an event that happened regularly until, finally, it didn't anymore.

No matter the case, it was a fact that his other family was somewhere far, far away—in the Pacific Northwest. And Izzy dreamed of escaping from Wagner.

The last memory she really has of him takes place at the multipurpose dinner table that sat in the middle of the TV Room/Kitchen. Izzy had just graduated to sitting in a booster seat at the dinner table. Darla was beginning to show signs of her disease, but not enough to draw attention, not enough to concern anyone who didn't have to interact with her *personally*—and as a single mother, estranged from her parents, teaching “A Historical Survey of the Medieval Epic” (as well as a few other courses that also dealt in the fantastic and mythical realms), she rarely interacted with anyone who would find her obsessive behaviors anything more than the eccentricities of a particular type of professor who seems to always be frantically trying to keep pace with her colleagues in every realm, who responded to questions like, *How's it going?* by delving into a well practiced monologue about how no one really wants to know the answer to *that question*.

Whatsmore, she was still mentally “there” enough to know that she needed to keep her conspiracies to herself (*until she could prove them, that was* [\[25\]](#)).

It was only in the privacy of her home that she indulged those darker impulses and wrote up abstract theories about “conduits of evil” and the “frequencies” emitted by certain areas of the campus where she believed there were inaccessible “vaults, hidden in the fabric of spacetime” that were used by certain individuals whose names she dared not speak, let alone write. Individuals who would soon begin to follow her — her script becoming progressively less legible — until eventually she stopped writing altogether, certain that they were able to access her personal notes through a sort of mental manipulation in which they looked through her eyes if they so desired. This, she later told the doctors, therapists, lunch ladies and ward attendants at Renfield, had been the cause of the often cited blackouts that took place with increasing frequency once Izzy's father had left for the last and final time.

They came upon a stone outcropping of small proportions that, simply put, did not belong. It seemed older than anything John could imagine having been constructed by his family at any rate—his first thought was of the native people of the area, the Creek people, who were really many different cultures but in most history that was taught and learned in this part of America, the nuances were irrelevant [\[26\]](#)—they might have been the Coosaw or the Kiawah, or they might have been one of the groups forced further northward out of Florida by the Spanish, they might have been the Hobcaw, Shawnee, or any of the myriad groups that were not captured and named by the early Europeans before they were infected, molested and eradicated; tribes around XX in the pre-colonial days were small and independent, almost family-like in their clannish independence—it is a great and terrible failure of the imagination to associate all natives with teepees and spears and great grassy plains and warring factions, chiefs with massive headdresses covered in face paint—the truth is far more nuanced and unknowable.

To the best of our present knowledge the natives who lived on the coastal islands of the lowcountry were bound to the water—to the creeks and inlets, and native agriculture that grows in abundance in such a bounteous climate—and they were largely peoples of peace. They had no need for the things that had forced their ancestors who were soon to barge across the Atlantic, bringing with them histories already filled to the brim with tales of murder, savagery and revenge.

When a bartering economy suffices, one needs not move toward the increasingly exploitative forms that follow.

John, was deep in thought about the native history as they approached the ruins, but did not even recognize he had been thinking, nor that he had been crying until he felt a tear drop fall from the mantle of his high cheek and land on the back of his hand between his thumb and index finger, opposite the fleshy part *he called his palm* .

He recognized a layer of abstraction between himself and his thoughts and pulled it back once again. He was uncomfortable with the widening gap between what he could see and feel and what he could comprehend, but when he looked at W. T. yet again, there was nothing but the same smile that had been there since they'd left the tent hours prior. There was something distasteful about it—it gave off the distinct impression of being stolen property.

He had a thought, “Perhaps they’re from Druids. It’s not impossible, eh?”

W. T. burped.

He then went on, “It was called an *exedra* in Ancient Greek, and in a domicile of an ancient Athenian it would be the room built for the sole purpose of contemplation and discussion about the nature of...

well, nature. Like a personal lecture hall, I imagine.” W. T. spoke and walked up two small stone stairs to the small stage.

He promptly turned around and looked out over the audience of one.

“How do you know that?” John immediately asked—not because he was skeptical, though he was, but because he wanted to hear W. T. say more and that had been the first question that had come to him.

“Why are you asking such a distasteful question?”

But there was nothing distasteful about it as far as John could discern. He thought about it and realized it didn’t matter much and moved on without so much as recognizing the impertinent response. “Do you know where we are?”

W. T. stood center stage and smiled the big, insincere, smile again as a broad beam of sunlight broke through the canopy above them and lit the stage with cinematic grandeur. “Now we’re talking,” he said. This made John almost spit. What was W. T. doing?

At that exact moment, though, a voice rang out from far down the drive, back in the direction from which they’d come. It was W. T. calling out to him and John registered distinct concern in the modulations of his voice. He knew instantly that the smiling man had not been W. T. and felt like an idiot for not having realized it any sooner. Everything about him had been wrong.

But he looked back towards the stage—where the light had shone so brightly it had made the man who was not W. T. seem to sparkle and glimmer—there was no one there. There was not a stage at all.

There wasn’t an ancient ruin, or a modern hut, or even a rock to sit on. There was just a large live oak with a trunk as thick as a small car—and down the middle of the trunk there was a large rift, fire-blackened and jagged, and he recognized it as one of the trees that had been struck by lightning on the night W. T. had first arrived.

He turned around and watched his friend moving quickly towards him down the road. A sense of relief overcame him.

Part X: Section 1.3.0

In the beginning there was lightning. An old, bent, weathered black sedan pulled down the oak canopied drive in the dark rain of night. The darkness was interrupted frequently, as heat lightning ran rampant through the clouds above with devilish curiosity, or else when genuine lightning struck down upon the earth with mighty and rapturous concussions, the only thing that could actually be seen from the window of the room above the garage, where I sat and watched the lightning, and occasionally

heard it, were the two broad beams of white light cutting out through the thick droplets of rain like a good carving knife through the fat belly meat of a large ocean fish: Grouper, Albacore, Sword.

It struck me as odd—the idea that great events, major events, could occur in my world—which at that time almost seemed to be shrinking, constricting against my wishes. This was perhaps the result of growing up on an island that almost no one ever seemed to leave, surrounded by people who took pride in being born and buried in the same place. I remember thinking the scene was too epic, its proportions too grand, that it couldn't possibly have anything to do with me.

I was physically growing. It seemed a pair of pants would only last two or three months before they became *high-waters*, and even worse than the length was that they would become tight around my thighs and buttocks and I found that for the life of me, when this happened, I could never keep my zipper up—I would go to the bathroom, urinate (so long as I was alone) and then zip everything up perfectly. I would even double check that the zipper was back in place after I washed my hands. But as sure as rain falls on when the tree leaves begin to turn, by the time I walked back to my class my zipper would slipped down again on its own: my thighs kept the pants stretched tight but with each step there was a small amount of slack allowed that the zipper quickly took advantage of, sliding down a bit before another step forward would make them go taut and repeat the cycle. Eventually, after fifteen or twenty steps the zipper would have descended completely, right as I re-entered my classroom. And this was the sort of thing my teacher never failed to notice, calling me up to the front of the class to whisper in my ear that I should 'X-Y-Z', causing me to immediately stare at the crotch of my too-small pants, instinctually, and I can still hear the laughter of so many twelve and thirteen year old girls when I think of those days prior to his arrival [\[27\]](#).

I was growing and until W. T. arrived, my world seemed to have failed to expand in the same way. It's a constant of youth, outgrowing your surroundings—first you are proud because you can reach the top of the bed with your fingertip and the bottom with your toe, and then one night you lay down and you no longer fit in your own bed. It's not yours anymore. It's just the place you sleep until your father complains that the guest mattress has been hurting his back, and so you get the set from the guest room, and your father gets a new guest bed to sleep on, and you wonder if he's ever going back to sleep with you mother or if this is more or less a permanent thing at this point.

Life stayed the same size and I took up more space. That's all there was to it. And this in turn made me feel that life itself was a small thing - that it would be filled with similar iterations of making big things feel little. Over and over and over again. This was no place for adventure and grandiosity—the only frontier that remained was aboard a shipping vessel, and it turned out I got sick once I lost sight of land.

So I couldn't believe it when I felt something coming on—even if it was just a sensation—it was something I felt to be true.

In my memory the storm made the island sway back and forth like a shipping vessel.

The mud-covered Ford Bronco had two different headlights, one more yellowish and the other a bright, hot white—in the dark and rain the effect this created was a bit confusing, somehow one got the feeling that one half of the car was traveling faster than the other, or at other times it seemed as if the car was constantly veering in a particular direction, when in reality it was not deviating from its path in the slightest. These sorts of optical illusions always excite me; they serve as great reminders of the general shortcomings of human perception.

That night the Bronco made its way down Roapes Drive. No one had told me of its coming, I only noticed its headlights through the open slats of my bedroom blinds and thought to myself that no one ever came down the road this late unless Dad had been out. Later it would become clear this was because mom had told almost no one of their coming—no one except Pappy. She had to talk to Pappy, of course, because it was his land, his house, and his choice to allow or deny my mother's request. Not many people knew it, but if you asked Pappy the right way, there wasn't much he would say no to—which he said was a curse that had been put upon him, and not really a part of his constitution—by which he meant he wished he'd said "No" more often in his life, but he hadn't. My mother knew this fact about Pappy particularly well, though she rarely took advantage of it, this was one of two reasons that she felt confident he would agree to her request.

The other reason was a bit more complicated, but will become clear in due time.

It was my father who was opposed to their arrival. He was a selfish man who seemed to despise anything that did not directly provide him some sort of reciprocal value on principle. Were he a smarter man he might have noted that there was reciprocal value in anything that makes one's wife and life partner happier and more satisfied—but he was a man who valued only very particular types of intelligence, and his emotional and social intelligence was subpar to be kind about it. Occasionally he could be surprisingly intelligent when it came to navigating the politics of a social environment, but never at any depth beyond the purely political. He was a man who did not have the capacity for empathy—of course I'm no doctor, but according to texts on the subject (widely accepted to be definitive), he was almost certainly a clinical sociopath.

*What I found most astounding about this, the more I learned, the more I researched my own father, was the very obvious fact (in my opinion) that sociopathy is at the heart of the modern American way of life, which is not to say that most Americans are sociopaths, but rather that **the very thing that prevents many Americans from achieving 'success'** (either via money or power) is **the inability to operate sociopathically**. That both sympathy and empathy (but perhaps empathy most clearly), are impediments on the road to achieving the American version of 'Freedom'—and whatsmore, it's almost accepted as fact that our terminally ill political*

*system is exclusively run by sociopaths. **There are no good guys** . It's a categorical impossibility.*

They had been bickering about it for weeks, though I'd grown so used to their constant arguing, and not just the last few weeks but for long enough that it was all it was practically all I knew, absences and arguments. I had, in most cases, long since stopped trying to figure out what they were arguing about. In general, my ears were finely attuned to catch words and phrases that indicated something was being kept from me, but if it wasn't a secret I paid it no heed.

My mother had, a week or so prior, casually mentioned to me that an old friend might be coming to stay for some indefinite period of time—but for some reason, on that particular evening, perhaps because of the rain, or the uncanny noir vibe that permeated the whole of the island (I presumed, something particular about *this rain* , that must have been felt everywhere it was falling), I realized this was a moment of some significance. I had what you might call a spontaneous insight. I decided then to listen through the walls to my Father's angry voice (always angry, it seems in retrospect), and then to my mother's pithy defense, which he constantly interrupted, to berate her, causing her to start anew with the same logical sequence of thoughts: 1) Mom said she'd offered it as a kindness to a friend who'd once done something for her that she could never repay, she worded it strangely like that, as if from a story book—2) she said she hadn't known about the boy (though to this day I question the veracity of this statement).

For the longest time I could not ascertain much about the Graysons, or what it was that brought them from places unknown to our small island at the edge of the country on such sudden notice. It certainly wasn't industry, no one moved here because it was the easiest place to find decent employment - in the southeast there was really only Atlanta for that.

I sat at the top of the stairs listening until I dozed off, sitting with my arms hugging the top of my bent tops of my knees, my head resting on my arms. While I slept I dreamt of myself as my father, though my father was still my father too.

That's why it seemed like something was happening to the wrong people. Ours was a life so devoid of anything that smelled even remotely of adventure (except for Pappy's stories) The night arrival of W. T. and the slow, storm front swelling the river so that the marsh grass was submerged and the dock was submerged and you could sense the full blood moon even through the obscuring clouds, and then another BOOOOM and in the distance you hear how loud a tree sounds when it is cracked in half by pure electricity.

Later that night, driving around in a golf cart, taking inventory, I could tell them tree by tree, when they had been struck and felled – until, that is, my father told me to stop making things up, and so I told him to get us to the *Heart Tree* , which had been a tree of great spiritual value to the X. X. Indian's from whom we'd taken the island, and was a tree that the the locals took much pride in, making various

claims as to its age and properties, and which—it was true—had branches so large and long that at a certain distance from the tree they became too heavy for the tree itself to bear, at which point they re-entered the earth and sprang back up again fifteen or twenty feet or so further on, like those images of ancient sea beasts, their sinuous bodies rising and falling from the water in small arches.

The heart tree, I told my father, had been struck in its core, split clear in half. And he looked back at me, with an anger in his eyes that W. T. would later tell me he saw fear (though, as is common knowledge, no boy can recognize fear in the face of his own father—and as such the sensation of fear in a patriarchal figure is rarely captured accurately, if at all) , and said “You should hope that ain’t the case, boy. You shouldn’t make up stories like that.” William’s mother was in shock, riding shotgun - it was nearly impossible to understand how a tree itself could be so sacred as to redden a grown man’s face just by saying it had been felled by lightning. But that’s how things were on X. X. Island, and William himself seemed to know it because he wasn’t surprised in the least by my father’s reaction, nor was he surprised when my father showed tears upon discovering that I’d told the truth, the heart tree was split down the middle as if by the ax of some ancient god. It’s two halves, however, remained propped up, though blackened with soot and charred, by the spider-legged branches, which now functioned like support beams, supported by the earth, with the singular purpose of keeping the two halves of the tree’s body from separating at any cost. And I imagined in that instant that the tree was a family, each branch a child, the trunk’s two parts each representing a parent trying to flee from the other, the kids wrapped in embrace begging them *please, please, please, don’t leave - don’t make us choose*. And as quickly as the thought crossed my mind it was gone again, but when I looked back at W. T. it seemed to me that he’d had the exact same impression. I couldn’t say why.

It was only later that he would confirm my suspicion, and with that link between us it was as though we had spent our whole lives together, as if we were brothers, in a way and one or the other of us had just returned from a long trip and there was a great deal of catching up to do. In any event, that was how it felt to me.

Part X: Section 1.4.0

Upon entering the Great House one was greeted by the warm scent of still time, one walks into this small pocket of the world and fills their lungs with the breath of *the still life* . Like a still life painting, in the great house life pauses to be observed, considered, and so too does the clock on the wall, the bananas that hang from the hook, captured in the liminal state between overripe and just right, coexisting peacefully, naturally as it were, with the single lime on the counter—and part of the scent of time that one cannot help but recognize, even if they can’t quite put their finger on it (though, perhaps they are unaware of what the recognition is of, precisely) the presence of language—though there was something wrong with the word itself, *language* , a sort of perpetual classification error—all of which are the subject of time as well as its means and its ends. The source of the scent is not obvious—one

enters into a very large hallway of sorts, though it is wide enough to serve as a passage and a destination. To the left there is a large, burgundy couch with vertical golden stripes spanning its length, they look like thin strips of ribbon . It doesn't look very comfortable, in large part due to the plastic covering that Mee-Maw has kept it wrapped in for time eternal—as if it were some kind of a museum piece.

Even now, though, it is the sort of couch that no one ever sits on.

A still life.

Part X: Section 1.4.1

The only time Pappy truly angered his daughter in law, was when he took it upon himself to discuss religion with John, who at the age of six was already developing a stubborn resistance to not only church, God, etc. —but more or less to anything doctrinal, mandated. Pappy had said that “*F ather T ime*” was the only man, woman, or beast he worshiped.

There was rarely a morning that John did not depart for school already red faced and testing out new curse words he'd learned listening to his Dad and friends playing cards, and all because he detested the fact that he was **forced** to wear his school's standard blue and white school uniform. Had it not been a uniform, he knew, he would have found the outfit completely inoffensive (at least relative to the uniforms he'd seen in his dad's old yearbooks, the ones he had been forced to wear at the very same school some three decades earlier). But the fact of the matter was that it was a uniform—the clothes that he was forced to wear in order to shape better cogs for some great machine. He knew it then, even if he didn't have the words to say it succinctly. Instead John cursed at the *sonofabitch* pants, and the shirt that was to *god dammit* tight. And it was actually in response to this latter utterance, the blasphemous *god dammit* that Pappy had raised his voice in a quick sharp shout—the way one shouts when caught off guard or frightened by something unexpected. Except, for Pappy, it was neither of those things, it was simply his way of calling for attention in a world that had by and large outgrown him. He was thin then but with the same recognizable protruding belly that he'd acquired around forty-five or fifty years of age, the same time everything on him began to slacken.

“What about *M other E arth*?” John asked. This sort of thing was always on his mind, even then, too young yet to have mourned a living thing and yet somehow filled with compassion that can only be derived from such particular endeavors. But he heard his mother coming from far off but did not have time to do much besides shake his head at Pappy, who was not paying attention in the least.

“Of course Mother Earth,” Pappy said. “I just assumed you knew what I meant. Father Time and Mother Earth are the same thing. There is no differ—” at which point he stopped speaking because Nea had stepped in to check on her son's sttik

It struck John as an odd thing to say. But John then scurried off to his room, taking the back staircase [28] , because he had heard the sound of his father's dress shoes clicking against the hardwood, headed towards the dining area where he and Pappy had been talking.

He was six years old at the time, an age at which most adults underestimate one's intelligence, and in turn fail to be sufficiently considerate of a child's vulnerability.

At six John had the capacity to comprehend most anything he heard, within reason, but had yet to develop the tools necessary to know what to do with the information. The information he registered often seemed overwhelmingly bleak, or if not bleak then sad, or if not sad then wrong, or unfair, or uncertain, or just plain mean—very rarely was the information the happy, fun sort, and in these cases it was shared with him, usually. Naturally, he got the impression that much of what was dark in the world had been kept from him, thus far—and for some reason he had seen it too early, and had gotten a peak behind the wizard's curtain. And when he went to first grade he felt distinctly out of place, surrounded by *children* , despite being fully aware that he was younger than many of them himself.

It's a state of being that must afflict millions of children.

Such a delicate balance is required throughout childhood—the sensory-emotional faculties on one side of the scale; intellectual-cognitive reasoning on the other.

The delicacy is required not because of any particular fragility in the child, in fact it is rather the opposite. It is the violent strength of unharnessed growth taking place (a growth rate that will, perhaps, not again be experienced for the remainder of the child's life). It is because the child is SO powerful, in fact, that they need their sensual/emotional/natural impulses to develop in near lockstep with the other side.

In John's case, as with many bright, young children—his thinking-self had doubled down, perhaps filling the void that might have been meant for his father's warm embrace, by comfort, safety...by love. Because when, indeed, he did find it (by way of his Uncle James, his Pappy, and in some odd way through W. T. himself) —he held it and observed it like an object to be studied: the natural intuition he should have *felt* , had long since redistributed itself to be used in more pragmatic ways.

Recognizing this inadequacy, this emptiness, he broke down and cried. Sniffles first, then tears and moans, then he wept, which was consistent and drew attention from downstairs, where his mother told his father, both of whom were incredibly confused. Pappy, for his part, looked as though he hadn't heard a thing. His mother, Beatrice, offered to go check on him, but his father grabbed her by the arm when she stood to leave the breakfast table. They still had time before they left for church.

Sternly, he said, “No Bea . I'll handle this,” and off he went in his Sunday attire, which was much the same as his weekday attire, except instead of blue jeans he wore his dark gray slacks, and instead of

boots he wore spotless white dress shoes. Pappy watched his son and felt a pang of sympathy for both Beatrice and John. He also felt a sort of guilt he could not shake.

Henry approached his son's bedroom and put his ear to the door, he heard sniffles and whimpers.

"Time to go, Johnny Boy. You almost ready in there?"

"Yes Dad," came the reply. "Coming. I'm coming." And out the boy came, his face wiped clear, not a remnant of a tear left to wipe from his cheek. And Henry Roapes realized, quite immediately, that he'd been the wrong one to go.

Why had Pappy chosen to tell him of all people? And why in that moment, as he sat dressed in ill-fitted clothes that were unbearably itchy (due to an allergy to the washing detergent, and in most other detergents for that matter, that would go misdiagnosed for at least the next fifteen years—so that all throughout his childhood and young adulthood John had to tell people his skin was just *like that*, and was constantly taking lavender baths and trying folk solutions which). For another thing, John had heard that people worshiped Jesus and God and even he knew there were some strange people on the island who worshiped the Devil (his Dad had told him); but he'd never heard of anyone who really believed in *Father Time*, it was like a fairy tale. The devil worshipers, who respectfully asked to be called Satanists, had a crooked church (if that was what they called it) with a crooked steeple that gave John the shivers just to look at. He imagined it had once been a place where people went to worship God or Jesus, but then something terrible must have happened, and after that it was a place where people went to worship the Devil; God's enemy. It had one single window and a bell tower and the piece of land it sat on was shaped like a thorn that jutted out from XX Island into the turbulent seas of the Atlantic.

Pappy said he only worshiped *Father Time*, so when John was young (young enough to think these sorts of things) he thought that the Great House was a place where people could go to worship *Father Time*, and that was why it had that particular scent that it did, like it was home to decades and centuries, and they were kept in the books. John was certain that if there was any span of time hidden in that house, and there almost surely was, then it was kept in the books in that office. And he loved it there.

Across from the couch are the ornate dark wood of the double doors to the office. From there the smell of a turning page emanates, Pappy turning to the funnies, a list of box scores from any decade. A discerning nose can pick up the scent under almost any conditions—though, there was rarely much going on in the Great House during the days, so the scent almost always proliferated the entirety of the entryway. It was the smell of books, lifetimes of books, and John thought it was the greatest smell that existed.

The office in the Great House was lined with floor to ceiling bookshelves on three walls. On the fourth wall there was a great, wide set of double doors made of thick, dark wood in flat panels. Pappy said

there was no need for ornate designs to be ingrained in a piece of wood like that, by which, he clarified, he meant a piece of wood that already held all the stories it could tell. For a long time John thought that he'd meant there was no need to add patterns to a piece of wood that held its own lines and shapes, curves and nuances all contained in the wood grain—and in part, that had been true.

He could remember how, as a child, he made a game out of finding new and increasingly obscure images in the wood grain. There were a number of factors that impacted the appearance of the wood grain, some of which were influenced by the craftsman, but others of which were contingent on the tree itself—entirely unique and inimitable.

The foundation of the imagined shapes were formed by the concentric lines, or growth rings, most frequently recognized in the stump of a felled tree where the clean bisection gives the viewer clear insight into the (now dead) tree's former life. Each ring was a literal representation of a year of arboreal growth—years of particular abundance were displayed by broad rings of significant growth.

Whereas years in which resources were scarce or weather patterns aberrant, or if there were a big storm that caused significant damage to the tree, for instance, and it was forced to spend its energy recovering rather than growing—these years showed very little growth. If you strung a few of the bad years together, in the event of a sustained drought perhaps, you might find several stagnant circles with almost nothing to show for themselves, years in which the tree did nothing more than hang on.

By nature trees are individualistic. Each tree is one of a kind. Even in those endless rows of pines one now sees with relative frequency if they drive certain stretches of interstate, planted en masse along the side of the highway [\[29\]](#) —even among those eerily man-made forested patches—each tree is entirely distinct.

A pine tree grows incredibly quickly under the regimented care of man, sprinkler systems and enhanced soils allow for a young sapling to grow multiple times more quickly than its naturally occurring kin.

The result is that the growth rings of harvest pine are incredibly wide and in twenty years a farmed pine tree can be harvested and turned into that same lumber we use to build McMansions across the country. But this is not without drawback, because the eighty year old pine that it replaced is built of sturdier parts—which is to say, it has more years under its belt, growth rings that is, which not only add to its strength but its character. Rings that result in those patterns and shapes that young boys stare at and find dragons, fish, castles and explosions in the night sky.

John loved imagining the stories trees told—and each plank of wood in the great house, in particular, had seemed alive to John when he was young. Then, briefly, they'd lost their allure, as had many of the things that relied on that same childlike sense of wonder—but as luck would have it this period was brief. There were three to six months during which he felt the onset of adolescence and the void that lay beyond it, and had his first encounter with the gray and nondescript vacuum of depression. His voice gave out on him occasionally and he noticed his own scent for the first time. It seemed nothing

fun was appropriate—his father had been telling him for some time *You're nearly a man, boy* , and sure enough here he was, a *manboy* , and feeling as alone as one would expect a *manboy* to feel given the circumstances.

Perhaps it was sheer luck, just like the broken clock's often referenced, twice-daily intersection with reality, but it was during this bleak window that Izzy and W. T. arrived in their long black Lincoln—and with W. T. looking like a pure man, physically that is— with the brain of a savant and open-minded creativity of a young child; an entire universe at his disposal, the concept of imagination took on a whole new meaning. Somehow, briefly, the ennui was swept aside—John had the feeling he'd only explored the world up to a certain depth and only now did he realize that there was an entire world that ran fathoms deep.

Each ring was a literal representation of a year of arboreal growth—and when John told W. T. about the images he'd found in the wood—explaining to him, for example, that a burl was a twist or swirl in the grain without a knot, that created a certain kind of pattern that looked particularly snake-like on the floorboard just beside the dining room; and furthermore explaining that the burl generally came from a spot where a branch had been located, which was to say that *this piece of wood here* the excited boy told his new friend, *came from a part of a tree which was near a branch, when it was still alive that was, and as a result you could see the shape that it made had taken the shape of a kraken* .

W. T. took this information and new ideas began to pop up in his mind almost instantly. You could see his mind spinning as he surveyed other floorboards, now observing the varieties of grain, pattern, color and even texture, in disbelief that he'd spent so much of his life walking on wood floors, surrounded by wood walls, and he'd missed an entire layer of reality — a whole new canvas on which to make life into art.

“Only Americans don't believe in Krakens,” he told John, who thought about the statement momentarily, perplexed.

“You're an American, though? Right?” John wasn't entirely certain why but he felt nervous that someone might have been close enough to have heard that.

He'd never heard anyone speak about America as though it were not the pinnacle of all human history. He'd never heard “Americans” spoken about in such a thoroughly condescending tone. Surely he'd misunderstood, he thought, awaiting his new friend's reply.

W. T. thought about this question longer than John had expected—and then, as though he'd never even thought about it before, he responded, “I guess so, yes.” He then went back to the wood, following the Kraken to another spot, and then another, moving small things out of his way as he went; an end table, a feeble, antique wooden chair that John had been told was older than the country itself. He wondered if that made the end table American, but found the line of questioning dull and fruitless. What had his

friend meant that he *guessed so*? *Was it even possible to be uncertain about what you were?* The latter question made him think - he realized it was contingent on several assumptions, and in those assumptions, perhaps, was the ambiguity. He was twelve years old though, and that realization did not come in the form of an articulated thought as stated above, but much more as a sort of recognition or sensation that there was more there than he had initially supposed, and that he'd need to think about this more.

Given the new living situation, he realized, the discussion would almost certainly come up again. So he set it aside, and decided to pay attention to his new friend—he had been so quick to think of him as a friend! —the boy who was contained in the man's body, W. T., was bow down on hands and knees looking intently at a plank that was different from its neighbors.

"Flecking," John said, "it's what makes those flared shapes—like these. The hills," using his finger to outline the area where the light, wave-like markings were visible.

The realization suddenly dawned on him: He was a veritable repository of knowledge on the subject of wood milling—on the subject of trees and wood in general, in fact—but especially with the milling. He wished that he could introduce W. T. to his Uncle James. He was the reason that John knew all of these things. But for the time being the best he could do was pass on the things he had

James Roapes had worked at the Mill during his junior and senior years of high school. It was a stipulation of the Roapes Family Trust that a male inheritor must have worked a certain number of years in order to earn the right to his allotment. But the contractual language had been quite vague and in the history of the Roapes family there was only one male family member who had not received his allotment on account of the employment clause—though his father had tried his hardest to make it a pair of them.

Whereas Uncle James had met the stipulation by working part-time during his high school years, and full time for the next four years, as a fisherman at first, and then on the business side of the industry, having realized that his compulsive drive for intoxicating substances (of any any all varieties) did not align well (or perhaps aligned too well) with the life of a deep sea fisherman—his father, on the other hand, had spent the five years during which he was supposed to hold down full time occupation finding ways to bypass the system, quite successfully, and in the end had acquired the unique occupational skill set of a white collar thief. A master manipulator, forger, loophole creator, reader of fine print, and most of all a prodigious liar: that was John's father.

His father's lifestyle left little room for John (or for John's mother, but that is a separate matter to be dealt with elsewhere in this narrative)—and as John was a particularly sensitive and aware child, it did not take long for him to understand that this was the way of the world. He was swimming against the current. His father disappeared into taverns and good ol' boy social clubs filled with men who in turn despised their own fathers. It was his mother's recognition of this void that brought Uncle James over

when John was young. Though James was younger than Henry, he was the more responsible, ethical, moral and considerate of the two men. He recognized what Bea had seen, and so it was that Uncle James spent the summer of his 24th year (having decided to take a break from the smell of fish guts) and taught John everything he'd learned about trees, mills, carpentry—all while building a small clubhouse together. John considered it the best summer of his life, and believed it could never be outdone, if not for the arrival of W. T. that might have been true, but he realized as they continued evaluating the characters in the woodwork that afternoon, that things were going to change in significant ways, though he wasn't sure how, or for that matter, how soon.

W. T. had listened with excitement that further encouraged John to show him more and more of his favorite spots in the house. Finally, John introduced W. T. to *The Burl*, which was a large swirl of a spot that fluctuated in shades of darkness, undulating beneath W. T.'s ecstatic gaze. It was tucked into a corner, on the floorboard at the intersection of two massive bookcases. You could almost see the ideas beginning to take shape in his mind—he'd found the location of the big bang, the genesis that set everything else off that would follow.

In what was perhaps W. T.'s first fully drawn out fictitious world *The Burl* was born. "The Burl" itself was the dragon that had breathed life into the entire world. It was a large swirl of a spot, which was actually not a burl, but John was too excited to tell him otherwise. W. T. said that embedded in the floor of the Great House someone had intentionally left the story of the Burl encoded in the wood. He began to point at spots that John's eyes had passed over so many times without noticing anything at all and telling John about a great war that had occurred. There were two planks laid side by side that had come from very different pieces of wood, one had many small, pointed shapes in succession, an angled cut that showed the concentric rings as something like long thin arrowheads.

John spoke of the difference between plain sawn, quarter sawn, rift sawn and live sawn oak. W. T.'s eyes widened.

Part X: Section 1.5.0

Mee-Maw was a Roapes by marriage, not blood, but she was esteemed as a matriarch as if by lineage. This was in no small part because she had played a significant role in saving the family from falling into complete and utter ruin by deciding to marry Pappy, who was at that time still known only as Percy or Percival. She often joked that he ought to have gone into sales seeing as how he had conned her into marriage in less than a year, and in a way it certainly did appear to be a wedding that was largely beneficial to the Roapes Family Trust. But those who know the truth of the matter know there was no con involved in the shared affections between Pappy and Deborah—if he were to have worked any sort of con it must have been on Deborah's father, who in essence agreed to revive the Roapes Family name

with one last investment, in the hopes that it would keep his one and only daughter from leaving XX Island for good – and in that sense his efforts were not in vain.

Percival Roapes and Deborah Wrathburn were two individuals that displayed the sort of manifest attraction and person-to-person magnetism that is well known to lead normally sober minded individuals to utter words as preposterous as “ *true love* ” and “ *soulmates* ” in reference to the pairing, even if the words were only spoken as part of a monologue about what saving grace it had been for the Roapes family (and how inconvenient for certain other families who had been circling the Roapes land like turkey hawks, waiting for the stubborn creature to fall over dead), the Roapes family had a knack for luck and “Roapes Luck” was a term utilized on XX to signify either a blessing in the form of a curse, or the opposite (and sometimes, perhaps, both).

It was late summer 1942 and the Great War was in full thrall when Pappy and his three best friends went off to enlist. It had already touched some of the families on the island more than others. But of the four boys that left to enlist that day, Pappy had been the only one to return to the Island, both turned down by the Army and informed of a significant medical defect, the likes of which had never been made clear to anyone apart from Pappy and that small group of friends.

Upon informing his family that afternoon, his father’s response was that he’d never known a man to flunk out of the Army. His mother hushed the man, who stood and slapped her once in return, but soon thereafter realized that he’d already found himself deep enough in the bottle that it was hard to keep his feet, and so stumbled to the backdoor of the greathouse, cursing, and disappeared in the direction of the Johnson’s small shack, where he often spent all day drinking with Eustace and Napoleon Johnson anyways.

When his mother approached her son, big red hand outlined across her cheek, his eyes were near ready to overflow with tears but he held them in out of anger. He saw a tear run down his mother’s flat, stoic face and thought to himself that she was such a homely woman, noticing then the poor quality of her dress, and that her necklace, which she had never taken off for most of his life, had gone missing at some point since his father had hit the skids. He reached out to wipe the tear away with his hand and she instinctively flinched.

With that he could no longer control his tears and he ran off, up the stairs to his bedroom, as if he were six years old again. He hid in his room and began, then, to read. And read. And read some more. He began to read as if it were his job. For three straight days he did nothing but read. He had the maids bring him breakfast and supper in bed. His mother came knocking but he would only respond to let her know he was alive and then explain to her that he didn’t wish to see any visitors.

On the fourth day, around the same time, at 1445 precisely, his mother knocked on the door again - this time more forcefully. Before he could even respond she shouted through the crack between the door and the frame, “If you wish to send this young lady away for the third consecutive day, Percival, it is

time you'd be a man and come do it yourself. I will help you hide no longer, you hear? Not a second longer!" and then he heard her heels clicking away, down the hall.

Later, he thought of her and their first brief interaction as he watched from the widow's walk of the Great House while massive planes that seemed un beholden to physics droned overhead as if held aloft by helium (But, they were so loud which meant they were unnatural). They carried soldiers, he knew, but he did not know where—only that they went somewhere else first somewhere over there, where he could not go, because of a problem inside of him that did not create.

"Life is not fair," his father had said, and though it had been true, his father's words were always so thoroughly wrapped in lie that Percival had not fully believed him when he'd said it. *Certainly there was some balance in life, some version of fairness and the issue was in our perception, not the conditions themselves.* Certainly, he thought. But it was not so. Then Deborah might cross his mind and for a moment he didn't feel it any more, the Question at the Bottom.

Instead he heard her.

He thought she made a sound, as odd as it might seem, he thought she carried a sound inside her that only he could hear. The way there are certain frequencies at which adults can't hear a noise but children can. Or like the other frequency that could not be heard by any living thing but a certain very specific, and very rare sort of dog. The dog contained what is most accurately described as a lycanthropic gene mutation—

Listen, John, I can only tell you these things when it rains heavy, so no one else can hear...And do not tell a soul or I'll box your ears. You hear me son? Don't talk...Right, just nod.

—and this was of course where werewolves came from. They weren't monsters at all, just rare and malevolent dogs.

But with Deborah to think about, he'd largely stopped worrying about the dogs at all. He listened only for her and thought about what he'd said to her that day, when his mother had forced him to see her, unknowingly changing the course of his life in the most miraculous way.

He thought the planes were full of soldiers from the nearby base, where he'd gone with his three friends to enlist. He saw them flying out over the great expanse of the Atlantic in those fat, green, balloons, headed towards that which they were unable to imagine despite the fact that they'd done *nothing but* imagine it since that fateful day in December a year prior. With every plane that flew overhead he wondered if his friends might be aboard. Though, in truth, he was unaware of the machinations of the US military at the time, and in fact his friends had long since left the local area.

He spent long days burning in the hot sun on the Widow's Walk. Skin that never learned how to tan, just radiating redness, on the lookout for an impossibility, as it were - but mostly just thinking.

These were the days in which *dowries* had gone out of fashion in modern American social custom—but still existed via loopholes and more discrete practices particularly among the dwindling upper class—those who had not lost everything they had during the Great Depression that is, not financially at least, but now had found that the world had been forced into a new order despite them—nepotism, that is to say, came to function as a sort of dowry system stand in, at least on XX Island this much was certainly the case [\[30\]](#) .

It has since become apparent that the marriage of Pappy and MeeMaw is the only thing that kept the Roapes family from falling into complete disgrace, socially speaking, though none of this was known outside of Percival “Pappy” Roapes and Elias Whittaker Wrathburn, MeeMaw’s father, until the writing of this history necessitated the thorough investigation of XX history, which is to say the history of The Five, of House Agrippa, of The Bridge to Nowhere, of the Grayson family and Wagner College, of the GAN and his role and all that would occur—no, not a bit of this would have been known, and quite nearly went up in smoke without ever being discovered...but we must be patient, I am getting to all of that.

Of course, in the most obvious of ways, it was the cause of significant good fortune that Mee-Maw, coming from the wealthiest of the Five families, the Wrathburns, had (the week before the wedding) been made owner of a fleet of fifteen fishing and shrimping boats that had been turning profit for nearly a century by then. The ink had not dried on their marriage certificate by the time another contract was signed, in which the wife transferred ownership of said fleet to the husband.

In this way Pappy’s career was selected for him by marriage, he was to run XX Landing and the vessels that came with it, an occupation that involved some travel, some business sense, and some skills in the art of negotiation—but Pappy learned quickly that his role was primarily superficial. The contract had been drawn up such that he in fact was the largest shareholder, owning 49% of the company, but would never be able to overrule or even strike down the other 51%, given they were united in their decision making. And because they all shared a last name, the former last name of his new wife, they seemed to be in alignment most all of the time. Pappy realized that in large part his was an occupation that required he stay out of the way and allow the Wrathburn conglomerate that owned XX Landing to handle the accounting and financials from which he was compensated lavishly, sometimes uncertain entirely as to what the compensation was for, but learned quickly not to question.

There was always another check coming in, sometimes there were four or five in a week. Slowly but surely, alongside their two sons, Pappy watched the Roapes Family Trust grow into a suitably healthy state and by the time the oldest boy, Henry, was an adolescent, the Trust, which had been wisely invested and maintained, was growing all on its own. The way it once had prior to the catastrophic years that Pappy remembered all too well.

Second Semester, Senior Year 2002

W. T had only one goal from the moment he first stepped foot in XX High: To be done with high school.

In many ways he treated high school as if it were no more than a waste of his time, which was arguably the truth in W. T.'s case , but as he would often repeat over the course of his life (as if it were something he had learned from someone he idolized at a young age, but an idol he had since forgotten or fallen out of love with): *The trick is to treat time the way a wealthy man treats his money—make every bit of it work for you, and be cheap with it where others spend freely* . As such, because school took up such a substantial amount of time, he could not easily accept it, and felt the need to actively display his disdain for the entire system.

The fact of the matter is it got between him and his obsessions; and his obsessions were, for all intents and purposes, the very building blocks that W. T. was created from. They were his stone and mortar. He treated XX High commensurately as an impediment to be dealt with in a quiet and efficient manner. He was also smart enough to know that it would be a waste of time to expend his energy and resources bucking against a system that would never simply give in. He would grow frustrated fighting such a battle, and in the end it would break the very principle it was intended to serve.

They could make him attend, but they could not force him to listen. Particularly not when he was more informed on the subject matter than his teacher, as happened to be the case in most of the classes — so with each class he attended he made sure to do only what was necessary, and only in the most efficient way. If he found that a certain shortcut bothered his instructor he would evaluate the degree to which the teacher in question was bothered, whether convincing the teacher (because it was never a question of if he could convince them, but rather how much effort it would take to do so) was worth the effort involved—to put it in colloquial terms, if the juice was worth the squeeze. If more energy would be expended defending his position than doing whatever was asked of him despite the inefficiency then he would just do the extra time. As such, he invested a good deal of effort early on in the semester, when getting to know his teachers, in developing a tacit understanding with them that he would be the ideal student, he would certainly get great grades, and he would even make them look good with his presentation, etc., so long as, that was, he was left to his own devices. This was simply because the earlier he could set this precedent, the more of his semester he could save. Many of his teachers, who had a low threshold themselves with regard to how many fucks they gave about what a given student

did so long as he did not disrupt their class and delivered high marks on any standardized tests—many of them would allow W. T. to set up his desk in the corner of the class, where he would spend the entirety of many classes reading from books on subjects too advanced for the teachers themselves to understand in concept. He was particularly interested in string theory at the time (though he said it would be proven false, almost certainly, almost a decade before the hadron collider crushed the dreams and careers of a large share of the contemporary hard science community). He found classroom instruction useless, if he needed to learn something, he would read the textbook. It was usually the first thing he did at the beginning of a semester, read everything on the class syllabus, annotate and create personal notes. For the remainder of the semester he'd continue his voyage through the library at the Great House. He told John he had decided to select his reading material using some sort of a cipher based on the books of the Gnostic Gospels, and though John suspected he was really just selecting books at random, W. T. did like to have fun from time to time by writing obscure equations on random slips of paper and then adding the name of his next book just to give his friend something to chew on. By then W. T. was testing his theory that nothing was truly random, and had his hopes that John, in a moment of pure unfettered genius, would discover the pattern where there was none.

He was, in fact, left out of the school yearbook that year—it was a mistake, of course, but still offers some insight into the extent to which he was an active participant at XX High. He attended his classes and his grades were literally perfect for his entire tenure as a student. It was only due to a technicality, the fact that he graduated a semester early, and so was a part of his own graduating class, technically speaking, that he was not the valedictorian and received no awards or commendations during the Spring graduation ceremony. He was not even invited.

Scattered Theories: Interludes

Apophenia [\[31\]](#)

“Maybe,” W. T. said, “he was really talking about stories. Like real stories, you know.”

UNSORTED PAGES

Part X: Section 1.3.X

His mother brought home men but was no professional. She was a giver, one might say, which was at the core of most all of her problems when you got right down to it, they came from a place of giving - too much, more than she had, the wrong thing, the right thing at the wrong time, to the wrong person, or for no reason whatsoever. It was a compulsion of hers— an addiction like all the rest - she felt the need to constantly be giving things away, as if she would otherwise lose them.

These are my own personal thoughts, to be clear, and in no way are they offered as representative of what W. T. or the GAN or anyone else who knew Izzy Grayson would have to say on the subject. But it's what I noticed during those early years when W. T. ostensibly lived at my house (before the years in which he actually lived at my house) and his mother would call me in the interval between his leaving their double-wide (on foot) and reaching mine, which was a matter of six to eight minutes, giver or take, and which I came to expect, so I'd stand by the landline in my bedroom as soon as I knew he was about to come over so that I could answer the phone within seconds of hearing the first ring, so quickly that my parents might look around, or at one another, and mutually wonder if they'd heard something. I tried to answer it so quickly that it couldn't even be recognized as a ringing phone, but could just as easily be the sound of a plate clicking against another plate as it was pulled from the cupboard, or a watch band glancing off some metallic surface.

Frankly, I had no desire for them to be aware of how often I spoke to Izzy, almost as much as I didn't want W. T. to know, because the fact of the matter is I was well aware it was a strange thing, our talking the way we did— inappropriate, in a way— because she'd tell me personal things that she had no business telling me— about how W. T. still had a bedwetting problem, though it was infrequent, it was still often enough to be considered significant (which is to say more than something that happened to him a few times, here or there, because he was such a sound sleeper). She told me sometimes about a man she'd brought home that she thought had particularly upset W. T., and would I let her know if William seemed off, or upset about it, because she liked the man well enough, and he could really help them out if he was around more often, but if her little man didn't like him, well, she told me, if that was the case she'd stop seeing him just like that, no questions asked. No matter what I said or how I worded it she'd already decided by then that it wasn't worth it to get William all worked up over some guy who'd probably turn out to be another dead end— so even if I told her, *no, he really seems to like this guy, you shouldn't stop on account of W. T., in fact, he'd probably be a little sad if the guy disappeared on him* – even if I said that to her with a cool, composed countenance, she would end up dumping him within the month. Sometimes for reasons she had failed to mention, like the good guy could be a little gruff and physical at the end of a workday, with a few beers in his system. And of course she never mentioned that sometimes it wasn't a case of her not allowing the thing to go on, but that it had been put to rest by the other party— though even then, at sixteen or seventeen, I was old enough, and well-read enough to make some assumptions about the way she was perceived by the men she met while working behind the desk at the Fuel Mart, and that it was unlikely the percentage of “good guys” she brought home after work was truly as high as she made it seem. I knew enough to know that guys were pretty quick to

stick their dick in anything soft and warm, and mostly she was just fucking these guys, and that some of them probably even EXPECTED her to try to press them for cash and felt uncomfortable when they realized that the sex they'd had was not as purely transactional as they'd imagined and that might have been the reason why they acted even nicer than she'd initially thought. In essence, she'd saved them thirty, forty, fifty bucks; whatever they might have thought she'd press them for, and they'd likely felt more guilt than they would have if she'd just made the whole thing more professional, but instead they had to be kind and pretend like it was something that it wasn't. I knew all that but I never said as much to W. T.'s mother, because what kind of asshole would that make me.

She often hung up crying when I told her I saw him round the corner and I'd better go. And there was a lingering, palpable sense of something having been "going on", when he'd walk up the back staircase to my personal bedroom door (by sixteen I'd moved into the apartment-like loft in our garage and I had my own entrance and exit and way more freedom than I could ever imagine giving my own children if had any, I thought even then).

And to address the elephant in the room— yes, I was sexually attracted to W. T.'s mother for all the reasons I just expressed and more. She was an objectively attractive woman with well proportioned features and a body that was too thin for her health but thin in the right way to make the difference between her hips and stomach noticeable in the way Coca-Cola bottles were designed to replicate.

Besides, at sixteen I was no Cassanova, not that I ever would be one, and I spoke more to W. T.'s mother than I did to just about any of the sixteen year old girls in my class, who were all at this point predictably busy fucking the guys on the football team, or the baseball team, or for some of the ones who wore a certain type of jeans they'd fuck the basketball team, which was composed of the most popular black guys at our school.

It was the turn of the millennium and race was a problem that I thought had mostly become a thing of the past - but what I realized in high school was that no kids really understand racism because it hasn't hit them yet - so when I started to notice there were differences between the way us white kids lived, and were treated, and the types of girls that would fuck us, I initially thought that it was a new flare up of racial injustice rather than the consequence of getting older and seeing, more clearly, the biases and bigotry that were present everywhere I looked.

In any event, none of the girls who any of the athletes wanted to fuck were interested in fucking me - I was unathletic and read a lot of books, and kept my headphones on and my hood up for most of the day when I was in school. Years later one of the girls eventually told me there was a persistent rumor that W. T. and I were gay together, even though he DID have sex with some of the popular girls - and that to be honest, she would have probably been more interested in me, back then, had she known I was just a quiet, bookish type— which, although it was nice to hear, and I appreciated her turning an embarrassing admission into a sort of flirtation, I also knew that it wasn't true, what she was saying about how she would have wanted to fuck me back then, and that it was only now that she was a sad, twenty-six year

old divorcee that the idea of sleeping with a kind of smart, nice guy appealed to her. And what I wanted to tell her but did not was that even her perception of me as a smart, nice guy was pretty off the mark and deep down if I did fuck her (either in that moment, or if it had happened back in high school like she was saying it could have) that I would have been doing it mostly for the worst possible reasons— with a devil-may-care attitude towards the damage those sort of one-off, you-only-live-once decisions that are gateway decisions to the heavier stuff, once you’ve stopped even trying to lie to yourself and the symptoms of atrophy in and around whatever soul nourishing parts of you remain (somewhere in the gut, personally, but people seem to keep their souls in all different parts of their bodies from what I can tell - W. T. swore he kept his in his left arm, oddly enough— we’ll get there).

Truth: Every time you do that sort of thing, that empty/unsettled/bottomless thing I’m fumbling to describe (because sex is just one of the simplest, most obvious examples, but there are so, so, so many more we choose every day if we aren’t looking), once you are there, suddenly the hovering knowledge of the fundamental lie you are telling yourself unleashes its full arsenal of tools on you. This, really is just one of the growingly pervasive and overwhelming symptoms of the “imposter-syndrome,” which has become an assumed component of modern adulthood, vis-a-vis the semi-ironic and detached verb ‘adulting’, which as much as it is mocked by baby-boomers, who were born into a world where managing an adult life had not yet taken on the absurd but shared understanding that the onboarding process for life had gotten harder not easier, since our parents had gone through it, yet the expectations had altogether stayed the same, which in a capitalist society actually means that the expectation was income growth because if you are not growing you’re dying in the world we live in, so to speak – that darkness that grows inside a person if left unchecked, and can eventually replace the person altogether the way a petrified tree turns to stone, slowly (so slowly) until each molecule has been replaced without moving from its allocated position.

Origin Story: 1 of 5

John and W. T. became quick friends if only because it was a need that they happened to share.

Neither child was particularly extroverted, especially when it came to other children their own age.

John’s solitude could be partially attributed to his natural introversion, inclined to participate in activities that did not depend on others to be successful. He was naturally averse to group projects, and forced social outings - preferring the company of books, which was something he’d picked up as a result of spending so much time with his grandfather at the Great House, where the joke was always to ask who was in charge of the other one.

W. T. on the other hand, gave one the impression that, though he was often on his own—and so had adapted to the lifestyle by learning to keep himself entertained—it seemed as though he had been shaped in a different direction than he had been initially intended to grow. Like a heavily manicured

plant, trimmed and tied and pulled and positioned in such a way to force it to grow sideways rather than upwards—or perhaps, more like the plant that has somehow grown in the cracks and crags of some high and remote mountain top in Patagonia, grown towards that far off light as if willed to be so, blooming with irreverence, gazing out towards the sublime with a hint of awareness of its own status as paradox. It would be difficult to say that their similarities outweighed their differences. Though at the same time it is difficult to overlook the fact that they were both inordinately intelligent for their age, both had spent more time around adults than children for the predominant part of their childhood. Both vaguely resented their mother, purely despised their fathers. But only one of them actually knew their father and could put a face to the hatred. For the other, it was a simmering indignation that had no one to hold to account—and as such seemed to end up feeding upon the source for its nourishment.

[Incomplete]

Part X: Section 1.0.5

W. T. had not seen himself, or his mirror or alternate or imitator or whatever it had been, he'd only seen John standing beside the road, looking perplexed, as was often the case, and was glad to have found him after searching the island for so long. When he told this to John his friend's expression, which had been one of joy and relief at their reconnection, had gone back to its original state of perplexity and concern. "What do you mean *for so long*?" he asked. "How long?"

W. T. now took on the same confused look. "Since you stormed off," he said. He exhaled a nervous laugh and it dissipated as quickly as it had been made. "You were so mad. I thought you'd come back. We both did. When you didn't come back by midnight I got worried."

John was visibly shaken, he began to ask a question, "What..." but then stopped after just the one word had left his mouth and disappeared into his own head again.

"I woke Pappy. He'd been waiting up for you too, but you know how Pap is—he fell asleep in his armchair, and so I sat there beside him and eventually woke him up. He felt bad, he'd been having one of his fits you know. It wasn't him that said all that. I figured you knew that. I figured you were just getting some air." W. T. stopped and gave John a moment to respond, perhaps expecting him to nod in agreement, or apologize for disappearing on them, but John had gone pale and stupefied. He looked like his mother, W. T. noticed. It was the first time he'd ever seen it—but there was something quite strong and stoic behind his dark eyes that he'd rarely exposed before. "Anyways—I woke Pappy and I said you were still gone. It was just like the dream I'd had—and Pappy goes, 'He's there.' I thought he was asleep or half dreaming, but no, he was completely lucid, and he sort of chuckled to himself and then looked me right in the eyes and said, 'I'll tell you where to go—but ain't no guarantees what you're gonna find.' He said it all ominous like that, which I knew was Pappy's way, but also it was a little different than that too—I could tell he was serious. He told me *Ain't noone without Roapes blood in 'em ever been there before. You get me boy? I don't know what happens if you go.* And I brushed

him off like I wasn't nervous, but I was, you know?—Are you listening to me? —John!" He shouted this time and John, startled, perked up a bit.

"Yeah, I'm listening man. I'm listening. I don't know what the hell is going on but I'm listening. You mean you weren't in the tent? The storm? This morning—the light?"

W. T. made a show of concern. He put an arm on John's shoulder and a hand on his back and led him to one of the limbs of the giant oak they stood beneath, finally ushering John to sit down on the low hanging branch, thick as a trunk of most other trees, hanging so low it almost touched the ground.

"Take a seat," he said. "Here, drink something," pulling out a bottle of water from his backpack, the same black Jansport he'd carried his entire life.

John took the water and chugged, thanking him. It wasn't until the water hit his dry, parched throat that he realized how thirsty he'd been. His body shook with gratitude. A headache he hadn't noticed he'd been carrying immediately began to dissipate. He finished the whole bottle in one long chug and then put the cap back on it and looked at the empty vessel for a moment. Not really thinking anymore about anything, but letting his thoughts work on their own, as if he were only an observer and they could go on working while he rested for a moment.

X.X. Island: 1.0

X. X. Island was populated long before people who looked like me showed up, gave it the name X. X. Island, and proceeded to kill, convert, or enslave every actual X. X. on the island. My family was one of the First Five, as they have been reverentially titled - the evidence of which is visible in the names of once prominent thoroughfares across the island; likewise with certain creeks, inlets and ponds. A one room school that now serves as a Church bears our name to this day. And perhaps most impressively, one of the two bridges that connect this island to other bodies of land bears my family name: Roapes Bridge (or, more officially, the "Stephen P. Roapes Bridge").

However, due to the declining class status of my ancestral forebears and thus, the decreasing frequency of their name in community related decision making boards, trusts, committees and things of that nature, the Roapes family name took on some loaded connotations and associations that in 1894, the Island's Governing Body known only as "The Hall", took it upon themselves to decree, unofficially, that the bridge be referred to thereafter as the "X. X. Connector," and it would, only in legal documents, be referred to as The "Stephen P. Roapes" bridge, and this maintained only because of the legal costs and effort that would have been required to go about legally changing the name, as well as the fact that my Great-Great-Grandfather, the representative for our family in all Island related items, is said to have threatened to expose some very consequential secrets related to three of the four other families that were a part of The Five.

And there you have it, a well stocked arsenal of secrets can be a powerful tool to have in one's toolkit when it comes to navigating the politics of a small coastal island in coastal South Carolina. One of my bucket-list items is to see the sign for the "X. X. Connector" taken down and appropriately replaced with a new green and white sign for the "Stephen P. Roapes Bridge," even if most everyone who crosses that bridge still passes the sign without so much as a glance.

GAN: 1.0

Though perhaps the following commentary is unnecessary, *a priori* [\[32\]](#) as it were, to be thorough, and in order to ensure there is no possibility of misunderstanding, I believe some qualifications may be beneficial as to defend the pure objectivity of the facts, if only because nine times out of ten this sort of statement (as in, a statement that begins with a proclamation of its own inherent truth value) is far from objective and rather indicates a pervasive subjectivity on behalf of the statement's source.

Following the publication and near instantaneous panegyricization of his second novel (*The Absence of Blue* , 1974, University of Chatham Press), the Great American Novelist was nationally recognized as "the voice of a generation," (New York Times [\[33\]](#)). There was unanimous agreement among the moderates of the intellectual literati—those that defined the "American Literary Canon" from an academic perspective presented as a unified front which was in and of itself a miracle to behold—agreement among critics being as close to an oxymoron as you can get without actually being oxymoronic. Perhaps more importantly than the critical acclaim it received in academic circles by those distinguished purveyors of fine literature, was the reception that TAOB received from the radical bohemian intellectuals, writers and thinkers who railed against the establishment on principle. Yes, most astounding was the unqualified, and again unanimous, praise heard in the throughout the underground community— they who determined what was *hip* , in a general sense, by identifying all that which was *anti-canonical*, groups who despised the New York Times bestseller list (For what did sales have to do with quality? In this case, as in many others from my perspective, they had a valid perspective— if only they could organize more efficiently, like an academy, so that their voice could be more resonant— but, I digress), one of them going as far as to say that TAOB was "a love letter, a bible, a creed and a call to action all dedicated to the misanthropic casualties of Dos Passos's *America*" – those circles that, at the time, were composed primarily of Loaisidas running zines out of Alphabet City apartments, who wrote the way they spoke and spoke the way they thought, mad geniuses living on dope and pure, unfettered belief in the singular redemption mad real only through art for art's sake; pre-ironic saints of *Real Art* , burgeoning pioneers of the postmodern aesthetic (*postmodern* specifically in its most direct context, which is to say: *that which follows Modernism*) – even in these circles the G.A.N. quickly bypassed cult status and was assigned the status of prophet— somehow bridging the

unbridgeable gap— the canyon of cultural division that may be best represented by the distance from *Between C and D* to the small, green, oasis-like campus of Columbia University, hidden behind the tall, ornate walls that kept students from the dangerous realities of pre-gentrification Morningside Heights, where *the Great Professors* of the time took turns shaping the face of American literature by deciding what books belonged in their class syllabi, and by extension in the anthologies that would become the go to texts across the nation for the next decade of English courses.

It was not long, then, before sociology, psychology, and philosophy departments started listing classes with names like “Marxism and *The Absence of Blue*” or “*The Absence of Blue* : A Survey of Post-Colonial American Perspectives”. The book was just *that big* . It changed the landscape that surrounded it, and one who ran amongst those circles can attest to the fact that there was the vague, general feeling of being a part of something that was really happening. Something that would alter the course of literature for better or worse.

The Absence of Blue , it turned out, would be considered one of the G.A.N.’s minor works by the time he committed suicide.

This was the beginning, it might seem, well before he had composed a single sentence of *The Pentad* , which would become his magnum opus, the Nobel Prize winning, five-book (or four thousand, four hundred and seventy two page) American epic that spanned generations, themes, topics and characters— in summary said to contain “everything vital that ever was, is, or will be a product of America”. Translated into languages so obscure the G.A.N. himself admitted he did not know several of them even existed.

So universal was the acclaim; so American was the prose, the pace, the characters and settings, the paradoxes and questions— that there is left no room for doubt as to the G.A.N.’s position among the greatest writers to have lived, and to this day there exists not one iota of disagreement regarding his status as the greatest American writer of the 20th century.

The only question, if it even merits mention, is what he would have done with the 21st century, and whether or not the three novels he published between 2000 and 2007 (his 21st century output, as it were, was made up of three novels, but also two books of philosophy, a number of short stories and poems, as well as an unfinished film script which was made into a movie after his death, despite being unfinished, and actually won the Academy Award for Best Screenplay) can possibly be outdone within the eighty or so years that remain in the century as of my putting this whole story to paper. Or if, as it were, the Great American Novelist is a title that found its home, and assuming the Great American Experiment in general is going to, like the structure of a novel, have a beginning, middle and end— I guess it seems possible to me that there may not be any further transfers of power, just as there cannot be a new Greatest Emperor of Ancient Rome, for example.

All of this is to say, no matter what you think of me or my friend William Theodore Grayson, because in recounting the story there is no doubt that many of the decisions we made, actions we took or failed to take, and even many of the little, inconsequential thoughts or failures of character that accrued along the way, will ultimately leave the reader with a more complex version of the (capital T) *Truth* regarding the lives of the Great American Novelist, of my friend W. T. Grayson (the titular *bastard son*), and by extension, I suppose, of my own life - which is probably, really, actually, truly where I need to start - if only that weren't the part of the story I understand the least.

Yours Truly: 1.0

...who is comfortable speaking about himself in the third person to the extent that it makes him uncomfortable about himself. Who for some reason has always imagined himself as some sort of third person version of himself anyways, as if he were watching the film reel of his life, even during the moments when he was supposedly most passionately living it. Who, for example, remembers the first time he got to third base in the back row of a movie theater via something like a three quarter angle camera angle, the sort of angle they use for basketball games to capture the action at the individual level (the ball being dribbled and passed and shot in long looping arcs and the precise angle of refraction with which it hits the rim) and simultaneously provide an overarching perspective of the big picture (the team's formation, a straggling seven footer loafing over to the bench, the purple faced coach yanking at his white hair and the explosion the crowd makes when the ball passes through the net, rather than refracting, hundreds if not thousands of individual expressions captured in unison) - the memory itself works like this too, so that sometimes he pays attention to the actual fumbling hand trying to undo the button of the girl, Melinda's, jeans, all the while trying not to make a point of the fact that it is difficult due to the paunch of her stomach, which like the rest of her is slightly overweight and has been forced into clothes that are a size or two too small- or sometimes he pans out and sees the rest of the row, adolescent couples all of them, each with an empty chair between them; a chair that is used to as a support for a cramping hand or elbow or other body part depending on the adventurousness of the adolescent co-eds, to balance the more ambitious of the pair (which was not always the male, and in fact, in his memory was surprisingly often the female at least based on his observations and experiences, the former more than the latter), posed in that uncomfortable position whenever the camera panned wide, and what was even more was his memory even contained the glint of the movie theater employee, who by law was at least eighteen, but by appearances could have just as easily been one of the back row collective, with his uniform (which he can swear they still wore back then) that made him look like a sort-of acne-ridden bellhop, and in the flickering semi-darkness of the movie theater a scary one at that, the shadows falling across his face in time with whatever scene was on screen (nearly always something from Memento, Guy Pearce and his tattoos and that confused look and time moving forward by the second but backwards in increments, in such a way that had blown his

mind the first time he'd seen it so much that it always seemed to be the movie he remembered playing at the movie theater no matter when he pictured the scene even though he'd likely only seen it the once, and almost certainly would never have taken a potential double or triple of a date to see a movie that he'd always want to watch, but in any case) –the bellboy like employee with his flashlight pointed down at the ground, swaying as he walked, attached to his waste by one of those extension cord type retractable clip ons, and he remembered the way the creepy bellhop would linger in the corner, sort of watching the various teenagers in their lustful embraces and wait until he could tell for certain that there was something worth shining a light on (he always imagined the bellhop was more aroused than anything else by the goings on in the back row of the movie theater and it would later turn out that this was more true than anyone knew at the time), so in his memory they are being watched as they *make-out*, and Melinda is fatter in his memory than she was in reality– though still nowhere close to the level of morbid obesity that she would achieve in her early twenties, making it impossible to accurately recall the normal looking, slightly heavy set Melinda of his memory, or to remember her in an objectively accurate way relative to the time period, that is, meaning fourteen or fifteen years of age, circa 1996/1997. Who remembers especially the way he fumbled around with the button for so long that Melinda herself got embarrassed and stretched back in the chair and unbuttoned her pants for him with a sort of blasé attitude that made him feel less excited about the endeavor, and at the same time worried that she had much more experience than he'd assumed and as such would realize right away that he had never actually touched a female pubic hair, let alone actually identify a clitoris in the dark with either his index or middle finger, or both (he couldn't decide), and although he immediately felt all of the romantic anticipation flood from the room he at least now knew for certain that he had been given access, the third base coach was telling him to make a break for it, and he remembers more than anything else about this particular event the confusion that struck him as he put his hand down Melinda's pants and felt pubic hair, and assuming he was close sort of rubbed his hand around on the front part of her groin, which was where he had always imagined the vagina lived, sort of pointing outward as it were, in the same place his penis began, and he remembers very confusedly searching for some time until Melinda, who by then had realized she'd have been better off just going to the bathroom and taking care of herself, grabbed his hand by the wrist and shoved it further down her pants than he ever thought would be necessary until he felt the dry outer labia, like a set of pursed but chapped lips, and proceeded to rub in circles around the outer edges of her vagina until he miraculously identified an opening, and realized that what he thought was one thing was in fact two lips he needed to part in order to gain entrance and then finally stuck one finger in, near the very top, but could not get very far, not very far at all, at which point the flashlight appeared out of nowhere, blinding him as he pulled his hand free as quickly as possible and Melinda, clearly very disappointed, made a sort of shocked noise as she quickly zipped her pants up and stared straight ahead, and the bellhop muttered in a loud whisper, "I catch you two agin n' yer out of here, mmkay?" and he, young Roapes nodded, but as soon as the light went away he turned back to Melinda who, to his complete and utter disbelief, had started making out with an older boy, who had taken up the empty seat to her left at some point that the younger boy could not recall, and had his hand elbow deep in her jeans and John Roapes could hear her

audibly moan as he stood to leave, Guy Pearce staring at him, completely naked from the big screen in the background.

That is John LaFontaine Roapes, in a manner of speaking.

History: 1.1

Birth:

1. 11/30/1984
 - 1.1. X. X. Island
 - 1.2. 2311 hrs.
2. Born on the kitchen floor of the (*Once*) *Great House* on November 30th, 1984 (X. X. Island). The (*Once*) *Great House*, or the “Main House”, as it was referred to by the other members of the family who did not share John’s self-deprecating sense of humor and had much more difficulty coming to terms with the realities of their family’s fall from eminence, as it were, was truly once a very great house. At the time of his birth perhaps this was less recognizable than it is today, as John, or JR, spent a large portion of his relatively minor inheritance—certainly with the understanding that having an inheritance that is significant enough to do such a thing highlights the relativity of a minor inheritance. This is to say JR was appropriately aware that his family was of some means, more unclear to him was the actual value of their once expansive and well-known estate, because in his entire life (or perhaps, more accurately, in that portion of his life that he truly recalls, meaning from age nineteen or so onward for some reason he could not even formulate clearly enough to deny) he had never once received the same answer from two individuals or even the same answer from one individual on separate occasions. It was as if the value of the Roapes family’s historical wealth fluctuated based on the phase of the moon or the astrological alignment of certain planets (which, in some ways, when speaking of value in its proper sense must certainly be true—based as it must be on the relative value of the US dollar at the time of the question itself). The value was not only contingent on who was asked, but when they were asked and by whom. The later into the evening it got, the more likely the number was to expand or contract radically, tongues loosened by that most powerful storytelling lubricant, moonshine, which the family had been in the business of crafting and distribution since the profitable but rather unsettling years of Prohibition.

They no longer did it for the money, the whole endeavor operated at a net loss like many of the Roapes endeavors, but they were always in stock - and that remains the case to this very day, in fact, given you make acquaintances with the correct sorts of folks and exude an attitude of the utmost discretion. The Roapes shine, in particular, was known to be both incredibly potent and come in a variety of fruit flavored combinations. JR’s favorite was blueberry, by a wide margin, though it would be safe to assert that the greater part of their

customers had always preferred straight White Lightning, as it was indeed the strongest variant and could easily be mixed with any number of beverages to be adapted to one's preferred flavor palette.

Moonshine though was more or less a familial "side hustle", however, and fails to capture the root of the Roapes wealth, which has also always been something of a moving target. The Roapes, it could be and has been said, are a lineage of professional bullshitters of the highest pedigree. Tracing back through their genealogy you find bible/cutlery/encyclopedia/insurance/etc. salesmen, you find stories of swindled parcels of land and massive amounts of high-stakes gambling, some evidence of farming in the early days (but that most honorable and respected profession was always a massive failure for the Roapes family and was the cause of the first great loss suffered by the family in the early nineteenth century when a hurricane (they did not name them in those days) tore across the island damaging crops and fence lines alike, and leaving in its wake fifty or so heads (and bodies) of cattle, rotten and pungent as can only be imagined. The smell was pervasive across the island for over a week, always on the mind of the residents that those poor cattle had not managed to keep their heads above the water level for such a sustained duration, and as they died one by one, in one of those sick ironies that mother nature is quick to provide, it was only then, after death, that they turned on their sides and floated on the top of the water, traveling far and wide on the island and reportedly causing a subsequent outbreak of some odd and unknown bacterial disease that went on to take the lives of another ten to twelve individuals of X. X. (who, perhaps were the victim of natural selection in some ways, having made the decision to bathe in and likely ingest water from, the same ponds and freshwater sources from which at least a few of the fifty or so mega-corpses of waterlogged cattle had been extracted only days prior). It was a source of significant shame for Heathcliffe Roapes, the Patriarchal head of the clan at the time, for he had been warned against cattle farming in such a location by not one but three of The Five families and he later discovered that they had an ongoing bet with one another with regard to how long his endeavor would exist without disaster. It was Archibald Redfield who took home the money betting that they would last two winters but not survive through November of the third year - and indeed it was November 2nd when that great storm hit.

It should come as no surprise then, that the Roapes and the Redfields have been feuding in some capacity ever since - which will not be entirely irrelevant to the life of W. T. Grayson - in ways that surprised John Roapes most of all, as he felt so far removed from the family by the time the feud impacted his life that it almost seemed to have reached out and grabbed him, much like Michael Corleone in *The Godfather III*, a wildly underrated film in the series, disliked because it did not mirror the same tone and function of the prior two films, with those critical viewers failing to recognize the fact that time, by nature, necessitates a change not only in people and characters, dialogue and mannerisms, but also in the way a story is told in its own right. As we inched towards the 21st century cultural and societal changes accelerated at such a clip that the gap of a few years contained what in previous decades might have taken several

generations to proliferate. And *TGIII*, while by no means a perfect film [34] at least dares to make the leap into the modern world and take something on— at least, that is, has the courage to be not another ambiguous film about the ambiguity of life and all its ambiguous peculiarities for example watching a film about heartless, murderers that you actually, deep-down-inside like. No, *TGIII*, goes for nothing of the sort, it lets protagonists die and works with genre clichés (or tropes, if you want to be an intellectual about it) and it does so in a way that admits it is a gratuitous film made for gratuitous purposes. If *TGII* is the ‘Nam Vet who came home stoic and stone-faced and beat his children quiet as a result of the horrors he’d seen, the vet who earned his purple heart and truly appreciated it on Veterans Day when he was thanked for his service, because he knew deep down he had taken on a terrible cost in the service of something greater—if that is *TGII*—then *TGIII* was my Uncle James, who came home from Vietnam and, having seen his superior officer squeeze the tits of a Vietnamese woman while her husband sat tied up in a chair and was *interrogated*, and who stood in the corner of that same room for another five minutes as his superior proceeded to lift up the wife’s dress, and pull her dirty white underwear upwards so that he could show the husband what his “*wife’s pussy would look like if she was cut in half*,” all while the husband shouted and screamed at him and the officer responded aloud, not to the man, but to the other soldiers like James, who had been forced to come in and watch a “*real interrogation*” that you could tell the man was lying, and spoke English, by the way his eyes looked up and to the left when he twisted the woman’s nipple— like Uncle James, who in the end had realized not only that the man did not speak English, and was no enemy combatant, and had taken the butt of his M16 [RESEARCH NEEDED REGARDING WEAPONS AND TERMINOLOGY] and proceeded to bring it down upon his superior’s head with a sort of violence he had not displayed once in the four or so months since he’d been there, who then continued to wail on the superior officer until two of the other soldiers in the room pulled him off and told him to cool it, be cool man, and said that he’d done the right thing by stopping the superior officer in the way he had but not to kill the cat because that would land him in Leavenworth, the same two soldiers who later would testify against him in the military tribunal, stating that they had said all of this to try to calm a ‘*lunatic*’ (one of several common terms used in both of their testimonies despite the fact that they testified with their hand on the Bible that they had not communicated or collaborated in any capacity regarding the testimony they would give regarding the incident in question), and in the end *TGIII* is like Uncle James who saw through the bullshit and acted against it in a way that itself was also a result of the romanticization of violence, but was at its core an unambiguous statement on what he thought was right and wrong, and who ultimately was found guilty and would have been sentenced to 2-7 years in Leavenworth for the military equivalent of aggravated attempted manslaughter, but was then taken into a room with two military lawyers and not a single recording device or window, and was told he could leave the building at that moment, with nothing but the clothes on his back and five hundred dollars cash (they slid it towards him in a small white envelope that was laughably thin) under the condition that he

signed this paper, which one of them pulled out from underneath the table even though there wasn't a drawer or basket or anywhere under the table that the document could have been stored (he wondered about this for many, many years), and the two soldier lawyers gave him a pen and said it meant he would never speak about the incident that occurred in [Research Location Name in Vietnam] meaning never, period, not even to his wife or mistress or while he was drunk at a bar in Tuscaloosa, not when he was ninety nine years old, or they would find him and throw his ass in Leavenworth where there were dogs that had been specifically trained to bite the asshole off a man if they were snapped at in a particular fashion. TGIII is like Uncle James, because, although a man with a moral code, he did not actually want to be a martyr when it all came right down to it, and so he finally gave up after having come so far and he took the money and left. Which is all to say Uncle James turned out to be a sad living casualty of Vietnam, on account of his own decisions– which were stronger, better decisions than his peers or superiors had made, but in the end ultimately turned out to aptly reflect the reality of life, which is that we all would have taken the \$500 when staring down the barrel of two to seven in Leavenworth, but very few of us would have stepped in and made the decisions that brought him to that sad excuse for a court. So, in some way, does TGIII ask all the right questions and deal with the problems of the genre in a straightforward and very self-conscious way, and also, like my Uncle James, ties on a clean bow at the end so that it does not have to answer for itself completely, because maybe it doesn't know how, or maybe, perhaps, there is no answer at all to certain things in life and it is more efficient and realistic to just take the money at the end of the day, once all that remains is the sentencing/credits.

So, this has been the chapter in which I introduce Uncle James, or James, who is second only to W. T. in my mind when I am asked about the people I admire/cherish/respect. The other important thing that needs to be made clear is that Uncle James, like myself, never really got along all that well with my father, and it was my father's running joke that maybe Uncle James (who was my father's Irish twin, and looked in all honesty as if they were actual twins) had pulled a fast one on my Mom the night she got pregnant with me, because it always seemed to him(my father) that Uncle James and I had the same thing wrong with us, but he couldn't quite put his finger on what it was.

I should also note that I am well aware the previous entry providing datum around the birth of one John LaFontaine Roapes was completely derailed and strayed an enormous amount from the expected brief biographical note that was intended. Furthermore, I am well aware that I have, here, ruptured the fourth wall irreparably. But far be it from me to let important details go to waste so, I must ask the reader to reset, as it were, and though I cannot justify the creation of a net new subsection to rectify my little authorial faux-pas (I can feel W. T.'s critical eyes boring a hole in the back of my head from some unknown realm), I aim to *soldier on*, as Uncle James would say in his deadpan-irony-infused manner, and ask that we return to the pre-detour status—in order that we can properly take in all of the— **ahem** — objective information that follows about John L. Roapes.

Birth:

1. 11/30/1984
2. X. X. Island
3. 2311 hrs.

Gender:

1. Male

Age:

1. 34 Years [\[35\]](#)

Hair Color:

1. Dark Brown (Black, in photographs)

Residences:

1. 1 Roapes Drive
 - 1.1. The Great House
 - 1.1.1. The second oldest home on the Roapes land, referred to as “The Great House” by members of the Roapes family because of its omnipresence in Roapes family history and lore. That it is the second oldest home on the property is a bit of a misnomer, as only a small portion of it, approximately five hundred square feet that makes up the back left corner of the house today, is the portion that is said to date back to the turn of the 17th century. The rest of the house was built in stages, continually growing until approximately 1934, when the last of the additions, the East Wing, was finalized in order to balance the façade. Which indeed it did, making the house look (in shape at least) something like a slightly smaller, and much more colorful, version of the White House.
 - 1.2. Dates of Residence
 - 1.2.1. November 30, 1984 - September 12, 1990
2. 3 Roapes Drive
 - 2.1. The Ghost House
3. 4 Roapes Drive
 - 3.1. Current Residence [\[36\]](#)

Occupation(s):

1. Customer Service Representative (Cashier) - Blockbuster - Dec. 2001 - Dec. 2001

1.1. Lasted a cumulative two and a half shifts. (Author wishes to express

acknowledgement of yet another digression which is required, lest the Blockbuster gig go unexplained and come off as a red herring, which in some ways it is in that it does not directly bear on the plot or any critical events that are plot related. However, it was a foundational experience for the young John Roapes and should be elaborated on in that it is notably brief and if it were to go unexplained would leave lingering questions that would merit frustration on the readers behalf. Additionally, as you will see, it was a formative experience for J.R. vis-a-vis his perspective on capitalism, consumerism, and maybe, in some sense, a particular kind of white woman.)

1.1.1. Midway through the third shift, the tedium and ennui of his first job already beginning to drive him toward an existential crisis of sorts, driving him to wonder, that is, if he was ill suited for a life that required full time employment, which it seemed relatively clear was going to be a requirement, given what Uncle James had told him regarding the family trust, and in any event knowing that there were certain preconditions to earning what was his of the family trust (if such a thing existed) and some of those preconditions would necessitate full-time employment for a substantial period of time, just as all of this was starting to bear on him an overweight Gold Star Rewards Member named Betsy Higgins had begun to redden at the cheeks as she demanded her money back, in full. She had rented "Me, Myself and Irene," on VHS but upon popping it in to watch with her husband she'd noticed that, despite the 'Be Kind, Please Rewind' sticker, the previous renter had failed to do their civic minded duty. The problem behind the counter was that this *particular* Blockbuster franchise owner believed the only path to profit was through minimizing overhead costs, and as such he had yet to replace the one auto-rewinding machine which had been broken since as far back as July (which John had known for months as a frequent renter and Silver Star Rewards Member himself). This was before the widespread cultural recognition of a *Karen* as a particular type of consumer, though even then, the other retail workers understood that Betsy Higgins belonged to a special class of individual who took joy in entering Blockbuster to complain about the fact that she had received a copy of "Me, Myself and Irene" that had not been rewound. And so those other retail workers, his colleagues for two and a half shifts, both made themselves busy restocking the shelves when she shuffled into the store, a massive bag slung over her shoulder, sweat stains beneath her half buttoned denim top, and shorts that would be called Daisy Dukes by definition but were pushed to the limits of the definition on Betsy Higgins as they fit in a way that

more closely resembled some sort of a thong or boy-cut underwear. The worst part was what John Roapes noticed after providing Betsy with her refund dutifully –as mandated by his Shift Manager, Jared, who was twenty seven and spent most of his time in the back office, or rather outside the door in the back of the back office where he smoked cigarettes and talked to the other shift managers from the respective franchise store fronts who also spent a good deal of time in the back alley behind the strip mall, smoking cigarettes and complaining about their completely incompetent employees– after Betsy called for Jared, and John provided her a refund, he watched her as she perused the store, taking out VHSs from their plastic containers and inspected the tapes themselves, and when she arrived at the front with the last copy of “Castaway”, John inspected it closely and informed her that it appeared not to have been rewound, noting that unfortunately their auto-rewind machine was broken, and he suggested she get another copy. Betsy gleefully replied that this had been the only remaining copy of “Castaway” and that no other film would do, and that as a Gold Rewards Member, of course, John would understand that the right thing to do would be to provide this film free of charge as the policy for Gold Rewards Members was to ensure that they were satisfied with the product, and she motioned with her hand to the back office and suggested that, since John was new, he should just ask Jared, the shift manager, who John then realized cared so little about the actual profit at the franchise because of the franchise owner’s dedication to the reduction of overhead costs that he usually just gave Betsy her movies for free; and upon realizing this he became incredibly despondent about the whole ongoing back and forth with Betsy, the recollection again from that three quarters camera angle, and he thought of what it would require of him to come to work on a regular or semi-regular basis and maintain his sanity with just this one individual, let alone the possibility that Betsy was actually representative of a *type* of individual that he would have to deal with on a regular basis (which was alluded to, somewhat, in the training modules he had been forced to watch, without pay, as a part of onboarding, in which they talked about *difficult customers*, and had offered some sort of acronym as a solution, something like “Keep C.O.O.L.” with ‘C’ standing for *Compose yourself*, and ‘O’ standing for *Offer Solutions*, and so on and so forth in that terrible way that reminded him, as all bullshit acronyms always did, of the *D.A.R.E.* program –the moment, he would always remember clearly, that he understood the term *propaganda* and realized that maybe his Uncle James wasn’t just a lunatic like his father said, and that there was a distinct possibility the U.S. government was knowingly lying to the American people about certain things, usually via acronyms, in order to serve

some other interest (although he still did not understand what that other interest might be, and for all he wanted to trust Uncle James, it seemed unlikely and even bigoted that it was *the Jews* as he frequently posited)).

2. Night Auditor - Hampton Inns and Suites - Mar. 2002 - Nov. 2002
3. “Greenhorn” on a Long Line Fishing Boat - *Anna Marie* - Capt. Law Horne - Mar. 2003 - Mar. 2003
 - 3.1. Another short lived foray into an occupation for which he was ill suited, though far more dangerous and frightening than his stint at Blockbuster. [\[37\]](#)
4. Assistant to W. T. Grayson - Contract Basis

W. T.: 1.1

[Wherein the Genesis Arc is prepared for with appropriate clarifications, assumptions, and miscellaneous anecdotes intended to function something like a *Prologue* or *Preface* [\[38\]](#)]

W. T. Grayson was born into loneliness the way some people are born into wealth, or a life of crime, or a particular religious sect that will henceforth have a foundational impact on everything they say and do for the remainder of their lives despite having had no say in the matter whatsoever; like a king’s birthright, and in some ways the comparison is not completely off base, given the shape that his life would take as a result of, among other factors, his obsession with his patrilineage and this pervasive sense of loneliness [\[39\]](#) .

There is a critical biographical note that was used against W. T. as evidence in the series of Cease and Desist hearings that were held between the years of 2016 and 2018, and that would be rather imprudent to disregard as it relates to W. T.’s medical diagnosis of General Depressive Disorder, or his own personal diagnosis of his mental state, which he once summed up quite well, despite having consumed at least seven pitchers of “house ale” at Murphy’s Law (our preferred drinking establishment) – he said, with only a hint of a slur in his speech, so minor that one would not notice it as a slur unless they new his standard speech patterns: “It’s as if the black dog is in constant pursuit,” at which point he guzzled what remained in the pitcher he was holding and set it down resolutely, demonstratively having finished the pitcher and at the same time preparing to continue his statement with something well thought out and heretofore unrecognized by the other party (me), but not in a condescending way. “And I am always aware of the hound on my tail, so there is a constant sort of fear, even when he is not nearby, because he knows my scent so well, for one thing, and for the other, it’s as if we both want answers to the same questions. So while I am actively trying to avoid him, and half of my life is spent running directly away from the floppy eared hound, with his constantly drooling

maw, the other half of my life is spent returning to the same approximate path on which he travels when he has lost my scent. It's like I run from him, even lose him on occasion, but then I have the option to reorient myself so that our paths won't cross again, and instead I have some inner GPS, like Monarch Butterflies or Gray Geese, that ends up pointing me back towards the very thing I was running from."

He then dug around in his pocket for a few seconds and came out with a twenty dollar bill. He used it to flag down Chicago, the bartender who, believe it or not, did not come from Chicago but had inherited the moniker because he always said he was planning to move to Chicago, year in and year out, but never did. W. T. called him "Shy-Town" (which was a sort of mispronunciation of "Chi-Town"), which he did then, sort of abrasively raising his voice above the din to get the attention of a bartender who, while clearly not all that busy, would have gotten to him soon enough without having been flagged down like a taxi - this was one of the things Chicago disliked about W. T., one of many, but because W. T. and I were *regulars* and because I tipped particularly well on nights when W. T. got out of hand (and in fact, almost always over-tipped because W. T. was a notoriously bad tipper, rarely grateful for anything, as it were, he lacked something when it came to expectations, and so was not a poor tipper because he did not wish to give, but rather because he would not want to 'receive', could only imagine the whole thing to be an act of condescension and farce [\[40\]](#) – whether paradoxically or not, he felt the pain of others in a way that bordered on unearthly, something beyond empathy, seeming to lack only the ability to look at himself with the same forgiving, understanding lens), Chicago usually didn't give him too much grief for being an asshole, for which he (meaning W. T.) was none the wiser.

W. T.: 1.2

[Wherein W. T. arrives on X. X. Island; and *The Heart Tree* is struck by lightning but will not fall.]

In the beginning there was lightning. An old, bent, weathered black sedan pulled down the oak canopied drive in the dark rain of night. The darkness was interrupted frequently, as heat lightning ran rampant through the clouds above with devilish curiosity, or else when genuine lightning struck down upon the earth with mighty and rapturous concussions, the only thing that could actually be seen from the window of the room above the garage, where I sat and watched the lightning, and occasionally heard it, were the two broad beams of white light cutting out through the thick droplets of rain like a good carving knife through the fat belly meat of a large ocean fish: Grouper, Albacore, Sword. I remember thinking the scene was too cinematic for a life like ours, the night arrival of W. T. and the slow, storm front swelling the river so that the marsh grass was submerged and the dock was submerged and you could sense the full blood moon even through the obscuring clouds, and then another BOOOOM and in the distance you hear how loud a tree sounds when it is cracked in half by pure electricity.

Later that night, driving around in a golf cart, taking inventory, I could tell them tree by tree, when they had been struck and felled – until, that is, my father told me to stop making things up, and so I told him to get us to the *Heart Tree*, which had been a tree of great spiritual value to the X. X. Indian's from whom we'd taken the island, and was a tree that the the locals took much pride in, making various claims as to its age and properties, and which—it was true—had branches so large and long that at a certain distance from the tree they became too heavy for the tree itself to bear, at which point they re-entered the earth and sprang back up again fifteen or twenty feet or so further on, like those images of ancient sea beasts, their sinuous bodies rising and falling from the water in small arches.

The heart tree, I told my father, had been struck in its core, split clear in half. And he looked back at me, with an anger in his eyes that W. T. would later tell me he saw fear (though, as is common knowledge, no boy can recognize fear in the face of his own father—and as such the sensation of fear in a patriarchal figure is rarely captured accurately, if at all), and said “You should hope that ain't the case, boy. You shouldn't make up stories like that.” William's mother was in shock, riding shotgun - it was nearly impossible to understand how a tree itself could be so sacred as to redden a grown man's face just by saying it had been felled by lightning. But that's how things were on X. X. Island, and William himself seemed to know it because he wasn't surprised in the least by my father's reaction, nor was he surprised when my father showed tears upon discovering that I'd told the truth, the heart tree was split down the middle as if by the ax of some ancient god. It's two halves, however, remained propped up, though blackened with soot and charred, by the spider-legged branches, which now functioned like support beams, supported by the earth, with the singular purpose of keeping the two halves of the tree's body from separating at any cost. And I imagined in that instant that the tree was a family, each branch a child, the trunk's two parts each representing a parent trying to flee from the other, the kids wrapped in embrace begging them *please, please, please, don't leave - don't make us choose*. And as quickly as the thought crossed my mind it was gone again, but when I looked back at W. T. it seemed to me that he'd had the exact same impression. I couldn't say why.

It was only later that he would confirm my suspicion, and with that link between us it was as though we had spent our whole lives together, as if we were brothers, in a way and one or the other of us had just returned from a long trip and there was a great deal of catching up to do. In any event, that was how it felt to me.

W. T.: 1.2.1

W. T. and his mother showed up just ahead of the storm, as mentioned previously— it was seven or seven thirty, but much later by all appearances, due to the cloud cover and wretched weather. And it was the shortest day of the year December 21st, which had been mentioned a number of times throughout the day by my mother, who kept mentioning how it made her sad. This feeling would later

be identified by a psychologist as Seasonal Affective Disorder, or S.A.D., which has always struck me as an unnecessarily on-the-nose acronym.

They had arrived in the long black sedan, a Buick - something about the car itself seemed stern and unfriendly - this was both reinforced and compounded later on when I learned its history. Our house had been their very first stop upon arriving in town - this was, of course, because they needed to get the keys to their new home, a doublewide my father had put up on some unused land and made liveable a few years prior - the product of a brief but severe marital dispute that had nearly left me trading weekends like half of the other kids in my class. At the time it had made no difference to me, I'd thought, but by the time W. T. and his mother had shown up I'd seen how unhappiness had grown into the faces of those other children despite their doubled Christmases, no matter how cordial their parents remained.

His mother and my mother had both gone to Wagner, a small, but very prestigious, liberal arts college in Iowa of all places. Both of them, of course, had been excellent students in their own rights. My mother attended a private girls High School only thirty minutes from X. X. Island, just south of Charlestowne proper, where her father was involved in politics and as such had ensured his daughter attended the most renowned Girls School in the state - though he paid not a bit of interest in her grades or interests so long as she didn't sully his name and maintained her waistline (she only this bit after her third or fourth glass of wine).

W. T.'s mother was something of a prodigy, she was as good as any concert pianist in the North East by the time she was 12, when she suddenly gave up piano overnight, and began studying mathematics with the same sort of general fervor and success, until it seems, she discovered the Philosophy of Math, which was for her a gateway drug into all other sorts of philosophy - which her somewhat normal, upper-middle class parents - hadn't understood in the slightest but were, of course, over the moon with excitement when she was accepted with a full academic scholarship mind you, to Wagner College - though they couldn't have told you the first thing about what it was their daughter, precisely, was interested in studying (forgivably, in some sense, given the almost encyclopedic nature of her personal collection of books).

He was just shy of thirteen when we first met, whereas I had been a veritable teenager for almost a month by then. All of it took me by surprise, the W. T. way - the way he introduced himself to my mother and father- not that he showed disrespectful familiarity by any means, but his language was from a different world, or perhaps a different time, I thought. The formalities of address: "Mr. and Mrs. Roapes, so pleased to meet you." Without a hint of sarcasm or irony, mind you. Well spoken, but not precocious, oblivious to his own age, or why his age might matter in the slightest, particularly with regard to who it was that he spoke to and what he felt comfortable discussing. He exuded the confidence that is the distinguishing characteristic that can be observed in effective leaders, scions of

business, the wealthy (particularly when they had managed to accrue said wealth on their own merit and shrewd business dealings).

He was tall and masculine in ways I had not even imagined happening to myself, at least not yet. None of the other boys from school looked quite so grown either, I thought, though it wasn't all physical - there was something in the depths of his gaze that often made me reconsider my stance on reincarnation and the possibility that we are born with certain predispositions. The parts that were, his muscular forearms, visible Adam's apple, even something about the way you could see the hint of veins beneath his skin when he extended his large hand first to my father, and then my mother.

Each of them displayed different sorts of surprise: My mother was pleased and perhaps even somewhat shy or bashful, embarrassed, I suppose, by her own inability to balance the boy's age with his almost adult presence. Undoubtedly she was also dealing with a number of emotions related to the presence of her friend, Izzy, that I couldn't even have begun to guess, at the time. My father was easier to read. He had the same response to almost anyone new, a guarded suspicion that came off as quite unfriendly. In this case the suspicion was further complicated by confusion which presented most noticeably as a sort of puckering of the brow. His dark eyes might as well have been black (though they were, according to the South Carolina Department of Motor Vehicles: "Dk. Brwn ."). Though standing in the doorway between me and my mother, his eyes were all but invisible because the light from the foyer was slightly behind him. Whenever we were given reason to present as a family, which was at a minimum as often as every Sunday, he always stood some six to ten inches in front of my mother and I, so that we were like wings, or shoulders, always on opposite sides and slightly set back from the head.

I could already imagine some future conversation at the dinner table: *Who the hell did this kid think he was?* But for the time being I couldn't have cared less. There was another boy, almost precisely my age, moving to Roapes Drive and although we had talked about it previously on more than one occasion, I had somehow failed to anticipate the reality of their arrival. In some sense it was the first time I realized how isolated I'd been my whole life, and that there was something about my family that was, by nature, isolated— *island-like* . And that this little change, perhaps was actually a bigger change than I'd ever thought. Which in some ways explained, though I hadn't quite realized it, the chaos that had occurred a few months earlier and how my mother was able to convince Pappy to not only condone, but very much welcome, the introduction of the Grayson family onto *Roapes' land* .

W. T. and his mother were the first 'outsiders' who were not slaves or former slaves who had been allowed to take up residence on the Roapes property. How they had managed it, was then a complete mystery to me, almost unbelievable - though I have since learned that my mother is a resourceful and veritably brilliant individual, and it no longer surprises me in the least that she thought of the idea in the first place. Unfortunately, in learning this lesson I learned a great deal about my family, and by extension, myself, that has somewhat darkened the already questionable history that had been passed down to me in my youth.

But all in time. There is nothing but time anymore.

Or more aptly, time is nothing anymore. On those rare windless days, from my newly christened office, a converted widow's walk where I too watch the water as though it might return something so irretrievably lost as a soul - I can almost do it myself, *excuse myself*, as he called it, and I feel the proximity of time's infinite moment. But upon recognition it flees, every time. Without fail. A sort of paradox: inescapable and ever fleeting. A microcosm of human life.

Izzy Grayson: 1.1

[In which the reasons for W. T.'s arrival/his mother's backstory are provided—likely multiple subsections]

Wagner College, with its roughly fifteen hundred students, is older than the state of Iowa. Its academic prestige is not unlike certain other small, private institutions that hold themselves to a standard that rivals, if it does not surpass, that of the Ivy League, which those in-the-know are aware is somewhat inflated as a result of its nepotism and political ties (so that the true value of an Ivy League education is predictably aligned with the “It's not what you know, but who you know” principle, systematic of the consolidation of wealth among elites, whereas Wagner College (like say, MIT or Williams College or Grinnell or Oberlin) is actually superior from an academic perspective, though will never surpass the Ivies in terms of average income post-matriculation. By virtue of the school's own stated mission, to maintain the value and impact of a *true, classical liberal arts education* and because of its storied battle for secularism, which led to it being the home of what could more or less be called the brilliant outcasts of American history; yes, by its very nature, Wagner is a black sheep of sorts. A ghost in the machine.

Wagner College: The alma mater of Randolph Cradle, known in some circles as America's Aleister Crowley, brilliant in his own right, both a chess savant and author of the occult masterpiece “The Left-Handed Book of Dark Rites,” and a less-well known, eleven-hundred page book composed of short segments of prose and verse, simply titled “Vulgaris”, which was said to have been self-published on a medieval printing press with it's own plague-related history, and then distributed to a list of individual selected by Cradle (again, it is rumored) of which only four had failed to commit suicide in the following month, presumably having had the good taste not to open the book at all (or, according to some, to have been the four who read the book correctly, and thus inherited its power). Try as you may, very little about Randolph Cradle can be found, even today with the all knowing internet at your fingertips. Save conspiracy chat rooms and the occasionally populated Wikipedia entry, which is as quickly taken down as it is uploaded and even in archived versions somehow always has its text almost

entirely redacted. By whom? No one knows. There is a watchdog of the internet, it would seem, who keeps the man impossibly shrouded in mystery.

Cradle is one of many infamous alumni known to have walked the halls at Wagner. Of the graduates who have gone on to make names for themselves, they often tend, for one reason or another, to keep to the shadows and maintain a safe sort of obscurity with regard to their arts - they all, invariably, are artists of one sort or another - and very few of them speak of their time at college unless quite seriously pressed. Of course, there are the upstanding moral graduates as well, though those who do come out of Wagner to lead a boring, if ethically and morally sound life as adults, are generally described by their friends and colleagues as aloof, off in their own heads, distant in some hard to define way. And in the majority of interviews I've held (and there have been many, many interviews) the Wagner graduates have all shared an almost universal forgetfulness about their time at the school - as though there were something in the water, quite literally, that turned their formative college years into something like a hazy, half-forgotten dream - or in some cases like the sort of psychedelic trip that leaves a memory of something that can no longer be described without sounding like a caricature of one's self.

Perhaps they know this. That is my general impression - that they know how odd it sounds when they describe their time at this isolated and very elite college - but few and far between have been the individuals that speak poorly of their time there.

The campus and the town of Wagner can hardly be separated - one was built for the other, almost simultaneously, and for almost sixty miles in any direction the unprepared visitor may be surprised to learn that everything from grocery stores to gas stations, from non-denominational places of worship (of which there are two) to hardware stores are in some way, shape or form owned, run and operated by the long sinuous arms of the Wagner community. It is, for all intents and purposes, a self-sufficient ecosystem for the brilliant and deranged.

For Izzy Grayson, Wagner, Iowa was a birthplace. Every day of her early life took place in the presence of the great and mysterious college, that baroque bell tower built in the center of the circular campus so that its shadow can indicate, with some degree of accuracy (if, that is, one has accounted for the necessary variables: days removed from the closest solstice, elevation relative to the base of the tower, etc.) the time of day based on the particular roof, or patch of grass, or stained glass window, or slab of concrete sidewalk, where its apex rests - that strange shape at its peak, where on any other campus a cross would likely be positioned and no one would ask a single question as to its meaning or appropriateness, but instead here the strange shape sat - something like a bastardized infinity sign overlapping a square tilted to a forty five degree angle - a symbol without any publicly acknowledged definition - which each year inspired a good five percent of the student body to participate in the annual Semiology-Fest, during which students and staff alike were asked to provide their best guesses at the meaning and interpretation of the sign itself- and then, each year a new winner was selected, and throughout the school year the new meaning and interpretation of the symbol was used in a number of

school functions set up expressly to invite students to think about how symbols function and what they mean, really, when it all comes down to it. How real they are, so to speak, if you give them some meaning.

Both the Semiology-Fest and the year's interdependent activities were inventions of her mother's - the Dean of the Pemrose School of Philosophy - where the national obsession with analytic philosophy never quite managed to bring about the downfall of *Continental* thought like it had (so thoroughly kicking its ass) in other regions, other schools, which proved, in the long term to be a forward thinking decision. It is surprising how often the corrected all but at the time stirred up quite a bit of debate among the American Philosophical Board, and was under constant attack, as *Continental* Philosophy was for some time (in American, that is) relegated to the sidelines of academia, treated almost like religion, because of the inherent American sentiment that if we hadn't figured something out by now (whenever now may be) then in all likelihood it was a problem with the question, as there couldn't be a problem that we really didn't have an answer to, not really [\[41\]](#).

Her mother was an unfortunately busy woman, and so Izzy's closest relationship was with her father, who ran *The Wagner Book Nook*, a small bookstore that made 80% of its revenue selling textbooks twice a year, and was otherwise a quiet bookstore/coffee shop that was ideally suited for young Izzy who was not what you would call a social butterfly, and spent every afternoon helping her father stack and organize and reorganize and restack.

W. T.: 1.3

[In which the first part of the Genesis Arc is concluded and W. T. begins to search for his father]

History: 1.3

Each end of the W-shaped Roapes Drive runs into Oakstone Road - the main thoroughfare on the island - a winding, confused mess of a road built in segments that each align with the particular goals of a particular group or individual and give the whole thing a sort of *Winchester Manor* vibe - each piece being built with no consideration of the whole, in service to no greater goal, as it were, apart from the immediate needs, some senseless, of the money behind the operation. Oakstone Road does in seven miles of paved asphalt what another road could have covered in approximately two and a half (which, is the distance, I should clarify, that a crow would fly in order to get from the base of the "Stephen P. Roapes Bridge" to the terminal point of Oakstone Road, *Wickham's Landing*, where the commercial

fishing vessels set sail and return, offload, weigh out, dress and sell their catch to the buyers). Based on some rudimentary suppositions, the road was first constructed when the majority of traffic still flowed to the West Bay area, where the Oakstone family had first settled and constructed X. X. General Store, which led to the addition of Hutchin's Butchery, and, in due time, Croxley's Wine and Spirits (which, as a testament to the autonomy of X. X. Island, never once closed down during Prohibition, just kept right on doing business as though X. X. Island was some sort of private jurisdiction where legal matters were managed independently of any Federal regulations). Later, when Hurricane Dymphna destroyed most of the West Bay, the road was rerouted towards the new center of island commerce, which had been built just East of the center point of the island, locally referred to as Mount Luck (though that name will not be found on any map of the region, and the name itself is undoubtedly the result of a longstanding joke about the relative distance above sea level, because there is nothing even remotely resembling a hill, let alone a *mount* in a forty mile radius of Mount Luck or X. X. Island). All of the businesses that were able to survive Dymphna, financially that is, were rebuilt near Mount Luck in what is now known as the "Mount Luck Shopping Center," - and is made up of Croxley's and the General Store (poor old Hutchins never did reopen his butchery and died the year after Dymphna struck in a terrible and sad fashion) - also in the shopping center one will find 'X-Pert Massage and Nails', which is the newest addition and has raised some suspicion among the wives on the island [\[42\]](#) [\[43\]](#) .

At approximately a half a mile, Roapes Drive itself is more or less a small road. Both ends of the drive are marked by ornate, but ill-maintained gates. At the first gate (meaning the end of Roapes Drive that one would encounter first when traveling Oakstone Road "across" the island) there also stands the remains of what once served as a small stone outpost, six feet by eight feet with a thin horizontal slot built into each wall and an elaborate and secret entrance that could be found located in the ground some twenty feet away, that led to an underground passageway which opened on the other side inside the nearly pitch-black room. During the days of piratical robbing and looting the outpost was to serve as a warning more than anything else - despite the fact that to the left and right of the gate any pirate (or really any able bodied creature at all) could bypass the gate altogether without risking much more than a scratch from a thorned weed or a run in with the low-hanging branch of some unruly live oak. The outpost was a complete farce - a remnant of a time long since gone when the wealth of the Roapes family was the sort of thing that was discussed at dinner tables, generated rumors at taverns and pubs - and allowed the Roapes family members at that time, to invest in the sorts of business ventures that in today's age would require the backing of a corporation or venture capital group.

Slowly but surely the inhabitants of the Roapes estate - where there were originally thirteen residences that were maintained by a small fleet of black women [\[44\]](#) - began to lose the financial savvy that had built the fortune and with the savvy went the passive income, small but consistent decreases in the profit margin went unnoticed for some time. Or at a bare minimum it went without remark in any primary document prior to the turn of the 20th century - at which point the effects of the dwindling

fortune were already visible and the status of the Roapes as one of “The Five ” suddenly became the more common topic of discussion at dinner tables, pubs and taverns around the county.

From where I sit in the Widow’s Walk of the *Great House* I can just barely see the far-off gap in the trees where the entrance to Roapes Drive sits. It takes no great effort to picture myself standing there now, observing the rusted iron gate one half of which hangs crooked, The small six by eight hut has been taken over almost entirely by the local flora and fauna - and looks more like a Roman ruin than anything that had been constructed in the recent past. Made up of dirt and packed gravel it serves as the primary artery connecting all of the properties that still stand on Roapes family land, as well as the ghosts of some that don’t. It has widened over the years, out of necessity, in order to accommodate our ever growing vehicles - including, at the peak of our national depravity, the monstrous “Hummer” which, while pushing taste to its conceivable limit, was ultimately discontinued as a result of EPA regulations that should have been unnecessary in a world run by theoretically intelligent individuals.

At one point there were two separate Hummers that frequented Roapes drive, one of which was owned by a second cousin who lived near the end of the drive, and had been all but banished from family functions as a result of his failure to consult Pappy regarding the sale of some land adjacent to his property, lining the perimeter of the Roapes land, despite the fact the the deal ultimately did not even go through due to certain events that are certainly not proper to be discussed at any dinner table (and which, furthermore, will not be described herein for legal purposes).

Yours Truly: 1.1

Since fifteen ‘*I’m thirsty*’ had been our personal code for, *I want to get drunk* . At fifteen I found this euphemism both hilarious and genius, the sort of purloined-letter-obvious that was too simple to be recognized. I had not yet realized that seasoned drinkers (addicts, in general I suppose) could fill dictionaries with their unique terminology and lexicon, some of which actually WAS smart or funny, but mostly was just a byproduct of lying to themselves. ‘Dry’ or ‘parched’ worked just as well.

I started telling this to W. T. over my shoulder as I made my way to the liquor cabinet. *Wasn’t it funny, I said, how the whole time we thought we’d been fooling our parents, we’d been parroting terms they’d been using in front of us our whole lives? And even then we didn’t see it! What a bunch of goons! We thought we were fooling them but it turned out we were the fools, more or less confessing to them when it came right down to it. Just ratting ourselves out when it came right on down to it. How ridiculous, right?* I don’t remember exactly what I said but it was something to that effect, silly, nervous babbling as though W. T. was an attractive girl and I played the part of the nervous suitor.

In retrospect all of this becomes so glaringly obvious, but that’s the whole point now isn’t it. In the moment I would have threatened to beat someone to a pulp if they’d inferred that I felt somehow

inferior to W. T. – or that, perhaps, I was worried that we were growing apart. At the moment, I suppose, I wouldn't have even given the idea a second thought - W. T. and I were kin (Pappy would say). When we were sixteen, when I'd started to notice the cracks in my parents' marriage and I'd been reading (on W. T.'s recommendation) the e'd done the whole 'blood brother' ritual with a swiss army blade and a bottle of bourbon. That mattered, I thought.

I'd turned twenty-one only two weeks prior, but the local liquor store, which was owned by a member of the Oakstone Clan, had stopped checking my fake ID almost two years prior. After two or three months of thinking I'd completely fooled Charlie Oakstone, who was some undiagnosed form of mentally impaired and as such had been given the lowest job available on the Oakstone family totem pole, into believing that I was one Christopher Oriolla of 1717 Palmer Court, born May 31, 1982. One day, though, I showed up and he gave me a big, friendly "Helllllo Chris!" Then he winked at me. As I was checking out I saw a broad, dim witted smile on his dumb face followed by a request for my ID. I was certain he'd decided enough was enough - outright stated that the most important thing was that I handed him a card so that the CCTV camera could see [\[45\]](#) in the event that the County went on the attack again.

It is difficult for me to pin W. T. as an alcoholic before he was legally able to drink, and the truth is W. T. was an addict for his entire life, so it is somewhat arbitrary to select a specific threshold during which casual, though frequent binge drinking, became outright alcoholism. And I'm more inclined to avoid the term a *lcoholic* altogether and just state that W. T. was already a 'drinker' by that winter break, and he was specifically a drinker of hard, dark spirits [\[46\]](#) .

I had taken to keeping a stocked liquor cabinet at the time, though I was a beer drinker myself. Scotch was my preferred liquor, when the situation called for something stiff, and W. T.'s general attempt to dissimulate his unease was like a bugle call for something extra stiff.

In two highball glasses I put two ice cubes each and then filled them three quarters full with scotch whiskey that had been put into an oak barrel before I'd even been conceived, then for good measure I added a splash of water.

The whiskey-water brought a series of memories and thoughts to mind in quick succession - only a loosely connected phrase of thoughts, really - not even a coherent memory - and all of it occurring in the time it took to press the glass of whiskey against the small lever in the refrigerator door that dispensed cold filtered water, two or three seconds, tops. Thoughts, though more scattered and fluid than can be captured here were, generally speaking, as captured below:

My 18th birthday. Hadn't seen Mom or Dad in two days. While they technically still lived here, they were always off doing something that the other knew nothing about. And they both had an annoying habit, when they did stop in, of asking where the other one was. Which I still can't make heads or tails

of - whether they were genuinely interested in the others whereabouts, wanted to seem (to me? to themselves? subconsciously?) as though it was the other partner who was constantly away, or if, perhaps, it was simply a matter of filling space with words.

One thing seemed undeniable though: they had turned each other into more selfish individuals by virtue of their union. Each of them constantly afraid they might lose ground to the other, they'd double down on their demands - where other, happy couples, can be seen each giving a little - in order to meet in the middle - my parents were on opposite sides of a taut rope, and in a way the very pressure they created by digging in and pulling in the other direction was the only thing that kept the other person from tumbling forward, face first- into what? -neither of them wanted to find out. Codependency is a disease.

It occurred to me that this was something they both tended to do, fill empty air with words, just any words at all. They couldn't stand silence - and maybe that's why I tend to be very deliberate when I speak, in an effort to balance all of the wasted words my parents left scattered about wherever they went.

But it also occurred to me (at almost the exact same moment, near instantaneous thoughts that I can still remember quite succinctly) that perhaps it wasn't *silence* in general that made this happen. My father, in particular, could sit in silence for hours on end, as he did nearly every time he and I were alone together for any extended period of time. He seemed to rather enjoy it, in fact - as if the very essence of the two variants of silence, or nothingness, were somehow quite unique.

Variant A: Silence with a spouse, where the things that went unsaid were things that likewise had gone undone or accomplished, or particular memories that'd soured - the forgotten birthday, or unfixed sink, or slurred words he'd muttered the last time he'd come from Corrigan's Tavern, that foul scent of whiskey, cigarette smoke, and the exorbitant amount of mints jangling around in his pocket like spare change. Best, one might suppose, to keep your mouth shut given the circumstances.

That scent lingered in the places he sat or rested when he got home. In the morning I'd wake up to the sound of his whistling. I'd meander into the livingroom and find his ghostlike smell hovering just above the couch, where he'd certainly slept. The damp smell of sweaty booze faintly trailing behind him throughout the house. And I would know then that mother was long since gone, having left some time before dawn so as to avoid any possibility of a confrontation.

Then there was Version B: My father and I would subsequently spend the whole morning in silence, more or less. He would whistle every so often, but as his hangover began to bloom even the whistling would die down until, by noon or so, we were just a pair of poorly suited roommates, stuck together by circumstance. He sat red eyed in his chair in the living room, some kind of beer in his left hand, the TV, muted, set to some odd channel that appeared to air nothing but commercials for things that certainly no one in their right mind would purchase. I would find my way into the living room then too,

sit somewhere nearby with an unopened book in my lap, not near enough that the smell might somehow attach itself to me, but close enough to watch him watch the products and wonder where he had been—and what's more, where she had gone.

Until eventually W. T. showed up.

It could have been worse.

This had been going on for the past several years by then, and in that time I had ostensibly become the main caretaker of the property – which is to say, the home had started to fall into a state of disrepair.

Minor things that had piled up. For example, of the eighty-seven lightbulbs in the house, only twenty two remained working. There were really only seven or eight lights I needed to function on a day to day basis, so only when one of those flamed out, which was more frequent than the others as a result of usage, of course, I'd go into the dining room, where antique china clattered in the cupboard no matter how lightly I stepped. I'd stand on one of the antique chairs, feeble beneath my weight, and pluck another bulb from the chandelier (four of twenty two remained), to replace the critical light (either in the kitchen, hallway, bathroom, my bedroom, or the lamp beside the easy chair, which was where I spent most of my time, reading). The chandelier bulbs were not of the same wattage as the bulbs they replaced, so the result was that even in those rooms I maintained, the lighting was forever dim and soft and my eyes became accustomed to existing in a persistent state of dim, shadowy luminescence.

I saved the stronger bulbs for the reading lamp, of course - and I recall, quite vividly the texture of light throughout the house, and how, when sitting to read, the single brightest light in the house shone right down on the wooden lap desk I used for both reading and writing - and I suppose it gave the whole thing the vague, somewhat cinematic appeal. A pastor reading from the brightly lit pulpit, or I then began to imagine, a writer on stage at some vagabond café, reading sections from his forthcoming novel to a small but enraptured crowd.

This is also when I started to write.

Uncle James, who had been married a number of times, never let a marriage get so far as to turn him selfish. He had remembered my birthday, at least, and came by in the late morning to surprise me.

We were both unemployed at the time, and he had started stopping by in the mornings to use my Moka Pot and offer advice on any number of topics. He particularly liked discussing women in a sort of wistful, melancholic way while he sipped his hot coffee and I nodded along. Sometimes listening, sometimes hardly paying any attention at all. He talked about just about everything from baseball to religion (both of them were boring but good for you for that exact reason).

That morning, the morning of my birthday, it was whiskey we discussed.

Uncle James told me: “You don’t mix whiskey with anything but water. That is a rule with no exceptions.”

[Rewrite or Cut Starting Here]

As he had no children of his own Uncle James had been completely oblivious to the changes to the drinking age that had taken place in the mid eighties.

The skin on Uncle James’s face and neck and forearms and hands were permanently suntanned in a fashion that made it obvious he’d spent a significant percentage of his life baking in the kiln of the low-hanging South Carolina sun. I could attest to it - the man was shirtless more often than not. He likened himself to “one of those goddamn lazy ee-guanas down in Belize,” with a sort of pride that confused me. Laziness, referred to in the bible as *sloth*, was actually a sin according to Pastor Mike. I’d never been on a Carnival cruise in my life, but I nodded him onward because I loved the way he told a story, he was nothing if not an excellent yarn-spinner - and anyways, I knew the iguanas he was talking about, there was no need to go to Belize to see them. You could find them right in good ol’ Florida if you knew where to look.

So it was the case that he thought he was bringing me my first legal bottle of whiskey (Four Roses Bourbon, nothing snooty) along with a pack of Marlboro Reds, a pornographic magazine aptly titled ‘*Triple D Sluts: On Campus Edition*’ which actually came with a DVD that had individual two minute previews of the ‘*Triple D Sluts*’ film franchise’s last eight feature length releases, one of which was a “Beauty and the Beast” satire, though perhaps satire is not the most appropriate word here - {Note To Self: Can a pornographic film be a *satire*? Is it by nature satirical? Or, conversely, is it categorically impossible for a porno to be a *satire*, given that it is a porno, and the weight of the explicit sexual activity as a component of the plot, and by extension, a component of the genre, does not leave room for the type of intentionality that the word *satire* might infer? [\[47\]](#) } In any event, the inferred bestiality kink left me a little disappointed in CockJocks™, in a general quasi-agitated way because it had made me feel dirty and vaguely worried about something, perhaps for the young woman in the screenshot for the trailer (which I admit, I pressed play in an attempt to see for myself, but was luckily stopped by some sort of system malfunction that made me realize how much I was upsetting myself) and to top it off he brought a variety of scratch off lottery tickets. To this day, it remains my favorite birthday gift I’ve ever received. We had a good laugh about the age mishap regarding my birthday, and then proceeded to drink the entire contents of the one liter bottle, passing it back and forth, while Uncle James finally let me in on the secret of about *Roapes’ Family ‘Shine*, and I played along as if it was a complete surprise, because, while I did know about our Moonshine cash business, to some extent, the truth is I’d been curious for some time as to what it took and how I might go about getting involved in the enterprise. I’d been particularly interested at that time because I’d decided to “take a year off” before going to college - and I’d only just started to realize I’d need to do something with my time.

Taking a year off is a great idea for ambitious kids, who more or less know they are going to spend the next 6-10 years of their life doing some type of intensive medical school thing. And I think it's good for those kids who are lost with regard to what they want to do with their lives, the ones who know that diving straight into a Communications Degree at State U will more or less be four years of keg stands and properly developed addiction forming, but who really feel, like deep down in their gut, that there is something better for them out there – *not just a job, but a calling* . Taking a year off is great for them, too. I'm sure.

But then there is another breed for whom taking a year off runs the risk of semi-disastrous consequences. This character ostensibly *takes a year off* (italics here to emphasize the near trope-like cultural associations that come with taking a year off, for this sub-variant of individual) because the drudgery and malaise of high school was so downright soul crushing and unbearable that they couldn't possibly imagine sitting at a desk in another classroom ever again (here, note, we find them making the critical mistake of inferring a difference between a classroom and most any other work environment, wherein the subordinate individual performs on command for an indoctrinated superior with a complex, handling a task only mildly more consequential or meaningful, and more likely than not, far more ethically questionable. Though, I suppose, at least completed for cash instead of grades). No they cannot even dream of voluntarily walking back into another year of school, any school, forced to take 101 courses based on rote memorization; taught by gray faced adjuncts whose best lecture of the semester will be on Day One, regarding their absence and chronic tardiness policy, in which they deliver an actual joke for the first and last time that semester; this adjunct who has already begun to resent their decision to pursue their passion in cultural anthropology but has more or less already found themselves pot committed. God, how sad it seems (to this breed of individual) to be forced to sit in a classroom and watch the idealism and fervor that had gripped them in their early graduate years; the slowly accelerating distortion of their expressions and mannerisms - like cheap makeup exposed to sunlight at the tail end of some all-night bender.

This certain breed, whose current girlfriend of four months, give or take, Jackie Oriesta, happens to be a year behind him age-wise – so he knows, as certainly as he knows his own home phone number, that going off to college would lead to a spiraling depression set off by his deep-rooted insecurity and tendency towards jealousy, he just knows it will spell the end of this completely amazing and potentially altar-bound relationship, even if State U is only two hours away and she swears she'd visit every weekend, and even if he knows that he is fooling himself with the whole H.S.-sweetheart-romance-thing, because he still prefers spending time with W. T. to her, and furthermore has recently realized he finds the scent of her vagina, when she is aroused, off-putting in a way he'll never be able to openly address with her but feels would be a deal-breaker at the end of the day, marriage-wise, if that pungency were in fact permanent, like some sort of vaginal halitosis, which he secretly believes to be the case.

W. T. started his freshman year at Wagner with twenty eight Wagner-approved academic credits - meaning that he was a mere two credits shy of being a sophomore, technically. Also it meant that he did not have to take most of the standard 101/102 classes that all students were required to take in order to select a major, because the AP credits he'd earned in High School were for courses that acted in place of the prerequisite 101 and 102s.

AP Bio (6 Credits), AP Chem (6 Credits), AP Statistics(3 Credits), AP Calculus (3 Credits), AP Psychology (*Wagner scoffs* 0 Credits), AP US History (3 Credits), AP European History (3 Credits), and finally AP English Literature (4 Credits). W. T. scored straight fives on all of his AP Exams (which really end up being College Equivalency Exams). [\[48\]](#)

Your average academic semester at Wagner consisted of a fifteen credit course load. This meant that after taking eighteen credits in his first semester, followed by another eighteen credits in his second semester, W. T. was well on track to graduate from Wagner a year early.

Winter Break, Year Three (2005-2006)

During the Winter break of his third year at Wagner – which was supposed to have been his final year, in terms of hours required to fulfill his major, though this would not come to pass as expected – WT arrived back on the island ten hours and twelve minutes after completing his last final exam.

It was 9:47 PM when he arrived at my house. I'd been anticipating his arrival the next morning. He'd told me his schedule, and I'd applied some mental mathematics, given he traveled five miles over the speed give or take, the whole way home, and assuming there would of course be traffic (particularly on that perilous stretch of I-95 around DC and Virginia where something had gone seriously wrong during the infrastructure planning, one has to assume, because (though I'd never traveled it myself) I'd never met an individual who had traveled that particular stretch of interstate and did not come out the other end complaining of bumper to bumper traffic and talking about how they'd never seen so much construction going on without a single construction worked in sight.

I'd also assumed he would stop by his own place first, see Izzy for a bit, rest up for the night before heading over to Talking House. Talking House was the name he and I had given the once regal southern estate house I'd moved into, temporarily, two years prior. The name had stuck around and so had I. The deal was I could live there rent free, so long as I paid the utilities and property taxes AND

made some progress on a large list of necessary home repair items that had been compiled by Uncle James. James, who had been thinking at the time of starting up his own home repair and renovations company, was dealing, simultaneously with divorce proceedings and a deteriorating disc in his lower back that caused him to make small sounds of agony every time he bent to restrap his velcro shoes. As a result of the previously stated roadblocks, it quickly became apparent that Uncle James was ill suited for the job, though his intentions had been noble all the same - and the house, which had been abandoned since 1942, when Pappy's brother Clyde left for the war and never made it home again - was sorely in need of a strapping young man with nothing but time on his hands and a penchant for being alone. Enter yours truly.

The name "Talking House" referred to the age of the house mostly (or should I say *to most*), the way it was so old it seemed to talk every time you took a step indoors. Particularly in the winter months when the hot humid air that swelled door frames and windows alike, was relieved of its heat, at least for a time - and like all things that swell in the heat, the wood that the house had been made of tightened up into slightly curved little boards. Whereas, for example, the side door that entered into the kitchen was nearly impossible to open in the summertime (despite our best efforts, every summer, to shave back the edges and get it to fit smoothly once again), it would fill to fit the space, so that by April you had to lean your shoulder against it a bit in order to get it to open, and by June we put things in front of the door to keep people from even trying, because if it was opened in that swollen state, lord help the man whose job it would be to put it back in place.

While other houses on the property had been maintained over the years by their respective inhabitants, The Talking House was left in a sort of purgatory, awaiting the formal word that Clyde's body had been identified. Pappy's father kept the house as it had been on the day he left - but eventually Clyde's widow could no longer bear it, there had been some sort of argument between her and my great-grandfather, and she left on a bus back to Tennessee with a suitcase in one hand and her two year old son, Clyde Jr. gripping tightly at the other.

It turned out that this was not the only tragedy the Talking House had seen, and I would learn a good deal more about this in the years that followed.

So W. T. had decided to stop by Talking House first, before going to see his mother, and thought that perhaps he would even hide out at my place for a day or three, telling his mother he had an exam on Friday (even though the final day exams could be administered was Thursday, and Friday was technically the first day of the Winter Term, when student's who'd fallen behind could make up an expedited course over the three and a half weeks, by attending daily three hour sessions as opposed to the regular MWF/TTr scheduling of the Fall and Spring semesters). In any event he had asked if he might park his car in my garage and cover it with a tarp for a few days, and, not that anyone would, but in the event someone should come by and notice the out of place car in my garage, he'd written down a few details about 'project cars', and he provided me with an incredibly thorough backstory involving

both the model of the car I was working on and some very specific reasons why the tarp could not be removed at the current moment having to do with a recently applied layer of coating that could not be exposed to light for at least seventy-two-hours. On the note, in brackets and then quotation marks, he'd written, "can state that 'it functions something like a dark room for photographs' - then, depending on the individual, you might be able to appeal to their interest in photography and divert the conversation from going any further." Here he was obviously speaking directly about his mother, who was a passionate, if mediocre, amateur photographer - and upon reading his notes I understood exactly how that conversation would go, should it occur, and told him fine, I'd do it - but, I told him he would have to explain to me, at some point that night, why he'd wanted to hide out at my house for three days when he could just as easily stop by his house, say hello to his mother, and THEN come over to my house for whatever duration of time he wanted without all the cloak and dagger bullshit.

"That's fair," he said. "But first, I'm thirsty."

GAN: 1.1

The aim of the experimental class he proposed was not entirely unique, truth be told, this much was stated in the proposal. It was, in fact, the continuation of a course that had been taught at the Collège de France, between December '78 and February '80, and had ended abruptly when the instructor, philosopher and semiotician, Roland Barthes, was struck by a laundry truck while crossing the Rue des Écoles in Paris at the age of 62.

He did not die immediately, and there was approximately a month during which his inconsolable fans [\[49\]](#) held out hope that their cultural icon might pull through. But despite the endless parade of flower arrangements and hand written letters, the death of the author took place a month later in a standard issue, uncomfortable, off-white hospital bed - not a family member or close friend at his bedside, no one there to record his famous last words, if words were even spoken. A cardiac event stemming from the incident would be the official cause of death.

He had just left a lunch event for François Mitterrand, who was then a presidential candidate, and a year later would become the first socialist president of France under the Fifth Republic, and would remain in office until the early 90s. He wore a tan blazer with a brown fedora-like cap, and a new pair of trousers purchased just for the event. The day, it has been remarked, was crisp and pleasant, a slight chill in the air that somehow seemed to make the world appear more crisp and precise. There was no augur, no ominous storm on the horizon, in fact when he'd first been struck by the vehicle, by all accounts, it had appeared as if he might just pop right back up - the low speed of the truck causing the whole event to take place in a drawn out sort of way, he really fell backwards more than he flew off the hood of the

vehicle. But of course, there was a concussion, several broken ribs, and the heart that they had spent their life protecting had a valve that had been, of late, struggling to keep up the pace with the others.

The series of lectures he was giving at the time of his death, which were delivered in a lecture hall filled well beyond capacity, bodies spilling into the aisles and hallways of the College du France, where individuals kept as silent as possible just so that they could make out the occasional word or phrase, hoping perhaps, to learn by osmosis or sheer proximity, all for this one specific course called “The Preparation of the Novel” in which Barthes, the father of post-structuralism and the man who had written the provocatively titled “Death of the Author” (titled so despite the fact that it was more accurately a critique of contemporary literary criticism, which relied so heavily on authorial intention that it all but ignored the presence of a reader, may have been more aptly titled, “The Reader Matters Too”), had decided that it was time that he write a novel.

Because *the author was dead*, meaning, the author was more or less an instrument through which a novel could be created, but also was altogether irrelevant in any attempt to derive meaning from a given work, Barthes decided he would make a lesson out of it. He had, for a year and a half, been delivering lectures that were related to the conception and considerations necessary in preparation for writing a novel. The aim of the course, misunderstood by many, was not so much for Barthes to write the novel – that, he admitted, would require “secrecy” – but rather to go about doing the theoretical legwork involved in preparing to write a novel, the way he understood it to work. And perhaps this was what the GAN found the most intriguing about the whole endeavor, about his own pursuit in particular, that the preparations for writing a novel were almost entirely empty gestures, not unlike the superstitious routines of the baseball player who restraps his left glove twice, his right glove once, and then spits near, but never inside of, the batters box. It wasn’t until the preparations were done, the writer having outlined and sketched out characters and motifs and themes, envisaged the two threads of the story coming together in some sort of pattern represented by the fibonacci sequence, or whatever mental model it might be that grabbed hold of the imagination that day - it wasn’t until after all of that and the throat clearing and the theorizing and the whole plot has been conceived of in 22.5 different variations, that the author, thoroughly exhausted from having conceptualized this brilliant disaster finally sits down in front of the blank page, and with three notebooks full of ideas all spread out across his workspace, writes the very first sentence - only to realize that they were on the wrong track the whole time, it wasn’t a love story but a ghost story they’d been trying to write. And at that point, when they are finally able to take the months (or years) of ideation and brainstorming and character sketches, and put those notes and notebooks somewhere in a closet where they will likely not see the light of day again until they are found by some meddlesome relative trying to find the “lost novel” (if one is very, very lucky) or else devoured bit by bit, by meddlesome rodents once they are moved to the attic to make space for the next set of notebooks.

Still, the concept was inspiring for the GAN, who although he knew all of the preparation could be wiped out by the occurrence of a single revelatory moment, still believed it was necessary, as much so

as the batter's precisely aimed spit. Barthes had lectured about the steps he was taking, the considerations that went into each step and why it was necessary, each decision he found he needed to make, the difficulties he faced and choices he made while working on the *CONCEPT* of what he had tentatively titled "Vita Nova" (in reference to Dante's *Inferno* but also referencing his own decision to take on a *new life* as a novelist).

The GAN, by then, was at a point in his career where he was seeking uncharted territories of literature. He had won just about every literary prize possible for an American author. The only unchecked box that remained on his list was the Nobel, and having learned early on about the politics behind those sorts of awards, he had slowly been able to convince himself that it was out of his power.

There was a time, following the publication of his latest novel, "Maps of the Panopticon", during which he had been on the cover of just about every magazine that could be purchased at an airport stall, interviewed on as many talk shows as there were hours in the day, had been able to cross off the Booker Prize AND the Pulitzer, and had for the first time in his career felt the sort of celebrity burnout that makes normal people scoff and roll their eyes, but which is indeed a terrifying and isolating condition, given that the list of people who can even remotely relate reads like a VIP list at Club Med, and half of them had to (in some cases, literally, the GAN believed) sell their souls in order to get there.

The ones who sold their souls could be identified by a certain reptilian shaped pupil that only came out on the exceedingly rare occasion that they looked you directly in the eye.

The other celebrities of this ilk were not the type of people with whom you had conversations about loneliness, loss, empathy—in fact, it struck him quite clearly at that time, they weren't the type of people with whom you had conversations at all. For a certain group of people at the very peak of celebrity, the ability to have a genuine conversation about, really anything, becomes an impossibility. They have reached that terrifying point at which if one stops, for even a moment, to think about their surroundings—about what it all means—there is a sort of existential vertigo that sets in—and when that happens, the GAN realized (peripherally, as it were) there is nothing but freefall. That was what he was aiming to avoid: the freefall.

Some part of him was glad to have the Nobel still out there. It was perhaps the one thing that kept him from losing that last thread of humanity. If he were to win it, he thought then, what would be left? To do another lap? Looking back on his life he could remember a time when the awards meant nothing to him; then, he could remember a time when the awards were the only thing that mattered. But he could not remember how he made it from one place to the other. Certainly, he had been there.

But at the same time, he could not stop - could not pause to take inventory, certainly was not ready to begin to consider trying to make the slow, cautious descent that would be required to land from such speed, so great a height.

Velocity—separates that which is in flight from that which is in free fall. Constant motion, progress—something to it.

He pulled a green notebook from his large jacket pocket. On its spine was the number 246. Back at his home in Wisconsin - the only one of his houses that was his home - there were 245 other small, green notebooks, each numbered in the exact same fashion - and each containing notes similar to that which he was writing now: *Constant motion keeps things aloft that would otherwise fall – other forces involved: Inertia, yes. Momentum, friction, etc. And of course gravity. The force that stops flight from being the permanent state of everything, in an accurate, though at first glance contradictory way. You need something pulling you down to understand what a miracle it is to stay in flight. A simple question of physics, trigonometry.* He was visibly captured by the thought, though a bit glassy eyed from the whiskey. He wished he hadn't ordered the last two - but how else was one supposed to bear the tedium and ennui of John F. Kennedy International Airport: *The constant reminders you are being watched, a veritable panopticon in so many ways - the feeling that armed policemen are behind every closed door – though, there are at present, none to be seen – the concept of the plainclothes U.S. Marshall, well enough established at this point that there is no one* , he looked up from his notebook and glanced around himself to verify, *no one who does not present the potentially ~~long arm of the~~ long-armed law.*

Satisfied for the moment, he pushed his notebook slightly to the side then he took out a stack of photocopied pages that had been kindly provided by Columbia University, where there was a graduate student who had been diligently working translating the French copy of “The Preparation of the Novel” and had been able to provide a complete first draft in English a month or so prior. The haste with which it was prepared was visible in the translation (the GAN was semi-proficient in French, enough to know when a translation was missing certain connotations or turns of phrase that were important to the meaning). He was now going through the translated text and annotating it, so that when class started in a few short weeks he could provide the personally annotated text for the students.

This, ostensibly, was the purpose of his last minute trip to Paris - a chance to do some on-location “research”. In other words: to stroll the Seine, visit the College Du France, interview a few of the remaining faculty who had met with Barthes while he was teaching his course. In short, to do what writers call work - to observe, document, question, and of course, drink.

He realized he'd been absently doodling and looked to see what he'd drawn in notebook 246: a spiral line closing in on itself, the golden ratio (drawn to perfection). Although the memory of creating such an image didn't exist in his memory.

Beside the note about *airports, being watched* he wrote a small, capitalized ‘Q’ inside of a near-perfectly drawn circle. The Giotto-like accuracy of his small circle pleased him greatly. Then he put the notebook away, put the pen back in his breast pocket, and returned to the whiskey drink he'd been nursing while he awaited his next flight.

Only a few hours to go. He was seated at the bar in the special lounge for frequent flyers of Universal Airlines, Platinum and Diamond members only – mostly large bellied white men in business attire with taut, reddened faces. The sort of men who yelled at anyone in a uniform if their coffee was too hot, but for whom, if the coffee was not hot enough to earn a good scolding, would then find the coffee too cold and dump it in a paper basket. Who could look a female flight attendant up and down in a way that they knew was perverse, and enjoy not so much the looking as the ability to look without reproach.

The GAN was somewhat known to be a closeted chauvinist - though his latest novel had acted as a direct affront to such accusations. Not the creepy voyeuristic sort whose presence made women feel uncomfortable in their own skin. He was a more covert manipulator, brilliant and perhaps the greatest composer of sentences that the US had ever seen—who knew precisely the right things to say and do to lure women into a sort of agreement to be objectified, because under his gaze, in some sense, he was able to make them feel like art. Which is, perhaps, the goal at the heart of the human condition - this desire to be a part of the tapestry of life rather than an observer or participant. A complex and contradictory desire for one's own objectification. The GAN knew a well timed apology allowed him to say things that a certain type of woman might actually want to hear, but could not accept wanting to hear it so bluntly, and by apologizing he would put them in a position where they now recognized that he was aware of his mistake; that his chauvinism was then somewhat of a turn-on, acting out a subliminal desire of the *bad boy* trope—because they knew it was something he didn't make a habit of, but of course there was some element of man that was pure animal too. His recognition of the slight faux pas he'd made, by being so direct about, for example, his own personal desire to get to know this certain woman as soon as he'd seen her would allow him to use his apology to spin a more intricate explanation in which it wasn't just her body that attracted him (*there, he'd done it again, he was just trying to explain himself*) but he'd noticed (and this was where the real magic took place) the book she'd been reading (which often enough happened to be some book-of-the-month pseudo-feminist novel about a woman making her way up a corporate ladder despite the difficulties and trevails that made such a thing all but impossible, but also had a love story built into it that was sort of the same thing that was going on here - where a well meaning, attractive, intelligent man made a series of mistakes that he had to fight back from in order to redeem himself and sleep with the woman who was able to then take on the traditional role of the male suitor, dictating the terms of engagement) and he'd mention that he actually had met the author and make a self effacing remark about how glad he was that she hadn't been there to overhear what he'd said because she'd still be letting him have it right now if she had; and yes, he actually was an author too; and he didn't know if she'd know anything he'd written; and then oh boy gee-whiz well yes, there were a few of his books in the *Hudson News* ; and so on and so forth until eventually he'd turned himself into an archetype, the sort of archetype that he lampooned in his own novels but understood very well, better than the authors who wrote them, who false and phony a person like that was - and he didn't like it about himself, this manipulative capacity he had that allowed him to get away with saying things that would earn most "average guys" a bright red handprint across the cheek - but he had time to hate himself later, after he'd invited her to come

grab a free copy of his book, the one that was on sale right there in the very same Hudson News in which they were standing - and brought her back to the VIP lounge area where there were actually small private rooms that serious travelers could use to catch some shut eye if needed, and smile and make a joke at his own expense and check to see that she was smiling too and that would be that. The sort of things that only took place in the movies, or to people who acted in the movies, or on occasion, to the guy who wrote the book that the movie had been based on. In his little green book he'd write down the name Sheila, later and some notes on what a prick he had been, and how a certain comment had elicited a certain response and question why it was he felt like doing these things when afterwards he wanted to throw up more than anything, notes on self hatred, and the texture of a certain type of nipple that had gone through the trauma of breastfeeding, and put a star next to a particular line or phrase he'd written, that he'd like to use at some point, stolen, as it were, from himself, if that was who he was just then.

In a mere four weeks he'd be giving his first lecture at Wagner. The thought doubled down his anxiety.

The title of his course was "The Composition of the Novel." Whereas Barthes had written about the *preparation*, the *fantasy*, as he had referred to it during the one and only lecture the GAN had managed to attend [50] while in Paris that year, the GAN wanted to do what he felt would have been a natural continuation of Barthes' course (although Barthes himself said he had no plans to do so).

Barthes wanted to evaluate and analyze the *preparation of the novel* - the concepts, ideas, structures, anxieties, politics, and everything else that orbited the creation of the novel, the click clack of the typewriter, or keyboard these days - he had wanted to do everything BUT write the novel.

The GAN wanted to **write** the novel.

Now there were two weeks to go and the same old demons were coming out of the shadows.

W. T.: 1.6

Though he made no mention as such, W. T. endured an incredible loneliness after arriving at Wagner. It was a dangerous, acediastic sort of loneliness - seemingly placeless and without origin, which led to his taking incredibly long walks in order to avoid interacting with others. It's easy to understand how this behavior, the avoidance of others, might seem counterintuitive to some, and W. T. considered this a good deal. Why, if it was loneliness he felt deep down in his gut, would he seek isolation in response? It would seem natural that the cure for loneliness must be the opposite of isolation - whatever that was (togetherness? conversation? the presence of others, like, physically?).

But he knew, with a characteristic certainty, that the other students at Wagner were unlike him in so many insurmountable ways that their proximity actually exacerbated the problem.

It was intuitive, one adapts.

In the face of loneliness, his intuition told him to go further into the island of the self. To walk, to ponder, to allow himself the ache—in defiance of the black dog, whose droopy, salivating black maw could be heard, always, nearby - the occasional *thwop-thuck* of clapping jowls.

He wouldn't admit to being on the run - this was why he always walked.

During his first semester at Wagner we spoke on Tuesdays, Fridays and Sundays. W. T. had worked everything into a schedule like this - and he let me know the schedule, of course, without asking whether it was convenient, let alone possible. That first week he'd called every night, though. In high school he'd never had a cell phone, even when they became pretty much standard issue and everyone had one. W. T. told everyone they'd have brain cancer in fifteen years and went about his business. He had the sort of essential charm about him that made it almost seem cool that he didn't carry a phone—though of course I was his phone for all intents and purposes.

By senior year I'd moved into the Talking House unofficially, and W. T. had practically moved in alongside me. At first it was because he couldn't stand Izzy's new boyfriend, for reasons that weren't entirely clear to me at the time but seemed vaguely ominous.

He wasn't the sort of child who inherently despised anyone his mother brought home—though he wasn't over the moon about the frequency of her suitors, nor the ratio of suitors that she'd met at Murphy's Law as opposed to, literally, anywhere else. But even here he remained reasonable, as she didn't do much besides work (behind the bar at Murph's) - and understood that if it were a Venn diagram, there was likely a significant intersection between [men that Izzy would practically interact with] and [men that at one point or another stopped in at Murphy's Law]. Sometimes he guessed it could be as much as 75% of the total set that shared both characteristics - this being in part because Murph's was realistically the only drinking establishment on the island that attracted a crowd that had not already started receiving their social security checks. The other drinking establishments were *clubs* of one kind or another, which, “clubs” is a term with unclear but somewhat nefarious connotations.

They were not just gentlemen's clubs, though there were a few of those to be certain. The other *clubs* on the island were either elite and snobbish, as in The Surf Club or the Hobcaw Yacht Club, both of which had recruitment and approval processes that, W. T. said, made rushing a Fraternity seem laid back and inclusive in comparison, or they were scary in a sort of occult, ritualistic way that seemed simultaneously unbelievable and as if it had to be the case. The Masonic Order of the Triangle, The Gray Flag, The Society of Clouds.

The Hobcaw Yacht Club, for example, did not allow members who could not provide literal paperwork tracing their lineage directly to a soldier who served in defense of the Confederacy; this was a fact I would learn later that year, when a proud W. T. came home to tell me he'd used his access to Wagner's digital research databases to gather said documentation for me, and furthermore that he'd done some initial, administrative stuff just to get the ball rolling, and for some reason I could only guess were sabotage related, was dead set on seeing me admitted into the Hobcaw Yacht Club.

In general, that is to say, he was fairly reasonable about it – and even seemed to hold out hope that his mother would land herself someone that would make life a bit easier on her.

I listened mostly, because he had plenty to talk about, and I was, as they say, living vicariously.

His dormmate was a *strange bird*, he said - I couldn't, in his current, fragile state, bring myself to reproach him for using a term like *strange bird*, though it was clear in the quick way he moved on without pause that he knew and was grateful for the restraint I'd shown—his capacity to *shapeshift* as he called it, was something he despised about himself, despite recognizing its value when it came to adapting to new environments.

His ability to *shapeshift* was in fact extraordinary. It went far beyond the superhuman ability he had to empathize with literally anyone he met, which as any psychiatrist will tell you, is a dangerous and exhausting power in and of itself. W. T. had the ability to take it a step further. He could internalize and regurgitate the whole of a person's character within minutes of meeting them. There was no accent he could not adopt, down to the little nuances that most people, even attentive people, recognize but cannot quite pin down. A sort of method actor of the human condition. For weeks after the Jehovah's Witness missionaries had made the mistake of strolling down Roapes Drive he couldn't walk past a member of the family without having to stop and hear the story of said family member's interaction with the duo before being asked, *for the last time*, they promised, to do the impression of the tall one again, the one with *the lip thing*. The lip thing was nothing more than a sort of pursed, grinch-like, way of smiling that everyone had noticed but *just could not quite pin down*.

[MORE HERE]

The roommate was a musician type with a pale, sallow complexion and rings on most every body part that would allow it. He couldn't be certain what type of musician, as he seemed to be proficient at many instruments—however he had yet to show an excellence with regard to any one instrument, or even type of instrument. He'd brought a keyboard, an acoustic guitar, a violin, and what seemed to be some sort of mixing board that he had to plug into a computer in order to make it create sound, and then he would loop the sound in rhythmic patterns that were pleasant enough, but for some reason that W. T. could not comprehend he was determined to do things to the patterns that made them objectively unpleasant.

“Not that I can’t appreciate dissonance,” he said. “But this isn’t dissonance for the sake of resolving the dissonance, you know? He never gets to the payoff. It’s more like discomfort.” He paused for a second and I could tell he was thinking. I lit and smoked a cigarette and held the phone to my ear while W. T. stayed silent – in the background I heard voices approach and then fade away two or three times. The cigarette was halfway to its filter by the time he spoke again, “Maybe that’s the point, I guess. Maybe the anticipation of resolution is like, foolish . Why does it need to solve itself?”

“Yeah,” I said.

“I mean he must be talented. He’s here on some kind of scholarship, same as me. Everyone in my dorm is on the same scholarship. The ‘Everett Sturgin Scholarship’—found out at a party last night it’s known as the *Forever Virgin* Scholarship or something dumb like that. Real bunch of Grade-A stereotypes so far, it seems. Everyone seems like they were selected by casting. Yeah. Yeah, party was alright. Don’t remember much to be honest.” I could hear him starting to drift off into thought again and told him I had to go.

At first it was a mile or two a day. Strolls really, never leaving campus just sort of circling the buildings and spots he found the most interesting or aesthetically appealing. But it was not long before a mile or two wouldn’t do it, he’d finish circumnavigating McTaggart Temporal Studies Building six times, which was built in the shape of an eight for reasons that W. T. was later embarrassed he did not immediately recognize, he only knew it was preferable (from an aesthetic, you know, walking perspective) to the ovular Bayer Arena , or the pure rectangle of the B. J. Peterson School of Geometric Sciences, the latter of which was a strange building where it seemed all of the blockheads and dolts had their classes and so traversing the area meant navigating a bunch of total squares who seemed to have inherited the brains of their baby-boomer parents without much of a thought—in any case he’d finish his 2.2 miles and feel that he had only just gotten started. If he stopped then, it seemed, he would be worse off than when he’d left almost, because he’d primed himself for some sort of a release and now could not achieve it as simply as he had when he started. In other words, he’d built up a tolerance for walking - not in any physical sense, but the mental stamina that was required of him was actually somewhat surprising. So constant were the stimuli in his day to day, that just by taking them away he struggled with where to allow his mind passage.

He saw no value in running, it would only make the whole thing disappear faster than it needed to, and the whole point was the whiling away of time, not for any particular reason, but in general, because time not spent being whiled away was unpleasant and lonely. As such he forced himself to walk slowly and purposefully so that anyone who actually saw him would think he was walking to class. If he noticed a particular group that was loitering for any extended period of time he would make efforts on each successive loop, to change his appearance in minor ways—turning his hat backwards, reversing his two-sided fleece zip-up, and then, if needed, taking the fleece off entirely and tying it around his shoulders in a highly affected Martha’s Vineyard sort of style, he imagined (having of course never

been on a sailboat, let alone to Martha's Vineyard, where he imagined each person carried around pictures of their sailboats in their wallets or purses, in front of their little wallet-sized pictures of their children or grandchildren, and no one ever moved their lower jaw when they spoke, ever), and if by then they still remained, he would slow down his pace to a near crawl, taking time with each step to observe and take in as much of his surroundings as possible, doing things like counting the number of lit windows on the interior face of the McTaggart Building, which took substantial concentration to do without pen and paper given its peculiar shape, which was not just the shape of the character that represents infinity, but consisted of an inner and outer building, requiring seemingly impossible intersections to occur, that W. T. noted seemed to be visually obscured by the overpasses that connected the two concentric buildings from every angle at which the illogical crossover should occur [51]. He would walk so slowly, in a complete daze, like some senile geriatric on the lam from the local nursing home, pausing after each step to try to identify some grounding piece of information that would bring their marbles back home. And all of this just so as not to be noticed subconsciously by any of the loitering coeds, who were almost always gone already by the time he reached the final curve of the observational leg of his walk. By which point he'd finally exhausted himself mentally, having forced himself into the same obsessive, recursive thought patterns that he'd been trying to escape by going on these little walks in the first place.

That first semester, it is fair to say, was a strange and relentlessly trying time for W. T. Because of this I was at first excited to hear that he'd met a girl, a beautiful Sophomore named Maya, of Dutch heritage (though an American citizen due to the fact that her mother had gone into early labor while on a business trip to the US, bringing Maya into the world on American soil only a day before she was scheduled to return home.

[MORE HERE]

Izzy Grayson: 1.1

Darla Grayson was Izzy's mother, responsible for the characteristically Southern Italian thick, dark and wavy hair that Izzy had kept long her entire life - proud never to have succumbed to the odd short-haired quasi-bowl cut epidemic that overtook the nation's population of 35-55 year old mothers in the nineties. She had once written (though failed to publish) an academic article in which she hypothesized a correlation between this phenomenon and the brutal murder of Nicole Brown Simpson. The paper had been leaked by someone in editorial at one of the academic journals to which she had submitted, and in the mid-aughts, when the internet was starting to take off but viral was a term that was still in its embryonic stage, it had gone as close to viral as an academic paper from a non-tenured female professor at a small, but elite Liberal Arts school, could go in those days. It was, in all likelihood, the most attention she'd ever received or would receive in her whole life. And she was never completely sure whether the virality itself was a positive or negative thing as it was mainly distributed through email,

and the forums where it had been posted were completely inaccessible to Darla Grayson, who still preferred to write at least three drafts in pencil, before switching to pen for two more, and then would finally ask her cousin to type it for her – she paid \$.03/word – the cousin was a lonely, hermitted soul, but knew how to type so fast people were constantly asking her if she was a stenographer, or something.

People had been commenting on Izzy Grayson's looks since she was a toddler. Not in the sort of strange, creepy way that seems mostly to come from aging uncles whose brains had long gone wet from pint after pint of liquor that even high school students would turn down in the most dire of circumstances. No, back then, mostly, people (genuinely, *just people*, in general - the set which contains all living human mammals with the capacity to speak) just could not restrain themselves from speaking aloud about how objectively good looking she was *for a toddler* –fully aware it was a strange thing to be saying (they might have said 'aesthetically appealing', if their vocabularies allowed for it, and in Wagner, Iowa, occasionally it did), and they always clarified their statement by appending it with, *for a toddler*, or sometimes, *for a baby*, if they were the type who called all children babies until they reached puberty, but it was as if they somehow were unable to stop themselves. Complete strangers would stop her mother while she was pulling Izzy down a grocery aisle, bribing her with lollipops they hadn't bought yet, just to ask if she had considered making little Izzy into a child model. And it was, undoubtedly, something to behold, the pure symmetry of her features, her adult gaze that seemed to be waiting, just waiting, for the first boy bold enough to look into them for longer than a moment. By definition she was remarkably good looking, though occasionally, understandably, she still smelled faintly of toddler poop as she was just learning to "make" on the "big girl potty" and wiping another human being's asshole is not a skill that comes naturally, not even to a mother, so more often than not her underwear became stained with streaks too dark to get out even in their brand new washing machine. But boy was she a looker though.

It was the sort of wow factor that goes along with all recognition of the inexplicable. The sort of thing that makes you stop and think, what does it really mean to be beautiful, anyways? For some reason it's much easier to accept that there are objectively ugly children out there in the world, they are being born left and right. Any given toddler has a solid thirty percent chance of being already destined to have to come to terms with whatever "league" it is he or she winds up allocated to - this, somehow, no one blinks an eye at. We see them all the time, toddlers wobbling around with large bulbous noses, or eyes that somehow seem to be misaligned so that they look to be in a state of semi-permanent confusion. Some kids just look (I feel bad just writing it) –but I mean some kids kind of seem like they are already...pre-hairy...and not in a Tom Selleck way.

Nothing about ugliness draws the same sort of commentary - but by the time she was three years old, she would occasionally have to be in attendance during one of her mother's lectures - and without fail, at the end of the class at least three of her undergraduate students would stop by her mother's desk which was rare of her students to do, approach her (mostly because it was rare for her students to be

genuinely interested in the microeconomics of angel investors in Afghani corn farming “industry” [\[52\]](#)), before heading out the door they would disappoint her mother by saying, “Little Izzy is just about the most beautiful little girl I’ve ever seen,” or, “Have you looked into modeling—I mean for Izzy, that is? I’m really serious. I had a cousin once.” Things of that nature - well intentioned comments that, because of their incessant nature, became harder and harder to ignore and started to really grate on her mother, the professor, who couldn’t get her class to show even marginal interest in really whatever it was she was talking about, if we’re being honest. They just made it more and more clear that there was actually something concretely pleasant, visually speaking, about Izzy that everyone could see.

It was only Izzy’s mother, Darla Grayson (née DiBosco) who failed to see what everyone else saw so clearly. Though never aloud, of course not, she was kind-hearted and had a deep desire to feel the motherly affection, see the stunning, and indescribable perfection of her daughter’s young face. Instead she saw something a bit piggish in her slightly upturned button nose that sat just above what she perceived to be a smaller than average, too-thin lips. All of which, she knew, if subconsciously, was precisely because of, or in response to the constant barrage of compliments that made her once (and only just the one time, **ever**) imagine what it might be like if her daughter’s nose was accidentally fractured in a way that made it maybe not sit so perfectly in the middle of her little three year old’s too-adult-for-her-own-good visage.

Perhaps it was on this day, the day that the vision of her daughter’s bent and off-center nose parked itself in the middle of her mind’s eye, pulled the e-brake, and settled in to watch her own reaction; perhaps that was the day she began to slowly crack. It is impossible to know.

There’s no way to know because not even Darla herself could explain where the idea came from - she had all but disavowed the possibility of religion. Had no interest in the occult, or cults, or rituals or anything remotely dogmatic. She wasn’t a cutter - cutters didn’t really exist yet (because they hadn’t been named, that is - though in reality there were probably plenty of pre-goth, long sleeved shirt wearing masochists back then too - things have to be named; and anyways she just wasn’t one of them). But that night, after a particularly difficult bedtime, she went into the untouched room, and went into an untouched closet, and found her ex-husband’s longest leather belt, with the thickest buckle and, for some inexplicable reason took off her clothes and knelt in front of the tall mirror like she was about to commit seppuku (and perhaps, with a samurai sword instead of a belt, well, it’s anyone’s guess) but instead of taking the Samurai’s way out, she proceeded to flagellate herself, thrashing the belt first over her left shoulder, then over her right, quite viciously—staring down her nude body as she did so, taking some personal pride in the fact that she did not so much as grimace even when the shock and perverse enjoyment faded away and she could feel little rivulets of blood traveling down her back and then collecting in the valley between her buttocks; and even when that same blood trickled all the way down to her perineum, some of it gathering in her pubic hair and some of it continuing to trickle down her inner thighs and all the way to the interior of her knees where it finally was absorbed into the thick, off-

white sheeps wool rug that had been given to her as a wedding gift from a wealthy aunt of her ex-husbands; she recalled this clearly and that it took little effort not to weep.

She remembered thinking of something she'd been told by her husband, who had been a Medical Doctor when they were married, he'd said that humans were made to withstand low intensity pain for long periods of time, and high intensity pains for shorter periods of time, and so usually, if something hurt like the dickens, you would pass out before the pain brought on cardiac arrest.

He'd given her that info (with regard to what, she could not recall) only six months before all hell broke loose. Six months later it occurred that he destroyed both his career and their marriage over the course of one late night at the lab. She found out from unempathetic detectives after he'd been missing for a good thirty-six hours, that he'd taken things more than a bit too far with his reptilian-looking research assistant, Pyotr, who had mistakenly joked about a particular type of asphyxiation fantasy involving an easily accessible respiratory device and a rubber strap used to cut off blood flow, were taken by her husband as an invitation to temporarily incapacitate, bind and then ignore all subsequent requests to be released, while under the influence of an incredibly strong cocktail of quaaludes and armagnac. He pleaded with the jury, explaining that he was both ashamed and embarrassed by what had genuinely been a misunderstanding—though they, peers of the heartland, were opposed to sodomy, let alone whatever this had been, even if it had all been in earnest.

Darla was unable to lay on her back for a week after the flogging, and she never even considered doing it again, but she still could not change what she saw when she looked at her daughter. So she tried from then on, as much as was possible without being obvious or cruel, she tried not to look her daughter in the face. Over time, she became quite adept at managing this small, sad goal - but in the end, reassured herself that it was *for Izzie* at the end of the day.

It is tough, objectively, to know what it is Darla saw when she looked at her daughter. This is because, around the time Izzy turned eight, it became impossible for even the most narcissistic, and nihilistic of her friends and family to ignore the rapid onset of her delusional paranoia and increasingly disturbing schizophrenic episodes (and these were *Wagner* [\[53\]](#) people for the most part, each one a paragon of the platonic ideal of Solipsism), and the altogether disturbing event that led to Darla's court mandated institutionalization when Izzy was nearing eleven.

Izzy Grayson: 1.1.1

Perhaps it goes without saying, but any information provided by Darla herself, comes with an asterisk or three, and should be taken with a spoonful of salt. To this day, W. T.'s octogenarian grandmother remains institutionalized. The two attempted 're-releases' into carefully supervised halfway houses have cumulatively resulted in property damage valued in the low six-figures, and three (possibly four)

incredibly innovative attempts on her own life that came nowhere near achieving their goals, but were disturbing to the staff in ways that left one of them with a sleeping disorder so profound she, herself, had to be institutionalized.

Hobson's Choice Halfway House was in fact a very old, converted slave quarters, divided by shower curtains to separate the men's rooms from women's. They lived four to a room, made no money, and did chores and public services to earn the ability to stay there.

This poor orderly had just been doing her job, preparing to clean the women's bathroom at the Hobson's Choice Halfway House. The women's bathroom, although far more sanitary than the men's, was still a job reserved for the newest paid female employee (the job was, on occasion, given to those volunteer team members, who came in far too chipper and ready to save the world, and who the staff would rather not have, than to hear them talk about how blessed it made them feel just to be there one...more...time). Chrys, was a paid staff-member, now on her third year there and they'd yet to hire a new employee. She had *more than done her time* but was stuck on 'plunger patrol' by circumstance. And so it was that, on that unlucky evening, she knocked on the very old, wooden door to the female bathroom and heard the bathtub running, but also what sounded like tired, but strenuous grunts.

Assuming the sounds were related to a dietary issue of some sort, which was not uncommon—and that the bath was a cover for the sounds, which were undoubtedly embarrassing, Chrys decided to give her a moment, but not much more than the time it would take her to go fill the mop bucket and return, which is what she did.

It was when she came back three minutes later to find the light still spreading out from the sizable gap between the door and the drooping floor board, and the bath still running, but heard no grunting anymore, she knocked once more and called out that she was coming in. All of the doors at Hobson's Choice were unlockable for reasons just like this.

She was expecting to find something wrong, that much was certain, but she was certainly not expecting to open to door on Darla, fully nude, her face an indescribable shade of bluish-red that was not purple, hanging upside down from the ceiling, her aging breasts drooped down to her chin, hung almost like salami at a butchers shop, her feet roped tightly into some sort of harness-like contraption that Chrys could not, for the life of her, make sense of - not how it was constructed, or what it was attached to; but there wasn't time for that in any case because the bath water was rising and almost at her forehead now.

Darla was completely incapacitated, but there was still life in her body, Chrys thought. And it somehow took her several seconds to think of what to do, but when she did it she did it well. Chrys screamed from the bottom of her toes for help. She screamed so loud that Darla shook slightly, showing signs of life, though it was life like a fish on a wire, not the sort that made one feel at ease.

Chrys screamed and ran to the bathtub, got to her knees and turned off the water. She pulled the plug and called Darla's name, looking up and down, not sure how to help her, the face so swollen with blood it might pop. She yelled and yelled and took the scene in so that it was seared into her memory.

Worst of all was that Darla looked to be smiling, she remembered later, though that was likely the effect of gravity, she'd been reassured. But that smile was what had broken her, sure enough, blue face, blue smile, fat blue cheeks and the way meat seemed to hang from bone, nothing about it beautiful or romantic in the least. Captured in a still frame it might have been titled, "Disease". It made Chrys sick in a way she had never once been adequately prepared for in all of her sessions of night school, despite several overnights she'd already done - despite every war story she'd been told, many of them far, far worse than this, stories that involved evisceration, stories that required the teller use the word *innards* several times, stories that were intended to search for an individual's limit with regard to fecal matter. She'd been prepared for the disgust, she'd even been expecting it—but there was something about the complexity involved in engineering her demise, something about the fact that it seemed more like she'd been trying to torture herself than kill herself, and yet it had not fit the mold of a typical "cry for help", it was something else altogether—and it felt...evil.

Yours Truly: 1.2

I am grieving I suppose.

If I come right out and say it, somehow, it seems less real.

We wrote things down so we could hide from them.

When the lights went out that night that the hurricane (I will not name her) really landed, I knew then that they would not be the same when they came back on.

Somehow the world had changed, everything flowing downhill the way it does.

The subjectivity of perception made itself apparent in the changing shades of blue (nearer black).

What was once—

What he was trying to say all that time, trying to tell anyone who would listen—not so much about needing him (I realized, too late), but to have such abundance inside and no place to put it—to set it down for a moment.

Noone ought to burn that bright.

It was too cold on dark nights to stand outside so long and smoke like that, like a soldier.

He only found the man to lose him.

Ever so many nights spent—

I was never able to grow up and he could never have the childhood he'd waited for.

He was a great writer, a singular and—
The world saw one brief flash and they knew.
But they were too late, too.
We asked the wrong questions, toes pointed askew, head trained forward.
Life hurdles by in the periphery, just like us, flying—he said, as we flew.
A river frozen in time, moving at a constant without disturbance.
Share a koan from a man named—
Steal a koan.
Name a man.

GAN: 1.2

The GAN was five minutes late to the first lecture, early for him by all standards, though he had, on that day, made every conceivable effort to show up, for once in his life, on time. It was strange, he had found himself thinking while driving home from Dr. Corinne Marten's house, where he had spent not just the last night, but the entire weekend, in order to stop himself from making any further amendments to his lecture outline and presentation, strange that he felt such anxiety about this course, the sort of anxiety that one rarely feels once they have reached some semblance of professional stability. And the GAN was beyond professionally stable. He'd turned the royalties from his first book, which continued to roll in with an astonishing consistency that was indicative of that novel's "canonization", that it was being taught across the country in college seminars on English Literature, and was actually now showing signs of growth in foreign markets that had made his agent quite literally squeal with excitement over the phone.

His newest novel was perhaps the most incredible feat yet, involving the sort of last minute epiphany that only can be attributed to something closely related to luck, though not blind luck, rather the sort of luck that overly-serious football coaches talked about when spouting the accurate, but overused aphorism about how *luck is when preparation meets opportunity*—in other words, the sort of luck that was earned.

But it had come at a cost, he thought, as he walked at a brisk but not sweat-inducing pace, towards the packed lecture hall. He still had to keep his back slightly pitched forward to avoid the specific angle that would lead to the spasms that had, day by day, been decreasing in frequency, as a result of his

continued efforts to do each and every prescribed exercise, despite how ridiculous they might seem. He often wondered if his doctors got a good laugh out of making up an exercise or two to add to the mix.

The event in question had been a singularly horrific one, and he was still coming to terms with what had occurred. It had been a month or so since it had happened, and he'd finally given up on expecting any new memories to come to him. It was forever going to be the partial memory that it was, *c'est la vie*.

He'd somehow gone home from happy hour at the Lit House with a particularly persistent PhD candidate (Working on a book length dissertation titled, "Psychoarchaeology, Critical Theory and Post-Ontological Semantic Reasoning: Kant vs. Can't") that he'd failed to recognize was stalking him and had assumed was just a regular at the same basic haunts, with a similar schedule revolving around the same two bars and their respective trivia nights and live music schedule, who'd become progressively more direct in her requests to discuss her work each time they "ran into each other"—until finally, after the fourth time he told her that really it was on the top of his pile, and he promised he was planning to read it that evening, she took the opportunity to invite herself over in an effectively provocative manner, he assumed, his memory starting to get hazy at that point and falling off almost completely thereafter.

He couldn't help but wonder if it was possible he'd been drugged. He remembered, among other pains, waking up to the feeling that his head was actively being sawed in two. What he did remember from the night prior washed over him in waves that morning, each one more frightening than the last. He remembered drinking some wine, but not an indulgent amount, certainly not enough to completely black out, and then a vision of her behind the wheel of his SAAB, singing Amy Grant or Cyndi Lauper maybe. Then he remembers coming out of a blackout half supine in his California King and there she was, fully nude with a sort of incredibly strong physique. She was laughing and playing with his semi erect penis, flopping it from one side to the other somewhat like an inquisitive cat might play with a dead mouse. Then it went all black again and his next memory opens with her astride him with a sort of crazy, *I get what I want* look in her almost glittery green eyes.

He felt somewhat certain that he'd been drugged, but didn't know what he would do about it if he had, and anyways, now that he wasn't drugged, he guessed he didn't mind so much (perhaps because of the drugs), at least not for the moment, apart from the tiny man splitting head in half and a vague concern about certain valuables that he told himself to double check before she left. The woman whose name he could not remember laughed when he asked if he could go grab some Aspirin. The laughter was a fixture in his memory and it haunted him.

Then he remembered the sunrise beginning to brighten his curtains: his body was involved in intercourse but his mind was still playing catch-up. The size of his morning erection let him know he'd certainly popped a few viagra the night prior. He was worried about the Viagra, slightly - he envisioned his doctor at the last visit reminding him the surprising frequency with which older men think their

heart works for their dick and not the other way around. “Literally aroused to death. It’s only funny until it happens to you,” the doctor had said.

He asked again about the aspirin, fully expecting her to stop and let him free. It wasn’t until she pulled back and slapped him, hard, across the face, and demanded he call her Alenka, that he fully and adequately recognized the preposterousness of his situation, and subsequently asked, somewhat apologetically, for her to stop, please.

In the seconds that followed a collection of thoughts and images swarmed upon him at once. In no particular order the following occurred to him: He wondered how much longer things with Corinne could possibly last; he recalled a scathing review of his third novel (which, up until its penultimate draft had been quite misogynistic despite his every intention to do the exact opposite) which was supposed to be a book that despised masculinity, was supposed to be his book to expand, as it were, and in many ways he did just that—but his intelligence, while vast, was susceptible to the same fatal shortcoming of so many other “great men”. And it did seem it occurred with a higher frequency to Great Men©, which seemed to be quite obviously linked to the fact that Men of Power, the so-called Great Men, had an innate desire and drive to spread their lineage, as like, perpetuators of their species, which one might suggest isn’t subconscious as much as it’s the result of some larger consciousness, the consciousness of say, mankind—and must itself be evolutionary in nature to some extent, that cro-magnon like instinct to place his “greatest work” inside of most anything that could potentially bear his offspring, regardless of his lack of desire for offspring in the practical sense even in the slightest—this being an example of the sort of theoretical evidence that Roland Barthes himself had used to declare the irrelevance of an author’s intention—the fact that their intention could very possibly be misunderstood even by themselves (as in fact was so often the case) when it came right down to it—so his novel, written from a woman’s perspective, initially having aimed to empower female sexuality by shifting a sort of agency (that’d he problematically identified as a male agency in the first place—failing to comprehend the inherent bias in his own perception, a fairly basic oversight, like surprisingly simple for a mind like his to miss, and yet miss it he did, as did his male editor, Turner Klapp, and Turner Klapp’s wife, Meredith, who was a better reader than her husband, as did his literary agent, Sophia Tengrim, one of the seven females he had asked to *pre-read*—all returning praise as if they’d felt an obligation) providing agency by shifting sexual agency to the protagonist of this particular novel, and she, not unlike—shit, was it possible the PhD’s name was Sarah?—not unlike ‘Sarah’ enjoyed dominating men sexually AND furthermore used deviant means, much like those used by—Sasha! The dominatrix was Sasha Rauthe! He could see her email still sitting in his inbox, unopened—the character was, it turned out, enough of a cliché when it came right down to it, that his more forgiving readers, many of which, surprisingly happened to have become critics—registered this protagonist as a sort of critique of the clichéd way in which male writers try to force themselves into a woman’s perspective (a precursor to the pejorative ‘mansplaining’, which the GAN would miss, that whole movement by just about a decade).

And here lies the brilliance of the GAN, which was not always in his writing (though of course, this is like saying the purpose of golf is not always to hit the little white ball—of course the brilliance is in the writing, but there are other things too), it was also very much in the actual speed with which he could create said brilliance when he'd entered into 'a state' (his word for 'the zone', 'vibing', 'on a streak', etc.). In a stunning act of both ingenuity and humility the GAN spent the last three and a half days, or eighty four hours, in a sleepless, machine like trance, rewriting the chauvinism back into his novel with a quiet intentionality, that now did actually wink at the reader ever so slightly about the characterization of the protagonist *as it related to the fourth wall breaking author*, making himself the butt of the joke in a way that was neither obnoxious nor trite, sort of exposing himself as a phony chauvinist fraud, but by doing so allowing himself to be forgiven for those very traits because the assumption of most readers (for which there must be some named fallacy or contradiction) was that if he recognized this, as was so clearly the case, then at least as a human he must be genuinely trying to do something to change this fundamental weakness of character, when in fact, he now realized he could add one more layer of irony to the language of the patriarchy/masculinity/chauvinism and an intelligent female reader would be forced, in some ways, to at least consider the fact that he was grappling with things that other writers would have fouled up completely, and putting himself "out there" to do it. A literary magic act of sorts, by which he was able to forgive himself of his own sins while publishing them in their least mediated form. It was a triumph and he pulled it off just in time to send his last revision to the publishers who didn't have the time to read through what he'd referred to as *mostly minor edits, grammar stuff*, and had to trust that he hadn't gone and done something drastic - though in truth they weren't the smart readers who would have caught the purpose or need for the changes in the first place, when it really came down to it.

"Sasha," he spoke in a clear, plain fashion, but also as tenderly as he possibly could, at the same time inflecting a sort of command that he felt would serve to reinforce his very serious frustration. A very grim thought had occurred to him and he now felt the imperative to be calm and patient - he had to be very careful not to let his mind wander down any dark alleys, stay in the bright, white sunlight.

She appeared to go through several stages of grief in quick succession, and when she landed on anger she stayed there. His erection had its own heartbeat. He was incredibly distraught by the conflicting feelings of pure uncut sexual excitement and total fear that gripped him as she continued to move her hips in a sort of figure eight motion, laughing with complete detachment, telling him she would not allow an inch of him out of her until she felt *something go off* inside of her. He had a moment's regret about the time he'd made light of a man who claimed to have been raped by his female boss - an incident for which he received substantial backlash from various groups and had to write a formal apology and wear a hat that read "No means No" in public for months. A demeaningly dumb axiom in his opinion, but one that he felt he could better understand now.

Even more confusing was when his fear became a catalyst for a return of his sexual appetite and he realized he enjoyed the slapping bit, though he'd never even dabbled in any BDSM related activities,

and now, here he was, on the verge of coming, condomless, inside an adjunct Professor of Gender Studies, despite the fact that No was supposed to mean No and he had very mixed feelings about the amount to which he should be enjoying it, versus the amount that he actually was enjoying it - all of which crescendoed in simultaneous climax in which he called out Alenka! (who was the protagonist of one of his most well reviewed novels written from a female's perspective) and she shouted Dario! who was Alenka's lover/homicide victim and then she toppled over, stretched out on the mattress and in doing so somehow made his hip twist in a way that it shouldn't - and a much less pleasurable spasm passed through his body instantaneously, and while she laughed he came to the realization that it was going to be difficult for him to move, anywhere at all that was, because something had gone seriously wrong in his lower back.

The GAN, found himself lying there, a prisoner in his own body, unable to move his head without shooting nerve pains that seemed to choose a limb at will through which to travel and temporarily numb, for the first time became genuinely frightened of his whole ordeal, when he saw, just barely in his periphery, the toes of the PhD seeking Sasha Rauthe, who he realized was balancing herself upside down in order to ensure that not a drop of his semen left her uterus, and that even the effort required to utter "Please...stop," sent those electric tendrils shooting, this time to the top of his head, which perhaps because he was so tired to begin with, was enough to make him pass out, and slip off into a dreamstate of sorts in which he was visited by a visibly distraught Collete who kept asking him if he was going to shit or get off the pot, over and over and over again, and he tried to respond but every time he opened his mouth something like oatmeal came pouring out, dribbling down through his thick beard and then dripping soundlessly into the porcelain basin of the toilet/throne where he was seated.

Izzy Grayson: 1.3

It was unclear whether or not Darla Grayson had, in fact, been attempting to commit suicide when she hung herself upside down, allowing her blood to slowly but surely begin to increase the pressure on Darla's brain, until she passed out, which, in conjunction with the incredibly high amount of lithium she had taken (noone ever was discovered as the source of the lithium, though the sheer quantity was so massive that even if she had not been taking her lithium daily for the previous three months Darla could not have saved enough of it to reach the levels of substance identified in her system)—all of this essentially caused a brain hemorrhage (which is, by its very nature a ghastly and grotesque scene once it begins to find orifices through which to reduce the pressure, which was the final thing that Chrys saw that day before blacking out herself, landing her head against the rim of the toilet seat in such a way that sent her body from the neck down on its own path in life, no longer taking direction from the brain, though continuing to pump blood and oxygen as necessary, paraplegic by definition - and she would be remitted for the rest of her life, to riding around in a wheelchair that she could navigate via progressively more technically advanced mechanisms ranging from blowing into a tube (very early on,

which proved to be labor intensive and hard on the lungs) to a sophisticated retinal capture device that allowed for a set of eye movements that told the chair what to do via science that Izzy never understood.

Izzy, for her part, spent the years from seven to approximately thirteen getting moved between unfriendly relatives who always made it abundantly clear that the situation was not a permanent one and that they were only able to help out in the interim, but were, of course, more than happy to be doing so (which was said in such a way as to make it abundantly clear that they were less than happy to be doing so, and that Izzy had better be grateful and put in some work around the house if she wanted the arrangement to last any substantial period of time). They were a working family from a town in Iowa that's sole purpose was to provide for a school filled with either rich or brilliant students who for one reason or another were not the sort of students that fit in at other top tier educational institutions. A school filled with weird nerds, to put it in her Uncle Carl's blunt but accurate language. And as such they were, mostly, dissatisfied with their lot in life, stuck in a town without industry, and didn't have the financial means to take on an additional child, especially not one who was, they each whispered it to one another, sure to go off the deep end, just like her Mama.

It was the green eyes, they said. A sort of pale, pistachio-like green. Green eyes in themselves are a rarity, but the green eyes of Izzy Grayson were, in your narrator's humble experience, literally one-of-a-kind. Something about the almost flat, immutable shade of green actually was far more compelling, aesthetically, than the shiny gem-like counterparts that are, in some parts of rural Appalachia and the deep deep south, considered symbolically linked to the devil. These eyes were not those eyes though. They were natural but obscure, rare but not baroque or obscene in their uniqueness. And so, apart from the money, and the fear of her own legacy, the women of her family didn't want Izzy around out of jealousy—and the men didn't want Izzy around because of the women. Or, in the odd case that they did want her around, such as was the case with her Uncle Carl, who had been something like the lone, kind soul, to the abandoned child – it was not without certain expectations that Izzy endured once and never more.

I suppose this is all to explain the difficulties that Izzy faced as a young child, perhaps, by extension, to explain why she found herself living hand to mouth in a place known as The Pit, when she was around twelve.

History: 1.3

The Pit was an off grid location in the immense stretch of woods that bordered Wagner on the eastern, southern, and western boundaries. The Talbot River formed Wagner's northern border, beyond which was a stretch of great, grassy plains as far as the eye could see. Whether wooded or grassland the terrain was univocally flat. Except for the Pit [\[54\]](#), a lone blip of depression and elevation in an

otherwise almost entirely flat landscape, topographical aberrance formed when a meteorite the size of a microwave made its final descent some time between twelve and fifteen thousand years ago.

Everything within a quarter-mile radius had been obliterated and *The Pit* was born. The teardrop shape of the crater is impossible to distinguish at ground level, though it bears unique platlife, trees that grow nowhere else in the state somehow took root - it looks like a hill, more or less, and the hill itself is obscured by the pinewood forest that covers it. Only from a particular vantage point at the top of the hill can one easily recognize the slightly stretched out bullseye shape that the single contiguous hill forms, in the middle of The Pit is Blackrock Lake, which is more of a pond than a lake, and one of the places the boys and girls of Wagner are often warned to stay away from as children for multiple reasons - some logical, others related to the local legends and myths that traced back to before the land was settled by the early pioneer families: cryptozoological stories of yore, tales of underwater creatures that rose from the lake once a century (or once a decade depending on who you ask), bodies somewhat human but with long branching tree limbs for arms that stuck out from their torsos at all angles, draped with algae in some stories, used like spits on which they collected their deceased prey in others.

In truth, the most dangerous creature that inhabited the interior of the pit was the human being. A small group of Wagner dropouts had created a tent village of sorts on the interior Western wall. They'd made an art form of laziness and stretched it to its logical extreme, cult-like communal homelessness. They were known throughout Wagner because they would, every so often, drift into town like some down-on-their-luck cousin. Their visits were cause for great amounts of concern among the locals, who'd made the mistake when the group first began [\[55\]](#) of writing them off as an offshoot of the hippie scene that would slowly but surely disintegrate along with their ideals, leaving behind a mess to clean up and perhaps a foul scent but not much more. They would spend a few days *recruiting*, an involved process that involved identifying the most disenfranchised and potentially drug-addled students they could identify.

GAN: 1.3

The GAN was five minutes late to the first lecture, early for him by all standards, though he had, on that day, made every conceivable effort to show up, for once in his life, on time.

There was an ache that remained in his back, forcing him to lean forward against the podium in a way that gave him the look of someone forced to remain in a certain place for a long time seeking a bit of rest for the legs by holding up their body with their arms.

It wasn't until he stepped the lecture hall where cool air was kept in constant circulation breezed past his wet underarms that he realized how much he had perspired on his way to class. If he hadn't been late already he would have quickly run into the school store and purchased a Wagner shirt of some sort, quickly changing in the bathroom, as he'd done before at other presentations and talks, given his propensity for inexplicable sweat episodes was one of the things that had shaped his life, genuinely, because of its perfect, self-perpetuating psychic machinery, which required only that he think about sweating for an event to start, and once an event began, he had no control anymore – he didn't require any actual heat, his body would do what it wanted to do regardless of conditions – and it was significantly more embarrassing, on a day like that day in mid January, when everyone else was commenting on the biting cold, to be forced to take off his jacket and show these students exactly what his pituitary glands were capable of.

W. T.: 1.7

Late one night towards the end of his third year at Wagner, W. T. realized that it would be a matter of less than two months before his time at the University was complete.

As though it had not occurred to him at all prior to that moment, he was suddenly consumed by a torrent of grief and confusion that lasted through the night and well into the morning and still had not dissipated by late that afternoon. If anything it had gotten worse.

He was surprised by it, initially. He had intentionally stayed on track for early graduation because he had spent the first two years at Wagner feeling utterly depressed and lonesome and completely out of place. Early on he'd learned that if you attended the Social Club parties (which we're frats, ostensibly, but composed of individuals who had gone to Wagner and thus were far too elite to be involved in fraternities and sororities, that would have Chapters at like, OSU, and would require some participation with the plebeians at State Schools as such. Fraternities and sororities were fundamentally not stuffy enough (or wealthy enough) for Wagner-ite involvement, so they had "Social Clubs", which W. T. quickly learned were Fraternities and Sororities for people who believed they were too good for Fraternities and Sororities. Social Clubs were in a different stratosphere when it came to funding, filled with the offspring of oil magnates and Senators and people who made Senators do their bidding.

He could never forget the first party he'd attended, which was a sort of vetting party held by one of the Social Clubs that went by the name OMNI. He'd been invited somewhat accidentally, because by sheer chance his dormmate, Davis Reynolds, happened to be of the R. J. Reynolds' lineage, and being entirely unlikeable, had failed to convince anyone to accompany him that evening, two or three weeks into the first semester, and as such had decided to ask W. T. at the last minute. It was as they were walking to the party, which was nearly a mile from their dorm in the residential part of town that was

exclusively occupied by privately owned *clubhouses*, that Davis absently asked what the Graysons did. He was so taken aback by W. T.'s reply,

who had a line item in their budget that read "Winter Sports". W. T. remembered distinctly being explained by a young man w

It had been early in the fall semester when he met Delia, who liked to gather in the local café, grow wildly anachronistic facial hair and wear things like suspenders and bowties, who tried their utmost to pretend they were not being ironic about it but were, in fact, being the pretentious snobs they decried in their shoddily made 'zines, and who were all queer in one way or another.

It had started as a strong sense of hopelessness. He thought about the conversation he'd had with his academic advisor, the computer program that had evaluated his responses to some specialized set of questions that were either oddly personal and intentionally obtuse, or else they were multiple choice questions that asked him to select the best response to a very specific, and maddeningly transparent set of circumstances that were broadly related to the computer sciences field. The idea with these tests was to come out on the other side with a list of entry-level job titles that were well suited for a Computer Science major. The test results were then distributed to head-hunters who were compensated based on their ability to place well qualified graduates into high-paying jobs quickly after graduation. He thought about the sick feeling he'd gotten while taking the test, from staring at a computer screen for too long, he'd decided – and then the realization that he was filling out paperwork intended to place him in a role where he would be required to stare at a computer screen for at least eight hours a day, five days a week, as a part of the economic machine, over and over and over again. He had, on the way back to his small apartment above the laundromat, following the exam, had to stop and vomit into the shrubbery at some professor's house, before continuing on.

when by late that afternoon he had not returned any of her phone calls, Delia Welling decided to take a stroll down Pearson Avenue, stopping by the liquor store and then "The House of boB", where she acquired an eighth of some potent strain of *sativa* that boB went on and on about (when she left he was in the middle of a story about his time in Thailand and so busy thinking about himself that he didn't notice her stand up to leave, he just went right on talking about some sort of ritual that required the use of a hallucinogenic, every fifth word or so was an extended, lazy variant of *maaan* or *dude*).

A thousand or more miles to his south, your narrator was eagerly awaiting the return of his only true friend, and spent most nights on the enclosed widow's walk (which, he worried, having been enclosed by glass windows as his great uncle's final distinguishing alteration to the property, may have by definition changed the widow's walk into something else altogether, but had decided not to investigate).

W. T. was on the third floor of the Carruther-Grantham Library, a modern behemoth of a building that was in opposition to everything that was modest and of a very particular time period and had nothing like the glass façades or intentionally asymmetrical lines that made up the Carruther-Grantham Library, which is to say, the library had been a mistake, aesthetically speaking, and the school of architecture and design had been all but defunded entirely upon the recognition of the alumnus community that they had been responsible for the creation of such a monstrosity on campus.

W. T. liked it. He liked that it verged on a sort of sci-fi aesthetic that leaned into this kind of vaguely decadent futurism - something wholesome in a *Danger Will Robinson!* sort of way; like hopefulness, to be shameless about it - the last bastion of a culture that has had anything resembling an identity beaten into a formless abstraction. He felt that the school was actually living up to what had hitherto seemed a wholly unwarranted reputation as culturally progressive.

Three years at Wagner had opened his eyes to many of the things that are so stereotypically revealed at this time as to make it a primary component of college. Which, of course, accounted for the oft-stated and rarely debated claim that the American System of Higher Education tended to liberalize its students. Occasionally, this statement was made in more obscene ways—the greatest of which, to his recollection, was made by Henry Roapes, who spoke more and more like Foghorn Leghorn the drunker he got. It was nearly impossible for him to hide a buzz because he lost all ability to use the ‘-er’ phoneme, which was replaced by “-uh” as if by magic. W. T. loved it, whereas yours truly found it nauseating. He had invented this character out of thin air at some point, and tracing its genesis was one of the lifetime goals of J. L. Roapes.

This was on one exceedingly drunken night during a period in which Henry Roapes and his wife were temporarily separated. These temporary separations were not in and of themselves uncommon throughout John’s life and he often found himself wishing that they’d just stay apart for once and be done with it. But this would never be the case. During these periods John worried about his father’s mental health, and during this particular episode he was even more concerned than usual. Henry Roapes spent most of his adult life fighting off a darkness - in this capacity he was more akin to W. T. than he was to his own son. John was unnaturally level headed, a gift indeed if you were level-headed enough to see it as such—which he, this is, John, was—unfortunately he lived with the feeling that his father saw him quite differently, as a candle with a dull wick, too hard to start and impossible to keep lit under any conditions more significant than a whispering breeze; a weak battery; a gunshy hunting dog.

It was Pappy who saw the truth of the situation, and from time to time he would pull John aside to share bits of private information, or stories he did not tell the rest of the family.

During this particular separation, however, John found himself uncommonly worried about his father’s state of mind, and so together with W. T. they would stop in to see the old man, who was only staying at the Waterside Inn for a week, he said, until Mom stopped seeing red, he said.

Admittedly, the boys had a bit of fun goading Henry and his surreal, liquor soaked, accent into making statements that they would later try to repeat to each other, syllable by syllable. W. T. was much better at doing a Henry impression than John was. As such it was an activity that mostly consisted of W. T. doing his astoundingly accurate impressions, while John laughed and shook his head in quasi disbelief, “Incredible. You sound just like him. Just like him; incredible.”

On this day, which was the second or third day he’d been at the Inn, Henry was talking directly to W. T. who had just been accepted to Wagner. Henry’s words reeked of bitterness when it came to the topic of higher education, in part because he had never gotten around to finishing his own degree, it was assumed. But John was of the opinion that this was not the root cause of things, at least not in and of itself, but that his father was a realist and understood why someone like W. T., without other means, required some method of climbing the socio-economic ladder, as it were.

Mostly, Henry Roapes liked making fun of college students and how little they knew of the “real world”. Of course, this was in itself humorously hypocritical of the man who’d spent almost his entire lifetime living on an island with roads, buildings, and even creeks and inlets that bore his family name [56]. Despite having never held a job with formal hours, or a boss for that matter - despite genuinely having never worked an honest day in his entire life, he could not help but voice his antiquated opinions regarding the “oblivious lib’rul herd” that attended college, (views which were embarrassingly conservative, and fundamentally bigoted in the sort of way that he was not old enough to defend - but, one must note with a sad sort of pity, his anachronistic bigotry was just about the only thing in the world he could say he held in common with his own father).

Speaking to W. T while vacantly staring into the clink-clink-clink of the ceiling fan: “High-uh Educayyyy-shun you say, boy? ...Mo’uh like indoc-truh-nation . Extremists! Leftwing-ed cult-ovation, yuh follow?” He lit a cigarette that he’d pulled from behind his ear. The small cherry burned bright in the darkness of the drawn blinds. He sucked in a mouthful of smoke and spit it out without even inhaling. “Do they teach you to Ji-haaahhd on Tuesdees and Thursdees; or is that mo-ah of a Mund-ee/Wed-nes-day/ Frid-ee type of course? Oh my,” he giggled to himself, some apparent bit of genius having dashed across his inebriated mind, “Puh-haps I’ve been uncouth. You must fuh-give me. Was what I said some kind of...some kind of... cultural uh-pro-cre-ation?” It was impossible to tell if he was joking, and by extension, it was impossible to respond to such a comment with any degree of sincerity. [Extended Pause during which W. T. and John visibly restrain themselves from condescending laughter] “Pardon my ignoramity, of course I meant to say uh-pro-priation. Is that some sort of uh-pro-priation, boy? Extremism, that is? Ji-haaad, and such?” And something about the way he said the word “boy” made you want to slap the word from his drunk and slobbering lips.

This presented something of an ethical dilemma for John - who on the one hand felt compelled to love his father, and could, in all honesty, understand how difficult it must be to live under the constant cold and contemptuous gaze of his mother.

But on the other hand understood the root of this contempt more and more as he aged, and he couldn't help but notice that she seemed to reserve it just for him. The man was near unbearable to be around when he was sober: miserable and cantankerous without any apparent empathy.

He was unable to see the effect his presence had on those around him - the way any room he entered seemed to slowly turn a monotonous gray, as if he acted as some kind of drain through which the vitality of life itself slowly emptied from the world. Like the fish joke the G.A.N. constantly referenced, where the two fish swim along until some other, older fish says to them, "Nice water today, right kids?", and one fish looks to the other and goes, "Water? The fuck is that?". Or like the Charlie Brown Rain Cloud Effect. Same thing.

It was just like that with Henry Roapes, except for him, it was this vague monotony that he exuded, a gray aura without the strength to even cast shadows, just a emptiness that hovered in his vicinity and would not leave; not for a long, long time had he been without it. Not for as long as he could remember.

A chicken and egg situation, no doubt. Had Beatrice hardened in order to save herself from the psychological whirlpool that was Henry Roapes? Or was Henry Roapes such a vacuity because the woman with whom he'd decided to go hand in hand into the future had turned out to be cold and calculating and seemed (rather openly) to despise who he was or had become?

When he was drunk, on the other hand, he was still all of that but it was accentuated by occasional bursts of obnoxious gaiety, and he spoke .

For many years John thought the more interesting question was how they had fallen in love in the first place - if he knew what had changed since then, maybe, perhaps, there would be a path that one could follow backwards. But upon learning about the archaic contrivance of their marriage he realized that there was never a time when they'd really fallen in love, rather as was revealed by a senile Pappy, confusing his grandson for his own son, John learned that he was at the heart of this desolate landscape of a marriage.

It had been his fault, all along, he thought. And so he sat in the smoky motel room and listened to his drunk father rhapsodize about conspiracy theories and dared not complain.

Neither John nor W. T. would think of this conversation until nearly a decade had passed, when it was revealed that for some time (meaning a decade or more) Henry Roapes had been involved in a fundamentalist organization and was prominently featured on more than one federal ' watchlist '. What was most surprising about this revelation [\[57\]](#) was that the organization in question – The Association of Seers and Sorcerers - House Agrippa Tantum Saeculum – was a fundamentalist to a Holy Text that made the Christian Bible, the Koran, even The Book of Joseph, seem like specimens of scientific rationalism in comparison.

Their text, known simply as *The Word*, was written by a historically forgotten figure (literally, they theorize that history has forgotten the being who wrote *The Word*—or as it is written in the first book of the text: *He who lived so that he may be forgotten*), who was supposedly a supernatural origin, was both a singular entity (or deity) and a group of four beings, two male and two female, who managed to cross copulate in such a fashion that they birthed a single offspring with four “parents” - and this character, whose teachings make up the greater part of *The Word* - is the rough equivalent of Jesus to the Christians, in that he is a living carnation of the Supreme Diety X - and is known on earth as Agrippa Tardis.

I shit you not.

Now where was I?

Yes W. T. and the Carruther-Grantham Library

Best of all, was that its very shape and aesthetic was so despised by the moneyed donors who each had their own, peculiar, caste-indicative accents. One gets the impression that assholes find a way to sound like assholes no matter where they are from or how they grew up. These particular assholes are of a specific generation who wrote letters to the editor of the “Wagner Wailer”, a paper as widely read in the town of Wagner as the *New York Times* or *Chicago Tribune*. W. T. liked that the new building suggested there was still room for change, and unlike the body of alumni, who represented the worst sort of pseudo left-wing conservatives that can be imagined - the embodiment of what happens to the idealism of youth when confronted with the “real world” [\[58\]](#) – the realization of capitalism’s socio-cultural vacuum – that existential emptiness that the whole world woke up to, some dreadful Monday morning in the mid-90s (which ought to have been called the “post-eighties” to make clear the extent to which it was more or less just the shadow of the preceding decade) – these slobbering dolts, the youngest of the baby-boomers, clinging desperately to a vision of the world that had been imprinted on them since infancy; this group of imbeciles, just old enough to have become disillusioned by the war in Vietnam, but wealthy and educated enough not to have ever had to face the threat of going, utter dipshits who became terrible parents who couldn’t care less about their childrens’ psychological well-being so long as they were smiling, who declared with a passionate vigor that orthodontic braces were not just cosmetic waging all out war on the insurance industry; they spoke about the importance of a “good, straight smile” without any apparent irony or a passing recognition of the scent in the air, the potent rot of privilege that was happening in less visible parts of their savagely depressed teenage dirtbag children. Who didn’t just hate Nirvana, but really, truly, genuinely, didn’t understand how anyone could prefer that ‘trash’ to, say, Michael McDonald and that ever-so-affable beard. Who loved Michael McDonald, genuinely. And who just could not understand where they’d gone so wrong as parents. When had they gone so seriously off track that they just sat there in bed sometimes, late at night, too tired to bang on the wall and get into the same fight, once again, about how it just wasn’t

appropriate for their fourteen year old daughter to be listening to “Rape Me” on repeat, and so loud, especially when Dad had work in just a few hours.

GAN.: 1.4

They had a two page spread on Roland Barthes, presenting the history of the class he’d taught at The College de France. In the center of the spread, such that the crease ran down the middle of his face, was a profile of the philosopher, critic and (one must suppose it can be said) aspiring author. Barthes, in his book on photography, had made clear his discomfort with being the subject of a photograph - and the lack of ease was quite visible in the makeup of his face. Everything in its right place, his dark, parted hair was neat and combed from left to right, rigid despite its waves. It made one think of the undulating surface of a calm ocean swell, somehow stuck in time, on the precipice of letting itself move forward in time, but somehow tantalizingly stuck in the moment, unable to release.

Below that was his high, gently wrinkled forehead, even more broad than it had once been—a result of the receding tide of his hairline, two thick apostrophes for eyebrows with the dramatic curves of a man trying too hard, thinking too much, about the meaning an image presents. Large dark eyes set deep in his face exuded the sort of seriousness that seemed a sort of prerequisite to be taken seriously as a man whose job was primarily to think for a living. The sort of half-cocked grimace you can picture a man practicing in the foggy, post-shave mirror – never quite happy with the results. The same man who had written a full essay on the construction of Greta Garbo’s face, down to the minute detail of the fine line that ran from the corner of her nostrils to the edge of her mouth. He was so hyper conscious of what was captured that nowhere in the image could you see a thing that seemed to be living, rather he looked like a picture of a person. A reproduction in his own right. The long French nose had grown somewhat bulbous with age – there, perhaps, was some humanity – but for the most part he gave away nothing in the image. I suppose what is most markedly seen is that the man *in the image* is so consumed by awareness *of his very image* that he could not bring it to life.

The GAN stood at the high topped counter of the Black Rock Cafe, gazing down at Roland Barthes' vain, frightened expression, framed by several inches of text on each side. He wondered if he had returned to make a fool of himself. He reassured himself that this had already been done, in a variety of ways, and anyways one could not achieve anything without leaping in the abyss of absurdity—walking around in the kings' newest attire without so much as checking in the mirror on the way to the parade.

The intentions of the institution were clear enough; his class, which had not yet held a single session and was already predicted to be the most attended course in the school’s history. The School of Marketing had developed an entire campaign around the lectures, building a sort of academic fervor and excitement that felt almost un-American. But, not to completely abandon our nature, the endeavor had been evaluated and was in the process of being squeezed dry so as not to leave a penny on the table.

The GAN had seen his face on a billboard alongside the empty highway fifteen miles outside of town. There were plans to televise the lectures, and the GAN's agent had participated in a series of discussions regarding the distribution rights and royalties that would have made the GAN blush had he read the transcripts of the conversation. Every effort had been made to quite literally quantify the value of genius.

Wagner, Iowa had long been known as a sort of intellectual mecca, an outpost where the stern, passionate giants of thought came to seek the quiet and solitude needed to do some undisturbed thinking. The coastal literati be damned; they could have their swanky parties, cocaine and politics. The brains at Wagner put in work. There were only two NCAA-recognized sports teams at Wagner [\[59\]](#)

The new Dean of the School of Arts and Letters, Bernadette— *Dr. Bernadette Simone* , he reminded himself—had played no small role in the conception of the lecture series. But they had both been living in New York back then, a full four years prior, and their passionate literary tryst was still in full swing when she'd received the news about the position at Wagner.

Everything had seemed so perfectly aligned. He meant it when he said she had become his muse. He was frightened by the fervor of his attraction, of course a part of him knew how dangerous it all was—a part that he kept sedated as best as possible, as if it were some kind of laboratory mishap that he both could not allow out, and yet could not bring himself to kill. He had loved her in earnest when she made the decision to tell her husband, a Boccaccio expert of all things, that she would be accepting this new opportunity, and moving to Wagner...alone. Perhaps, he sometimes thought, she was the first woman he had truly loved—though he recognized that this idea itself seemed to be a recurring one, and was more likely just the failure of human recall—the inability to memorize a feeling. The inability, really, to truly remember anything at all. The whole time the GAN had struggled with guilt, a part of him concerned that he would suffer some karmic retribution if they got away with the whole thing, scot free—a part of him certain that he would one day be the Boccaccio scholar himself, just another schmuck, another David, someone for another man to pity, someone to haunt another man's dreams.

Perhaps worst of all was that there was part of him that knew that he would never, not ever be able to have a healthy romantic relationship, if only because he'd always be looking for someone else's averted eyes, the sidelong glance, the move to check a watch that didn't . The most sensible part of his brain was completely riddled with shame, self-loathing. In the evenings, at social events, his light had gone out. He had never been the life of the party, but he usually ended up in the center of a small group, answering existential questions with witty allegories and the occasional recitation of some poem by William Carlos Williams or Marianne Moore, Philip Larkin when he was feeling particularly snarky or could tell the room needed a laugh. This Be the Verse, undeniably, was the sort of recitation that could turn whole evenings around.

They fuck you up, your mum and dad.

They may not mean to, but they do.

*They fill you with the faults they had
And add some extra, just for you.*

*But they were fucked up in their turn
By fools in old-style hats and coats,
Who half the time were soppy-stern
And half at one another's throats.*

*Man hands on misery to man.
It deepens like a coastal shelf.
Get out as early as you can,
And don't have any kids yourself.*

Now, though, even Larkin came out flat, and sad.

*Man hands on misery to man.
It deepens like a coastal shelf.*

This was not the kind of man he was, he repeated to himself in the post-shower steam, thick enough to hide his reflection from himself, though never long enough. Sometimes he said it aloud, "I am not like him," thinking of his own father, the cartoonish playboy, and trying his best to refrain from casting blame. But more often than not it was a silent chant that echoed in the vaulted chambers of his mind. *This is not who I am. This is not who I am.* As he shaved with a flat razor as he'd been taught, wiping foamy clouds of shaving cream against the damp face towel, thinking of course, of her.

No matter how clearly or frequently he stated it, it was plain enough to see this *was* the kind of man he was, by definition.

On occasion, he was able to make himself feel better by remembering that this was a man who could recite entire sections of the Decameron in the original Florentine vernacular (and had a bad habit of doing so, as a party trick, when he'd had one too many martinis) – which is only to say, he was able to convince himself that Bernadette would have found the escape hatch with or without the GAN as an excuse, and he had been more of a convenience, at least in that regard, than a catalyst for the decisions she'd made. He reminded himself of certain banal platitudes - that *it takes two to tango* , and that biologically speaking *man was not built for monogamy* . He made himself a victim too, in this way – and though he saw right through himself, the moments of despair could never overpower the high of complete and profound nothingness he felt when he came inside of Dr. Bernadette Simone, a married woman's teeth digging into his earlobe until she tasted blood. It was unreal.

[Need to cover the husband's reaction - the subsequent union of Bernadette and the GAN - the fallout - the ultimatum - she is able to keep her job]

The GAN would describe a few of their raunchier exploits in a book of erotica written pseudonymously as a woman. He'd chosen the almost offensively baroque (not to mention transparent) pen name, Blanche Stuyvesant, but failed to consider the accuracy of his phony biography or consider that there might be readers who were able to investigate such details as the schools Blanche had attended, or the existence of the small town in which she'd supposedly spent her entire life dreaming up "this one great romance".

In his posthumously discovered journals, the GAN first references "I Am Not Your Venus" (under the original working title: *Entropic Desires*) in an undated passage that falls approximately between December 1983 and May of 1984, a time during which he was feverishly working on four simultaneous book length projects, only one of which he would not go on to publish in his lifetime; though one need not worry, his estate made sure to publish anything that he ever so much as looked at after his death. For example, the GAN kept a notebook beside his toilet (he suffered from IBS his entire life and also is likely to have suffered from undiagnosed Crohn's disease). There are pages and pages of excrement related limericks, poems and short passages of prose. His estate did not bat an eye at the specter of publishing these pages, despite the author's explicitly scribbled wishes to the contrary found on the front page of many such notebooks.

It was only after the GAN made his public reveal, despite the advice of his agent and editor ^[60] that the criticism started pouring in. The book, titled with a wink, *I Am Not Your Venus*, in fact, *did* publish to great acclaim—but quite suddenly it was trite, trashy, meaningless smut. Critics published vehemently argued retractions, the idea of literary theory was suddenly on the tongues of students and scholars alike, and in some ways it was a marvelous awakening. To see such a thing had purpose, meaning; because if it were true that literature were to be studied independent of its author it would put an end to the dispute once and for all - for the language itself had been received to great acclaim—even the critics who were now thrashing the work, carefully baked in admittances of their own, occasional, desire to embrace the work regardless of its genesis. But "Genesis is never to be ignored", which became a tenet of post-illusionist thought, and was also the title of a Poetry chapbook by one of the foremost Post Illusionist poets of the aughts.

If *the author was not, in fact, dead*—which is to say if it mattered that Blanche was the GAN [and in the mind of the GAN this was the case—his had been a willful attempt to deceive, supplant, coerce and though all of his critics had failed to mention it, a fact that made the GAN almost giddy to be able to call himself out on this, thus taking ownership of the intentionality of his own voyeurism. Say what you will about the man, he did not fail to own his decisions.

Or, bluntly, *The GAN, had demanded he be considered*. Of all the things about *I Am Not Your Venus* that the even most vocal of his detractors did not mention, perhaps what surprised the GAN most was the inherent voyeurism of a man hoping to feel true feminine

It was his arrogant public unmasking, a dreadful miscalculation, that turned a good portion of his readership against him.

What gave him the right!? How exploitative! Deceptive! Egotistical!

And perhaps it was arrogance. Certainly there was ego involved. But he couldn't help but think of Barthes, the bus that struck him, right after he had declared to the world that he felt he had reached the middle of his life, as he was setting out on this new chapter—this *Vita Nova* as it were. And how few fucks he gave about the moaning around the unhappy readers of his dip into his woman's mind. It was his, no doubt, but he had been Blanche—still was, from time to time. This new world he'd found. This is what he wanted to bring to the classroom. The excitement still existed, somehow. Perhaps this was his *Vita Nova* as it were. And maybe Bernadette would see.

W. T.: 1.8

Delia pushed their way into the auditorium much more aggressively than made W. T. feel comfortable. He was a large person despite his every effort. He ate as little as possible, went running frequently and maintained a nearly vegetarian diet. He had been born that way, his mother often spoke of it in situations that made him uncomfortable—at dinner with Bea, he still remembered, when they'd barely moved in and Bea had invited them to dinner as a sort of welcoming party/ice-breaker event for their two sons, both only-children, and even though John technically was not a *bastard* not in the same way that W. T. was (which is to say John *had a father*, even if he seemed to be absent or hidden away—whether by choice or by order, he'd not yet even seen the man) both unmistakably *unique* amongst their peers (though in very different ways)—she told the story of his birth quite openly, how he had been a *breech baby* and a particularly large one at that—and he remembered the way the two women who were as slight as they were powerful, winced and chuckled Izzy mentioned his birth weight of almost eleven pounds.

W. T. never got angry with his mother, but on occasion as was the case at that uncomfortable dinner, he stopped playing along when she'd ask him to tell a particular story, or chime in with his thoughts about this or that topic. And he could get snide, like most adolescents, as was the case when he set his fork down with a clatter and said, "You managed to get me in there. The least you could do is not complain about getting me out," his voice squeaking slightly towards the end of his statement, as if to emphasize his adolescence.

Izzy did not so much as bat an eye. The two of them were on terms that were completely foreign to John and his mother—the distressed look on both of their faces indicating as much—John's round, soft face flushed red at the word *vagina*, redder still when he looked at Izzy Grayson, who was (he had decided in the two weeks since they'd arrived) the most beautiful woman he'd ever seen in real life, and

apart from Nancy Sinatra (who he'd seen in a Playboy spread that had been given to him from a classmate in exchange for allowing him to copy his homework for an entire semester) Izzy Hrayson might very well have been the most beautiful woman of all time.

What no one at the table knew was that W. T. felt a sort of guilt about the whole thing, his large size at the time of birth, the fact that he had been delivered breech in a bathtub, and quite nearly killed them both (a part of the story that went untold, of course)—but the guilt seemed unfair and so he always became a bit resentful when the conversation came up. As far as W. T. was concerned, it seemed that much of life was not fair.

This would become a foundational principle in W. T.'s "Rules of Engagement", a manifesto of sorts that he wrote down a year or two later, though its core principles had been fairly well locked in by then.

1) There are no rules to life—but you have a life to rule. 2) Life is not fair, get over it.

He certainly hadn't chosen not to enter the world head first, in fact he hadn't chosen to enter the world *at all* - nor had he chosen the broad shoulders that made him take up an uncomfortable amount of space to this very day. Sitting beside someone in seats made for the average person seemed always to lead to him constantly apologizing until he could find a way to sit that didn't cause his muscles to cramp, usually hunched forward a good three to six inches in front of anyone seat so that his shoulders were not aligned with the shoulders of whoever sat in the adjacent seat. People were constantly eyeing him with this sideways, pissed off glance, as though he were intentionally pulling his shoulders back so that they imposed upon the person next to him, entering that invisible marginal space between two strangers that should not be crossed in his personal opinion.

All of this was on his mind and causing him to start to sweat as Delia deftly navigated between the heavily populated top level of the semicircular lecture hall—a row that was supposed to be a walkway and was currently breaking all sorts of fire safety codes—she gripping his hand tightly and pulling him along so that he had no choice but to clumsily force his way through the crowd, turning sideways and sucking in as much he could, when he could, given the speed at which Delia pulled him.

They finally made it to the far edge of the top level and the crowd thinned out to almost no one, because W. T. recognized, there was a giant column directly between where they now stood and the stage.

Having arrived there W. T. was certain they would now stop, and simply listen, which was just fine with him - the man they were going to listen to was a writer, it was not as if there would be some elaborate song and dance to go with it.

But Delia had other plans. She dropped his sweaty hand and started walking down the stairway that ran along the back wall of the stadium, descending towards the front of the house, which sat a good eight feet below the stage in both directions. She looked back over her shoulder and said, "Just wait there, okay? Just wait for me, I'll be right back." A portion, right up front, where if it were a concert the maestro might have stood with his little magic wand, invisibly pointing all the instruments into action,

was a section that had been roped off, presumably for special attendees. It had been filled with fold out chairs, which were clearly less comfortable than the cushioned chairs throughout the rest of the stadium, but W. T. supposed, that was the cost people were willing to pay for proximity to this apparently great man.

The hall was packed, but the fold out chairs up front still had ten or twelve open seats. The lecture had another seven minutes before it was supposed to begin. W. T. assumed the remaining seats would fill in due time, students continued to enter and spread out along the back wall, which was by now three or four individuals deep, and left only a very narrow corridor for walking along should someone, like Delia, try to make her way back. The thought struck him that she might get stuck wherever she'd gone, presumably to the bathroom, and would not make it back before the walkway was blocked altogether and so he decided it would be best that he follow her, or follow in that general direction, so that in any event there would be less terrain for her to cross in order to find him.

He had only taken a few steps when he saw her, at the bottom of the staircase, speaking to a man who must have been in his mid-fifties or so, sixty at most, wearing clothes that were all a size too large for him, as if he'd recently lost a great deal of weight. He had a long, unkempt gray-brown beard, and sported a paperboy cap that sat atop a head of hair that was full and long, pulled back into a ponytail, that same gray-brown of his beard (though whereas the beard was more gray than brown, the hair on his head seemed more brown than gray).

Here was a man beginning his descent, thought W. T. –though Delia was clinging to his arm like a schoolgirl, enraptured no doubt by whatever he was saying, laughing in that particularly showy way she had of laughing at W. T.'s jokes when he knew what he'd said wasn't all that funny. Seeing the two of them dampened his mood, but the man was old, so old, and of course no actual threat to W. T. – though even W. T. could admit, from this distance, that there was something magnetic about him—an appeal that confused him, and that was the source of the uneasiness, of course.

Someone bumped him from behind and he nearly fell over into the row of seats he'd been parked beside, watching. Whoever had bumped him had turned back immediately to apologize - it was another student he recognized from a philosophy course he'd taken, a big, overweight, and soft spoken character who always seemed to be on the verge of tears. Whatever anger W. T. had initially felt immediately disappeared as his fat, chronically dismayed classmate (who's name happened to be Stuart Stewart, unbelievably) turned back to apologize in his high-pitched, frightened voice, and in turning, hit someone else, this time a dainty, freckled female student, who only barely managed to stay standing, so before he could apologize to W. T. Stu-Stew was already turning back to apologize to his second victim, clearly distraught by the entire situation. W. T. could see the thick dark line of sweat gathering beneath his breasts and under his arms and felt a pang of sympathy for him.

There are few worse feelings than those that accompany the realization you are trapped in your own body—there is no escaping alive. For all intents and purposes it is akin to a sentencing, whatever ails this device you spend all day inside of, you will be bound to it forever. W. T. was among the lucky ones, he complained of broad shoulders and thick body hair, but looking at Stu-Stew he felt like an asshole.

To make things worse, he had been carrying a powdered donut in his right hand, and in all of the commotion the donut had somehow gone flying, and there was a third individual now involved, a grumpy elderly fellow in a tie and blazer who had been seated one row in front of Stu-Stew's current location. The man stood, powdered donut in hand, and turned, spewing German vulgarities that required no translator to interpret.

The commotion had been enough to attract the attention of the nearby attendees. The dynamics of a crowd are difficult to understand but it is true enough that a single event can draw recognition from far across the room, inexplicably, as though passed like an electrical impulse across a room. This seemed to be the only explanation, at least, for Delia looking in his direction at that very instant. She covered her mouth in a coy gesture, to indicate that she was holding back laughter at either the angry German, who continued gesturing with the powdered donut, sending little flecks of powdered sugar drifting in a trail behind his motions; or perhaps she had been laughing at Stu-Stew, who continued pitifully apologizing while at the same time trying to reach out and grab the donut from the German man's hand. Grasping and missing several times the way one looks trying to catch a housefly in midair.

W. T. was, at this point, beginning to sweat too—he'd temporarily been able to transfer his anxiety onto Stu-Stew and the German, he realized, but the moment he made eye contact with Delia it was as if he snapped back into his own body—*he failed to recall the leaving, but could not forget the all-encompassing heat of re-entry*—as his blood started pumping again in a way that he could not help but consciously consider. Just the thinking made him sweat, this was the amazing thing—and not thinking made it stop just as quickly—but the complete lack of agency or control, and the awareness that this was the case, made the thinking all that much worse, and in turn the same with the sweating.

Delia now waved him down with a “come here” gesture. The man she'd been speaking with had started walking away, but not towards his seat in the front section, as W. T. had assumed he would—rather, he walked to the door at the end of the walkway, the one that led backstage to the “Green Room”, where speakers were to prepare and gather their thoughts before a particular lecture or performance. And as he lifted his arm to open the door W. T. saw a dark round stain beneath his arm, and felt what he could only describe as kinship with the man, for the briefest of moments.

He now recognized the sloppy man Delia had been speaking with. He'd seen his face almost every day for the last several months at Wagner. His face was plastered across the homepage of the school's website. It had been somewhere on the cover of the *Wagner Wailer* for four straight weeks. And then,

of course, there was the special edition that had been put out and distributed across every possible venue in town. Handouts fluttered down the street in the cold tails of winter winds, local news channels ran programs with that same slightly nervous, overly internalized, damaged, concerned and wide-eyed and frightened face—a fifty five year old child who had written treatises on the infinite. That face!

It was none other than the GAN himself, of course. And there, in the front row, Delia had somehow managed to obtain two seats, with a sort of ease that only certain sort of individual who, knowing they cannot fail in their endeavor, move towards a goal without any concern for the path that they should take, seeking only the result, which somehow leads to the most direct and graceful path possible, but one which could not have been plotted in advance.

W. T. thought it was something to behold, indeed—though of course, he was careful not to let on for even a moment the sort of things he thought about, when he thought about Delia. Those, he kept hidden, even from himself, to the best of his ability.

GAN: 1.5

He sometimes wondered how things might have been different had they not been so brazen about it and gotten caught, if he would have wound up in Wagner under very different circumstances. Perhaps they'd even have been headed towards their own divorce by then. Or he'd be one of those old men turned fathers, who have children that look more suited to call them Grandpa than Papa. Perhaps things would have been very different altogether. But that was not how it happened.

With a shared devil-may-care libertinism they fucked in the bathroom at the MoMa; with brazen indifference they showed up simultaneously at a Paris Review party and were reported to have “spent the night intertwined, and always within shouting distance of the bartender” (perhaps, the fatal mistake here was their failure to tip effectively, as the other major gossip reveal of the evening was that another well known artist/alcoholic was also outed as having fallen off the sobriety train in a messy puddle of tears—she too had been less than benevolent with her pocketbook, though it had been due to blacking out, she would claim and was not something related to her constitution, but this did not manage to keep her from becoming a victim of the press herself).

They took a weekend trip to his lake house together, both failing to make their Monday classes, and upon returning to the house that afternoon, Bernadette simply turned around and walked back out the front door of their Brooklyn brownstone, when her husband, her David, asked her if she truly thought he believed there was a seminar on 19th Century Yugoslavian Romanticism being held at Colgate? Had it been a joke at his expense or was she really that daft?

Her husband, who would have had to plug his ears and close his eyes and ride the G-train going “la-la-la-la-la” like a complete and utter lunatic to avoid noticing the glaring inconsistencies, and literal tabloid articles (that Bernadette, in her smitten obliviousness simply chose to imagine did not exist, even when presented to her by concerned peers), did what any rational person, seeking a beneficial outcome in any future divorce proceedings might do, he gathered evidence, which was plentiful and painful alike. He recorded their personal conversations, her half stuttering lies seemed so callous and cold when played in a legal setting that even her lawyer gave her a look of disappointment and disapproval.

W. T.: 1.8.1

...which is to say the fear of sentimentality in prose is paramount, of course, there is a good deal of embarrassment and shame still left to be claimed even among the greatest of writers—and, it is growing by the day, because, out of fear, no writers attempt what is vital in order to become great, that very failure...that very embarrassment—do you want to know why, in particular, it seems that latin americans and jews hold a special place in the literary world, that world of imagination, glory, romance, love, sex, drugs, the interplay of words so fraught with tension and emotion that seem themselves to be lovers (somehow untouchable by europeans, russians, and with americans one might go as far as to say why bother)? Why is it so easy to call Bolaño an artist? But with Thomas Mann one feels more inclined to call him a writer? Why does someone like Witold Gombrowicz have the ability to say in earnest what others would say and be mocked?

The answer is both simple and incredibly complex—and the intent of this lecture series is to unpack what I am about to say—so please, if you write down one note today, just one, make it this:

W. T. heard the entire auditorium hurriedly pull out their pens and pads, all having simultaneously realized that class was in session ten minutes after it had already kicked off. W. T. had no pen or pad, but he had the sort of mind that could nearly repeat every word that had so far been said by the GAN without actively trying to recall anything.

Art, like anything precious, is created under great pressure and intensity and as such it follows that the greatest Art, that which earns a capital-A, is necessarily brought into the world by men who see it as a response to the totality of death.

He then stopped talking, took a sip of water, placed two hands firmly on each side of the podium and slowly scanned the room. It was a very slow process indeed, dramatic and intense. There was nothing but silence for one minute, then two. After three minutes someone in the back of the auditorium spoke, at a normal volume, but in the extended silence it was deafeningly clear, “This is bullshit. I’m getting outta here.” W. T. did not turn his head to look - and though he couldn’t see behind himself, he got the

feeling that not many in the audience did. Four minutes had gone by, he approximated, and it started to feel painful. This was, of course, to make a point, but wasn't four minutes enough? How much longer would he stare like that? There was a second clatter of doors opening and closing, someone whispered something, laughed, and then the doors opened and shut again. Five minutes, six. It was a test. He realized that he had been intently staring up at the underside of this man's bearded jaw for an incredible amount of time now, and the only movement the man made was the very slow, continuous process of looking across each aisle and back again, very, very slowly. When the GAN's line of sight landed on W. T., he could not tell if he imagined it, but he seemed to linger there an abnormally long amount of time, extraordinarily long. It stayed there so long that he literally felt a bead of sweat blossom above his temple and then slowly gain the mass needed to break the surface tension and run down the side of his face.

He thought he heard the GAN say something to him. Like in his head. But knew he must have imagined it.

The door opened and closed another six times - and by his estimate a total of twenty two people had exited the arena.

He isn't sure when he began to think about it, time had taken on an altogether unique form while a full room of people sat in silence, and most impressive of all, the speaker, who W. T. immediately felt an extreme curiosity about, seemed the most impressive of all as he took on the weight of all eyes, second upon second, pressure building as if the room were a stone sinking to the bottom of the ocean—but at some point he thought of John Cage's *4' 33"*. The piece, which Cage *composed*, had received a similar reaction when *performed*. Cage sat at the piano for four minutes and twenty two seconds and played not a single note. Though this was not the first performance of the famous composition (Cage was more often the composer than the musician) - the first performance was by David Tudor in 1952. The piece itself is made up of three acts, each of which is composed of not a single note. Tudor, in order to accentuate the three act structure, opened and closed the lid of his piano between each act.) An element of the piece is about the method one takes in performing it, W. T. thought. Briefly, he felt the absence of John, in a profound way that he could not quite pin down, and he decided he would write him a long email that night telling him all about the GAN, and his own rendition, which had all but stopped time in the room at that moment, allowing W. T. nearly infinite time to consider what it was he felt and was experiencing, and furthermore to question the duration of time itself. It surely couldn't have been the full ten minutes it had seemed to have been. Another three times the door opened, closed, during which W. T. remembered talking with John about *4' 33"* and to what extent it was brilliant versus cheap. Whereas John had firmly believed in Cage's brilliance, and the brilliance of *4' 33"* W. T. had been quick to write it off as a gimmick. But John's response had given him much to think about:

You want your art to be worked for, John had said. You think it needs to be earned.

Is that so wrong? came W. T.'s reply. And until now he hadn't given it much thought, but suddenly he was certain it had been wrong. Something had been revealed to him and he was not yet clear on what it was, or why it had been given to him, but he realized suddenly that he'd been outside of his own body, for how long he didn't know, looking at himself looking at nothing. It was unprecedented, and were he not so committed to rational pragmatism [\[61\]](#), he would have called his experience a hallucination, or a figment of his imagination, rather than what he did call it in the note he wrote to his friend that evening, he said he'd moved to another plane of existence, and meant it quite literally. He understood something now that he hadn't before! It was revelatory!

W. T.: 1.8.2

When the GAN finally broke the silence he spoke very, very quietly. His surprisingly high-pitched voice whistled across the amphitheater—it was only because things had been so silent for so long that he could be heard by all. “Ten minutes,” he said, then opened the bottle of water that sat beside the microphone, and the crackling snap of the tendons that kept the lid sealed until twisted open could be heard throughout the room. Even louder than his voice was the sound of his opening a 12 oz. bottle of Poland Springs water. He took a slow, intentional sip, recapped the bottle, set it back where it had come from.

W. T., like the rest of the audience that remained, took the opportunity to look at the time. Surely he meant that there were ten minutes left in class. It had been at least a half an hour, he was certain. But looking down at his cell phone he confirmed the inaccuracy of his mental calculation. Only ten minutes had passed. It was unbelievable.

There were hushed whispers throughout the amphitheater that were distinct and articulated from one another with odd clarity, some resonance of the “Ten Minute Drill” (which is what the GAN would later call it), the whispers sounded crisper, not louder - for a few seconds W. T. realized he could discern the unique conversations taking place independently, not unlike the moment one puts on a pair of glasses for the first time and is dumbfounded to find that they can make out the individual leaves of a tree. It was not the simple hum of background noise—each voice had its own tone, cadence and rhythm that could be distinguished by simply focusing in on it.

But this lasted only a few brief seconds before the noise congealed into a single wall of sound again.

“Now take out a sheet of paper,” the GAN finally spoke again. “Write the opening paragraph of a novel that has not been written yet. You have ten minutes.” A wave of chatter ran through the audience.

Students exchanged confused glances at one another. There was some thrill in the air too - something exciting had occurred in the amphitheater and the whole group of them were collectively coming to terms with it. The GAN took another sip of water, looked out at the audience, and told them to begin.

Though it was not the case for the GAN, for Bernadette their exposure had severed something integral to the affair and it could not be repaired. In her defense, it is possible she did not know how she felt, herself - no one seems to know themselves it matters like these. We are forgetful creatures, and we can no more remember how we felt yesterday, what we *really* did feel at a given moment [*rather than what we recall when we think of what we had been thinking*], than we can know what our dreams will bring come nightfall.

No matter how much she swore that it was not the case (*on the far end of the line: the GAN blubbing like a heart broken teenager*) there were no words that could revive the feverish, sotto voce, late night calls, which had stopped altogether since the night of the incident. Though it is true, some part of the disaffection was brought about because the nature of their relationship heightened the intensity of their interactions, made everything that much sexier because it was so naughty and made them feel bad inside. There was that sort of masochism, she could now call at any time of the day without worry, without guilt, and so they were no longer in that forbidden space together - and because she was able to call, she realized that she really had no reason to call. But it was more than that too. She started to realize that without that to talk about, without the need to build stories and alibis, with a sort of normalcy about the whole thing, that she didn't much care for talking to him in the first place.

All he talked about was art. If it wasn't literature, it was film ("Kurosawa on the Mind", Grand Strand Quarterly #39); if not film then it was philosophy ("Schopenhauer's Optimism" Black Pond Review, Sept. '05); if it was not philosophy, it was the paintings of late Manet, the music of Glenn Gould (and his madness too—one could not speak of Glenn Gould without mentioning his madness); he talked about Buddhism and Haiku and the tradition of the Noh performances. He knew nothing about dance, but he still spoke about it, only with more curiosity than authority. He talked about a man he knew who lost his hearing and wrote poetry only in sign language—"One of the most beautiful poems ever created," he said, "was a dirty limerick he made up one night while drinking at a strip club on the fringes of Las Vegas. I know. I was there."

There was no end to the supply of stories, which is a sure sign of one's tendency to exaggerate—but with the GAN people often thought he was exaggerating, and he held firmly to the position that he only lied when he was writing, so when someone questioned the validity of one of his stories he would go to great lengths to prove that they were true.

Bernadette had nearly instigated a road trip to Las Vegas by asking him to name the deaf poet. Though in the end she had classes to teach, and a David to consider, and it was only after the GAN had packed his suitcases and created a phony pamphlet for a seminar on Derrida at UNLV that she realized just how serious she had been. Ultimately she'd had to tell him she believed him—and she had to make it sound genuine. She could not believe the lengths to which he would go.

At first it is gorgeous (if not sublime) to see someone obsessed like that - but after some time it becomes evident that there is a reason we say someone is *consumed by their work* as though it were some type of ancient and hungry beast. There are few things to which we attribute the same supremacy as we give to Art with regard to the artist.

For the GAN writing was not an outlet, nor was it a tool that he used to communicate ideas.

Writing was a fundamental component of his makeup, a necessity, like pissing or shitting. The way a mockingbird recites a song, the way generations of monarchs march back and forth across the continent.

To him the whole world was a book to be written—and living beside him one began to get the feeling of becoming a character. She couldn't describe it any more eloquently than that—when they'd first started seeing each other she'd told him, "It's like you are writing...me."

She hadn't known precisely what she'd meant when she first said it, but she *did know* there was no other way to say it. It had been right after they'd had sex in his office, late one night, and the statement had seemed like an expression of love at that time.

Now she thought she knew what she'd meant, and it was apparent that the sentiment was actually not a pleasant one. Whether the meaning had changed while she hadn't been looking, or whether she'd misinterpreted the meaning when she first said it, and only now was understanding what it was she had been trying to say—she did not know. It surpassed objectification, originating from a space that was altogether different. The feeling, she thought, was better described as fictionalization. He turned her into something less real, composed more of his creation, *his vision*, than of her own free will. Of course, she knew the point would be lost on him, how many hours he'd spent explaining to packed halls about the artificiality of free will, the tricks we play on ourselves—not that she'd told him as much.

What had she expected when she jumped into bed with a man who'd generated a literary movement by the time he turned thirty?

She was not daft enough to think he would change for her—and it was precisely because of that, her expectation to be forgotten, that she was all the more confused when, after things had all but completely disintegrated, he *did* call. He said he *would make a change*, *if only she would tell him what to do*. *If only there was some set of rules to follow.*

Of life's great mysteries, parenthood is far and away the most baffling. By all accounts Percival and Deborah Roapes had provided a kind and nurturing environment for all three of their children. Despite coming from generational wealth Percival had promoted humility and gratitude, raising his two boys Henry and James with compassionate discipline—firm but never violent—he almost never lost his temper.

He had his shortcomings, of course—an inherited taste from anything dark and 80 proof or greater. He liked anything that seemed like it would turn a quick profit, and by nature this found him frequently in the company of unsavory characters. On a few occasions his dealings with certain characters put him in a difficult spot, but almost never anything he couldn't buy or negotiate his way out of—people had a way of forgetting things when their minds became focused on how they might spend a bit of extra pocket change.

Percival was not the only member of the Five families who had learned this insight into the human condition. As a group, in fact, the Five had maintained a longstanding agreement with the local authorities that allowed them a certain amount of freedom, one might even say, protection. There was, for example, a small but proper racetrack that had been built just after the first World War. It was a dog track, not a horse track, which was a venture that required less overhead, provided better returns, and on XX Island required oversight and regulation from one group and group only, The Five. The mysterious holding company that ran the greyhound track, the *Five Star Group* (on paper), was the largest independent financial contributor to both the police and fire department respectively on an annual basis - a trend that would continue to this very day.

This may provide some insight into why a certain son of his thought it would be safe to default on a sizable amount of gambling debt accrued at the tracks, where, as was mentioned, the law was generally administered by the people. Still, a decision that to Percival made no sense no matter how you cut it, but made even less sense when compounded by his decision to look for help amongst the ranks of the XXPD, where he had made quite a scene only a day or so prior, demanding to speak with the Captain while in a state of devastating inebriation, holding the keys to the car he'd driven to get there in one hand, and a cup of spiked waffle house coffee in the other. Stumbling through the lobby in a way that would have landed anyone else in the drunk tank immediately—but for the thirty- two year old Henry, had earned a call to his father as if he'd taken place in some sort of high school debauchery gone wrong. *Oh Henry* , he thought, *where did I go so wrong?*

Percival stood on his back deck, looking out towards the water, unable to discern how high the creek had risen yet. It was four thirty in the morning, he hadn't slept a bit, and even the rooster had not yet started to crow—it would still be some time before there was even faint light out, another hour at least, but that rooster could smell the light or something because no matter the day you could time him, almost down to the second,. Then he would be able to see what damage the storm had done. He thought briefly about the storm and its thick blustering winds, which momentarily kept his mind off Henry, but just as quickly made him think of just how reckless he'd been all over again. Driving in *that storm* ? It would have been ill-advised had his BAC been nothing but goose eggs. But Henry was as logical as one of those M. C. Escher pieces, with stairs that somehow are ascending and descending at the same time, doors that lead into places that did not exist; that was his Henry, an Escher.

What did that make James? He wasn't sure.

He stood there in the dark, his bare feet cold against the wet two by sixes that he and James had used to build the deck - and went on questioning his entire philosophy of parenting, trying to work out a solution, to solve yet another problem that his son, his Henry , had brought him about twenty four hours prior.

He thought, too, of his grandson. John, all of four years old - how would he handle it if Percival wasn't able to get things sorted with the Chief and the Oakstone boys down at the track? It was as though his two sons had gotten things all mixed up at birth. James should have been the one with the wife and the family, he should have been the one with the responsibilities in a manner of speaking. Henry had been born with a touch of pirate blood in him—that was all there was to it—and pirate blood isn't the sort of thing you can discipline out of a Roapes boy. That was a fact that had been proven time and again when you looked back at the family history. In this case Henry had come into the world already thirsty for those things that make a pirate's eyes get wide—James, who followed close behind, had been born his complete opposite. A paragon of rationality and cautious to a fault.

Why, then, had Henry found himself a Bernadette while James lived in a perpetual state of heartbreak? Henry took for granted all of the things he'd acquired. James worked to acquire all the things that Henry took for granted and was met time and again by the cruel hand of fate. What was a father supposed to do?

It sure was a mystery, Percival thought, as somewhere in the distance the cock began to crow. Maybe parenting didn't have a thing to do with it, really. That was the best answer he could come to about the whole situation— maybe he'd never had a say in it one way or another. He hoped it was the case, for John's sake at least. Even the lord couldn't predict what the world had in store for that child.

Perhaps it was fitting that he was the last of the Roapes.

If you ask me W. T. had it better than I did in the dad department. Sometimes having no dad at all is better than the alternative. I think some dads must know that, and when they high tail it outta there it's not all selfish, part of it is because they came to the realization that at least with no father you give a kid a chance to dream about something—whereas with a father like mine, too scared to leave the island, but too narcissistic to actually love anyone—you can't even dream about a world in which your father is off living the life of a playboy, or vagabond, or rolling stone. You know just what he is—it's sitting right there in the lazy chair, drinking a white russian and complaining about the temperature in the house.

Everyone has something to complain about though. I guess that much is true.

By the time we were off to Hobson's Choice that day W. T. had already had more to drink than I could put down on a good night out—but he seemed no worse for the wear, perhaps a bit more chatty than he had been that morning, which I was actually glad to see. He was miserable to be around when he was miserable—the impact of high expectations—you reach a point at which you're a let down if you don't lift everyone else up. It's not a burden you hear many folks complaining about, but it's a burden nonetheless, and W. T. was more aware than most, of his influence that is.

[UF]

That night he couldn't sleep. He could think of nothing apart from the lecture which had been largely met with indifference or confusion amongst the students; annoyance, disdain, jealousy or envy amongst the faculty. Mostly annoyance, he believed. The ten minutes of silence had been too much for them to bear (both the students and the faculty, for different reasons), and the fact that it wasn't followed by some sort of grand gesture, not neatly wrapped up with a summary and gratifying conclusion had apparently been a let down, according to the digital message boards and social media venues he paid close attention to when no one was looking. It was only a matter of time before one of his numerous fake digital identities got outed, he thought. *That will be a PR nightmare*, he thought. *But that's my agent's job*. And it almost made him laugh to imagine the unmasking of 'Pepito Crescencio'; the cries from the New York literati of *Fraudulence!*—maybe even a piece in *Slate* or *Wired*—any one of the new generation of anti-intellectual thinkpiece magazines that just exude the existential dread that permeates modern technology. Editors who gauge the potential of a story by its *accessibility*. More American than hot dogs and pick-up trucks—technology—*they put the fluoride in the water*. Apolitical, in theory, because *What is more democratic than tech?* but secretly inclined to believe that

everyone is a libertarian who doesn't know it yet. Although, of course, they haven't done the reading. Though, the truth was, ninety five percent of the time there was nothing fraudulent about it. Only occasionally did he write about his own work - *and he was tough on himself too*, he thought. It was more of a pen name than anything else. But still thinking of his agent's distraught phone call made him bubble up with a pleasant humorous feeling.

Towards the end of the lecture W. T. had taken a moment to look around at the amphitheater which had been well beyond capacity when Delia and he had arrived and now appeared to be approximately half-empty. The GAN.

The GAN had finished up his first lecture by making a comparison between the way a photographer, for example, sees something *like the interplay of light filtered through a thin curtain and cannot help but think about the implications that the light (and its interaction with the fabric) has on the aesthetic sense conveyed to the observer, whereas the writer, seeing this same interplay of light and fabric, removes themselves by a dimension to put it crudely, and as such must see the light as if he or she were a multiplicity of photographers all at once, having an argument about the light and the fabric* — which is to say a writer of some genius must expect of themselves the impossible; and despite being fated to fail MUST convince themselves again and again and again to understand the interplay of light filtered through a thin curtain as seen by every photographer in the possible and impossible world alike. The writer-genius, when operating at peak performance, must write with the confidence of the Gods. Blasphemy be damned.

Narcissist! someone yelled.

That doesn't even scratch the surface, said the GAN, and at least that got a small laugh from the remaining crowd, though a nervous and slightly uptight laugh all the same.

This was not the answer they had been looking for - at least not the amateur critics who went home that night and wrote their diatribes on Reddit, some made video responses on Youtube, some took the night to write something on Microsoft Word even, waiting until the morning to post it on their blog, ensuring it was thoroughly spell checked, and thinking themselves superior to the redditors, who write in a language of their own and paid no heed to grammar or spelling for the most part.

It didn't take more than a cursory scan to get the gist of the feedback. Over and over again they rambled on about the narcissism of the whole endeavor. Before his first lecture there had been some feedback in that vein—it was, the GAN reminded himself, the same criticism that Barthes faced—and at least partially this was the very reason he had decided to talk about narcissism so directly in his first lecture. Ever since things with Bernadette had soured, since the irreconcilable had been spoken (which, the GAN, in his first published novel had written about in what remained one of his favorite pages he'd ever written— “Not until the irreconcilable occurred, she thought, would things be done. And so she began the thoroughly unenjoyable process of fellating his brother, knowing he was already in the

building, headed up. And though it was not how she'd anticipated it working out, it might have made the irreconcilable that much more so when forty five seconds later he walked in to find her cursing in a rapid Italian, wiping semen from her eye, while his brother sat in the lazy boy, unsure who he should focus on apologizing to first.”)

One particularly resentful photographer, seemed to have read the entire lecture as a diminutization of her craft and took the time to digitally manipulate photos from inside the amphitheater to make the GAN's head appear as though it were an over inflated balloon, ready to pop at any moment. Another master of photoshop then took the liberty of making it appear as if the head had popped and added in bits of viscera strewn about the amphitheater. The first three rows blanketed in the explosive brain matter. It was disturbingly realistic and quickly taken down but not before W. T. saw it and he couldn't get the image out of his head for the rest of the night.

W. T. was not active on any of those platforms, but it was quite literally impossible to live without knowing about them—and they entered all other forms of discourse without being invited, since they had essentially overtaken actual journalism as the primary form of daily news intake. The newspapers cited Tweets. Everything was in the process of being forced into bite-sized chunks. Life had become a series of clickbait stories, images, images, images—misleading headlines, more images—violence without context, everything without context. It was easy to understand how your average American citizen could turn on the news and see everything going on as essentially part of the same thing. What difference did it make if there was a protest in Argentina or Venezuela? Even among the educated, among the students at Wagner, there was nothing but surface level comprehension of even the most fundamental news stories. But could you blame them? Most of them, those who were around his age, had been teens in 2001—not just teens, but sheltered, American teens who understood things like ghettos as places you saw off the side of the highway but never stopped. Most of them still were unaware of the biases inherent in their high school text books which were generally written in the mid to early 90s—strikingly, these textbooks told stories of the Middle East that seemed to be largely the same stories they heard on the news on a daily basis. The Middle East might as well have been a single country to them—read the text books or not, it didn't matter—they were filled with the same stories, a list of countries and a paragraph or two detailing the Cold War propaganda that had been handed down to the Reagan administration (the same administration that actively proposed a methodology called KISS, “Keep it Simple, Stupid”). Then, lo and behold, the attacks of September 11th occurred.

Despicable tragedies lead by terrorists, undoubtedly—but no one, hardly any of W. T.'s generation could formulate an educated position on the groups involved let alone the geography of the area. The Taliban was a term learned overnight, and it didn't take much convincing for them to turn into enemy number one. But my hypothesis is that if they'd so desired, the news media could have said they were members of some Islam sect out of Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and it wouldn't have made a lick of difference. The government was never going to admit its real reasons for essentially re-entering the war that never ends —this sort of vague, gung-ho jingoism was perfect. And the formula for getting

Americans on board fully indoctrinated despite knowing almost nothing: Make it far away, and create an enemy who is vaguely foreign, other.

There were ads for new applications that helped you learn the classics in summary.

W. T. got his fill of it through Delia, of course. They'd only just made it out of the auditorium, Celine lit two cigarettes at once and handed one to W. T. Then she immediately turned to her phone, out of habit more than anything it seemed. He was no longer the curmudgeon he'd been about social media—no one ever likes change, he reminded himself, that's the constant—though he couldn't help but feel there was something more to this dissociative response.

“Well?” he asked.

She did not look up from her phone and said, “One moment.” He saw that she was typing furiously, completely zoned out.

He took a drag on the cigarette and coughed emphatically. “When did you start smoking menthols?” he asked, but she just put a finger in the air, still typing with the other, and didn't respond. For a moment he had the feeling that she was going to walk right off - like, she was done with him and she was going to finish typing whatever it was she was typing, something incredibly long-winded apparently, and then she'd turn and begin to walk away and when he followed after she'd say something cruel like, *What do you think you're doing?* even though she'd never done anything mean or cruel like that to him for as long as he'd known her. Just the thought of it mortified him. “When you have to type so many words doesn't it make more sense to just call?” he finally asked after three more pulls on his cigarette. When she didn't respond he threw the half-smoked butt on the ground and stomped it out. “These things taste like shit. And they've got fiberglass in them, you know? Cuts your throat open so the nicotine gets in quicker or something.”

Finally she pressed a button and looked up from her phone. She wore the suppressed smile of someone passing on a long anticipated gift of great value—it reminded him of the way John's Pappy had smiled as he handed John his pocket watch. Or maybe it was the other smile, he thought, the smile of the recipient, in which a restrained sort of gratitude was displayed, equally as intent on showing respect or thanks they were in displaying their own happiness at receiving something of such rare value.

Which was it? Was Delia giving him something?

“Well, do you want to meet him?”

INTERLUDE 3

No Horizon

Part I

One

McCallan Road runs unevenly across Renfield Island. On the Panzee River side, the island is accessed via the newly renovated Harris-Parson Bridge - a long and sinuous crossing that spans approximately a half a mile of tidal marshland before disappearing into a thick wall of live oaks, elms, pines, and low-lying bushes of all varieties, penetrating the border of the island. McCallan is the first road on the left.

It sneaks up on the unsuspecting navigator. The sign is hidden behind a massive live oak that is rumored to be over four hundred years old. The oak was here before we (Americans) were here and is treated commensurately with admiration and respect - despite the inconvenient location and the history of motor vehicle accidents. Rightfully, the island has agreed that the tree should not be removed or even thoroughly trimmed - in a speech during a recent town hall meeting the Island Arboreal Society stated that “it has more right to this land than we do.” This speech was made in response to a new

permit request that was almost unanimously voted down. Not all of the old giants have had the same fate though - many of them were felled without resistance before the damage to the land became visible.

The thick woods get thicker after taking the left on McCallan. More live oaks line the road, spanish moss dripping from their limbs, the brush grows thicker at the base of the trees. On the sunniest days light comes through the canopy in slats that flicker across the dashboard and on more than one occasion this flickering has been known to cause driver disorientation and fatalities. Every so often, when taking a sharp turn, an observant driver will notice a wreath nailed to a tree, dead flowers scattered at its base, a set of initials and a date. Some of them will make the sign of the cross, some of them will look away, some won't think of it at all.

As the crow flies the road covers approximately six miles of island - but in order to navigate the variety of wetlands across the terrain the road winds and cuts back and curves such that if it were stretched out into a straight line it would reach almost six additional miles out into the Atlantic from Grayson's Marina, where McCallan Road concludes in a pebbled drive that runs directly into the boat landing where shrimp trawlers and swordfish boats and all varieties of sea vessels unload their haul, weigh out, pack and distribute their catch. Grayson's Marina is an old place and if you aren't a fisherman or a fish buyer you just don't go there.

McCallan was here before the rest of the roads it now crosses - bigger, newer roads built to accommodate the massive increases in population that the island has seen since the early 21st century.

And when driving down one of those four lane highways one would almost certainly make no specific note of the McCallan stoplight - its appearance is no different from any of the other roads leading into hastily built neighborhoods or shopping centers or local parks - but it is, in fact, different. It is the oldest road on this island, and for those of us who were here before the traffic, it is a road with a soul - and depending on your level of superstition, it is a road that contains many souls.

My name is William Theodore Tipnam the Third and my family has lived on this island for as long as this island has been lived on by people with names like William. We once were a large bunch - back when the McCallan Oak stood smaller - back when entire black families were kept as slaves and women weren't allowed to vote and the white man was busy slaughtering any vestige of life that did not consent to total submission, and sometimes those who did. But those days were a long time ago now - our numbers have dwindled - and with regard to the depravity of the white supremacy that reigned on high even here on this island, it has for the most part scurried into the corners of the place, hidden itself in the cracks in the roads, which is not to say that it has gone away, mind you. There are many examples of the ways in which we are a far more humane society now than in our past (our town councilor, as a matter of fact, is a black woman), but there are many more ways in which this sort of thing is easily identified as a con, a sham, a cover-up. It took me reading a lot of books that they don't prescribe as a part of any school curriculum around here to learn some of these things. I'm an

uncommonly educated member of the Tipnam family and I can say with some degree of certainty that my relations are at least mildly resentful about this fact.

I didn't go to school past the seventh grade for reasons that I will come to explain. Because of this, almost every tidbit of information I've learned that wasn't about how to fish or hunt or drive a boat or whittle, I mean most everything I know that isn't what you'd call "practical" knowledge, every bit of that, I learned from books I got from my friend Benny, whose father ran a bookstore when we were younger and who took over that same bookstore when his father passed away of a heart attack at the age of 54. That was when we were in our twenties.

Why I mention all this is that I may have a peculiar way of telling stories, and my vocabulary may be anachronistic to some readers, but I assure you I am a member of the twenty-first century and I own a cellphone that can identify a bird by listening to it's song to prove it. But because I was in and out of school so fast, and because I learned all of what I know from books that were written before my time or by authors with antiquated vocabularies, I've been told I have a tendency to talk and write like I, myself, was written up before my time and some people seem to think it's a farce, which it's not. I suppose you might say I don't really know how to speak modern American English - but my point seems to be received and understood all the same no matter who it is that's listening .

Some of my family, on the other hand, can't be understood outside of this state. They speak just fine with one another and use modern terminology and the likes (albeit, without the same linguistic flair as yours truly), but their accents are more like dialects and when they travel to the city for medical procedures or legal trials they always return (given that they return) laughing about how nobody could understand a lick of what they were saying no matter how slowly they said it. They seem to like it, the isolation and all that comes with being a Tipnam - but I never could stand it and when I became old enough I made it a goal to never find myself in a position where I couldn't speak my mind in an educated fashion to educated people and be understood properly and well. Still, sometimes I get laughed at for talking the way I do but it's not the same way they get laughed at and that's the difference.

I suppose you have to figure that a family that settles on an island and doesn't pick up and move for a couple of centuries must have something in their blood that keeps them from wanting to acclimatize or integrate themselves with people who aren't of their same nature. They are isolationists in the strictest human sense of that word, and in many ways I don't fault them for it, though I can't deny I've spent nights wishing I was born to a mortgage broker from Atlanta or a professor at some Ivy League institution.

My family lives off McCallan Road and this is the reason why I decided to give it such a wind up at the beginning of the story - because it's the road that I've traveled more than any other in my life and

because it's a road I have no intention of running away from despite my eccentricities and desire to present myself as a more cultured man.

In fact, in truth, I have a psychiatric issue I should mention at this juncture. It is a phobia, of sorts, that would be classified as *agoraphobia* in a textbook but I've never been certain the causes related to such a term were entirely accurate in my case (though this is not to say the symptoms aren't incredibly similar). I cannot leave the island. This is since my fourteenth birthday, which in and of itself was an event that changed several things in my life, but my newfound phobia was the most impactful of them all.

If I leave the island, or should I say, on the four occasions I have attempted to leave the island since the day I turned fourteen, I've been beset with a coughing attack and breathing fit that has forced me (and whoever had accompanied me on my venture - Benny, mostly) to turn back and cross the Harris-Parson bridge to the safety of the island, where only then I could catch my breath and slow my heart rate. This, too, has contributed to my "eccentric nature" - and is one of the largest obstacles in my pursuit of worldliness and culture.

I don't wish to overstate the simplicity of the island, however. The island has entered the modern age with a fervor - there are chain coffee shops and restaurants and grocery stores with self-checkout aisles. We have had high-speed internet for as long as the rest of the country. We have a hotel for tourists and a motel for the destitute. We have new neighborhoods that pop up on the landscape like moles on a grandmother's back - half-cancerous - with cleverly engineered drainage systems and playgrounds that meet all sorts of safety regulations. We have an elementary school and a middle school - but the high school is located off the island. We have three gas stations (one appears to be abandoned but sees consistent traffic for an unknown reason). We have a fire department and a police station where a few isolated police cars seem to never leave the parking lot unless there is an active emergency. We have electric cars and recently there has been discussion of putting in a high-tech bowling alley (though I don't know the specifics on what it is that makes a bowling alley "high-tech"). We have everything a person needs to live, even this day in age, except perhaps the jobs, and there are plenty of people here who live without those as well.

When we were a larger family, long before my mother and father spent the night together for the first time, the Tipnam family owned almost one hundred acres of the island. Their land ran up against the shoreline stopping just shy of the Grayson Marina. Only sixty percent of what we owned was not underwater most days of the year and on the dry parts we built our homes - a few of which (mine included) we continue to own and live in to this day. One of my ancestors (it is debated as to which) built a large plantation style home - which was the pride of our family until it was taken by the bank (along with a good percentage of our acreage) in the mid-thirties as a result of the great depression.

The history as I tell it is only as it's been told to me and it's difficult to say for certain as to what is true and what is only part-true and in all of my looking I've found that records around this sort of thing are

hard to find. I have to wager this is not by sheer accident. It seems that important documentation around things of value often disappear when the timing is right for one side or the other.

All of this is of no matter to my story but provides some backdrop, some semblance of a setting for the rest of what I have to tell, and perhaps it informs some of the decisions that people around here, who are from here, tend to make when faced with new things and changing ways. Nobody likes it when the bank takes your place. Not even your enemies.

The Tipnam family is at present reduced in number to eight. Of the eight only three live on the island. Of the three only one is a male - that's me - and my prospects for reproduction aren't all that promising the more I've analyzed them. My very first girlfriend, Genivieve, who I met and asked to be my girlfriend in the third grade, turned out to be autistic (although back when I was a child they called just about any mental deficiency "retarded"). Now, it just so happens I may be autistic myself per the doctor's evaluation and some things I've noticed about myself and read about on the internet as well. But at the time I didn't know as much and when I found out my girlfriend was autistic I dropped her quicker than a hot cast iron. It wasn't that I was ashamed, but my mother and father certainly were, and they told me she wasn't welcome at the house or on our property anymore which made it particularly difficult to see her anyways. Even then I was pretty apt at reading between the lines, as they say, and I got the point of what they were trying to say without forcing them to utter it out loud. So I quit that relationship very fast and assumed I wouldn't have much trouble finding another one that would suit me just fine if not better but that was not the case.

To this day I feel horrible about the way I treated Genevieve. We were young then, though, and I don't think that youth can be blamed for its inherited ignorance - only for what it does when it comes of age and understands the truth behind what was and was not right, and even then it can be tough to say with some people. For my part I try to balance my own shame with my own forgiveness and in the end I come to the conclusion that for the most part, to the best of my ability, I've done the right thing when I knew what the right thing was to do. It's only those other circumstances, when I wasn't sure of what was moral or just, that make it hard to fall asleep from time to time - and I will tell you about a few of those cases in these pages.

I feel horrible about a lot of things that I know, in my heart, have no good reason for the heaviness with which I bear them.

My mother's death for one - and then my father's after that.

In my mother's case it was that I couldn't protect her from my father. And in my father's case it was that I couldn't bring myself to forgive him. One died of alcohol and pills, the other died of pills and alcohol. Luckily I've never been one for getting too intoxicated - it makes me anxious - so I think I escaped those vices by virtue of my nervous psyche and that's why I believe sometimes good things come from bad circumstances.

I'll tell more of my mother and father later, when it's pertinent to the story, but they left me earlier than most children get left on their own - and most of my story that's worth telling takes place after they were long gone and I was just coming to adulthood. What is important from before that time I will tell, but only when it serves the larger story, and only if I can say with some degree of certainty that I remember it correctly. I cannot stand telling lies, even by accident, because I think we have a responsibility to consider the truthfulness of our words diligently, examining them for potential fallacy, before speaking - particularly, I might add, during these times of social media tyranny (I abhor and will not participate in any form of personal social media - which is all I will say on that).

As I've mentioned, there are three Tipnams still living on the island, two of us still living in our original birth homes, respectively. The other two are my Aunt Harriet and my grandmother. I am very fond of both of them even though I remain the black sheep in a family of three. Our houses are spread across the property at distances significant enough that we cannot see one another's houses from any vantage point within our own houses. Respectively, that is.

To this day we maintain an unbreakable ritual of Sunday dinner at my grandmother's house.

Until seven years ago she was the only family member who continued to actively attend church on Sundays. When she returned from church she would start cooking and she would not stop for the entire evening it sometimes seemed. She is an excellent cook - "never measures a thing 'less she's bakin'." - which she likes to say any time anyone asks her if she can tell them a particular recipe for a dish she'd created. Which was something my mother used to do quite frequently, never realizing the answer would remain the same, and later, always attempting to associate actual measurements with words my grandmother would use when describing her recipes (*a dash, a pinch, etc.*) but never realizing that those words were not even associated with specific sizes in my grandmother's own head. They were just the words she used when she did not have a numeric value to place against the amount of a particular ingredient a recipe might require. In other words *a dash* could mean a teaspoon or a tablespoon or even somewhere in between depending on the recipe and how she'd chosen to cook it on that particular occasion.

Or maybe my mother was aware of all this - she was a bright lady despite her rural inclinations - and she was merely trying to make conversation with a woman who hadn't been particularly fond of her from the day they'd first met. The mothers that I've known rarely get along swimmingly with the wives of their first born sons - but perhaps I am reading a bit too far into that.

To clarify, of the three Tipnams living off McCallan Road, only my aunt and I are Tipnam by blood.

My grandmother, of course, is married into the Tipnam name. She married my grandfather when they were both sixteen and theirs is a love story of the sort you know cannot be true when you hear it if only because nothing ever goes wrong throughout the entire story and they lived about as happily as a married couple ever could. My grandmother inherited her house from my grandfather when he passed

away. My aunt inherited her house from her own father, as did I from mine. Perhaps it should be noted that Tipnams, except on rare occasions, gave birth exclusively to male progeny. Which was, early on, what kept us as such a large, robust family. However the curse of having primarily males as children was that violence on occasion welled up within our family and throughout our history there are at least two occasions upon which feuding between male Tipnams resulted in the loss of life.

It is a strange thing, I often think, the way genealogy traces - what I mean is that I, by virtue of being downstream, somehow am fully a part of my grandmother but she will only ever get to be a *part* of me.

To put it even more simply - when you give birth to a child you must always share them with the other half of that equation, but the child (whether or not there are siblings) by nature of being a vessel in which two components were combined, is somehow completely both mother and father simultaneously.

I don't know if i've stated this accurately and shall revisit my thoughts here after doing some further investigation into the nature of DNA and genetics and things of the sort. But when I get to thinking of my mother and father and the lines that run through this family, this land, down that road and across this island, I find myself often wondering what it means about who I am and where I will end up.

For now this is enough information about my heritage and my family - these are things that are always more interesting to the teller than the listener in my experience and I hope I have not already started telling my story in such a way that I have alienated the reader with unnecessary detail and exposition. I will now return to a bit of the *story* proper - which has often to do with Benny and requires that I explain a bit about him in order to tell it properly. With that I will conclude the first chapter.

Two

Benny is a Jew - which once would have been considered very uncommon on this particular island - for example when his grandfather lived here. As children, his grandfather often told us he and his wife were the only Jews on the island up until 1961, which was when Benny's mother was born. Benny's mother married a protestant and they were not very strict Jews as far as I could ever tell - but he did get to celebrate both Haunnakah and Christmas which always made me a bit jealous. In the Hebrew tradition the religion of the child is determined maternally - as such Benny was born Jewish with a Protestant father - though in the end these things all meant more to them politically than they ever did spiritually as far as I could ever tell.

In the last half-century or so the island has become more ethnically diverse. Prior to that the island was composed almost exclusively of black americans (descendents of the slave trade) and anglo americans. Even Catholics at this time were a rarity, though not completely absent. Slowly, though, as America is wont to do, we have had new ingredients added to our composition - and undoubtedly this has given the

island a more complex and vibrant flavor. My grandmother used to say, *No good stew is made of water and potatoes alone* .

As mentioned previously, Benny's father owned a bookstore in town, which was approximately seven miles north of the island. It was called Steinman's Books, which I found odd given that their last name was O'Rourke, not Steinman, but I was later informed that there was an investor in the bookstore named Steinman who was from the northeast and with whom Benny's mother had family ties - and not much more needed to be explained beyond that.

As a child I had no understanding that literature could be "dangerous" - and I did not understand that the Steinman bookstore, among the conservative crowd in town (which was the larger demographic by multiple factors), was looked at as a quasi-extremist place of commerce, that being despite the fact that the O'Rourke's themselves were quite conservative politically and averse to making a commotion in any circumstances. Luckily for me, my family was not the type that was aware of the political radicalism of a bookstore that carried *Das Kapital* in a town such as ours. In truth, my family was highly sympathetic to the O'Rourkes, if only because they fervently detested the 'Axis of Evil' and were very much aware of the terrible persecution the Jews suffered under the Third Reich.

It is perhaps not surprising that had Benny been black the whole story would be a different one, because the persecution of blacks was done by Americans and as such was not the type of thing that one even allowed one's self to question - at least not on this island, in my family. On the few occasions I, as a child, addressed the topics of race and discrimination around family members, I would immediately be shushed and told to go check on the chickens or goats or go fishing or whatever it was that would get me away from distracting the fertile conversation about effective fermentation techniques for creating moonshine or how so-and-so's boat had broken down once again. Most of my family in those times worked on boats, with boats or around boats. Grayson's Marina was our primary employer - beyond that there were great deals of inherited wealth that we'd, as of then, failed to deplete entirely. Apart from losing the Great House we still maintained most of our land well into my childhood.

Benny was a crack shot and that is likely what my family liked most of all about him. As children we would shoot skeet at every family gathering, tucking our twenty gauge toys up by our ear and following the clay pigeon with unmatched intensity. The older family members would drink and laugh and when they missed it would not bother them nearly as much as it bothered Benny or myself. Though, while I cared equally as much as Benny I simply did not have the natural hand eye coordination that he did, sheer luck of the draw I suppose, and so Benny would often be the star of the show late at night when the whole family was long past drunk and he would get on a streak of smashed plates that would draw the attention of everyone once the count was high enough - and even I would watch, jealous, I suppose. Once he started on his streak we both knew we'd be allowed to stay out with the adults for as long as we wanted so long as we returned to the platform to shoot every so often. Benny learned to drink early

at those family events and it was more than once that his family threatened he would not be allowed back upon smelling his breath after arriving home on his bicycle.

They never followed through on that threat and I can't say I know for certain why.

Even when I was young and did not have the same fears about leaving the island I did not find myself wanting to venture across the water often. Unless I was compelled by forces beyond my control - for a family event or doctor visit - I didn't often find myself wishing to go much further than the pond or the arcade (there was one on the island when I was young) or occasionally the marina where I would watch from afar as the boats came in and depraved looking fishermen came off, some of them family members, reeking of fish and salt and blood and sweat dried upon sweat. Mostly bearded, thin men with tattoos and absent teeth and cigarettes that seemed to always be in need of lighting. They wore tattered clothes to a man - t-shirts half ripped and painted with the arterial spray of some recently decapitated seabeast. They had hard, dry hands - I remember one of them grabbing me by the arm once who had seen me watching and come to talk to me, I suppose, except when he got close enough to me he looked down by my feet and noticed what I hadn't, a large cottonmouth in the taller grass beside the shed and he grabbed me by the arm and I felt as though his hands could have cut through my skin if he'd so desired, but his only goal was to yank me away to safety before the cottonmouth got too close. I told him afterwards that I was very appreciative for his concern and he warned me to always watch where I'm setting my feet because "beasts in the grass can be some of the worst kinds of beasts". I assured him of course that I would. But it wasn't soon after that when I realized he was still a bit depraved from having been at sea because he continued to talk about snakes in the grass as though he was more or less talking to himself and I decided to head home out of concern for my own safety. I felt a bit bad walking away from him so hastily. All in all he did me a favor and I was grateful to him for that.

Later in my life I would learn much more about the men who work the boats and the lives they lead and I would think back on that day, the feeling of his hands around my juvenile bicep, and I would wonder what had become of that man who hadn't lasted long at Grayson's.

Okay, back to it. As I was saying before, though I was willing to leave the island when I was young I didn't do it often. Except, that is, in the rare cases when we were invited to spend the day in the back room at Steinman's books by Benny's father. These days would occur approximately quarterly and we would have a job of reconciling the inventory of books that were stacked haphazardly against walls and on chairs and on top of rusting filing cabinets. It was the late eighties and things like this were still handled manually by business owners who had not started to modernize - which Mr. O'Rourke certainly had no intentions of doing. We worked in green ledger notebooks. I would start in the far corner of the room to the left of the doorway. Benny would start directly to the right of the entrance. The room was a rectangle with a tall wooden table in the middle of it which, as a rule, was the only place books were not stacked because that was where the paperwork was managed. We would work counter-

clockwise around the room - the idea being that by the time I reached where Benny had been, Benny would have been reaching approximately where I had started, and we could then say we'd covered the entirety of the room. But that was not how it worked out. I couldn't help myself.

Every time I found a book that had an interesting title, or image on the front, or if it weighed a certain amount, or was bound in a particular way, or the print was small enough (I've always loved very small print) I would, without really thinking about it, start reading. I would read until Benny looked up and noticed that I'd stopped working - then he'd shout at me to get back to work. At that point, if the book I'd been reading held any particular interest to me, and that could mean any variety of things, I would put it aside and ask Mr. O'Rourke if I could borrow it at the end of the day. Only under one circumstance did I ever take a book without asking and that's because the book might have been characterized as lewd and I wasn't certain that Mr. O'Rourke would allow me to have it if I asked, but I simply had to have it, so though I am not proud of this I must admit that I stole one book from Mr. O'Rourke in my youth. The book was "Pimp: The Story of My Life" by Iceberg Slim. Now I knew Iceberg Slim could not have been the author's birth name but it took me reading the book to understand who Iceberg Slim was and why he used the pseudonym that he did. I should be clear that there were plenty of books filled with smut in that back room - but it wasn't smut that I was interested in. There was something very unique and special about the bright pink title of the book across a dull gray background. It was also a small publication, smaller even than a trade paperback by my estimation, and so it was easily hidden inside my belt.

It wasn't until later in my life, when the internet showed up and I would spend days researching things for no particular reason, that I found out that Iceberg Slim was something of a "cult author" as they call it. He gained a substantial following of dedicated readers who were drawn to his prose for many of the same reasons people like Hemmingway or the likes - he said things simply and clearly and he was not afraid to write about the darker impulses of human nature. Those are pretty good rules for any writer to follow - although I don't know if I follow them well enough myself, but I'm not a published writer anyways and what I do write, I write for my own personal satisfaction and perhaps to one day share with someone on my deathbed if there is someone there to share it with, that is. But Iceberg Slim was a convicted felon who'd spent his days in prison reading and honing his writing skills and when he was released from prison he wrote several realistic novels about the lives of pimps and drug dealers and other sorts of inner-city criminal types. The reason his stories were so appealing was that he didn't write about being a pimp as though he was someone who had conducted interviews and read a bunch of books on the subject - he wrote about it because he knew it inside and out from his own days as a criminal - and because he himself understood the psychology of a man who does those things he was able to tell the story in a way that seemed genuine and even had a little empathy for the ne'er-do-wells he wrote about because he was basically writing about himself.

I knew nothing of pimping. I was no more than twelve years old when I found the book. So when I read about it, at first, I was incredibly appalled. This was, in some ways, my introduction to what life

must be like in major inner-cities. Everyone was black in the novel except for cops and maybe the oddball white guy who came from poverty. I knew plenty of black families on the island, but not any of them that spoke the way these black people did, and I was amazed to realize that the dialect I'd come to assume was second nature to all black people was very clearly not the same dialect that was spoken in urban areas such as those depicted by Iceberg Slim in his novels.

I must have read *Pimp* three or four times before I read another word of any other book. I would read it in my bed and whenever I got the sense that anyone was nearby that might walk in and discover the smutty contraband I was enamored with I would tuck it all the way under my mattress and pick up the bible, which I'd been forced to keep by my bed after my Aunt Reenie moved in to take care of me following the death of my parents. Reenie was a stickler for God all the way up until she was caught doing ungodly things with one of the men from the fishing boats, after which she decided she wasn't much for God, and she and that man conceived a child out of wedlock that would be born with a cleft lip and a bad attitude. This all occurred in very rapid succession around the time I was fourteen and Aunt Reenie moved off the island (to Puerto Rico, in fact) with her new family and we never spoke to her again to the best of my knowledge. No one else moved in with me after that - which is how I came to live in my own house at the age of fourteen.

The thing with *Pimp* was that, while it was clearly written with short, readable words and simple sentences - subject, predicate - occasional exclamatory flair - the thing with it was that I couldn't actually translate the *meaning* of a good eighty percent of what was written. It was more than vaguely explicit, but I didn't know what was being referenced when the author said he'd been "Georgied" or what specific element of the female anatomy was being discussed in certain cases. It wasn't until I read through the whole book the first time - a thoroughly enjoyable, dirty, but altogether confusing adventure - that I found the glossary in the back of the book with clinical definitions for all of the terms that had flown completely over my head on first take. If the book had seemed gritty before, it now seemed downright revolutionary - I didn't know people were allowed to write the things Iceberg Slim had written. It wasn't pornography, I thought - or if it was it was not the kind of pornography I thought would be enjoyed by any of the adults I could imagine. How different was Chicago from our little island? By my best estimate it seemed the European novels from the 19th century would be a more recognizable setting than inner-city Chicago in the 20s and 30s.

Forgive the pun if you catch it, but *Pimp* was just the tip of the iceberg. I read everything that I found in that back room that was even mildly interesting. By the end of the day Benny would have lapped me in the inventory work while I had accrued a pile of books a foot and a half high for Mr. O'Rourke's review. Only once did he reject a book I was hoping to read, in fact, upon finding it in my stack he took it and threw it directly into a trashcan. I did not object but I was curious as to why. It was later, when I was able to research Celine, the author, that I realized the nature of his discomfort with the novel and I decided I would never read Celine myself because there was enough great literature out there that I could afford to skip reading a guy like that.

I read a great deal of Faulkner, Hemingway and Steinbeck. Anything I stumbled across with their name on the cover would almost immediately go into my pile. Mr. O'Rourke knew I read quickly and carefully so as not to injure the spine or damage any of the binding. As soon as I was done I would drop the book back off at his house. Eventually I was returning books with such a frequency that Mr. O'Rourke put a bin outside his door that was watertight and asked that I simply place my finished books in there rather than ringing the doorbell because I had been known to interrupt their dinner a time or two and that was something that frustrated Mr. O'Rourke to no end.

But it wasn't just the great white Americans I read - far from it. I became infatuated with many Europeans - Bernhardt, Mann, Joyce and so on. With the Europeans I enjoyed their philosophy too - Foucault and Derrida and Lacan were all close friends of mine. Kant and Hegel I struggled through. In those early years I also found Marquez, Rilke and Cortazar. I was fond of Rilke but not Marquez - and found Cortazar difficult. At that time there was still very little in terms of African or Asian literature available for sale in Steinman's - and I realize now that this may be because there was a great wave of translations that had yet to come, and much of the world literature I've come to love now that I am well into my thirties (nearing forty, in fact) was simply not available to read when I was younger.

Benny wasn't nearly as excited by reading as I was - he was far more interested in the financial machinations of the store and more and more when we would be invited to to the store he would spend time up front with his father learning how to balance transactions and the art of merchandising and meeting all sorts of people who came in to peruse the shelves. I'd rather have met them on the page.

One funny anecdote - a few months before Benny's father passed away he told us both that he'd never needed us for the inventory. He had done it himself prior to our visits (to ensure nothing ever went missing - and he winked at me) and that our trips to the bookstore had more or less been an excuse to allow our mothers (or aunts) some time to themselves, which is something a child just doesn't consider but as a young adult it made significantly more sense. He also said that once he realized how much I enjoyed borrowing from his "little library" the trips began to make him particularly happy - as it is important to pass on the gift of literature to new generations. And when he said this I did feel a pang of sympathy for my friend Benny, who hadn't shown the same enthusiasm as I had for literary arts and hadn't known it made his father so happy. I also felt some shame because I now knew that Mr. O'Rourke had known I'd taken *Pimp* all those years ago and never said a thing about it and neither had I. But I was also very grateful to him for that.

Three

Because it is not the type of thing you can simply ignore, I should provide a brief overview of the state of my family's finances (and by extension my own) starting from the year of my birth, 1983, to the

current day of my writing, early fall of 2019. I only know the pieces that I know - and where wealth is concerned, particularly when it is inherited wealth, there is often some mis-direction and inaccuracy in the information we receive. I will only state as true things that I know to be categorically true - of the information that I cannot validate I will explicitly say as much, so that the reader has the same information that I have, with mostly the same context. What should be stated clearly is that the Tipnam family's accrued wealth lived in a family trust whose sole owner would remain my grandfather until the day he died, that is to say even through his final years of psychiatric instability.

Now there is a great deal of history that precedes my birth - and during that history we were a wealthy family and a name that was known on the island for our land holdings. When I was born we still had yet to deplete our fortunes. But of the family members in existence with the intelligence and wherewithal to maintain that wealth in the face of the changing economic landscape we were numbered. My grandparents had only born one son with a head for money and he had a tendency to use his head too much (my grandfather used to say) - this was my Uncle Woody. He was always coming to them with one idea or another - starting the farm back up, investing in particular emerging industries, and he found success with several of these prospects and for a while it seemed he could be the salvation of the family and we would one day buy back the plantation home that had for so long been our biggest source of pride and our most apparent display of wealth. It was shortly after I was born, however, that Uncle Woody got heavily involved with the goings on at Grayson's Marina and decided to purchase a shrimping vessel. In and of itself this probably was not a bad idea and my grandfather must have felt the same way because he granted the financial backing to Woody, who had, until then, often returned a profit and so could be trusted to a greater degree than any of his brothers or sisters. The shrimping vessel was quite expensive, it had been commissioned as a new vessel rather than purchased used which turned out to be a grave mistake. For one thing, Woody was not (nor had he ever been) a fisherman. Almost every decision he made had to be made with consultation from experts. This was one of Woody's greatest weaknesses as a businessman - he couldn't tell a con artist from a close friend - and many of the men who spent time around the marina in those days were con artists who were very adept at playing the close friend. Almost everything went wrong. The boat designs had been lost twice (twice!) without clear explanation. The folk tale is that Uncle Woody was a very heavy drinker (this part is true) and that not once, but twice, he had taken the designs out to the dock after a long night of drinking and quarrelling with the builder and lit up a cigarette before lighting up the designs themselves so that the men drinking inside the marina, including the builder, could see a flare of light reflect off the water. And when he came in, it is said, both times, he looked the ship builder up and down and said only, "bigger". The problem with this, it turns out, is that bigger is not always better when it comes to shrimp trawlers. And bigger proved to be both more expensive and took a much longer time than had been anticipated or promised to my grandfather.

It must be noted that all this time the rest of my family was spending money like they had the rest of it buried somewhere in the dirt and the goal was to get rid of what they *did have* so fast that they could

get out there and dig up the rest and get to spending that. But there wasn't money in the dirt. It was the eighties and as far as I've been told the Tipnams liked powerful cocaine with their breakfast toast - though for my part I have no actual memories of cocaine binges occurring in my presence. As I've mentioned previously, drugs and alcohol never truly agreed with my countenance and as such I was spared this expensive proclivity.

What I was not aware of until the day the cops arrived to take Woody away was that the reason the trawler needed to be so much larger was in order to increase the cargo space so that it would be a suitable vessel for moving that speedy white powder up and down the Atlantic coast from Puerto Rico to Newfoundland (where, it turns out, even the remotest Canadians have a taste for the stuff). On that day when the cops came I ran directly to Benny's house - we were both in our mid-twenties and living in the same houses we'd been born in. I lived alone, as I had for a while, and Benny might as well have lived alone the way his mother turned silent after his father died.

It was disparaging to find that Benny knew all about the cocaine boat and was unsurprised to hear that my uncle Woody had been caught. He admitted to me that he did have his own taste for the stuff and that my uncle's arrest had brought him great distress for selfish reasons as well as the personal relation he had with Woody and our family. He, I later learned, was also turning a small profit off the stuff and was no longer able to afford the expensive lunches he had grown accustomed to taking at the elite restaurants in town. And it should be noted, this is a town where that sort of disappearance from routine does not go unnoticed.

It is a mystery to those who do not come from wealth as to how it maintains itself across generations. But it is likewise a mystery to those of us who, like me, have watched wealth dwindle away into debts and bankruptcies and desperation, how the life of wealth is not self-sustaining. Its never-ending nature is one of the fundamental precepts of a family like the Tipnams.

One thing is for certain, as surely as we were once a wealthy family of ambition and industry in the antebellum south, we are now a family of meager means and limited opportunity in the twenty-first century. Where our name once made the newspapers for innovation and savvy business acumen, we now make the news primarily in the obituaries or crime blogs. The modern socialites of our region know our name as a family that once participated in the community but disappeared quietly sometime around the millennium. If it were not for Benny and his allowing me to make a salary buying and selling books for him from my home office, I would surely be living in the attic of my grandmother's house or (I can even imagine it) permanently sleeping somewhere at the bottom of the Atlantic like my Uncle Woody does now.

I'll explain. He was on parole for his charges of drug trafficking and (somehow) negligent manslaughter when he decided to head to Grayson's one night and play some cards. He played well enough and had the largest stack of chips at the table, it is said, when he stepped outside to have a

smoke. This was strange, his decision to go outside to smoke, because all of them smoked inside the marina office and there was no reason beyond desire to step out, where the air was humid enough to quench a parched man's thirst, for him to have decided to take his smoke outside. Outside he climbed aboard one of the long-line boats docked there that was in bad need of repair - he untied their anchor and with a pocket knife cut a strand of rope from one of the life-preservers that were kept in the captain's quarters. As quickly as only a practiced hand can do he tied one end of the rope to the anchor and the other end around his ankle, cinching a knot so tight it would have taken him sometime to undo it even on land. He took no time at all to throw the anchor overboard and the men inside said there was an audible crack when his ankle pulled him down and the crown of his head made contact with the steel rail on which he had been seated only seconds prior. There was blood left there, along the rail, and no one really ever questioned the motives or circumstances around Uncle Woody's death. It wasn't until the next day when it was reported and later than that even when what remained of his clean picked body was pulled from the churning waters below the docks at Grayson's.

Woody's death was the culmination of months of turmoil around the whole fiasco and for some of the family I don't think I would be lying to say it came with some feeling of relief.

After Woody's death the family was another man down. This was in 1993 when I was ten or eleven years old depending on the month and date. There were a number of Tipnams still around at that time but of my father's siblings they had been reduced in number from five to three - my father and Woody now having both retired from the breathing life. The remaining siblings were his two sisters, Reenie and Harriet, and his older brother (the oldest of the five), my uncle Bocephus.

It was said after the event, that Uncle Woody had been trying to do the family a service by giving himself a saltwater burial. He had more knowledge of the family's financial straits than anyone other than my grandfather himself, and would have known very well that the legal costs associated with his trial would have on their own been substantial enough for the family to be required to sell yet another property (which would have meant consolidating families in a single home - a thing which we had, as of yet, not been forced to do). We were still far from rock bottom at the time, in many ways thanks solely to Woody himself, and it was later on when I came to a somewhat different conclusion about the reasons Woody had for exterminating his own life. In my late teens I conducted some covert research into this particular event. How I conducted this research will be covered in great detail in the following chapters - but what is relevant for this particular chapter is only what my findings led me to believe.

I shall just come out and say it: My personal inquiries have led me to believe that my grandfather knew a good deal more than anyone was ever aware about the illicit drug trade and had further inquiry been made into the nature of the family business, which had been funded in its entirety by the family trust, it would have been discovered that the patriarch, my kind and passive grandfather, had been well aware of the profits that the boat would bring not only as a shrimping vessel but as a carrier of illicit drugs.

Now I am likely not the only person who is aware of this fact. In all likelihood even the local police department (and it had been kept a local crime, somehow) would have been aware of this truth - and when one considers all of the possible ways in which this information could have easily been discovered by the local authorities, (For heaven's sake, it was my grandfather's signature on nearly every document!) one is nudged towards the conclusion that the local authorities chose to pursue the matters no further out of some sort of sympathy for the old man, and by extension the Tipnam family itself. We were, by now, a family in irreversible decline, and it may have been that the local authorities thought it best to let nature have its way with what remained of the Tipnams. There was some generosity in that and I have always been grateful to those unknown actors who chose to look the other way. Simply put, when Woody died they closed the case on the drug trafficking charges and even returned the boat we'd built to Grayson's Marina in one piece where grandfather promptly sold it to Jameson Grayson himself, who found legal use for it and continues to maintain it to this day.

Only three years ago, in fact, Jamie (as I know him now) decided to convert the *Island Girl* (he had renamed it as such) into a cannonball jellyfishing enterprise. We do not eat jellyfish here in the United States (I have tried it and think the decision wise) - but in China and Japan it is known as quite a delicacy - particularly in China, the largest market, where unlike the Japanese who only eat the helmet-like epidermal "bell" of the creature, the Chinese eat every part of the blob of semi-life including the tougher and meatier "oral arms" of the creature.

I could go into details around the numerous small ways in which money would be dispersed from the trust only to provide negative returns. Each of these were like a small jab at the raging bull, and with each we bled out a bit more, until grandfather finally locked down the trust, giving a small portion to each of his remaining children or their respective descendants if they were still living on the property (myself included) and telling them to manage it wisely because no more would be distributed during his lifetime.

Grandfather began losing his mind in 2003. Many times I pleaded with him to allow me to help manage what remained as I had read a great deal about market trends and compound interest and even had a few suggestions as to savvy investment strategies. I cannot blame him for his reticence (or rather, outright denial). He had, by then, been swindled one too many times by his own family and had made a decision on the day he doled out a portion to each family that he would not be alive when the trust hit zero. For my part I had what remained of my father's portion (it was not much) and I had learned ways to stretch it and as I did not travel or need expensive things to keep me satisfied. So because I was not in dire need of financial assistance I did not push my grandfather even when I knew he was making decisions that were no longer in the best interest of the long term stability and growth of the trust.

Between 2004 and 2007 my grandfather made a series of investments with the money in the trust, goaded on by a young, black haired wealth advisor who had relocated to the south east from the Upper West Side in Manhattan - Francesco Torini. The man was a charlatan, and I knew it - what I did not know was the amount of damage a single charlatan can do to the vestigial wealth of an entire family in

such a short duration of time. Perhaps I will return to this in due time, but it is a story in and of itself, and for the purposes of this chapter the most important thing you should know is that when the “Great Recession” occurred in 2008 what remained of our trust was depleted in an extreme way and we were forced to sell all but three of our remaining properties and a large percentage of our acreage.

Luckily for my grandfather (and Harriet), my grandmother had been siphoning money from my grandfather for as long as they’d been wed. She’d packed several suitcases full of cash over the years - they sat innocently in the attic, tucked between other nondescript and completely empty pieces of luggage. They sat there until the day came when all the money was gone and grandfather, riddled with dementia, told grandmother that all would be fine, Woody would take care of it. She then took one single piece of luggage out of the attic (there were at least four that I am aware of - but possibly there are more) and from that day forward they only transacted in faded green American dollars. Harriet received a weekly stipend from grandmother without grandfather’s knowing - and I have always hoped that by that time he was so far gone that he did not know what he had done by collaborating with that sinister Francesco Torini from the Upper West Side of Manhattan.

For my part I still retain a small amount of that initial compensation - I’ve held onto it by placing it in conservative investment funds and for the most part I spend only what I make through my work with Benny and other small ventures on the island that I participate in from time to time. I am not a wealthy man but if I manage what I have correctly I should not need for anything fundamental in my lifetime.

Four

There is only one middle school on the island and it is on McCallan Road, nearer to the Harris-Parson Bridge than it is to Grayson’s Marina. It was constructed in the middle of the island in the mid-forties, which is where most of the commercial and government buildings are built in order to avoid the frequent flooding that occurs on the periphery of the island when a large storm coincides with a strong tide. Topographically the island is variably crested, like a hill with a very minor gradient, so most parts of the center island sit at a safe margin above sea level; the closer one is to the bodies of water that frame it, the Nan-Wah River, the Carolina River and the Atlantic Ocean respectively, the nearer the land is to sea-level. Noticing the tides comes second nature to island inhabitants and over time I’ve come to appreciate them with a particular intensity. I liked the way they operated on their own clock and were not consistent with the sun’s constant rise and fall. They paid attention to the moon instead, and I’ve always felt there was some sort of metaphor there that would be worth reading if the proper author set it to paper.

During my early adolescent summers, before life became one perpetual day-off, Benny and I would spend entire days on one of the dilapidated docks that ran out into the churning water where the Nan-

Wah met the Atlantic. Because the land had been taken by the bank and then, for reasons I did not understand, left untouched and unsold for decades, trespassing was never an issue we had to deal with. The land had become overgrown and the houses and docks we once had owned had quickly fallen into ruinous states. One of the docks had remained particularly sturdy, though, and that was where we would spend those days. Benny would bring more fishing rods than we had hands and the tackle to go with it. It was rare that I would fish with him because I hated the prospect of unhooking a fish. I would usually bring multiple books with me - I could never be certain as to how the day would alter my desires or curiosities. My moods were then, and continue to be, subconsciously driven by the weather, season, or time of day. On any given outing I could go from wanting to read about the varieties of dinosaurs that existed during the Cretaceous period to having no interest in paleontology whatsoever. It was for this reason that I never could read only one book at a time, and it was often the case that I had a bookmark stuck in a half a dozen books at the same time.

Though the dock was stable, by no means did this mean that it was safe. It took no more than a few steps to catch a splinter the size of a toothpick. Barely half of the planks that constituted the actual walkway were still there - those that remained had either been taken by storm or termites. Rusted nails punctuated the walkway - many of them jutting out of the surface as a result of the constant expansion and contraction of the wood. It gave me the impression the wood was forcing them out, just in the same way I'd been informed the body forces a splinter out if left to its own devices. It also seemed to be a favorite sunbathing spot for Cottonmouths, easily identified by their "hershey kiss" pattern and wide bodies - which Benny seemed to relish, if only because he knew they frightened me so intensely.

Across the Nan-Wah was the heavily wooded western border of a barrier island that hosted some of the most elegant and violent birds I've ever seen. Osprey, with their treetop perched nests and high, anguished calls. During those summer months you could watch throughout the day as the father hunted the waters diligently, always returning to the nest with his fresh catch to feed the newly hatched chicks. Brilliantly white bellied birds that always seemed to move with greater grace and agility than the red-tailed hawks that lumbered through the sky or the occasional bald eagle, too grand and triumphant to display the same easy ferociousness of the osprey. We'd see alligators with some frequency, too - ribbed green logs with vacant, prehistoric eyes. Small groups of pelicans would glide past seemingly without the flap of a wing. Playful dolphins. Keen eyed herons, knee deep at the water's edge, ducking quickly to pull small minnows from the muddy water, flipping and flailing manically against thin yellow beaks. On occasion there were even manatees that meandered down the river - they are the smelliest creatures I've ever encountered but they exude docility and (somehow) kindness and no other vision made me as happy as the giant gray manatee plodding its way toward us, sniffing around like an old dog. Later, when I began to spend more time at the marina, I learned that manatees are constantly in search of fresh water and by placing a running hose of fresh water directly into the river you could draw manatees in, and whether they are fearless or trusting or just plain dumb I will not wager a guess, but they would come so close you could pet them, rubbing your hand down their oddly hairy hides, and

they even seemed to enjoy it. Then it was best not to wash your hands but to find an unsuspecting victim and smother them with the terrible scent of sea cow.

It may surprise the reader to learn that despite my natural proclivity for the literary arts I was not a tremendous student. My grades were barely passing by the time I entered middle school and early in my seventh grade year - the final year of my Uncle Woody's life - it became apparent I was at risk of having to retake several fundamental courses if I did not score well enough on the mid-semester exams.

While my averages in history and reading comprehension were significantly above average - in the remaining classes: Science, Mathematics, Home Economics, and Physical Education, my scores were abysmal.

Take mathematics, for example. Of course I could calculate the radius of a circle based on its circumference. It is a simple equation and requires only that one populates the numbers and then follows the basic mathematical principles of multiplication and division (even with the inclusion of exponents this was not much more complicated) - but the problem that I encountered was in that when that exam paper arrived on my desk I would look at the circle and the equation would come to mind and when I went to write it all out on the paper I would wonder about the scenario that might require this kind of equation. In what practical scenario might we know the circumference of a space we are trying to measure without knowing already it's diameter - and with its diameter, I thought, we could certainly find the radius by simply dividing that in two - which is what the equation posits anyways. So then I'd realize that the question is about how to determine the diameter of a circle based on its circumference which made a bit more sense to me - say for example....still, I struggled to come up with the practical application. Suppose there was a pizza, I'd think -- but why would I ever know the circumference of a pizza before I knew it's diameter -- and what interests one in the measurements of a pizza anyways?

Perhaps if I were hunting, and I'd walked a large circle around the perimeter of an area where I knew there to be a decent sized buck somewhere there in the center -- but even then I'd have had to calculate all my steps and ensure that I'd been walking in a perfect circle and then I'd have to know that the buck was in the exact middle of the circle and so on and so forth. I would get stuck on this sort of thing as the clock ticked away or I would simply give up on the question and move to the next.

I should think my poor scores in physical education and home economics speak for themselves. How we waste the lives of our youth in those prisons of education.

It is perhaps most surprising that I was a significant failure in science - and that is because the reason for my failure here is quite different from the reason I was so terrible at the others. Whereas with the other subjects it was a lack of interest, not a lack of ability, that caused me to score so poorly. With science I was beyond interested in the subject and very keen to learn all that could be learned - but the problem with that class was the damned teacher (excuse my language, I curse rarely and only for emphasis). Mr. Dupont was an old white haired miser and he hated my family with a passion for things my uncles had done to him some decades prior. Now in such an objective space, such as science, it

should be difficult to impact a student's grades subjectively (the way, for example, an english teacher has a good deal of gray area in the evaluation of a paper's success or failure) - but what a teacher *can* do is to constantly focus on one student, criticizing them for their tardiness or sloppy handwriting or, on one occasion, stench - and that might cause the student to lose focus and ambition, which was the case with me. Mr. Dupont took it a few steps beyond that even, once holding me after class to let me know that I was a "smart-ass" just like my uncles, and that he didn't like smart-asses, and that he would make it his goal to see that I did not pass his class.

I don't know how a grown man comes to have such hatred for children in his heart. It certainly had more to do with deep seated insecurities and trauma than it did with anything I had personally done. I could not speak for the actions of my uncles, though I had heard some stories about live snakes being used to replace the dead specimens for dissection and things of a similar nature.

There was only one student Mr. Dupont hated more than me, and that was Benny. And if it wasn't for the fact that Mr. Dupont hated Benny, I likely would never have been expelled from that school.

Mr Dupont did not vocalize his reasons for hating Benny in the same way he vocalized the reasons he had for treating me so improperly - and as a child I assumed it was due to Benny being my only friend and that Mr. Dupont's hatred for Benny was a direct extension of his hatred for me and in a lot of ways I felt guilty for that. After Mr. Dupont's death things would come to be exposed about him and his family heritage that would lead one to draw a different conclusion, that he was a long-term Nazi-sympathizer behind closed doors - but this something Benny and I knew long before he died.

It was almost a weekly occurrence that Benny would be forced to stay after class for a lecture from Mr. Dupont - I would wait for him so that we could walk to our next class together. It was the third or fourth time that it had happened in the semester when Benny came out crying for the first time. I asked him if he'd been crying - which was a dumb question, I realize - and he told me to "fuck off," and walked briskly away from where I'd awaited him. As an adolescent with a tinge of autism things like this were quite difficult for me to understand and I was mad at Mr. Dupont for having said something to Benny that I assumed had made him mad at me. Defense mechanisms were still difficult for me to wrap my head around.

The second time he came out of Mr. Dupont's classroom he was crying much harder than he had been the first time.

"Is something the matter?" I asked, I was always asking questions in a dumb way like this.

"What do you think?" he said in a curt way. There were still kids scattering about the hall towards their next classroom before the late bell rang. He kept his head low and eyes down to avoid being mocked. I watched a tear drop to the linoleum floor from the tip of his nose. "I'm outta here," he said, and he went left rather than right, towards the stairwell that led to the back exit, so I followed.

I'm not a "rule-breaker" by my nature, but neither am I a "rule-follower" - this seemed to me the moral and right thing to do in the circumstances - particularly when the alternative was to go study an equation for the curvature of a semi-circle or something.

When we were outside I asked him where we'd go. He was busy surveying the area for any sign of the security guards who prowled the grounds in search of cigarette smokers or truants. With none in sight he high-tailed it across the parking lot directly to the treeline on the far side. I chased behind him, less physically fit but still young. We sat ourselves behind a large live oak so that he could finish his crying and we could make up a plan on where to go. It was a Thursday in Fall and very hot. We decided we should go to the dock to clear our heads - it was a long hike, probably five miles or so, but we figured we could keep a pace of fifteen minutes a mile or so - which would get us to the dock in seventy five minutes, on in other words, it wouldn't even take us an hour and a half to get there. We knew how to take back roads and avoid just staying on McCallan all the time where we were certain to be spotted and have the cops called on us or worse.

On this walk Benny told me about Mr. Dupont's rabid anti-semitism. I frankly could not believe it. It was the early nineties, mind you. The Berlin Wall had fallen only a few years prior. Communism had been stamped out and people were free across the globe, I thought. Anti-semitism was something I read about in books, but I could not imagine it still existing in real life - at a relatively modernized middle school on a small island. Sure, they still taught Creationism, but at least now they mentioned that there was a subset of scientists who believed in the theory of evolution (at which point they would expound on the differences between a theory and a law).

"Mr. Dupont is a fucking bigot. He told me I smelled like lox. I don't even eat lox! I don't even know what lox tastes like in the first place! Christ, I don't even know what lox is!"

"Cured salmon," I told him. I did not understand the affiliation between lox and bigotry. We were on a dirt road with small houses on one side and a drainage ditch on the other. Beyond the drainage ditch was nothing but woods as far as I could see. "Lox," I repeated, still working it out. "Was that all he said?"

"You wouldn't get it," he said.

"Perhaps not," I responded. "But he told me I smelled like I belonged down at the dock once, and that upset me enormously. I know how that felt."

Benny didn't speak for a while. We kept on walking, past an abandoned trailer that looked as though it was being consumed by vines. The vines were known as "Wandering Jew". The faded red bed of a Ford truck sat by itself in the dirt drive, as though it's other half had run off in the night. It too was covered in vines and all manner of weedy growth. The trailer was raised on concrete blocks, maybe a

foot or so. We'd gone almost two miles by then and the heat and humidity had started to make me sweat fiercely. I wished I'd taken a sip from the water fountain before we left.

"Lox, of course, is traditionally eaten by Jews. I get it now. He was making fun of your mother."

Benny's great quality as a friend was that he never got mad at me for saying things the way I said them because he understood, for the most part, the way I thought and the way I looked at the world. Unlike most of our peers, who mocked my intonations and the sort of dyslexic way I saw causes and effects, Benny would take the time to think about it, at least, and try to understand how and why it was I'd said what I'd said.

He stopped walking for a moment so I stopped too. He picked up a small granite stone from the road and chucked it into the woods where we heard it clip a couple of leaves and then nothing else. "It's a good point, Tipnam. He was making fun of me too - that's why I was mad. But I guess it bugged me more because he was really making fun of her. I guess I didn't realize it until you put it that way." We started walking again and no more than two minutes passed before we heard a large, thunderous boom from somewhere on the other side of the woods. From our vantage point there wasn't a cloud in the sky - but on our island the sky is prone to rapid changes of mood. The sound we had heard was associated with a particular large, tall, dark black cloud known as a *cumulonimbus* that was a frequent afternoon visitor during the summer and fall months. These were clouds that brought heavy rain with thick droplets, quickly flooding the roadside ditches - but they were usually as quick as they were violent - and when a *cumulonimbus* finishes releasing its bladder it usually kicks on down the road and leaves a wake of clear blue skies and vocal wildlife.

This is all to say that though we could not yet see the cloud, we knew by the thunder where it was and what it had intended for us. Within minutes we could smell it, feel the humid breezes, and I noted that the leaves on the trees had begun to turn upside down, which was a well known *folk-indicator* of a nearby stormfront.

"Could give a damn if I get wet," Benny said, but I did not feel the same way. Several of the books in my backpack were his father's, for one, and I hated the idea of destroying any book, let alone books on loan from Mr. O'Rourke. I also had a Walkman, which had recently become a prized possession of mine, and in it a tape I'd curated from the radio with recordings from Casey Kasem's "American Top-40". I also had my grandfather's pocket watch - which he'd given to me for my tenth birthday. It was still ticking, and he had told me that with proper maintenance it would continue to do so until I passed it on to my own child some day.

"I have to differ in opinion there, Ben. My bag can't get wet. I've got some of your dad's books in there."

“Oh to hell with your books,” he said, lightheartedly - but then he must have seen the concern on my face because he apologized. “Let me think. This road isn’t the safest place. It’s all coons back here.” I didn’t respond - I was surprised to hear him speak that way. “That old house we went past a bit ago - that place was abandoned. We could probably just take cover in there until the storm passes.”

I had been worried this would be his suggestion. But while he’d been thinking I’d been thinking too and I wasn’t comfortable knocking on the doors of any of the other trailers on the street. This was the sort of place where you were shot for trespassing, undoubtedly. We would not make it anywhere near my house or the docks before the storm hit. We likely only had another five or ten minutes before the skies broke loose. The first edge of the storm cloud peeked over the top of the large pines. A barometric pressure drop was palpable. “We have no clue what could be in there. What if the place is full of bats? They carry rabies, you know - you can get it just from smelling their feces.” I wasn’t certain as to the accuracy of what I’d stated.

“Ozzy Ozbourne ate a bat,” Benny said. “We’d survive.”

“Ozzy Ozbourne is a cretin.”

“Sure, but you’re a pussy.” He chuckled. I laughed too because I knew he meant it as a joke. “C’mon Tip, let’s get moving.” He started walking back in the direction of the house. I waited a second or two but there was another loud boom and a flash of lightning that lit what we could see of the cloud brilliantly. I followed him back down the road.

I don’t know why, but all I could think at that moment was that I wished my parents hadn’t died, and I wondered if it was possible that when I died I would see them again.

Five

We got to the trailer quickly and stood in the road for a second, each of us waiting for the other to take the lead. Both Benny and I knew that it would be Benny - it was always Benny - but still we vacillated a bit. “You go first,” he said. And I realized it was rare that I saw Benny scared or uncertain and it made me more frightened once I thought of that.

“I can’t,” I said. “You go.” He didn’t think long before making his first steps towards the place. There was another crash from the clouds. He moved quickly once he’d set his mind to it. I crept slowly up the dirt walkway behind him - trying my hardest not to look out of place (as though there were a way that could be conceivably done) - as he jimmied at the locked door. He pulled and pushed and lifted until the shoddy locking mechanism slipped out of place and the door opened inward. The stench of

death came breathing out of the house. “Fuck!” Benny yelled. He pulled his t-shirt up over his nose and looked over at me. I made haste towards the doorway - feeling nauseous immediately.

A wall of rain was making its way towards us, now just a few hundred strides down the road. It was the sort of rain that thuds when it reaches the ground and is frightening if only for the immediacy with which it becomes deafeningly loud. These were the sorts of raindrops that you could feel individually as they hit your skin, as opposed to the more misty sort of rain that one can walk through for a bit before beginning to feel wet at all.

It was a matter of seconds before the cacophony was upon us. We hadn’t even had the time to survey the interior of the trailer before the rain came down so hard on the metal roof that we practically had to shout at one another just to be heard.

“IT’S REALLY COMING DOWN!” I said. Benny kept his shirt pinched above his nose but chuckled. I hadn’t meant to be funny but I understood why he laughed. It was a simple thing to understand.

It was only then that I fully absorbed the scent of the place. Urine, feces, decay, something chemical, something burnt, something that was probably unhealthy to be smelling at all. At least there had been no bats. I don’t know why it was bats that I’d been the most worried about.

The interior of the trailer was littered with trash - mostly aluminum cans and paper napkins and glass liquor or wine bottles, a few used syringes here and there. There was a hole in the floor directly in front of the doorway that looked down into a dark hole where the sound of rain reverberated loudly and more cans and bottles and paper boxes had been discarded. It was hard to see around inside once the door was shut. All the windows had been darkened by vines and mildew and mold. One of the things I found most disconcerting about our circumstance was that the volume of the rain was substantial enough that, were a rat to scurry past my feet I would have had to feel it to notice, because I could not have heard it over the din of wind and rain - which was particularly loud due to the makeup of the place, the decayed holes in its baseboards functioning like amplifiers. “I DON’T THINK IT WILL LAST LONG,” I shouted. “SMELLS HORRIBLE IN HERE!”

I was nervous even to set my bag on the floor so I kept both straps on my shoulders and stood there in silence, holding my breath in long intervals until I had to inhale and even then doing it only through my mouth to avoid the stench. But after a few minutes, when the rain did not stop, I realized I’d have to come to terms with my environment if only for a bit.

It was so dark that the other senses were more acute. The rain pounded incessantly on the thin metal roof. The smells individuated themselves. There was rotten fruit, urine, feces, wet paper, bleach perhaps, wet ash like you’d smell from a left out tray, wet fur of some sort - there was decayed shellfish, somewhere, I was almost certain, and there was also the salty, heavy smell of escaped swamp water somewhere behind all that - the heat driving it all forward into a sort of crescendo. I was ready to

vomit but wouldn't allow myself. I'd grown skilled in that practice during my years on the island. I pinched my nose and pictured flowers, as my mother had taught me, and it served me well. Benny did not have the same fortitude and was soon opening the door into the downpour to catch a breath. That really made me laugh. Through the open doorway I could see a large torrent of water streaming down the road - the flooding was quickly becoming substantial.

Flooding is often more brutal in the poorer areas on the island. The introduction of new roads and neighborhoods significantly alters the drainage patterns on the island - and it is not without some money that a neighborhood or particular road avoids being the benefactor of the new found runoff. The road we were on (which I'd never known a proper name for besides "Old Dirt Road") was one of those unlucky inheritors.

Benny saw the current of water too and said the same thing I'd been thinking, "If this doesn't slow down we are going to get stuck in this fucking place." I wished he hadn't said it - the idea burrowed into my psyche and began a pattern of thought that I recognized as, on occasion, having led to one of my *breathing attacks*. A circular sort of thinking where the fear would present itself clearly. I, in turn, consciously attempt to shoo it away - except that by thinking about getting rid of it I begin to realize that there is no proper way to get rid of a thought, it has no dimensions and responds directly to my fears by digging in deeper. The inability to exorcize the fear only gives it more power, more validity, which in turn makes it become more present. At this point the *breathing attack* makes an appearance, compounding the concern - the fear attaches to the attack, they begin to wrestle, I've lost all control of my own thoughts. When this plays out in its entirety I end up sitting in a corner somewhere with my knees tucked to my chest, counting backwards from one hundred as I've been instructed by a variety of educated psychiatric professionals from the respectable corners of the internet.

Of course I didn't want this to happen - there was nowhere to sit.

We realized we could keep the door open without getting too wet. This helped mitigate the claustrophobia and allowed us to see the breadth of the stream that was forming. You would have thought it would have done more to help with the smell, but it did not.

The light from the doorway cast a faint shadow and I glimpsed a small movement on the far counter. A rat, I was certain - luckily they didn't bother me much, but I knew not to say anything to Benny, who was a tidge phobic of the creatures. I kept my mouth shut and watched the rain fall. It showed no signs of letting up.

The stream, by now, had covered the dirt road in its entirety. A thin sheen on the surface of the road that flowed in the direction we'd been headed, towards the ocean, the same direction everything flowed on this side of the island.

It should be noted, as the lay reader who has not grown up on an island like ours may not fully understand, flooding in and of itself was not a rare occurrence by any means. In all likelihood the road we were on flooded more often than not in the face of a large storm - so we were not yet incredibly nervous. Once the rain stopped the water left quickly - a road could go from flooded to navigable within minutes of a storm's conclusion. It was only when the storm did not stop for some time, or when the storm followed another storm that had already swollen the ground with water, which meant the escape routes were clogged. In this case it hadn't rained in days, so that was not a concern. I mentioned as much to Benny, but he responded by informing me that the tide was coming in for the next hour, and it was a full moon on top of that, which meant the tides would be higher naturally. This was the other complicating factor in the alleviation of heavy rains - high tides contributed substantially to the flooding. "IT SHOULD STOP SOON!" I reiterated. But it continued to rain.

What had once been a stream had evolved into a full fledged river. It was swallowing up the front yard quickly and expanding by the minute - rising towards the house. From the doorway I saw a man in the distance, walking through calf-deep water. He walked slowly, as though he didn't have a care in the world about the storm or the rain, truly as though he didn't even notice he was wet. There is something insidious about a man who walks through chaos at a leisurely pace - perhaps because it is an unrecognizable state of mind to the observer. How can one not feel the need for self-preservation? It reeks of insanity. "LOOK AT THAT FUCKING CRACKHEAD!" Benny shouted, pointing. "UNBELIEVABLE!"

It struck me then that we were standing in what I would generally refer to as a *crack den* . I did not want to frighten Benny - he was the source of our confidence and I needed him to remain in control of the situation lest we lose our composure - so I chose to say nothing in response. My *breathing fit* circled the perimeter of my mind like one of those ospreys I loved so much. I could feel it in there and I started counting again from ninety nine.

The man was probably one hundred yards from us now. Still, through the rain, it was difficult to make out his features. He was black, tall, skinny, and dressed in heavy clothes. This was another recognizable quality of the local crack addicts - they wore winter jackets during the hottest days of summer, blue jeans and hoodies. I could not restrain my concerns any longer, "I THINK HE'S COMING THIS WAY. THIS IS A CRACK HOUSE, BEN!" The rain was as loud as it had been since we'd arrived there.

Benny looked up when I said this and I could see that he now connected the dots that I had only a few minutes earlier. He tried to shut the door but it had been irreparably damaged during our break in and would not latch. Benny shouted a few curse words.

Sixty yards now - it was as though the man was walking behind a wall of television static - I could not register a face. He had been walking on the far side of the road - by my estimates - but now he had

crossed to the nearer side of the road. The water was to the bottom of his kneecaps.

“WE NEED TO BEAT FEET!” Benny yelled.

“I CAN’T! MY BAG!”

“FUCK YOUR BAG! LEAVE IT HERE - WE’LL COME BACK FOR IT!”

“I’M CONCERNED WE WON’T RETURN!”

“YOU’RE WHAT??”

“CONCERNED! THAT WE WON’T RETURN!”

I was surprised to see Benny’s expression - something like anger and pity. “LET’S FUCKING GO, TIP! I’M NOT DYING FOR BOOKS!”

“JUST GO!” I shouted, I don’t know why. There was a devil-may-care edge to it. I felt, for the first time in my life, like the brave one.

Now, I should explain the series of thoughts that led me to this response. They occurred very quickly, almost simultaneously. They were internalized and interpreted in a matter of seconds. As far as I saw it there were two options. One, we could dart out into the flooded island, nowhere to go, no shelter to speak of, and hope that the storm did not dole out more than we could manage. In this case there were a variety of ways to die - pure drowning, fallen tree, lightning strike, derived sickness. Even if one resisted the morbid impulses there were a number of truly terrible things that could occur regardless - snake bites, pneumonia, and *the unknown*. On the other hand, if I remained where I was, there were only two things that seemed immediately threatening - the man and the water. Of the two, the water was a shared property of risk. Only the man remained as a known threat. But (and again, I must be clear, I am putting these thoughts to paper from a remove - in the moment all of this was considered as a whole - there were no steps) there was no certainty that the man was a threat. It struck me as odd to run from a human being with no purpose. Had he been a white man we might have thought differently, I reasoned. And in this weather, unless his sole intention was to kill a person, would it not have been possible to reason with a man? Even if it was a crackhead, I thought. Even they have families and some form of humanity, don’t they?

To be certain, this line of thought comes more easily to a young person than it does to those who have been wearied by time, hardened into their comfortable positions of stereotype and assumption. It is true and should be said - many psychologists agree that stereotyping is a critical tool used by the human race for a variety of self-evidently beneficial purposes. In fact, we are masters of the stereotype - using it as a utilitarian artifice that allows us to judge circumstances without all of the required information and make decisions that hold some statistical validation. Which is to say - at a macro-level,

stereotyping is a critical tool for our species - but at the micro-level it is absurdly problematic. I have much more to say on the topic but wish not to stray too far from the ongoing action, the critical juncture at which we'd arrived. Benny felt an obligation to stay with me, I could sense as much - but every fiber of his being told him to run. I felt the same obligation to Benny, but my fibers spoke otherwise.

"LOOK TIPNAM - LAST CHANCE - I'M GOING."

I responded with great sadness, "AS IT MUST BE!"

He cursed that I was a stubborn, stupid motherfucker and then turned. The water was up to his ankles just outside the front door. He took an immediate left and trudged down through the brown river in the direction of the Nan-Wah, the Atlantic. He did not look back once he set himself in the direction he was headed, and he made haste through the rain, staying towards the left of the road where the land was most elevated.

The man was now at a distance of thirty yards - close enough that I could make out his downcast eyes and aged skin. I could see short gray bristles on his cheeks. I could see the Reebok logo on his jacket now. He had a long wooden walking stick in his right hand that he set in front of his every step. He had not looked up for any duration while walking and it was almost certain that he had not seen us, did not know I was awaiting him. He was on a bee-line for the house - that much was certain - there was no doubt anymore of where he was headed.

I wished I'd left with Benny. I thought about making a mad dash and attempting to catch up with him but he'd moved so quickly when he left that he was no longer in sight. For all I knew he'd been taken by an alligator (I'd seen photos of Alligators in all sorts of places after a large flood).

Because I did not want to frighten the man - even a sane man, when frightened, can be a dangerous one - I made my mind up to shout at the man, to let him know I was there. "SIR!" I shouted. "SIR!!" Louder. On my third call he heard me and looked up. He was no more than thirty feet from the house now, in the "front yard", if it could be called that. He did not respond to my call but he saw me. He altered neither speed nor gait. He wore a stoic grimace. I stood in the doorway where I'd been standing for the last ten minutes. My heart beat rapidly against my chest.

A loud crash rang out to my left. Somewhere in the distance I heard a generator blow. The moment had arrived. I clenched my hands tight around the straps of my backpack. The man approached the door. He stopped, for a brief moment and stood there in the rain to look at me. "HELLO," I shouted. He smiled a crazy sort of smile and said nothing. I took one step back from the doorway and he stepped up inside. We were about six inches from each other when he spoke - I could barely hear him through the sound of the battering rain - "You seen't my kittens? Oh lord, my kittens." And then he walked inside, deftly avoiding the sinkhole. He entered the kitchen area to the right and reached for something on the counter. Suddenly there was a bright, fluorescent light illuminating the totality of the ruin inside the trailer. "Where dem kittens? Oh lord. They gone. They gone. Lord they gone." He

held a lantern out as he moved about the space, getting progressively more frustrated, ignoring me completely. I still felt nowhere near safe. The door remained open - I could still attempt to make a break. I looked outside at the single grim alternative that was available. I wondered how far Benny had made it - where he was now. It would have been best to die together, I thought. But then I heard the man laughing behind me - a deep belly laugh that seemed completely incongruous with the setting, the man himself, with the storm and the flood. "You sneaky little mu'fuckas. I knew you ain't leave off on yo' daddy. Smart lil mu'fuckas! I been worried bout y'all. Thank the lord I was worried oh thank lord." He tried to grab one but they darted off behind the variety of boxes that were randomly strewn about the place. Then he turned to me and smiled again, "Now who da fuck you be?"

The man was not all there - that much could be certain. Particularly in the upcast light from the lantern his eyes seemed to work independently of one another. He had a smile that would not go away but only four or five teeth to fill it. He was older, it seemed, but how old I could not venture to guess with any accuracy. Every article of clothing he wore was soaked as though he'd swam here.

I told him my name. I said that I'd been on my way home from school when the storm hit - that my family would certainly be looking for me. He asked me if I was a child and I responded in the affirmative. He seemed to think about that for a bit. I did not move an inch - ready to bolt at any second. The rain, finally, began to let up a bit. There was no longer a need to scream to be heard. I assured him I would leave just as soon as the flooding subsided, lifting a hand uselessly to point out the door at the newly formed lake that rippled with raindrops all around the trailer. The man asked me if I had a cigarette. I did not. He seemed temporarily angry, but moved on quickly. The rain then stopped completely.

The oddest thing occurred. Having apparently run out of questions for me the man turned back to the corner of the room where he'd found the cats. He called out to them several times. He looked at his fingers, cursed a few times, rummaged through a box of trash, pocketing a few items. He seemed to have forgotten about me entirely. A flash of blue sky appeared beyond the treetops. "Do you live here?" I asked aloud. He turned back towards me and gave a quizzical look. I had the sensation that I'd accidentally spoken to him in a foreign language. He turned away again.

It was at that exact moment I saw Benny charging towards the trailer. He had a gash above his left eye and some blood running down his face. I looked back nervously at the man - he had been no threat, so far, but things like that can change in an instant. I put my hand up like a police officer at an intersection, letting Benny know to stop, that things were alright - but it was too late; the man had heard Benny's legs splashing through the water towards the trailer. Whether he felt threatened or frightened or just snapped I do not know. What I do know is that he came charging at me, I saw a box cutter tight in his grip. I bolted through the front door into approximately ten inches of standing rainwater. I ran towards Benny who had quickly stopped running towards me and made an about face towards the woods. The water grew deeper with each step. I did not stop to look back until I'd crossed the road,

falling once in the drainage ditch, and then made my way up the other side to the forested area where Benny stood and water remained ankle high. My backpack had been soaked through in the fall.

The man stood in the doorway like a ghost, neither moving nor standing still - just hovering there it almost seemed. But we were at a safe enough distance that he could not catch us, I calculated.

I had a vision of the forest floor then, teeming with snakes just below the surface of the water.

“A branch almost took out my fucking eye coming back to save you,” Benny said. “Guess it’s a good thing I showed up when I did. You should have listened to me the first time, Tipnam.” And then as though it had just dawned on him - “I wonder if they noticed we’ve been missing from school.”

The short answer was yes. The school had noticed. On a normal day that would not have been the case - it wasn’t the first time we’d ditched school for the docks - but what had occurred was that the storm had caused a county-wide tornado warning. The tornado warning required that the teachers all report to the gymnasium with their classes, where full attendance was taken and corroborated against the homeroom attendance from that morning. Two students, of course, could not be accounted for - and that was how we got caught and suspended from school - a suspension that would, for me, mark my last day of formal schooling.

Six

I had been suspended for two weeks and had not yet come to the conclusion that I would not be returning. That decision was the result of several events that took place during the interim. Benny had been placed on a strict regiment by his father - he attended work with him every day and was tasked with the creation of perfectly fitted plastic book jackets for the rare books collection. Each book was a different size and thickness and so each jacket had to be cut to precise specifications and then carefully folded and melted with a special tool so that the jacket stayed on firmly whether the book was open or closed. I was not allowed to join him at work because that would have made the whole thing a good deal more fun and would not have sufficed as a punishment. This seemed reasonable enough to me, if a bit of a disappointment.

I would have traded my freedom for Benny’s punishment without a second thought - just to be around those magnificently old, yellow-paged first editions of this or that author. There was beauty and art to be found in the physical product itself - not only in the elegant fonts and antiquated ampersands and grandiose chapter titles and tiny, meticulous footnotes (it is so rare to find a well used “ibid.” these days) - not only in all of that but in the tactile parts too: the fragile binding, the warm, fireplace-like scent of the pages themselves, and even the occasional stain or ink mark that, while not desired in the

used book trade, made a book seem all the more valuable to me by virtue of its having been lived in, held, and consumed by some stranger of both time and space.

My family, what remained of it, hardly seemed aware of the little adventure Benny and I had gone on.

The police, unable to contact anyone on our property, had given me over to Mr. O'Rourke for transportation home. Aunt Reenie had been my legally decreed caregiver for several years by then, but she did not bother herself with actually attempting any form of parenting - apart from, I suppose, the ritualistic Bible that I was forced to keep at my bedside.

That night I told her directly of the events of the day, that I'd been suspended from school for two weeks. "For what now?" She asked - as though it was the first time she'd listened to a word I'd said.

When I thought about it I couldn't say that the punishment truly seemed commensurate with the crime.

"Truancy, I suppose? But really it's not as though it's something we do often. Most kids at school don't get any more than a slap on the wrist for skipping class." The problem was that this time the cops had gotten involved and there had been a storm that had proved dangerous, and so it seemed that the punishment had been determined more so by the circumstances than by the crime itself - and that should be a crime - it seemed to me to be an antiquated, utilitarian system of punishment. I was not fond of the utilitarian thinkers, generally, unless they were strict utilitarians in which case they dealt primarily in the abstract anyways, because the value of utility is not something we have the capacity to measure objectively at all the way I understand it.

"Well that's no excuse," she said. She was on the upstairs porch, smoking a cigarette and paging through a recent copy of People Magazine. "Hopefully you learn from this. What you gonna do with yourself now? You can't just mope around here for two weeks. Go see if you can make yourself helpful at the docks. Maybe Bocephus can get you a job with one of them boats. He'll be a captain soon, you know."

"I'm sorry, Aunty. Really I am." This was an unadulterated lie and I felt bad for saying it as I'm opposed to lying in almost all its forms - but I simply needed to be done with the conversation and there are many philosophers who suggest that there are different degrees of lies and not all of them are unethical (though I'm not sure this example fits the bill).

"Of course you are, dear. You ain't had it easy in life, lord knows. Go make me a vodka with lemonade, would you? Then all will be forgiven," she laughed. I made her a very strong cocktail and apologized once more. Then I went to my bedroom and read a collection of essays by Borges for the remainder of the night. It was one of the few books I'd been able to salvage from the backpack and it's pages were still damp and they stuck together as I read. His essays, I should say, have always been far more interesting to me than his fictions, which I find irredeemably pedantic.

In the morning I decided I would follow her instructions and go to the docks to see what could be learned there. I did not, however, go in search of work as she had suggested - I was more interested in study. I was known by most of the hands there on account of the long standing relationship between the Tipnams and the Graysons, and, as such, I was left alone to wander the place without being questioned with regard to my general purpose or reason for being there. Uncle Bocephus was out on a two week swordfish trip aboard the *Ellie Mae*, which apparently Aunt Reenie did not know, so I did not have a direct familial relation to help guide me around. There were both men and women who worked the boats and they were characters from a novel, each and every one of them. I wanted to know their stories. Even the mangy, long-haired dog that lived at Grayson's was legendary. No one, not even Mr. Grayson himself, could say when it was he'd shown up, who was feeding him, or how long he'd been alive. He was older than me, I'd been told before, but that was about the most detail that'd ever been provided. He'd been given the name Duke, after John Wayne, and he was a slobbery canine. He gave one the impression of being standoffish on first encounter, but it did not take long for Duke to become very amorous. He loved to lick the fingers of anyone who had recently touched a fish.

I spent the first day there without speaking to a soul apart from Duke (I hold the belief, though it is not scientifically sound, that dogs have souls). He showed me around the place at his own pace. He took us a few places we shouldn't have gone, the back office room for example where the men who surrounded the table seemed more keen to kick me out than the dog but gave us both the boot in any case. They were doing something illegal, from what I could gather, and thought it inappropriate that I should see.

Given my age I did not gain access to the inner workings of the place with much ease. To most of the laborers at the dock, a thirteen year old child could be nothing but a problem. For one thing, children are notorious for snitching. As Casper later told me, "Even the coolest, hippest kid has the capacity to go back home at night and tell his mama about the drinkin' and druggin' and stories he'd overheard." Casper was the first adult to bother to give me his name or ask me mine. For the most part when I arrived, they had whispered to one another that I was a relation to Woody and Bocephus and the old man Tipnam, but they did not pursue any direct contact.

It was on the second day when Casper came in from a shrimping expedition that he recognized me immediately, as he had been Woody's best friend, and he made an effort to bring me 'into the fold'. It was early in the morning when the boat came in. I'd been exploring the marshland with Duke, picking periwinkle snails from the reeds and chucking them out into the water like pebbles. One moment he was sniffing at a dead fiddler crab and then very suddenly he turned his whole body, pointed his snout, and lifted one of his front paws like a Pointer. He may well have been part Pointer but I couldn't see it in him. Either way, he pointed like a professional and then I said to him, "What do you see there, Duke?" and his tail began wagging rapidly - it reminded me of one of those spiral spring door stops that I enjoyed catching with a foot just to hear them whir back into place. I could not, as of yet, see even a portion of the boat. I just stood there watching Duke, wondering what it was that had his senses so

perked. Duke stayed in place, moving not a muscle but his tail. Several minutes passed like this, if you can believe it, before I saw one of the outriggers coming around the bend and then the rest of the boat followed - a moderately sized boat with a newly painted white hull with blue trim. I could see a few men on deck excited to arrive. And with that Duke turned and bolted towards the Marina, leaving me in the dust to find my way back alone.

[Need to do research for offloading scene]

Casper was his name by birth so it was only coincidence that he was the fairest skinned Irish man that I'd ever seen. Now as anyone who has read about melanoma rates in Australia is well aware, the Irish are not made for long term exposure to direct sunlight and Casper was bright red from his forehead to his belt buckle. He didn't seem to notice in the slightest but I felt pained just looking at him.

I was standing by the ice machine, catching the hot breeze from its fan, when Casper approached me, still shirtless. He was thin bodied everywhere but his forearms, which were massive. He had tattoos scattered about his torso and arms, one on his neck and another that covered most of his left shoulder blade. He walked up to where I was standing, Duke at his heel, and he pointed to one specific tattoo on his chest - I could make out the name Woody and understood what it was he was showing me. "Your uncle, innit?"

"Yessir," I said. I don't know why I called him sir - I never called anyone sir.

"He was a good one."

"My other uncle works here too," I told him.

"I know him." It was clear Casper did not share the same warm feelings towards my Uncle Bocephus. It seemed there were not many kind words to be said about my Uncle Bo. I knew him to be a mean man and could understand why that might be the case.

He'd had a wife once - after I was born but before I can remember - and by all accounts he was a terrible husband who drove his wife mad. As it's been told to me in private, she had a psychiatric episode one evening after Uncle Bo struck her across the face. She chased him across the property with a revolver in one hand and a butcher's knife in the other. She must have been quite fast, or else Bocephus was extra drunk, because she caught up to him at one point and put a scar across his gut that remains to this day. Uncle Bo, however, must have had some sense in him still, as he ran to the waterline, knowing that she could not swim, and he waded out into the water, laughing at her, all the while his blood drifting down the Nan-Wah for all the sharks and gators and other varieties of predators to smell. Finally my grandfather, having heard the commotion from his bedroom, showed up with a strong flashlight and was able to persuade Bo's wife to drop the weapons and allow him to return to dry land. He then walked out on to the nearest dock and shone his flashlight out at Bo. Behind him, the

story goes, were no fewer than six sets of red eyes, soulless and reptilian, of which my grandfather did not notify Bocephus until he had been safely retrieved.

After that Bocephus never married again and when he spoke about women it was always in an unkind way that reminded me of that Iceberg Slim novel, *Pimp*, in which most of the men treated women as though they were wild animals to be trained and beaten and fed only what they needed to stay alive. It seems to me that one must be terribly broken first, in order to feel such things, and Uncle Bo could be said to have been a terribly broken man.

I decided not to say another word to Casper about Uncle Bo. I asked him his name.

“Hah!” He chuckled. “Woody said you talked funny.” Then he stuck out his hand and said, “Casper. But I aint no ghost.”

“William Theodore Tipnam the Third,” I said, and proudly shook his hand. I did my best to display a firm grip and maintain strong eye-contact as I’d been instructed by my grandfather. Casper laughed again at the way I’d said my name. I didn’t understand it, to be honest, how many ways are there to say a name? My whole life it has been the case that when I say my name to someone I get a half a chuckle. I suppose I could just say William, but that’s not my full name now is it? And there is something informative about knowing an individual is the third or fourth of a given name, if, that is, the purpose of asking a man his name is to understand him more thoroughly and be able to speak with him more clearly.

“I know who you is - you the one lives with Harriet,” Casper said - I could have sworn I saw him blush. “Ain’t you s’posed to be in school?”

“I was suspended,” I said - and he laughed with a great intensity at that one.

“I thought you was the brainiac. How does a brainiac get hisself suspended?”

“I suppose it was for truancy -- they didn’t really say what it was that I’d been charged with.”

If I gauged it by the response of the current, one-man audience, I should have focused my efforts on stand-up comedy. It seemed I was hilarious no matter what I said. I started to tell him the whole story - beginning with Mr. Dupont telling Benny that he smelled like lox and our decision to head to the dock, but I’d barely explained who Benny was when someone shouted for Casper from inside the dock house.

“Stay here,” he said, “I gotta take care of a few things inside, you keep Duke company. Duke, stay boy.” Then he laughed again as he was walking away. It wasn’t until he was gone that I realized how strongly he’d smelled of shrimp, sweat and saltwater. It made me think of those old books that Benny was busy measuring, covering and prepping for display. Somehow these were earnest scents.

It was an hour before Casper returned. Neither Duke nor myself had moved at all since he'd left. I have always enjoyed doing nothing. It was often said by my grandmother that "Idle hands are the devil's playground" - but I thought it was a silly, misguided aphorism. For one thing the devil was a construct - what the saying really meant was that 'a person with nothing to do is more likely to create mischief than a person with a busy schedule' - which in and of itself seems reasonable. But I take exception even with this translation - because 'mischief' in this case would be analogous to 'evil deeds' and I do not agree with this correlation. It is not true that 'a person with nothing to do is more likely to commit evil deeds than a person with a busy schedule' - evil lives on both sides of that spectrum. What I found even more problematic was that, in some sense, free time is a prerequisite for intellectual growth. How many of our greatest scientific advancements were discovered as a result of a long walk through an orchard, a quiet moment of reflection beneath the stars, inventions made simply as a cure for the idle mind. Where was the devil at Walden's Pond? Where was the devil when Siddhartha Buddha found his truth?

The need to be constantly occupied strikes me, more or less, as a methodology intended to keep the mind from thought. Thought, then, was the danger of the idle hand - and I could not, having followed this logical sequence, find any redemptive value in the idiom.

All of this is a long winded way of saying I sat there and thought about life and felt about as much a need to move as a rock does while resting in a stream.

Mr. Dupont was on my mind - when all was said and done he held at least some of the responsibility for our current two-week probation. It was unquestionably inappropriate for a man in his position to demean and denigrate the young minds for which he'd taken on the responsibility as a profession.

Benny was on my mind. He was the closest thing I had to a brother and yet he was not my brother. I had no brother. I was the last and only son.

Uncle Bocephus was on my mind. I couldn't determine how I should feel about him at all. He was my family - and when I was young he had taught me to catch flounder off the dock with nothing more than some string, a hook and a piece of ham. But he was a violent man too, and this was not to be admired.

School was on my mind. I'd started to dread going back within hours of my suspension. I learned nothing in those hollow classrooms, besides how to bend a knee - and what they did teach I found to be wrong quite often, or at a minimum in question. And I wondered about the value of an institution that heralded creationism alongside a history of the War of Northern Aggression.

Intercourse was on my mind, too. I'd recently learned about new ways to spend a half an hour in the bathroom, and that experience had led to a completely new branch of unanticipated interests. I wondered how frequently people really copulated - it could not be like in the tapes I'd found. The men in those videos barely had to speak a word before the semi-nude woman became a fully-nude woman

and they would contort themselves into unthinkable positions so that the man could penetrate the woman from a particular angle, sometimes with more than two people involved, even. It quickly dawned on the adolescent man, after this sort of cataclysmic realization, that everyone must be having intercourse. How else did all of these people come to be? For some reason it was Mr. and Mrs. O'Rourke that came to mind most frequently - if only because Mrs. O'Rourke was quite beautiful and I'd only really just realized it.

So that was another item preoccupying my mind while I sat there with Duke and we waited for Casper to return, though we did not expect him to be so drunk when he did.

Duke noticed his intoxication as soon as he reappeared from the dock house, a slight sway to his gate, and he took off into the woods (angrily, it seemed to me). I had experience around drunks and didn't mind the way they got silly and would say inappropriate things without any remorse or second thought. But most of the drunks I'd known were the funny variety. I had less experience with the red faced, angry types, which it turned out Casper was, and so I was caught off guard when he reapproached asking me, "The fuck you still doin' here, booyyy?"

"You'd asked that I keep Duke company, remember?"

"Hella good you done on that front," he said.

"He only just ran off - I believe down towards the bird's nest we found earlier."

Casper laughed in a mean way. I couldn't understand why he seemed so upset. I knew that he was drunk, of course, but at the time I only knew alcohol to lift the spirits of man, never to cast such a malevolent look in his eye. "What do you want from me, boy?" he said.

Truly, I wanted nothing. It was he who had approached me. I disdained illogical lines of thought.

"I was only listening to what you said, Mr. Casper."

It was then that a young black woman who worked with her husband on a crabbing operation saw Casper leaning this way and that, and she must have seen the deranged sort of look that was set across his face, because she walked over quickly and raised her voice. "Casper let that boy alone!"

He turned to face her in slow motion. Her husband stood beside her. They'd only come down to the dock to collect a bit of money they were owed by Mr. Grayson. Her husband was a big, strong man - he had the type of body I'd never seen on a white man before with large bulging biceps and neck muscles that seemed to extend all the way into the back of his head. He must have been six foot three, I could not even venture to guess his weight. At the sight of her husband Casper lost the grin he'd been sporting when he turned around. I felt quite frightened at that moment.

Casper spoke, "I's just testin' his mettle." Then he leaned back towards me and rapped on the top of my head as though it were the lid of a garbage can, nothing too hard, but it wasn't gentle either. "Stainless steel trap," he said. And then he turned and walked back towards the dock house.

I was grateful for the black couple who'd scared him off. I wanted to let them know as much - but they quickly got into their truck, made a three point turn, and drove back off down McCallan Road.

Seven

I am nearing the date of my thirty-seventh birthday, November 30th, which just so happens to be the birthdate of Winston Churchill, who I often cite as one of my favorite historical characters. It is still warm here on the island and I spend much of my time out on the porch reading. I've put up mosquito netting around the entire front porch and it has made the experience altogether more enjoyable.

Yesterday was another Sunday dinner at my grandmother's house. She is as healthy as a horse, it seems - healthier than Harriet, to the eye at least.

Harriet has some sort of disease that I have ascertained was contracted in an embarrassing way, and it makes her look as though she's always tired no matter how much she's rested. Her eyes bulge substantially in their sockets (which is a symptom of another of Harriet's conditions, hyper-thyroidism). Her skin is blotchy - light red areas against pale white skin, as though her blood were distributed unevenly across her body. Her fingernails curl back into thick, sharp points - reminding one of the wicked witch from "The Wizard of Oz". She also smokes almost forty cigarettes a day which has contributed to a smoker's cough that has steadily grown heartier over time.

Grandmother, on the other hand, is a short but well-built bulldog of a woman. She wears exquisite jewelry from the moment she wakes until she takes them off before her evening bath (which she takes religiously). She has strong, thick calves and has all her life had thick, curly brown hair, worn short. She has a single tattoo of Rosie the Riveter on her left arm, and she always wears the sleeve of that arm rolled up to ensure that it is displayed.

Yesterday's dinner turned out to be an interesting one. Grandmother had made chicken with rice, peas and gravy, a favorite of mine. Harriet arrived five minutes late, breaking a cardinal rule in the Tipnam family, and she brought a man with her, unannounced. Grandmother was very distraught, she had not known there would be a fourth guest. She always made enough food to feed a family of ten, but if she'd been made aware she would have cooked for a family of fourteen. She quickly made up a fourth place setting.

I recognized the man Harriet had invited to dinner. He was an older man with a long white beard and a big protruding beer gut. I estimated he was twenty years her senior, a septuagenarian, but still in good health, perhaps as a result of the physical labor his profession had demanded. He owned a farm on the far side of the island where he grew seasonal fruits and vegetables that he sold through the local farmer's market as well as a small network of roadside stands. His farm was well known on the island because of the "haunted house" he hosted every year for the entire month of October. The entire month of September was dedicated to redecorating the old farmhouse, creating his frightening installations, and the cutting of a cornfield maze. His farm was also considered to be the premiere pumpkin patch in the entire county - many people would come from off the island just to select a perfect specimen for their doorsteps or classrooms. It was not more than a few years ago that a particularly rainy hurricane struck the island the week before Halloween. Hundreds of pumpkins, which of course are mostly hollow, were swept up in the flood waters and carried across the island like toy boats. They were found in locations more than 3 miles apart. Three of them floated all the way to Tipnam land and I invested a great deal of time that year into carving them into detailed portraits of classic horror-film serial killers. I am skilled with the written word but visual arts escape me and all of my portraits ended up looking like plain old jack-o-lanterns in the end.

Harriet had long since stopped talking about the day she would get married - she'd resigned herself to life as an old maid by the time she was forty. As such the unexpected guest came as a genuine surprise to both grandmother and myself.

The man's name was Darrel Halfburn and it turned out he remembered my grandmother from childhood, when he was just a boy and she, ten years his senior, was a voluptuous waitress at the Carolina Cafe - that job lasted until my grandfather wed her, impregnated her, and told her to stop working at the age of twenty three. If she remembered him she did not say it. He mentioned an older brother of his that she might have known, but the name didn't ring a bell.

He made pleasant conversation. He also made his intentions with Harriet clear by reaching to hold her hand, on top of the table, while we sat around waiting for the kettle to heat after dinner. My sense was that grandmother was unhappy with the man's presence, but for what specific reason I wasn't sure. He gave off the impression of being a kind, reasonable man, who did not want to spend the remainder of his days alone. He'd lost his first wife to breast cancer almost twelve years prior. Perhaps grandmother did not like his age, or perhaps she *did* remember his older brother and knew something that she kept to herself.

But there also was the distinct possibility she did not want Harriet to have something else in her life - because Harriet is now the last remaining child she has around as company, and as hard as I've tried, I will forever be a bit too much of an *oddity* for my grandmother to ever take seriously as a companion. Thirty six years old and she still refers to me as Little Bill. It doesn't bother me much.

Whatever the case, grandmother had enough tact and grace not to make her feelings obvious. Only someone who knew her well and could read the creases on her face by depth and shape, understanding that when the line above her left eye crept upward it meant she was questioning something that had been said - or when she smiled in a particular way it was not actually a smile but a scowl - in other words only myself and Harriet, were able to see it.

During tea Darrel told us about some of his adventures with the Navy. He was incredibly proud to have served his country and gotten the opportunity to see the world while he did it. Italy, Germany and even a brief stint in Hawaii (which, he said, was a poor, nasty place and he would take our island over their's any day of the week) - he spoke in great detail about each of the places, giving a picture of the culture he'd absorbed and sharing a few curse words he'd learned in Italian.

I dared not share my own personal phobia. Here I sat with a man of the world, someone who'd climbed in the Alps, gone fishing off Maui - I was ashamed to consider myself a man of culture in his presence, but also I admired him some. I kept pressing him to tell more about Italy in particular - What had the wine been like? Did he ever manage to see the Sistine Chapel? The Shroud of Turin? Had he been to Sicily or "remained on the boot"? With each question I asked grandmother seemed to find Darrel more and more offensive to her nature.

After a second cup of tea grandmother announced that we were out of hot water. Harriet and Darrel said their goodbyes and left. Grandmother watched through the blinds as they disappeared into the darkness in the direction of Harriet's house. "A dirty old man," she said.

I put the dishes into the dishwasher while grandmother wiped down the table. We were done cleaning in no time.

They say a parent should never bury their own child. Well grandmother had only been able to bury one of them, but she'd lost four somehow, and it was a haunting thing to realize when the thought came to your head.

"He seemed rather like a gentleman, to me," I told grandmother. "Harriet seemed happy."

But my grandmother simply responded that she'd better go run her bath, it was getting late. I thought of my own upcoming birthday and my own isolation and wondered how grandmother would respond if it was me who had arrived with company. I still have some hope, you know.

I thanked her for supper and returned to my own front porch, where I sat and read a novel by B. Traven about a young man who can't seem to find a way home. I read until it started to rain, around two in the morning.

This morning I woke with a scratch in the back of my throat and a strange cloudiness in my thoughts. I anticipate I will need to take a small repose before returning to the construction of this tale and hope I

shall emerge revitalized. How strangely these ailments come and go and come and go until eventually they come to stay.

Eight

I decided not to return to the docks on my third day of suspension. Casper had frightened me a bit. I thought it would be safer for me to wait until Bocephus returned from his trip - which I'd been informed would be the next day. I decided to spend the day reading down at the dock. I brought a pair of binoculars with me, to observe the osprey should they be active.

Between chapters, I plotted ways to ensure I never had to return to school again. I could, of course, simply get myself suspended again - which would result in expulsion as per school policy. If I were to be expelled there would be no way for me to find transportation to another middle school, and I figured that this would be sufficient to end my career as a student. There were substantial risks involved in this plan, however - as the Department of Social Services would not simply allow me to drop out of school until I'd reached the age of sixteen, which was unquestionably too far away. And if DSS was involved then the police would be involved and there was no greater crime on the island than getting the police involved in things they have no business being involved in. I'd think on it, peer through the binocs at an ibis in the tree, an anhinga's snake-like head moving through the water without a wake.

What I really needed was a way to indicate that I was transitioning into a homeschool scenario - and in order to do that I needed to have Reenie on my side, my legal guardian. Reenie was a good woman who'd been overwhelmed by vices her whole life. She was pious on Sundays but started happy hour with breakfast on the other six days of the week. She liked to have men over often, sometimes more than one at a time. They were usually men from the docks, badly in need of a bath - and Reenie was happy enough to oblige. She'd take them up to my parent's old bedroom, where she now stayed, and made them bathe themselves as their first course of action. I had seen on more than one occasion a bit of money left by the front door that I knew had not been there before the man came and departed. I may be a bit odd, but I'm not daft, and Iceberg Slim had taught me pretty well what that money meant. He'd also taught me a bit about the art of the con, the value of leverage, and that people can be persuaded of many things.

It was out there on the docks, reading a history of the Romanov family, when these ideas infiltrated my thoughts - and by the time I returned to the house that night I'd come up with a half-baked plan that I believed would ensure Reenie would bend to my will if enacted correctly. As I slept that night I dreamt I was alone on the *Island Girl*, somewhere out at sea, and when I looked down at my feet they were buried in a copulating mass of snakes that I could not identify. I was too scared to move so I stood

there looking out at the water as a big wave sat motionless somewhere in the distance. When I woke I had sweat through my clothes and the bed was as wet as if I'd urinated.

I'm sure the reader can already envision the general shape of the plan. I would blackmail my aunt. The means by which I would accomplish this and the demands that I would make were still being formulated.

I have the liberty as the author of this particular story to defend myself retroactively - please allow me the indulgence. I do feel a good deal of shame and regret about the way I treated my Aunt Reenie in this particular scenario - especially because I think it's easy for one to get the impression that it is more moral or just somehow to blackmail a person who displays improper conduct than it would be to blackmail a person with a sound soul and conscience. But in truth blackmail is blackmail - the act and the circumstances (the utilitarian value, in some cases) play no role in determining the morality of the action itself. There is no difference between blackmailing a priest or a prisoner. It was no more proper to do this to Aunt Reenie than it would have been to do it to my own grandmother, had circumstances required it.

I know this now, though I did not realize it then, and in my head and heart I felt justified in my actions because Reenie, herself, was participating in behavior that opened the door and allowed me to take advantage of it. I was also angry that she was having intercourse with these men in the same bedroom in which I was first breastfed by my mother. There was an element of disrespect in her actions that I felt deep in my bones.

I say this not to seek forgiveness, but to inform the reader that as your current narrator, out of a sense of duty to the truth, I cannot gloss over actions that I myself have committed. I can explain them, and can only possibly redeem myself by assuring that I have learned many things between then and now, and what I did then no longer meets my standards for a moral and just way of living - but when I did them then I felt much differently.

That is enough hiding behind the curtain.

I needed evidence, first and foremost - simply knowing the truth would not suffice, I needed to be able to prove it. If there is a rulebook on blackmail I am sure this is one of the very first rules. You cannot blackmail on hearsay, it simply won't work.

That was when I thought of Casper.

Casper had frightened me, true, but before he'd done that he'd shown himself to be a friend of my Uncle Woody - which made him an ally in some sense. What else did I know about him? He was a shrimper - he disliked Bocephus - he was an angry drunk and quick to get there - he had a strong bond with Duke - he was very pale with big forearms.

I wondered if he'd ever been the source of money by the front door - it seemed unlikely.

I decided that I would go to the dock early the next morning on the pretense that I was waiting to watch Uncle Bo's ship come in. I would spend one day doing research before deciding on my approach - this seemed to be a considered type of approach that would keep me from doing something unwise or making decisions without giving them adequate thought.

My grandfather taught me when I was young never to make any decision with an empty stomach or a tired mind. I've always thought that was sound advice.

I stayed out there, reading and thinking, until the sun began to set. There was one particular section of trees where the ibis returned every evening to rest. Over the course of the last thirty minutes or so of daylight they would arrive in loud honking droves - filling up the branches of the tree with their oddly shaped white bodies, yelling at one another through their curved bills. They packed themselves tight into those branches - by the time the last of them had arrived one could no longer see the tree through the birds. They reminded me of school children fighting over which desk was theirs and who sat beside them. When an unwelcome bird decided to squeeze onto a branch the other ibises would get furious, audible no vacancy signs flashing sound against the dark water. They'd banish the latecomer to a far off branch on some outlying tree - where the cast off bird was more likely to be injured or killed by nature in all her sublime manifestations.

I felt on the precipice of a great freedom - but also of a great betrayal - and I felt I bore a great responsibility to fully consider the implications that the theoretical success of my, heretofore roughly sketched, plan would carry. I was struggling, though, to play the devil's advocate - I felt that whatever shame I put my Aunt through in order to accomplish my mission would be justified in the name of the desired ends - my liberty. If this were not the case, I consoled myself, I would bear that burden.

Homeschooling was a relatively new function in my home state - and I was unaware as to the red tape, paperwork, and outright lying that would be necessary for me to achieve what had become my sole mission in life - to stay out of that terrible building where children were sent to have their souls destroyed in the name of establishing social mores, grooming good young boys and girls who would be fed into the machine like pennies to a slot machine, with the knowledge that one in a thousand will pay-out, and so on and so forth.

On occasion I saw young black men, children really, working down at the docks, no more than a year or two my elder - and I could say with more than a degree of certainty that these boys had not seen the inside of a school building since the day of their birth. What luck! I thought. How had they managed it? It was as though a black child could be left alone without a soul in the world forcing an education down their throats. This was how I felt, then. Criticisms of my socio-economic literacy are merited - but I should note that it was not within the school halls that I was trying so avidly to avoid where these abhorrent notions would be squelched. In fact, as I sit here today, I should say I've seen more boys

hardened against the truth than opened to it by following the strict regiments of public school tyranny on my small island. I cannot speak for the rest of America, having not been to any other part of it since the age of fourteen.

As I thought on it that night I slept for naught and I heard the late night visitor, his quick interaction, the squeaky way in which he put his boots back on, the clatter of the porch door as it shut on his departure. I grew more and more stubborn, if it can be reduced to that, perhaps 'unyielding' would be a better word, perhaps 'certain' - whatever the case, my mind was settled: I would not return to that school or any other, no sir. I'd done my time.

I can hardly call it waking, as I cannot call what preceded it sleeping. At the hint of sunrise I got up and dressed myself for what was certain to be an eventful day. I tried my best to adorn working man's clothes - denim jeans and a white t-shirt with a small, homemade rip on the left sleeve. I also pocketed my small switchblade, badly in need of a sharpening, a small multi-purpose tool, who knows what for, and I put a small tin of dip tobacco in my back pocket for the ring. I'd swiped it from Uncle Bocephus months prior, following a particularly drunken Sunday dinner from which he'd stormed out, leaving the tin in his hat beside the front door. I took the tin and the hat and went to drop it all out front of his house when dinner concluded, but for some reason I left the hat on his doorstep but I kept the tin for myself. I forgave myself the lie, as there was only a half a tin left, and in all likelihood Uncle Bo hadn't remembered much of the night prior, and might very well have assumed he lipped the whole remainder of the tin on his angry walk home.

Now I'd never tried using snuff, dip or chew tobacco of any sort - and I was unaware that I was about to make a big mistake - but we all learn these things one way or another and this was the way I went about it myself. I'd observed the way it was done hundreds of times - the tin was held between the thumb and middle finger and then slapped rapidly so that the index finger made a loud snap when it struck the tin. By slapping it so quickly the index finger connected with the tin in rapid succession and the result was a *clack-clack-clack-clack* that was one of the most recognizable sounds in the world to my young ears. I loved the sound, the motion, the routine of it all. The next step was to open the tin - inside the tobacco would have been pressed to one side of the tin as a result of centripetal motion (I believe this is the correct term, but physics never interested me enough for me to say with certainty that 'centripetal' is accurate). In any case, the opened tin looked like a small container of dirt with all the dirt cleanly settled to one side. Next you used your index and thumb to pinch the appropriate amount of the stuff ('snuff', 'dip', 'chew' - there were a variety of terms used that all seemed to refer to the same material) - with your other hand you could then hook your lower lip and pull it outward to make space for the pinch of dirt you then would set in there. Finally, once properly inserted, you locked your bottom lip over the small bulb of moist gritty tobacco so that it appeared you had a small marble between your gums and your lip. Then you spit occasionally and the spit was black and thick and always smelled vaguely pruny. When indoors, the spitter would carry a cup or comparable vessel to collect the dark odorous matter - but outdoors it seemed there were no regulations around where a man

(this pastime seemed to be exclusively masculine) could jettison the globs of black paste, so long as he didn't paint the side of the boat with it or land it in someone's hair.

As with many other things that are learned exclusively through observation, without instruction as it were, there are nuances to this practice that I did not know about - and these nuances turned out to be fairly critical if one hoped for an enjoyable experience while dipping Copenhagen snuff - which was the only snuff worth dipping if you asked Uncle Bocephus.

Why did I take the dip with me that day? It must have been that I sensed it was intrinsically tied to adulthood, like smoking, but also with an added layer of masculinity that smoking failed to provide.

Everyone smoked -- only men with deep voices and stern, dark expressions dipped tobacco. It also created a recognizable contour in the rear pocket of a man's blue jeans - an inverse crater that had been imprinted into my visual dictionary.

While walking through the woods to the dock that morning I stopped beside a large live oak and leaned myself against its grandfatherly trunk. The air was already warm and wet and my recently developed relationship with perspiration announced itself again. I reached into my back pocket like I was reaching for a wallet, pulled out the tin, and tried the finger slapping technique I'd been mentally practicing for as long as I'd known what that imprinted pocket meant. It was not, it turns out, as simple as it was made to look by experienced hands. It hurt, for one thing, and the *clack* was not nearly loud enough. When I plucked the tin lid from the top the tobacco had not been compacted in the slightest - it looked as if I'd done nothing at all. Well, that was that, I would have to pinch the stuff myself with my fingers and try to formulate a compacted ball. It was tough to get it to stick together properly, everytime I picked it up and squeezed small chunks would fall off on either side until all I held in my hand was a pea of tobacco, pressed so tightly that the juice dripped down my fingers. I tried several more times, going back to the slapping technique, back to pinching it freehand, all with limited success and growing frustration. It was getting late and I wanted to be there early. I decided I'd just work with the pea sized bits, if I put several of them in there and clamped tightly with my lip, then I supposed they would congeal in my mouth and form the correct shape in time. I put in one, then another, then another. I pulled my lip tight against my teeth and tasted the nasty, bitter flavor. It was nothing like prunes. Almost immediately I felt lightheaded. I figured it was right to breathe through the nose, not to open the mouth unless to spit, and that was to be done often.

I had not been taught, unfortunately, the price of swallowing even a bit of the poison. But so far I had been doing nothing but spitting flecks of tobacco, and the opportunity to make the fatal mistake had yet to present itself. The tobacco had not collected together in the way I'd hoped and it seemed there were flecks of dip in every corner of my teeth and gums and I felt some crawling towards the back of my mouth - but no matter, it was in there, I set off walking again.

The first thing that happens when you gut (which means swallow) your tobacco saliva is that you feel a burning in the back of your throat and there is a mildly chemical flavor that permeates your tongue. Then there is the immediate heartburn - it comes on so fast you can't imagine it is directly the result of the tobacco, but surely it is. Your mouth dries out, and if you're like me you begin to sweat - and that sweat is really just the introduction to the nausea, which comes on quickly and violently. This, at least, was my experience as I rushed through the woods that morning. First the taste and sensation, the heartburn, the sweat, the nausea. I slowed my trot to a walk, then a full on stop. I felt it bubbling up inside of me, whatever it was. I dug my hands into my mouth and plucked up as much of the dip as I could. I spit and spit and spit but the poison had done its damage. I retched, painful bile raised up in my throat. I made the mistake of swallowing that bile, trying to save myself the private embarrassment of vomiting and the scent that might come with it.

A second, much more violent heave was the result. A bit of the previous night's greens and pinto beans painted my boots. I felt so sick - I couldn't believe it. How did these men do this all day? Did they never accidentally swallow even a bit? Later I would learn that it was actually a source of pride among the initiated, if one was able to gut their lip, start to finish - a masochistic fetish if I've ever known one.

I wiped my mouth and spat and spat and rested against another tree - only a quarter mile or so to go - but now I noticed I'd vomited on my shirt too, a small orange and brown spot on my belly and a bit of spittle closer to the neck of the shirt. I wiped it away to the best of my ability but now I smelt the bile on my hand and chucked again. The day was not going well. Even the birds had quieted down - I became self conscious of their observance - it seemed to me they must all be huddled up on their branches gazing down at this wobbling mess - how it must have appeared - this boy running then slowing, halting, retching, groaning, crying (maybe), spitting and spitting and spitting - how pitiful can one child look? I could not approach the docks in my current state. "God damnit," I muttered - it was the first time I'd used his name like that and I was surprised how little it bothered me. I'd never been one for the use of vulgarities. But I was a vulgar thing. Pitiful and vulgar. I turned back towards my house and was grateful to know that Reenie would not be awake for some time now. That god damned snuff. I pulled the tin from my back pocket and tossed it just as far as I could - which, on account of it's light weight and poor aerodynamics, was an appropriately short and embarrassing distance. Then I began my shameful trek home, all the time hating my own scent and cursing god again and again.

Nine

Reenie was not asleep when I made it home and she was full of questions.

“Where have you been?” she asked. She had a mean, tired look in her eyes. It had only been a matter of hours since she’d gone to bed. Reenie was a woman who looked fat despite being so thin. She had a wide face and her cheeks hung like jowls. She was forever pale - a symptom of her proclivities for night activities and daytime rest. When she was particularly mad she would bite her tongue against her cheek and stare at her victim. Some people, I’ve found, do anger naturally - Reenie was one of them.

“I took a morning walk,” I told her. “I couldn’t sleep well last night. I was up the whole night through.” And though I didn’t wink I might as well have.

“Is that so?”

“Yes ma’am.” Was I snide? Perhaps. Somehow I pitied her, though - I hadn’t even sought to enact my blackmail scheme and already I could see the blood draining from her pale flat face and I was gutted by the sadness behind it. God damn it. What did she have in this world? An orphaned nephew for a son - some illicitly contracted disease - a flat face and nasal complaint of a voice. Some people have it rough, whether by circumstance, bad luck, or a faulty calibration of the ol’ decision maker between the ears. Reenie had it rough perhaps as a result of all three.

“You smell,” she said.

“I vomited something awful. Last night’s supper didn’t sit well with me. Was that why you were up too? Bad stomach?” I was a vile, deceitful child. I revelled in it and then despised myself and then forgave myself again.

“You listen too much - it’s not a good way to be. I was up because I was worrying about you and all this trouble you’ve gotten yourself into. I should have you sent away, I’ve been thinking.” This was not a good turn of events - it came quite unexpectedly. I needed to respond cautiously. I needed to be thoughtful and intentional in my approach. As Iceberg Slim said it, I needed ice in my veins. I said nothing but I also did not avert my eyes from her frigid stare. “There is a boys’ school upstate for children who need a father figure in their lives,” spoken with precise and clean execution.

“I have a father,” I said. “I don’t need any new figures in my life.” I wanted to be done with this conversation. “And I don’t like having other men in my father’s house, either.” I parried.

“You making a suggestion of some sort?”

“No ma’am. A statement, more like.”

“You haven’t been reading your bible.”

“That’s correct,” I said.

“You seem to have forgotten who is in charge here,” Reenie said. We’d never been down this road before - the whole thing was too raw and complicated and altogether strange to ever address head on. Rather, we had generally lived harmoniously by ignoring one another. I was not, despite all evidence to the contrary, a troublesome child - nor was I one to cause a commotion, seek attention. I was at my best when left to my own devices.

This idea though, of Reenie being “in charge,” perturbed me in a way I hadn’t anticipated. Perhaps I had not been direct enough in my approach. The entire morning had been thrown to chaos by that ridiculous, hollow, hockey-puck of tobacco. I was now completely improvising, and it was not a skill that came second nature to a boy such as myself, the often-confused sort.

It is quite a thing to be young - particularly because you don’t know it about yourself. You’re always the oldest you’ve ever been. In that moment I felt completely, naively capable of my own self-governance and sustenance. And sitting here today, the oldest I’ve ever been in my life, I can think of nothing more than the drunk way youth finds its passage through the thickets of age, scratching and maiming itself on every stem and branch in its path, licking its wounds, jumping into the water once again. Washing itself with the water of history itself. This is how I see youth when I see it in my own thoughts - a rippling surface of water growing fuller, somehow, without referent or horizon.

“Reenie,” I began.

“Aunty Reenie. Show respect.”

“Reenie,” I began again as she huffed, but did not repeat herself. “You have been my guardian since my father died - nearly six years now - and you’ve sacrificed dearly for me.”

“Can’t you just talk normal to me?” She interrupted.

“I’ll do my best,” I said. “I know it hasn’t been easy is what I mean - and I appreciate what you have done for me and hope one day to be able to give back to you for all of that.” She picked a fingernail - I knew I needed to spit it out. “But I cannot stand for your having so many men in the bedroom where my parents slept. That is my bedroom, when I am of age, you know. And I see the tips they leave you by the door. You can’t think I’m unable to reason things like this. *My bedroom* is not meant for prostitution.” I let it sit there in the space between us and watched her face redden while her eyes turned a frightening shade of charcoal. “I have been meaning for some time to bring thi--”

“You shut your mouth boy or so help me God I will shut it for you,” and she made a sign of the cross.

Just then a shot rang out through the woods - it was the sound of a .357, I’d have bet my life on it - and there was no logical reason for a .357 to be shot at this hour of the day that I could come up with. It gave Reenie an opening to escape the conversation, and I, in all honesty, was completely at a loss as to what I’d have said next had that shot not rang out through the heavy morning air. “What in the hell is

going on over there,” she spoke only to herself. She stepped around me and reached underneath the chest of drawers that sat beside the front door. She came back up with a twenty gauge rifle [Gun name here] I’d never seen before. She looked at me then and said, “Don’t you ever touch this rifle,” and she walked out the front door towards the sound of the shot, which had come from the general direction of Grayson’s Docks. At that moment there was a second shot.

The sound of the gun shot had not frightened me - and had we not been involved in that particularly uncomfortable conversation, I doubt that Reenie would have made much of the sound herself. I decided to go change my clothes, brush my teeth a second time, and then if Reenie had not yet returned, I would head back in that direction.

I ripped another white shirt and put on another pair of blue jeans. I wiped my boots down with a wet towel. I brushed my teeth and washed my mouth out with gold tinted Listerine. It was now nine thirty in the morning or so and the sun was coming to life with full force. The old house took on heat quickly and I could feel the temperature rising as I made my way back downstairs and out the front door. I followed the same path I’d taken that morning, making note of the tree where I’d lost my stomach. A pair of turkeys bobbed their way through the trees to my left - I *gobbled* at them but they did not get the joke. The way there was imperceptibly downhill, through the golden colors of Fall’s arrival. It was the sort of day where everything looked as if it were made to be printed in a book somewhere - lightplay in the golden leaves, anxious squirrels digging holes everywhere you looked, the sound of the water somehow present without being recognizably audible. You could smell the sea, taste it even.

Then, through the trees came the shimmering of the water, and further to the right I could see the entrance to Grayson’s, two small stone pillars on either side of the gravel road that marked the spot where McCallan Road ended and Mr. Grayson took over. I crunched through the bed of pine straw and dehydrated leaves all the way up to the entrance, where I could see the commotion about one hundred yards down the road, just before the drive turns right and becomes the dock parking lot. There were maybe nine people standing in a vague circle, shape d around a figure on the ground. I knew Casper and Reenie, I recognized Mr. Grayson. I saw the man known only as Pappy, standing beside his son - he was a black man who’d been on this island just as long as my own family if I had to hazard a guess.

He worked at the dock with his son and nephew - they headed and gutted the fish before packing them out, they packed the shrimp and scallops and anything else that made its way off the boats at Grayson’s. They lived in a small compound on the other side of the docks, several trailers aligned in a circular formation like a clock with five hands. There were a few other rascal types I did not recognize, ‘greenhorns’ or else new hands sent down from up north. In the middle of the circle I now saw Huck laid in a position that did not bode well. His legs stuck straight out - his body did not seem to move.

It was as though the sight of Huck made me hear Casper - he was wailing, I realized - full on bawling, and I knew right away that the dog was dead.

I approached slowly and as I neared I understood why there had been two shots. Beside Huck lay the headless remains of the largest cottonmouth snake I'd ever seen in my life - as thick around as a grown man's bicep. The two dead animals lay side by side as though they'd been placed there together - but on closer examination I could see the splattered remnants of the snake's head only inches from where its body sat. Likewise, blood pooled below Huck's swollen head. There was an entry wound just beside his ear - blood dripped from his mouth. They'd been shot where they lay.

Eventually Mr. Grayson spoke, "The *Ellie Mae* finna be here in fifteen minutes." He touched Casper on the shoulder and said quietly, "He was your dog more than the rest'vus. Good one too. Once we offload and pack out we'll get him in the ground." Casper wiped his eyes with a dirty sleeve. He picked Huck up with one arm below his neck and the other below his belly - a trickle of blood ran from his mouth down Casper's arm. The dog had not yet gone into rigor mortis.

Pappy picked up the snake and carried it towards the dock house. His son followed behind.

Reenie, apparently bored of the scene and visibly frustrated with my presence, turned and began to walk back up the gravel drive without once glancing in my direction. The remainder of those who'd gathered around the scene now lit their cigarettes and started back towards whatever they'd been doing before the incident.

Casper kissed the dog on his bloody head and stifled one last mournful wail.

A horn sounded from the far side of the dock house - it was the clean, low rumble of the *Ellie Mae*. Mr. Grayson looked off in that direction, "There she is," he said.

"Mr. Grayson," I said, "Excuse me Mr. Grayson." He looked my way. "I know how busy you'll be here shortly sir - I thought I might be able to be of some assistance in digging up a grave if you'd like me to, sir. I can take care of that for you if you have a shovel to lend."

"You talk funny, son." Then he called out to Casper, "Ey Casper! Where'd y'want Huck buried? Little Tipnam here's gonna make himself useful." Casper pointed off to the right where a crooked old live oak stood solitary a few yards off the drive. I'd never noticed the tree before but now that it had been pointed out it struck me that it was a particularly unique specimen. Its trunk was thick and knotty - it looked as though the tree had started growing in one direction and then one day, for no particular reason, decided to redirect itself at about a sixty degree angle, but must have thought better of it after some number of decades because it then grew directly upwards again before spreading out its long branches that sank again down towards the ground up until the place where they'd been necessarily trimmed back to keep the driveway clear. Casper later told me that there was not a tree in the world that Huck had preferred to piss on or lay beside. He said he'd always figured that's where he'd find him when it was his time to go - but on account of his unnatural departure it only made sense that this would be where he should take his final rest.

Mr. Grayson told me to wait a moment and then he went off towards the dock house. A few minutes later Pappy came out with a shovel in one hand and a small hand ax in the other. "This'uns for them roots," he said, handing me the ax. "Watch you don't lose a finger," he said, and then he held up his left hand to me and I saw that his ring and pinkie finger were only stubs.

"Yessir," I said, taking the ax from him first, setting it at the base of the tree, and then returning for the shovel. The shovel came to two points, rather than one - I'd never seen one of the sort before. "Thank you sir. I hope it was no inconvenience," I said.

Pappy laughed. As he was walking away I heard him talking to himself, "Boy sure do talk funny."

And then, "Inconvenience," he mimicked. Then he laughed again and went off into the dock house to await the *Ellie Mae* with the rest of them. Suddenly it was just me outside with a dead dog, a shovel and an ax. Without reason, I felt that things were really changing for me. Yessir they were.

Ten

On this date, November 12th, 2019, I am a slightly graying, moderately overweight man of somewhere near six feet in height. I maintain about four inches of hair, enough that it hangs just beyond my ears and in the back rests above my collar. I am thirty six years of age, the last score of which I have spent confined to a small coastal island due to psychological condition. I have a closet like Charlie Brown's - which is to say I wear the same attire nearly every day, blue jeans and a white shirt (perhaps this makes the closet more like Bruce Springsteen's). At the moment I am slightly feverish. I have a hard dry cough and a feeling that my eyes are too large to fit in my head. I've been taking my rest day by day on the front porch for the most part - Knausgaard or Toni Morrison, my two companions of the moment.

I had intended to quickly run through the days of my youth before jumping into the recent past, during which considerable events have occurred that are well worth detailing - but I have failed to achieve the first goal of mine at the pace I had hoped for - and still there is more to tell of it.

I bring this up to make the reader aware that I, early on, indicated I would be only briefly touching on these affairs and have only extended their telling insofar as was necessary for the telling of the events of the present and recent past as well. It seems all tied together - I have realized only through its telling.

And as I sit here, always on the porch, I look out and feel somehow that all of it is deeply connected. I mean all of it. The trees speak to one another through their roots and branches, providing homes to all varieties of winged creatures and climbing creatures and creatures that live off the tree's own decay - enveloping in themselves entire ecosystems and economies. And those trees breathing out the oxygen that we breathe in and then us, in turn, breathing out the CO₂ that they take in again to purify. Even

conversing with the sun, those majestic canopies that absorb and deflect and divide the light before it reaches the ground where those same trees have shed their leaves to be ground into smaller and smaller pieces until they are but pieces of dust travelling nomadically around the world, particles at my feet that have come from much farther than I myself have ever been.

I'm no naturalist, it should be said, but then there is the owl practically singing against the night and one can't help but stop to listen. The quick patter of a caught mouse in the darkness. It's all more than one can absorb in a single moment - it requires the accumulation of nights spent in quiet contemplation, from the same spot, the same vantage point as it were, the same seasons coming and going and the same storms that thrash the coast with awesome fury and then leave again like ungrateful summer guests, detritus left strewn about the landscape. But not merely the natural world unites us - there is a great layer of industry cast across the land like a bait net and left to settle, never retrieved as it were, so that life grows up where space allows, in the abandoned tractor where the possums make their home, in the powerline highways for squirrel transport, in the ninety degree sculpting of the oaks that embrace the roads like a ribcage, ground away by box trucks at their precise heights into a flat, boxy corner, an invisible shape recognized only in its absence so that one gets the impression of travelling through a square tunnel with no walls. And can it even be said that humankind is of the natural order anymore - or have we now been birthed by nature and become something altogether more contrived? We shun instinct and break nature's laws with abandon - and yet somehow, we grow and grow like that cursed kudzu vine, but all the while we evolve and adapt and make ourselves smaller to fit into the safe outposts provided by the earth itself. Hunter-gatherers turned agriculturalists, warriors, seafarers and artists - turned rot, decay, carbon, and absorbed for the value of our deconstructed parts. Oh we are all so much a part of everything, I can feel it in my bones. And so, too, is the story that I will continue to tell.

Eleven

"I should not like to return to school," I told my Aunt Reenie when I had finished burying the dog with Casper. It was late in the afternoon and I'd found her in the kitchen refilling a glass of white wine. The digging had been more extensive than I'd anticipated and required more energy than I'd gathered during the previous night's restless hours. There was an amount of energy expended, too, on trying to communicate with Casper - but there is no right way to address a man who's only earlier that day had to shoot his own dog - so I left it all alone, thinking that Reenie's silence that morning had been admission enough to leverage, perhaps.

I was very wrong.

"Oh you shouldn't?" she said. "I don't even know what the fuck that means."

“I’d like to extend my suspension permanently. I’ve thought it through thoroughly and should you be-- if you would just sign some papers-- I could educate myself right here without ever having to attend that school. It wouldn’t take much. I could do all the reading and tests and everything without ever having to touch those damned linoleum floors again.” I put my hand down on the table theatrically when I said it.

“When you are sixteen,” she said, “do what you want. Until then you’re gonna go to school because it’s my ass on the line when the social service come knocking. And I don’t want them knocking at all.”

“I’ll tell them,” I said.

“Tell them what?”

“About what I know.”

“You know nothing, boy. Less than that. Jesus, they aren’t lying about getting too big for your britches.”

I was stunned by the way she’d brushed my comment away without thought. Did she know I’d never really do it? Do I stink of cowardice so thickly?

“I hear you, Reenie, at night. And I hear them too.”

“You hear nothing,” she said. “You dream a bit much, child.”

I said nothing.

She spoke again, “Now fuck right off. Don’t you ever threaten your Aunt Reenie again - I am a vengeful woman - ask any man I’ve ever known.” Now I’ve been known to have poor intuition when it comes to understanding what a person means by the words they choose, but even I could feel with certainty that there was no lack of intention in the words she’d used. Evading my public education was proving more difficult than I’d hoped.

It was at that moment, precisely, that I decided I would run away. It was something I had never considered before, but now saw so clearly as my only option. It was as though I had been blind to the path that had already been laid out in front of me but now a light had been turned on - like a fishing vessel in the middle of the great nothing I saw only what was illumined by the flood lights and nothing more. There was a treehouse that Benny and I had once found about a quarter of a mile from the Harris-Parson Bridge. It sat between McCallan and the Island Parkway, a few hundred yards inwards through the woods that lined the intersection. We’d once camped out there, telling our parents that we were staying with the other, respectively - and though it hadn’t been a pleasant stay (the mosquitos in particular were horrendous, I woke looking like a leper) - though it hadn’t been pleasant it also had not

been unbearable - and when I set the two things on a scale: the return to drab linoleum hallways, or the threat of death by mosquito, I decided I'd take the latter any day of the week. This could not be a permanent solution, I was aware - but if I stayed long enough out there on my own I thought that my attendance at school would become a secondary concern. And then if I could stay just a mite longer it might disappear altogether like some storm cloud that never releases its liquid contents.

I perhaps have not been clear enough regarding my distaste for school. I have admitted a few frustrations, broadly pointed at the education system itself and the imbeciles that dictate curriculums and so on and so forth - but there was another reason that I hated the school I attended in particular. It was not just Mr. Dupont who was a racist and a philistine - perhaps he was only the most vocal. Mrs. Rectora was also insufferable, as was the fascist gym instructor, Ms. Potts, who looked as her name might suggest, round and bulbous and completely unfit to be teaching the merits of physical activity. She also had short cut hair and often mentioned the days when she served in the US Navy. Surely she could not have looked the same during those days, and I maintain my suspicion to this day that she was, in fact, not in the Navy, but instead worked in some capacity for the government on the Navy base, but I've never been presented with the opportunity to verify the claim.

But as I've alluded, the teachers were not the only problem. There were the students, too. Maybe even most of all there were the students.

They mocked me incessantly, as though it were not me that they were mocking, but the concept of someone like me. They'd make attempts at speaking with some element of sophistication and all that would come out was a British accent. These philistines, luddites - they could not comprehend the difference between erudition and the word *wanker*. They thought it hilarious to ask me "How art thou?", rather than "What's up?" or "How's it going?", to which I would have responded in all seriousness and without a hint of confusion - but when they asked me "How art thou?", all the while snickering in their huddled gatherings, I struggled to grasp the insinuation.

It took Benny explaining it to me, that this was their interpretation of my vocabulary and manner of speaking. And it annoyed me to no end because I would never say something like that. *How art thou??!!* As though I'd learned to speak only in antiquated cliché and hackneyed platitudes. A dumb lot, but I could even forgive them that. The biggest issue was that forty percent of them, that is to say the majority of the white population, were incredibly arrogant and bigotted and outright mean to the other sixty percent of the population, who were either not-white, or not-southern or spoke funny, or dressed funny, or perhaps just didn't enjoy fishing or hunting, or didn't know where their father was, or whatever made anyone any bit different from the tightly constructed, adolescent expectations of a *true southern* boy or girl. There was an invisible hand guiding the segregation that defined everything from seating positions at the lunch table to the routes taken by school buses to the food served to the new investment in basketball facilities to the cost of "field trips". It's not that there was anyone outright dividing up the haves and have-nots, rather that the way of the world had somehow done it for us. And

it was not until I'd read much, much more, that I understood the way ideology rains down from the clouds, so that it cannot be traced to a simple source.

By the other sixty percent I was treated more kindly in some ways, but by this I only mean that I was ignored altogether. There was not a group that would welcome me - the child of dilapidated aristocracy, who spoke like he'd been written by some European thinker (I do not assume to not this highly of myself, it should be noted, but these are the ways in which I was interpreted, you'll understand) - they, like all people who are not allowed by the leading strata of their peers to participate as equals, also had a bad taste in their mouths for someone who was "not-them". It was in this way that I felt isolated from the rich children of white *generational families* while simultaneously being unwelcome among the black population, the hispanic population, the band members (I could not play an instrument despite my keen interest in classical and romantic composition). The loners even rejected me on inherent principle. Though I'd been cast as a loner myself I felt so far from it - I was hungry for interaction, but I wanted it to be with the young, promising minds of my generation. I wanted to discuss Twain at the lunch table, not *Mortal Kombat*, and only Benny was willing to sit and let me talk about such things - in part because of his father's profession, and in part because he knew that when he went to class the other children would not make the same gestures behind his back, whisper the same old "How art thou?" as he walked down the hallways between bells.

Benny was an athlete and this was to his benefit in the social sphere. He was no all-star but he could hold his own and he made a name for himself on the playground for being a particularly scrappy rebounder and never seemed to miss the basket when he jumped back up to return it to the hoop.

Basketball was a great equalizer in those days - the white athletes and the black athletes were no different when running up and down the hot blacktop - except on the occasions that Benny caught flack for wearing Chuck Taylors instead of Jordans, which were surprisingly frequent.

When Benny played ball I watched, making sure all the while not to come off as a homosexual. To this end I didn't cheer for Benny at all - rather, I'd watch the game expressionlessly, and only after the bell had rung letting the students know that there were only ten minutes remaining to get to your fifth period classroom, only then I would approach Benny and comment on the impressive way he'd ducked under an opposing team member rather than immediately returning to the hoop, so that the opponent sailed passed him, allowing free access to the backboard and rim. He didn't pay much attention to my commentary but he didn't mock it either.

For my part I tried my hand at everything from wall-ball to four-square to a brief minute and a half stint on the basketball court, during which I caught a ball quite directly with my nose and the court had to be blocked off for the remainder of the period while the cleaned the blood. Needless to say, none of my attempts made me more acceptable to the status quo, and the final event on the basketball court even had the opposite impact, after which many jokes were made at my expense even when I attended the games purely as a spectator. They called me "Dicknam" for a while, which wasn't particularly clever,

but then I wasn't notable enough to even maintain a nickname and eventually it all came back to "How aarrttt thouuu??"

I art fine, I should have said - What do you know of art, troglodytes?

I did, in earnest, attempt to befriend two or three other students (apart from Benny) during my tenure at the middle school. One of them was a tall black boy named Trey. Trey was not his real name, it was his nickname on account of him being the third in a lineage of men with the same name. But when I asked him what that actual name was he would never say. While eating lunch, seated by myself on the bleachers, one sunny afternoon - I'd noticed him sitting by himself a few benches above me, and I asked him what sort of instrument he carried in that big black case of his. He played trombone in the school band and I asked him all sorts of questions about why he'd chosen the trombone and what it felt like to perform in front of the entire school - but he was shy and not particularly eloquent and all he ever told me about that was how it made him nervous and he only did it because his father would have beaten him if he came home from school before five. His father played trombone too, as did his grandfather, and being that he was a *Trey*, it made sense that he would do the same. But Trey hated the trombone, and I came to find he hated his father too. We talked about it on the bleachers between bites of bologna sandwiches and Lay's potato chips. Then one day a few weeks into school Trey was taken out of class and never returned again. It was rumored that his father had gone insane and Trey and his mother had been forced to move back in with her parents, somewhere upstate. It was a shock to the system, undoubtedly - I'd been so excited to have found anyone besides Benny who didn't find my questions downright silly - but just as quickly as I found him, he was gone.

It was soon after that I met Gloria - she was a first generation American born of El Salvadoran parents. Her father worked long hours for a lumber supply company on the island and her mother cleaned houses while she attended school. Gloria was a chubby girl but still with the body of a child - I remember having the very distinct impression that adolescence would change her more than it did for the average child - and when we reconnected later on in life it had turned out that I was very much correct. She'd grown much slimmer and only retained from her youthful appearance the roundness in her face. Even the way she smiled through her eyes had changed by then.

It was in gym class with Ms. Potts that Gloria and I first met - the second semester of the same year in which Trey and I had met, become friends, and parted ways. Gym class had never been my favorite class before middle school, but once I began my career as a heavy *perspirationist* I found I liked it even less than I had before. I changed clothes for gym, as was required, but we were only given a few minutes to change back into our school clothes at the close of the period and that was far from enough time for my body to return to its normal, only semi-sweaty, state. It was not only that I had begun to sweat so heavily at this time, but that my sweat was particularly odorous, and so I would lather on additional deodorant and douse myself with Axe body spray - but after a few weeks of this my Geography teacher pulled me aside after class one day to tell me that I was "over-applying" the spray in

particular and asked that I consider “moderation”. In this way I felt that I was being unfairly subjected to ridicule by virtue of being required to take this class on physical education despite my, easily displayed, spectacular comprehension of the mechanics of walking, running and even jumping rope - but to require it as a class that led directly into sixth period seemed, to me, somewhat sinister.

Because of this I soon began finding ways to avoid the more sweat-inducing components of gym class, and Ms. Potts quickly noticed. If it was dodgeball day, for example, I’d take a quick thud to the orbital socket and make my way to the bench where I’d explain I could not return due to vision impairment.

When it was demanded we run the mile I wore a pair of work boots to school and explained to Ms. Potts that I had work to attend directly after the school bus dropped me off at home and I could not risk the need to change shoes before attending to my duties as it was late in the year and sundown would only allow me fifty minutes to complete an hour-long job. Once I put a dollop of antibacterial soap in my left eye while the other boys changed clothes in the locker room. I told Ms. Potts I had pink eye but she did not agree.

Gloria, it seemed, found my creativity inspiring. She would come into gym class with a bandage wrapped around her ankle, or a roaring cough, or (one I learned from her) a migraine headache. A migraine headache cannot be confirmed as present by even the most sophisticated science on the planet, nor can it be denied by the most authoritarian of gym teachers - you cannot simply tell someone that they do not have a migraine. And Gloria got them constantly - sometimes they seemed so real she fooled even me. Once she came in with a black eye - but I do not believe that injury was intentional, and I never thought it proper to ask.

Because of our frequent maladies we found ourselves seated next to each other on the sideline for forty five minutes or so with some consistency. At first we did not address one another. Gloria would work on math problems while I drew up maps of imaginary locations in my personal notebook. She played coy for quite some time before finally asking me what it was that I was always scratching away at on that pad of mine.

“Just some maps,” I told her.

“Of what?” She asked.

“Different places,” I said. “Not real places. Well, sometimes real places. But mostly not real places.”

“Can I see one?” She asked. I was appalled by her directness if I am being honest. But in some way I guess I also found it refreshing. Someone who wanted to see what I was doing - I put aside my issues with her having asked so bluntly and showed her what I’d been working on. That day it was a map of a city I’d imagined - there was a central government area which was highly restricted, ovular in shape - and then the roads of the city shot directly off of it in all directions. I explained that there was also a tunnel that ran beneath the government center that could be used by the residents of the city to cross

from one side to the other without having to circumnavigate the entire complex. Gloria suggested a second tunnel, and a way to draw it with a dashed line that would indicate it was subterranean. I resented her contribution but realized very quickly she was thinking clearly, I had missed quite a simple improvement, and I thanked her before going back to my map. I still had not named the place.

Later that day, on the bus ride home, I thought of Gloria. The bus ride was one long winding trip down McCallan Road and I was one of the final stops - this gave me ample time to read, in most cases, but on this day I couldn't keep myself focused on the words on the page. I was reading Stephen King's *The Shining* and kept finding myself wondering if it could be called, "literary fiction," or if, rather, it belonged shelved in the other parts of a bookstore, amidst the genre authors who wrote and published paperback best sellers in a truly industrialist fashion - as though it was the mass production and efficiency that was most impressive about the work and had less to do with the art itself, if it could be called art. On this day I was fairly well settled that King was a pile of rubbish - his stories were made purely for entertainment, and the thin strands of *philosophy* that ran through them were like *diet* versions of true storytelling.

(It is not without some semblance of irony that I put down the words in the above paragraph - as I'm certainly no Nabokov and the yarn that I'm spinning in the writing out of these stories likely falls well short of the bar set by Stephen King, who is undoubtedly one of the cornerstones of American literature - I wish to remind the reader that the man who tells this tale is presenting from some remove and does not truly feel superior to the great novelist so critically attacked in the previous passage. Blame Gloria.)

I wished Gloria shared my bus route - there were only four busses that covered the island and of course mine was filled with the students who talked of nothing but video games, cheerleading, newly learned vulgarities, what breasts or penises looked like, and occasionally the oldest of which would navigate to the far rows of the cabin where they sloppily sucked each other's faces and necks and even some other things that were rumored to occur but I never could personally say to have witnessed myself.

I went to sleep that night thinking up new maps I might draw. I'd include a map key, moving forward. Even her simple observation about the addition of an additional tunnel had seemed, to me, revelatory. And the dashed line - how had I not considered it? How many other kinds of lines could be implemented to add depth and nuance to the maps I was creating?

For no particular reason I decided I would not tell Benny about Gloria. It was rare for me to withhold anything from Benny, but somehow this was precious. From my current remove I can say that I, undoubtedly, felt the stirrings of romantic passion for the first time in my adolescent life. Whereas with Genevieve I had been a mere child, play-acting a role that seemed to be normative behavior, with Gloria the sensations I felt were internally born, intuitive and genuine.

The next day I went to gym class with an ear infection, but Gloria was well and did not sit out. It would be another two weeks before our ailments surreptitiously found us isolated from the rest of the class - and in that time I'd built an entire world I wanted to share with her - but I will have to get to that later.

These were a few of the things I thought about as I packed my bags to run away.

Twelve

I woke early to pack my belongings in a military rucksack of unknown origins. It had been sitting in the attic for as long as I could remember but no one had ever laid claim to it. Had we not been the original owners and builders of the house I might assume it had been left behind by some previous tenant. I took the bag down to my room and locked the door behind me.

It was an old green nylon bag with more straps than you could count. On one side of the bag, the side that would rest against one's back, was a strong, slightly curved, aluminum frame (also olive green, everything on the bag was olive green) that was taller than the bag itself. The concept behind this contraption seemed to me to be two fold. One, it provided support for lugging large amounts of weight, redistributing the weight of the bag in order to protect one from straining their back on long journeys. Second, one could use the frame in conjunction with bungee cords to add items to your haul that would not fit in the bag itself. There was a waist strap attached to the bottom of the frame that was used to tighten the rucksack to the body, which would have been one of the more beneficial components of the whole deal had I not been too small to properly fit the gear. The main pack was about half the height of the frame. It had a cinch to close off the bag and a flap that came down over the top of the cinch. There were large pockets on the exterior where a soldier might hold a canteen of water, some rations perhaps - and I noted they were large enough to fit a trade paperback without bending or creasing the book.

I shouldn't need to reiterate that all of it was solid Army green. The modern US military has adapted its uniform to camouflage in desert environments - but this bag was made for the earthy greens and browns of the jungle, or in other circumstances the thick reeds of a coastal island, the heavy growth of its interior swamps and plantlife.

I found the bag to be surprisingly large inside - it must have been invented by the same person who'd created the bag Mary Poppins carried. When it came to clothing, I provided myself with two of everything (in addition to the clothes on my person, which is to say three of everything total). Two pairs of socks, two t-shirts, two pairs of briefs, two pairs of denims - I even brought two hats, as I had a propensity to sweat through hats very quickly and would find it incredibly inconvenient to have only one wet hat to wear around. Hats were a necessity for me more than most because I wore seeing

glasses and as such could not wear sunglasses to block the ferocious midday sun - the only solution for this I'd found was to wear a brimmed hat at all times.

When I went to pack my first book, Hesse's *Siddhartha*, I felt something at the bottom in one of the exterior pockets. Inside I found two necklaces, one silver and one gold, and seven gold rings that varied in size and shape. They looked like wedding bands to me. I took the items and stowed them away in the back of the drawer of my bedside table. In one of the pockets on the right handside I found a small pocket knife that remained in relatively good condition. I could still open each tool in the contraption, and when I rubbed one blade flat against my finger I could feel it still held an impressive sharpness. It was almost as though it had been freshly sharpened. The handle of the blade had been made with small dimples that covered it from top to bottom except for one small area in the center where the raised letters, "U.S." could be made out, worn by time but still easily legible.

I hadn't known anyone in my family to have been a soldier, but I could be certain this was a soldier's bag. This is something that bothered me later in life, but in the moment meant nothing to me - things in that house came from all varieties of people and places and many of them preceded my own consciousness. A boy's childhood house is much less wondrous to him when he is actually in his own childhood and only takes on that reverential air of *history* once the boy is no longer a boy and cannot, no matter how hard he tries, recreate the newness of the world as it had felt then.

The pocket knife would prove valuable so I put it in my hip pocket. I replaced it in the bag with a heavily dog-eared copy of *The Call of The Wild* and didn't feel a bit embarrassed about it - being some sad, underaged, diluted imitation of Christopher McCandless. I hadn't even heard of *Into the Wild* in those days.

It was after I closed that strap that I felt my first inkling of fear. I had no idea what else I needed.

Rations and water, of course. Some money, certainly (I would need to take trips to the store for necessities at a minimum) - but what else? I decided on the following items: A lightweight blanket, a tactical flashlight, a small pillow, a lighter, my grandfather's broken pocket watch, and (because I did not have a gun) a high-powered slingshot that I'd built with the assistance of my Uncle Woody, and knew had the capacity to take a squirrel from a tree with the right ammunition. It was a welded steel contraption with a high-tension resistance band and a pocket for the pellets made from the hide of the first and only deer I ever shot.

I filled a flask with water and took some pre-packaged crackers, the unnatural orange, square sort, with peanut butter filling. I had three hundred and fifty dollars in a coffee can that I put in a ziploc baggie to protect it from rain. I must have been completely prepared.

Even then I might have known that it was funny. But the truth is I don't remember myself well enough to know for certain how I truly felt. Sometimes, even now, I feel like I stumble upon the way I'm really feeling - as though everything I'd been feeling up until that point was somehow a distorted version of

my thoughts, something indescribable has shifted and now I know that what I feel - what is at the *root* of my thoughts - not the *foliage*, which is fickle in its health and dies at the first glimpse of winter. I don't even notice it now until it happens - so I certainly can't remember from back then. And, now that I'm thinking of it, I would need these two semblances to coincide, in a way, I would need to have my new found clarity revealed to me in the present, like the removal of a mask you hadn't known you were wearing, and remember this moment in which I had done the same thing.

But let me stop, I shouldn't think this hard. I think I may be feeling ill again. This sickness is beginning to wear me thin and it's only by pure necessity that I continue to write these things down.

Sometimes, these days, I wish desperately that I had a family. Writing all this has made me feel it worse than ever. It's almost laughable to think that I'd been looking for catharsis.

What else do you need to know? I left my childhood home and made it to the treehouse. The walk was uneventful. The most notable thing of the trek was that, while crossing some particularly murky coordinates, I saw the largest alligator I'd ever seen in my life. It didn't bother to look at me and I didn't let on that I'd been startled. I saw no reason to consider it an omen.

The treehouse was in worse shape than I remembered it. The ladder to reach the promenade was composed of two by fours that had been nailed into the tree trunk haphazardly. Many of the boards had begun to rot and one of them had split in half between the two nails, and now was two smaller pieces of rotted two by's that hung vertically with nails driven right through their centers. I was impaled by a mammoth splinter on the fourth rung (fifth, if you count the broken board I'd bypassed) - it was more like a toothpick and went deep into the pad of my left hand. I had to continue climbing though, and could of course not use my other hand to pluck the splinter without taking a fall from the height of a basketball hoop. Each grasp of the left hand as I continued upwards made me grimace in pain. I reached the top and flung my sack over. It took several attempts to gain the necessary momentum. Then, finally I hoisted myself up onto the platform and breathed a sigh of relief.

The platform was built around the trunk of the thick tree and extended out into branches which had grown, substantially it seems, since its construction. Some of them grew down into the platform and were now in the decades-long process of deciding whether to break or divert themselves around the unexpected barrier. The tree was, of course, a large live oak. When I am telling this story and refer to a tree of any merit, it can almost be assumed I am referring to a live oak as they are the trees that make up the soul of the island. There may be a larger *quantity* of pines, but they fail to exude the same natural command of the scenery and as such seem like stage props. The boards that make up the platform were all very warped by weather but still strong at their cores - they were swollen and depressed and cracked in some places. The whole thing was in need of a serious sweeping. There were small acorns strewn about, a thin layer of pine straw haloed the tree trunk, bird shit of at least three varieties had artfully decorated the surface. Then I saw evidence of human activity and it bothered me -

who else had been here and could they come back? There were two crushed cans of Keystone Lite, several cigarette butts in a pile, and what seemed to me to be a torn off bit of a white sock lay wet and plastered to the wood near the trunk. I'd failed to bring a broom.

All in all I realized I'd been rash in my decision to run away. Reenie certainly hadn't even taken notice yet, if I returned now I might as well have just gone off to the docks for the day - I knew I needed to spend the night there if my efforts were to have any impact. How quickly I had gone from anticipating a life on the road, to considering a return to my own familiar, familial incarceration. I decided to read a bit of *Siddhartha*, which had been recommended by Mr. O'Rourke as a "necessary book for any young man to read upon reaching a certain level of maturity," which was, of course, a compliment. I knew as a matter of fact that he had not recommended the book to Benny.

I found the first few chapters to be a real bore. We already know how this story turns out, I thought, and as such I didn't find *Siddhartha* nearly as compelling as the other figures in the story - his father, most of all, who tries his best to stop his son from jumping into a life of asceticism, only to be defeated by *Siddhartha's* ability to *wait*. That was all. The kid waited through the night which thoroughly impressed his father, and after checking three or four times to see if *Siddhartha* was still waiting for an answer the father gave in. I read and reread this interaction - *Siddhartha* wants to join the ascetics, he wants to sacrifice his comfort to go off in search of the *atman*, which seemed, to me, to be an Eastern translation of the word "enlightenment" (connotations withstanding) - which I found noble as all hell but not noble enough to weaken a good father's resolve - not that I had much to compare it to. I guess, in a way, my father had done the same thing, just less resistance.

Before I knew it the sun began to set and I wondered if Reenie was worrying over me yet. My flask of water had run dry and I'd eaten all my crackers. In the morning, I decided, I would venture to the gas station (no more than a ten minute walk), and I would pick up some essentials to hold me over.

All of the things I hadn't considered now flooded my thoughts like headlights in the oncoming darkness. I had no way to bathe, cook, or use electricity of any sort. Bug spray. Sun block. Anything waterproof - I'd brought nothing at all that was waterproof, not a tarp or a raincoat or a water-resistant pair of boots (the one's I was wearing had already been soaked through during my trek).

Perhaps worst of all: I'd left Benny without saying goodbye. It wasn't Reenie, or Uncle Bo, or even my grandmother that I thought of, but Benny, my only friend in the world, and I was physically distressed by the realization.

I tried to rest my mind. I was tired from the day and thought I'd find sleep easily - but it was as though the mosquitos recognized me only once I'd laid out my pillow and blanket, and when they found me they attacked with a fervor.

It was a hellish night. I covered myself as best I could with my blanket but no matter how I wrestled with it either my legs were sticking out on one end or my neck and shoulders were exposed on the other. I would pull the blanket up to cover my neck and the mosquitos would migrate down to my ankles, which they found particularly scrumptious. Then I'd tuck my legs up underneath the blanket, but by doing so my neck would again become exposed as I stretched the blanket to cover my knees from the attacking forces. The persistence and fortitude of the mosquito, always one slap away from a grizzly death, is something to be admired for it's instinctual consistency. They were no quitters, those mosquitos - and it took them less than twenty four hours for them to turn me into one.

Some time around two AM I felt myself going batty. I'd started hearing noises and recalled the mythical black panther that locals, almost to a person, will swear to having seen at least once in their lives. For my part I'd never seen it, but I was the only member of my family who was willing to say this aloud. The rest of them all claimed to have seen the great beast at one time or another. It was somehow more believable than claiming a Yeti or a Nessie, or any of the other fantastic creatures that fuel nightmares in other regions - because a black panther was a *real thing*, so despite the fact that there is no evidence to suggest such a creature has ever walked these lands, it is at least *plausible* that one could be roaming here, even if, as it was sometimes suggested, it had originated as an escaped zoo animal or exotic pet.

I would not say I slept that night, but I did glimpse its figure. I'd close my eyes and try my best to imagine nothing. Of course, this is a fruitless endeavor and instead of nothing, I imagined I was on the shore of a churning river and the waters were rising - "No, no, think of nothing," I'd remind myself and then I'd think of an imaginary place where I might sleep the next night, perhaps on the other side of the Harris-Parsons, something with a mosquito net - I thought of meeting a friend, somehow, out here on the run. I thought about returning home and the repercussions I might face. I'd go down these rabbit holes and come closer and closer to sleep until that narcotic moment when I could almost see sleep as a form and I'd run after it and just at that moment I would recognize an uptick in the cicadas' battery against my eardrums, or an ambulance in the distance would sound its horns and I'd wonder if anyone was looking for me, which in turn would lead to thoughts of home, and Reenie, and as much as I tried to avoid it, would eventually lead to thoughts about the next morning and how it was growing closer by the moment - and suddenly I'd feel as though I was more awake than I'd been before I started thinking of nothingness and all of that - but it's hard to put this sort of thing to words, you'll understand. It's harder than I can manage, I should say.

I suppose I must have slept some, come to think of it, because I was awoken by the sound of my name coming from the base of the tree. It was pre-dawn which meant the world was not lit by the sun, but the curvature of the earth carried the sun rays such that they provided ambient light without observable source. I'd read of places where there were hours of such light that constituted an entire day - places nearer to the poles where only the incredibly strong-willed and independent choose to rest their heads.

The very tip top of Scandinavia, parts of Alaska and Canada and Russia - and that is only in the northern hemisphere - surely it must be the same in the Antarctic regions.

This was the way the light was when I woke up - I could distinguish different shades of dark in the naturally thatched roof of tree limbs and yellowing leaves. Then I could make out a flashlight coming up through the intervals in the floorboards of the treehouse. My name rang out loudly from the ground. It was Mr. O'Rourke, one of the more recognizable voices in my mental repository. I was glad he had come.

"Yes, Mr. O'Rourke. I'm up here. I'm up here!" His flashlight rushed around the floorboards as though he were searching for me hanging there like a bat. "I'm up in the treehouse, Mr. O'Rourke. I'll come down. I'll come down."

"Come on down, William," he said. I started to cry but I wasn't certain why.

"I have a bunch of--I've got stuff up here. I'll need to toss it down, Mr. O'Rourke - I don't think I can carry it on my back."

"Toss it down, William. I'll catch it."

"It's large, Mr. O'Rourke. Just let it drop."

"I'll let it drop," he said. I dropped my Rucksack over the edge of the platform. It's *thwump* echoed through the trees. Birds all around had begun to yell at us for having woken them up so early.

"I'll come down, Mr. O'Rourke," I said, "No problem. Not a problem. Here I come." But as I stood over the small hole that gave entry to the rotten ladder I realized I couldn't imagine climbing down. I couldn't even understand how I'd made it up there in the first place. "I'm coming," I assured him. "I've just got to make sure I'm not leaving anything behind. One second--one more second."

One step at a time I reassured myself. Two feet secure before taking the next step. But what about when you are at the top of the ladder, I thought, and you have nowhere to put your hands and you're standing on a half-inch plank with nothing to hold on to and you look down and the ground is further from you than you'd remembered and you know you have to get down, there's no two ways about it, but the height is dizzying and suddenly you don't feel so confident in the hold your toes have inside your boots and really, really, really you are starting to feel dizzy..."I'm feeling a bit dizzy, Mr. O'Rourke," are the last words I remember saying before I woke up on a gurney with the bright, dazzling lights of an ambulance interior slicing through my eyelids, my name being repeated by Mr. O'Rourke and a few other strangers, the whirl of a highway beneath my seat. I was no longer on the island - I could smell it.

Thirteen

A Story about My Father:

I am a superstitious man and will let this chapter tell it's own story by its absence.

Fourteen

It was late November but the hot summer weather still hung around most days. On occasion there might be a cold front attempting to settle in for a while, but as of yet these residencies had not lasted more than a few days, and were always quickly replaced by days of mid-ninety degree temperatures and afternoon rain showers. The hospital could not figure out where to keep the temperature so it was always either too hot or too cold in the room I'd taken for my temporary stay.

I'd fractured one leg in the middle of the shin and badly sprained the other knee. I'd passed out a second time in the ambulance and my sense of time was completely disoriented. I saw that night was beginning to come on - had it been an entire day I'd been sleeping? There were a few other beds in the room but none of them were occupied, nor was the chair at the foot of my bed, where a concerned family member might be sitting.

The room was approximately twenty feet by thirty feet - beds lined the walls below the window side of the room. Opposite the window side were several medical stations with instruments of all shapes, sizes, and possibly utilities. What was the rubber tube that looked like a clear vacuum hose? The small accordion in its glass cylinder? I recognized the ear lightbulb and the device that was used to shoot a small gust of air into your eyes. I also knew what the tall coat racks were used for - carting around all varieties of liquids in small plastic bags that were to be hooked into the body intravenously. It was all quite ghastly to me. Sitting alone in a hospital room with all the whirs and beeps and automation that comes with it, one really begins to settle into the feeling of being a very, very small part of the whole - a fuse with a backup always on call - no glory in the burning out.

A large, shapeless woman came into the room and announced herself to be Nurse Turpin. She reminded me a good deal of Mrs. Potts, there was not a thimble of kindness in her. Her shirt was half tucked in below her stomach with a questionable stain on the breast pocket where she had about eleven pens and a badge clipped on.

"Mr. Tipnam, I see. You haven't been trying to escape have you?"

"I'd sure like to," I said.

“Well that ain’t happening -- okay -- let me see here.” She saw. “Hmm. Mhmm. Yes.” She said, but I knew she wasn’t looking at a damned thing of interest. What more was to be evaluated? My leg was broken. Had they done some other tests I was simply in the dark about? Then she took my temperature and looked into my ears for who knows what reason. “You been scheduled to go on the table first thing tomorrow morning. Can I get you water? Anything you need?” She was already inching her way towards the doorway. I had the feeling that if I asked for anything other than water I’d have been quickly reprimanded.

Now I knew for a fact an adult would have been required to sign off on any sort of surgery and I asked the nurse who it was who’d come in to see me. Was Mr. O’Rourke still here? But Mr. O’Rourke had long since left. My Aunt Reenie, it seemed, must have been on premise at some point for all of this to be moving forward. “Nurse Turpin,” I said, “Who has been in to see me?”

“Your mama’s been here. She had to run off to work, she said.”

“My mother?”

“Yup-yup,” she said. She slipped a thermometer into my mouth.

“To work?”

In my drugged, confused state I momentarily thought I had a mother. Then it dawned on me, and it was like when one wakes from a bad dream to realize the other side of consciousness was even worse than what their nightmares had held - pity compounds sorrow. Of course I didn’t have a mother.

I had a slight temperature. I was given potatoes, gravy, beans and a slab of gray meat on a red tray. I told the nurse I wasn’t hungry but she informed me it was necessary to take down some food so that I could take my medicine. I told the nurse I didn’t like taking medicine either but she would have none of that. I was given two large pills and a cup of water.

“Has a man been here?” I asked.

“During visiting hours he was here,” she responded.

“Mr. O’Rourke?”

“I didn’t catch his name,” she said. “How is your level of pain, one to ten? Look at the chart.” She pointed to a large poster on the far wall of the room. There were ten smiley faces drawn out with a corresponding number. At the top was the sort of smile you’d draw in a diary while writing about some secret crush. As your eyes descended the poster it was like watching this poor wretch slip off a cliff and realize he was falling towards hell, where he landed with a thud at pain threshold “ten” and by the looks of his eyes and mouth might as well have just died.

“How do you mean?” I asked. “My leg feels like it’s broken - and the other leg feels like it’s broken, but less so. Pain is really something indescribable.”

She laughed at the way I’d said it, I guessed. “Are the meds workin’? That’s what I need to know. With the medication you’ve been given are you feeling sharp or dull pain?”

“It seems to be both sharp and dull at the same time,” I told her as honestly as I could. “Like someone is stabbing me through a sponge or something.”

“You are some sort of wordsmith,” she said. “I’ll up the dosage just a bit. Do you need to go to the restroom? You must need to go to the restroom.”

I told her I did not. I asked if she knew when my mother would be back. She informed me it would not be until the following morning, after the surgery, and gave me a sort of quizzical look as though I should know my own mother’s work schedule. She shook a vial of something grayish and began preparing a syringe.

“What is that?”

“Medicine,” she said. “For the pain. You don’t feel nothin’ at the moment because you already have some of this in you - but give it another hour and you’ll be cryin’ out for me, and I’m a busy lady, kay? You ain’t my only patient, you know.” I looked around the room at all the empty beds and decided not to question her. An alarm sounded out in the hallway that would not stop ringing. The nurse ignored the clanging altogether, as though she didn’t hear anything at all, and then approached me with the needle. It was only then that I realized I’d been hooked up to an IV the entire time I’d been sitting there. How could I not have noticed the sticky discomfort emanating from my inner elbow. It was almost as though the feeling hadn’t existed until I’d seen the device. She pressed a few buttons on a panel that was attached to the metal coat rack contraption - it beeped and then beeped again, three times - with that she seemed satisfied. I watched as she stuck the vial of golden gray into one of the machine’s tentacles. In no less than thirty seconds I felt I could go back to sleep and sleep as long as I wanted without a care about what environment I might wake up in. I felt that I could have gone to sleep and been transported to the moon and when I woke up I wouldn’t have been disturbed in the least by my isolation and weightlessness and I’d just push off back towards the earth and float and float and float...

Upon waking, later that night, I was startled by the silence - apart from the whirl of electricity, which was at such a low and constant hum it almost increased the silence, and the regular beep of from the machine that hung from the coat rack, I heard no footsteps in the hallways, chatter between nurses, sirens or even traffic off in the distance. It took me a few minutes to accept that I was not still dreaming. I was very cold and my throat was so dry it made me want to vomit. I made a mistake and guzzled the entire contents of the bottled water beside my bed. I began to feel a gurgling in my stomach, which I interpreted to mean the meat slab had not settled well. It may seem common sense to

the reader that I should have looked around for a way to call a nurse, and in fact there was a button right there, to my left, if I'd taken the time to look more intently at the machine with the beep - it showed a woman in a hat with a very defined figure and below it a sticker had been placed that said: "NURSE CALL". But common sense to one person is distant knowledge to another and I would never have thought that there would be a button I simply pressed to make people come running my way.

My leg was throbbing pretty fiercely. I took the blanket off and for the first time saw how it had been temporarily casted - two massive popsicle sticks and a lot of medical tape and gauze, maybe something else to stabilize that I could not see. There was a wheelchair in the corner of the room that seemed miles away. I'd lose my bowels just trying to make it there. Boy was I stuck - it was a shitty situation alright, yessir it was.

My stomach had gone to war against that meat and the final battle was commencing. It was a lucky thing that these hospital gowns were open in the back. There was a wastebasket below my side table - the degradation one faces in a hospital! - I put it in position and then shuffled my body around, shouting from the pain, and hung my buttocks off the edge of the bed. As though it had been timed to perfection, my bowels released mere milliseconds after I'd arrived at my final seated position. It was not a clean operation though - there was a three foot gap between the exit point and the final destination and not all of the passengers made it to the correct location.

Please forgive the vulgar scene but this is what happened in the hospital and it was as mortifying as you might imagine. The scent was unforgivable. It was at that point I began to scream and cry simultaneously - "NURSE!!!! NURSE!!" - why I hadn't thought of it before is still a mystery to me.

Moments later the door opened and thankfully it was not Nurse Turpin on the other side. It was a young male nurse. Out of reflex he put his arm up to his face and covered his nose - "One second, buddy," came his muffled voice. Then he turned back into the hallway and said to someone in the hallway, "We have a *shituation* ."

These are the humiliations I suffered. There was a three person cleaning squad that came in with mops and sanitizing sprays and some disposable towels. My leg hurt something awful but I was too embarrassed to speak. One of them turned me on my side and wiped me like an infant. They were a dignified crew and made no efforts to cheer me up - they simply went about their business and departed.

After the clean-up protocols had been completed the young male nurse, who introduced himself as Nurse Rashad, returned to speak with me. He was bald headed with a thick mustache. The first thing he showed me was my bedpan, which embarrassingly had been sitting beside me the whole time, on a shelf below my side table. "Did Nurse Turpin show you the call button?"

“No,” I told him. “I’ve been sleeping quite a bit since my arrival. I suppose she didn’t want to wake me for things of that nature.”

He showed me the call button, he showed me the button I could press to make my leg hurt less, it released a small drip of morphine into my IV and once I’d pressed it I felt near immediate relief from the pain. He took my temperature and blood pressure. Eventually he asked me what happened.

“Well I just couldn’t hold it,” I told him honestly, which made him chuckle.

“No, no - with the leg. How did you hurt yourself?”

“Oh,” I said. “Well that’s really quite a long story and I shouldn’t like to bore you with all the details. It was a fall, primarily. I’d climbed a tree I shouldn’t have climbed, I suppose.”

He laughed at me again. Everyone was always laughing at me when I was not trying to make them laugh - and for some reason when I tried to make them laugh I had the opposite effect. He told me I’d better get back to sleep - my surgery was scheduled to be the first one in the morning. He double checked that I remembered the bedpan and the call button. Then he left, still laughing with his eyes, and I wished more than anything in that moment that I had a mother. It was a terrible feeling.

Fifteen

It strikes me in writing this all down that I may have, my whole life up until the moment I set it to paper, underestimated the loneliness I felt by being orphaned. The fact of the matter is that I have never really remembered my parents, and for this reason I’ve been under the impression that they could not have had a large impact on my upbringing or psychological makeup. I see now that this simply isn’t true. Even while writing this all down I’ve felt pangs of sadness and loneliness for a loss that occurred before I can remember. Transparently, it has thrown me for quite a loop, and during my recent sickness I became so depressed by it that I did not leave my bed for several days. My birthday has come and passed. I am thirty seven now. Harriet came by with a cupcake from my grandmother and a small gift from her and Darrel. The gift was wrapped in newspaper, the comics section specifically, which was a subtle reference to my grandfather, who was notorious for wrapping christmas presents like this and signing as Santa Claus, which in turn was the way in which each of us are said to have learned the truth about Christmas, according to family lure. For my part I don’t remember ever believing in the fat man in red.

At first I didn’t understand the significance of the gift. I unwrapped the newspaper wrapping, which I’ve always hated because the cheap ink rubs off on my fingers and I end up leaving a smudgy mark somewhere unintentional after the fact. Inside was a small white box like jewelry might come in - I

opened that to find tissue paper wrapped around a dog tag. Initially I thought it was a cool bit of memorabilia and was grateful if unimpressed - I appreciated the sentiment, I should say. But she kept staring at me in a way that suggested I was missing something - on re-examination I saw my own name on the dog tag, William Tipnam. Then I saw the suffix, II, and realized it was my father's - I'd never known he'd been a soldier. I was taken aback by the implications.

"Don't you like it?" She asked.

I was still sick, and in no mood to make exuberant displays - I wasn't even in the mood to ask many questions. I simply said, "It's the most special gift I've ever been given," and then I told her I'd be inclined to kiss her if it weren't for the infection.

It was a lot to take in all at once. Darrell said something to the effect that my father was a great American and how he'd wished he could thank him for his service. He said it in a genuine way and I could not find fault in it. For some reason though, I suddenly wanted to say many things about my father that were neither kind nor productive, but I stopped myself, realizing there is nothing that keeps a man from being a great American and a terrible father at the same time. In fact, the thought came to me, being a great American might have something to do with being a terrible father when it all comes down to it - the toll that it takes on a man's soul and life and time - all that "one life to give" nonsense, nationalism, the rest.

It was only later, after Darrell and Harriet left, that I began to wonder how it could be that I'd never known about my father's military history. Certainly if it had been the sort of service that earned medals and commendations and hometown parades it would have been on full display. What was strangest about my father, I suppose, when I really come to think about it, is that with his death he was all but forgotten by my family. There were hardly any stories of him told around the dinner table, almost nothing said about him at all. What kind of man earned that? And what was worse, what does that kind of man pass down to his son?

I held the dog tag in my hand for a long time, sick in bed there wasn't much else to do, I looked it up and down, front and back. I felt the punched stainless steel - the depression on one side, impression on the other. I felt the braille-like contours of my own name with my thumb. Below the name was a set of letters and numbers I did not know the meaning of - below that the letter "A" (this, I knew to be indicative of blood type, should a soldier require a blood transfusion), and then finally below that, the dog tag read "Protestant". For some reason it struck me as odd that my father had had a religion. I felt the rolled edge, felt the weight - it was heavier than I'd have guessed. Then I set upon a coughing fit I could not rid myself of and eventually I decided to get back to resting. I put the dog tag in my bedside drawer - right beside the precious jewelry I'd found so long ago.

As I tried, fruitlessly, to get back to sleep, I travelled, in my mind, back to that fateful hospital visit - I remembered the next morning being woken up by construction taking place somewhere at the street

level below the window. Sun thrashed against my eyelids and my leg throbbed. At some point in the night I'd been joined by a roommate - I heard him snoring from behind a partition - by the sounds of it he was a heavy man, you could almost hear the way his chin must have rested against his chest, head tilted forward by the oversized but uncomfortable hospital pillows. For the first time I remembered my rucksack and I decided to ring the call bell as the nurse had shown me the night prior. Turpin was back and for some reason she seemed much kinder in the new light of the day - not as though she had changed, but by virtue of the world around her having shifted imperceptibly her own self was somehow not as difficult to bear.

"Good Morning Nurse Turpin - I hope you've had a pleasant night."

"Yes, just wonderful," she said. "What did you ring for?" I loved the way she got straight to the point - I was no fan of idle chatter myself.

"The rucksack," I said. "I had a rucksack with me when I fell. Did Mr. O'Rourke bring it in with him? Is it here, I mean?"

"No," she said. Then after I did not respond, "Is there anything else?"

"No, thank you. That is all Nurse Turpin - thank you very much."

"I will be back within the hour," she said. "We are supposed to get you ready for surgery but your mother has not arrived yet." I don't know why I didn't correct her. "We have tried her phone number several times. Do you have a work number for her?"

I laughed, "No - until just yesterday I did not even know that she had a job, Nurse Turpin. It's quite a surprise to me too, you'll understand." The snoring man woke up with a loud hacking cough. "I'm sure she will arrive - but if she doesn't I'm happy to go through with the surgery all the same. I'm in a good deal of pain."

Nurse Turpin was the type of woman who looked mean, and spoke mean, and even acted mean more often than not - but just behind all that there seemed to be a terrible sadness - and so one should not blame her for the way she spoke and looked and acted because one must assume she felt the same way about herself as she did about the rest of the world and that is a terrible sort of disease to carry. I've learned, in time, that this sort of person isn't all that unkind when it comes down to it, no matter what they project on the world around them - which is all a way of saying that Nurse Turpin suddenly must have realized something about me, that I was alone in this world and aware of it, and she no longer seemed agitated by my presence, though she did not say anything to that effect. "Unfortunately she's required due to your age." I mentioned something about personal agency but Nurse Turpin didn't seem to understand. "I'm sure she's gonna call back any moment now - you just hold tight, alright?" I gave her a quick *Yes Ma'am* and wondered if Reenie would show. It's quite frustrating, you must imagine,

this lack of agency I'd mentioned to the nurse - I'd have been better off as a ward of the state than in my current position.

It was an hour and a half later when Nurse Turpin returned. Red-eyed Reenie followed behind her. She wore a red and white blouse that had a missing button near the navel. Her blue jeans hung sloppily from her waist as though she'd lost significant amounts of weight recently, which I knew to be untrue, she'd taken to wearing my mother's clothes when she'd gotten too lazy to do the laundry. The nurse let us both know that the doctor would be in to see us soon and from there I would be taken to be *prepped* for surgery. Reenie sat in a hard plastic chair near the foot of my bed and nodded at Nurse Turpin.

"Haven't been able to sleep just been worried non-stop," she said. "Finally found the sandman this morning and I guess my 'larm just didn't wake me." She rubbed one of my toes and I squealed in pain. "Oh lordy I'm sorry," but she didn't look sorry at all - she looked rather mad the way I saw it. "Shit this is some mess you've gotten us into. Do you know what this is going to cost us? An arm and a leg alright."

"It should come from my trust," I said.

"Yes," she said, "that's our trust though - for me to be able to take care of you - and it aint a slight as large as it used to be." I did not know then that portions of my trust had been invested in the *Carolina Girl* too.

We didn't speak anymore until the doctor returned to give us a detailed overview of the nuances of the surgery. The doctor was a tall, gaunt man with a dark unibrow and a large pointed nose - he did not look unlike some of the more racist caricatures of Jews that one sees watching old cartoons. He told us his name was Dr. Fanta, like the soda, and then he quickly jumped into the details. The gist of it was this - two metal bars would be set parallel to my tibia and then bolted in place to provide it with the necessary support for my bone to grow "back together" in a sense. Although, he noted, neither the bars nor the bolts would ever be removed and I was destined to set off metal detectors for the rest of my time on the "floating sphere," as he called it. "The bionic man," the surgeon said, "you can tell your friends you are part superhero now."

"Hah! I'll be certain to say that to Benny. He'll get a real kick. The *bionic man*, perfect deflection tactic. I'm sold."

The doctor chuckled at what I'd said, but not the way Reenie chuckled.

I decided he was a kind man and I trusted him.

"Does she need to stay?" I asked him. Reenie's gaze turned cold on me. "I only meant, Reenie, that I know you've had a long night at *work* and I thought you might want to rest up during the surgery, which of course will go swimmingly - that way you will have more energy when all is said and done."

Reenie went to interject but the doctor cut in, "Paperwork is signed. No need for her to be here during the surgery - but we will want to discuss rehabilitation efforts, etcetera," (he literally said the word etcetera, I loved it). "The surgery should be a few hours from incision to final stitch." He looked down his long nose at Reenie and I didn't know why but it was clear to me that he was asking her to leave.

"If you return around half past noon you will find this young man a little worse for the wear but much improved in the overall sense." I couldn't have been more grateful. A few hours prior I'd been cursing my isolation but Reenie's arrival had reminded me of many things, most of all what I'd been running from, and as I sat there awaiting my fate I thought, for the first time in my life, of suicide and what it would take - if I had it in me.

I can tell you, my dearest reader, that in the twenty-plus years since my first attempted escape, that same thought has been fluttering around me like a pet butterfly, resting on my shoulder for moments, disappearing entirely at others, always soft and present in my ear, if invisible.

A man gets to know one way of the world - his and his alone - which means many a thing, but more than anything else it means that he only has the right to the telling of a single story, and the way he shapes that story is the choice of no soul but his own.

I am not a modern man despite living in a modern world, and my story is one that is served neither by contextualization nor mythologization. It stands alone and falls - it joins the crowd and perishes. And I'm not certain, as of now, that there is a place for it in this world - the only thing I can assure you, dear reader, is that by the closing pages here I'll not have answered this question in any way you might find satisfactory or redeeming.

If this be the goal, though I am late in mentioning it, you'd be best served by taking your search elsewhere. A book like *Siddhartha*, perhaps, would be best for a reader with that in mind.

Oh, it's been a night. I'll need to retire before I begin asking where my life went or what of it is left. Thirty seven, might as well be seventy three. I'll be off to chase a dream now, wish me luck.

Sixteen

Reenie did not leave the hospital that day, whether out of duty or shame I don't know - but she stayed there, albeit back in the waiting room, for the entirety of my surgery until I came out sewn up like a rag doll, and she saw that I was alive and was informed it would be another two days of recovery before I could be sent home. She was appalled, having thought she was waiting there the entire time to bring me back to the house when it all was finished.

“And two days may be conservative,” Dr. Fanta continued, “We will need to see how his recovery progresses.”

I was groggy and out of sorts. I couldn't really feel my leg at all, or parts of my face for that matter. Slowly my body came to life in the bright fluorescent light of my new, windowless room. I turned my head this way and that - brought my hands up to my face and rubbed my eyes as though I'd been awoken from a fourteen year dream. I spoke with Reenie but don't remember much of what she said - then she was gone and I was being asked to do my first round of rehab, which consisted primarily of standing up and then sitting back down again. I was told I was making tremendous progress.

A heavy set woman named Tanya was introduced to me as my night nurse. She had dark brown skin and an accent that let me know she was undoubtedly born on the same island as me. She reminded me of the call button, showed me the tin pan where I was to defecate until I was able to make it to the restroom - which, she told me, should be as soon as tomorrow. She showed me my little button to make me feel better. That would only be around for another day she said, before the pain medication became tablets. She asked me questions about my life, about school and so on, and I told her a bit about how I couldn't stand school and the way I was treated there and the way kids acted and so on and so forth.

“We went to de same school,” she said. “I feel de same way, dem kids always been cruel.” Cruel was the right word for it. “I always been fat. I was born wit' diabetes - dem children ain't kind to no fat girl.”

I apologized, not knowing what to say, “I'm quite sorry to hear you've faced similar harassment.” The nurse did not laugh but instead grabbed the bottom of the blanket and pulled it down just a bit so that my toes were covered. “Thank you,” I said - and then I felt so tired I knew I would fall asleep only moments after Nurse Tanya left the room.

That night I dreamed there were tigers on the island, in the tall grass and wading through the marshes, well camouflaged by their stripes - but amongst the crowd, one of the tigers was all white with no stripes, an albino of sorts, leucistic as it is called in the scientific community, and I followed it through the landscape as though it were leading me somewhere, protecting me from the others. I don't remember all of the dream but I do remember that it ended with me looking around fruitlessly for the all-white tiger as the thick marsh grass became crowded with orange and black stripes that seemed to pay me no attention at all. It felt, somehow, as though we were all hiding from something as a group - something large and ominous - and in some way I was safer amidst the tigers than on my own.

The next morning I awoke in a thick layer of sweat. It was quite early but Mr. O'Rourke was there. “I told them I was your Uncle,” he said. “It was the only way they would let me in. That Nurse Turpin is a tough lady.” I saw my rucksack at his feet - beside it a plastic bag with at least six paperbacks inside. “I didn't go through your belongings,” he said. “I hope I didn't smuggle in any contraband.” We laughed. One by one he showed me the books he'd brought. He gave me a brief synopsis on why they

were worth one's time. I asked about Benny, told him to extend my regards. He agreed. He told me that the doctor had indicated my surgery had gone smoothly - that I'd given him a serious fright that night. He told me I'd fallen a few feet from a stump that could have broken my back. He told me I should count myself lucky. He called me an asshole, in jest.

"I have to ask though, William - what were you doing out there? Why didn't you tell anyone?"

I thought on this a good while before responding. "Mr. O'Rourke," I began, "I can't go back to that school. I'd rather live in a tree." He nodded and seemed to understand but didn't say anything else.

"Of course Reenie would not hear any of it. She doesn't care about my education - it's not that - she just wants me out of the house. She wears my mother's clothes, you know? And it's not that I don't enjoy learning, quite the opposite," I went on. "It's the philistinism of the whole operation. They teach children about algebra and trigonometry and how certain chemical bonds interact but they don't mention a word about life and philosophy, ethics or politics. They're either racist or classist and most of the time both. That goes for the students and the teachers, by the way. They teach nothing of interest to me besides English and that I've learned quite well all on my own." I felt myself beginning to cry. "If they make me go back--If I have to go back to Mr. Dupont, or that nasty gym teacher, or...I don't mean this disrespectfully, sir, but if I'm made to go back I'm going to run away again."

He looked at me with an expression I can only describe as "fatherly," though of course I have no private knowledge of fathers and how they construct their looks. What I suppose I mean by "fatherly" is that his demeanor was calm, shoulders relaxed. His eyebrows displayed some form of thoughtful concern.

His hands rested on his knees, indicating that he had nowhere to go and there was more to discuss. He leaned towards me, a bit, but not in an imposing way. His lips were pursed in reflection, tightened against one another in a way that suggested some element of fear, but not only that, there was also something proud in it, a *that's-my-boy* sort of look that confused me.

"I find no fault in your objections, Mr. Tipnam. School can be a bit like prison given a particular set of circumstances. But," he continued, "there are laws, you understand, that require you go to school."

"Yes, I've heard. That's what I was running from - the law - I suppose it could be said."

"A regular Clyde Barrow," he said.

"More like Siddhartha," I responded - though I didn't fully agree with the comparison I did think it was a more accurate analogy than the former. I also knew it would be harder for Mr. O'Rourke to refute, given that he'd recommended Hesse in the first place.

"It seems you've reached an impasse."

"I'd say."

“You’ll have to return to school, you understand. This isn’t a novel.”

“What good is a novel if it doesn’t mean something?” I responded, perhaps a bit brashly. “I’m sorry,” I quickly tried to redeem myself. “Really I am - I um...Thank you for coming to find me, Mr. O’Rourke. I didn’t know someone would come to find me. I was scared, Mr. O’Rourke.” And then I really began to cry - it was as though I felt for a moment what it was like to have a father, to know concern, to want to be a *man*, whatever that meant. “I’ll go back to school. I will,” I told him between sobs - and when he hugged me I realized I couldn’t remember ever having been hugged by a man before.

The remainder of the day I spent attending rehabilitation sessions and reading during the intervals between. By the end of the day I’d improved quite impressively according to the technicians and nurses who guided my exercises. When the third and final rehabilitation session was concluded Nurse Turpin was still on duty - “Pulling a double,” she informed me with palpable frustration. As she rolled me down the hallway I saw that it was again dark outside - there was a crescent moon in the clear sky. I asked her to stop by a window, for a moment, if she wouldn’t mind, because my room had no windows and I’d begun to feel claustrophobic. “I’ll do you one better, hun” she smiled for the first time and then took an unanticipated right turn that led directly to the elevators. “I need a smoke.”

Something in Nurse Turpin changed when we stepped outside - it was immediately recognizable. She lit her cigarette so naturally it made me wish I was a smoker. We were in a small garden-like area on the side of the hospital and there was not a soul in sight. She took a deep inhale and blew a large cloud into the air above our heads. It was a clear, cool night - since I’d been in the hospital the temperatures had dropped substantially. I was cold beneath my hospital gown but I said nothing lest I perturb the moment. There was a clear, large crescent moon in the sky but the lights from the hospital obscured the stars I was used to seeing from out on the island.

She started to tell me about her grandson, who was a few years older than me, and apparently a very highly regarded baseball prospect when it came to his college applications. “I hope he’ll go to State, to be honest, but he has all sorts of offers. All sorts. Of course the boy wants to go to California - get hisself as far from home as he can. Get hisself away from his mama - I think. She never figured how to raise a boy.” I knew how it felt to want to get away - I told Nurse Turpin as much. “Hunny you an’ me both. I left Georgia when I was fifteen. I get it, I get it.” She drew on her cigarette so naturally it was as if she wasn’t smoking at all - just breathing through a straw and spitting out clouds. “What y’gonna do though? You leave, you just find it again. That’s what I know.” This particular sentiment caught me unprepared - I supposed it was true. There’s no running from things. It was something I felt I’d been learning over and over again, recently. But at the same time I couldn’t outright accept it, because if I were to take it as true it would mean my aims had been childish, wrong, missing the point. It would mean I’d broken my leg for nothing at all - an idea which had been slowly permeating my confidence since the fall.

“I don’t know - I’m still young, Nurse Turpin. I want to get away too, you’ll understand, I want to be my own man.”

“But what about your mama?” she asked. “You don’t think she’ll mind?”

“Reenie isn’t my mother, Nurse Turpin. I thought you were aware. I haven’t had a mother since I was young.” Then, seeing her face, I added, “Please don’t pity me for it.” To our right a single cricket began chirping loudly. A plane flew overhead, nothing but a faint hum in the distance and a blinking light that slowly crossed the sky. Nurse Turpin finished her cigarette and snubbed it out in the ashtray beside the bench. She asked me if I’d gotten enough fresh air and even though the answer was no I responded that it had been great. “Thank you for bringing me out here,” I told her.

“I’m sorry about your Mama,” she said as we made our way back to the small backdoor we’d come from.

Seventeen

By the second day I was cruising around on my crutches with ease. I was mobile, finally, so I practiced in the hallways. Taking a right out of my room I lunged down the hallway, past reproduced frescoes, men on horseback travelling through foreign country vistas, the occasional still life painting, an apple in a bowl, a cup of water and some celery, the sort of thing that bores you stiff unless it’s a masterpiece.

The sort of art that is created to keep disenfranchised invalids passive. Each closed door I passed contained some other soul navigating some phase of *rehabilitation* - a word so indeterminate I hesitate to use it. Rehabilitation indicates some return to a previous, almost by definition, improved state.

Uncle Woody had gone to rehab once, but not of this sort - and I’m not certain he came out so *improved* when the pieces were down. At the end of the hall one of the doors was open - inside I saw an old gray skinned man who looked like he might have already taken his last breath. I watched a moment longer as a nurse that I had not seen initially appeared from the other side of the room and began speaking to the man as though he were a child. Rehabilitation.

After they closed the door on me I continued down the hallway until I reached the far window that looked out on the peninsula, providing a view of the whole bottom half of the town, where the city came to a point at the battery. I realized I couldn’t discern what floor I was even on and was beset with some psychological form of vertigo - if every floor beneath me disappeared I couldn’t tell you how far I’d have fallen and the thought made me dizzy with uncertainty. I trained my eye on a red tailed hawk that drifted through the tall skies patiently before landing on a church steeple - he looked like a painting they might put on the walls in a place like this. The city itself has a varied, but always religiously oriented, history - as such the “skyline”, if it can be called that, is made quite recognizable by the sheer number of steeples that one can see from most any elevated vantage point. At that time there was an

ordinance in place that forbade buildings of a certain height from being constructed - the reason was both symbolic and practical. Symbolically the wish was that nothing in the city stood taller than the tallest steeple in the town, which approximately meant thirteen stories - in this way no part of the city could be said to have been built above *God*, and whatsmore *God* could be said to be looking over the city. In local lore this spared the city from many of the more destructive forces of both the Revolutionary and Civil Wars - particularly Sherman's March, which moved throughout the south with the seemingly entropic force of a late hurricane. The practical value was that the city was able to resist some of the more destructive forces of modernity - maintaining a clean "skyline" that would not be swallowed whole by the advancement of capitalism and modern urban architecture - which, really, is all just a way of saying it kept the city pretty. The peninsula looked like a flattened Manhattan, one might say, though I must admit I've never been near enough to that Gotham of a city to speak from personal experience.

Much like Manhattan, in fact, the peninsula is bordered on both sides by rivers, on the other side of which there sit suburban populations that have now significantly outgrown their progenitor in population. In another striking similarity - the city is primarily driven by a gridded system of streets, Main and Donohue Ave running north/south as the primary arteries - and then crisscrossed by other, smaller roads to make up the majority of the grid. Only at the tip of the peninsula does the town deviate from its logical pattern of ninety degree turns - and this is because the roads here at the tip, like the roads in lower Manhattan, were built organically, without consideration for the scale of urban explosion. From the window my eyes could follow Donohue Avenue in a straight line for an estimated half mile before the intersection of Trade Street, where the road does not *end* per se, but is offset at the intersection so that a driver is forced to take a right and then a quick left in order to continue on Donohue. On the other side of Trade Street, Donohue becomes a thin cobblestone drive more than a street in its own right - the houses on that side of Trade Street increase in value by factors, and by the time you reach the battery, that final tip of the peninsula, the houses, or I should rather call them estates, are among the most valuable pieces of property in the southeastern US - not to mention the most haunted, if you believe in that sort of thing.

Somewhere down there was the old slave market, though I couldn't see the building itself, only the gap in the rooftops where I knew its single story structure to be located. The market now served as a center of commerce for trinkets and artwork rather than human bodies and steerage - but I'd been once, on a field trip during my fifth grade year, and it is difficult not to notice the thick iron rings that stick out of the walls every six feet or so where one can imagine shackled slaves being chained up like dogs in a pound, being sniffed and poked and measured by other members of their same species to be carted off to perform backbreaking labor seven days a week when they were purchased by more reasonable members of the landowning class - in the other cases they could be beaten, mutilated and raped, separated from their families, whipped until they took new names, murdered for insubordination.

This is a part of our nation's history of which we are aware but choose not to look in the eye - as though these were the stories of a since reformed alcoholic parent, and we don't wish to bring up the days when they would guzzle a jug of moonshine before taking out the day's grief on their offspring, preferring to focus on the changes they've made, the personal battles they've overcome - how proud we wish to be, if only for our own sakes.

I was shaken from my reverie by some commotion to my left. About forty feet down the corridor was the front desk, lobby and waiting room area - beyond that sat double doors that led to the elevators. From where I stood the front desk was on the left of the hallway and the opposite site was a wide open space with mildly comfortable chairs and televisions playing muted news. The lobby extended all the way to the large bay windows that looked out on the Medical University campus across the street.

Many of the doctors here were residents, having recently finished their medical degrees and found placement within the system. The medical university here is known to be a top-tier organization and is a source of pride for the local community. There was a bustle in the corridor, people shuffling towards the wall-length window that looked out into the street. A woman in a blue suit was nervously talking to someone on the phone from the front desk. The admissions secretaries were all standing, faces aimed in the same direction. I hobbled over as quickly as I could - when I rounded the corner into the lobby area I saw eight or nine people standing at varying distances from the window, all looking across the street, where a man was pacing on the ledge of the university building, which was approximately three stories or so below us. No one on the ground had yet noticed. I heard the woman on the phone speaking with some form of emergency services. I got nearer and saw the man stop pacing now and seat himself on the ledge. A person in the street noticed and quickly there was a small crowd there as well. The man was wearing a white lab coat and even from a distance I could see his thick rimmed spectacles.

The sound of an ambulance rang out from nearby - but it might as well have been a starter's pistol. From where we watched the most that could be discerned was that the man leaned forward and then gravity took over.

He fell with less grace than a pierced balloon. His regret was immediate, it could be gathered, by the wild way he flailed his limbs. An observer who had not seen the thirty seconds or so of morbid deliberation that occurred on the roof would be logical in concluding the man had been pushed from the rooftop - just by the desperate way he attempted to cling to the air that rushed through his grasping hands - his white coat flapping madly above his head like a pale flame.

We watched in horror, and the horror was only intensified when the man finally struck the ground, feet first, and moments later a guttural scream, loud enough that it was heard through the thick paned glass several stories above the ground, flooded the air making it clear to all with ears that the man had failed to die. I don't believe I've ever felt such pity in my life.

Of the group who'd watched, the reactions were varied. One nurse fainted, another began to cry, a man in a black coat strung together more unique curse words than I'd have wagered existed. Finally, a doctor with a desperately dry throat said, "That was Marty," and began to hyperventilate.

I don't know what I did - I suppose I mostly watched them, the group that had congregated around the large bay window. In the moments immediately following fall some of them pressed in closer to the window - some of them seemed to be unable to move. I found myself a member of the other class of voyeurs, we who backed away from the window slowly, as though it were a cliff rather than a thick, hurricane-resistant wall of glass. I had to remind myself to use my crutches - moving backwards proved a bit awkward. The doctor with the dry throat was among the group that backed away too, breathing quickly. I saw him searching for a ledge or chair to catch himself should he collapse. It was as though the seconds stretched themselves for a few brief moments - time barely moved at all, graciously, until it decided I'd been granted enough time for mindful self-reflection, and then like a slinky, it constricted again and I felt as though every cell in my body was racing in different directions, trying to find a place to hide within myself.

I looked around desperately for Nurse Turpin but the three o' clock shift change had already taken place and it was Rashad, the nurse who'd dealt with my excremental crisis, who was back on duty. He was nowhere to be seen. The collective gasp of the group who had stumbled upon this viewing nightmare, though, had been felt throughout the halls it seemed - nurses, technicians and some of the more mobile patients poured in from their respective rooms and offices. They each asked the same question in different ways - What happened? What happened? What happened?

The dry throated doctor had taken a seat in the waiting area at the back of the lobby. He held his head in his hands and seemed to have regained his breath. Another doctor showed up through the double doors that led to the elevators. She was a tall woman with long gray hair to go with her long face. She immediately recognized that something had occurred and then, noticing the doctor with his head in his hands, she approached him with the calmness of a woman who'd seen plenty of death in her life and knew how it looked when painted on an observer.

I looked around and it seemed everyone had found someone to talk to - everyone was busy rattling on to one another, some of them despondently, others with angst, others even who came off relatively stoic about the whole thing, taking sips from the same can of soda they'd been holding when they watched him fall.

"Marty?" I heard the female doctor choke out.

The first of several ambulances had arrived. People who had gone to the window now walked back muttering to new arrivals that they should not go look. Even the people who had initially continued to watch on in horror now were backing away. Only one or two of the nurses remained by the window, watching. One has to wonder about that sort of person. I decided to walk back over just to peek.

The entire scene was blocked off now - the man had landed so close to the road that he was hidden behind the emergency vehicles that now occupied the entirety of the street. There was a large tent being set up - the street had been blocked and was now being taped off by security guards. It was a devilishly clear and perfect day outside.

Nurse Rashad appeared behind me to let me know I was late for my final rehab session of the day. If it went well, he reminded me, I could be on my way home as soon as tomorrow. He didn't realize that I'd begun not to mind the hospital now that I was mobile, and this provided no incentive for me.

Either way, there was nothing left to see apart from a hodgepodge of red and white vehicles and tiny people scurrying here and there, doing whatever it is that so many people do in situations like this - by which I mean walking from one person to another seemingly without aim, consoling each other with their stoicism, some helping to move things along swiftly, others seemingly stunned, just crossing the street to head back again. The din on the rehabilitation floor was diminishing. There was work to be done and there were unwell patients that needed to be made well again. Only the male doctor remained inconsolable - the female doctor was urging him to get up, take a walk, something along those lines - but he sat there with his head tilted towards the floor, shaking it back and forth to indicate that he could not move, not yet, as though he was arguing with the floor.

I considered feigning injury during rehab but thought better of it - how long could a ruse like that go on? I breezed through the exercises and listened diligently as we talked through a pamphlet of ongoing exercises I would need to maintain. After rehab it was time for a doctor visit. Within a day I'd come to recognize the regimented way in which the floor operated. They maintained a strict schedule, which made sense given that they all had homes to return to, dogs and children to feed, husbands or wives to argue with before bed.

The doctor was supposed to arrive at five thirty, by six thirty I wondered if I'd been forgotten. At seven, when the door opened, I understood why he'd been late. It was the doctor from the lobby, Dr. Cato according to his name tag, and if I hadn't been privy to the scene earlier I'd have almost certainly identified him as a man on a bender. His eyes were red and raw and the dark patches below his eyes were expansive enough they almost touched at the bridge of his nose. He sat down in the visitors chair and began to flip through the paperwork about me that was kept at the foot of the bed. The doctors never show you this paperwork so you can't be sure just what it is they've written in there about you. He did a few nods, a few *hmms*, then he set the paperwork back in the slot from which he'd taken it - exaggerating a large, unprofessional exhale (the medical equivalent of yawning at a teacher or asking a chef for salt).

"Welp," he said, "new x-rays look good. Everything in its right place. How's the pain?"

"It's not bad but-"

“Okay great, good to hear. I saw you galloping around earlier - seems rehab is going well.”

“I wasn’t galloping,” I said.

“Of course not. Well, either way, we’ll be moving you to outpatient tomorrow.”

“Outpatient. Of course,” I said. Something about the doctor rubbed me the wrong way. Not him personally, I suppose, but his position as *my doctor* made me uncomfortable. It had been only a matter of hours since I’d seen him allow his sentiment to get the better of him - this was shameful practice as far as I was concerned. His tone was that of a man who’d spent all his energy on one argument and no longer had the drive to hold another. While he was scribbling a prescription in his pad I decided to speak again. “That was quite a scene earlier,” I said. “Was the man--is the man who fell--well, is that person still alive?” The doctor did not look up from his notebook. I did not think he had failed to hear me but felt compelled to push the conversation still, “From that height there might be a chance, I’d think? Do you know anything? Have you heard?”

The doctor tore a prescription from his pad. “Would you like something to help with that? Is that what you’re asking for?” He began to scribble again. I was taken aback, I suppose you might say - was the doctor being antagonistic? I certainly did not want to be approved for release by a doctor who was in an unsound state of mind.

“No sir. I mean, no Doctor...Um, I don’t think so--well, what does--how do you mean help?”

“Drugs,” he said bluntly. “To make you forget.” We are a country in the midst of a drug epidemic - though from what I can tell the drug epidemic is about as new a problem as erectile dysfunction or schizophrenia - which is to say, just because you invent a term for something doesn’t mean it didn’t exist prior to that term’s creation. For my part, at that age, I couldn’t see how a pill could make a feeling any better, but that didn’t mean I wasn’t willing to give it a try. It must be better than drowning in booze like the other men in my family had been known to do - so I told the doctor I’d appreciate it. He gave me the prescription he’d been writing initially - eighty Vicodin, to be consumed in pairs every six hours as needed - then he began writing another prescription out. He still had not looked me in the eyes yet. “Like Valium,” he said, “but better on the body,” and with that he tore another sheet from his prescription pad and shoved it in my direction.

“Did you know that man?” I asked as I folded the second prescription up and placed it in my pocket.

“Unfortunately,” he looked at a folder on the counter before continuing - “Unfortunately Mr. Tipnam, I did. Yes.” Then as I began to open my mouth to speak again he raised a hand to stop me. “I am very far behind in my rounds, I need to be going. No, no. Please ask the nurse for a psychiatric reference upon dischar--Nevermind, scratch that, I will make sure that Nurse Turpin provides you with a

reference on discharge. I'm glad you're recovering well. I'm sorry for what you saw." And that was it. He walked out of the room and never told me his name.

Eighteen

There was not even a story in the newspapers about the fallen man - I've since learned that such accidents are not nearly as infrequent as one might assume, and that the powers who determine what sorts of information should and should not be made public knowledge all firmly agreed that this type of event, despite its public nature, was of the variety that should not be written up or addressed by the news media. In fact, I've learned that when the roads were blocked off to all traffic the only information that was provided to an inquisitive passerby was that work was being done that required the complete closure of the road that bisected the hospital and the medical university. There was no mention of the fallen man, the regretful gestures he made during his descent, the inhuman cry that penetrated the surrounding buildings when he struck concrete. Nor was it made public information, later on, that the man had somehow survived after spending weeks in the same hospital where I'd been stationed on that very day.

What I know of the incident I have learned only by connecting the elements of my first-hand experience with second-hand resources in conjunction with research conducted online. Put simply, it's what I saw, heard, and read about online. I clarify this in order to follow my own strict obligation to transparency in the telling of this story - I am being honest, I mean, even if the truth of the story is more complex or complicated than the understanding I've established in my head.

Enough throat clearing - this is what I know:

That morning, Martin "Marty" Anderson had learned that he'd failed the USMLE, or United States Medical Licensing Examination, for the third time. For all intents and purposes this meant that his career as a medical doctor had concluded before getting off the ground - he could have taken another test in six months time, per standards and regulations set by the United States Medical Licensing Board, but must have known, intrinsically somehow, that it was not in the cards for him - not in this lifetime. And for that reason, it is widely assumed, he decided to take the back staircase up to the roof of the Medical University on that clear, cool November afternoon.

His classmates, all of whom had managed to pass the test already, included the young doctor with the baggy eyes who'd seen me on my last night in the hospital. *Marty*, the doctor had said, because he'd been more than aware of Marty's plight and knew beyond a shade of doubt that Marty had been a better student than he. *Marty*, he'd said because of the way the body fell. *That was Marty* he said to himself - the way one says, *That was a red tailed hawk*, moments after it disappears beyond a veil of trees, realizing nothing more can be known about where it is or what has become of it.

Marty had suffered about as much damage as a body can take without splitting at the seams. He was comatose for a week and a half and upon coming out of the coma was unable to walk, eat or shit on his own. He'd also suffered substantial damage to his frontal cortex and was no longer able to speak in full sentences or remember the name of his fiancé.

Marty would have been better off dead - that's the conclusion I've drawn so many years later.

Per recent evaluation by an accredited psychotherapist I have been diagnosed as a sufferer of symptoms related to Post Traumatic Stress Disorder to this day - the genesis of this trauma, it has been posited, was the watching of the fallen man (compounded, as it were, by the absence of familial support systems). At first I rejected the diagnosis outright - I have no fear of loud noises, I don't frighten at the sound of fireworks, I do not sit with my back to the wall always facing the door, always. But I have done some reading of my own and learned a thing or two about the ways in which trauma can occur and the myriad ways in which it allows itself to be manifested in the human psyche.

Yes, I was traumatized, though I did not know it. Reenie came to pick me up in the morning and I said nothing as she anxiously navigated the narrow one way streets and construction detours, almost clipping a young bicyclist with the passenger side mirror. I was uncomfortably squeezed into the back of the sedan, casted leg across the length of the seat, my disassembled crutches rested on the floor. My rucksack had been squeezed into the trunk.

Yes, I was traumatized but I did not know that was at the root of my unease as I watched the city disappear behind us and we made our way back towards the island. I mentioned not a word of the fallen man to Reenie, of course not - I couldn't think of a time when Reenie's insight had proven valuable in the slightest. I simply sat and watched out the window as the buildings grew smaller and more dispersed and the view from the window slowly eased its way from man-made grey with patches of grass to earth-made greens punctuated by construction sites and modern architecture. The Harris-Parsons Bridge struck me in a whole new light - I saw first the landscape and then observed the imposition of the structure - thick pilings that disrupted the water as it passed by. A catamaran cut through the water leaving a small wake in its trail - on a tiny beach island in the distance I saw a group of boats tied off to one another while their passengers congregated in small groups on the shore. It was known as Ghost Island and there are a variety of stories regarding the origins of that name, but the simplest one is that the island disappeared in particularly high tides - one day you might see it crossing the bridge and on the next crossing see nothing in precisely the same spot.

The Harris-Parsons is not a pedestrian bridge and as such I was caught off guard when I saw a body walking up the small shoulder of the road - cars zipping past it recklessly. By its gait I could tell the body was a man's - he walked slowly with long strides and kept his head trained on his feet so that one could not see his face through the veil of dirty hair that hung down across it. Reenie, in the far right lane, was coming up on the man quickly - and like the rest of the cars seemed not to notice the man at

all. It's well documented the ways in which we ignore the destitute, avoiding looking it in the eye, walk the long way around the park to avoid the bench occupied by a supine vagabond - but this was something else, it was truly as if they didn't see him at all. The car ahead of us nearly clipped the man's shoulder with its passenger side mirror. "Reenie! Watch out!" I spoke up from the back seat. She made a concerned noise and looked around quickly. Then she took her eyes off the road and looked back at me with a quick, angry glance.

"The fuck are you scaring me for?"

"The man Reenie!" He was coming up quickly on our right. One slight veer to the right and I could see the catastrophe that was coming. She cursed under her breath and turned her head back to the road at the exact moment we scraped past the man - just barely - his unbuttoned shirt flapping up in the draft behind us. The man hadn't raised his head even for a moment. He'd somehow been pardoned. I was in shock. "Christ almighty!" I pulled out one of Benny's phrases that seemed appropriate for the moment.

Reenie, her attention back on the road, raised her voice. "You gonna make me crash this car - and don't take his name so light as that! What in the hell are you thinkin'? Are you playing with me?"

"The man," I said.

"Oh lord, he's seeing things," she spoke to herself.

That's one habit I cannot stand - a person who speaks under their voice, to themselves, all the while fully aware that the statement is being directed to another person within earshot - and while I cannot verify my suspicion, I've always been under the impression that people did this in my presence more often than they did it in the presence of others. Don't ask me why.

"I certainly am not," I told her. I looked back over my shoulder and watched the man slowly trodding on. Through the back window I saw that he wore green and black military pants that were tucked into heavy black boots. He carried a black backpack, the sort one might bring to school, and had on a dark gray, oversized, hooded sweatshirt. He walked at a constant pace - each step at a perfect interval. We drove on and he grew smaller until eventually somewhere near the bottom of the bridge he disappeared completely having somehow reached the apex of the bridge at record speed. I realized almost immediately that the man had not been real, I had, in fact, been "seeing things". It still bothered me though - the man walking so close to the road, cars whipping past without even recognizing his presence.

We took the left onto McCallan and were stopped by a few unaware turkeys bobbing their way across the road. Reenie took the opportunity to beep at them but they were unconcerned. She muttered to herself something about time, tapped the horn once again, and they were gone.

Having been stuck in the hospital for three days had been long enough for me to have begun to feel *homesick*. The island itself seemed new again on my arrival. So many things I'd never seen before made themselves apparent to me as we sped down the road towards our property - a lone gate with no supporting driveway or passage to make it useful; a tire swing hanging from a half-broken branch; a middle-aged man with a small white dog in his lap, full basket of laundry inexplicably sitting in the middle of his front yard. How many things there were on this island - everywhere I looked was something I'd never seen before, something that had never occurred before in fact, and I was beginning to feel better about going back to school with this new found perspective. If only I could bring these same eyes with me to my school day - what would my teachers and peers matter to me then? - I could spend my days enjoying the way a pencil sounds when tapped against a desk with varying degrees of sharpness - I could busy myself taking inventory of the bathroom graffiti, listening to the cacophony of the lunchroom. In short, I realized it all was quite amazing.

But this sort of feeling passes as quickly as the need to sneeze and by the time we made it back to the property I'd forgotten why I'd been so excited to be back all over again.

My house was the same as I'd left it, mostly. One exception was the front porch, where Reenie had apparently spent a night emptying beer cans and setting them on every available space apart from a trash receptacle. Pabst Blue Ribbon - the iconic beverage of Grayson's Landing - red white and blue, twelve ounce aluminum cans - there was something almost beautiful in the way the mid-morning sun refracted off the angled surfaces of the cans, some of them crushed, others half full, others with cigarette ashes scattered around the mouth of the cans that had been repurposed as ashtrays. Reenie had huffed at the scene, as though she'd forgotten what a mess had accrued the night prior. I made a comment about it looking like there had been quite a gathering, but was ignored. Inside the house it smelled like cigarette smoke and something else that I would later come to recognize as marijuana. The latter smell, which was much more floral than the scent of spent tobacco, was actually pleasant and I thought Reenie had perhaps sprayed the house down with some sort of odor neutralizer. The only other thing that was different was a bouquet of flowers on the table that had not been there when I left - it looked like they'd been hand picked from around the property - I recognized the greens, pinks and purples of flowers that grew locally, though I knew not a one of them by name.

"That's thoughtful," I said to Reenie. She looked at me with some surprise and then saw what I was referring to. "I've never been interested in flowers but these are really quite special. Did you find them nearby?"

She took a few moments to respond in the affirmative and then quickly went off to the kitchen, returning with a black garbage bag, and then went back out onto the front porch and began systematically cleaning the porch between cigarettes. She whistled while she picked up - as the day pressed on her spirits lifted progressively. At one point, early in the afternoon, I'd come downstairs to fix myself a bologna and cheese sandwich. Through the window I saw Reenie dancing with the broom.

She was still on the front porch - cigarette dangling from her bottom lip - all the cans had already been taken care of and now she was sweeping the cobwebs that had been there all my life. A small pail of soapy water rested on top of the table, a sponge, a thick-haired bristle brush. She was humming a song by Carol King and sweeping and smoking and it struck me how much more attractive she appeared in her new frame of mind. As daft as I am I was not so vain as to assume it had been my return at the root of this new found vibrancy.

Part II

One

Benny came back from his first year of college and there had been a change in him - he had a whole new set of topics to discuss, worldly type things. During his first semester away the towers had fallen, and soon after that our country was at war again, though it was unclear as to who it was we were specifically fighting. The enemy had become amorphous. There was Osama Bin Laden and the Taliban, of course - terrorism in general - and all wars require a battlefield, it is known, so it seemed we had selected Afghanistan for just that purpose.

Like the rest of the country, Benny and I were in full support of the response to the events of September 11th - but we did discuss our reservations around the ambiguous nature of the declaration of war.

I had almost no knowledge of the geography or politics of the Middle East. From the news I understood it to be almost entirely Islam, repressive, anti-American and backwards. Images of women in burkas were astounding to our American gaze - they showed not an inch of skin, only their eyes visible through small openings in their veils. There were feral dogs, children toting hand-me-down Kalishnakovs, bearded men in turbans who sat in nefarious circles. The image of the planes and the towers, the pentagon's gaping wound, had been seared into our collective psyche. *You'll always remember where you were when you learned that the towers fell* - our new folk-knowledge, everyone knows where they were - *like when JFK got shot*.

But it couldn't be that that whole side of the world was our enemy. I knew that deep in my bones. But when I brought this up to Benny he didn't seem as concerned about this as I was. "No, not all of them. But it's spreading like a disease over there. They hang up pictures of the president on their shooting ranges - our president! Look at how they treat their women - imagine that - they treat them like animals, Tip. Don't you think?"

"It's certainly not a lifestyle I'm accustomed to. The women, the burkas, that is quite distressing - but I'm not certain it's indicative of a terrorist. And those weapons, I've read that we bought those for them in the eighties, you know? We gave them all these weapons that we're now taking pictures of to prove how violent they are - I just don't know. I mean, how could a whole part of the world be evil - it just doesn't make sense. Even in Germany there were good people and bad people, during the war I mean. Not every German was evil, I mean."

"They were all complicit," he said. "Millions and millions of Jews and they did nothing - they let it happen. That's wrong enough." One thing that happens when a person goes to college is that they become much more certain about things in general - instead of saying, *It seems to me that...*, the newly educated college student begins to say things like, *No, no no. Of course you couldn't understand, but the truth is...*, and so on and so forth. It is not that the student has become arrogant or is even more certain about what they are saying, but that they have learned that conviction can be as powerful as evidence when it comes to making sense of the world - whatsmore, it seems to me, the newly born academic becomes oddly averse to conflicting opinions, particularly those that contradict a belief they have come to acquire from a *respected professor*.

"I can't say I agree, Ben. Don't get upset over this now, but I just mean some of them went with it - but many of them just wanted to go on with their lives, didn't know what to do, how to help. They'd have died if they resisted, of course. I don't blame them for not wanting to be martyrs. I don't know, don't you think it's not so simple as that?" I knew it was a rough thing to say given that Benny was a Jew and I was not - the sort of thing you don't have the right to say even if you believe it to be true. I went

on, “With the Taliban, for instance, do you think it would be safe to tell them no? ‘Hey man, my wife don’t wear no burka!’ You’d be shot on sight!”

“It’s not the same thing,” said Benny.

We were out on the dock. It had taken quite a beating from a hurricane the previous fall. A large portion of the raised walkway had been washed away completely, leaving only the barnacled pilings behind - for all intents and purposes the dock had been cut in half, we were restricted to the first thirty feet before the missing portion, and then beyond that the remainder of the structure stood in isolation, no way to get there apart from wading through the sharp bladed oyster beds and quicksand-like pluff mud. It is worth a mention that oyster beds are not to be taken lightly - one slip can cause an arterial laceration that will put a man down on the spot.

The tide was high but going out, we could see the tips of reeds speckling the surface of the water with green points, behind them small ripples caused by the fast moving current. The surface of the water was patched by small pockets of turbulence that were generally known as demarcations for large oyster beds that should be avoided by deep-hulled boats. Occasionally a large mullet would jump into the air to catch an insect. In the more shallow parts, nearer to the shore, in the reeds, we saw a few red fish, fins sticking out of the water like sharks. They attacked their prey with ferocity and caused a big splash when they did. Benny mentioned that we should have brought our fishing poles.

I’d brought a book, a trade paperback copy of “Herzog” by Saul Bellow that I’d been struggling through. It fit nicely in my back pocket and remained there as we continued watching the water and discussing things Benny had learned about in his first year of college.

In his psychology class, for example, he’d written a paper on frontal lobe injuries and the history of lobotomies in the mental health arena. He told me the famous story of Phinneas Gage. **[MORE HERE]**

Business class, in particular, had given him much to think about. His father’s bookstore, for example, was running on an antiquated system of book-keeping that he believed had an impact on the overall margins because it did not account for certain costs, new taxes - they were also behind the times in terms of capitalizing on the growth of the internet, which even by then had begun to rapidly expand into the economic sectors and was a force that simply could not be ignored. “My father will hear nothing of it, though. He can’t stand the internet, doesn’t get it. I think it scares him, you know?”

“Absolutely,” I responded. “It’s horrifying. Just horrifying. But I see what you mean about it being a ‘necessary adaptation’ for any business. I can understand that - it almost makes it more frightening when you think of it like that. There’s no turning back.”

I'd seen very little of Mr. O'Rourke since Benny had gone off to school. It wasn't until he returned for the summer that I realized that I'd been feeling that absence too. The whole year I'd thought it was only Benny I'd been missing, envious of, nervous for - but the conversation about the bookstore reminded me of Mr. O'Rourke and it was apparent to me that I'd missed Benny's old man too. Not that I needed him for books anymore, the internet had made it possible for me to purchase almost any book I wanted at any time. Amazon was then still primarily a bookseller but had recently dropped it's branding as the "World's Biggest Bookstore" and was branching out into other products and services. It was not that I didn't want to support the O'Rourkes, or "Steinman's", but that it had, by then, been nearly four years since I'd left the island and I did not foresee that changing any time soon.

Around lunchtime we got hot - we trekked back to my house and I prepared a salad while Benny cracked a beer he'd found in my fridge. This was something people did in college, day drinking, and Benny took to it like a natural. "Nothing like a Pabst Blue Ribbon. Yankees don't know about Pabst." He took a sip and I'll be honest it sounded about as refreshing as anything I'd ever heard before - the booze galloping from the can down his throat in a constant rhythm - "What in the hell are you doing with beer in the fridge anyways?"

"Reasonable question. Casper stays here between trips. He can't stay on the boat with the rest of them, he says. He's not like them."

"Like who?"

"You know, the other guys - Porky, Chris, Tommy Boy - too many opportunities to 'eff it up' as per Casper. I don't mind the company." Benny guzzled the last of his first can and went looking for another.

"Do you still work with them over there?" He spoke with his head in the fridge so his words came to me muffled and distant.

"Not so much, no." I didn't tell him about the trip I'd taken though I knew it would eventually come to light.

It was embarrassing and I didn't feel like going through the same explanation again. No, I hadn't gotten seasick. No, it hadn't been some vast, sublime oceanic dread - it wasn't the weather, the company. It was difficult to explain what it had been, to be honest, in the same way that it was difficult to explain to other people, normal people, why I couldn't leave the island without throwing up or passing out (both of which I'd done while aboard the *Carolina Girl*). Things had gone fine for a while during my first few weeks as a fisherman. Prior to the final trip I'd gone out with the shrimping boats near shore - nothing far enough that the birds and dolphins disappeared - just a short trip here and there - not so much for the income, which was a pittance, but for the companionship, camaraderie, the *purpose* inherent in a fisherman's labor. It was only when I was invited on a swordfishing trip that

things took a turn for the worst. We'd been sailing steadily eastward all day at a pace that made even Captain Larry happy. He was a cantankerous old sea dog who told stories all day long. He never seemed to work, but was always around, observing, and when weather got rough, it was said, there was no one you'd rather have at the helm. [MORE ABOUT FISHING TRIP]

Two

Benny took a mid-afternoon nap on the couch in the den. He let me know with enthusiasm that mid-afternoon naps were essential to his lifestyle at college. He had reorganized his sleep schedule in such a way that he slept only four or five hours at night, allowing him to stay out late and enjoy the *dyonisian* festivities that could be attended nearly any night of the week now that he'd joined a fraternity - then, during the daytime, he was able to sneak in another two to three hours of rest between his morning and late afternoon classes. "In college," he told me, "you get to select your class schedule. Some of the guys pack all of their classes in the mornings - from eight in the morning til three in the afternoon just like it was high school. But I like it the way I set it up - with a break in the middle of the day to refresh for the second half. It's like having two days in a day," he said, thinking he sounded quite smart and bohemian, I interpreted.

I was mostly interested in hearing about the festivities he'd alluded to - all day we'd talked about school and studies, professors and curriculums, books I needed to read, the merits of socialism (not that he was sold) - put simply, we discussed academic things. Every time the subject of his rollicking nights came up Benny would quickly change the subject to some more pedestrian topic.

While he slept I began preparations for dinner. I'd learned a number of simple recipes that worked well for a party of one. Cooking for one can be a difficult and lonely exercise - I was excited by the new opportunities a larger meal afforded me. I ran down to Grayson's quickly where I had free reign of Casper's marked bottles - I brought back a clear jar of moonshine with Casper's name on it, sharpied onto a small piece of white packing tape on the lid. There weren't many people at the boat house, and not a one who I was obligated to stop and talk with before I was quickly out the door on my way back to the house.

I only owned one cookbook - "The New York Times Cookbook" by Craig Claiborne. It was published in the early nineties and still contained many recipes calling for the addition of MSG, the glorious flavor enhancer best known for its contributions to Chinese cuisine. The product MSG has gone from being lauded to despised to tentatively accepted again, making a mockery of nutritional sciences along the way. That being said, it wasn't the sort of thing I could pick up at the grocery store. Its substitution always provided an interesting challenge because the appropriate replacement was entirely dependent

on the dish. One could not, for example, simply replace MSG with beef broth in every recipe, although in dishes that contained some liquid element this was often a suitable solution. Alternatively it can be replaced with a variety of other savory ingredients: soy sauce, garlic, tarragon, pepper or salt. We call the flavor it contributes *umami*. Making the wrong decision can be costly, but is usually educational from a culinary perspective. Flavor combinations, like social interactions, are simultaneously contingent on the relationships between the individual parts and the method used to combine the parts to form a whole. We stir in flour, rather than dumping it, to avoid clumpiness; we use a particular pan to distribute heat evenly; we brown the onions before adding the garlic. The difference between a good cup of chili and a great one is in the nuance - the small dash of seasoning added at exactly the right time, the perfect simmer, fresh tomatoes, the perfect serving vessel, maybe even the music playing in the distance, the color of the evening sun, the size and shape of the utensils or even the small cut on your lip that stings against the hot sauce.

The same thing can be said for collections of people, whether it be the environment in which they meet, the way one of them holds their hands behind their back, the way another speaks too quickly or too little, alcohol consumption, a sidelong glance, the accidental brush of an arm as one person glides past another on his way to shut the window. An unexpected guest disrupts the whole party.

These were the sorts of things I was thinking about while I added salt to a pot of water and turned on the back left burner (which was slightly larger than the other three to provide a larger and wider flame). The salt was rumored to decrease the boiling temperature of the water, though I had found this to be a wife's tale - it did, however, add a slight hint of flavor to the pasta water, which I would later use to decrease the viscosity of the pasta sauce.

I went outside to pick some rosemary and basil from the small garden I'd constructed along the side of the house. The summer heat was in full effect and I realized that I hadn't put on any sunscreen earlier in the day - my wrists and the back of my hands were reddened and my forehead felt as though it had been pulled tight against my skull. I snapped off the corner of an aloe plant I'd grown for this exact reason and rubbed the clear, mucousy substance all over my face, neck and hands. The garden had proven useful and I gave myself silent congratulations on it back inside to dice some onions and garlic.

It didn't take long for the aroma from the sizzling skillet to wake Benny from his *afternoon nap*. "Hot damn! What are you making in there?" There was a large opening between the kitchen and the den that made it so that the wall barely qualified as a wall - it was a precursor to the open floor plans that dominate the modern communities being built these days. When Reenie left I'd set up a foldable partition between the two rooms to emphasize that they were separate spaces. The modern world has embraced "open architecture" without me. In my humble opinion "open architecture" is for people who like to mix their peas and potatoes and gravy and ham in one giant lump before digging in - it's like

when children paint with all the colors of the rainbow, only to find that, once combined, everything becomes the same shade of lifeless brown.

I've learned over time that the scent of browning onions and garlic in olive oil is the easiest way to get someone to comment on the quality of food that is yet to be prepared. It doesn't matter what you do after that - you could be making peanut butter and jelly sandwiches, so long as the olive oil/garlic/onion combination is in the air you have already captured the audience. Every time, without fail, your guest will speak up as though you've discovered some brand new culinary possibility. "Wow, Tip - been learning how to cook, I guess. I'm impressed." I thanked him for the compliment while I crushed fresh roma tomatoes by hand. Little squirts of juice and seeds sprayed in unpredictable directions.

"Just making pasta," I spoke towards the partitioned den, accentuating my humility. "There's really nothing to it. I can teach you a few tricks if you want."

He appeared from behind the partition. His eyes were red and he looked like he was still tired. The nap hadn't done him much good, it seemed. I realized he'd consumed a substantial number of beers since he'd cracked the first one. He looked different. His hair was longer than it had ever been but it wasn't just that. It wasn't some particular physical feature that marked the change that had come over him. It was a myriad of small things that were visible - and something that could not be seen by the eye too.

Visible : He kept his fingernails long and ill-maintained. I've never minded dirty fingers so long as they aren't kept at such a length that the detritus of the day accrued in the cavity between the nail and the fingertip. Dark gray pluff mud had dried there on Benny's hands and I, with all the tact in the world, offered him a toothpick and plastic grocery bag to scrape his excremental dirt into.

Visible : A small tattoo he hadn't told me about yet, but I had noticed earlier in the day when he had leaned a particular way to slap a mosquito from his ankle. It was on his left shoulder and all I'd seen was a small black point that could have been just about anything. I am ambivalent about tattoos, I don't believe in the worship of the human body as something to be unchanged - which is to say I could have cared less about the tattoo but I was surprised he'd failed to mention it.

Invisible : He now said *y'all* on occasion. He also referred to things as being "wicked," which taken in context signified that the subject was very cool, hip, *rad* , excellent, etc.

Visible : He'd gained weight. Not that he'd gotten fat, but he was no longer skinny - and of the weight he'd put on it was apparent that it was comprised mostly of beer and was not the result of a strict weight lifting regimen of any sort.

Invisible : When I mentioned his father he only responded quietly and paid his attention to small things of no importance. He stared down at his dirty fingernails, commented on the crown molding (the same crown molding he'd seen his whole life). He asked if the weather was supposed to get rough. Brought

up fishing, or books he saw laying around, or thought to mention some deceased family member of mine he'd never asked about before. I found it odd but didn't push - how our relationship felt suddenly it seemed unwise. I couldn't dream of losing it, though for some reason the thought had crossed my mind with an alarming frequency.

Benny ambled around the kitchen aimlessly. It was a large open kitchen, re-done at some point in the early eighties when everyone was busy making the same mistakes, covering their original hardwood floors with linoleum, redoing cabinets so that they matched the microwave. A layer of modernity had been added to every surface of the kitchen, but the real thing was still behind the façade - it was a metaphor of some sort, for something. He looked in the empty cabinets and commented on the dust. He poured himself a glass of water from the sink. I added the fresh tomato sauce to the garlic and onions, a can of tomato paste and the appropriate spices went in as well.

He found the mason jar, opened it, and took a swig without so much as looking in my direction. The effect of the moonshine, which was intended to be cut with some sort of juice or flavored element to mitigate the urge to regurgitate, was quickly apparent on Benny's face. He swallowed once, and then made a sort of grunting sound before directing his gaze down towards the floor and inhaling deeply through his nose. "Rough," he sort of choked out the word. He surveyed the room for the most appropriate place to vomit. Quickly I grabbed the waste bin from below the kitchen sink and brought it towards him. "Water," he said - again it was if he spoke quickly because saying anything longer would cause too much opportunity for the moonshine to get the best of him. I grabbed the cup of water I'd given him earlier and set it down beside him. He seemed to regain some of his composure after taking a sip. "You look at your toes and breathe in deep through the nose," he said. "You're supposed to do the breathing thing before you take the shot but I for--" he gagged again - moved his hand to his mouth - waited a moment - then took his hand away and went for another sip of water. Finally, whatever he'd been feeling had passed. He asked if I had pineapple juice for a mixer. I told him that I did not but he could survey the fridge for an alternative.

As he poked around the refrigerator I continued my preparations, breaking the spaghetti in half, as his father had once taught me to do so that the twirled fork method was more manageable. A veritable sin in the Italian kitchen, I knew, but I am a man who believes logic trumps tradition and it seemed to me a wildly logical indiscretion. "I'd have figured you'd be better at drinking by now," I jested.

He gave me a quick middle finger and laughed. "Man the old people on this island could drink my brothers under the table."

"Brothers?"

"Frat brothers. Once you go through the hazing and all you consider yourself *brothers*. You call each other brother. Like you go through all this shit together and when you come out of it you're brothers. It's wicked."

“Surely you can’t feel close enough to all of them to think of them as *brothers* . In less than a year? It seems improbable to me. The things you’ve been to together, I mean, they aren’t *real* things. What can hazing be, really.”

“I’m sworn not to go into all that but I’ll tell you it was horrendous. Illegal, some of it - dangerous, some of it. Just last year a fraternity was kicked off the campus when their hazing rituals were exposed. Not allowed to say a word about it - but it was gross, man. You go through the stuff we went through and you come out the other end a little more tied together, I guess. And since we all have to keep the same secrets we’re bonded like that, you know?”

It sounded like a lot of lip service to me. I’ve heard about people forming those sorts of bonds during war, certainly - bullets flying past their helmets, last night’s dinner companion struck in the carotid with a piece of shrapnel - *real* things, I mean. That I could understand. But what could hazing be?

Chugging alcohol until you puked? Serving your superior *brothers* as though they were idols?

Consuming some disgusting substance to prove your dedication? A bunch of ideological brainwashing? The occasional act of public service in the name of campus politics? It struck me that we lose more than we gain as we age - and I’d always thought it the other way around. The sort of freedom you get isn’t really freedom at all - but I stopped myself from going down that path. It was the sort of thought exercise that culminated in useless dread - a late night spent deciding whether I was more comfortable laying on my left or right side, before realizing that I’ve been the type that sleeps on my stomach the whole time.

The pasta was put in it’s boiling bath and swirled until each half-segment had lost its rigidity. Then I used the claw-like spoon to further separate any pieces that had become stuck together. Pasta is a simple, but fickle ingredient. I would very much like to make my own, one of these days, but I almost can’t bear the thought of going through all the effort to make my own noodles only to cook it too long, or not stir it frequently enough, or compliment it with the wrong sauce.

“You went through the whole thing for the *brotherhood* ? Is that why you joined a fraternity? I really know nothing about it. A fraternal order. It’s a club, really, no?”

“Well yes and no, but you must be invited. That’s one of the most important things about it. There is an element of prestige.” Prestige. I thought about it. This seemed to me like putting the cart in front of the horse, as the saying goes - how could one be accepted into a group of prestigious individuals without having had enough time to even display one’s own merit. I didn’t want to say as much to Benny - he seemed to take pride in it and I was not nearly in a position to ridicule anyone for their social dealings.

“How are you selected? How do you know it’s a group you want to be invited to, I mean, when everything is so secret about it?”

“I asked myself the same thing, Tip. I didn’t know either - the year kicks off and all of a sudden there is all this chatter about fraternities and sororities.” He paused and took another sip of the moonshine, swallowing it more reasonably this time. Still, he made a face as though he’d taken a bite of a lime.

“And anyways everyone in the dorms are talking about it on the first night, right away. Some of them had older siblings and knew all about it - so I sorta relied on them. My roommate, it so happened, had a brother who was already in one of the frats - and he’d been told about a party that was going on that night at a house off-campus.”

I cut a baguette into small slices and plated them alongside a butter dish. All of the items were falling into formation on the counter top. I took out the salad I’d prepared earlier in the day and topped it with salt, pepper, and some grated pecorino romano. Beside it I set bottles of extra virgin olive oil and balsamic vinegar. I told Benny it sounded like a pretty cool scene. “Extraordinary,” I said.

“Thousands of students come together on this first night of the semester - the first night on their own for some of them, first time without their parents I’ve got to imagine - and they get together and somehow word spreads through that ecosystem letting them know where to go, what to do.”

“Tip, man, you make these things too complicated. I couldn’t live a day in that head of yours.” He took a piece of the baguette, buttered it, and ate it in two bites. Little flecks of bread sprayed from his mouth as he told me, “It was wicked Tip. I showed up to my dorm, unpacked my bag in like thirty minutes, then my roommate tells me about a party we should go to, I put on the coolest shit I can find and we’re on our way.” He ladled some sauce into his mouth directly from the pot and commented that it was hot. I guess there are some things you don’t pick up in college.

Three

My father was a cold man but not overly violent. He only once raised his hand at my mother - she had fallen into one of her depressive states and threatened to swallow her whole bottle of pills. I was in the living room at the time, likely exploring the small pen that was my day time play-space (until I was old enough to lift one leg over the barrier and hoist myself out - then, no more pen). He demanded she give him the bottle, threatened to call the police. My mother knew no Tipnam would ever make that phone call and told him as much. She called him a coward, I’ve been told, and then she opened the bottle and as she went to tilt it towards her opened lips he reached back and swung. The pills went flying - for weeks afterwards I was restricted from crawling anywhere outside of the den, as there was no safe way to confirm that all of the pills had been located.

Not that I remember any of this, of course - this story was told to me by my grandfather one day in my adolescence, when I’d been in one of my inquisitive moods and needed some reassurance that I hadn’t been born to monsters. “Only one time,” my grandfather reiterated, “to save her life.”

I suppose it's time I explain how it is that my parents died. In order to do this in the most objective and least obscured way I will provide the facts first, things that cannot be denied or rejected by any party. Only then will I explain some of the theories that go along with it all - so that the reader can decide on their own what is and is not worth consideration.

My mother died first, when I was seven years old, by her own hand. She left a note which read: "To my Williams: I love you both. Please forgive me." She was thirty two and had been beset with a psychiatric ailment which has since been subdivided into a myriad of more specific diagnoses. She used the rope from the crab traps and a knot my father taught her.

My father, two years her junior, died six months later on McCallan Road. It was in the dark morning, a half a mile from the entrance to our property. Hours later his blood alcohol level was calculated to still be double the legal limit. By extrapolating this data the coroner estimated he had been "excessively intoxicated" when his small truck took a corner too wide and lost its grip on the road. The vehicle wrapped around an old oak. He did not suffer. That was our consolation.

I have no memories from before my parents' death. Not a one, really. I can conjure up certain sensations maybe, but of those I can't be certain what is fact and what is fiction. Did my mother really embrace me so tightly I felt my breath taken away? Did my father really tickle me until I'd cry? I'll never know - that's the way it works.

What I do know is that my father was a quiet alcoholic and my mother was a manic-depressive who loved painting. One of her paintings hangs in my house to this day. It is oil on canvas and depicts a room much like our den, but with a slightly different layout so that the fireplace was where the entrance to the kitchen actually exists. In the painting the only visible entrance or exit to the room is the window on the left - presumably, then, the only way out of the painting would be through the painter herself, since that window has been painted shut for eternity. If it weren't for the window, maybe, I wouldn't even assume it was based on the den - but the window in the painting is undeniably a reproduction of one of the windows in the den, down to the cracked pane in the bottom right, down to the small piece of the frame itself that had been painted a slightly different shade of eggshell. There is a man in the painting, that almost goes unnoticed but ultimately is the element that makes the painting anything more than a reproduction of an imagined room. The man is in the background, seated on a small chair we never owned - he holds a glass of alcohol in one hand, a bouquet of flowers in the other, and it is apparent from the way he sits that his lover, his best friend, his other half has not come home for the night. The fire radiates beside him, casting his shadow back towards the viewer, and in it (the fire), if you look closely, you can see a face that looks neither devious nor benevolent - as though the fire itself was trying to cast off any preconceptions around its metaphorical meaning. It was just a fire - but a fire with a face.

No one likes this painting except for me. Most people ignore it, and those that comment say it seems *dark*. Oh, I want to say but hold my tongue, *I don't see it that way at all. You seem to have ignored the fire.*

Losing one's parents is a tragedy at any age - it goes without saying - but I am lucky in some ways that I lost mine so young - not to be ravaged by memories of pleasant trips to the beach and happy family dinners and the rest. I don't go to sleep at night and have dreams of my mother's soft voice, my father's masculine love. No I have none of that and it's a lucky thing because then I might have to dream of that. I couldn't bear to dream of that.

At the heart of my parents' strife was my father's inability to find a way to make money that wasn't inherited or illegal. My mother, who'd married into Tipnam wealth but came, herself, from a family of meager means and small prospects, wanted my father to lean into life - push it until he made a space of his own - she wanted us to leave one day. Or if not leave, she hoped we would become the preeminent family on the property - the family to look up to.

You'll forgive me if I don't speak about all this with particular clarity. I've been trying. But there's just nothing to tether it to. There's this giant ambiguity around what I'm made of - what they wanted from me - the things I was meant to do but just didn't know. What happened, of course, is that I lost my map only a few weeks into the journey - and since then I've decided to set anchor, I still see the shore and the people and the ways of being that are more or less acceptable, and I don't need much more than that, I suppose - that is, if I'm being honest.

After my father died Reenie took over the house. She was indignant about it, because the house was mine by will and there was no benefit gained from inheriting the responsibility of a child. She had no idea what to do. The next year, when I was set to start third grade, I refused. There are laws about this sort of thing, of course - but I was a terror and due to the traumatic way the previous year had unfolded I was treated more gently than most. Perhaps a year off, it was decided, give him a year of *homeschool* and we'll reintegrate him then. But that reintegration never was to take place. I got comfortable teaching myself, and Reenie, realizing that I didn't need much instruction, had no problem with my decision to take on my own education, so long as I did it quietly and did not wake her before eleven in the morning.

There is no way for me to tell this story that doesn't paint Reenie as some sort of wench-like stepmom - but there is no good way to take on what it is she'd been asked to take on. She was no more than twenty five. In those days she was still young enough that she saw a way out. There was a life she was still waiting to find somewhere out there and I was a minor impediment in her pursuit. I didn't blame her then and I don't blame her now, though there were years in between during which I resented her so thoroughly that I'd cause her to cry by telling her she was unsuitable for motherhood.

To this day I know I hold some responsibility for her running off the way she did - disappeared to the night like she'd pulled a scam. And I think of her often, now - my hope is that she's forgotten all of us, everything. My hope is that she's satisfied.

Whereas Reenie felt trapped by the island, the family, a life with no ultimate ambition but to survive it - I felt that the confines were liberating. A map of the world that was to be my own. It's no fun playing tennis without a net, they say. Without referent we're all lost. So for me the island was as dynamic in its possibilities as I could ever imagine needing.

To look so long is to miss the sudden. I read it in a poem once and think I know what it means.

Four

I had two very conflicting ideas about what college was like. One came from the books I'd read about undergraduates navigating their way through untenable amounts of school work, strict professors, beer-fueled philosophical arguments that lasted late into the night, a romantic endeavor built on a mutual admiration of Rilke - things like this. The other came from American cinema, particularly the film *Animal House*, which gave the impression that college was practically a non-stop orgiastic gathering of lusty men and coy women, beer-fueled conversations were bawdy, not intellectual, everyone looked forty somehow. In both versions, it is worth noting, there is the same underlying pulse of sex in everything. In both books and film a character could not so much as say hello without having some underlying sexual desire driving the car.

Benny's version of college struck me as a strange amalgamation of both - but certainly it couldn't be the case. On the docks we discussed political science - at the house we discussed beer bongs, magic mushrooms, and regional proclivity for promiscuity amongst the freshmen women. "The difference with girls from the south," he said, "is that they want you to remind them of their fathers. You know, buying drinks and pulling out chairs and sorta talking down to them a little bit. There is some masochism there. Yankee girls, on the other hand, want you to be more like their older brother - protective, brash, quick to the punchline - with northern chicks you need to be mean on the surface, but soft in private. With the southern girls I think it's sorta the opposite, you know?"

Of course I had no idea. He seemed to be saying girls wanted you to be mean to them, if I was understanding correctly.

He went on, "Both are just as likely to screw you. For what it's worth - it's just a matter of how to best get there. And at a school like State, you know, there are just more southern girls than there are yanks. The yanks stick out like a sore thumb, form their own clicks. They wear sweatpants like all the time! I

like them better than the southern girls, to be honest, they do more maintenance on their pussies.

Southern girls are fifty percent more likely to have that seventies bush.” I almost spit out the piece of pasta I’d been testing for firmness. Benny bent over laughing at my response. The pasta was a perfect al dente. I strained it and ran it through a cold water bath to stop it from cooking any further. Then I poured some of the leftover pasta water into the sauce and stirred it a bit more.

“The starch in the water does something to the sauce. This is a good trick,” I told Benny, who by now had made his way over to the shelf that contained my father’s records. It had gone practically untouched for a decade. I had no interest in his music. From early on I’d been drawn to slow, pensive classical music. My father’s shelf was almost exclusively rock, classic rock, prog rock, glam rock, and most of all southern rock - Lynyrd Skynyrd and the Allman Brothers made up a good twenty percent of what was there.

This was the year 2002, CDs were in vogue, but I didn’t have a single device that could play a *compact disc* - the only sound that could be manufactured had to come from the television or the record player.

The record player itself was a cheap thing but it had never failed to work the few times I’d tried it out. I admired the simple genius of the invention. It repackaged sound more perfectly than even the compact disc because it was a genuine copy of the sound. Whereas a compact disc turned the data of music into bits, a record owned the music in its infinite entirety. The space between the notes, which mathematicians will attest is necessarily continuous, is all present on a vinyl. The difference between a cd and a vinyl is not dissimilar to the distinction between a man made staircase and a hill. One defined by intervals, the other a constant no matter how it is constructed. Even a hill shaped like a staircase would not be a staircase - it would be a hill in the shape of a staircase - whatever that means. At the end of the day there is something more genuine in the way an album takes you to the music. While perhaps inaudible, there is something missing in the intervals of digitized music. And for that reason I did not protest when Benny put on a live Lynyrd Skynyrd album titled “One More From the Road”.

“Careful with the needle,” was all I said - and Benny laughed.

The thing with rock n’ roll, as I see it, is that it is fun. More so than almost any other genre of music, rock n’ roll at its heart is intended to reduce inhibitions and open the mind and (I could almost slap myself for saying it, but the word is necessary here)--open the mind and soul to more fundamental sensations, primordial feelings, to let the rule of instinct take the throne, if only for a night, if only for a song. This isn’t inherently counter to my personal philosophy - at least I don’t think - but it’s not something that stimulates me in the way it does others. Somehow I become aware of the way my inhibitions have dissipated and rather relishing in it’s absence I go anxiously searching for that foundation again. I end up wanting my inhibitions back. Erik Satie, on the other hand, composed music that brings me great joy. The music of Erik Satie hardens my resolve, brings structure to chaos, tells me to calm and focus.

“Skynyrd! Man! I can’t believe I never knew how much these guys rocked!” Benny strummed at his air guitar and bounced around the den.

“Impressive musicians, undoubtedly.” I was telling the truth, there was an undeniable virtuosity in their performance. I just didn’t understand why it needed to be so loud. “Would you mind if I turn it down a bit though, for dinner?” Benny jumped up on the couch for a solo.

“Turn it down?!?” *Saturday Night Special* had just hit its stride and he was feeling it. There was something untethered about Benny, I started to think - something loose. Something frightened, perhaps? The song faded out. Benny twisted the volume knob to a more reasonable decibel.

“Dinner is ready,” I told him and pointed to the counter top in the kitchen where I’d set up plates, utensils, napkins as well as the food I’d cooked. I kept the pasta and sauce separate so each of us could choose our own ratio. I’d put out a pitcher of ice water, a pitcher of sweet tea. Benny filled a glass half full with moonshine and then topped it off with some sweet tea before setting it at the table and returning to fix himself a dish.

There was a question that I’d been wanting to ask him since he’d come back but I didn’t know how to say it. It wasn’t that the words weren’t accessible to me, but rather that I could imagine myself saying them, and how they’d be received, and I knew it wouldn’t result in the sort of response I sought. I wanted to know if he’d had intercourse while at college. I knew almost as a matter of fact that he’d not managed to “score” in high school - this based on a fundamental misunderstanding of the female anatomy that he accidentally divulged to me before he set off for his freshman year. Luckily I set him straight then, and in his embarrassment he never got around to admitting he’d lied about the events that he’d described regarding prom night.

As such, I was worried that if I asked him too directly about his coital experiences, he might subconsciously harken back to the old lie he’d told me, and then remembering that he had to maintain that lie begin a whole new set of lies - all of which would muddle the information making it such that I could not know if what he was saying was in earnest. As such, I knew tact would be critical - and I also realized that the over consumption of moonshine was beginning work in my favor. If I could tease it out of him rather than asking directly - that would be the ideal scenario - just lure him into the discussion and let it slip out naturally.

The sauce was acidic. Quite a disappointment. Benny seemed unaware, though, and immediately began to rave about it. “This is better than my Ma’s sauce, Tip. I mean it! Don’t tell her I said that though,” he dragged a thumb across his neck. “Snitches get stitches.” Then he laughed. There was something maniacal in it - something more than just the booze and the uncomfortable joke.

I told him that I hadn’t seen his mom in almost a year. I mentioned that the sauce was a bit acidic, I thought. “It’s funny,” I told him, “almost paradoxical, really. Salt is a good way to cut the acidity. I

would have thought just the opposite but it's absolutely true. Salt makes the sauce less acidic in the same way that sugar works. There is a good deal of science in the culinary arts, I've found." I took another bite, "I didn't add enough of the pasta water...or maybe I didn't add enough salt to the pasta water. It's an experiment everytime, really."

I was on my third bite when Benny made the noise, that emphatic exhalation, that indicated he'd finished his dish.

There was something sad about him that had been present all day but somehow I hadn't fully managed to recognize. Perhaps the alcohol had brought it closer to the surface, the way it drives the capillaries to redden a drinker's cheeks. He took a long sip of the moonshine-sweet tea concoction and didn't make a face as he swallowed it. The opening chords of "Simple Man" wafted into the kitchen. We'd fallen into the type of silence that only sturdy relationships can bear. Both of us in our own heads, trying to make sense of what we were trying to think about in the first place.

*Oh take your time don't live too fast
Troubles will come and they will pass
Go find a woman yeah and you'll find love
And don't forget son there is someone up above*

Ronnie Van Zandt's voice was simultaneously exalting and melancholic as he finished off that last note. Benny scoffed. So, he is a cynic now, I thought.

I was finishing off my plate when Benny finished off his moonshine. "Ya mind if I crash here tonight?" he asked, speech slurred a bit now.

"Of course not. Mi casa, su casa," I told him - but I was curious about something. "Are your parents not begging you to come home? You've been back, what three days?"

"Three days," he repeated. "Yep. I haven't exactly told them I got back just yet. Mind if I smoke in here?" he asked while lighting a cigarette.

I didn't even respond - if he'd have waited I would have asked him to take it outside but it was clear he didn't care much how I answered. Instead I went and found one of Reenie's old ashtrays in the junk drawer. Benny returned to the den and sat in the chair beside the back door.

"Here, for the ashes. And what do you mean you haven't told them you're back yet? Where exactly do they think you are?"

"Not sure," he said. "They've got bigger things on their plate right now, it seems like. Daddy O'Rourke got himself in some trouble." He laughed at nothing in particular, looked at nothing in

particular - a haze settled in across his gaze that made one feel as though he was not even thinking about anything in particular. He was just sort of there.

“I see. Or maybe I don’t. What kind of trouble do you mean?” Had he cheated? It must have been something like that - he must have gotten a loose hair when Benny went off to school and stepped out on Mrs. O’Rourke. But then again, that didn’t seem right. Mr. O’Rourke was not a faultless man, but loyalty was seared into his ethos.

Once, when we were nine or ten, I’d watched a red-faced Mr. O’Rourke berate Benny for a perceived lack of loyalty; that was until Benny split into tears and ran off to his room, leaving me there with his father to sort things out myself.

We’d been involved in a crime of sorts - which is to say we’d taken a few bucks from the till at the bookstore in order to purchase slushies at *The Village Shoppe*, which was more or less a mini-mart that carried the same sorts of things one finds at a gas station or pharmacy, plus it had a back room with a few arcade games, gambling machines, and a photo-booth which had been appropriated by high-school aged co-eds for illicit purposes. We’d been given the afternoon off when Benny came up with the idea. We’d take two five dollar bills (one each), buy an ice cream and whatever else we wanted, then with the change we’d play the poker machine and make the money back, replacing it in the till before his father counted the drawer. I did not protest.

The plan went incredibly well early on. Mr. O’Rourke went to the back to make a call and smoke his lunchtime cigarette. He asked us to watch the register, as was standard practice. *Of course, no problem*, we told him. As soon as we heard the latch click Benny clicked a few keys at the register and it popped open with a quiet *ding*.

“Bingo,” he said. And he took out the cash, handing me a five. “Put it in your pocket for now - I’ll get us off for the afternoon.” When his father returned, apparently perturbed by the phone call he’d just gotten off of, Benny asked him if we could go hangout at the park, since business was slower than *molasses in January*. We promised to be back by four so that we could help him finish out the day and were approved.

With that we were out the door and into the battering heat of mid-June. *The Village Shoppe* was only a few doors down but still somehow it felt laborious to change from one environment to the other. It’s difficult to describe how oppressive the air could be on the island. The temperature is only *one of the components* of the sensation. The temperature forms a foundation and then the humidity amplifies it, the pavement refracts it, the sweat emphasizes it. The weatherman says things like, *Ninety four today but feels like a hundred and twelve*. It can get muggy enough that one physically feels as though they are going through extra effort to move through the atmosphere. Thoughts become slower. People speak slower. Time takes breaks throughout the day, barely moving at all for short periods before getting back on track. Einstein posited that when you move at the speed of light time ceases to exist - I

would suggest amending this to include a specific kind of climate that does things to time that seem otherwise inexplicable.

The Village Shoppe was run by an older man named Ronnie Carville. It looks the same today as it did on that hot day in June and Ronnie is still there, somehow the same age in appearance. Ronnie always wore blue jeans and the same clean, blue and freshly ironed, short-sleeved button-down shirt. He wore gold glasses with circular shaped frames that made him look like a caricature of himself. He was always very kind to me when we came to the shop but had a grudge against Benny I didn't yet understand.

There was a bell on the door at the shop that was just like the one on *Steinman's* door. The bell served a few purposes, primarily to wake the store owner from his morning, mid-morning, afternoon, mid-afternoon, or evening nap. Surprisingly, in this case, there was already another customer in Ronnie's shop so we did not have to disturb him with the bell. In fact we were able to quickly duck over to the far left corridor that led to the game room without being noticed at all. We had to forgo the ice cream in the name of discretion. Benny led the way and walked right past the *Mortal Kombat* machine, past the ornately detailed *Captain America* pinball machine and the lights that danced across its tilted arena floor. He went straight to the back of the room where the lights were slightly dimmer and a row of five machines stood side by side, each with a vacant barstool in front of them. They were all identical in shape and size, five foot tall rectangles of hard black plastic with a screen for eyes, and a stainless steel basin at the bottom that jutted out slightly like a jaw. If located in a different state or on a riverboat, this was where coins would come pouring out (given that one had a little luck on their side and knew a thing or two about when to hold and when to fold). Just above the jaw were two rows of buttons, the top row green, the bottom red - which were used for a variety of purposes depending on the game that the machine had been configured to run. Finally, beside the two rows were three larger buttons - one to play, one to cash out and one to double up.

A lightbulb in the corner of the room flickered lazily and without pattern. All of the lights were so dim that it barely registered unless you were watching for it. There were four lights in total, each hung from a long cord that came directly out of holes that had been roughly cut in the ceiling. Do-it-yourself lighting. They weren't even evenly spaced. They sported atrocious lampshades - deep purple affairs with orangish tassels. The tassels were probably white at one point, but had since been painted their new shade by cigarette smoke and time.

Benny walked up to the first machine and looked at the screen for a bit. It was a blackjack machine. There were two digital cards that displayed on the main screen and flashing below them were small red letters that read, INSERT CASH TO PLAY! Benny took his five and put it in the machine. A small jingle played from the speakers and some images flashed across the screen before two cards were virtually dealt, a three and a five. Benny tapped his chin for a moment - looked back to see if Ronnie was nearby - then he selected the button that said "STAND/HOLD".

“Ben?”

“Hush,” he said. The computer/dealer was showing a seven. It flipped another seven. Game over.

“Fuckin’ ay.” He’d only recently started swearing but seemed to do it well. Across the screen a message popped up - a countdown in a small window (10, 9, 8-), above which it read: INSERT CASH TO CONTINUE! “Hold on! Tip, what’s going on here? What about the rest of my money?”

“I believe you wagered all five, Ben. I’m certain of it, in fact. I thought you knew how to play.”

“What?! No! So that’s it?” I heard his voice quiver and got nervous he was going to start crying - it was something he was prone to doing when very upset and it made me uncomfortable. I’ve always found it difficult to watch another person cry, regardless of circumstance - I struggle with pity, I suppose. Just the way I was cut.

“I’ve still got my five, Ben. We can still win it back. I’ve played this before. My Uncle Woody thinks he’s a pro.”

“Let me have that five,” he responded. “It’s mine anyways.”

And what was I supposed to do? Fight with him? “You stood on a three-five,” I said - and then half-way mocking Uncle Woody, “Don’t do that again.” I took the five from my back pocket and handed it over to him. He’d thrown it in the machine before I could return hands to my pockets.

Two more cards - Jack, Nine. The dealer showed a four. Benny thought for a bit, then a bit longer. He bit at his left thumbnail.

“You stand with this hand. Your hand equals nineteen,” I spoke up. I couldn’t believe he was playing without any knowledge of the game itself.

“I know that,” he said. “I just had a feeling - but yeah, I know. You’re right, you’re right.” He pressed the button to stand. The dealer flipped a ten, which meant he had to hit again. A nine was dealt.

Busted. YOU WON! Digital cash flashed across the screen. At the bottom of the screen a green number went from 0005 to 0010. “Hot damn!” Benny whispered his exclamation.

Just then a black cat walked up from the front of the store. It was one of Ronnie’s cats - they came and went as they pleased. It sauntered up beside Benny, rubbing itself against his leg, before hopping on the stool to his right and purring softly.

“Perhaps that’s an omen, Ben. When you’re gambling you have to take omens seriously. It’s the only way to justify playing a game of luck. Maybe we should count ourselves lucky we won that money back - return it where it came from, you know?” My change of heart had come about suddenly - what had we been thinking?

Benny's eyes had gone feral though - I was too late. Adrenalin had never been my thing - I seemed to react to it by shutting down. No fight, no flight - the possum-like instinct to play dead. Benny and I were not aligned in this regard. The bright green and white lights from the screen flickered across his young face, strobe-like. I realized I was frightened. Something about the cat, the lights, Benny's eyes, the machine with its obnoxious noises, the lamp shades, the flickering bulb - it all landed on me at once and I wanted to be done. "I think we'd better go back," I reiterated, but Benny had already doubled down and been dealt a natural blackjack.

He started to absently pet the cat in the stool beside him. I paced behind him. "We're up ten dollars now," I said. "Let's call it a day. One hundred percent return is great any day of the week."

"Oh stop being such a pussy," said Benny.

"You don't even know what you're doing Ben. I hardly know how to play and I can see that. Do you even know the rules of the game?"

"Dude," was all he said.

"What will your father say if we don't replace the money, Ben? I don't want any part of this anymore." But it was no use, he had the cards dealt again on a ten dollar bet.

"You play this hand," he said. What was I to do? He was my only friend. A person should always have two friends at a minimum, if possible, in order to avoid situations like this. A person should maintain a savings account of friends because they are fickle as a group, and a person without a backup plan is already beset with a handicap. I had to play - is what I'm trying to justify here - I didn't want to lose Benny.

Four, three against the dealer's six. Deal. Four. Deal. Blackjack.

"This fucking cat. You were wrong, Tip. It's not a bad omen - it was a good omen."

"How do you know that until you stop? Will you still be saying that if you lose it all?"

"No, no, Tip - you're thinking about it all wrong amigo. If I quit now then he would have, by your estimation, been a good omen. Right?"

I thought about it for a moment and I couldn't disagree with him. If we split right now the cat would, theoretically, have been a good omen - his appearance having coincided with the accumulation of an additional twenty unearned dollars.

"Well, yes," I conceded. "That would be the case if we left right now. But omens aren't a real thing anyways. It's luck is all it is. My Uncle Woody was the one who was interested in omens, not me."

Tip bared his teeth in a smile. “Bullshit, bullshit. I’m calling your bullshit, Tip, man. You said when we are dealing with luck, things like omens HAVE TO be taken into account. You said that because of the cat and now you’re backin’ out on your own brilliant thoughts. Bullshit, Tip. You. You were the one who said that.”

I supposed there was nothing else I could do to divert his ambitions. I said, “I suppose there is nothing else I can do to divert your ambitions.” But I had a plan. “Here is the deal - if I win we collect, if I lose, we collect, and I’m only putting twenty down.” I put out my elbow for him to tap it with his own elbow, which was a little action we did to signify that we were in on something together. Hesitantly, he tapped it.

There is a part in all of us that wishes never to stop - and I don’t just mean at the blackjack game in the back of *The Island Shoppe* - I mean with life, with drinking or smoking or fighting or despising. There is a part in all of us that wishes to be like the fruit that is only at its ripest before it is rotten. I didn’t think Benny would accept my offer - and he certainly wavered enough to justify my opinion.

But in the end, as was the case more often than not, Benny’s brain maintained its prominence in the make-up of his person.

“Fine. You fucking fuck.” He tapped my elbow with his own.

“Not as eloquent as usual.” I pressed the green button and the cards fell. Pair of eights.

If there was one rule that I had seared into my brain from my Uncle Woody it was that you always split on Aces and eights. The logic is that neither hand is particularly strong.

Aces can be either ones or elevens and there are more cards that are valued at ten than any other number in a blackjack deck.

A pair of eights, on the other hand, is one of the weakest hands in the game. By splitting it you provide yourself additional opportunity to turn the hand around. The problem was, however, that in order to split, you had to double down your bet as well.

I explained the above to Benny and he started laughing maniacally. “Good thing I took an extra ten my man.” He pulled it from his back pocket and grabbed my hand, which I hadn’t realized was clenched in a fist at my waist. He grasped my hand in a *thumb war* position with another pair of two five dollar bills between us.

I was at an impasse. Logic dictated that I do it. It was too late to back out and a pair of eights was certainly losing. On the other hand, by splitting I would be risking all the money; and if I lost we’d have to answer to Mr. O’Rourke. If I lost on the eights, so what? We’d return the money to Mr.

O'Rourke and call it a day. "We can't do that Ben," I told him. "Let's just get out of here in one piece."

It was at that moment I watched him slip into a version of himself I've seen only a few times since. He reminded me of a jackal - there might as well have been drool dripping from the corners of his mouth. "You fucking pussy," he said. "It's my money - get out of the way."

Just then the cat jumped down from the chair and exited the back parlor. Neither of us mentioned it. Our hands were still grasped, now in a contentious, adolescent sort of way.

If he wanted to lose his money, I decided, so be it. I let his hand loose and the two five dollar bills remained pinched between his fingertips and his palm. "I'll wait outside in that case, Ben. I'm only trying to...I'm just trying to be logical here." He'd already turned back to the machine, plopped the money in the slot, and pressed the button to double down. I walked out through the partition, paying no attention to where Ronnie might be or the sounds filtering in from behind me. I walked past the staircase that led to Ronnie's upstairs apartment and heard him thumping around up there. I opened the door slowly so that he wouldn't hear the sound of the bell. Then I stepped out into the miserable heat and began to cry for no good reason at all. [FINISH THIS STORY]

Five

"Let's put it this way," said Benny, "he isn't staying on the island right now. Mom's nervous sick and I'm not ready for all that. Every time she calls she starts crying by the end of it. I can't stand it - I end up getting mean with her - like real mean like my dad can be, you know? It's not cool. I don't want to make things worse."

"Where have you been staying since you've been back? Didn't school get out on Friday?"

"I've been staying with Jenny. She started working at *Peachy's Grill* after highschool. We've been in touch since I went off to State. She's got her own apartment, shit's wicked."

"I know Jenny," I said.

I knew her because she did a little buying for Peachy and was down at Grayson's with relative frequency. They bought shrimp for salads and any sort of white fish by the bucket. Peachy's was known for one thing and that was a fried fish sandwich - *guaranteed local* - though there was no guarantee what the fish would be. Your average palette isn't sophisticated enough to recognize the difference between fried mahi, fried grouper, and fried flounder. They'll tell you they do, they'll swear it, but put them to a blind test and I'll promise you seven out of ten will fail it. That's why fish prices

rise and fall the way they do. It's not that one fish is better than another to the average American palate - it's the market that tells you what a fish tastes like.

It's well known that lobsters were a poor man's food for most of American history - this is because they were so bountiful in the northeast. We considered them the cockroaches of the sea. It was once the railways opened up and canned food came into vogue that all that changed. At some point there, in the middle of the nineteenth century, we took to canning and shipping that *cockroach* meat, and the poor adventurers out in the middle of the country welcomed the new addition to their diet with such a ferocity that lobster became a rich man's food by virtue of demand, by extension it became much tastier to the public. Nowadays you see it with cod, bluefin tuna, wild-caught salmon. They too, will be replaced in our collective diets before long.

You don't know what you like until they let you know, and even then.

"Are you and Jenny... a thing?" How I fumbled words like a caught politician. Never in my life did language interfere with my ability to communicate except in matters of interpersonal relations, particularly those of the co-ed variety.

Benny and I were seated on the porch watching the lightning bugs flickering. The moon was large and full - its bright light filtered through the tree tops and reached the floor in muted patches. The only disruption was the occasional commercial airplane. A new flight path had been agreed upon, apparently, that passed directly over the island. Many of the local islanders disapproved of the new flight path - it was hotly debated in town hall conversations, but there was not much that could be done to stop it.

"We're just friends - that's all," he said. Then he finished off another beer and added it to the pyramid he'd been constructing. I'd need to get more beer if he planned to stay any longer. "I mean don't get me wrong - I wouldn't mind giving it the old college try," he laughed. "But no. I don't know if she really sees me that way, anyway."

"Right," I said. "Girls are a confusing lot. Tough to know what they really want, I guess."

"Try impossible. I mean, really, I guess I was a little confused - she invited me to stay with her. I told her I'd sleep on the couch but she told me she wanted me to sleep in the bed with her. You'd think...I mean, I thought that it meant--" he stopped himself. "I don't know what I'm saying. I think I'm finally drunk."

"You slept with her?"

"Well yes, but in the literal way."

"I've never slept with a girl that I can remember."

“Me either, Tip. It’s sorta uncomfortable, really.” Just then he let out a large belch followed by an equally impressive fart. He cracked himself up for a moment watching me pinch my nose and wave my hands about to ward off the smell. “You gotta hold your farts in all night long, for one thing. I wake up in the morning with a stomach ache, I swear. Plus, the bathroom is right next to the bedroom so if I go in there in the morning she can hear every noise unless I run the shower or something - which is just extra obvious. I’ve been waiting until she leaves for work to take a shit. It’s not sustainable.”

“Do you like her?”

“*Like her?* What are we, twelve? She’s hot, bangable - but you know what she was like in high school.”

“Not really,” I said.

“Right. Sorry. I always forget you weren’t there.”

“Well I still caught wind of some of the rumors - but never really knew if they were true or not. The guys at the dock salivate when she comes by. One of them says that his nephew ‘rode that train’, to use the colloquialism that he used.”

Benny was visibly upset by my comment. His face, already reddened by sun and alcohol, now deepened its shade. “Which one of them said that?”

“I didn’t believe it Ben - don’t take it the wrong way. I just meant that’s all I’d heard was all. I figured it was a bunch of talk. You know how those guys talk.”

“Was it Cotton? I bet it was Cotton. His nephew is a total bullshit artist. Kid works at a car shop and can barely change his own oil. What’s his name? Lester? Leonard?”

“Lawrence,” I said - “Well, Larry I guess is what he goes by.”

“Larry, that’s right.”

“I really didn’t mean to get you upset, Ben - honestly.”

“Tip, I couldn’t get mad at you if I tried. It’s nothing to do with you. I feel bad for Jenny is all. She’d give her left tit to get off this island. It’s all she talks about. She’s suffocating here, she says. She got caught one time, at one of Harrison’s big house parties, doing something. And now the whole island thinks they know who she is. Fuck this island, man.”

“I’m sorry I brought it up,” I said. I didn’t know what else to say. “I might sit out here and read for a while tonight. I got you set up on the couch - put out pillows and blankets etc. Did you get a chance to check it out?”

“Nah,” he said. “Not yet.” He was far off in his own head by then.

I thought of making a joke about him and I *sleeping together* , but at least in this I was smart enough to read the room and withheld my comment. “I’m going to grab my book,” I told him. “Need anything while I’m in there?”

“Nah,” was all he said.

I went inside and fixed myself a glass of water before grabbing my heavily worn copy of *The Magic Mountain* from beside my reading chair. I was on my third read-through and for some reason this reading had been less satisfying than I remembered it. There was something insincere about Hans Castorp, the main character, that I hadn’t really recognized in him before. Too obviously a tool for the author, not quite human enough, it had begun to seem to me. But still I wanted to finish it all the same - there were moments of pure lucidity scattered throughout the work that still offered me moments of clarity and recognition. It was not that the book itself had lost its merit, is what I mean, but that I’d grown apart from Hans Castorp in some way and no longer felt the same admiration for his constant questioning and prognosticating. Joachim’s character, on the other hand, Hans Castorp’s cousin/foil, seemed to me all the more real now.

Back on the porch Benny had fallen asleep with a half-full can of beer dangling from his fingertips. He looked like the man in my mother’s painting, I thought - tired and awaiting something, something, something. I took the can from his hand gently so as not to disturb him. He made a small unintelligible noise and readjusted himself without waking. I went inside to get a trash bag and returned to collect cans and empty the overflowing ashtray.

Finally, cleaning done, I sat down to read - but something about the day had disrupted my routine. I couldn’t focus on the book. I’d read a sentence and then begin to wonder about Mr. O’Rourke, one thought leading to another, concern welled in my chest. What had Mr. O’Rourke done? He was the closest thing I could imagine to having a father - the only male besides my grandfather who’d been a constant in my life. But with Benny’s departure for college, the fact that Mr. O’Rourke was *not* my father became all the more apparent. How long had he been in trouble? What could he have done to keep Benny away? I couldn’t know - it wasn’t part of the agreement - and so not only was Mr. O’Rourke not my father, but by extension Benny was also not my *brother* . Bitterly I thought about his explanation of fraternities. Those were his brothers now, I thought. Bonded by ritual.

Before I went inside I shook Benny to wake him, but he brushed me off with a mumbled, “No, no, no.”

“Ben, your neck is gonna feel broken if you sleep like that.”

“Mmhhh,” he half-snorted and then turned to his side a bit.

“Can I get you a pillow or something?” But by then he’d stopped responding to me at all. I turned the lights off and the fan on as I went inside. I left the door unlocked and put a cup of water by the couch in case he made it back inside.

That night I dreamed about Jenny. In my dream Benny was off at school somewhere far, far away while Jenny and I were seated on the dock. She wore a towel as a dress and throughout the dream I tried in vain to accidentally step on the corner of her towel so that it would fall to her ankles. I followed her out onto the dock, past where it had been swept away by the storm. Eventually, in my dream, I turned around to look back and there was nothing there. The dock was just an island. Jenny was gone. A storm was coming in.

Six

The next morning I woke early, as usual, and decided to make corned beef hash and scrambled eggs. Benny had made his way inside at some point during the night and was sprawled out, stomach down, on the couch. His entire face was pressed into the pillow in a way that made it hard to understand how he could breathe at all. The scent of corned beef hash roused him. “What the hell time is it?!”

“Five forty seven,” I told him. “Eighteen minutes til sunrise.”

“Haven’t you ever heard of sleep?”

I pressed the hash down into a thick patty with a flat metal spatula and listened to it sizzle. “It’s good for you to watch the sunrise. I read about it recently. The point of the article was that it’s good for the human sleep cycle to be in alignment with sunrise and sunset.”

“Nonsense,” Benny muttered.

“It’s best to wake a few minutes before sunrise and begin powering your body down, preparing for sleep I mean, just after it gets dark out. Your circadian rhythm is really very important.” Benny meandered into the kitchen, eyes sunken into his head and red, shirtless. He was wearing a pair of my gym shorts that I’d left beside the couch on my way to bed.

“Damn you know a lot, Tip. You know that?”

“Almost as much as one of those *brothers* of yours, I’d imagine.”

“Oh I get it now,” Benny said - a smile eased into his dazed face. “You’re jealous.”

I had to restrain myself. The problem was that he was right. That was often the problem with Benny. He knew me well enough to aim at the gaps in my armor. I was jealous. Yes, of course I was. Still, was I not right as well? A counter attack of the character - *ad hominem*. It was the type of response that intentionally went nowhere fast. A good rhetorician, however, if they keep their composure, can parry an *ad hominem* attack in a variety of ways. I decided to take the most adolescent approach.

“Jealous? Hah. I’m sure you are made randy by the homerotic undertones of your fraternal order, but I’m more interested in women - thank you very much. You can keep your *faggot* club for yourself.” I couldn’t believe what I’d said. I doubled down. “Bet you had to fellate one of the seniors just to get in the cool club. Sad, really, it depresses me that you bought your friends.” I couldn’t stop myself.

Benny was not smiling at all anymore. His blank eyes looked more confused than anything. “Nothing to say to your *jealous* friend?”

“Jesus, Tip - I didn’t mean to hit a nerve.”

Immediately I felt terrible for what I’d said. I apologized and offered him a plate of eggs and hash. In the center of the kitchen was an L-shaped countertop and some barstools where Benny took a seat.

“I’m not jealous of those guys,” I told him. “I think it’s weird is all - I mean, it’s just not my kind of thing. I didn’t mean what I said, though.” I stopped myself to put the words together just right. “I was being defensive in response to what I perceived as a verbal slight. I’m sorry, again.”

I realized Benny was in his own head again. He couldn’t have cared much less about what I’d said. He poked around at the eggs (which, objectively, were excellent). He took a bite and chewed and thought.

“It’s fine, Tip. It’s nothin’.” He had the bottle of hot sauce upside down over his plate - some of the sauce had congealed in the mouth of the bottle and nothing was coming out. He pounded at the bottom of the bottle with an open palm until the dam broke and hot sauce came pouring out in a solid stream. By the time he righted the bottle his eggs and hash were swimming in a bright red pool of cayenne pepper sauce.

My friend Benny was depressed. He set his fork down on the counter and took the spoon from the coffee I’d set beside his plate. He proceeded to ladle the egg/hash/hot sauce soup into his mouth as though nothing had happened at all. He’d gone insane, it seemed. What had college done to him?

“What’s wrong Ben? I’ve known you long enough to tell something is off.”

It was just after six in the morning and the birds and insects had commenced their morning symphony.

“There is nothing wrong with me, Tip. I’m pissed at the old man. He fucked up good this time. I knew it was coming - but I didn’t know it was gonna be so soon.” A mother mockingbird swooped at some noisy finches out the kitchen window. “I don’t feel like talking about it to be honest. This is their thing to deal with. I’m staying out of it.”

[MORE HERE]

Seven

It had been a week since Benny had *moved in* with me for the summer.

He'd gone back to Jenny's soon after breakfast that following morning. His toothbrush was still there, he said, and his mouth tasted like shit. He said he'd be back later that afternoon but I did not hear from him at all that night. I was restless and nervous about him. It wasn't the drinking, but the way he drank like he was on a mission. It wasn't the crooked smile but the unnatural way he forced it to his lips as though it sufficed as a response. Some smiles are just grimaces in a state of undress.

That night I hardly slept. I heard a coyote ambush a wild turkey just outside the bedroom window - in the morning I would find a few bloodied feathers beside a smattering of small pawprints and not much else. I watched heat lightning paint the thin blinds in bursts for several hours. Heat lighting, by virtue of its silence, provides an almost surreal experience wherein expectation and reality are slightly askew. The light flashes and one waits for a clap of thunder that is never to come. I read a few short stories by Raymond Carver in the soft-glow light of the lamp beside my bed. Too fatalistic. Carver is a bummer. His characters have always made me want to shout at them: *Take control of your life!* But in the end perhaps they are more honest in that they do not. Agency is a concept well worth a thorough investigation and literature may be the best place to do that - so I don't blame Carver, but that doesn't mean that I enjoy reading him either. Sentences so blunt and sad that they'd give me the briefest feelings of existential weightlessness - the quick glimpse of being nothing.

Just before seven AM on that second morning I heard his car pattering up the gravel drive. I guessed I hadn't fallen asleep, but I couldn't be sure. The night can be funny like that - twisting time in shapes that make no sense to the conscious mind. I couldn't *remember* having been asleep, but I couldn't be certain I hadn't slept either - like the night had happened to someone else and I'd only been watching. Perhaps the main character had dozed off for a moment or two but even then I was watching.

The old Volkswagen he drove chortled loudly and at once I was alert - whatever semi-conscious state I'd been in was now completely evaporated. By ear I could discern that he came to a stop in the parking area across from the decrepit fountain that sat a few yards from the front porch, centered in the drive. It had once flowed with drinkable well water until our well was sold off with the rest of the property. That had been a disaster - getting city water out here - but that was what we had now. Reenie had decided it was too expensive to run the water now that it came from the city - she let the fountain fall into ruin. In a mere decade it had turned ancient and I'd yet to find the energy to involve myself in resurrecting it.

My bedroom, which had once been Reenie's bedroom and my parents' before that, was tucked away in the corner of the house down a hallway that seems longer than the house should allow. It is on my to-do list, to this day, to have an architect provide blueprints for the layout of this house.

This is because the hallway is not the only incongruity that baffles me. The office for example, which occupies the front right corner of the first floor of the house, has much higher ceilings than the other rooms on the first floor - but there is no visible accommodation for this on the second level of the house, which is all built on the same plane. How could the ceiling be higher than the floor above it? Of course, it must be that it only seems this way - but it is jarring enough to bother the discerning observer, even if subconsciously.

He sat out in his car for a while and listened to Leonard Cohen's *Hallelujah* (it must have been at full volume) on repeat three or four times before I heard the engine shut off and once again the natural sounds were all there was. I'd introduced him to Leonard Cohen and specifically I explained to him why I found the original version of the song superior to the Jeff Buckley interpretation, which sacrifices the exalting tone of the original in favor of amplifying the melancholy. I felt that this ran counter to the dualism that seemed to me to be fundamental to the song's purpose.

*And even though it all went wrong
I'll stand before the Lord of song
With nothing on my tongue but Hallelujah*

I finally sat up. I twisted the long pencil shaped rod that rotated the slats of the blinds to either let in, or block out, the penetrating light of the outdoors. By rotating it clockwise I was able to set the slats to a horizontal position that allowed me to see out into the front drive where Benny was parked. The dirty gravel was in bad need of replenishing. It was supposed to blanket the ground like snow but as it had not been kept up it now would be more accurately described as *peppering* the ground. Dirt was visible throughout - particularly in two thick ruts where car tires followed the same tracks coming and going from the house. As children we used to run across the gravel barefoot, though it was painful to us both - and when we'd return to the house we would inspect the soles of our feet with our young fingers, the impression of the gravel surface imprinted into our skin. Some days we spent inspecting the gravel piece by piece, in search of the fabled *megalodon* tooth. Amateur archeologists. We never found the tooth of the prehistoric shark, but we did find other things - the teeth of smaller sharks, small imprints of shells that we called fossils, (despite the fact that many of them were likely far younger than the ten thousand year old requirement as dictated by the objective definition of the term *fossil*), cigarette butts by the bucketload, a cubic zirconia earring without its significant other. As I looked out on his car, the interior light still on, a small thread of smoke coming out of the cracked window on the driver's side, I thought back on those earlier days and felt a pang of sadness about the ways in which the world had seemed to infect us with its ambiguities.

Finally he emerged from his vehicle. He pulled himself up and out of the front seat by grabbing onto the doorframe. The door swung a bit on its hinge and Benny wobbled a bit to catch his feet. He looked up towards my room, which would have been the only light in the house. I do not know if he was able to see me from where he stood, but he at least acted as if he knew I was watching. He waved a floppy hand in the direction of the house and then teetered a bit more before stumbling in that general direction. He forgot to shut his car door behind him. The interior lights of the car remained on.

He didn't bother to come say hello once he made his way inside. I heard his heavy steps find their way to the den - *thunk* as he fell down onto the old, worn leather of the couch. I decided I'd rather wait to speak with him - let him *sleep it off* as they say. So I waited a few minutes, until he began to snore loudly, before I went outside through the side door of the house to shut his car door. I didn't want him to find out I didn't even know how to jump start a car - it was one of those shortcomings (or as I liked to call them, *blindspots*) that a boy without parents around grows to despise within himself .

Eight

Midday light came in through the large, aging windows and glass door that led to the porch out back. Sunlight permeated the room to the extent that no artificial light was needed. If I'd turned on the lamp it would only have been for the thrill of electricity - there would be no purpose to it. Through the windows the canopy was visible, and in the canopy there was a car-sized gap between two trees that let one particular area of the house receive the warmth of the sun in all its sublimity. The space for the sun was man-made - by which I mean Casper had scaled the tree with a saw in one hand and a Pabst Blue Ribbon in the other - he'd climbed out onto some of the heftier branches and made quick work of paring back the new growth so that the view would be opened up. After he was done I was able to see straight to the blue sky from my recliner, and at certain hours of the day the sun would come through at exactly the correct angle and act as a spotlight on whatever book I held in my hands as I sat there and read. That morning I remember that the sun was particularly bright - its inverse shadow stretched across the room all morning until it had come upon Benny and the couch, waking him.

After some moaning and stretching he finally sat up. He coughed up what sounded like a massive ball of phlegm and then promptly swallowed. I could have thrown up. Perhaps it was that sort of thing that had led to his late-night/early-morning arrival. He grunted and coughed again; groaned. "What happened?" I finally asked.

"She told me I was like a brother to her. What the fuck was that supposed to mean?" It was just after noon. Benny had arisen in a miserable state. His sparse facial hair was beginning to look like little patches of weeds sprouting in isolated locations around his face. A patch on the cheek, a thin strip on the jawline, strong growth at the chin, but barely anything in between except dry red skin and a mouth

shaped like a shrimp. “You don’t sleep in the same bed as your brother. I mean, that’s mixed messages if you ask me.”

He’d tried to make a sexual advance on Jenny, from what I could gather, but the feelings had not been reciprocated. It was strange, I agreed, to sleep in a bed with someone who reminded you of your brother - but what did I know? I didn’t have any siblings.

“I didn’t push it or anything but after she made it clear that I was supposed to stay over on the other side of the bed I couldn’t get back to sleep. I just sat there and thought about it and felt wicked dumb.”

He pretended to be holding some sort of a weapon and fired it towards the sky. “Shot down.” Then he used his hand to mock an airplane nose diving into a crash. “Eventually she falls asleep and starts snoring and I realized I wasn’t going to get to sleep at all.” I didn’t bother telling him I hadn’t slept myself - he was off in his own head again, as he’d been most of the time since he’d been back.

“Well you know you are welcome here. Glad to have you, in fact - it gets boring around here.”

He looked around the den and laughed, “Tell me about it.” Benny had never been rude before. This was a symptom of college, I thought. “Not like that, Tip-man. I love it here. Love you like a brother,” he laughed, “but I ain’t sleeping next to you in bed.” I chuckled to let him know I wasn’t mad.

“She said you were like a brother? Everyone is a *brother* nowadays I suppose. Filial bonds just aren’t what they used to be.”

“Nah, that’s just a chick’s way of saying they don’t want to fuck you. She doesn’t really care about me all that much, I don’t think.” Then he paused for a sad moment, “But I don’t get why she would have put me on like that, I guess. I guess I was reading the whole thing wrong.”

I offered him some coffee which he graciously accepted. I felt, for once, that I was not the *second in command*. Benny needed me. “Fickle,” I said, “the whole lot of them.”

Benny laughed.

I laughed.

I’d never seen him so far off track.

“Maybe it’s just the women on this island,” I probed. “You’ll be back to state in no time. You need one of those yankee girls that want to *bang their brother*.”

“I didn’t say they want to *bang* their brother - I said they want to bang someone like their brother. Oh, I see what you’re getting at. Good one, Tip-man.”

“I wish I could come visit,” I said.

“You could,” he said. “I’ve told you that.”

“Yeah but you know.”

“I know.”

“Besides, it’s not as cool as I made it sound. I only got laid once, to tell the truth. And I can’t really remember it all that well.”

“Only once?”

“Jesus Tip, don’t rub it in.” I’d hit a nerve. “Who are you to be giving me shit anyways? You some kind of Cassanova?” He retrieved a pair of sunglasses from his breast pocket and put them on - wide rimmed with dark lenses, thin metal temples that wrapped completely around the back of his ears. I was struck by the ways in which he looked less and less like the Benny who’d left for college a year ago, clean-shaven, bright-eyed and thin with youth.

Had something been lost or gained? I couldn’t tell.

I knew I had changed in some ways too. There were things I wasn’t ready to say to Benny - which had never been the case before. I had secrets. It felt terrible.

Since Ben had been gone I’d become friends with Casper. Not like *brothers*, of course, but we shared a camaraderie and mutual respect for one another’s eccentricities.

Casper, for example, smoked copious amounts of marijuana and often liked to do cocaine late into the night. This was fine with me. He did his cocaine and zoomed around the house, rode a bike to the corner store to pick up alcohol and cigarettes, talked in circles about things that were logically impotent, smoked and smoked and smoked. He asked me to tell him if I was ever being made uncomfortable by his presence and I had taken him to heart on that request. I was very forthright with him - “You’re giving me anxiety by moving around so much and I don’t think your last statement about Guatemalans was even mildly appropriate.” He’d apologize and do his best, though of course much of it was simply his nature and I did not blame him for saying the things he said or acting the way he did. With a childhood like his, one would be misguided to expect a polished temperament.

The most we can ask of one another is generosity of spirit and genuine intentions. I mean the very most we can ask of one another is simply to try. Casper tried.

I should say: I admired Casper in that he could fail so often and continue to try. He navigated life with the hardened resolve of a pinball - clacked around in all directions, occasionally swallowed up when the chaos became too much only to re-emerge, firing on all cylinders, back into the entropy of his existence. He was, without knowing it, a semi-successful Buddhist, I thought.

I was nervous about introducing Casper to Benny. Not that I was worried how Casper would react. He was simple, in that he could only be himself. There weren't secret parts of him that might be holding their tongue. There were variations of his personality, but those too were easily understood. There was "no-beer Casper", who was nearly silent unless someone mentioned beer or women. Then there was "six-beer Casper", who was still fairly reserved but would occasionally pipe up with half-remembered axioms and bits of convoluted wisdom. "Ain't no atheists in a fox's hole." And it was a fool's errand to attempt to correct him - it was as though once he'd said something it had been completely excised from his brain. Then there was "beer Casper", which just meant the number of beers no longer mattered. He was funny and morose, friendly but rude, a storyteller as skilled as any fisherman. He told long-winded stories with contradictory plots and ambiguous conclusions. He wrapped his arm around your shoulder to apologize for something long forgotten. He occasionally performed incredible mathematical feats in his head that no one could believe until they were verified by a calculator.

No, it wasn't Casper that concerned me, but Benny, who had been showing signs of a vulnerable mental condition and seemed to be drinking his instability into reality. Casper drank as though it was a part of himself. Benny drank as though he was trying to harm a part of himself. They were radically different approaches to the same fundamental act - and differentiating one from the other seemed near impossible.

That morning, for example, I watched him fill and empty a shot glass three consecutive times while he thought I was reading a Tom Robbins novel. Really, I'd picked up the novel merely to disguise myself - who in their right mind could read Tom Robbins in the morning? It would be like asking for your day to fall into chaos. On the third pour I saw him grimace after he swallowed the shot. Then he washed and dried the shot glass quietly before returning it to the exact same spot it had been on the drying rack when he found it.

I called out to him presently, "Are you planning to see your parents at all?" When he didn't respond, "You don't have to talk to me about it if you don't want to - I'm not attempting to persuade you in any direction. Just curious. I can't imagine you don't miss them. Are they still giving you money?"

The finances of the O'Rourke family were altogether a mystery to me. *Steinman's* was perpetually empty. In my youth I'd been under the impression that he made large sums of money trading in rare books behind the scenes. I presumed the storefront was more or less an office where Mr. O'Rourke left the doors open from time to time - if someone stopped by and wanted one of his books he would part with it for a price - but the real money, I guessed, was made during the important calls he took in his back room when sometimes he shouted and other times he forced laughter, even other times he spoke in a near whisper, despite the fact that there was no one around besides Benny and myself to over hear him.

I hadn't made up the idea about the rare books. Mr. O'Rourke himself boasted sometimes about particularly rare editions he'd recently *stumbled upon*, a first edition of *Finnegans Wake*. A signed copy of *Ulysses*. A rare printing of *Meditations* that was specially published for soldiers to read during the Second World War. I'd never seen one of them, and as far as I knew Benny hadn't either - so they were more or less lore to us, and we'd often joke that they didn't even exist.

At some point it became clear to me that even if there was a secret treasure trove of rare literature somewhere in the back of *Steinman's*, it wasn't as though that would provide the income required to send Benny to private school, keep the shop afloat, and pay the mortgage on their house, which had a three car garage, was fronted by large Greek doric columns, and sported a master bathtub large enough for several adults to fit in comfortably. Their property was two plots down from where our's ended and the house was constructed during the same era, with the same classical styles and detailed finishings. It was a moneyed place. There had to be some other source of income to allow for that - something other than a bookstore on a small barrier island where (from what I could tell) there weren't too many "literary" inhabitants in the first place.

Secrets beget secrets. And the same can be said for suspicions, I have often thought. Now that I was aware Mr. O'Rourke had been deceiving me throughout my childhood I could imagine the myriad secrecies he might continue to hide. *Steinman's* - a book store - hah! It was all beginning to make sense, I thought.

As a young man with little to occupy his time I was beginning to feel some excitement around investigating a *mystery*. I wanted to know everything there was to know about the O'Rourkes. My best friend, Benny, was not going to give any of it away, I had come to realize. Perhaps before he'd left for college I could have teased it out of him, but not *new Benny* - he wouldn't even give me a clear answer as to whether his parents were still supporting him financially. I'd asked him if they were still giving him money, to which he responded, "I'm getting what I need to get by." But this wasn't an answer to the question.

"Do you need money? I can lend you--no, I can *give you* some if you need it. I hardly spend anything out here."

"Thanks but no thanks. Debt is the devil's best friend. I don't ever want to owe you a dime - that's how you lose people." He spoke as though it came from a great well of sadness, a dearth of experience with life, death and money, that I simply knew he didn't possess. He could sense my intuition. "Look I don't want to go into all of it about my old man, alright? Alright? *High Tide Inn* - if you want to get into all that you can go find him there. Room thirteen, I think." And then he lit his first cigarette of the day. He'd become a heavy smoker, it seemed. His hands shook as he brought the cigarette to his lips. "What time is it anyways?"

Nine

It took four cigarettes and the rest of the mason jar of moonshine but finally Benny came to life. We'd planned to go fishing, gathering all the tackle and gear, rigging multiple rods so that we could fish for the sheepshead and flounder near the dock as well as casting for bonnethead shark out in the middle of the current. No matter what we used we always came up with more stingrays than anything. Useless creatures.

The weather turned though, before we'd even finished getting ready. I was in the kitchen making sandwiches to bring with us when I noticed the gray light out the window. The leaves on the trees all showed their undersides, a sure sign of weather to come according to my grandmother. The birds had, for the most part, gone silent. My birdfeeder, which usually served as an aviary clubhouse, swayed lazily in the gathering wind, empty.

These mid-afternoon showers were to be expected during the summer. During the day one could feel the buildup of moisture in the air, a sense of tension grows as clouds begin to congregate in more tightly gathered packs, growing and darkening until somewhere there is a release, the water grows too heavy for flight, and it is released in thick raindrops that make large plops when they hit the ground.

Visibility decreases and one's world feels a bit simpler in heavy rain. The heavy clouds reverberate the totalitarian supremacy of rain sound, amplifying it and isolating the individual from other farther off sounds that they might normally hear. There are no more sounds of foghorns or far off traffic, an ambulance passing by on McCallan might as well be in another state. One finds themselves in a temporary position of audio-visual isolation and the whole world constricts.

On most days the isolation was a pleasant experience - but being that I was watching over Benny, and Benny himself was not in the most effusive states, on that day the feeling was more one of being trapped than comforted. I thought it would be a good idea to get out of the house.

"How about we shoot some billiards? I've been practicing a bit since you left."

This was an understatement - every time Casper came in from a trip, after he got some food and booze in his system, our first course of action was to go play billiards at *Rickert's*, which was defined as a social club for some sort of convoluted tax purposes, but by all definitions was nothing more than a pub with a billiards table, a few poker machines, and a jukebox with an incredibly limited selection (in fact it was very similar to the selection of records left by my father).

For the first few weeks I barely played at all. This was one of the fundamental rules in the "The Casper Williams School of Shootin' Stick" - one must observe, observe, observe, before finally beginning to play.

On the first day Casper taught me the fundamentals: a proper stance, how to position your thumb against your index finger to provide a bridge that was both flexible and sturdy.

[MORE HERE]

A group of local bikers arrived, a few of whom Casper had known in “another life” as he put it, and Casper told me to sit and watch for the remainder of the evening. One by one the bikers would approach the table, insert two quarters, rack the balls in a small diamond (this was a different game than the one Casper had shown me - I learned the rules in short order while watching); then Casper would break the rack and if he did not clear the table on the break he’d make short order of it after his opponent missed his first shot. It was incredible to watch. It was immediately obvious he’d been merely toying with me earlier. I was both grateful and embarrassed. He could hit bank shots, kiss shots, combination shots. Hardest of all, he constantly would tell me, were the straight shots, and he hit those too. Never, though, did Casper attempt a jump shot. That was for amateurs, he told me.

I didn’t realize, until there was a minor dispute over which ball the cue ball had struck first, that Casper was playing for money. The sequence in which the balls were hit was of great importance in *nine-ball*, I came to understand, as the goal of the game was to pocket all of the balls in order before reaching the final ball, the nine-ball. A player could sink all eight of the prior balls in order, miss on the final shot, and hand the stick to his opponent who needed only, now, to make the one single shot in order to win the game. I liked the rules of nine-ball - they brought a great deal of strategy into the game. Whereas eight-ball required strong tactical skill and the ability to pocket your balls quickly, nine-ball was a game that introduced greater emphasis on strategy while also providing the opportunity for a great burst of luck at any given time. This is one of the reasons why gamblers, I’ve come to learn, prefer nine-ball to eight-ball.

The bikers were only an appetizer for Casper - they played until their pockets were empty. Within an hour he’d swept them off the table.

They had been replaced by two young Chinese men who were, in Casper’s words, “Respectable hustlers, but out of their league.”

They’d been playing for almost an hour and a half when the soldiers arrived, presumably on leave from their base, which was forty or so miles south of the island and served as a training facility for new cadets. One of them was easily recognized as a drill sergeant because in addition to being fully donned in military garb he’d brought his hat in with him, Casper pointed out. The others, his colleagues (there were four of them altogether), were also dressed in uniform, but did not carry a hat like the drill sergeant’s, which was wide-brimmed and tall and reminded me of the hat that Smokey the Bear wore on television commercials. Their sheer mass drew the attention of the other patrons at *Rickert’s*. They travelled in a small pack, never straying too far from one another. They took a seat at a table against the wall on the opposite side of the bar. I thought it an appropriately tactical choice as it provided a full

one hundred and eighty degree view of the establishment without obstruction. Though I had not thought of it before they'd taken their seats, I now saw that it was an *outpost* of sorts in that it provided maximum visibility of the space they'd entered and allowed no opportunity for one to approach them without being seen first.

"Watch the big one," Casper whispered to me. "He keeps looking over this way. Wants to play." He was putting the finishing touches on the more skilled of the two Chinese men. The other had retired to watch from a seat in the corner - my doppelganger, I thought.

The man Casper was referring to, the big one, was the drill sergeant. He had dark brown skin and his head was almost entirely shaven except at the very top where he maintained a very short thatch of hair, cleanly squared and trimmed immaculately. His tiny eyes frightened me. They looked like two raisins that had been pressed into the boxy frame of his face. His jaw was broad and rigid, as though he were a caricature of himself - a trope, or cliché, depending on one's generosity of spirit. Below his bountiful jaw was his neck, supported on either side by buttresses of trapezius muscles that seemed to rise out of his shoulders, large enough they could have supported a pair of wings. He couldn't have been able to turn his head very far in either direction. It also was notable that the man appeared not just large, but dense. What must a man like that weigh? I wondered. Suddenly he was staring back at me with those small dark eyes. I looked down into my cherry soda and felt my face go flush.

The next time Casper walked past me, rounding the table to observe a bank shot from the opposite side, he muttered under his breath, "You didn't have to watch that fuckin' hard." Casper was not educated in the formal sense of the word but he was always the most observant person in the room. He attributed this to his short stint in juvenile detention, which he asserted could be as dangerous as any state penitentiary out there. He posited that *juvies* were scarier than adults in that they'd yet to develop an instinct for self-preservation - furthermore, he argued, they were more likely to have severe undiagnosed mental disorders.

As such, he knew that the drill sergeant was Panamanian, a combat veteran and had been divorced at least once - he knew all this before the man came to the table, put a quarter down beside the hand-chalk, and asked if we ('they') were playing for money or pride.

Casper, as though it had been staged, lined up a three ball combination that resulted in the sinking of the nine-ball, ending the game in impressive fashion. He looked up at the soldier with a coy smile and said, "Been playing for twenty a game but don't let that scare you off."

The drill sergeant laughed in a frightening way - without moving any of the muscles in his face - and then walked back towards the table where he and his *brethren* sat. Whatever he said caused the whole group to look our way simultaneously and I felt a pang of fear course through my body. Then he returned to his party, speaking over his shoulder as he walked away.

Casper played two more games with his current opponent. After the second game, a thoroughly embarrassing rout, the opponent walked over to the corner where his confidant sat stoically. The seated man whispered in his partner's ear. The shorter one, all but weeping, finally seemed to accept defeat. He made a sign with his hand to indicate that they were all done. Casper sat down beside me and counted a stack of folded bills in his hands.

He spoke in a low drawl, "S'gettin' fun." Nothing about it seemed fun to me, quite the opposite, I was frightened - but I cannot deny that I was exhilarated too. Casper handed me a twenty dollar bill and asked for a Pabst and a shot of Goldschlager.

"I'm only eighteen," I said.

"And?"

"What if they ask for my ID?"

"It's a social club, not a bar," he said. "You have to be twenty-one to come inside. Get it?" I nodded.

"And you're already inside," he raised his eyebrows at me, laughed, and put his small, muscular hand on my shoulder. "Now how about that drink? It ain't much to pay for the show I'm about to put on."

He swung his pool cue around like a baton in one seamless motion, then he clutched it under one arm and drew it back into a pseudo-karate stance. "Young grasshopper," he smiled and laughed again.

Then he motioned to the group of soldiers, who as I've mentioned, could observe everything going on in the dusty environment from where they sat.

I went over to the bar and stood quietly between two large men wearing patches on their leather vests. Hairy-shouldered giants - one peppered with faded tattoos, the other with a scar that ran from the corner of his mouth up his cheek leaving an absence in his beard that was to be noticed.

The bartender took drink orders from the two men I'd squeezed between, but then before I had a chance to catch her attention she'd turned around and was washing a cup out in some sort of badet/dishwashing apparatus. "Excuse me," I squeaked out, but it was as though no one heard me, or if they had, that I'd said the wrong thing somehow. To the follicle-rich men on my right and left I was non-existent. I had the feeling that if they made the decision to squeeze together hip to hip I might, indeed, disappear. I looked back over my shoulder to see Casper watching me from the raised platform where the billiards tables stood. He gestured at me with a flick of his back hand - it was a vague gesture but I understood it nonetheless, *get on with it*. It felt like I was being hazed, I thought. Tough love. The soldier had stood from his table now and was making his way back to the corner where the game was to take place.

The bartender was a heavy-set woman whose age was almost impossible to estimate in the damp lighting. Dark shades diluted low-wattage yellow lightbulbs. She could have been forty as easily as seventy, neither would have surprised me.

“Excuse me!” I repeated, this time louder than before, and raised my hand outward so that it extended between the two oafs that flanked me. Finally, I was recognized - the bartender made an exhausted grimace. The oafs chuckled. “A Pabst,” I said. “And a Goldschlager.” And then for some unbeknownst reason I said, “Make it a double.” Perhaps just in an effort to inhabit the scene. I thought on it and spoke again. “Two Pabst, in fact. Make it two Pabsts and two Goldschlagers, please.” The oafs chuckled again. The bartender eyed me down, dark black circles in the damp light. Then she got on with it. I returned to the table with two beers and two shots.

Casper, astonished, took the drinks from my hand and set them down on the small hi-top in the corner. “Now we’re talkin’,” he said. All the while the drill sergeant was polishing off the tip of a cue-stick with a square of blue chalk. When finally his ceremony was concluded he put two quarters in the machine and racked the balls into the small diamond shape.

There was only one bright light in the whole of *Rickert’s* and it hung approximately three feet above the billiards table, encapsulating it in a spotlight of sorts, so that even the players who circled the table were not illuminated. Only the heavy, cast-resin balls and scuffed green felt were lit in the fluorescent glow.

There is something altogether cinematic about the game of billiards. Perhaps this is why people like Casper, with their proclivity for the dramatic flair (only once intoxicated, of course), are drawn to the game so naturally. Imagine the scene from above: his hands enter the stage; with stern grace they assume their position - disembodied, like a scientist’s gloves as they handle some radioactive material behind thick safety glass - the person responsible for the action is nothing more than a vessel for the hands to do their work; Casper’s *hands* then, not Casper himself, aligning the cue stick so that it strikes the ball in a particular location, a specific quadrant of the sphere, drives the stick into the ball with force, but not necessarily speed, follows through the impact, the only way to make “english” truly work; a ballet of sorts as they pull away from the action now, several balls collide with each other; one refracts at an angle that seemed impossible only moments prior, another slows to a halt, a third, the all-yellow nine-ball, runs down the rail in a straight line, destined for the pocket. Confident hands withdraw the stick from the stage and the act is finished only when the ball drops into the pocket; the gratifying “*thuck*” sound as it disappears from sight. Now all of the action takes place off stage, in the damp light, wet with darkness - an exchange of currency, an accusatory comment, a tip of the glass bottle, an offer to double down.

“You rack, I break this time,” said the soldier.

Casper’s weakness was in his general distaste for seriousness. “Sir, yes, sir,” he responded with a half-cocked salute and a shot of Goldschlager to chase it. The soldier did not laugh. Instead he inserted two more quarters and pressed the green button that released a gate in the bowels of the table. There was something gratifying about the sound - the balls began a slow trek down a small track inside the table

and then dropped, one by one (*clunk, clunk, clunk*) , into a basin at one end of the rectangular table, where there was an opening for the players to retrieve the balls. Day in day out they suffered this fate - those round progeny of Sisyphus.

This was how I saw it at least. Were this scene to have been documented by Casper the whole thing might be a much simpler affair - but the gap between perspectives is unfathomably wide, if not infinite, and, as such, the night in question was more of an exercise in observation than participation, and must so be the same for you, dear reader.

Casper won the next game, and the next, and the next and by my fourth trip to the bar I no longer had to tell the bartender my order. I simply raised my hand from behind the furry wall of shoulders and the drinks would appear in short order. One of the men seated at the bar even handed the drinks over to me, kindly, and I was astounded when he replied to my thanks with a well articulated, “You’re welcome.” I supposed I’d assumed he could only speak in grunts, howls, and barked orders.

At some point during my trips to the bar and back the stakes had been raised. They’d gone from twenty, to thirty, to fifty where they now sat. Casper was up substantially, dancing around the table as he played, it seemed as though he couldn’t leave a ball poorly. The drill sergeant, for his part, was a skilled shooter but had failed a few times down the stretch, missing a critical shot by a decimal point, accidentally applying too much backspin to a particular shot causing the ball to run all the way to the far rail when it should have slowly settled into place just a few inches behind the initial collision. There was so much nuance to the game. I realized, now, why Casper had wanted me to watch before picking up a stick. Many things in this world are better learned through patient observation than immediate participation - intuition serves as a fatal master for some of us who do not observe this in principle.

The fifth game began. They had been alternating breaks and it was now the drill sergeant, Victor, who had the opportunity to break. He approached the table thoughtfully, placing his left hand down to form a bridge (a different contortion than Casper had shown me), slowly he placed the cue stick in the cradle created between his index and middle finger. Then he made one, two, three warm up pumps with his right arm, back and forth like a piston, before letting loose with more force than I’d seen a ball struck all night. *CRACK!* There was a loud pop that actually got the attention of his table of friends, who now looked up and began to pay attention to what was occurring in the back room. On first contact the cue ball had jumped straight up into the air, perhaps six or seven inches, before dropping back onto the felt where it spun rapidly but went nowhere. The rest of the balls clinked around the table like neurons, two of them dropping (not the nine ball, thankfully), before they came to rest, evenly spaced across the table. “Well damn Victor,” Casper said. “Looks like someone is finally ready to play.”

I suddenly felt thirsty. I realized the whole time I’d been catering to Casper I’d forgotten to hydrate myself and it was as though I hadn’t noticed it but I had, actually, been quite thirsty for some time.

While the drill sergeant tactically surveyed the table I stood and walked over to Casper who paid me

not an iota of attention. "I'm going to get some water," I told him. "Want some?" But Casper did not respond. He was evaluating the table, the position, the opponent, with his entire body. I walked off to the bar while barrel-chested Victor approached his next shot. I heard a swift *clink-clink* on my way to the bar and then after another second or two I heard the sound of a ball dropping into one of the hard plastic pockets.

Upon my return I noticed that the two large men had vacated their respective positions at the bar and there was an empty seat available. The other had been taken by the form of a young woman. I decided I would take a seat to order, if only because I wanted to see what kind of a woman it was that frequented *Rickert's* at this time of night (it must have been nearly eleven by then).

It was her scent that struck me first. Before I could even reach the bar stool I was overtaken by the powerful scent of her perfume. Something floral but also antiseptic about it. She had very straight dark hair that she kept back in a ponytail that hung to the bottom of her shoulder blades, which protruded significantly and were visible beneath the thin fabric of her short-sleeved blouse, also black. She wore a pair of very short denim jean shorts, intentionally ripped in several places. Her arms were incredibly thin, elbow joints like knuckles. I took my seat beside her and inhaled deeply.

When the bartender arrived with the drinks I told her that I was actually only hoping for water and a coca-cola - "I don't need these.". She left the drinks on the bar in front of me and turned away without saying a word. For a moment I was concerned that she hadn't heard me - but then I could see that she'd reached for the soda gun - the long, tubular hose with a spray nozzle attached, and had begun to spray it into a red cafeteria cup - my Coca-Cola, it was a relief. If she hadn't heard me it would have been quite an embarrassing affair trying to get her attention again - and in front of the woman to my left? I didn't dare imagine it.

Heavy rock played from the jukebox. The bartender placed the Coca-Cola in front of me. "And a water, please," I reminded her as she walked away. I had a feeling the water was not coming. So be it, the Coca-Cola was refreshing enough.

I took a long drink and set it back on the heavily-lacquered counter top. The beer and shot remained. As you may imagine, I was quite uncertain as to what to do next. The woman to my left raised the cigarette to her lips again. "Hello, I'm William," I said finally - and only after speaking the words did I turn in her direction and see the woman's face, gaunt and shadowed - young and old simultaneously. She had big, wide eyes with high cheekbones that jutted out from her otherwise obscenely thin face. She had thin, tiny lips that spread into a big smile when she turned to me. A small, pointed nose with long nostrils that seemed permanently flared. Her hair was pulled back so taught that it seemed as if it was holding her face in place. It would have been a very pretty face, I thought, were it not so ugly.

"Well hey there, sweetie," she said. "Guess your water ain't comin', huh?"

I was taken aback that she'd overheard. What a perceptive mind! I was flattered by her attention and I felt my cheeks warm. "No, it certainly appears that it's been forgotten." The bartender was leaned over the countertop at the far side of the bar, chatting with an older, heavy-set man who wore a bandana tied around his head. "The Coca-Cola should suffice, though. It's quite refreshing on ice."

She giggled in a way that seemed too young for her face. "I didn't know professors came into *Rickert's* ." I began to tell her I was not a professor but she cut me off. "And cute professors too. I like a man with a *big brain* ."

I thanked her for the compliment but let her know I was not, in fact, a professor. I told her that I worked at *Grayson's* from time to time. "Of course, I enjoy reading. Have you ever heard what Frank Zappa said?"

"Frank who?"

"Zappa," I said. "You've never heard of Frank Zappa? He's wonderful, really brilliant." She smoked her cigarette in response. "Well Zappa said, 'If you want to get laid, go to college. If you want an education, go to the library.' Ha! How great is that? Go to college to get laid, go to the library to get an education. He really thought college was a scam. Ha!"

The woman drew me in with her eyes. In the poor lighting I could not make out if they were green or brown, mostly they just looked black - but they were alluring all the same. They seemed to look right through me. She snuffed her cigarette out in a small gold ashtray and then turned on her stool to face me. "William, Sweetie, I don't know about no Frankie Yazza, but I can tell you one thing he got wrong. You ain't gotta go to college to get laid," she put one hand on the top of my knee, with the other she picked up the shot of Goldschlager and brought it to her lips in one smooth movement. She put her head back theatrically, opened her mouth wide, and poured the shot into it from about an inch above her lips. I watched the clear, syrupy liquid glisten. "You weren't drinking that, were you?" She giggled that same giggle. "My name is Christmas."

Ten

Benny was firmly against a trip to *Rickert's* for reasons that were not entirely clear to me. He'd vehemently rejected the idea of billiards and summarily dismissed *Rickert's* as a "shit establishment for shit people."

"I have to disagree with you about the people, Ben. There are some really wonderful characters there. A little rough around the edges, sure." I often turned to the use of euphemism, for example, *rough around the edges* , to ensure that my statement was being understood clearly: to be vague was to clarify

the meaning in some inverse sense. “Regardless, we don’t have to go. It was only an idea. I didn’t know you felt so strongly.” I entered the den from the kitchen to find Benny slouched back in the big armchair, my grandfather’s chair. It had large golden rivets cinched the weathered leather. The arms of the chair had, over time, flattened out into a creased brown terrain, twin deltas of wrinkled I worn over time from the forearms of my forebears.

“I didn’t mean it like that. Just not my idea of a good time I suppose.” He pulled a bent cigarette from a soft pack he’d discovered in his breast pocket. “What luck,” he said. “Thought I was out.” He held his cigarettes differently now too, with more confidence. Before he’d left for college he smoked only on occasion, to emphasize a moment in its particularity, but now he did it like a smoker. Now he did it like he’d be doing it for a long time to come. First he placed the cigarette in his lips and let it hang there a bit, dangling it as if to spite physics. It bounced around as he spoke, “I think I need a day where I just do nothing. You know what I mean?” Then he raised his right hand to form a cup around the tip of the cigarette and used his left hand to deftly strike his zippo, pulling it up against his thigh to open the hinged lid and then flicking it back downwards against his thigh once more to light the flint. It was a graceful maneuver, the sort one practices by oneself until they get the hang of it. He brought the light to the tip of the cigarette, pulled, inhaled, and then spoke while exhaling so that the smoke came out in the same cadence as his speech. “I think - I just need to take a day .” He exhaled the remaining smoke. “Do nothing for a day. You know? You ever wished you could just pause the world for a day - a week, even? Not like get rid of it, not like disappear, just pause it I mean.” He drew on his cigarette again while I emptied one of the three ashtrays into a waste bin by the back door. “I just want it to stop for a few days, let me catch up. And then you-” He coughed, wiped his lips, and then continued, “Then you start thinking about that, I mean, and you realize it’s just not an option. Never. It will never be an option.”

I did know what he meant. I’d had the inclination more than once myself. But he was also right in that it would never be an option - and perhaps I was the more practical of the two of us in that regard - I did not let thoughts like that hold court in my psyche. Impossibilities have never garnered much attention in my imagination. Wishes, hopes, prayers and the rest - fodder for the illogical and needy. This sort of fanciful thought was a weakness of character in some ways - to allow an impossibility to impact your consciousness - nothing could be more nonsensical.

“Perhaps you’re depressed,” I suggested.

“You think?”

“Undoubtedly similar symptoms. It could, of course, be anxiety. The two things are so interrelated it’s difficult, sometimes, to tell one from the other.” I put my hands together with interlocked fingers to show him the way depression and anxiety were closely related. “Sometimes you can be so depressed it

makes you anxious. And of course sometimes it's exactly the other way around." I paused to evaluate his response. Nothing.

I put a fresh ashtray on the table in front of him and took the other to empty it. How many cigarettes had he smoked? It was a latent suicide wish, I'd read somewhere. But I wasn't completely sold on the argument.

When he finally did speak I was surprised to hear him apologize. This was *new Benny* too. "I'm sorry for being a bummer, man. I guess Jenny didn't dig it either."

After I finished emptying the third ashtray I spoke. "No worries, Ben. I care about you, for what it's worth. I have a few errands I've been meaning to run in any case. I'll leave you the extra key. I'm in dire need of a haircut, if you haven't noticed." I ran my hands through my short, brown hair. For most of my life people had commented on its impressive thickness - but for me the thickness had also proven a difficulty. The hair made its own rules - no amount of pomade, or hair gel, or (the worst mistake of all) mousse could break its spirit. No matter how I went about it my hair always seemed like a part of my body that paid no respect to the wishes of its master. My hands and feet, eyes, nose, joints, and dare I say, brain, all seemed to align with me in the name of the greater good. But my hair was more like my nails, or my skin, in that it was not really a "part" of me (by which I mean something that I personally had domain over), but rather I would describe it as a *symptom of being me*, which is neither good nor bad by nature, but independent in its purpose and frequently ran counter to my own ideas of what would be in the best interests of William Theodore Tipnam the Third.

Benny laughed and tousled his own hair, "If I were in better shape I'd join you," he said. His hair was the longest I'd ever seen it, a reddish-brown bird's nest that hung messily over his ears, long at the nape and seemingly parted in several places. He had, for most of his life, kept his hair short and parted to the left like his father. I could not imagine that his new style (and I'm beginning to wonder if I should call it that at all) was much of an asset when it came to his romantic affairs, but then again what did I know about college women?

"You better do something about that...mop on your head," I jested. He laughed at me.

"Good one, Tip-man. Been reading some satire while I've been away, huh?"

"Satire? I should think not. I'm not so-" but then Tip really started laughing and it was only then that I understood the joke.

It's not that I don't have a sense of humor, but perhaps it is not a modern one. More often than not I find myself outside of the joke, in a manner of speaking - I understand the incongruence, but for some reason fail to map it correctly in my mind. On more than one occasion I have found myself amused by something that had been uttered in my presence hours prior - halfway through some essay on new

criticism and it will strike me out of nowhere, *This was the meaning!* , and I'll laugh to myself with slight embarrassment at my previous, ultra-literal, interpretation.

I explained to Benny that I understood what he was insinuating: It was so rare for me to attempt humor myself that I must have been reading humorists recently; it would be the best explanation for the rare, comical statement I'd made.

"You hit the nail on the head," he said. "Now be gone - make sure to ask for the hot neck shave. If you don't ask, they don't do it - but it's free! Don't forget!" With that he took the blanket that had been hanging over the back of the chair and covered himself up to his neck. He took his hat, which he'd hung over the arm of the chair and set it on top of his face so that only his nose and chin were visible. "I'll be in the same spot when you get back!" He said. But that wasn't altogether true.

At that time I was driving my grandfather's Oldsmobile. It was Harriet's car by title, but we shared the ownership in practice and I was allowed to take it out any time I pleased so long as it was available.

Harriet, at that time, was seeing a man who lived on the far side of the island. He was a man of means and gave Harriet the keys to his second car almost the moment she began sleeping there. As such, the Oldsmobile was mine for all intents and purposes. It was a large, brown, boat of a car with an ashtray in the dash that still held a few butts from my grandfather that neither Harriet nor I could not bear to dispose of (we'd discussed it). Crumpled cotton mouthpieces, pinched and bent to be snuffed out, they sat there so long it seemed as if the ashes themselves had evaporated and only the filters remained.

They had been last touched by him, Grandfather Tipnam, and something about their presence provided me with an inexplicable comfort.

I was not a great driver. I admit as much. And I often spent an unreasonable amount of time idling at the end of our long drive before pulling out onto McCallan, which came to a bend just a short distance to the left of the end of the driveway. The absence of traffic was just as frightening as the presence of traffic - without the ability to see around the bend there was no fail-safe way to exit to the right without risk. At any given time the car could be coming that would not have time to stop. So I would sit in the Oldsmobile with the window down attempting to listen for any approaching vehicles, which was only effective a portion of the time, when the approaching vehicle was a truck or motorcycle, but failed to protect against the new electric vehicles which had begun, even then, to appear with more frequency in the face of new revelations about the oncoming cataclysm of global warming; that giant hole in the ozone layer that seemed to make liberals quite nervous and conservatives quite angry.

As I sat there that day, perched at the top of the drive listening for the faint sound of an oncoming catastrophe, it began to dawn on me that my life was in need of a drastic change. It was not that I was depressed - I was not. I was happy in my own way. I was not unsatisfied - that would be an exaggeration. I did not feel compelled to find some sort of labor to fulfil an inner desire. I do not have that inherent need to be useful that some people feel. Rather, what I thought about was the

opportunities that were out there. It was a moment of great excitement. I was in need of a drastic change, yes, but not to fill something, more so to expand upon something that had suddenly seized my - I hesitate to write it even now - something that had suddenly seized upon my *soul* .

I was happy with my life. I reminded myself as I sat there. I had grown into an adult at some point and now, looking down, I saw the strong veins climbing around the bones in my hands, pulsing, subdermal rivers that had not been noticeable only a year prior. *A late bloomer* . But the time was now - I was a man. It was as though Benny's reappearance, his arrested development (as I interpreted it), had made something clear to me that I hadn't been able to see before. But how could something be clear without being expressible? I *clearly* knew that there was *something* that needed to occur - but that was all I was *clear* about.

What is the saying? Unable to see the forest through the trees - but in this case it was the opposite - I could not see the trees because it was the forest I was looking at. Not the branch, but the web of branches that made the whole. Not the root, but the network of roots that made up the superstructure they supported. There is more and more evidence these days to suggest that a forest works as one, a mesh of incomprehensible signals communicated via soil and bacteria that make the whole a fundamental unit, and the individual tree a mere participant. This was what I thought about as I continued to sit there and consider merging into traffic.

I needed to do something that meant I was a man - something needed to occur to make me a man, I thought. I felt I was a tree. A part of this world. I really felt it.

The window was down. The sky was dark and the air was full with water - but silent, silent - so silent that it rang in your ears. I took a right, peeling out onto McCallan. Recklessly, I burned rubber down the road. Something was happening, I thought, something was changing. It was all so clear to me.

Then there was a boom in the sky. The valve had been released. I rolled up the window just as the first *plat-plat-plat* announced the initiation of rains that were not to stop for the next week.

Eleven

I have been coy in failing to give the entire story around Christmas and our interactions earlier in the telling of this tale. I shall hope the reader will forgive me as the reasons for my doing so were multifaceted and well considered.

I shall now return to *Rickert's* and the evening Christmas and I first met.

She'd emptied the Goldschager but declined the beer. She suggested I drink it. I told her I didn't drink often but she did not seem to have heard me and continued to suggest I take a sip. She told me my

shoulders seemed tight and rubbed my back between my shoulder blades with surprising strength. It was an odd feeling, being touched, and she did it with a certain amount of intention that I could feel running through my body. Physical touch, at once disconcerting and pleasant. If there were a time to drink, thought I, this might just be it. I lifted the Pabst in my right hand and raised it as a silent toast, then I tilted it to my lips and poured some of the cold, stale liquid into my mouth. It was unpleasant but not unbearable. The few times I'd tried alcohol previously the circumstances had been much different - something about the atmosphere influenced the flavor, I surmised. Something about Christmas, and Casper and even the crass, old wench behind the bar, something about it all aligned in such a way that the bottom barrel beer was almost refreshing as it effervesced against my tongue. Almost involuntarily, I expressed my satisfaction with a large *Ahhh!* and wiped at my lips with my forearm.

"Damn good," I said. And in case she hadn't heard me the first time I repeated, "I don't drink much. Not much at all." This time Christmas laughed with her whole chest, turning imperceptibly more in my direction (though I perceived it, I did). Her thin torso was juxtaposed against her lofty, sizable breasts. She was now at a forty five degree angle, split halfway between paying her full attention to the bar and directing it completely at me.

"I ain't much of a drinker myself," she said. Her accent was southern, but not local. "Especially not tequila. I don't drink that stuff, hardly ever." She giggled again - this was a joke that I'd failed to catch - I laughed too. When she smiled I saw her teeth - they were small and stained, I could tell even in the poor lighting - the way they were set in her gums made them seem as if they were slightly angled towards the back of her throat, like one of those worms from a science fiction film, hidden beneath the sand until it opens it's gaping maw and the world above it is consumed. Almost imperceptibly inwards, but inwards nonetheless. Like a lamprey's mouth - easy to enter but impossible to escape. Something about it thrilled me.

"Well I've never tried tequila, not even once." I announced.

"Not once?!" She was joyously appalled.

"Not a single drop," I reiterated.

Christmas turned her chair back towards the bar and began waving a hand towards the bartender. "That changes today!" she said loudly. She lifted her arm so high that the hem of her shirt lifted with it and I could see a two-inch strip of skin just above her jeans - it was enough to make my heart palpitate.

With each wave of her arm her breasts jostled from left to right. I saw the outline of a nipple beneath her blouse. My penis reacted without consulting me. I couldn't stand up without revealing my excitement. Anxiety settled in quickly. I felt myself beginning to sweat at the collar, down my back, under my arms. Disastrous.

I looked back over my shoulder at the game of pool going on in the corner. Casper was not dancing any more, rather he was pacing the table with his stick upright, evaluating some position from multiple angles. The soldier, who at first had seemed stiff and inpatient, now lounged in a plush chair, watching the table but not really watching. His friends had migrated in that direction to see the game and were each gaily conversing with one another. Guffaws of laughter, lots of nodding and clapping one another on the shoulders. Identical haircuts, each and every one of them.

There were five of them in total, including Victor, the drill sergeant. Victor was the largest by a significant margin, but the others were still not to be scoffed at - thick chests and shoulders, wide set stances and crossed arms. Five of them and one Casper. I was too far off to make out the grimace that hung on his face, but perceptive enough to read the kinesthetic language of the scene. Casper was losing.

“He your boyfriend or somethin’?” Christmas pushed a small shot of tequila in my direction, spilling as it travelled. In her other hand she held her own shot glass, tilted in my direction to indicate that we should ‘cheers’. *Boyfriend?* Certainly she couldn’t think I was a homosexual. Had I somehow given off the impression that I was more interested in men than women? What could have given her that impression? I’d merely looked in his direction! Pure disbelief coursed through my body and still I’d failed to respond or even take the shot from her hands.

Finally I spoke in a stream of words “I’m sorry Christmas, but I may have given you the wrong impression, certainly you could not have been given the impression that- I mean of course you know that I’m not a...homosexual. Certainly not. That is just my friend, Cas-”

“Shhhh. Baby, hush. I was only teasing you. I know you ain’t no fairy. Take this shot now.” She pushed it further in my direction and it caught a ledge in the counter top, toppled, and the clear liquid sprayed in my direction. “Oh my lord,” she began to apologize profusely, “I’m so sorry baby. Don’t be mad at me hun.” She took a napkin from the small container behind the counter where all the lemon wedges and cherries and olives were kept. She dabbed down my shirt, over my belly - first quickly to absorb the moisture, but then slowly and methodically to make sure she got every spot. I couldn’t find the words to stop her before she moved to pat the crotch of my pants. It was taut, almost painfully so - my erection had been diverted down the left leg of my denim pants.

Christmas gasped. “Oh my.” Cirque du Soleil was taking place in my chest. I felt the stirrings of nausea in my throat. I couldn’t run, I couldn’t even stand and make my way to the bathroom without risking full visibility of my condition. I sort of hunched over, hoping she would save me the embarrassment and move on quickly, but that was not Christmas’s way. Rather, she ran her hand down my pant leg to the furthest extremity of my extension. “Baby that is something special you have there,” she said, smiling deviously as she spoke. She leaned in closer to me and continued *wiping my pants clean*. She was close enough that I could smell her breath - a warm, boozy concoction topped off with

a mentholated finish. I saw the off-colored roots of her hair; could clearly make out the uneven topography of her skin.

Finally, because there was no other option, I spoke. "Thank...you." It was difficult to maintain a spoken cadence as Christmas had begun to squeeze lightly around the head of my penis - which was something I'd only experienced by my own hand and created a substantially more exciting effect when performed by a member of the opposite sex. "I believe that...was a compliment." She leaned in further and whispered something in my ear that made my entire body exhale goosebumps. "No, certainly not. I don't...think..." I tried to picture my grandmother in the nude - the inside of a rotten pumpkin - snot running down the face of a young child. "My friend is shooting...pool. I told him...I'd be right ba-...baaaacckkk." And with that Christmas had solved my problem in her own way. A wet glob shot out down the inside of my pant leg. My face was hot and red. I huffed involuntarily. "Christ," I said. "Oh Christ I-I'm not sure-" but I was cut off by Christmas.

"That was free, hunny. But come prepared next time."

And what does one say? I was grateful, to be certain, that I'd been *deflated*. It had simultaneously been one of the most frightening and exhilarating moments of my whole life. But I was not daft enough to fail to understand the implications of her previous statement. She was a lady of the night. Since I had not paid for anything, I thought, I was not a proper *John*. But now that I knew what it took to be a *John* I could not say with any certainty that it was something I would avoid in the future. In reality I'd already begun wishing it was the next day and we could visit *Rickert's* again.

At that moment, though, Christmas, who had rested her head on my shoulder in a sort of loving, romantic way - spoke quietly into my ear, "It looks like that boyfriend of yours isn't doing so well."

Casper! I'd almost forgotten he existed. I turned my head to look at him and Christmas turned her head back at the same time. Her lips brushed mine, perhaps by accident - heavily glossed but somehow dry and rigid nonetheless. The scent of fruit and chemicals - and then *the taste*, too, with an instinctive lick of the lips.

There was Casper, handing cash in the wrong direction. The whole group of comrades watched on in respectful silence as the competitors discussed another game. The wad of cash now looked like a receipt in his hand. How had it depleted so quickly? "I'm sorry Christmas," I said, "I might need to get him out of here." Casper's analytic swagger around the table had turned into a sad sort of saunter. He fed a few coins into the machine and I heard the balls drop. My erection had subsided. Christmas was smoking a fresh cigarette as she reapplied her lip gloss.

"Ain't you sweet," she said with a side eye. "Give me a kiss for the road, baby. And don't tell no one about that."

A kiss? A real kiss? It seemed so ridiculous - I barely knew the woman. She puckered in my direction. I hoped Casper wasn't looking as I leaned in and touched my lips to hers intentionally. She pressed her tongue through the firm barrier of my lips and licked around my mouth a little. It was not altogether unpleasant but it was not specifically pleasant either. It just was.

It was my first kiss and - for some reason - it made me wonder why I'd been born a human and not a jellyfish or an inchworm or an oak tree for that matter. Why I'd been born as anything at all. The mystery pervaded my thoughts for the remainder of the evening.

I thought about it as I walked, with a gunslinger's gait, back to the pool table. The sticky concentration of seminal fluid was still hiding in my pant leg. I couldn't very well go wash myself in the bathroom where there were no doors on the stalls nor seats on the toilets. With each step, as the pant leg stretched and contracted, I could feel it spreading and drying into my leg hairs uncomfortably. So be it.

I thought about it when I saw the look on Casper's face upon seeing me reappear - both embarrassed and grateful, a sad twist in his mouth that directly contradicted the confident stare he directed at the table. These performances we put on! We act the part so genuinely that one is forced to reflect on the possibility that we don't choose to be the actors at all. Each of us jesters in the court of King Existence.

I couldn't tell him that I'd ejaculated on myself, certainly not - but all the same I needed a ride home, and soon. Perhaps the half-can of Pabst I'd consumed influenced my inhibitions - it's tough to know such a thing about inhibitions, once they are lowered you don't care enough to find out why - or perhaps it was the recent sexual release. Not many a man can say that a woman made him ejaculate first, before landing him his first real kiss. It was all so absurd I lost any concern I'd had about sounding like I didn't belong.

"Casper!" I yelled his name at an unnecessary volume. "I need to get back, post-haste. Something has come up!"

I expected him to be frustrated with me for interrupting his game but his reaction was rather the opposite. He began collecting his belongings quickly, speaking over his shoulder to the drill sergeant, "Gonna have to finish this showdown another time. My man Tip, here, has got an emergency we gotta deal with."

"Hold your horses cowboy," the drill sergeant spat back. "We've got a game to finish." I looked down at the table, up at Casper, back to the drill sergeant, then over to his pals who had taken on the nefarious air of a street gang from an S.E. Hinton novel. "It's your turn to shoot," said the drill sergeant.

Twelve

To hell with a haircut, I decided. I was going to see Mr. O'Rourke and get to the bottom of all this. My personal knowledge of fathers and fatherhood was limited, I'll admit, but one does not have to be a professional musician to be a successful music critic - a solid theoretical foundation compounded with an intense subject-matter interest often makes up the right recipe for a properly open-minded analysis of the audible arts. No, I was not experienced with the dynamics of a nuclear family, but I knew something here was gravely wrong. Mr. O'Rourke had faltered and something in Benny had broken - and though correlation does not mean causation it often can help in the formulation of a proper hypothesis. One must be scientific with these things - we are biological agents when all is said and done, and the scientific method must apply to us just as it does to the rest of the universe we inhabit.

Benny, as the axiom goes, was his *father's child*. They shared a hearty intelligence, a squirrely countenance, the ability to use laughter as both a compliment and a threat. They shared other things too - things I hadn't come to learn yet - things they kept to themselves, both, which is to say they did not even share them with each other. Were it not for my visit that day I don't know for certain if I would have learned about any of this - but there is no use speculating on possible worlds that are not our own - there is no value in a purely academic pursuit with no practical utility.

They had the same gunmetal eyes - that was what first struck me when a distressed and secretive Mr. O'Rourke answered the door of Room 13 at the *High Tide Inn*. He wore a purple robe with braided gold along the seams. There was an ornate emblem sewn onto the left breast that interested me - perhaps it was some sort of Masonic insignia, I thought, or perhaps it was nothing at all. Whatever the case the robe was a sad but regal affair and, paired with those bullet-like eyes, it gave me the feeling of being in the presence of an exiled lord - royalty eroded. Behind him the room was in disarray. Liquor bottles sat in the trash bin beside the TV stand, the smell of smoke exhaled upon me from the hot, hot room. What temperature did the man keep it in there? Was he attempting to sweat himself to death?

The TV was on in the background - a mountainous chart of greens and reds with a scrolling list of more green and red across the bottom. It was a channel that displayed the financial markets, I gathered. I'd never known him to be an investor in any capacity but there were many things about the O'Rourkes I did not know, I would come to find.

The *High Tide Inn* was a single story residency shaped like a horseshoe. It was one of two motels on the island - the other was even more distraught by appearance, but both were primarily known as a center for the distribution of illicit goods of all varieties. The motels on the island, unlike the hotel (which was a polished, upscale affair in comparison), allowed "extended stay" tenants - which is to say half of the rooms were occupied by locals who had been thrown out by their partners or lost their jobs or simply preferred not to have to furnish and clean their own living spaces. Looking over Mr.

O'Rourke's shoulder, however, I could say for certain he was not living there for the cleaning services.

He stood in the doorway for a few moments without saying a word - I kept my mouth shut in kind.

Perhaps he was hoping if we stood there in silence for long enough I would change my mind, turn around and make my way back to the Oldsmobile. He looked at me in an odd way. It was as though it had been a decade since he'd last seen me, the way he blankly surveyed my face as if to remind himself how he knew me. There was something inquisitive to the slant of his brow, something frightened in the chapped, taut way he held his lips.

Then he was looking past me, still not a word uttered, out into the sparsely inhabited parking lot. I turned to look with him, only four cars were parked in the lot that made up the center of the horseshoe. None of them were his, I'd noticed when I parked. Where was his prized Saab? I couldn't figure out what to make of it.

Satisfied with the view, he finally spoke. His voice was dry and raspy, smoke-tinged through the vowels. He sounded like a man short on breath. "William, what a surprise." It was neither cynical nor genuine, but somewhere in the middle, as though he were disinterested in even his own thoughts. He backed up a few feet now, into the shadows of the hot, dingy hotel room, and picked up a burning cigarette from the ashtray by the television. Benny's "freshman fifteen" (which was probably more like thirty) had made the two men look more similar in physical appearance - a sort of middle of the road physique. They had been genetically gifted with a high metabolism but had gotten lazy as a result. Back lit by a reddish glow from the bedside lamp I observed his silhouette and wondered what Benny would think if he knew where I'd gone.

"Mr. O'Rourke," I said, still standing outside. "It's good to see you." Rain clattered against the metal awning. "Benny doesn't know I've come," I assured him.

"You've seen Ben?"

"Oh yes, of course, Mr. O'Rourke. He stayed at my house the last two...yes, the last two nights."

He seemed to think on this for a moment before bringing the cigarette to his lips in a way that struck me as particularly villainous. "He should have been back more than a week ago. I suppose he *did* end up visiting his mother then."

"No sir, Mr. O'Rourke. He hasn't seen her either. He seems to be upset with both of you, from what I've observed. I mean... Well I think... you aren't the only one he's mad at." I hoped this would bring a smile to his face but I would have no such luck.

Mr. O'Rourke half-scoffed and then began to cough a bit. "Stubborn son of a bitch."

The rain thickened and the *PAP-PAP-PAP* grew louder. “May I step inside Mr. O’Rourke? I was hoping to speak with you - if you’re willing, that is. I have some concerns about Benny.”

Mr. O’Rourke checked his watch. It was the same gold Rolex he’d worn his entire life - thick gold links formed the band which was attached to the face of the watch, on which (apart from the primary dial) there existed several smaller subdials, which distinguished the watch as a “chronograph” - meaning it could also function as a stopwatch with incredible precision. Mr. O’Rourke had once explained to me that the watch’s second hand moved perpetually rather than in a ticking motion. It was one of the simplest ways to spot a cheap fake (though there were good fakes, very good fakes, that were much harder to distinguish). The second hand never stopped moving unless the watch was broken. It made me think of the vinyls - the way they outshone the compact disc by virtue of their continuity. The sound that comes from a vinyl record, like the time that is counted by a genuine Rolex, is a constant - a rare commodity, thought I, yet altogether natural.

“Suppose I have the time,” he said. “I’m sorry it’s a bit of a mess in here. I wasn’t expecting guests.” He flicked a switch beside the doorway and the dim ceiling lights turned on. It almost seemed to make the room darker, somehow, as though it created more shadows than illuminated space. On the far side of the room, beyond the bed, there was a table piled high with books, notepads, pens and a few crumpled up wads of paper. There were two chairs with dark red cushions for seats and no armrests. Mr. O’Rourke pulled one out and then sat in the other. He began to place the crumpled paper balls into the trash, one by one.

I closed the door behind myself as I entered and began to sweat profusely from both the heat and circumstance. There was a rectangular area on one of the yellow-ish walls that was less yellow-ish than its surroundings. Below it I saw a frame turned backwards, resting against the wall.

“How long have you been staying here?” I finally asked. It was odd to be speaking to Mr. O’Rourke in such a direct way - it was entirely new to our relationship, always, prior to that moment, I had been a friend of his son’s - a best friend, not to trivialize it, but a friend of his child’s nonetheless. I was speaking to him now as...as what? A confidant, a friend - a concerned citizen, perhaps, a good samaritan simply doing a duty so as to avoid the smiting of some omnipotent hand.

The question gave him pause. My arrival had caught him off guard and with each question he had to calculate an appropriate level of transparency. A fact of the O’Rourke’s (and perhaps, I might posit, a characteristic of *good men* in a general sense) was that their faces betrayed themselves in the telling of a lie - and as such they were prone to telling obscure truths in the place of a falsehood.

“I’m sure Benny’s told you,” he finally spoke. “I screwed up, Will. Took my family for granted.” He scratched the back of his neck, “All for noth-...All for myself, I should say. I’m a weak man at the end of the day.”

“There are studies out there that show man isn’t built to be monogamous, you know. Gorillas, chimps, hominids - our closest relatives - they’re well known to exhibit similar behaviors. I don’t mean to say it’s right, of course,” (*Shouldn’t have said that*, I thought) “but it’s not...unnatural. Not even unique, you know, for a man to *spread his seed* .”

He barked a short laugh and then returned his face to a neutral position. “Little consolation, but thank you. My wife, well, Mrs. O’Rourke to you, for the time being, she doesn’t quite see eye to eye with you on that front. But hell, it may be true.” He leaned back and took a deep breath. “How about a drink? You drink yet?”

“No sir,” said I. I never said *sir* .

“Well,” said he, “I do.” He turned on his chair and was able to reach the dirty cup on his bedside table. He opened the drawer of the bedside table as well, the spot where the Christian bible resides in motels, hotels and inns throughout all of American literature, but instead of a bible he retrieved a bottle of scotch and filled his cup half-way, setting the bottle back in its place before turning back to the table and taking a substantial sip. “It’s an acquired taste,” he said. “Like coffee.”

“Never been one for coffee either,” I admitted, feeling more and more like a child by the second. Perhaps I wasn’t ready for this conversation at all. Perhaps I shouldn’t have gone to speak with him in the first place. But there I sat, sweating down my back, wiping at my damp forehead, without a clue as to how to approach the man that sat before me. We sat in silence for an entire minute while he proceeded to finish off his drink - looking left and right, down at his shoes, opening his mouth twice as if to say something before stopping himself again. “It’s none of my business,” I finally said. “I’ll leave if you’d like. I just thought you’d like to know that Benny seems to have changed, from my perspective. Not just college stuff, you know? Not just new independence like that.” I pulled a handkerchief from my back pocket and rubbed at the nape of my neck. “It’s like he’s stuck in a hole - metaphorically of course - and I can’t figure out how to help him up out of it. He just sits there and... drinks.” This suddenly made Mr. O’Rourke nervous. I was grateful for the anxious stare he returned. “I haven’t seen him sober, not really, since he’s been back.”

“I see,” said Mr. O’Rourke. He played at his facial hair with yellowing fingers.

“Yes, now you see?” said I, wishing for nothing more than a beard to distract my hands. Instead I placed them on the table, palms down, drumming lightly with my thumb and index fingers. So much waiting without the words to say. Sometimes I wish I could write everything down before I speak it - but of course the contingencies are the responses, and those cannot be predicted with any sort of accuracy. If only I knew those - I consider the possibilities to this day - I would spend my evenings penning precise responses and finely tuned insinuations and through speech alone I would be something like a superhero - immune to the pressures of conversation.

“What should I do, William? You’ve come to ask something of me. What is it?”

And suddenly the right words generated themselves in my head without thought. “I suppose, first of all, I’d like to ask you to turn on the air conditioning. Can we start with that?” I felt I’d instantaneously taken control of the conversation. I’d like to be more comfortable, what a simple reply. “Then I’d like to hear the real story - from the beginning.”

Thirteen

Few and far between have been the moments in my life that left me truly, existentially unsettled. That afternoon with Mr. O’Rourke would prove to be one of them. Perhaps my childhood—perhaps my having been constructed under such absurd conditions—perhaps that steeled me against the depravity of existence. Perhaps I lived a life so upside-down that it was always the characters who seemed to be right-side-up that confused me the most. And Mr. O’Rourke, as it were, had been the most *right-side-up* figure in my life since Benny and I were first introduced as toddlers - bonded by our mothers’ mutually shared desire to get an *afternoon to themselves* . We were neighbors, back then, before we sold off the lot that sat adjacent to the O’Rourke’s - then we were separated by the Rathburns, who quickly divided the property into four hastily built single family homes and sold those off in kind. And when my parents passed, one after the other, it was the O’Rourkes who stayed foundationally stable as the rest of my family succumbed to the mounting chaos created by Uncle Woody and his increasingly intrepid plans. I spent many a night hiding out at the O’Rourke’s house - from the endless days of dominos and mud-pies to the insecurity of pubic hair and body odor to the endless false tales of “Benny Cassanova” - all a part of that one great support beam that held the entire sloped roof of the carnival going on in my cranium.

Mr. O’Rourke’s adulterous behavior was the least of his transgressions - in fact, it turned out he’d been seeing the girls that lived above the laundromat to the full knowledge of Mrs. O’Rourke (if not with her tacit approval). “Marriages aren’t often what they look like,” he told me after turning on the air conditioning unit that sat below the front window (which was the only window in the room). “Ours was like a garden that bloomed, reproduced, and then died with the freeze. We didn’t hate each other - we just didn’t love each other.” The cool breeze from the AC unit finally reached me and it was like being released from shackles.

“Ahhh—” I exhaled, “Why were you baking yourself in here?” I asked and laughed so that he’d know it was a joke I’d intended but he did not laugh in response. “That couldn’t have been for your personal comfort.”

“Of course not,” he said.

“Then why?”

“It seemed suitable.”

“I’m not sure I follow.”

“Penance, you know?” He lit another cigarette before the first had even fully extinguished in the ashtray. “Your grandmother is a Catholic. You should understand reconciliation.”

“You aren’t a Catholic, though—I mean, I thought you didn’t go to church. You never—when we were younger.”

“That’s true. But some rituals can’t be escaped. I’m not a Catholic anymore, but I was born one. You can’t wash clean of that.”

It seemed altogether silly to me - too silly for someone like Mr. O’Rourke, who had for my entire life been a pillar of logic and reason. Mr. O’Rourke, who’d taught me to be wary of ideologies, critical of all dogma, that superstition is a sort of failure of the intellect. This was Mr. O’Rourke, who’d introduced me to the likes of Bertrand Russell, had a closet full of the same shirts and same pants so that he never had to waste energy selecting his attire. When had he gone soft in the head? What had become of him? It was devastating to think about - so I didn’t.

Instead I glanced at the dual pillars of books that sat near the edge of the table, beside the smoldering ashtray. It was a grave sin to smoke near books. Whatsmore, they were stacked horizontally, which Mr. O had scolded me for my entire life - *Books are meant to stand upright like men. Never set them on their sides like dead things. It’s bad for the soul of the book - not to mention the spine.* But there, sitting between us, were two piles of books, one of which rose to a greater height than the seated patriarch. These were not just any books for that matter, but *old books* - the sort that, at *Steinman’s*, I’d only been allowed to touch with gloves on and under close supervision. Now they sat like *dead things* beside an ashtray and a bottle of scotch with a loosely fastened cap that Mr. O’Rourke once again lifted to his lips.

I didn’t recognize the books themselves. They all lacked dust jackets and there was no print along the spines. I surmised that several of them were part of a collection - they shared the same shape, same dark green covers, and deckled edges. I could smell them too - the scent of time elapsed, of fragility.

What sort of reading material does one bring with them in the face of a crisis, I wondered. Around the books were scattered sheets of looseleaf paper, torn from a yellow legal pad, covered in script so sloppy it I almost couldn’t believe it to be Mr. O’Rourke’s. He’d gone to Catholic school and had handwriting

that rivaled a computer's print in its precision. *The nuns*, he'd always reminded us, *carried a ruler that felt as though it was made of iron when it landed on your knuckles.*

None of it fit. Nothing was right. The room was a macabre distortion of the world I knew.

"If I'm understanding correctly, this...all of this," I waved my hand in a general sort of way to mean *the whole scene*, "has to do with something other than infidelity. It is not that you were seeing... prostitutes. Since, as you've already mentioned, Mrs. O'Rourke was aware."

"You are correct in that regard," he replied.

"But that is what Benny seems to think - at least, that is what he's told me."

"It's what it's best for him to believe, Will."

"It can't be best for him to believe a lie. How can this be best for him? He's drinking moonshine until he vomits. Yesterday he cried while reading the back of a cereal box. You may think you're doing what's best..."

His eyes drew in tightly and he pulled on his cigarette until the ember reached the filter. He was angry, now - a rare state of being for Mr. O'Rourke. Suddenly I felt frightened.

"This was a mistake," he said. "I shouldn't be talking to you. I think you should leave, Will."

"But you haven't told me anything, Mr. O. How can I help Ben?"

"Tell Ben," he muttered and then seemed to have forgotten what he wanted to say. "Tell Ben that it will only be a few more weeks. Tell him it's almost over. You can tell him I said that."

"But what is *IT*?"

"It's a mess I need to clean up," he snuffed out his cigarette and blew a fat plume of smoke in my direction. "And it's none of your fucking business. Families have their own secrets - your's has plenty of their own, I'm sure - and it's in everyone's best interest if you leave now." He stood from his seat and took a moment to balance himself. He walked over to the air conditioning unit and turned it back off. As he did this I snatched one of the looseleaf pages on the table and shoved it into my pocket as quickly and quietly as possible.

I wanted to cry, but it's not my nature.

I wanted run over to Mr. O'Rourke and cry and hug him and tell him how much I cared for him, how much he meant to me - that I wouldn't have been able to survive my childhood without him - but

instead I left, wordlessly - and walked out into the rain which continued to envelop the island in it's sublime cacophony of identical notes.

I slumped into the car, dripping wet, put the key in the ignition, turned it over, and the car sputtered to life graciously. I took the sheet of paper from my pocket, which was damp but had survived the journey to the car for the most part. I opened it up and flattened it out then I set it on the dash above the AC vent to dry it out. Just at that moment the sky went bright, nearly fluorescent white and there was a boom louder than I'd ever heard before. It took my eyes a moment to adjust, but when they finally came back into focus I saw a giant oak across the street had been struck by lightning, and was now split down the center, smoke rising from its trunk like a thick fog in the falling rain. My ears would not stop ringing.

Fourteen

As a boy, Henry O'Rourke attended St. Francis Academy, a small school of only 150 or so students aged five to eighteen. The academy was directly attached to the church itself; it was a short, tan, rectangular structure that looked as if it had been glued to the church as an afterthought. The two buildings looked nothing alike. The church had a tall vaulted roof and ornate stained glass windows that depicted stories from the New Testament as see-through mosaics. The school looked like an oversized shed that had been shimmied up against the church at an angle - all concrete and linoleum, fluorescent lights and light yellow walls that gave one the impression of being in a hospital. A miserable place, as Mr. O'Rourke described it, then he would inhale as though he could still conjure the aroma and describe the scent of a particular cleaning solution that he said smelled like it could burn through skin. The teachers were stereotypically stoic nuns, hesitant in their praise and heavy handed in their punishments. "Except Sister Beatrice," Mr. O'Rourke made clear. "She was the kindest woman I've ever known besides my own mother." Sister Beatrice had been his second grade teacher - a young, busty nun who Mr. O remembered with a particular fondness because of her habit of squeezing him tight to her chest when she gave him a hug. "She didn't give hugs to all the kids," he'd say, "I was special."

There were three priests employed at St. Francis: Father Shaw, Father O'Meara, and Father Dunneman. It is Father Shaw who is relevant to this particular story (it is also Father Shaw who disappeared only a few years back, rumored to have abandoned his holy life in order to start a new chapter in his life with one of the Guatemalan landscapers employed by the church - but this is only island lore, as likely to be fiction as fact). Father Shaw handled reconciliation for the elementary students at St. Francis - a practice that occurred weekly - and he was notorious for the inconsistency of his sentencing. Mr. O'Rourke always posited that Father Shaw had a propensity for spirits, "...and not the holy kind," - which meant, to the students, that the redder the eyes, the harsher the repercussions were likely to be.

On Fridays, when reconciliation took place, the students would barter with their time slots, which were randomly assigned by the nuns and posted on a board in the main hallway of the schoolhouse. Students allocated for early sessions offered portions of their lunch, baseball cards, yo-yos, or anything else they might possess that functioned as a commodity on the schoolyard market, in exchange for trading slots with one of the children who'd been given an afternoon assignment. Simply put, Father Shaw's mood seemed to lighten throughout the day in almost direct correlation with the lightening of the ornate golden flask that he kept somewhere hidden in a secret compartment of his robe.

During the year spent under the tutelage of Sister Beatrice there was construction being done on the church, and as such the confessional booth had been removed, and reconciliation was temporarily to take place in the upstairs office at the church. It was a small room, tucked away behind the large bronze organ pipes that ran the height of the building. The room sat directly at the front of the church, and had one small circular window that, seen from the outside, sat directly below the steeple. There was a comically small spiral staircase in the corner of the room that led, presumably, to a small space in the cavity of the steeple. The purpose of such a space has never been fully apparent to your faithful narrator.

One Friday early that school year, Mr. O'Rourke showed up at school having forgotten to bring any trading commodities. It had been a particularly balmy September, the summer season having still refused entry to the forgiving respite of fall. Young Henry O'Rourke was despondent when he saw that his was the first name on the list for the day - and after failing to con anyone into accepting a hastily made rubber band ball in exchange for their later time slot, the morning prayers concluded and first session was set to begin. Reconciliation was generally a quick affair by necessity - there were almost fifty children to punish over the course of the day - which meant that each session was limited to ten minutes. There was a process for all of this that kept the process regimented and punctual. Two students would be gone at any given time, one who was actively confessing, and the second who sat on a small bench just outside of the office, in front of the organ pipes, awaiting their turn. When the prior student exited from their sentencing they would tap the next student on the shoulder before returning to their classroom. When one student returned from their confession, the next would quietly exit the classroom. One by one the students performed this ritual with military precision and there were rarely any disruptions to the process. Fulfilling one's penance was to be done between the hours of three thirty and five, following the final bell. This period time, on Fridays, was completely dedicated to matters of faith, whether that be religious studies, church upkeep or performing the variety of punishments that had been doled out by Father Shaw during the day.

[FIN]

[APPENDIX 1: ALTERNATE TAKES]

[Embryonic]

One - William Theodore Tipnam III

On the night of his tenth birthday, his grandfather, having lost his mind to dementia, set a curse upon the head of young William Theodore Tipnam the Third, thinking all the while that he was cursing his second-born son instead. One need not believe in the reality of curses, spells, omens, or even evil to understand that this curse had ramifications. Following his grandfather's indecipherable incantation, William Tipnam the Third would never again set foot on any land mass that was not Renfield Island. With or without magic, the curse had worked.

Renfield Island was a flat, low-lying, triangular body of land that rested just off the coast of South Carolina, surrounded on two sides by the George and Panzee Rivers, respectively, and on the third by the turbulent, dark waters of the Atlantic Ocean. It was first the home of the Panzee Tribe of Native Americans, until the Europeans arrived by ship, the Tipnams among them, and took Renfield Island for themselves (unoriginally named for the Captain of the first ship to land there) first by force, then by treaty.

It quickly became a land of farmers and fishermen and remained so for several centuries. It was not until the late twentieth century that the third major industry of the island, tourism, began to take root, bringing with it a new type of island inhabitant, the *transplants*, as they are endearingly called by locals. The *transplants* built hotels, chain grocery stores, townhouses and even a golf course - first paving, then widening the roads that threaded through the lowland marshes, farms and plantation homes that seemed so idyllic to the *transplants* in the first place.

It was in this place, in this time of change, prosperity, conflict and modernization, that William Theodore Tipnam the Third was born. The Tipnams were a family with an inconsistent legacy - a fortune that had ebbed and flowed over the centuries, and at the time of William's birth seemed to have found itself at the tail end of a recession that might be its last. In fact, it was the birth of young William, our protagonist, that caused his father to sell off what remained of their rice fields, incurring the wrath of his own father, William Theodore Tipnam the First, and setting into motion the events that

would lead to his son's eventual imprisonment on Renfield Island. Once one of the *great families* , known across the southeast for their industry and stature, the Tipnams had become something of a joke by the time William arrived - the last of their wealth actively being squandered by the most recent generation on both absurd investment opportunities and personal vice. It was only because of his grandfather, the same one who had cursed him, that William had been left a trust and a home, which would prove sufficient to keep him warm and fed for the remainder of his life on the island, but would not be enough to pass down to future generations unless something profitable was made of it. The trust, you see, had been intended for his father, but was unilaterally revoked prior to the boy's twenty-first birthday due to conflicts that will come to bear in the following chapters. It was in order to slight the boy father, William Tipnam the Second, that the trust was transferred to his son's name - to be accessible only after his twenty-first birthday and given that he'd met a set of personal requirements (namely that he not have spent any time in prison prior to his twenty-first birthday - the same low benchmark that his own father had failed to meet).

William adored his grandfather as much as he hated his own father - and even after the event of the curse (which will be detailed for you shortly) - William placed the blame for his condition on the man who the ire was directed at moreso than the man who'd committed the act itself. His grandfather often went into bouts of extreme dementia: speaking with his first wife despite the fact that she'd died by way of drowning nearly forty years prior; listing, in no particular order, the presidents of the Fraternity of Renfield, a list that included him among the ranks, though he never spoke his own name during these events; catching innocent anoles by the tail and then holding them tightly in his palm like William himself liked to do on those early spring nights when it was still cold enough to keep them slow, like a child he did this, and for no apparent reason; sometimes he'd take his shirt off, exposing the dropped remnants of a once-grandiose physical form, and then he'd tug at the white hairs on his breast as though trying to extract them at the root, but never with enough force to actually remove them - William was particularly disturbed when his grandfather did this as the wrinkled skin from which the thin gray follicles extruded would be extended outward when his grandfather tugged, taut like the skin of a hog hung from a hook, but he never asked his grandfather to stop, knowing full well it would be fruitless.

It was also in these states that his grandfather would do his incantations, all of which to William's knowledge, up until the day of his own fateful curse, had been utter nonsense, the sort of thing you heard occurred at the Baptist church by the river on particularly feverous nights. A form of *tongues* .

When William was older and his grandfather had long since passed he would try to recall the incantations, but his memory would forever fail him in this regard - all he told those who asked was that they were vaguely Latin and were spoken at a volume barely louder than a whisper. If only he could remember that one, most fateful, incantation, he thought - perhaps he could break the curse, see the world beyond the water, meet a woman. But this was a laugh.

This story is not leading to a cathartic realization about freedom and curses and the shackles of legacy. This is a story about a man who became trapped on Renfield Island and never left.

Two - McCallan Road

McCallan Road runs unevenly across Renfield Island. On the Panzee River side, the island is accessed via the newly renovated Harris-Parson Bridge - a long and sinuous crossing that spans approximately a half a mile of tidal marshland before disappearing into a thick wall of live oaks, elms, pines, and low-lying bushes of all varieties, penetrating the border of the island. McCallan is the first road on the left. It sneaks up on the unsuspecting navigator. The sign is hidden behind a massive live oak that is rumored to be over four hundred years old. The oak was here before we (Americans) were here and is treated commensurately with admiration and respect - despite the inconvenient location and the history of motor vehicle accidents. Rightfully, the island has agreed that the tree should not be removed or even thoroughly trimmed - in a speech during a recent town hall meeting the Island Arboreal Society stated that "it has more right to this land than we do." This speech was made in response to a new permit request that was almost unanimously voted down. Not all of the old giants have had the same fate though - many of them were felled without resistance before the damage to the land became visible.

The thick woods get thicker after taking the left on McCallan. More live oaks line the road, Spanish moss dripping from their limbs, the brush more dense at the base of the trees. On the sunniest days light comes through the canopy in slats that flicker across the dashboard and on more than one occasion this flickering has been known to cause driver disorientation and fatalities. Every so often, when taking a sharp turn, an observant driver will notice a wreath nailed to a tree, dead flowers scattered at its base, a set of initials and a date. Some of them will make the sign of the cross, some of them will look away, some won't think of it at all.

As the crow flies the road covers approximately six miles of island - but in order to navigate the variety of wetlands across the terrain the road winds and cuts back and curves such that if it were stretched out into a straight line it would reach almost six additional miles out into the Atlantic from Grayson's Marina, where McCallan Road concludes in a pebbled drive that runs directly into the boat landing where shrimp trawlers and swordfish boats and all varieties of sea vessels unload their haul, weigh out, pack and distribute their catch.

McCallan was here before the rest of the roads it now crosses - bigger, newer roads built by those entrepreneurial *transplants*. And when driving down one of those four lane highways one would almost certainly make no specific note of the McCallan stoplight - its appearance is no different from any of the other roads leading into hastily built neighborhoods or shopping centers or local parks - but it is, in fact, different. It is the oldest road on this island, and for many of those who inhabited Renfield Island before the traffic, it is a road with a soul. In fact, to many of the more open-minded residents it is a road that contains many souls.

The Tipnams, for their part, funded a good portion of the initial construction of McCallan Road. There was a time, when the island was young, when their property was so vast that several miles of McCallan road marked their property line, beyond which the Tipnam holdings stretched all the way to the river.

As of the writing of this history, which is to say in the second year of the first Trump administration, their property only lines a small swath of the road - and one wouldn't even know the Tipnams lived there except for the overgrown entry to the drive - a rusted and bent swinging gate that opens to a long drive composed primarily of crushed shells and gravel. It was lined by a decaying wooden fence, barely standing in some places, completely absent in others, a staccato pattern of broken remnants and repaired sections. Where their land used to extend for miles on either side of this fence, they now hold on to only a slim stretch of that corridor, a hundred yards or so in either direction - and of the houses that used to exist on their property only four remain in their possession - two of them inhabited, two of them in ruin. One of the houses belongs to our protagonist, William Tipnam the third - the other belongs to his Uncle Bocephus Tipnam, and houses the man, his wife, and two daughters, William's cousins.

This is all to say that William, the isolated and cursed character at the heart of our story, was likely to be the last of the Tipnam line - unless, that was, he were somehow to father a son - a pursuit that, for the greater part of his life, existed primarily to serve as the premise for most of his Uncle Bocephus' drunk, mean-spirited jokes.

"Where curses exist, so too do miracles." It would become William's refrain, later in life, when the undeniable legitimacy of his curse had driven him to the brink of madness and left him there. "So too do miracles."

Three - November 21st

One could easily be forgiven for assuming this curse to be no more than a psychological condition - William, himself, spent years debating the veracity of the ailment, testing the limits of his restriction at great cost to himself and those close to him. His grandfather, as it were, succumbed to a fatal bout of pneumonia a mere two months after that fateful evening, and after his passing there was not a soul left in the world that could, with certainty, say what William Tipnam the First had said to his only male grandchild.

But rest assured, cynical reader, the child was veritably cursed. Over the course of the current chapter I will describe to you the events that have (for your humble narrator) nullified any possibility of doubt as to the reality of such a curse's function. And if what I have to say is still not enough for the scientific mind, then it is science itself that should be beset with an asterisk.

The truths that follow are indisputable. There are things in this world that exist beyond our capacity for comprehension and the story of William Theodore Tipnam the Third is among them.

William's tenth birthday took place on a Sunday - November 21st, 1993. Because it was a Sunday and his mother was still alive William had attended church that morning - though not without a great deal of anxiety given the events of the Sunday prior. His mother, Maureen, was a stern Catholic. On Renfield Island the Catholics were a minority. Most of the island was Christian of some other denomination (primarily Presbyterian if you were white and Baptist if you were black). There was one other religious group that William did not know about until he was much older, which will be given significant attention later in this story - this group was unique to Renfield Island and went by many names, its practices were an amalgamation of every religion that can be imagined. William's life, you will find in the chapters that follow, would lead him to learn so much about this group (one hesitates to use the word *religion*, though by definition term must be allowed, as was decided in the case "Tipnam v. Renfield" many, many years later) - his life would lead him to learn so much about this *religion* that some of it, one has reason to assume, would come to guide his thoughts and judgements if only by osmosis.

It was only later in life that William would look back on this and find it strange that she'd married his father (who went by "JR"), a non-practicing Presbyterian - a man who, for all intents and purposes, looked at religion with the same disinterest that he displayed when the subject of professional sports or the stock market was brought up. Like with baseball and the Dow Jones, William's father was aware that religion existed, but any mention of the topic would find him searching his breast pocket for a cigarette and an excuse to step away from the conversation. He simply did not care.

The same cannot be said of the rest of the Tipnam family which, in 1993, was still relatively robust. On the property lived William, William's grandfather, his mother and father, his great Aunt Lucille and her daughter Reenie (a mean, strange, old-maid with a penchant for brandy), his Uncle Bocephus and family (Aunt Mary-Ann and their children, William's cousins, Harriet and Claudia), and finally at the end of the lane lived the third brother, Ernest, a rarely seen recluse, who was often the punchline of jokes at family gatherings. Ernest was homosexual, which was the cause of great strife in his life - but let me not get ahead of myself - that part of the story, too, will be told in time.

It was his tenth birthday and a warm day in November. At six that morning he woke to the sound of his mother whistling a solemn, religious tune. The tune had been in his dream, he thought with some degree of certainty, but he couldn't remember what he'd been dreaming anymore. All that was left was a lingering sense of uneasiness - a foreboding that, to a ten-year-old child, was unrecognizably distressing. He didn't even remember it was his birthday until he made it downstairs to the kitchen where his mother was stirring at a pot of grits, still in her nightgown - "You woke up too early, child. I'm not done with your birthday breakfast yet." Though she smiled, her voice was unwaveringly stern. When she stopped speaking, you were certain she had finished her thought. Which is not to say she

was not kind, only that the kindness was of a very serious sort and made the young William have the constant feeling of being in trouble, even when that was not the case. This was a condition that would become deeply imbued in his being and follow him throughout his life.

“I’ll go pick my church clothes out,” the boy said. His mother nodded but did not respond in any other fashion. While he was making his way back towards the staircase he heard his father’s heavy snores emanating from behind the frosted glass door to his office. He saw his father’s muddy boots haphazardly scattered near the shoe rack where he’d likely tossed them off the night before. His father was a drinker, a friendly one, but a drinker nonetheless, and it was a constant source of discontent for the boy’s mother. William himself had no qualms with his father - rather there was an element of resentment towards his mother that festered in him. When they’d married, by all accounts, his father was even more keen to spirits - for instance, there was the frequently told tale that his father had disrobed on the night of the wedding, down to “his birthday suit”, only to make a full speed dash down the dock, performing a cinematic cannonball, only to rise from the waters badly gnarled by the oyster beds that were well known to line the silty riverbed. An infection developed that forced them to postpone their honeymoon, a postponement that lasted indefinitely and would be a frequent source of conversation at family dinners for the remainder of his parents’ time on this earth.

William scaled the stairs to his bedroom, running his hand along the ornate wooden banister and humming his mother’s hymn to himself as he went. He heard the sizzle of bacon when he reached the top of the stairs and by the time he reached his closet he swore he could smell the smoky, salty scent of pork fat as though it had instantaneously permeated the floor. He loved the scent almost more than the taste.

One by one he collected his attire and set it out on the bed: dark trousers, white shirt, black belt, long dark socks, and a black jacket he’d recently outgrown. Even at ten he’d begun to feel that this act of dressing up was farcical - like putting on a costume to perform in a school play. The only piece of clothing he wore by choice was his Batman underwear - though even that had begun to seem silly and childish to him. But it made mother happy, his playing dress-up and kneeling on command for an hour a week, so he obliged.

Having selected his clothes (though of course he hadn’t put them on, that was only to be done after breakfast), he took a shower and then dressed. Cleaned and dressed, he sat on his bed for a few minutes running a comb through his hair, silently calculating the appropriate time to return to the kitchen. Of course his mother would re-brush his hair, perhaps she’d even pick out a new outfit for him - the process had been no more than a way to make up for his early arrival at the breakfast table.

Finally the scent of bacon became too much to bear. He made his way to the top of the staircase and called down to his mother, “Ready yet?”. Seconds later she appeared at the base of the stairs with a gift wrapped rectangular object in her hands and a rare smile that eased William’s anxiety and brightened

his mood. He floated down the stairs, bypassing the gift his mother held out, and wrapped his arms around her thin torso. It had been so long since they'd last hugged that his head, at least for the first time he could remember, was aligned with her breasts. When they embraced it was as if he realized that his mother had a body in a new way. A cosmic shift was taking place in him, he could feel it, but he didn't know what it was or why it was happening. Did turning ten actually do something to him? Had something in him spontaneously been altered? He quickly pulled away from the hug, trying to hide his shame, and thanked his mother for the gift as she handed it to him.

The box was smallish, rectangular and heavy. "I should wait for Dad before I open it," he said.

His mother's smile faded - her face returning to the same rigid, symmetrical order as usual. "Perhaps you should," she said, and then turned on a heel and returned to the kitchen, her nightgown glimmering for a brief moment as she walked through a patch of early morning light that came in through the small window above the front door. It shimmered and flickered and then went dark, like a match lit in the breeze.

Four - Sundays

His father had not risen by the time they left for 9 AM mass.

Father Dinty delivered his sermon in the same cartoonish monotone as always. Each word seeming to wait for the word prior to expire before taking its place in sequence.

On the drive home he mentioned as much to his mother - the day was proving to be a fine one, tall cumulus clouds against a bright blue background extended out to the horizon as though it were a traffic jam to nowhere in particular. "He's so boring--the way he talks I mean. I can barely remember how he started a sentence by the time he finishes it."

She chuckled but said nothing. Perhaps she felt the same, he thought, and then he considered that perhaps this was an unspoken understanding among the entirety of the congregation. But what was there to do? Pray for an improvement? His mother took a slight detour on the way home, stopping by the Idle Hour Bakery. William sat in the running car and watched a collection of turkey hawks gliding in effortless circles above the woods that lined the opposite side of the street. He'd seen a show on PBS about birds of prey recently - they were scavengers, the turkey hawks, which meant they were looking for something dead to eat. He wondered for a moment if birds went to heaven and hell. Was a scavenger better, in the eyes of God, than a predator? Surely that wasn't how God worked. He almost laughed at himself. *I'm ten years old now*, he thought, *I should know this*.

It had been a warm November so far and that morning the pattern held. They drove with the windows down and the radio off (his mother never allowed the radio while driving, considering it an unjustifiable distraction). In his lap sat the birthday cake his mother had picked up from the bakery. A cookies and cream ice cream cake, as was tradition. He could see his name through the cellophane, drawn on the cake in thin blue icing - they'd abbreviated his middle name just to "T" and used roman numerals for his suffix - still, it barely fit.

"Happy Birthday!
William T. Tipnam III"

As they pulled into their drive the bright sun cut through the canopy in slats. The shadows cast by the trees flickered and danced across the windshield. Every so often a patch of unobscured sunlight would cross paths with the metal crucifix that hung from the rear-view mirror and William would reach his hand up to cover his eyes as though he could catch up with the light.

William was eager to see if his father was awake. As they pulled into the carport beside the house William thought he saw a figure moving through the kitchen window. "I think Dad's awake," he said.

His mother put the car in park and, as usual, put her hands together to pray, once more, before removing the key from the ignition and resuming the day's activities. Rituals upon rituals. When he was younger he used to put his hands together and mimic his mother, but recently he'd stopped doing that - not out of any sort of rebellion, but rather because it had begun to feel disingenuous - sitting there with his hands together, trying to think of a prayer that sounded like a prayer was supposed to sound. So now he just waited while his mother prayed. He didn't interrupt her or make a move to exit the car - he just sat beside her while she prayed and waited for her to make the sign of the cross, letting him know that the "church hour" had concluded and regular Sunday activities could commence again.

Theirs was one of the oldest houses on the property. It had been well maintained since its construction and as such was still in excellent condition. There were three other houses on the property of approximately the same age, but two of them had been left unoccupied for years as the Tipnam family began to dwindle, and as a result they'd fallen into disrepair out of neglect. The third was his grandfather's place - and it too had begun to deteriorate as the old man had become less able.

In contrast, Uncle Bo's home was relatively new. He'd had it built when he learned his first daughter had been conceived. He was overconfident in his "vision", and he had fired three architects before finally finding one who would draw up the illogical, claustrophobic mess that he had in mind. The resulting house was a massive, labyrinthine affair - that gave one the feeling of being in a maze regardless of their position in the house.

Once at Sunday dinner (which always took place at William the Eldest's house), William's father, in jest, asked his brother if he was even able to draw up a rudimentary blueprint of his own house. Bo

took the joke seriously, pushed his plate aside, and began sketching on the back of a napkin. He quickly realized his proportions would not allow the house to fit on the napkin so he started anew, this time on a sheet of printer paper. After twenty minutes or so he looked up from his drawing, most of the table had been cleared but William's father remained. Bo handed the sketch to his brother, who looked at it and after a minute or two spoke, "You're missing a bedroom," and then passed the drawing back to his frustrated sibling.

Bo started anew and worked diligently at it even as William's father stood and left. "It was just a joke, Ceeph," he said on the way out - but his brother didn't even look up.

Five - Back Home

Not only was the boy's father awake, but he'd been hard at work while they were away. They found him standing proudly in the center of the room, beside him something tall and asymmetrical was hidden beneath a gray bed sheet. His bloodshot eyes and blotchy red face betrayed his hangover, but that was something only his wife noticed.

William ran into his father's embrace. His father lifted him from the ground and squeezed the boy tightly against his chest. Then he began to sing with his raspy, worn out voice. "Happy Birthday to youuuu," the voice was warm and comfortable but crackled at the edges like an old fire. His mother joined in with faux enthusiasm. The scent of Dewars didn't bother young William in the slightest, in fact it added to the warmth to some degree. His father always smelled of Dewars - which the child recognized as alcohol - and while William personally didn't mind the smell he could already anticipate his mother's response if she were to come too close.

When the song came to an end his father set him down and coughed a few times.

"Lord, I can smell it from here," his mother said.

"Oh gimme a break, Mo," his father responded, looking not at his wife, but rather honing in on the blanketed gift that sat between them now. "Now what could this be?" he said, turning his attention to their son.

They'd each bought a gift for the boy, separately. Sometimes it felt to JR that they were not a married couple at all. Sometimes it really felt that way. Though, oddly enough, they'd never once even discussed separation or divorce. He wondered if Maureen felt the same way, sometimes - but of course such a discussion could never occur, their relationship didn't allow for such honesty. *Perhaps Maureen wasn't even dissatisfied*, he thought. In a way she'd always been like this, but when they were younger and both beautiful there was a charm to her elusive, distant nature. Back then it had been something

that JR perceived as intellectual, deep, mysterious. But there were never any more clues to that mystery - and over time it had turned into something more simple than that, a pure and unrelenting stoicism.

William looked at the tall object before him and then to his mother. He felt uncomfortable but wasn't certain why. He would open the other gift first, he told them, hoping to see his mother smile. She didn't though. She brought her hand to her mouth and coughed quietly. "It's in the kitchen," she said, looking first at William and then at the ground, then back to her son again. "Let me...I'll go get it now."

"Of course," his father said to no one in particular. "You're right, you're right. I'm sorry I slept in so late - I couldn't fall asleep last night. Tossing and turning. It's too hot for November." Of course this was untrue. While they'd been away at church he'd woken up still dressed in the previous night's attire. JR could hardly remember his drive home the night before. While they'd been away at church he'd woken up still dressed in the previous night's attire.

William was only vaguely aware of the strain on his parents' marriage - something dark and uncomfortable hovered in his consciousness, the scent of his father's stained breath, the ineffable distance in his mother's gaze.

What could a ten year old boy know of that world?

No more or less than that which he felt.

Six - A Book

The box was even heavier than William remembered. The wrapping paper was an excessively plain shade of blue, the folds were tight, corners precise, and there was no card or note attached whatsoever. He sat on the couch and held the gift in his lap while his father, from his armchair, watched impatiently and his mother stood by the window and cleared her throat.

"I think it's a...book," he said with a smile, glancing at his mother who returned the gesture. In the last year he'd become a voracious consumer of the written word. He'd discovered MAD Magazine at the convenience store next to the barber shop. He'd been perusing the aisles while his father was getting a haircut next door when he saw the cover of the magazine, a young boy with a giant freckled face and red hair with a cigar hanging from his lips. This led him to the realization that there was more out there to be read than the books his mother allowed him to take home from the school book fair. Since then he'd taken to perusing the library in his father's office - floor to ceiling bookshelves made up two of the four walls in his office. His father was an inconsistent, but voracious reader. He'd go weeks at a time

without so much as picking up a book and then for a week he'd be unavailable to his family, locked up in the room, visible to his son only as a muted shape through the frosted glass panel of his office door. Sometimes he stayed up late into the night with a book in his lap and a glass of scotch on the desk that seemed to be perpetually full no matter how red his face got.

William carefully unwrapped the book, peeling the tape from the corners and gently unfolding the wrapping paper as though he were determined to keep it in a condition from which it could be reused. He opened one side completely so that the top was open like a cereal box.

"Just rip it up Will! You waitin' on the second comin'?" his father said loudly and laughed.

It was the boy's way - slow and deliberate - something he'd inherited from his mother. But he was not all his mother, JR thought as he watched his son rip the wrapping paper off and toss it aside, holding the massive leatherbound book in his hands. No it was not only his mother in him, but she was the best part. JR rarely saw himself in the boy and when he did it seemed to be in times of weakness, when he walked off the baseball field in the second inning because his coach had been too brash, the way his left eye quivered when he was about to cry in someone else's presence. From his mother it was graciousness, patience, fidelity, intuition .

The outline of a large, gold cross was imprinted into the cover. *A bible*, thought JR, *unbelievable*.

William held the book in his lap and looked up at his mother, nibbling on her lower lip. He thought she was beautiful, like one of those movie stars beautiful , and again he found himself wondering how his two parents had managed to end up together. "I love it, Mom. It's beautiful." The book was astoundingly heavy, heavier than it seemed it should be. And of course it was not the sort of thing he'd hoped to find, but he was surprised at the excitement he felt as he leafed through the thin pages - something about the sheer enormity dazzled his young brain. He turned to the back of the book and found the last numbered page, 1299 - but there was more even beyond that: "Appendices". He didn't know what that meant but he gathered it was supplementary information, like you'd find in a school book, glossaries and such.

"The greatest story ever told," his mother spoke. "Everyone should have their own bible." Her smile had returned. "It's a fine edition. My parents gave me the same thing for my tenth birthday. I know it's not--"

"It's great, Mom. I love it. I'm going to read it front to back," at which his father chuckled, earning himself a darted glance from his wife.

The grandfather clock sounded eleven times. William just never knew what to do when he was in the presence of both parents. He found himself paralyzed by the anxiety of their combined presence.

JR, for his part, felt bad for the boy. He was glad he'd stumbled across the telescope the night before.

What kind of a birthday would it have been if his only gift had been a bible? What kind of a gift was that? He understood Maureen less and less by the day - but, still, as he looked at her he found himself wishing he were a different man, the sort that would have made her happy. How does a person become more foreign over time? Really, what kind of a gift was a bible? *Was William really happy?*

He already wanted to start drinking again.

He excused himself to the kitchen where fixed himself a coffee and then, quietly as possible, snuck into the pantry, filled it the rest of the way with Bailey's Irish Cream, and took a large guzzle before topping it off once more.

Seven - JR's Gift

The aged brass of the long tube did not shine so much as it glowed in the midday light, gauzily filtering in through the live oaks and pines that ran all the way from the house to the river, nearly a half mile away - the brass emanated something internal and timeless, like a hot iron pulled from a fire.

It was apparent that the telescope was of the pre-owned variety; there was visible wear on the eyepiece, main tube, and adjustable legs. William inspected each element of the mechanism patiently - moving from one joint to the next, evaluating the multitude of knobs, adjusting the angle of the tube on its fulcrum so that now it pointed toward the ceiling, now out the back window. Silent for so long his father grew uncomfortable as he watched on.

"What ya think? Somethin' else ain't it? Like it?" JR looked over at Maureen and for a moment thought he saw something kind in her eyes. Maybe it wasn't all over, yet. Maybe there was a way to fix this, he thought.

"It's the best gift I've ever gotten, Da. I can't believe it. It looks old...not like bad old, like good old. Like an...antique or something." JR nodded and smiled.

"Weather should be great tonight to get it working. After your party, you n' me gonna take this bad boy for a spin. I can show you the big dipper."

"How about Orion's Belt?" William said. "Can we see Orion's Belt?"

JR had no idea - he didn't know the first thing about astronomy truth be told, "Ab-so-lutely. There ain't a star in the sky we can't see with this here telescope. It ain't the biggest telescope ever made, but don't let it deceive you now, that's one of the most powerful telescopes your old man has ever seen in

person. Got this from one of the top astronomers in the state,” he said - and then stopped, deciding he’d better rein in his tales a bit, the boy was coming into the age of skepticism.

JR left to the kitchen to refill his coffee. A few moments later Maureen followed, finding the pantry door open and the light on. “Looking for something?”

He quietly screwed the lid back on the Bailey’s and placed it where he’d found it, now only a quarter full.

“Looking for some Tylenol or something. I’ve got a headache.” She scoffed. He walked out of the pantry, into the kitchen, and was immediately concerned by the gaze that confronted him.

“I’m sure you do,” she said, “judging by the ruckus you made gettin’ in the front door last night. You know it was three in the morning?”

“Oh hunny I didn’t mean to—I lost track...Trapper, you know how he is, we were all at the Den, and Trapper had just lost his dog, got bit by a cottonmouth, you believe that? And we couldn’t stop him.

You shoulda seen the way he was drinkin’ - and you think I’m bad, oh man. I was worried we was gonna have to bring him to the hospital the way he kept at it. I didn’t realize it got so late baby, really I didn’t.” He took a large gulp of what was mostly Irish Cream. “A man and his dog, you know? Broke his heart worse than Katelyn did, I swear it.”

“Sure,” Maureen said. “You got up at least.” He thought she might have smiled. She stood on the far side of the island bar that JR had built in the center of the room. She leaned forward, resting her weight on her elbows against the granite countertop. Her church dress wasn’t all that conservative, JR observed. The v-shaped neck of the dress plunged forward so that he could see the curve of her small breasts beneath the shadow of her chin. She looked as though she hadn’t aged since they’d married.

Her skin was flawless; she had the same thin, naturally tanned arms. He imagined how he’d appear in a mirror and lost his moment of reverie. “JR, why didn’t you tell me you got him a gift? We could have planned something.”

He finished off the syrupy mixture in his coffee mug in one final gulp. He took it immediately to the sink and began washing the cup. “I didn’t know if it was gonna come through until last night. I didn’t want to let you down,” he paused to rinse the cup out once more before putting it in the dishwasher, “like last year.” The year prior he’d promised William a new bicycle - he wanted a specific type of bike with metal tubes that stuck out from the axle of the wheels he called *pegs* - but on the day he was supposed to pick it up from the store something had occurred that required JR’s immediate attention - so he attended to it, fully intending to return to the store after he’d done what he had to do, except the thing he’d had to do took longer than that, and when he showed up at the store at a quarter past seven to find it closed he realized he had a problem on his hands back at home.

“And who was this world famous astronomer? Don’t tell me you got this from Marvin.”

“I won’t tell you that,” he said.

“Figures,” Maureen responded. “I don’t know how that man isn’t back in jail already.” JR laughed and it made the pulsing pain in his head worsen. “The Tylenol isn’t in the pantry.”

Maureen walked around the island and opened a drawer, retrieved a small bottle, and walked it over to her husband. Sometimes she ached for him; he was always in pain, always fighting with something in his own way. And even though it was all his fault, she loved him, and she’d promised to do so until death did them part.

Eight - The Johnson’s

The birthday party would be, with few exceptions, no different than most every other Sunday evening gathering of the Tipnam family in those days. They gathered at his grandfather’s house - a great, palatial affair that stood a hundred yards or so closer to the river, on the opposite side of the drive.

At that time, in 1993, his grandfather was the sole remaining inhabitant of the house, though he was visited daily by the Johnson’s. The Johnson’s had been under the employ of the Tipnam family for at least three generations. They helped keep the place in order, even when the boy’s grandmother was still around they’d been there, day-in, day-out.

The two younger women, Annabelle and Clara, cleaned, sewed, collected from the garden, and worked alongside the matriarch of the family, Paulina, whenever she needed help in the kitchen. They canned and salted all sorts of foods for preservation. There was a room behind the kitchen, more of an alcove than a room, really, that was lined floor to ceiling with various sized mason jars containing everything from pickled eggs to beef strips, peaches to moonshine, rice and pickles and salt cod. A man could have lived on the contents of that alcove for years, his grandfather liked to boast.

Paulina, in addition to cooking, kept the old man company in a more general way. William’s grandfather was decades a widow and in the time since his wife’s death he’d sought no new company.

At first it had been a matter of chivalry and dignity, when pressed by his children he gave the same response - “I promised Genny no woman sides Paulina gon’ come in this house while she’s away, n’ain’t nothin’ changed in that regard.” But over time, as his dementia became recognizable and then unignorable, mere practicality ruled it out for good. But there was always the Paulina clause, which allowed the old man a woman’s touch. There was much speculation as to the nature of William the Eldest’s relationship with Paulina - but in truth, the family didn’t care one way or the other, so they

gossiped about it in jest. It was only Paulina who felt hurt when the whispers reached her, but perhaps this was for a different reason altogether.

The three Johnson men, John, Robert and Carlton, handled repairs, of which there was a list long enough to keep them employed for this life and the next, they'd joke. They were first cousins of Annabelle and Clara, though, at least to the eye, they were closer in age to Paulina than their cousins.

While his parents discussed things in the kitchen, William cautiously moved the telescope to the window and pointed it towards his grandfather's house. When he peered through the eyepiece, however, all that was returned was a blurry amalgamation of browns and greens. He left it by the window and went to look at the Bible his mother had given him instead. Unlike the telescope, which was nicked and worn, the book he held in his hands was flawless. He ran his small hand over the leather cover, the inlaid cross in the center of the book a depression beneath his hand. He opened it to a page at random and began to read - it was a list of names, who begat who, a chronology of sorts, but some of the people it named lived to be hundreds of years old! He made a mental note to ask his mother about this - everything in the bible was true, according to her, but he'd never heard of anyone living to the age of five hundred and twenty six before. For "the greatest story ever told" this part was pretty dull, he thought. **[Bible Research]**

He heard tensions rising in the kitchen and decided not to wait for his parents to return. He hoped this wouldn't carry on into the night and put a damper on his party. This always seemed to happen before big events - he remembered the trip that never was, two months spent planning a weekend trip to a small lake in the Appalachians, only, the night before they were set to leave, there'd been a long conversation in the kitchen that ended with his father disappearing in the RV they'd rented for the trip. He'd stayed up late in the night waiting to hear the sound of that heavy vehicle pulling down the drive but it never came, not for three more days at least, when his father returned with a fresh wound on his face and a limp in his step that never really went away.

He started wishing Benny would come around soon. When Benny was around there were always ideas - that was Benny's strength, he came up with all sorts of ideas to keep the two of them busy - and when Benny was gone William always wondered why he couldn't come up with any good ideas like that on his own. He'd sit and think, even trying to imagine he himself was Benny, and think like that - What would I do if I were Benny right now? And that's what he was thinking as he stood there looking at the radiant brass telescope by the window - What would Benny be doing right now?

But nothing came to him then, not even a hint of an idea, his mind was too filled up with the frantic noise coming from the kitchen. It had escalated into a pure shouting match, William only able to make out every third word or so.

Criminal.

Absent.

*No-Good Son of–
Tired!
Tired.
Accuse me? (or was it Excuse me?)
Don't bring him–
Every time!
Why can't–
Stop it–Just stop! Enough...
Enough.
Every time, every single...*

And so on and so forth.

It was enough to make William start crying despite his best efforts to hold back - he'd even tried pinching the bridge of his nose like Benny had told him.

Just then, as if someone had been watching, the skies turned dark and it began to rain, heavy and loud - coming on all at once with a percussive rush. Giant raindrops *THWAPPED* against the old glass windows - an electric flash of light and a loud *BOOM!* from the direction of the river. The lights in the house dimmed briefly but then returned. The argument in the kitchen went on, but it was consumed by the loud, tinny noise of the storm and relegated to the background.

There had been no sign of rain until the moment the rain came - that was just how it was during the short days of November, the skies were rebellious and unforgiving.

William moved to the window to watch the rain. The first thought that entered his brain was of the siblings from *The Cat in the Hat*, the image of them staring out through the rain in bored anticipation of life. But it was then, looking down at his bible, that he decided to let his mother know that he was ready to donate his children's books to the church. It was time he left all that childishness behind, he thought. Yes, that time had come - he wanted to be a man.

Nine - The Nap

It wasn't long before William fell asleep in the chair by the window. He dreamt he was at a birthday party for another family member, though he couldn't be sure who it was, and in his dream the person never arrived for their own birthday. Music played and the party went on but the birthday guest never showed. In the dream he just waited and waited for someone to arrive while all around him the other guests seemed to have forgotten that anyone was missing. In his dream he desperately struggled to

recall who it was that they were waiting on but it never came to him - he just knew that he had to wait, and go on waiting. He had to keep waiting while the rest of the party went on or someone would never show up and the family would have lost someone dear, someone important - if only he could think of who it was, if only he could remember.

He woke up to a loud silence, with a blanket on him that hadn't been there when he drifted off. The rain had stopped and there were no more raised voices coming in from the kitchen.

He felt sweat down his back and under his arms - sleep always made him sweat, but the blanket made it worse. Realizing he hadn't yet changed out of his church clothes, he decided to head upstairs to his bedroom and take another shower. He couldn't go much longer than a few hours without feeling dirty. This fixation on hygiene, he knew, was abnormal. But *how abnormal?* There was no way to know.

More and more he'd begun to feel that life had plans for him - life was up to something - and there was a gap that was forming, growing, building between him and *other people*. He felt that everywhere he went there was a bridge between himself and the world around him, one that he could cross if he wanted, he could step off of his own **lonely island**, but at great risk. On the other side of the bridge was a world that was connected in a way he wasn't - Mom, Dad, bibles and telescopes, Paulina, and Uncle Bo, the Panzee River, the girl from class who wore crooked glasses, McCallan Road and Grayson's Marina, the country, the president, flags and road signs, boats and cars and windows and broken hearts and, and, and...his heart raced as he climbed the stairs to his bathroom, he just needed to get into the shower and wash himself clean. The shower always helped - that was at least one constant he could recognize, one firm thing on his **lonely island** and he was grateful for it. He let the hot water run until he saw steam rising over the curtain rod and then, finally, washed himself clean of the morning's accrued filth.

In his post-nap daze he hadn't completely registered the silence. It wasn't until he came back downstairs, dressed in normal clothes (oversized blue jeans and a plain black t-shirt) that he realized both his parents were missing. Observing the driveway he noted that both cars were gone, too. They hadn't left together. It was the first time he could remember being left home alone. He stood on the front porch and listened to the inconsistent *drip-dripdrip-drip* of individual raindrops falling from the trees. A large breeze swept by, brushing more water from the branches and leaves and then, having passed, the same *drip-dripdrip-drip* resumed. Puddles in the drive and their intersecting ripples transfixed him. A few small twigs and branches had fallen during the storm. They were scattered down the drive like pieces of driftwood along the shore.

A pick-up truck drove past the house, towards his grandfather's place. The Johnson men sat in the bed of the truck, smoking cigarettes and laughing. When they noticed him one of them yelled out, "Heyyyy der birt-dey boy! Happy BIRT-DEY!!" and they hollered and laughed as they continued on past.

It was Clara driving, the elder of the two girls, and the only Johnson other than Paulina who had a driver's license. She was constantly bringing them some place or another. Gas station for beer, grocery store for a particular pepper Paulina needed, to the hardware store for a different type of screw (they never had the right screw); sometimes they went on a drive for no reason at all, just *cruisin' roun* , they'd say, to enjoy the lowcountry air, which was a different type of air than all the other places in the world according to his father, who'd been a lot of places in his life before he found himself drawn back to the island as though it's gravitational pull had finally worn him down.

For some reason the men only sat in the bed of the truck. Annabelle and Paulina were the only Johnson's who ever rode up front - though the passenger seat had been empty this time. William had an affinity for Annabelle, perhaps because she was closest to him in age (thirteen to his ten), but also because she was shy and kind and she spoke to him in a different way than the others. She was always asking him about his life, his own personal life: *Did he like his daddy? Why do his mama always look like she mad when she ain't, when she really more kind than mos' folk? What was school like? What kinds of things did dey teach him? Was dey kind? Was dey any other brown kids at school?* Annabelle had stopped going to school when she was very young, after her *mama and daddy had took off one night and lef' her an Clara with Paulina to be raised.*

On top of her kindness, Annabelle was pretty. Her eyes were a shade of brownish-green like the spanish moss that hung from nearly every tree on Renfield Island.

Recently he'd begun to dream about her, even. The dreams were really only one dream, the same each time, but different too - as though when he went to sleep and dreamed this dream he just would pick up where he'd left off, and even though everything was the same it was different too. William didn't fully understand it himself but he enjoyed the dream and wished for it to greet him when he closed his eyes each night.

The dream went like this: They were walking on a twisting gravel road that never ended, sometimes there were trees and birds and cars driving by, other times they were alone. In the dream William knew (and Annabelle knew too) if they kept walking they'd never have to be apart, not for one single moment. He knew it as a fact, the same way he knew the sun set over the river, not the ocean; the same way he knew that his father meant no harm even when he messed things up the way he did. That was the dream. That was it. The road never had to end; if they kept on walking nothing ever had to end.

He woke up from those dreams confused, vaguely sad. He wanted more than anything to find that road. That place where nothing ever had to end.

He thought he'd tell her about the dreams that night, at the party. And then he thought, something really has changed inside me.

The feeling was growing by the moment and was no longer a vague perception but a tangible, nearly physical, sensation - something had changed in him and nothing would ever be the same.

Then the truck disappeared over the small mound that blocked his grandfather's house from view and William, alone again, began to worry about his parents.

Ten - The Argument

After they'd run out of insults, the argument in the kitchen died out quickly. Maureen left to check on William and found him contorted awkwardly on the loveseat, the way only children can fall asleep. She kissed the top of his head and covered him with a light blanket.

She heard JR storming through the dining room, the rattle of crystalware vibrating in the cabinets with each heavy footstep. She heard the click of his office door and hoped he'd keep it together for the party - sometimes he went into the office one way and came back out a few hours later looking like he'd been in there for a week without sleep.

Poor JR, she thought. She couldn't even remember what they'd fought about.

She was really too hard on him, she knew. She was tough on everyone and everyone knew it. In many ways she was grateful that JR was such her opposite if only because of young William, who deserved more affection than she was capable of providing. Sometimes she could come to despise herself for it - but she'd been born this way, and JR had married her this way too.

But even if she knew all this, it didn't mean much - it couldn't stop her from getting angry with him for the way he was: irresponsible, entitled, groomed on legacy and wealth, sheltered and protected by the isolation of Renfield Island where, if one believes the lore, the Tipnams had literally gotten away with murder on at least two occasions, back when that sort of thing was more common than it is today, when land disputes could be settled by duels; back when sleeping with another man's wife merited a death sentence, no trial required. And it was just this sort of mythologized history that made life so difficult on JR, who wasn't cut out for the changing requirements dictated by the modern world. He'd been born too late, put simply. His identity was intrinsically shaped by all the bravado and charisma of legend, but he lived in a time that had rendered it useless. There was no hope for a man like him with the dawn of the twenty-first century looming.

There is a logic to the world sometimes, but not mostly; mostly life is just a collection of gestures, subjective and without order, occurrences that come to pass or don't; mostly, the system we ascribe to existence is a construct, built by us and for us, useless in all other ways. As though we thought it was

only by drawing the map that the continents took their shape; as though a word was more than a symbol - like objects needed words to exist and not the other way around.

Eleven - Late

Then it was time for the party and his parents had failed to return. William was literally sick with worry. His stomach turned and groaned loudly. He'd spent the afternoon sunk into the big chair in the living room, leafing through the bible, waiting for any sound from the driveway, wondering what he should do and where they'd gone. The grandfather clock had chimed three times before he forced himself to get up and go to the restroom - something internal had urged him to stay in place, not to move, as if leaving the seat would reset some omnipotent clock, and his parents would stay away even longer than they already had. But his bladder got the best of him, he could no longer wait, and so he got up and ran to the bathroom (he was on the precipice of wetting himself), and in the bathroom he urinated for a record amount of time. He wished he'd timed it.

As he washed his hands he could see only the top of his face in the mirror - small bridge of a nose, clear blue eyes like his father's, dirty blond hair that had started the day cleanly parted, but had been anxiously twirled into a mess while he read. Some of it hung down over the left side of his face. He brushed it back into place and wondered aloud what he should do.

"I guess I'll go to the party," he said to himself - his voice echoed off the tiled bathroom walls. He took one last look at the part in the mirror. Satisfied, he put the brush back in the basket where it was kept and walked back to the living room. *But what if they come back and I'm not here? Mom would be mad.* His stomach growled again, perhaps it wasn't just that he was nervous, he realized, but now that he was hungry too. *But I need to eat. Mom gets mad if I don't eat. What is the "right thing" to do?*

Honor your mother and father, it was one of the ten commandments, but what were you supposed to do when you weren't sure how to honor them? Simple rules never turned out to be so simple when they were put into action, he thought. Only then did it strike him to call his aunt and uncle. Why hadn't he thought of it before? At least if he did what Uncle Bo said, he could say he'd followed the advice of an elder - and Mom couldn't be mad at him for that, even if she wasn't so fond of Uncle Bo, at least he was an adult. His grandfather was "losing it", he'd overheard his parents discussing it on more than one occasion, so that ruled him out, but Uncle Bo was a safe bet.

There was just one problem: he didn't know his Uncle's phone number. He knew only two phone numbers by heart - his own home phone, and 911, which he was only to dial in the case of an extreme emergency.

But this wasn't an emergency, was it?

The party was set to start in an hour. William paced the living room the way his father did when something wasn't right. He tried to whistle like his father but still couldn't manage it - spittle ran down his chin as he blew silent air through pursed lips. Eventually he got a bit dizzy and stopped trying. He blinked and wiped at his eyes, walked to the back door and put his hands on his hips the way his father sometimes stood. He rubbed at the back of his neck, ran his hands through his hair, tapped his fingers on the glass door that led to the back porch, then paced some more.

"I can't call 911," he said aloud. He couldn't calm himself down and his heart started to race. The pinkish-orange sky was visible through the trees, serving as a reminder that time was passing. "I'll just have to walk to Pappy's house by myself," he spoke aloud again - but the thought of the trek made him nervous. He was not a brave child and the disappearance of his parents had made him feel even more cowardly.

Just then the phone rang. He jumped in his own skin, felt as though his heart had stopped for a second, and then he regained composure and ran to the kitchen, where the phone hung on the wall just low enough for him to reach it by standing on his toes.

"Mom?" he answered.

"Huh?" came the voice from the other end of the line. It was the shrill voice of his Aunt Mary-Ann.

"This ain't your mama, birthday boy."

"Hi Aunt Mare," he said. He heard the way his voice quivered and suddenly he had a recollection of a feeling he'd had only once before - lost in the corn maze at Bonner Farm - as though the world was a sinister place and he was only now realizing it. And just like it had happened at the farm, as soon as the feeling took over him he began whole heartedly sobbing. He couldn't clearly make out what his Aunt was saying over the sound of his own high-pitched cries.

Twelve - Mary-Ann and Bocephus Tipnam

Mary-Ann hung up the phone and called out to her husband who was in the living room watching football. The sound was cranked up so loud that she could feel the bass vibrating through the old wooden floorboards. "Turn that god damned television down!" she shouted. He was half-deaf as a result of his motorcycle, his "mistress", as she referred to it, a black and orange monstrosity that he'd ride for hours at a time, several times a week. He refused hearing aids, though - instead he turned the volume up on the world or, when that wasn't possible, didn't hear it at all. This was a great frustration to Mary-Ann, who was soft-spoken by nature and abhorred loud sounds - but wasn't that the way things

went? We fall in love with the people that drive us the most insane - somehow that is the nature of love - we need it to be difficult or it isn't love at all.

Of course Bo hadn't heard her so she walked into the living room and positioned herself in front of the oversized television. He threw his hands up in the air, half joking, but then saw her eyes and reached for the remote to silence the TV.

"Bo, you gon' drive me nuts if you don't start puttin' them hearin' aids to use. Somethin' bad coulda happent," she said.

"Well, did it?" he said. His voice was heavy and worn as a well seasoned cast iron. He always spoke at the same cadence, with the same rhythm, whether he was reprimanding one the girls for rudeness, or arguing with his brother about financial affairs, or even when he was pillow-talking with Mary-Ann late at night, which was when she was fondest of the warm touch of his voice.

"Did what now?"

"Did something bad happen while I was busy not hearin' you?"

She remembered why she'd shouted to him in the first place and suddenly felt nervous again. "Well I don't know certain, it's something unusual at least." Claudia walked past the doorway with headphones on, listening to one of her tapes loud enough she'd end up with ears like her father. "I just been on a call with lil' William and he don't know where JR or Mo is. He says they lef' a few hours ago and ain't arrived back yet." She paused, still reflecting on the situation herself, "Ain't like Mo. We's supposed to be over at your daddy's house in a half hour. Just ain't like Mo, right?"

Bo muted the television and directed his attention towards his wife. It was absolutely like his brother to do something like this, but he agreed, nothing like Maureen. She was dependable to a fault, never really even left the property without having announced her purpose and intention days in advance - and never on a Sunday! After church she came home, renewed religious zeal, and did whatever she had to do around the property with a humble sort of piety that didn't really exist anymore. Like a pilgrim, he thought - a woman like a rock, dense with stability and fortitude - unchanging.

The Falcons were losing again. Glanville's coaching career had quickly reversed course and it was getting to be unbearable to watch anyways. "No, ain't like her at all." He turned off the TV and stood, all two hundred and eighty pounds of him, grimaced a bit at the pain in the base of his back. "Lemme go check on 'im then."

"He's cryin' awful - be nice to him, Bo. It's his birthday, remember?"

"I'm always nice to him," Bo said. "It's his father bugs the piss outta me. Daddy like that he ain't have no choice bein' a runt."

“Stop it Bocephus.”

He hobbled to the door, grimaced as he bent down to tie up his boots. He'd have to drive the truck on account of his back acting up again. He wondered why the lord hadn't granted him a boy as he drove the short distance, past his father's house where the Johnson girls were putting up streamers, over the small hill. And when the house finally came into view, something about the bleak darkness of his brother's place made his gut clench up. The feeling you got looking a buck in the eye as it bled out, something gone from *being* to *not being* - that was what he felt. And he knew the night was going to be a long one.

Thirteen - Time Passed

Maureen had decided to apologize, but as she approached the office she could hear her husband speaking to someone - agitated, but trying to maintain a whisper. She could not help herself but to listen for a moment, despite the overwhelming sense that it was something she would come to regret. She couldn't parse the words themselves at first, then she heard a staccato burst of curse words so vile they made her cringe. JR wasn't the sort of man who spoke like that, not in front of his wife at least, but she'd clearly heard him string together the f-word, c-word, another c-word, a b-word, and a word she'd heard before but couldn't tell you what it meant if her son's life depended on it.

Her sweet son, what kind of a family had they brought him into - disaster seemed to loom around every corner. A feeling of doom hung over them and she knew it. The whole Tipnam line, in fact, she'd known it since high school - but back then it was sexy and exciting, and back then she was a different person, hadn't found God yet, that wouldn't come until William was born - this was, paradoxically, the very thing that trapped her in this life of vileness. Her son, her little William, was simultaneously her savior and her captor. A backwards sort of munchausens, she thought. More than once she'd thought of taking the boy and fleeing for good - but for God and his Holy Commandments she might have done it too.

She heard him slam the phone back in its cradle, then heard him pick it up again and begin to dial.

Quickly she ran to the kitchen and picked up the other home phone, simultaneously placing her thumb over the mouthpiece to avoid being heard by her husband. What a nasty thing to be doing, she thought, it was wrong to listen in on the private conversations of your husband. But something had gotten into her, some bit of that vile nature took over. Imagine he'd listened to her conversations with Christine, that wouldn't end well, she thought. But still she put the phone to her ear and listened to the line ring five times before a sultry female voice answered: “Sorry I've missed your call. You know what to do at the beep.” She could picture the sort of woman who had an answering machine like that - could almost

choke on her perfume right there in the kitchen, the Dolly Parton lips, breasts barely contained by a doll-sized bra, thick, dark mascara layered on like acrylic paint.

She felt her face flush as she heard the line go dead - he hadn't left a message. She hung up the phone and, not knowing what to do, darted into the bathroom to catch her breath.

She'd never once thought JR was stepping out on her - even now she didn't assume it to be the case - he was a lot of things but not a cheater. Not JR, he was a terrible liar, didn't have the intellect to hide something like that. Or was she naive? She'd been accused of it in the past, by JR no less, every time she handed a dollar to the Cart Lady (whose name was Carol, and had actually only been a year behind JR in school before she dropped out - but he swore he didn't remember her). He'd chide her for taking Carol's stories seriously, even if she didn't believe them: she needed bus fare to get to her new job, had lost her food stamps in a fire, had her gloves stolen by a man on a motorcycle - *drove by'n took'um right off my hands!* "But what would the lord do?" Maureen would retort to her husband. But she knew full well the Lord might as well have come from one of Carol's stories as far as JR was concerned.

She'd been staring at herself in the mirror for almost a minute before she turned on the sink and splashed her face with cold well water. Looking at herself again in the mirror she noticed thin wrinkles that ran from the corners of her mouth downward - they'd begun to form while life passed by, she supposed, but she'd never noticed them so much as at that moment. At the corners of her eyes too, curving downwards again, as if every face she made had some sort of downward element in it. Like the imprint left behind when something has sat somewhere too long, her face was becoming a monument to her terse demeanor, a living fossilization of her dissatisfaction. It had gone on too long, she thought, but it was too late now - and anyways life was not supposed to be the hedonistic ferry-go-round that her husband apparently found so enjoyable. That was no way to be, she thought. That was no way to be, she reassured herself.

Fourteen - The Drive

The drive curved around in a sort of u-shape, a horse-shoe path made of gravel and dirt that connected McCallan Road back to McCallan road. With every heavy rain the drive would become pocked with small dips and potholes that were filled and smoothed over by the Johnson men on a consistent basis, a process which required multiple trips to the local depot where they filled the back of the pickup with gravel and then drove the path, Clara driving, two men shoveling from the back of the truck, and a third that followed on foot, smoothing the small stones out with a hard metal rake. The raking was the hardest part, and it was usually Carlton who was assigned the duties that required the most effort - as he

was both the strongest and youngest, and had never thought that he might be able to use his strength to change the pecking order that had been quietly established in his youth.

The main house, William's grandfather's house, was built closest to the water, at the apex or valley of the drive, depending on one's perspective. The houses of the two brothers were opposite one another, on opposing sides of the patriarchal home. From above one might note the near perfect symmetry of the layout - each brother's home being equidistant from their father's house as well as the road - the loop of the whole drive completed by McCallan road, an obtusely curved segment of the two-lane thruway, which perhaps not incidentally was almost precisely the same distance (approximately .4 miles) as the distance from the son's houses to the grand home, respectively.

The curved triangular path that resulted was uncannily precise in some ways. And yet one would never notice the nearly perfect shape, distances, equivalencies, without consulting a map or diagram (none of which displayed the private drive anyways) partially because of the slightly disorienting undulation of the land (due to the mounds that had been built there before any white man was even aware of the existence of any land mass between Europe and "the orient"), and partially because of the thick green arbory that enveloped the land as a whole, both covering the houses from above and obscuring the views between each of the homes like a lush, hazy, chirping, croaking, ever-growing (yet seasonally expanding and contracting, breathing, as it were) mist of foliage.

Bo had taken the route that led past his father's house for purely practical reasons - but as explained above, there were always really two ways to get from any one point to any other point along the Tipnam loop. No one in their right mind crossed the middle by foot for reasons that will come to bear in the following chapters.

Fifteen - Thresholds and Skepticism

Bo entered through the garage. He'd installed the new automatic garage door the year prior with the help of his brother and still remembered the code they'd set up. Five, five, five, five. Bo had suggested his brother change the number to something more *secure*, but JR only laughed in response. Bo had assumed there was no significance to the number, and nothing had been divulged to indicate otherwise.

As he entered the code now he noted that the rubber button in the center of the keypad had been worn down so far that the number itself was no longer visible. Every other number remained as pristine as they'd appeared on the day of installation. He made a mental note to discuss this with his brother when he got back - and then a voice in the back of his head chimed in, uninvited, "*If he comes back,*" - the feeling of dread washed over him again. He shook his head and tried to focus his attention on other things, more immediate things.

The helmet was still in the garage, mounted on the golden horn of their grandfather's leather saddle - the saddle was an heirloom that had been in that garage since the boys were young, and it had been serving that same purpose: helmet-rest, since JR'd taken to riding motorcycles - which is to say, since his eighteenth birthday. It wasn't unlike JR to take off without his helmet either, so Bo was not surprised to find the left behind equipment. His riding gloves were still there too, though, as were his riding glasses - both resting on the workbench beside the saddle - and this was a bit more out of character than pure irresponsibility allowed. From the little Bo knew about riding he knew it wasn't very enjoyable to "cruise" without eyewear - one's eyes ostensibly took on the responsibilities of a windshield.

The interior garage door opened into the kitchen. He walked in quietly, for some reason, slowly closing the door behind himself and refrained from calling out for William - the eerie feeling again pulsed through his body, like there was a predator on the premises, like he was not supposed to be there.

Though he wasn't able to identify these things at the moment - there were dishes left in the sink, the door to the blue room (a room that served no practical purpose but had forever been decorated with blue and white furnishings and artwork) had been left ajar, there was a low humming noise in the background - though he didn't notice them explicitly at that point he knew that the house was not the way the house *should be* as he walked the length of the kitchen and turned right, entering the living room where he was startled by telescope, with its human-like appendages and sharp vertices.

Where was William? The wind picked up outside, branches whipped about in the fading light of the post-storm evening. He heard them clacking loudly against the roof and siding and thought he'd better plan to trim back the branches for his brother again.

Still he remained quiet - he was frightened in a way that reminded him, more than anything, of his childhood - the tall grandfather clock that now stood in front of him had been an object from a ghost story in his youth, a story his father had told the boys when they'd been acting particularly ornery.

The old clock, according to story (portions of which William the Eldest swore to have witnessed, himself, when he was still in grade school), had arrived on the island in the middle of the night without any information regarding its origins or intended destination. "An apparition," he said, "like a ghost itself, except it were real and it were here, sittin' at the depot, which were still a depot then same as it is now." The depot he spoke of was a warehouse where, when the island was a smaller place, all of the businesses on Renfield received their inventory shipments.

The clock, of course, was not a ghost - it could be touched and lifted and even moved - which was what had been done the very next day, as no one had made a proper claim of ownership and the owner of the depot was indebted to the Tipnam family for reasons undisclosed.

But despite the undeniable physical reality of the clock, despite the fact that it was *not a ghost* - there was not an expert within a hundred mile radius that could give any insight as to its possible origin.

Whatsmore, there were features about the clock that could not be explained by these same experts - it was constructed in a way that baffled even the most accredited of the scholars brought in over the course of the next few years - and eventually the search for an explanation was abandoned altogether in favor of the mythologized, paranormal backstory, which had become a part of the structure itself in the interim, like barnacles on a piling - one could scrape them off, but to what ends? To find what beneath the surface?

There Bo stood, entranced by the ticking of the second hand, when something flickered in the glass reflection, a movement just behind him, causing him to turn on his heels quickly and call out, finally, for William, whose reply came from the opposite direction, he was in his father's office. "Uncle Bo - she's still not back!" and Bo decided he'd better just get the boy and get on out of there before he, himself, started believing in ghost stories.

Sixteen - At The Desk

William was seated at his father's desk, biting his nails, looking so much like his father that it made Bo uncomfortable. He was small for ten, Bo thought, thin shoulders and arms that made him look underfed. He was the sort of child that didn't finish his dinners, Bo thought - *I was the one that should have been given a son*. He was angry with his brother, too angry to be worried, and the way the boy looked, like a sickened version of his father, it filled him with conflict.

"Let's go birthday boy," he said as he walked around the desk. He lifted the boy by the armpit, causing him to emit a high pitched squeal before being set down. "That hurt?" he said, smiling beneath his mustache, a darkness running through him.

William rubbed at his arm and tried his best not to cry. "A little," he said. "Not much." He was relieved but frightened. "Do you know where they are?"

"Boy, I don't know a damn thing when it comes to your Daddy," Bo said. He opened the door that led to the foyer and looked back impatiently at William. "Come on now kid. You ain't gonna find them sittin here cryin, that's for damned sure."

"I wasn't crying," William spat back.

"Watch it now. I ain't your Daddy but I'll take my belt off if I need to."

William felt his lip beginning to tremble. Everything was wrong. He'd gone to sleep a few hours earlier and woken up in a nightmare. It was all backwards. A lightning bolt struck in the distance and a shattering boom reverberated through the house. He stood from his father's chair, took in a whiff of the air around him, his father's scent from a few hours earlier still lingering there. It would be gone in a few hours, and somehow he knew for certain that it would not be back again. "Sorry Uncle Bo," he said. And then they left the house together, stepping out into the hot, damp air where a light drizzle had begun.

William had to hoist himself up into the truck, which sat on wheels as tall as his shoulders. He rode in the front seat, something his mother would never have allowed, and looked for the moon through the trees as they took the horseshoe drive back to his Uncle's house. According to the clock on the radio it was 6:17. They passed his grandfather's house where the lights were on in the garage and the doors were open. The garage was always empty now that his grandfather's driving privileges had been revoked - but now he saw that the long white folding table had been set out in the middle of the space. Two of the Johnson men were setting up chairs around its perimeter. He looked for Annabelle but saw no one else. Then they turned around the bend and he stopped looking for anything.

His parents were gone. That was all he could think. And as they pulled up to his Uncle Bo's house he begun to wonder what would happen to him if they never came back.

Seventeen - A Premonition

The rain continued on and off for the next thirty minutes while William, Uncle Bo and Aunt Mary-Ann sat around their kitchen table. Mary-Ann smoked her long thin cigarettes, intermittently tapping the ashes into a small dish that Claudia had made in a middle school pottery class, just before she had decided she was destined to become an *artist*. William liked the dish - it was formed by one long string of clay coiled in progressively wider circles. The coiled rope terminated in a snake's head, jaws agape, facing outwards from the rim of the bowl as if it were prone to strike. He wanted to be interested in something the way Claudia was interested in art - wanted to love something so much it would give shape to his life - something like whatever had caused Claudia to dye her hair blue, paint dark rings of mascara around her eyes, wear nothing but black, decorate her room from floor to ceiling with portraits of poets, painters and torn out pages from her notebook filled with illegible handwriting. Of course, he didn't think of it in this way at the age of ten - all he felt was a vague dissatisfaction with his life, an ambiguous emptiness in his character, as though he wasn't a fully formed person yet. He wasn't an artist like Claudia, a trouble maker like his father, nor was he devout like his mother, or masculine like Uncle Bo. He wasn't wise like his grandfather or funny like Benny - not beautiful like Annabelle or matronly like Paulina. He felt as though he was composed of nothing - he just existed.

But then it struck him, and did not make him sad in the way you might think, perhaps he was an orphan. It was a feeling that had come upon him suddenly and without announcement, and it felt to William as if it had been there his whole life, waiting to happen, even before he fell asleep on the couch that afternoon, dreaming of an absence while his parents disappeared.

Eighteen - Renfield, Apart

Mary-Ann was nervous that something terrible had happened. Something in the sound of little William's voice like he was aware of something that had occurred but didn't know how to speak it aloud. Like it was more than a gut feeling. And even worse there was nothing to be done about it. Bo had thought to go driving the island, whispered it in his wife's ear after he'd come back with the boy - but what good would it do? It was dark out now and they'd left on their own accord.

They couldn't call the police and that was for two reasons. Firstly, they hadn't been gone but a few hours, and the police weren't going to act on a hunch (and anyways on the television shows they always said a person had to be missing at least twenty four hours before you could file a "missing persons report"). And the other reason was the police on Renfield Island weren't fans of the Tipnams just as much as the Tipnams weren't fond of the police. That had a history going back longer than she'd been a part of the family and it was well known on the island that the two parties only interacted to quarrel. The Tipnams were an old family and Renfield was an old island and the way things worked on that island wasn't anything like the way things worked out in the real world where people lived normal lives like you see on the television where folks held normal jobs and people lived on their own accord, as individuals.

On Renfield, on the Tipnam property, it was like you didn't just live your own life but you lived the life of everyone around you too, like everyone was all part of the one bigger organism, like ants or bees - connected by an invisible web so that nothing was individual or private...but she was going too far, she thought. She snubbed out her cigarette in the ashtray Claudia had made, looked at the clock on the microwave, and said to Bo it was time they got going.

William had his head down on the table between crossed arms, so that his face could not be seen. He looked up at the sound of Mary-Ann's voice and she realized he'd been crying since they'd sat down. She made eyes at Bo to let him know to keep quiet. Then she said to him, "You take the girls in the truck and we'll follow right behind." Bo called the girls down from their rooms and they left through the garage.

Mary-Ann took William into the bathroom and washed his face with a damp towel. She rubbed the back of his neck and ran her hands through his hair. "Your momma and daddy are gonna be back soon, babydoll, you'll see. Put a smile on that face. Grown-ups are silly sometimes."

“My mother isn’t silly, Aunt Mare. Have you ever seen her act silly?”

“Of course I have,” she forced a chuckle. “Everyone has a little silly in ‘em. We was in school together, your mama and me. You know that?” He nodded. “She was a few grades younger’n me but she was one of them smart kids, you know, so we was in class together for math. Mr. Crick. Creepy old man.” She made eye contact with him through the mirror and smiled, then she grabbed a comb from the drawer to his right and ran it through his hair while she spoke. “We all hated Crick cause of the way he looked at us with his creepy glasses down at the end of his nose, ‘specially the girls. Your mama caught him starin’ at her once so the next day she put Visine in his coffee when he wasn’t lookin’.”

“What’s Visine?” William asked.

“Like eye drops,” she said. “I don’t know how your mama knew, but when you mix it in with someone’s coffee it makes them need to use the bathroom like you wouldn’t believe,” she said, now genuinely laughing, done with the comb, just talking now, looking into the mirror like it was a window and William was on the other side. “So Mr. Crick got about fifteen minutes into his lesson and all a sudden his face turns bright red like a stop light. He stops talkin’ in the middle of his lecture, just like that, and starts runnin’ towards the door like his ass was on fire.” She covered her mouth to let him know she realized she’d said a curse word but went on.

“I’ve heard plenty of curse words, Aunt Mare,” William was almost laughing now too. “My mother did this?”

“Told you she was silly. And anyways, Crick did it to hisself, you ask me.”

“What happened?”

“What d’ya think happened?”

“I don’t know,” he chuckled.

“You ask your mama when she gets back,” she answered. William let out a whimper of a laugh and then rolled the window down. Hot, wet, salty air filled the car - the scent of pluff mud and oyster beds - too thick to think, he thought. And then they arrived.

Nineteen - The Storyteller

“Uncle Bo don’t want you to say nothin’ to Pappy,” his aunt said as he was rolling up the window.

“Okay?”

“About my parents?”

“Yes,” she replied. “About your parents. Pappy’s old and Uncle Bo doesn’t want to worry him, you know?” William nodded, but he didn’t know.

“Don’t you think he’ll notice anyways? I don’t mean any disrespect, I jus-”

“Don’t say nothin’. Let Bocephus worry about that.” William wasn’t sure what to say so he said nothing. With the window up and the car off it was quickly getting steamy in the car - he looked over to his aunt, who was looking at him with concern. “You got it?”

“Yes ma’am, I got it.”

Apart from Uncle Bo, Harriet and Claudia, there were only a few others in the garage, none but his cousins under the age of thirty. His grandfather sat in an old recliner at the back of the room, gazing blankly at the congregation before him. His cane was laid across his lap like a safety harness for a theme park ride. The handle was a bronze mako shark that had been the source of many homespun myths when William was younger and his grandfather’s mental state hadn’t deteriorated to its current state. His grandfather was a great storyteller in those days and William could recite many of the stories he’d been told by heart. The old man would never admit that a tale was a product of the imagination, no matter how absurd or surreal the events he’d described, he would stomp the cane against the ground and protest against anyone who questioned so much as the accuracy of a word he’d uttered. The chair, back then, resided in the reading room, before it had grown threadbare and dull - and his grandfather would usher in his grandchildren by ringing a small metal bell that he kept on the side table that sat next to it. For a brief time all three grandchildren would rush in to listen. But that only lasted until Harriet decided she’d outgrown the fantasies, and started skipping many of the family gatherings altogether. Claudia, who was only one year Harriet’s junior quickly followed suit, and by the time William was six, whenever the bell rang there was only one pair of feet that scampered through the house to hear whatever madness their grandfather had concocted.

He told stories about great fishing adventures with his own father, who’d owned the cane before him and used it to determine the location of big tuna by spinning it, upside down, and setting course based on the direction in which it landed. In another story the shark had once been real, caught by spear on a stormy voyage, then shrunk by a shaman on a distant island where they’d found themselves stranded for several months. Sometimes the shark was a relic he’d stolen from pirates that had raided Renfield when his grandfather was a young boy. Sometimes the shark held a genie that could only be released by a forgotten incantation - they’d invent mystical languages to try to summon him until it was time for the boy to go home. Standing at the entrance to the garage, observing the celebration that seemed to have hardly noticed his arrival, William found himself wanting to hold the cane once more, just for a

moment, struck by the idea that if he could only summon the genie he could wish for the appearance of his parents and turn the events of the day into nothing more than a bad dream.

For a year or two the stories were a routine pleasure.

But then, like the chair, his grandfather began to lose his luster. The chair was moved into the garage and replaced by a new, state-of-the-art, medical-grade recliner. The new chair had a button on it that would literally lift his grandfather into the standing position, tilting forward like the bed of a dump truck. By then William had grown too old to sit in his grandfather's lap - and the stories stopped making sense altogether, sometimes diverging into strange murmurings that frightened the young boy - ending abruptly, mid-sentence, his grandfather's eyes suddenly gone blank like a fish on ice. One day this occurred in the middle of a particularly disturbing story. William ran to his mother, upset by what he'd heard, and asked her to tell him what a "spawn of incest" meant. That night his grandfather's bell was taken away and the stories were not spoken of again.

Twenty - The Incident

In the center of the garage two large fold-out tables had been set end to end. A plastic tablecloth composed of blue and white stripes covered each table, on top of which sat the food. A woman sat at the far end of the tables. She waved at William as he approached the spread, shouting "Happy Birthday!" with a degree of excitement that was out of place at a Tipnam gathering. She was a friend of William's mother back in grade school but they'd gone separate ways when they hit adolescence. Upon seeing the woman's face William was reminded of the event that had led to her invitation. It made him want to turn around and go back to his house. He couldn't believe she'd come.

It had occurred the Sunday prior. His mother had been in a particularly good mood that day. After mass concluded she'd decided to stop in at the post-mass gathering that took place in the parish hall, an informal event where coffee and donuts were provided. Father Dinty would meander about the hall shaking hands with everyone before making announcements regarding upcoming fundraisers and events. William never enjoyed it, someone was always forcing a donut on him (he wasn't one for sweets, but no adult would believe a child who said they didn't like strawberry filled donuts). The worst part of the whole charade was the children - they'd cluster in small groups, making jokes and whispering with each other, their faces caked with white donut powder, sticky red cherry filling drying into a crust around their lips.

His mother had decided to attend the gathering for a reason, he realized. Watching her from the corner of the room, where he'd taken an uncomfortable seat on a stack of empty plastic crates, he noticed that she was maintaining a presence in Father Dinty's orbit. She wouldn't go so far as to directly approach

him, rather, he observed, she tried to stay within his line of sight, hoping to be the next person he chose to greet.

Later in life he would reflect on the days and weeks prior to his birthday obsessively and this scene would often come to mind. It was typical of his mother, this sideways way of approaching things - and it was yet another way in which his mother and father led not just *different*, but almost diametrically opposed, existences.

Sitting on the crates still he saw the moment his mother encountered the two women who now sat at the table in the garage, waving him over to come say hello.

Father Dinty had just finished talking with an older man in a wheelchair and had turned in his mother's direction. William was relieved - once she spoke with the priest they would be able to leave - and there was nothing he wanted more at that point. One of the groups of children had begun playing tag nearby, which meant he'd need to move before long if he wanted to avoid getting unintentionally roped into the game. He saw Father Dinty approach his mother with his hand out, watched them exchange greetings.

But it was at just that moment that a young girl with a lollipop in her mouth dashed past him, oblivious to his presence, and clipped his left foot with her leg. She tried to maintain her balance, skipping with her other foot to try to catch herself, but she wasn't able to redistribute her weight quickly enough, and William watched the girl fall for what seemed to be an unrealistically long time. As if time itself had slowed down, he watched her arms flail outward rather than forward to catch herself. Her instinct for self-preservation was fundamentally lacking, he thought. Toppling forward, he saw the thin white stick of the lollipop between her lips. It pointed directly towards the ground.

Even before she made contact with the hard vinyl floor of the parish hall he realized with horror that this was the exact scenario that his mother warned him about so many times before.

When she hit, she hit hard, and there was an audible crash that echoed throughout the chamber. Several people gasped. The accusing eyes of the congregation were on him instantaneously. If time had slowed down when the girl fell, it compensated by accelerating once she landed. She lifted her head slightly and proceeded with a noise unlike any William had ever heard before, choking and sputtering as bloody spittle flew from her lips. Blood dripped from her lips and spread between the tiles. Several of the adults in the congregation came running in their direction at once. A woman shrieked from far off and then screamed the girl's name, "Jocelyn!"

Only then did William find his mother's eyes in the crowd. She was in the same place she'd been moments earlier, a few feet from the coffee station - only the priest was gone now, the conversation had been sabotaged by her own son. Against all odds, without moving so much as an inch - it felt quite cruel to the young boy, who still hadn't gotten up to assist in any way.

Twenty One - The Woman

The woman across the tables rose from her seat and began walking towards William, a broad smile across her face. There was something sinister about her having come, he felt, though there was no good reason to feel it.

She'd been the one who ended up saving the girl that day. "I'm a paramedic," she loudly confirmed to no one in particular as she pushed her way through the circle of congregants. "Make some space please!" The girl was now on all fours, heaving in an oddly soundless way. The stick of the lollipop wasn't visible from William's perspective, all he could see was strings of blood that hung from her lips and the animalistic way she was convulsing. "She's choking," the woman said, "stand back! Give her space!" The woman got down on her knees beside the girl, her back facing William so that he couldn't see what was going on. She said something quietly in the girl's ear. Then she quickly tied her hair back into a ponytail and leaned over the girl's back, wrapping her arms around the girl's waist, and grunted loudly as she pumped her arms upwards into the girl's stomach. The heimlich maneuver, William thought, they'd seen a safety presentation about it at school in gym class. Nothing happened though, the girl still made no sound.

The woman released her grip, reset herself in a slightly different position and then leaned forward again. It was then that William noticed her dress had ridden up, some part of it folded beneath itself, and he could see the top of her legs and in between them a sliver of her underwear. It was a light tan color, another shade of skin, and William had at first thought it to be skin, but then saw a small tuft of dark hair exposed from beneath it.

He was ashamed of himself but as always, he didn't know what else to do. He found himself frozen by his own thoughts. Of course it should be the girl he was concerned about, but instead it was the woman's exposed backside, the gathered church-members who couldn't seem to make their mind up on whether to focus their attention on William (the culprit) or the young girl (whose name he would later learn was Meredith). He should have been concerned for the girl but instead he was anxious because his face was flush and hot, red; instead he thought how upset he must have made his mother by interrupting her conversation with Father Dinty (and what had she needed to speak with him about anyways?). He was ashamed that he was so ashamed as the woman contracted her arms again, her dress flying upwards with her motion, and William looked away for a moment, until he heard cheers coming from the gathered crowd. His mother's voice among them, somehow a decipherable tone amongst the white noise of the cluttered applause. And then the girl began to cry with so much fear and relief that it was unbearable to the young boy's ears.

He began to cry then, and did not look back at the crowd as he made a dash for the bathroom, his mother's voice calling out behind him, "William, stop! This instant!" It was the first time he could remember that he'd deliberately disobeyed her.

Twenty Two - Baby Teeth

He'd ignored his mother's knocks until she threatened to get the keys to the bathroom herself, and only then did he speak, "Just a minute," he said, "It was an accident. Just a minute. I'll come back out."

Five minutes or so later he stepped out into the hall with painfully dry, red eyes. Jocelyn was okay, his mother told him - her parent's had taken her to the hospital.

"What happened?" she asked.

"There was so much blood," he said.

She'd lost a tooth, his mother told him, that was the blood. "How did it happen?" she asked again.

"She tripped," he said. "All the kids were running around and-, and she ran past me," he voice began to quiver. He couldn't help himself from crying sometimes, he thought. He hated it about himself - this total inability to control a part of himself - to William it felt the same as if he couldn't stop himself from picking his nose, or pick up a glass of water. How could he have so little control over his own body?

"She just ran into you? You didn't stick your leg out there to trip her?"

He was genuinely surprised. Of course he hadn't done that. He was ashamed she'd even thought it possible. He didn't speak but shook his head *no*.

Before his mother could speak again the lady appeared in the hallway. He could think only of what he'd seen, her pubic hair, and looked away as she approached. She put her hand on his mothers shoulder and spoke in a kind voice. "She'll be fine. It turns out that tooth had been loose anyways. In a way you did her a favor," she said, now speaking to William. "The tooth fairy will come earlier than anticipated."

"I didn't DO anything," he spat his words out, still looking at the ground.

His mother told him to go wait by the back door - staring at him until he began to move.

When he was out of earshot, she turned back to the woman, "I don't know what would've happened if you hadn't been here. Really. I'm so glad she's alright."

"She shouldn't have been running around with a lollipop in her mouth like that," the woman spoke.

“Still, I feel terrible. He says he didn’t trip her. He’s an honest child.”

“He seems like a good kid, Maureen. I wouldn’t worry about it too much.” The woman still had the same face she’d had as a child, Maureen thought. She felt vaguely bad about the way she’d treated her so many years ago. In grade school they’d been close friends, but then in Junior High they’d been sorted into different social castes, and Maureen had stopped talking to her altogether. She still couldn’t remember her name.

[1] Unlike traditional epigraphs, in which the quotation, aphorism, axiom, truism, statement, couplet, accidental turn of phrase, lyric, utterance, or bit of wisdom is first provided within the appropriately inverted commas and then followed by the MLA formatted citation, offering the **author’s name**, the title of the poem, song, book (whatever) from which the excerpt is excerpted, the year of publication, edition, page, etcetera and etcetera (it really can go on for quite some time if you want it to) - I have instead decided, with regard to the **author’s name**, it would best serve the work for the format to make like a pair of commas and get inverted, structure-wise. As such, you will notice that the epigraphs are categorized by writer, because there are many, and the occasional writer/poet/artist/sanitation engineer/capitalist/Gomorrahian or Sodomite may have more than one epigraphism© contained herein. Make of it what you will. It makes me quite happy, in any case.

-J. L. Roapes

[2] N. B.: The title when first translated: *The Three Cornered Room*

[3] “*Newborns are the most alien beings on earth.*” W. T. wrote on the topic, in a journal entry dated two days after the birth of his half-sister, Cioran, born nearly sixteen years his junior. “*I held Cioran this morning for the first time. She is a silent, foreign thing. Oddly quiet for a baby. It’s all Mom and [redacted] speak about since they came home from the hospital. I feel bad for saying this - so I don’t say it, of course - but she kinda gave me the creeps if I’m being honest. It seemed as if there was nothing inside her yet, an empty vessel. And I’m sitting there holding this baby shaped container, and it’s staring at me, and I get the feeling she is basically taking something from me (not in the figurative sense). I know it’s absurd. It’s not the sort of thing I plan to talk about. But that’s the feeling I got, like she wasn’t herself yet, she was something else, or nothing, rather— and she was taking something from me that she’ll never give back or even know she took.*”

[4] Seventy four complete character studies were found by the G.A.N. after the death of his father, whose true name the G.A.N. never actually was able to identify with any level of confidence, though he did figure out with near-certainty that it would have been more than likely derived from some sort of Croatian/Serbian with hard, phlegm-inducing, bronchial syllables, and nothing like the ridiculous, yet passable, Nibbolino, that his father chose, for reasons unknown, when it right down to it.)

[5] Here we see the nature of the GAN’s father as creator, not researcher, apparently failing to have done even rudimentary research into DaVinci, who almost certainly preferred to have intercourse with men, if he had intercourse at all, and never fathered any children (though notably he did have twenty-two half siblings - a fact that is more incredible today than it would have been then - but still, would have been a remarkably sized family, even then).

[6] Later this would become the central concept driving one of his more critically well received novellas, titled “Mother of May”

[7] This really doesn’t touch the tip of the iceberg that sits in the gap between two beings trying to communicate—even to get here we are at such a remove from what two people mean when they say *love* in the first place that it seems reasonable to question the pursuit of *honest communication* in the first place. This is the abyss that I believe T was talking about in that last, hopeful letter that was found following his disappearance. When I first had this realization I felt I’d cracked an unbreakable code—but it was not long before I realized that nothing had been encoded at all, I’d simply failed to *understand* what T had been repeating to me clearly and explicitly for years on end, believing with all his heart that I’d understand in time.

[8] Taking on the nickname T, as it were, was a decision he'd made in the moment, while introducing himself to the Roapes family, partially as a way to get back at his mother for what she was putting him through, partially as some kind of inside joke meant to mock his new neighbor/landlord, but perhaps mostly as an experiment to test the power of a name

[9] For the longest time William was confused by the seemingly oxymoronic concept of a "party meeting" —when ultimately he came to the recognition that these were 'political parties' and not the sort where drunken adults acted like idiots, it caused a series of thoughts to occur in sequence, one leading to the other like a chain of dominoes, and his interest in language was kindled. Izzy, smart enough to recognize her son's brilliance, fed him first Bertrand Russell - but it was not long before he betrayed Russell for the French semioticians, ultimately landing on Barthes as his Virgil— though he was confident it was not the rings of Hell he was exploring, he remained uncertain as to what IT was. [See "The Complete Unabridged Journals of W. T. Grayson"]

[10] Kelly and the Idiot were Kelly and Jared Oakstone. Like the Roapes they were one of the original Five. Unlike the Roapes they'd never been a large group. They'd maintained a small but profitable family business and been lucky to have borne at least a few male descendants in each generation to maintain their patrilineage. The shape of their family tree might resemble a column, neither growing, nor shrinking, simply continuing to create the life that was needed to replace the lives that departed. It was rumored that anytime someone of Oakstone blood died a new child of the family was conceived. Of course something so ridiculous could never be true, but it was amazing how frequently it turned out to be the case that the news of one's death coincided with the arrival of new life. The Roapes family tree could not be described with such a symmetrical shape—rather it would reflect a period of great growth and prosperity during the Golden Age of the Pirates followed by a recession in which the family shrunk in size significantly, further on down the line there would be two more generations of a similar feast or famine dynamic, until finally, over the last fifty years or so, it has dwindled once again. This time rapidly. John Roapes, it appears, is the final male who remains in the cone of possibility, as it were, though in truth the prospects there are beginning to look grim as well.

[11] That is, the subjectivity of the reader, who is empowered in this way to become a creator, thus filling the gap left by Barthes' "Death of the Author". Which was, in today's terms, a *clickbait* title.

[12] Nihilism, it turns out, did not provide the optimal conditions for fostering a lively, involved creative literary scene —though perhaps the same cannot be said for its music, which is able to say and do things literature simply cannot.

[13] T in a journal entry about 9/11: "*We've been primed for this. Of the conspiracy theories that arise in the following months and years there will be several that are improperly categorized. There are some elements of these attacks that give me the same intangible feeling I have when I know I have unwittingly taken gambit-bait in chess, and all I can do is wait, feigning confidence. The entire world seems to disagree with this sentiment—that's how I know it must be true.*"

[14] Here one needs only to consider the ends of this spectrum to make clear the reasoning. On the more complex end of the spectrum is telekinesis or whatever is beyond telekinesis, pure neural interfacing, which we cannot even in our wildest imaginations conceive of without assuming some sort of silent transmission of words and sentences. On the other hand is, say, the ant, which we tend to anthropomorphize despite understanding how pheromones work to an extent, despite understanding that a single ant is more or less a part of the world in the same way a grain of sand or a leaf or a drop of water—the ant, however, displays instincts that the sand, or the dead leaf or the drop of water do not—and with these instincts and pheromones a group of ants becomes a colony and begins to show signs of non-language communication that we can not replicate and cannot use to actually interact with ant colonies and is thus, we are alone with language.

[15] At this point in the note there is a long line ending in an arrow drawn from the word 'hole' that led to the bottom of the page, either because adding a footnote in a personal letter would simply be too pretentious, though this is hard to believe, or more compelling, he was so absorbed in his own writing at this point that he annotated it as he would something he was writing for himself, thinking it at draft of a draft of a draft. In any case there was a line that ended with an arrow that pointed to: "[*hole*→*whole*: etymologically related? Seems unlikely, but offers a fun opportunity for a semantic study perhaps]". The note was then struck through with a single line so that it remained entirely legible but excised from the text.

[16] The words *whole* and *hole* are not etymologically related.

[17] I should clarify that the actual name given here is “Preventable Deaths” not car accident explicitly - but then, where does heart disease caused by lack of exercise and diet fall in this categorization schema.

[18] This according to a document which had been created by Dr. Marshall B. Oakstone in the late 1880s—the accuracy of which should be considered dubious at best. The document in question was the subject of great reverence among the leading patricians of the Five as it was written in a language that had never been seen before at the time of finding it. Once deciphered it described a number of unlikely stories, statistics and dates, which were subsequently transcribed in ‘The Book Agrippa’—after which, quite suspiciously, the document is said to have been lost, somewhere inside the house, but the location of which has never been identified since. Each family has its own theory with regard to the actual text, none sufficiently logical to be considered truth, all revealing in their own ways..

[19] A variant of “The Golden Rule” can be found in *The Principles of W. T. Grayson* a small manifesto of sorts that he’d written after he left for Wagner, but before he met Delia and the GAN, which is to say before he was a writer. The contents of *TPOWTG* are presented in the Appendix.

[20] NB: Argentinians are the people of Argentina. As an adjective it is Argentine.

[21] He particularly was fond of Clint Eastwood, but not the Dirty Harry franchise as one might suspect. He much preferred the movies in which Eastwood portrayed a man in love. And he said that

[22] Or there was Tino, who preferred to blend it all into one name and would call her *Saragata*—which could have been a reference to the word *sagato*, meaning ‘sagacious’ or ‘wise’—or could just as likely be a play on the word *sragato* which loosely translated to ‘unraveled’. In truth I don’t think it was anything as considered as this, but over time I have learned it is best not to make assumptions about another person’s intentions as a rule. Trust only what is real, what exists.

[23] This, unfortunately, will have to wait for its own book – as even beginning to investigate gave me a case of the creeps not worth further elaboration.

[24] The term “exactly” here is based off of a comparison of the video timestamp of the moment in which Darla abruptly turns on her heel and with the reported time of the fires inception, as indicated by forensic specialists in the field, who at a minimum are incredibly confident about their figures and estimates, and who both swore on bibles before testifying in court to the accuracy of their own estimates, which are specific to the minute, and involve a complex chemical process that was described to the courtroom but comprehended by very few. The fact that the timing was so precise is one oddity among many that has been pursued by relentless online sleuths in obscure corners of Reddit—though nothing more than conjecture has been produced as a result.

[25] It was proving them, ultimately, which caused the frustration, that led to the outbursts, that led to the intervention(s), and ultimately the institutionalization.

[26] Even worse than irrelevant, one might argue if they felt they had the energy left to do so (it is so tiresome to argue with no opposition who cares), even worse than *irrelevant*, the nuance was *a disruption, a complication* to the categories we’d established upon arrival.

[27] Sometimes I think it was the uniforms—that they were made intentionally for this purpose—because there were a few other children with the same wide thighs, “built like a horse” as they say, and it’s true I was not the only student to suffer this cruel condition.

We never spoke about it though.

[28] A standard component of old antebellum era manors were back passages in and out of gathering areas. These were used by the house slaves to prepare and serve guests while staying hidden themselves.

[29] John associated them most with the single long family road trip he remembered, at least—because he had to sit quietly in the back during the nine hour journey northward, to Washington D.C., as his parents either argued or stewed while gathering energy for the next bout—John watched out the window and could clearly remember the unnatural way a patch of trees would appear naturally occurring, but then suddenly they would fall into perfect rows when the car passed at a 45 degree angle, for a split second they were lined like soldiers, then the pattern would disappear until, at 90 degrees, it would happen once again—perfect rows—and he remembered that he’d asked if that was natural, and that it

was his father who had thought it would be funny to lie, so told him yes, and by the time he realized the truth he already had learned how his father's lies felt, and he was only angry with himself for being so gullible; so naive.

[30] These days have only recently departed in truth, and have done so only because the consolidation of wealth has made the exchange of resources amongst the wealthy a much more liquid and elusive thing—this is to say The Five, today, would really be called the One .

[31] Apophenia is a term for when one's pattern detection capacities are in overdrive, giving one the tendency to view correlations, patterns and connections between unrelated things.

[32] (if only because I, the narrator, am the owner of this world, and as such it should go without saying that when I provide some bit of information as fact, it must be accepted as fact (in the narrative sense, meaning, as a fact in the context of the story being told, not in some total, metaphysical/philosophical capacity by which truth is a measurable concept, but inasmuch as it must be *acceptably real* in the world we are both participating in) – [*it must be accepted as fact*] by the reader in order for our tacit agreement: that I am the narrator, telling you the story the way it needs to be told for the purposes of this story, (regardless of whether I am a *reliable* or *unreliable narrator* I must, to some extent, be trusted implicitly to decree what is to be taken as true vs. what may be left in the air to be wondered upon, in some way to be aware of my own *unreliability* even) in order that the immersion be fully maintained; which is to say– the moment you begin to question whether or not what I am saying is true (in my eyes as previously clarified) the whole notion of my being the teller of this story as opposed to some third person omniscient being becomes massively problematic for both of us, because with that bond broken your faith in me slowly withers away until the story might as well be the retelling of a personal dream, which any editor worth their weight in bacon grease will tell you is the deathrattle of any decent story (unless, that is, you are by chance of Latin American origin or descent, or if you are Western European to some extent, and also just if you do it really well, in which case it's acceptable to write and speak in a dreamlike manner– but of course these are exceptions to the rule that are provided only to “Great” writers, which is far from the case with yours truly– even as I try to tell you a story about the Great American Novelist, which will require that I, in some ways, assume I can understand how the G.A.N. might have thought and acted, but with the caveat that I was able to do ample research and portions of what the G.A.N. says or does within this narrative are only poor plagiarism of things the G.A.N. actually did or said and as such are more him than me... I have digressed) –[*deathrattle of any decent story*,] slipping into a dreamworld, or perceived dreamworld at any rate)

[33] Similar claims were made in the LA Review of Books , The National Review , Vanity Fair , and Time Magazine - just to name a few. It was a genuine literary phenomenon.

[34] And let's be honest many of the people who ardently love the second film in the franchise still struggle to sit through its full runtime, particularly when it dips back into the past and travels to Italy, but they wax poetic when it comes to discussing the film because it does what the first film did so well...humanizes the grotesque. Whereas the third film makes the human grotesque, and no one wants to see that for a number of reasons that you can read about in John Roapes' collection of essays, “Criticism is for the Birds: Assorted Studies in the Hypocrisy of Man,” an electric work that also contains the wonderfully titled “The Hypocrisy of Mann,” an essay that never found a suitable forum for publication, but presents the conflict between the Mann brothers in the context of WWII and its fallout as a microcosmic reflection of the states of struggle that Western Civilization would come to face.

[35] At the time of writing

[36] At the time of writing,

[37] In order to refrain from another diversion which would necessarily be lengthy and require that I reconsider the structure of this Biographical Overview altogether, I will point the reader to [Pg. XXX] of the book where this particular adventure is detailed in the context of a longer conversation with W. T. Grayson on the topic of fishing, vegetarianism, and Captain L. Horne (better known as the “President of the Atlantic”)

[38] Perhaps notably the narrator, who has gone as far as to outright plead for your faith and trust in his knowledge, authority, etc. is not quite certain as to the relevant distinctions between the terms: *Preface* and *Prologue* - though he is aware that there are important distinctions. Whether this is indicative, therefore, of his use of intuition as a guiding principle, pure laziness as an author, or the belief that this distinction would be arbitrary in the mind of W. T., who didn't care much for linguistics and word games in the same way the G.A.N. did. Notably, the G.A.N. would almost certainly take offense to the misuse of any term like *preface* or *prologue* . So, it is perhaps possible that under the

guise of laziness the narrator is making a nod to the protagonist of our tale, W. T. Grayson - or by virtue of adding the footnote, is doing the exact opposite. Your stance on the matter matters in this matter. ;-)

[39] Unlike the G.A.N. there are no books dedicated to the study of his biography, psychological make-up, etc. – so I don’t think it needs to be said, but these are the impressions of the author based on research, interviews, and personal experience. It is possible, in other words, that I am wrong. It is unlikely, however, that there is a resource more thoroughly informed and qualified to speculate on the subject. Do with this information what you will.

[40] W. T. was oddly out of touch with the nuances of modern life, of the ramifications of capitalism and consumerism as it were, and was the last to understand that it was not the system, or the establishment, that he was gesturing at, both literally and symbolically, by not leaving a tip. He was also, with near certainty, somewhere on the autistic spectrum, so he registered nothing in the sarcasm and witticisms of the bartenders– nor did he recognize it when later, as we’d become regulars, they looked to me as a sort of shepherd for W. T., and treated me in some ways like his parental figure, or he as a sort of dependent, always serving me first, and often asking me for both of our orders, etc. In many ways, despite his brilliance, he’d become a perpetual child - oblivious to surface reality (which is, for many, the totality of existence), and yet he had an unmatched comprehension of the fundamental truths, the platonic, the ethereal and the sublime–this was his domain, and he never strayed.

[41] This of course is a gross simplification of the myriad reasons that Continental Philosophy lost its foothold and fell out of fashion in nearly all academic circles. It just seems to your narrator, that this was the *fundamental* reason - and that something about the 21st century knocked the American Academic Ego down a peg or two, which has since seen a return to the realization that there are fundamental questions that very much remain to be grappled with. For a primer on the subject, one could find no better place to start than the G.A.N.’s own book, “Living in the Panopticon,” which was one of his only works to be poorly received by critics, but has since had a rebirth of sorts, and a full-tilt reversal of many of the initial criticisms that were hurled at it following its initial print run. The NYT Book Review, notably, stopped just shy of a full fledged apology in their most recent G.A.N. Retrospective.

[42] For reasons that, at the time of my writing this, are likely self evident - however, should you, dear reader, be wondering - suffice it to say that the definition of a *massage* at ‘X-Pert Massage and Nails’ differed significantly from the commonly assumed definition of a *massage* - and that several of the husbands on the island had taken to getting massages with a frequency that disturbed and upset their wives. However, the ownership of ‘X-Pert Massage and Nails’ it is rumored, has a well established relationship with local law enforcement and is unlikely to face any significant ramifications any time soon, as far as I can tell.

[43] My personal experience at the Massage and Nail Parlor is a story in and of itself and will be addressed in due time.

[44] Initially slaves, lamentably, but to the credit of one Descartes Roapes, this period of time was brief, and well before the Emancipation Proclamation, in the year 1821 precisely, the use of slaves on the Roapes Estate was abolished entirely (though it is, of course, clear from certain historical documents that the foundations of this decision was largely related to a certain type of early *cost-benefit analysis* and the extent to which this was a show of moral or ethical fortitude remains unknown, and likely limited). Descartes, as it were, had made a prediction that the quality of work and temperament of the employed would be significantly improved if they were paid even a pittance (and a pittance it was) and given living accommodations that were superior to the hundreds of other slaves on the island at the time. This hypothesis was proven true in short order - though the unpredicted ramifications among the other patriarchs of The Five, were not insignificant, and thus began the feuding that continues to this day (with the Redfields in particular). Descartes Roapes is an enigmatic figure in the Roapes family lineage, and his tenure as the family patriarch is also closely tied to the first signs of a fall from grace, as it were. Though grace is a strange and antiquated term and your narrator feels strongly that no such correlation exists when closely scrutinized.

[45] I am under the impression, to this day, that I had in fact fooled him - but for some reason, between visits, he had found out who I was and been planning to let me know that he knew, with his creepy wink, for a few days at least, if only because the delivery came off as though it had been practiced in the mirror a few times and he was straining to pull from memory what he wanted to say.

[46] His lifetime drink of choice would be whiskey. There were phases within the world of whiskey, first a bourbon drinker, then it was Irish whiskey (which had its own sub-foray into scotch whiskeys) and then there was Canadian whiskey, followed by ‘la creme de la creme’ which was Japanese whiskey, an exciting, new frontier at that time - still, without fail, ultimately the cycle would start over. Of course, if it wasn’t whiskey, there was rum, cognac, armagnac, anything dark and brown and cold, in essence. Belly warmers.

[47] Further note to self: Does satire require intentionality? And if so does the existence of satire categorically rule out the metaphorical *death of the author* - given, that is, the inferred meaning of the “death of the author” in post-modern academic terms, as infamously coined by Roland Barthes, is actually the elimination of “author ity” or “authorial intent” in the context of critical literary theory, not the death of the literal author, as this novel, coincidentally deals with in both form and content.

[48] Example for reference: A 5 on the AP English Lit Exam equated to credits for English 101 & 102 (2 credits a piece), whereas a 5 on the AP Bio exam plus a 5 on the AP Chem Exam were the equivalent of twelve credits (nearly a full semester of college courses) as they replaced Bio 101 & 102 plus Bio Lab and Chem 101/102/Lab - each class worth its own unique amount based on the amount of time and coursework anticipated. This was fairly standard practice in the aughts, at least, though I admit to being less aware of the way advanced placement courses work today, at any rate, as pretty much all of my institutional knowledge regarding the ins and outs of higher-level education was obtained vicariously (and via an unreliable source, W. T. - which is not a criticism of his character but a comment on his *inventive* nature).

[49] This is hard for an American audience to imagine - a public intellectual with a fanbase so inspired and enraptured by the writer/thinker as to be described as “inconsolable”. In fact, it’s likely hard for an American audience to imagine a public intellectual with any genuine fanbase, at all. For that matter what does an American even imagine when they hear the term “public intellectual”? The image that comes to mind for most, I worry, is the vague image of a “thought leader ” delivering a TED talk - those IMAX sized slide presentations, with any number of graphs and misappropriated statistics that seem somehow entirely unrelated to the subject of the presentation. Each one promising to *change your life* in five simple steps.

[50] He was in Paris on grant money from a foundation that had later been revealed to be a quasi-cult, and had given him the ‘heebie-jeebies’ fairly quickly after his arrival in France - the sole intention of his trip having been to attend the lecture series and write - when they realized how psychically unmolestable he was, they had gone as far as to withdraw the grant by sending two mustachioed Parisians to his apartment with a manilla folder containing grainy black-and-white photographs of him two nights prior seated between two women at a local discotheque, his arms around their shoulders, while someone he did not remember held out a plate, and someone else held a straw and in the picture he was captured with his head at a forty-five degree angle, halfway through a three inch line of some of the finest cocaine he’d tasted in years.

[51] Which, come to think of it, may have been one of the first concrete examples of his tendency towards the conspiratorial mindset—because this architectural mystery that seemed to genuinely befuddle him, was easily put to rest when he finally made the decision to walk up to the intersection in question and saw the, albeit creative but aesthetically horrendous solution the architect had put in place, which, ultimately explained a number of other asymmetries that had been driving him mad for months.

[52] Corn was not corn, these were poppy farm investors. Investments in opium, her mother, the professor, never realized despite teaching the very specific topic for several years.

[53] Pronounced even worse than you would imagine. Most of them would pronounce it ‘Vaug-ner’ like total dickheads. Somehow too brilliant to recognize what idiots they sounded like.

[54] In W. T.’s unfinished autobiography, he notes that it was called “The Great Depression” by the Wagner student body, however in all of my research, which included student and staff interviews, I have not been able to verify this as true in any capacity. I must, unfortunately, conclude that W. T. was being somewhat inventive with this little bit of marginalia - and that, if anything, it may point to a personal opinion or state of mind that W. T. associated with the place.

Table of Contents

THE BASTARD SON OF THE GREAT AMERICAN NOVELIST	1
TABLE OF CONTENTS	1
Preface (Yours, Truly Yours)	2
History Lessons	4
BOOK ONE	6
PART X	6
I	6
II	7
III	8
IV	8
V	9
VI	11
VII	12
IIX	13
IX	16
X	18
XI	21
XII	23
XIII	25
XIV	26
XV	29
XVI	31
XVII	32
XVIII	36
XIX	37
John Roapes	37

12.1.2002	38
FORM: ENTROPY	40
Epistolary	44
Part ∞	46
$\leftarrow$	46
$\rightarrow$	48
$\leftrightarrow$	49
$\rightarrow \rightarrow \rightarrow \rightarrow \rightarrow$	50
$\nearrow \nearrow$	51
$\nearrow$	52
INTERLUDE	53
Of William	54
(or, Life as a Close Reading: An Assorted History of William Theodore Tipnam the Third, Grayson Island and Its Inhabitants, The Bridge to Nowhere, and Some Thoughts and Remarks on the Nature of Reality, Humanity, Existence and Consciousness with regard to the Concepts of the Absurd, Sublime and Transcendental)	54
Selected Epigraphs (From “The Collected Notebooks Vols. 4-7: The Words of Others”)	54
“How many horrible and beautiful things!”	54
Honoré de Balzac, Facino Cane	55
“Living life falsely and in dreams is still living life.”	55
Fernando Pessoa, The Book of Disquiet, Entry 49	55
“He intended nothing at all because he wrote the way a child pees against a tree, in order to relieve himself.”	55
Witold Gombrowicz, Diary: Volume 1, pg. 70	55
A Thinkpiece	55
The Great Continuum	56
From the “Unpublished Notebooks of William Theodore Tipnam III” (November 14, 2000):	57

A New Gold Standard	58
The Post-Illusionists	59
Pappy's Manor	59
A Brief Aside #1	60
A Different View of Pappy's Manor	61
The Secret to Success	61
The Works of William Theodore Tipnam III	63
A Rebirth of Sorts: The Arrival	65
A Relative Paradox	69
Looking and Seeing	70
Some Notes on Time: I	73
Prophet	74
One Version of the Beginning	75
Jonelle	75
Truisms For Idiots	79
Jonelle: Deuce	79
INTERLUDE 2	80
Part X: Section 1.0.0	80
Part X: Section 1.0.1	83
Part X: Section 1.1.0	92
Part X: Section 1.1.1	97
Primary Documents: The Principles of W. T. Grayson	97
Primary Documents: Notebook #214	98
Primary Documents: Take Home Quiz #1	99
Part X: Section 1.0.2	100
Part X: Section 1.1.2	105
Part X: Section 1.1.3	108
Part X: Section 1.2.0	112
Part X: Section 1.0.3	115
Part X: Section 1.2.1	118
Part X: Section 1.0.4	119

Part X: Section 1.3.0	121
Part X: Section 1.4.0	125
Part X: Section 1.4.1	126
Part X: Section 1.5.0	132
Part X: Section 1.3.1	135
Part X: Section 1.6.0	136
Scattered Theories: Interludes	137
UNSORTED PAGES	137
Part X: Section 1.3.X	137
Origin Story: 1 of 5	140
Part X: Section 1.0.5	141
X.X. Island: 1.0	142
GAN: 1.0	143
Yours Truly: 1.0	145
History: 1.1	147
History: 1.2	150
W. T.: 1.1	154
W. T.: 1.2	155
W. T.: 1.2.1	156
Izzy Grayson: 1.1	159
W. T.: 1.3	161
History: 1.3	161
Yours Truly: 1.1	163
W. T.: 1.4	169
W. T.: 1.5	169
GAN: 1.1	171
W. T.: 1.6	176
Izzy Grayson: 1.1	180
Izzy Grayson: 1.1.1	183
Yours Truly: 1.2	185
GAN: 1.2	186
Izzy Grayson: 1.3	190

History: 1.3	191
GAN: 1.3	192
W. T.: 1.7	193
GAN.: 1.4	199
W. T.: 1.8	203
GAN: 1.5	207
W. T.: 1.8.1	208
W. T.: 1.8.2	210
GAN: 1.6	210
Percival Ignatius Roapes 1.0	213
J. Roapes: 1.0	214
W. T.: 1.9	215
INTERLUDE 3	218
No Horizon	219
Part I	219
One	219
Two	225
Three	230
Four	235
Five	241
Six	248
Seven	255
Eight	258
Nine	263
Ten	268
Eleven	269
Twelve	276
Thirteen	281
Fourteen	282
Fifteen	286
Sixteen	290

Seventeen	294
Eighteen	300
Part II	304
One	304
Two	308
Three	313
Four	316
Five	325
Six	329
Seven	331
Eight	333
Nine	337
Ten	345
Eleven	349
Twelve	353
Thirteen	358
Fourteen	361
[FIN]	363
[APPENDIX 1: ALTERNATE TAKES]	363
[Embryonic]	363
One - William Theodore Tipnam III	363
Two - McCallan Road	364
Three - November 21st	366
Four - Sundays	369
Five - Back Home	371
Six - A Book	372
Seven - JR's Gift	374
Eight - The Johnson's	376
Nine - The Nap	378
Ten - The Argument	381
Eleven - Late	382

Twelve - Mary-Ann and Bocephus Tipnam	383
Thirteen - Time Passed	385
Fourteen - The Drive	386
Fifteen - Thresholds and Skepticism	387
Sixteen - At The Desk	389
Seventeen - A Premonition	390
Eighteen - Renfield, Apart	391
Nineteen - The Storyteller	392
Twenty - The Incident	394
Twenty One - The Woman	396
Twenty Two - Baby Teeth	397